Luke 1A

Luke 1:1 Inasmuch as many have undertaken to compile an account of the things accomplished among us,
Luke 1:2 just as they were handed down to us by those who from the beginning were eyewitnesses and servants of the word,
Luke 1:3 it seemed fitting for me as well, having investigated everything carefully from the beginning, to write *it* out for you in consecutive order, most excellent Theophilus;
Luke 1:4 so that you may know the exact truth about the things you have been taught.

- What we know of Christ's time on earth comes principally from 4 men: Matt, Mark, Luke and John
    - Their writing was inspired by the Holy Spirit, as all scripture must be
        - The Holy Spirit drove them and organized their thoughts and even brought specific words to mind
        - But they didn't necessarily sense the HS influence in the moment – they had a simpler, natural purpose
        - Luke, like many authors in the NT, states his purpose immediately in his gospel
    - Of the 4 gospels, two were written by Disciples (Matt & John) and 2 were written by later followers (Mark and Luke)
        - Mark was a close companion of Peter, and his account is probably told through Peter's eyes, to a large extent
        - Luke was a faithful traveler with Paul, and even though Paul didn't accompany Jesus, he did receive direct revelation from Christ after the resurrection
- Luke was a physician and a gentile, the only known few gentile author of scripture (along with Acts, which together are 27% of the NT)
    - He wrote his gospel not long after Christ's death, probably during Paul's Roman imprisonment
    - He was a physician, which was not the same thing as being a doctor today
        - No one liked to deal with the body, especially sick and dying bodies

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- It was unpleasant and considered dirty work
- And Jews would never consider such a role, since they would be considered unclean
- So the role usually went to Gentiles and more than that, - often to Gentile slaves or indentured servants
    - This may have been the relationship between Luke and Theophilis, the intended audience of Luke's gospel

- Luke's scientific nature meant he took a very careful approach to his writing
    - Luke tell Theophilis that since others have tried to write about Christ's life based on eyewitness accounts, he wants to try his hand at it too
        - But Luke suggests in the first verses of his gospel that he is in a better position to write
            - He has investigated carefully
            - Placed everything in chronological order
                - His gospel sets the record among the gospels
                - But it was not necessarily perfectly chronological – the word is **kathexes** which means orderly sequence
        - And his purpose is to ensure the reader knows he can believe what he's been taught
- Likewise, that should be our purpose today – to believe what we've been taught – but ensuring we get the facts right
    - Knowing the facts of our faith strengthens it
    - Those who would diminish the importance and value of study he Bible don't appreciate its relationship to faith

Rom. 10:17 So faith *comes* from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.

- The very foundation of our relationship with Christ begins with His word
    - Our ability to hear comes from the word of Christ

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- And then our ability to grow in that faith continues through the word

Heb. 5:11 Concerning him we have much to say, and *it is* hard to explain, since you have become dull of hearing.
Heb. 5:12 For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you have need again for someone to teach you the elementary principles of the oracles of God, and you have come to need milk and not solid food.
Heb. 5:13 For everyone who partakes *only* of milk is not accustomed to the word of righteousness, for he is an infant.
Heb. 5:14 But solid food is for the mature, who because of practice have their senses trained to discern good and evil.

- We are commanded to press on to maturity by Heb 6:1 – it's not an option – to stay immature is to disobey the Lord
    - Do you abstain from idol worship?
    - Do you come to church regularly and participate in communion?
    - Do you try to lead a Christ-like life pleasing to God?
    - Then you must learn the word as well
- Luke is helping his readers fulfill that responsibility through his giving of an accurate, complete account of Christ's life

Luke 1:5 In the days of Herod, king of Judea, there was a priest named Zacharias, of the division of Abijah; and he had a wife from the daughters of Aaron, and her name was Elizabeth.
Luke 1:6 They were both righteous in the sight of God, walking blamelessly in all the commandments and requirements of the Lord.
Luke 1:7 But they had no child, because Elizabeth was barren, and they were both advanced in years.

- Judea is the name for modern day Israel
    - In Jesus' day, it was a province of the Roman Empire, whose governor was Herod the Great

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- The nation of Israel, though under Roman rule, still had permission to rule themselves according to their law
  - The temple was standing – Herod had made it even grander
  - The sacrifices still took place
  - Priests still officiated at the temple

- One of those priests was Zacharias from the division of Abijah
  - David divided the sons of Levi (priests) into 24 divisions with a family leader as head of each division
  - Aijah was the leader of one of those divisions
  - Each division served in the temple for one week twice in a year

- His wife, Elizabeth, was also descended from a priestly family, Aaron
  - God wanted to be clear that the product of this union would be fit to serve God, as the priests serve Him in the temple
  - Moreover, they were godly and blameless
    - The term blameless is one we've seen before – Noah was called blameless in Genesis
    - Doesn't mean without sin – means without giving opportunity for men to find fault

Rom. 12:18 If possible, so far as it depends on you, be at peace with all men.

- Don't lose sight of the fact that when God wishes to bestow on men the greatest of honors, He will select men and women who lead godly lives
  - God called Noah blameless
  - Abraham was told to be blameless
  - Job was blameless

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- David declares repeated in the Psalms the virtues of being blameless

- We should all make living a blameless life a high priority, so that God might decide to use us for great service and honor

- Only one problem with this marriage – the union was childless
  - Where have we seen this before?
    - Abraham, Isaac, Jacob
    - Whenever God wishes to make the point that a child given to a couple will be especially important in His plan, he delays it's arrival
    - Which emphasizes that when it arrives it was given by Him
  - But because this birth will be closely connected to the birth of His Son, the giving of the child will be preceded by angelic announcers

Luke 1:8 ¶ Now it happened *that* while he was performing his priestly service before God in the *appointed* order of his division,
Luke 1:9 according to the custom of the priestly office, he was chosen by lot to enter the temple of the Lord and burn incense.
Luke 1:10 And the whole multitude of the people were in prayer outside at the hour of the incense offering.
Luke 1:11 And an angel of the Lord appeared to him, standing to the right of the altar of incense.
Luke 1:12 Zacharias was troubled when he saw *the angel*, and fear gripped him.
Luke 1:13 But the angel said to him, "Do not be afraid, Zacharias, for your petition has been heard, and your wife Elizabeth will bear you a son, and you will give him the name John.
Luke 1:14 "You will have joy and gladness, and many will rejoice at his birth.
Luke 1:15 "For he will be great in the sight of the Lord; and he will drink no wine or liquor, and he will be filled with the Holy Spirit while yet in his mother's womb.
Luke 1:16 "And he will turn many of the sons of Israel back to the Lord their God.
Luke 1:17 "It is he who will go *as a forerunner* before Him in the spirit and power of Elijah, TO TURN THE HEARTS OF THE FATHERS BACK TO THE CHILDREN, and the disobedient to the attitude of the righteous, so as to make ready a people prepared for the Lord."

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- Zacharias was in the temple performing his duties during one of his two weeks per year,
    - He would have traveled from home to the temple for the week of work – a business trip
    - Each day, there was incense burned before the altar as part of the daily sacrifice
        - Burning the incense was considered a special honor
    - Since there were so many priests in each division, each priest would be given only one opportunity in a lifetime to burn incense before the throne
    - Today, Zacharias wins the lottery, as it were, and is selected to go into the Holy Place and burn incense
        - Do you think the day of his selection was an accident?
        - We know that God selected him that day, so that this day Zacharias could be used by God
- The angel appears as Zacharias stands before the altar
    - Naturally, he is afraid, but the angel tells him not to fear
    - The angel says his petition (his prayers) have been answered
        - Zacharias had been praying for a child, a son
        - God was answering his prayers
    - His son would be named John and he would have a special place in God's plan

- The very last book of the Old Testament, Malachi, God gives his final words to Israel prior to the arrival of His son, the Messiah
    - It was a time of great apostasy, the nation of Israel almost to a man gone astray, corrupt
- And God says to Israel in Malachi:

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Mal. 2:17 ¶ You have wearied the LORD with your words. Yet you say, "How have we wearied *Him*?" In that you say, "Everyone who does evil is good in the sight of the LORD, and He delights in them," or, "Where is the God of justice?"
Mal. 3:1 ¶ "Behold, I am going to send My messenger, and he will clear the way before Me. And the Lord, whom you seek, will suddenly come to His temple; and the messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight, behold, He is coming," says the LORD of hosts.
Mal. 3:2 "But who can endure the day of His coming? And who can stand when He appears? For He is like a refiner's fire and like fullers' soap.

And again

Mal. 4:1 ¶ "For behold, the day is coming, burning like a furnace; and all the arrogant and every evildoer will be chaff; and the day that is coming will set them ablaze," says the LORD of hosts, "so that it will leave them neither root nor branch."

Mal. 4:5 ¶ "Behold, I am going to send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and terrible day of the LORD.
Mal. 4:6 "He will restore the hearts of the fathers to *their* children and the hearts of the children to their fathers, so that I will not come and smite the land with a curse."

- These final words were a stern warning that before the coming of the Messiah, God would send a messenger ahead of him
    - But the context of Malachi makes clear that he was referring to Elijah himself returning and the time would be at Christ's coming to establish His kingdom – in other words, the end times
        - But Malachi's prophecy concerns the end times, the second coming of Christ and His setting up of His kingdom on earth
- So why does the angle refer to Malachi when describing the birth of John the Baptist?
    - Is John the Baptist Elijah?

John 1:19 ¶ This is the testimony of John, when the Jews sent to him priests and Levites from Jerusalem to ask him, "Who are you?"
John 1:20 And he confessed and did not deny, but confessed, "I am not the Christ."
John 1:21 They asked him, "What then? Are you Elijah?" And he *said, "I am not." "Are you the Prophet?" And he answered, "No."
John 1:22 Then they said to him, "Who are you, so that we may give an answer to those who sent us? What do you say about yourself?"

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John 1:23 He said, "I am A VOICE OF ONE CRYING IN THE WILDERNESS, 'MAKE STRAIGHT THE WAY OF THE LORD,' as Isaiah the prophet said."

- Later in Luke, Zacharias actually quotes from this same part of Isaiah 40

Is. 40:3 ¶ A voice is calling,
"Clear the way for the LORD in the wilderness;
Make smooth in the desert a highway for our God.

- Interestingly, Isaiah 40 includes elements of both Christ's first and second coming – giving prophecy of both events in the same chapter

- So John the Baptist is fulfilling some of the prophecy of the Messiah's arrival found in Isaiah, at least His first coming
  - Then how is he connected to Christ's second coming, as the angel suggests with his quotes of Malachi?
    - We know that our God works through pictures and repetition
    - He often places events in the lives of men as pictures or examples of greater things to come
      - Isaac was a picture of Christ as was Joseph
  - Now we see John fulfills Isaiah's prophecy for a "voice in the wilderness crying out" in advance of Christ's first coming
    - But this is itself a picture of an even greater event
      - The time when Elijah returns before Christ's second coming
      - In other words, John the Baptist is a type of Elijah – he is NOT Elijah, but he pictures Elijah's coming before the "great and terrible day of the Lord"
      - Just as Christ's second coming has great glory and power than his first coming, so also Elijah's return will be a greater ministry than John the Baptist's

- When Luke quotes from Malachi, he adds an interesting detail - that the messenger would prepare a people made ready for the Lord

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- John's ministry was first about preparing a people for Christ
  - In Chap 3 we'll study John's baptism of Jesus, but for now consider this
    - When Christ begins his adult ministry, he starts with His baptism
    - In that moment, he immediately has an audience
    - Gathered around John were his disciples who had been hearing about the coming Messiah and the fulfillment of prophecy for a savior – a people made ready for the Lord
    - As soon as Christ is ready to begin His ministry, the Father has already prepared a people to be looking for him and ready to respond

- The Father is still doing this even today
  - The Holy Spirit is the person of the Trinity responsible for preparing hearts to receive the Lord today

John 6:44 "No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him; and I will raise him up on the last day.
John 6:65 And He was saying, "For this reason I have said to you, that no one can come to Me unless it has been granted him from the Father."

1Cor. 12:3 Therefore I make known to you that no one speaking by the Spirit of God says, "Jesus is accursed"; and no one can say, "Jesus is Lord," except by the Holy Spirit.

  - So John is a picture of the Holy Spirit's ministry as well, something we will expand on when we get to Chap 3 and Christ's baptism

- Then Zacharias, having heard the angel's words responds:

Luke 1:18 ¶ Zacharias said to the angel, "How will I know this *for certain*? For I am an old man and my wife is advanced in years."

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- Does this seem familiar? – Abraham said this to God when told he would have a child:

Gen. 17:16 "I will bless her, and indeed I will give you a son by her. Then I will bless her, and she shall be *a mother of* nations; kings of peoples will come from her."
Gen. 17:17 Then Abraham fell on his face and laughed, and said in his heart, "Will a child be born to a man one hundred years old? And will Sarah, who is ninety years old, bear *a child*?"

- Their reactions seem very similar, don't they?
    - In Abraham's case, God simply assured Abraham that Ishmael wouldn't be the chosen son and that another son would be born
    - What about Zacharias?

Luke 1:19 The angel answered and said to him, "I am Gabriel, who stands in the presence of God, and I have been sent to speak to you and to bring you this good news.
Luke 1:20 "And behold, you shall be silent and unable to speak until the day when these things take place, because you did not believe my words, which will be fulfilled in their proper time."

- Why the difference?
    - Consider the words each used and what thoughts were likely behind them
        - Zacharias said, "How will I know for certain?"
            - In other words, he asked for proof, a sign, something that would cement his belief in the angel's promise
            - He's standing in front of an angel – one that made him fear – and he needs proof in order to accept the statement he's heard
            - He doesn't believe, and the angel says the same thing
            - So to prove his power, the angel makes Zacharias mute
                - Now I'm sure he believed – he got what he asked for: proof!

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    - Abraham's statement is different
        - In Chap 15 he was told that he would have a son, and God entered into a covenant to promise him one
        - By Chap 17 Abraham has a son – Ishmael
            - So naturally, Abraham believes he has the promised child
            - When he hears that Sarah will have a natural child, he laughs – astonished – and then exclaims is it possible that I can have a child at this age
            - In other words, he reacts in this astonished way because he believes God can do it!
        - His next comment further supports that view

Gen. 17:18 And Abraham said to God, "Oh that Ishmael might live before You!"

- Abraham asks God to select Ishmael rather than grant him another son – but God refused to do so

- So Zacharias' comment indicated lack of faith while Abraham's was because of faith in God ability to do what He promised
    - But there is likely a second reason that Zacharias question was punished while Abraham's was not
        - The angel speaking to Zacharias quoted OT scripture – Malachi to be exact
        - This was a place in scripture that every devote Jew would know
    - Abraham didn't have the benefit of scripture, yet he still believed God's word
    - It seems God placed higher expectations on Zacharias because he had opportunity to understand what the angel was speaking

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Luke 1:21 ¶ The people were waiting for Zacharias, and were wondering at his delay in the temple.
Luke 1:22 But when he came out, he was unable to speak to them; and they realized that he had seen a vision in the temple; and he kept making signs to them, and remained mute.
Luke 1:23 When the days of his priestly service were ended, he went back home.

- Perhaps this is a good lesson to end on for us today
    - Having been given God's word, how familiar are we with it?
    - Do we make learning it a priority in our life?
    - Are we still needing milk and therefore unable to discern good from evil?
    - If God were to place you on the spot like Zacharias, how would you fare?

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Luke 1B

- The writer Luke is preparing us for the arrival of the promised Messiah, the promised King of Israel
    - Luke alone chose to emphasize a comparison between the birth of John the Baptist and Jesus
    - But this makes perfect sense considering Luke's purpose and emphasis
    - His account is emphasizes the human qualities of the man, Jesus
        - Among synoptic Gospels, Matt wrote to the Jews, emphasizing Jesus as King, the Messiahship of Christ
        - Mark wrote his Gospel for the gentile Roman church, emphasizing the Servant nature of our suffering Lord
        - And Luke wrote for the gentile Greeks, emphasizing the perfect, ideal man that was Jesus, the Son of Man
- Last week we learned how the arrival of John the Baptist was announced in advance to Zacharias, and yet he doubted the word of the Lord spoken through Gabriel and received a rebuke in the form of silence
- Now we see the fulfillment of that promise and a similar set of events in the life of Mary and Joseph

Luke 1:24 ¶ After these days Elizabeth his wife became pregnant, and she kept herself in seclusion for five months, saying,
Luke 1:25 "This is the way the Lord has dealt with me in the days when He looked *with favor* upon *me*, to take away my disgrace among men."

- The scripture says that after these days, meaning after the week when Zacharias has served in the temple, his wife becomes pregnant
    - She was old
    - She had never had a child
    - But she was married and had every opportunity for natural process of conception to take hold and to produce children

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- But now the marriage produces children where it never had before

- Once she recognizes she is pregnant, Elizabeth goes into seclusion
  - Couple often hide the fact of pregnancy while waiting to get through the difficult first few months
  - In her case, the extreme nature of this late pregnancy probably made her extra cautious

- But notice her immediate response to the fact of the pregnancy
  - She credits God and praises Him
    - Think with me…How much did she understand of her husband's experience in the temple?
      - He was mute, and it would be hard to explain and convince her under the best of circumstances
      - But she probably came to this conclusion putting 2 and 2 together (from Zacharias' sign language) together with her own faith in God
  - Elizabeth exclaims that God found favor to take away her disgrace before men
    - Elizabeth understood that though she was considered a disgrace before men, she was favored before God
      - Childlessness was an occasion for reproach
      - Woman was blamed, not the man
      - And her role was to produce children
    - We ourselves may suffer reproach from the world
      - Our appearance, our weaknesses in health or ability like Elizabeth
      - Our lack of formal education, our low social status
      - Our devotion to raising our children certain ways
      - Our devotion to honest business practices

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- But no matter how much disgrace we have before men, we are made perfect before the Lord
    - And He may chose to remove our disgrace before men, as He did for Elizabeth or Joseph, but He may not

- Moses, for example, went the opposite direction in God's plan
    - God actually brought him to a point of reproach before men, where before he had been in a position of remarkable prominence

Heb. 11:24 By faith Moses, when he had grown up, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter,
Heb. 11:25 choosing rather to endure ill-treatment with the people of God than to enjoy the passing pleasures of sin,
Heb. 11:26 considering the reproach of Christ greater riches than the treasures of Egypt; for he was looking to the reward.

- One of the first and most important growth steps for a Christian to take is to recognize that our experiences in this world -
    - Our joys
    - Our gains and losses
    - Our health
    - Our material happiness
- They are a very poor measure of our righteousness and of God's pleasure with us

- Now, six months into her pregnancy, Elizabeth gets company from a relative

Luke 1:26 ¶ Now in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God to a city in Galilee called Nazareth,
Luke 1:27 to a virgin engaged to a man whose name was Joseph, of the descendants of David; and the virgin's name was Mary.
Luke 1:28 And coming in, he said to her, "Greetings, favored one! The Lord *is* with you."
Luke 1:29 But she was very perplexed at *this* statement, and kept pondering what kind of salutation this was.
Luke 1:30 The angel said to her, "Do not be afraid, Mary; for you have found favor with God.

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Luke 1:31 "And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you shall name Him Jesus.
Luke 1:32 "He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David;
Luke 1:33 and He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and His kingdom will have no end."
Luke 1:34 Mary said to the angel, "How can this be, since I am a virgin?"
Luke 1:35 The angel answered and said to her, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; and for that reason the holy Child shall be called the Son of God.
Luke 1:36 "And behold, even your relative Elizabeth has also conceived a son in her old age; and she who was called barren is now in her sixth month.
Luke 1:37 "For nothing will be impossible with God."
Luke 1:38 And Mary said, "Behold, the bondslave of the Lord; may it be done to me according to your word." And the angel departed from her.

- Gabriel is a busy angel, and now we see him dispatched to visit Nazareth
    - Luke generously describes Nazareth as a city
        - It was more of a settlement
        - To Luke's gentile readers in his day, it would have been a completely unknown town for anyone living outside Palestine
        - Remember, in John 1:46 people ask can anything good from Nazareth
            - I used to have similar reactions when I told people I lived in El Paso
        - Here Luke begins his contrast between John the B and Jesus
            - John's parents come from the strictly Jewish center of Jerusalem, a place of Pharisitic tradition
            - Jesus' parents live in dusty, backwater Nazareth, a place that was influenced by the pagan world and less strict in observance
- The angel visits a young woman, Mary
    - Her name probably meant exalted one
    - She is called a virgin, young and unmarried

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- In those days, betrothal took place upon puberty, but the consummation of the marriage would await the man's ability to care for the woman was established

- Her husband-to-be is Joseph, a man descended from King David

  - In fact Joseph's father, Eli, is the 40th generation after David, which is an interesting number spiritually speaking – and we can speak more about that fact when we get to chapter 3

  - Joseph is essentially Mary's husband at this point, though there has not been a formal wedding ceremony

    - They were considered husband and wife but lived apart and did not have sexual relations

    - Only a divorce or a death could separate them at this point

- Consider God's comparisons at work here:

  - Mary is a young woman , while Elizabeth is old

  - Mary has made now attempts to bring forth life, while Elizabeth has been working her whole life unsuccessfully

  - Mary is from a place without religious significance (at least in man's eyes), while Elizabeth life is steeped in the culture and formality of Jewish religious practices, focused on the carrying out of the law and sacrificial system

  - Even their husbands reflect this contrast – Zacharias is a priest in the Jew's religious system while Joseph can legitimately lay claim to the throne of Israel by birth

- It seems clear even now how Luke positioned these two accounts as contrasts between the old and the new

  - The Old Covenant and the New Covenant

  - The age old desire to create new life within our dead bodies by our own means vs. a new birth brought by God and through God and given freely to those He chooses

  - A comparison of the old system of man-made rules, of dead religious practices, & of following the law outwardly vs. a new

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grace to be found apart from works, a humble and unadorned faith

- Of God's reigning in the hearts of His people vs. men ruling through a system of laws and regulations
- The child, John, who would be the last of the Old prophets foretelling of the arrival of Jesus, the New Adam who would set men free from slavery under the law

- When Gabriel arrives at Mary's door, the scene plays out very differently than it did for Zacharias
  - Gabriel begins with "Greetings, favored one."
    - Favored one means one who received grace
    - Not the usual do not be afraid greeting, although that comes later
    - In fact, the whole scene plays out in such a way to suggest that the angel has appeared in here in a more human form – less threatening
  - Mary is not bothered by the presence of the messenger, just his greeting
    - Mary was the be that favored one, and she was perplexed as the messenger's greeting, probably because she had not yet had opportunity to conceive
    - The announcement stuns Mary, because every believing Jewish girl dreamed of being the one through whom God would bring the Messiah for the nation of Israel
- The angel senses her concern, and offers his customary line, "Do not be afraid"
  - Then, he explains why she is so favored
    - She will have a son
    - A son of the Most High
    - Who will inherit David's throne and sit upon it forever
  - Gabriel uses language almost identical to those in Isaiah 7 when King Ahaz declares:

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Is. 7:13 Then he said, "Listen now, O house of David! Is it too slight a thing for you to try the patience of men, that you will try the patience of my God as well?
Is. 7:14 "Therefore the Lord Himself will give you a sign: Behold, a virgin will be with child and bear a son, and she will call His name Immanuel.

- Then Mary asks the natural question – how?
  - This is fundamentally different than the response that Zacharias gave
    - Mary is assuming the truth of the angel's statement, which is why she asks for clarification on how it can happen that she conceive without a husband
  - Gabriel answers that the conception would be by the Holy Spirit Himself
  - In other words, God Himself would be the Father

- In fact, did you notice that the angel gives God's revelation of a coming child to the woman here rather than to the man as in the case of Zacharias
  - Luke is making another contrast here
    - Remember, Luke's intended audience, Theophilus was a Greek and had reason to desire proof of what he had been taught of Jesus
    - The Greeks had their own religion based on stories (we call mythology) that included children produced by the mating of Gods and human women
      - In Greek mythology, Zeus the king of Gods had many offspring from both goddesses and human women
      - So to teach that God produced His own offspring through an earthly woman was not news to a Greek
      - But the truth and significance of such an event was important for Luke to stress to his Greek audience
    - Every other faith has stories of prophets, representatives of God, or gods themselves

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- But they all lack proof of the diety's endorsement – the ultimate proof that their claims can be trusted – the power over death
- Confucious, Buddha, Mohammed are still in their graves
- Christ, though he walked earth as a man, died and then walked the earth a second time. He rose from the dead

- Even though John the Baptist was a child created by God's divine intervention, the revelation of his arrival was given to Zacharias because it was to be Zacharias' physical child
  - Luke wanted God to receive the credit for producing the child, but he wanted his audience to understand it would come by natural means
- But in the case of the announcement of Jesus, the revelation is given to Mary – a virgin
  - This helps make the point that Mary would carry a child without regard for Joseph – Joseph was not a factor in the making of this child
  - In fact, Joseph would adopt Jesus to ensure He was properly included in David's kingly line, but as Luke records in chap 3, Jesus was merely supposed to be a son of Joseph

- Gabriel also mentions to Mary that her son would be the Son of the Most High, the very Son of God
  - The term Most High was a common term – even among Greeks – to describe the chief deity
  - There is no doubt that Luke is testifying to Theophilus and the all Greeks that Jesus was both a true man and truly God
- Luke wanted his Greek readers to appreciate the humanity of their Lord
  - Luke wanted it to be clear that God's son was not the product of God and a woman mating – as with Greek gods
  - No, God's Son was placed in Mary supernaturally by the power of the Holy Spirit

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- And thought Jesus was a man, he was not to have the nature of fallen man
    - Remember the first Adam was also created by God's hands, not born of a woman
    - And so he was created perfect and without sin
    - But his disobedience of God introduced sin and changed his nature
        - it produced a creature with a spirit opposed to God and unable to please God or even be in His presence
        - And he would forever produce children after his kind, in his image: i.e., sinful and with a nature opposed to God
- But rather than end it all then, God preferred to make a plan for Adam's redemption
    - He needed someone who could begin again, as it were
        - Someone who could start where Adam started but not yet not fail as Adam did
        - Then God could take all the wrath that His justice demanded and that the first Adam and all those of his kind deserved
        - And He could chose to pour it out on the second Adam, who had not earned any wrath of his own and did not deserve it
        - Thus he could save the first Adam by sacrificing the second Adam, so long as the second Adam willingly accepted the wrath that was not his, and the first Adam willingly accepted the glory that was not his
- So, God had to produce another "Adam" –
    - One that was not born of the fallen nature of the first Adam,
    - Yet one who had all the same desires and limitations of the first Adam so that he would be a suitable substitute
- In other words, God's plan of salvation by substitutionary atonement

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- Finally, Gabriel announces to Mary that her relative, Elizabeth has also conceived
    - We don't know the exact nature of the relationship between Mary and Elizabeth
    - The word for relative literally means kinsman, but we know that Elizabeth came from the line of Levi while Mary descended from Judah
        - perhaps it refers to their kinship as Jewish woman or the common bond they would now share in their children
    - The angel offers this fact as proof of God's ability to do anything
        - Mary never asked for proof of the angel's statements, unlike Zacharias, but the angel determines to give one anyway
        - His announcement of Elizabeth's impending birth is intended to reinforce Mary's trust and hope
            - After all, Mary didn't know that Elizabeth was pregnant, and now the news coming from the angel would cement Mary's belief
            - Even in this detail God's plan was perfect
                - Elizabeth's pregnancy was now self-evident and her birth would proceed Christ's by at least 6 months, giving her added hope
- Mary ends by calling herself a bondservant of God and says let everything happen as you have said
    - You have to take a moment to appreciate the courage in that statement
        - Mary was agreeing to become a pariah, an outcast
        - She would be hated and misunderstood
        - People would assume she was not chaste until marriage and would shun her
        - Yet she accepts this sentence of worldly condemnation willingly
    - Here Luke is offering another contrast

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- Elizabeth's child would remove reproach from her while Mary's would bring reproach in her lifetime
- Consequently, Elizabeth continues to reflect the Old Covenant,
  - A covenant that produced outward praise by men for those who could confirm to their expectations of righteousness
- While Mary reflects a New Covenant that often brings upon its followers the world's scorn and derision
  - For it does not bring righteousness by conformance with outward measures but by inward change that rejects the world

- Next, Luke will bring the two story lines together, as Mary and Elizabeth meet to share their good news
  - The meeting produces some of the most compelling examples of Gods sovereignty in the lives of His people in the Gospels
- But we should end today with prayer and meditation on the awesomeness of a God who would take human form to correct Adam's mistake

Heb. 2:5 ¶ For He did not subject to angels the world to come, concerning which we are speaking.
Heb. 2:6 But one has testified somewhere, saying,
"WHAT IS MAN, THAT YOU REMEMBER HIM?
OR THE SON OF MAN, THAT YOU ARE CONCERNED ABOUT HIM?
Heb. 2:7 "YOU HAVE MADE HIM FOR A LITTLE WHILE LOWER THAN THE ANGELS;
YOU HAVE CROWNED HIM WITH GLORY AND HONOR,
AND HAVE APPOINTED HIM OVER THE WORKS OF YOUR HANDS;
Heb. 2:8 YOU HAVE PUT ALL THINGS IN SUBJECTION UNDER HIS FEET."
For in subjecting all things to him, He left nothing that is not subject to him. But now we do not yet see all things subjected to him.
Heb. 2:9 But we do see Him who was made for a little while lower than the angels, *namely*, Jesus, because of the suffering of death crowned with glory and honor, so that by the grace of God He might taste death for everyone.
Heb. 2:10 ¶ For it was fitting for Him, for whom are all things, and through whom are all things, in bringing many sons to glory, to perfect the author of their salvation through sufferings.

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Heb. 2:11 For both He who sanctifies and those who are sanctified are all from one *Father*; for which reason He is not ashamed to call them brethren,
Heb. 2:12 saying,

"I WILL PROCLAIM YOUR NAME TO MY BRETHREN,
IN THE MIDST OF THE CONGREGATION I WILL SING YOUR PRAISE."

Heb. 2:13 And again,

"I WILL PUT MY TRUST IN HIM."

And again,

"BEHOLD, I AND THE CHILDREN WHOM GOD HAS GIVEN ME."

Heb. 2:14 ¶ Therefore, since the children share in flesh and blood, He Himself likewise also partook of the same, that through death He might render powerless him who had the power of death, that is, the devil,
Heb. 2:15 and might free those who through fear of death were subject to slavery all their lives.
Heb. 2:16 For assuredly He does not give help to angels, but He gives help to the descendant of Abraham.

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Luke 1C

- Two woman, Elizabeth & Mary, at opposite points in their lives, are expecting children
    - Elizabeth's knows it is a miraculous birth and she has given God credit in faith for the child to be
    - Mary actually heard from an angel concerning the nature of her child, and she responded in reverence and submission
- To encourage both women, the angel told Mary about her relative Elizabeth, and of course Mary will rush to find her and share their experiences

Luke 1:39 ¶ Now at this time Mary arose and went in a hurry to the hill country, to a city of Judah,
Luke 1:40 and entered the house of Zacharias and greeted Elizabeth.
Luke 1:41 When Elizabeth heard Mary's greeting, the baby leaped in her womb; and Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit.
Luke 1:42 And she cried out with a loud voice and said, "Blessed *are* you among women, and blessed *is* the fruit of your womb!
Luke 1:43 "And how has it *happened* to me, that the mother of my Lord would come to me?
Luke 1:44 "For behold, when the sound of your greeting reached my ears, the baby leaped in my womb for joy.
Luke 1:45 "And blessed *is* she who believed that there would be a fulfillment of what had been spoken to her by the Lord."

- Mary lived in Nazareth, located in the northern part of Judah about 64 miles as the crow flies from Jerusalem
    - Elizabeth and her husband live outside the main part of the city in the hill country of Judah
        - This phrase is often associated in scripture with Hebron, which is another 20 miles south of Jerusalem
    - So Mary likely walked by herself approximately 60-80 miles to see Elizabeth – at least a 4 day journey

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- How excited do you suppose Mary was about this child and about hearing that Elizabeth was having a child?
- Did Mary have any other plans I wonder?
- Was she scheduled to be somewhere and to do something important that week?
  - Did she wonder how she was going to be cared for while away?
  - Did she worry about what her friends would think?
- Another man did much the same thing – Abraham left Ur

- You see, when God takes hold of you and gives you new direction and purpose – when He awakens you to His work and makes you a part of it…
  - Your interest in normal life, worldly life will naturally drop
  - You will find yourself losing interest in things you used to find so important
  - And you will become consumed by things you should have been consumed by in the first place
    - My call into a teaching ministry
    - My list of things I don't find so interesting any longer

- But you have to listen to God, hear His instructions, and take them to heart
  - You may be tempted to say that Mary heard so clearly from an angel that she couldn't miss God, of course
  - But let's be honest - many times so do we, yet we aren't in the habit of listening much less responding
  - So we don't often take the kind of radical steps that the characters of the Bible so often do
    - There are probably many reasons why we don't
      - Less time in study, in prayer, in reliance on God
      - But perhaps the most important reason for our culture is really very simple – we're too busy

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- We have busy calendars, we have action-packed lives
    - We pass that to our kids – they can only do three sports, two club activities, two musical instruments, and no more than 4 sleep overs per week
    - We drive our kids much like we drive ourselves, to be completely absorbed in the life of this world – forgetting that as a Christian we are to be as foreigners in this world knowing it is all passing and worth nothing
    - How much better would life be – and how ,much better would we hear and respond to God – if we observed what David said in Psalms 46-10: Cease striving and know that I am God.
    - And what if we taught our kids that same principle?
- We could all learn from Mary, and recognizing that when we give Him space to direct our steps, we will hear from God,
- And when we hear Him, nothing else will matter and there will be no doubts, no need for excuses – we can just respond and start walking like Mary and like Abraham

- So Mary arrives at Zacharias' house, and at the sound of Mary's voice, the baby in Elizabeth's womb leaps and she is filled with the Holy Spirit
    - The Holy Spirit features prominently in this passage, and there are several things to note about the HS work
    - First, remember the angel who announced the child to Zacharias in the temple…he said in verse 15 that her child will be filled with the Holy Spirit
        - This seems to be the point when that occurs
        - The child reacts to Mary and likewise, Elizabeth herself is filled with the HS
        - The presence of the HS in Elizabeth brought about her speech in praise of Mary and of her child
        - In fact, Elizabeth calls Mary's child her Lord

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        - And Elizabeth even calls Mary blessed because she believed the promise that her child would be the Messiah

    - Her entire outburst seems to have occurred before Mary says anything to her whatsoever about her child

        - Elizabeth would not have known about Mary's pregnancy from observation (it certainly wasn't visible yet)

        - So, we must conclude that the words she spoke were inspired words, as Luke records them, the direct revelation of God given to Elizabeth through he Spirit

- This is one of many examples in scripture of how the HS works in the lives of men and women

    - The HS has always had a ministry on Earth

        - -He's seen in the second verse of Genesis hovering over the surface of the waters

    - Later in OT times, the HS would come upon men for various reasons to accomplish God's purpose

        - He would give power to men, wisdom, or revelations and prophecies

        - He would also give utterances – as with Balaam in Num 24 when the Spirit of the Lord comes upon him as he tried to curse Israel

        - But the permanent indwelling of the Holy Spirit did not happen – at least not routinely to men of faith

        - Christ told the disciples that the HS would baptize them after His accession – thus beginning a new period in history where the HS would now indwell men permanently

    - Elizabeth's experience seems consistent with the OT manner of how the HS worked

        - He came upon her for a time to produce this utterance but did not remain continually

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- The second aspect of the HS to notice here is that the HS's primary ministry is to glorify God, in particular here through Elizabeth's speech
    - Giving glory to Christ and the Father is a consistent role for the HS
        - He does so by how He causes men to behave (our sanctification) and speak and praise God (worshipping in Spirit and Truth)

John 16:7 "But I tell you the truth, it is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you; but if I go, I will send Him to you.
John 16:8 "And He, when He comes, will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment;
John 16:9 concerning sin, because they do not believe in Me;
John 16:10 and concerning righteousness, because I go to the Father and you no longer see Me;
John 16:11 and concerning judgment, because the ruler of this world has been judged.

- The HS has three roles in glorifying the Son and the Father
    - He brings conviction of sin
    - He brings about righteousness in believers as a picture of Christ in Christ's absence
    - And He testifies to coming judgment through signs and wonders appointed by God

- The final aspect of the Spirit visible in this passage is perhaps the most profound
- Paul taught in Romans that the definition of a Christian is anyone who has the indwelling of the Holy Spirit

Rom. 8:9 ¶ However, you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you. But if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he does not belong to Him.
Rom. 8:14 For all who are being led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God.

Eph. 1:13 And you also were included in Christ when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation. Having believed, you were marked in him with a seal, the promised Holy Spirit,

- So, if the Holy Spirit comes upon men as a seal of their faith, what does it mean that the Holy Spirit came to John the Baptist in the womb?

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- First, it confirms the truth of Eph 2:8-9

Eph. 2:8 For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith — and this not from yourselves, it is the gift of God —
Eph. 2:9 not by works, so that no one can boast.

- The gift we all received from God was our faith – it was a supernatural moment when we believed in the Gospel, because our belief in God was a product of a faith He gave us

- He acted first and we responded

1Cor. 12:3 Therefore I make known to you that no one speaking by the Spirit of God says, "Jesus is accursed"; and no one can say, "Jesus is Lord," except by the Holy Spirit.

- The second thing John's indwelling means is that God is not dependent on the intellectual faith of the believer to provide the gift of faith

  - Since it is a gift, it comes as a matter of God's power and right to give it without regard to our understanding

    - we don't think and reason our way into our salvation – that would be a work and we could boast

    - But so that no man may boast, faith itself is given to men apart from intellect – though we disclose our faith to others by our intellect

    - Even to ourselves, we come to a realization of the faith we have been given

- Since John the Baptist was given the Holy Spirit prior to birth, it proves that God was not dependent on John the Baptist's understanding the Gospel and the need for him to agree with it before he could bring John the Baptist to faith

  - Like Paul says in Romans about Jacob, and Esau

Rom. 9:10 And not only this, but there was Rebekah also, when she had conceived *twins* by one man, our father Isaac;
Rom. 9:11 for though *the twins* were not yet born and had not done anything good or bad, so that God's purpose according to *His* choice would stand, not because of works but because of Him who calls,
Rom. 9:12 it was said to her, "THE OLDER WILL SERVE THE YOUNGER."
Rom. 9:13 Just as it is written, "JACOB I LOVED, BUT ESAU I HATED."

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- John the Baptist was going to believe in the Gospel because God gave him the gift of faith while in the womb
    - The implications of this truth run deep
        - This means that God may be producing saving faith in people we may have always wondered about
            - Infant deaths, invalids, mentally handicapped
        - Secondly, there is no need to manufacture the extra-biblical teaching of an age of accountability

- Before we move the next passage in Luke, consider how Elizabeth addresses Mary
    - She says that Mary is mother of her Lord
    - This is not the same as saying Mary is Mother of God
        - Jesus is God, but not all of God is Jesus
        - Though others have called Mary "Mother of God," scripture never uses that term

Luke 1:46 ¶ And Mary said:
"My soul exalts the Lord,
Luke 1:47 And my spirit has rejoiced in God my Savior.
Luke 1:48 "For He has had regard for the humble state of His bondslave;
For behold, from this time on all generations will count me blessed.
Luke 1:49 "For the Mighty One has done great things for me;
And holy is His name.
Luke 1:50 "AND HIS MERCY IS UPON GENERATION AFTER GENERATION
TOWARD THOSE WHO FEAR HIM.
Luke 1:51 "He has done mighty deeds with His arm;
He has scattered *those who were* proud in the thoughts of their heart.
Luke 1:52 "He has brought down rulers from *their* thrones,
And has exalted those who were humble.
Luke 1:53 "HE HAS FILLED THE HUNGRY WITH GOOD THINGS;
And sent away the rich empty-handed.

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Luke 1:54 "He has given help to Israel His servant,
In remembrance of His mercy,
Luke 1:55 As He spoke to our fathers,
To Abraham and his descendants forever."
Luke 1:56 ¶ And Mary stayed with her about three months, and *then* returned to her home.

- Now it's Mary's turn to give an inspired utterance in praise of God
    - It's hard to know if she had been working on this beforehand or if it was entirely spontaneous
    - It's worth noting that many of the phrases she uses come directly out of the OT, notably the Psalms
    - Even if the Spirit brought these things to her mind, which is likely the case, it also illustrates how much glory God receives from praises that rely on His word
        - A primary requirement of worship should be that God's word features prominently – not just in study but also in praise music and prayer
        - When His word is missing, we are not worshiping in spirit and in truth and He is not glorified

- This passage also helps us refute a common heretical teaching concerning Mary held by the Catholic Church
    - Mary, as we know, gave birth to Jesus while as a virgin, and since Christ was a second Adam, He didn't carry the original sin of Adam
    - The RCC goes one step farther, however, and they declared that Mary herself was also born free of original sin – the Immaculate Conception they call it
    - This passage has Mary praising her Lord, her God, her Savior
        - If Mary was born without original sin, then she would have no need for a savior just as Christ needed no forgiveness for His own sins

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- Instead, she acknowledges her need for a savior as does the rest of mankind – she suffered from sin as do the rest of us
- She didn't pass that sin to Christ, because He was merely placed in her by the Holy Spirit – not created from her

- In mentioning all the great things God was doing for Israel and the world through the gift of his son, she counts herself blessed for all time
  - Every orthodox Jewish girl who ever lived grew up hoping that she might be the one through whom the Messiah would come
  - In realizing that dream, Mary is overwhelmed with admiration and joy
- And as the passage finishes, we learn that Mary stays long enough to see the birth of John, and then return while she still had strength to travel home
- Now Luke transitions to concluding the account of Elizabeth and particularly Zacharias

Luke 1:57 ¶ Now the time had come for Elizabeth to give birth, and she gave birth to a son.
Luke 1:58 Her neighbors and her relatives heard that the Lord had displayed His great mercy toward her; and they were rejoicing with her.
Luke 1:59 ¶ And it happened that on the eighth day they came to circumcise the child, and they were going to call him Zacharias, after his father.
Luke 1:60 But his mother answered and said, "No indeed; but he shall be called John."
Luke 1:61 And they said to her, "There is no one among your relatives who is called by that name."
Luke 1:62 And they made signs to his father, as to what he wanted him called.
Luke 1:63 And he asked for a tablet and wrote as follows, "His name is John." And they were all astonished.

- Elizabeth and Zacharias have their son and the family and neighbors have been praising God for the miracle of a healthy child for such an older couple
  - How wonderful it si when God's graciousness in the lives of His people results in praise of His name
  - We should always makes sure that His blessings upon each of us results in not only our praise of Him but in others as well

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- Impress upon those you know how much God has done and give them the example to follow in giving credit where credit is rightfully due

- At the eighth day, under Jewish tradition as given to Abraham by God, it's time to name the child and circumcise him

  - Naming the child was the Father's right, although the woman no doubt played a part in choosing that name

  - Since this was their only child – and likely to be their only child – and since it was a first born son, the natural assumption among the family was the child would be named after the father

  - Remember the father can't speak yet, so there isn't effort being made to engage in conversation with him, so they ask the mother if he will be named Zacharias

- She says he will be John, which we know is because the angel gave him that name

  - Naturally, the family is confused since the name has no connection to the family

  - They ask the father for confirmation

    - Curiously, they use hand gestures to communicate to Zacharias – Why? Was he mute and deaf

    - The word for mute (kophos) in 1:23 can mean deaf and mute, so perhaps he was unable to hear either

  - If true, this would better explain the rest of the account, because when Zacharias writes John, it astounds them all

    - If Zacharias could hear but not speak, then his repeating of John wouldn't seem so amazing – just an odd name to pick

    - But they are astonished – marveled and amazed

- Upon hearing him give the same name, his voice returns

  - It would seem that God was determined to receive the glory and praise that Zacharias should have given God in His temple when he saw the angel

    - Instead of praise, Zacharias asked for proof, doubting God's word

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- God will not be put to the test and because Zacharias denied God the glory He deserved, he was silenced
- Until the day when God could use even Zacharias' silence as a means of gaining glory, as He has now done
  - This crowd would now give God glory over the amazing way the baby was named – clearly his name came from God
  - Then God would give Zacharias' voice back, having gained the glory He deserved in the end

- This is exactly how God deals with each of us
  - We are His creation and we exist for His pleasure
  - He takes pleasure in us, but He created this world to His own glory
  - And He saved us by His will and through His own Son also for His glory
    - When demonstrate doubt in His Word,
    - or when we fail to give Him the glory for His work in our life,
    - or when we bring shame upon Him and grieve the HS by our disobedience
    - God will find ways to discipline us for our errors yet all the while bringing glory to Himself through our errors
      - Because His glory will not be diminished one bit
  - How much better is it to give God glory through obedience than through disobedience!
  - Remember what God said concerning obedience versus dead religious practice:

1Sam. 15:22 Samuel said,

"Has the LORD as much delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices
As in obeying the voice of the LORD?
Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice,
And to heed than the fat of rams.

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Luke 1D

- Elizabeth has given birth to the promised son, and now the time for circumcision on the eighth day has arrived
- As the family and friends are all gathered around for the circumcision, she and her husband call the child John by the inspiration of the Holy Spirit
    - John has remained mute and most likely deaf for the entire 9 months of pregnancy
    - And suddenly he finds himself free from God's discipline and ready to speak to the world concerning God and, interestingly, both his son and the son of his wife's relative, Mary

Luke 1:63 And he asked for a tablet and wrote as follows, "His name is John." And they were all astonished.
Luke 1:64 And at once his mouth was opened and his tongue *loosed*, and he *began* to speak in praise of God.
Luke 1:65 Fear came on all those living around them; and all these matters were being talked about in all the hill country of Judea.
Luke 1:66 All who heard them kept them in mind, saying, "What then will this child *turn out to* be?" For the hand of the Lord was certainly with him.

- God purposed to silence Zacharias in the temple in response to Zacharias' doubt of the angel's word
    - His doubting heart robbed God of glory and praise he deserved
    - And it had the effect of demanding proof from God – a test, in order words
- God's discipline of Zacharias dealt with his mistake and at the same time accomplished at least two other good purposes
    - First, God was true to His character in chastising disobedience and disbelief through His decision to silence Zacharias
        - Zacharias became a public spectacle for those nine months, receiving the misery of God's chastisement, all the time considering the words he spoke in the temple and regretting them

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- God's punishment was so appropriate because it dealt with the problem – rash speech – and gave Zacharias plenty of opportunity to consider his mistake and repent

- Remember Paul's words in Romans:

Rom. 2:4 Or do you think lightly of the riches of His kindness and tolerance and patience, not knowing that the kindness of God leads you to repentance?

- What proof do we have of Zacharias' repentance? He names the baby John, which the angel had instructed him to do – proof of his acceptance of God's word through the angel

- Secondly, despite Zacharias' error, God still received His proper glory, and in fact, His glory was magnified even further because of Zacharias' error

  - At the point when Zacharias first heard the news from the angel in the temple, he was alone – completely alone

  - Now had he responded in faith in that moment, God would have received glory from Zacharias and later the world would have given God glory as Zacharias testified about it

  - Since Zacharais didn't praise God and he was silenced, he became a spectacle as punishment

  - Later, God used that spectacle to magnify His own glory by returning Zacharias' voice in a very and miraculous way public way, with many people watching

    - As John was named while Zacharias was deaf and mute, it gave God glory

    - Then as his voice was restored, it gave God glory as it was seen as a supernatural healing

    - And then we see how God receives the glory for the miraculous gift of John as the people realize that the family had been involved in something miraculous (v 65)

- Finally, God used this entire situation to bring special attention to John's birth and his God-appointed purpose

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- In verse 66 the people begin to connect the dots and wonder what will become of a child so obviously brought by miraculous circumstances

- God was glorified in much greater ways and His purpose to bring John was even enhanced by Zacharias' disobedience and doubt

  - Does not God turn all things to good??

Luke 1:67 ¶ And his father Zacharias was filled with the Holy Spirit, and prophesied, saying:
Luke 1:68 "Blessed *be* the Lord God of Israel,
For He has visited us and accomplished redemption for His people,
Luke 1:69 And has raised up a horn of salvation for us
In the house of David His servant—
Luke 1:70 As He spoke by the mouth of His holy prophets from of old—
Luke 1:71 Salvation FROM OUR ENEMIES,
And FROM THE HAND OF ALL WHO HATE US;
Luke 1:72 To show mercy toward our fathers,
And to remember His holy covenant,
Luke 1:73 The oath which He swore to Abraham our father,
Luke 1:74 To grant us that we, being rescued from the hand of our enemies,
Might serve Him without fear,
Luke 1:75 In holiness and righteousness before Him all our days.

- Like Elizabeth and Mary, Zacharias finds himself filled by the Holy Spirit and begins to prophesy, we're told

  - Zacharias' outburst differs from the women's in that his speech

    - His is a combination of showing fulfillment of prophecy and providing new prophecy

    - The women gave praise without significant prophecy

  - Zacharias is being used by God to deliver the real meaning of these events in the course of giving God thanks and praise

- Interestingly, Zacharias begins talking about a baby that's not his own – Mary's unborn baby

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- While it might seem strange from a worldly perspective, Zacharias' decision to start with Jesus makes perfect sense
  - Zacharias' child has only one purpose – to foretell of Christ
  - Without Christ, John the Baptist has no reason to exist
  - So naturally, The HS begins Zacahrias' speech with the true purpose for his son's birth – Christ's coming arrival
- He calls Christ the horn of salvation, a quote from Psalms 18, the same place Christ is called my rock, shield, refuge, stronghold
- And he declares that God is bringing the Messiah to fulfill His Holy Covenant – specifically the covenant given to Abraham

Gen. 22:16 and said, "By Myself I have sworn, declares the LORD, because you have done this thing and have not withheld your son, your only son,
Gen. 22:17 indeed I will greatly bless you, and I will greatly multiply your seed as the stars of the heavens and as the sand which is on the seashore; and your seed shall possess the gate of their enemies.
Gen. 22:18 "In your seed all the nations of the earth shall be blessed, because you have obeyed My voice."

- Paul explains the full meaning of those verses in Galations:

Gal. 3:16 Now the promises were spoken to Abraham and to his seed. He does not say, "And to seeds," as *referring* to many, but *rather* to one, "And to your seed," that is, Christ.

- When we see Zacharias saying that God has remembered His holy covenant with Abraham, it means that God has remembered to bring the seed that Paul explains is Christ

- Now Zacharias finally turns to his own son.

Luke 1:76 "And you, child, will be called the prophet of the Most High;
For you will go on BEFORE THE LORD TO PREPARE HIS WAYS;
Luke 1:77 To give to His people *the* knowledge of salvation
By the forgiveness of their sins,
Luke 1:78 Because of the tender mercy of our God,

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With which the Sunrise from on high will visit us,
Luke 1:79 TO SHINE UPON THOSE WHO SIT IN DARKNESS AND THE SHADOW OF DEATH,
To guide our feet into the way of peace."
Luke 1:80 ¶ And the child continued to grow and to become strong in spirit, and he lived in the deserts until the day of his public appearance to Israel.

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- Now begins Zacharias' prophetic pronouncements concerning his son John
    - John the Baptist was to be the prophet of the Most High
        - He is the one appointed to specifically foretell of the Messiah's arrival
        - To prepare the way of the Lord

- How was John to "prepare the Lord's way?"
    - Actually, John prepares the way of the Lord in at least a couple of ways
        - First, he provided a physical preparation, as the angel announced to Zacharias

Luke 1:17 "It is he who will go *as a forerunner* before Him in the spirit and power of Elijah, TO TURN THE HEARTS OF THE FATHERS BACK TO THE CHILDREN, and the disobedient to the attitude of the righteous, so as to make ready a people prepared for the Lord."

    - John's clearing of a path filled a very real practical need
        - When the Lord began his ministry in AD30, he found Himself in a world largely dead to the knowledge of the living God
            - The world was dominated by a pagan world power, the Roman Empire
            - Which itself had been preceded by another pagan world power, Greece
            - Which itself had been preceded by another pagan world power, the Medo-Persians, etc.
        - Even within Palestine, the Jewish people had long been ruled by sects of self-righteous men
            - They carried out the law as a yoke to burden men
            - They taught of a Messiah who would conquer the Romans through political overthrow

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- And they defined righteousness in hypocritical ways, seeking to keep themselves above the people

- In this climate, true faith was crushed and true understanding of God's purposes was nearly lost

- God wished His Son to be met by an understanding and watchful people who were waiting for Him

  - They should be understanding of their own sinfulness, rather than proclaiming their righteousness

  - They should be understanding of their need for salvation from God, rather than claiming righteousness for themselves by their works

  - Verse 77 says exactly that

  - Essentially, John would take what little remnant remained in Israel and build it up in anticipation of Christ's coming

- It's worth noting note how much our world reflects the one that existed immediately before Christ's first coming

  - Our world is dominated by pagan culture – even Christian pagan culture in many forms

  - A true knowledge of God and His Word is rapidly fading from many places

    - Thought we may have trouble believing this, given how much attention we ourselves give to scripture, it's true

    - Even our Christian culture is also largely ignorant of the God of the Bible and His word

  - Many people who claim to be Christian are often just modern day Pharisees

    - People don't believe in sin or even absolute moral laws

    - People don't recognize their need for a savior

    - Righteousness has returned to an external act for many people, according to man-made rules

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- So in addition to many other signs given by scripture to testify that we are in the end times, I see further proof in this fact
    - That our world has as much need for a John the Baptist to prepare a path for our Lord's return as the Roman world had before Christ's first coming
    - And in fact, that's exactly what scripture says, as we studied a few weeks ago
        - Malachi told us that the Lord will send Elijah before the great and terrible day of the Lord to prepare people for His second coming
- Now Luke's attention will turn to the birth of Jesus…

Luke 2:1 ¶ Now in those days a decree went out from Caesar Augustus, that a census be taken of all the inhabited earth.
Luke 2:2 This was the first census taken while Quirinius was governor of Syria.
Luke 2:3 And everyone was on his way to register for the census, each to his own city.
Luke 2:4 Joseph also went up from Galilee, from the city of Nazareth, to Judea, to the city of David which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and family of David,
Luke 2:5 in order to register along with Mary, who was engaged to him, and was with child.

- Luke's second chapter opens with the historical context for Jesus' birth
    - We should begin by reviewing a little political history of that time
        - The region of Palestine was a province of Rome at the time of Christ's birth
        - A province was considered a holding of the Roman Empire – a territory under Roman rule and obligated to pay taxes to Rome but denied full citizenship and protection of the law
            - It would be comparable to the American colonies under British authority
            - There was a limited degree of autonomy but always with Roman governors ruling
            - Palestine was essentially split according in three provinces, which dated back to the Alexandrian Empire

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- Syria to the north
- Judea in the middle
- And Nabatea in the Sinai to the south

- Each had its own Roman governor

- The emperor of the entire Roman empire was the Caesar, in this case Caesar Augustus – who issued the decree for a Empire-wide census

- There had been other Roman censuses before, but this was the first census to include the provinces
- Census were done because the Roman Empire would tax its various territories and provinces according to the number of people living there

- The Caesar would assess a certain tax on the province and the governor was obligated to pay it
- The governor then had to collect what he could from the province to pay Caesar, and anything more he could collect became his own wealth
- This is why tax collectors were so despised because they operated on commission, something like an organized crime syndicate

- So Augustus' census was designed to set new tax rates according to the number of subjects in each territory

- Luke also ties this event to the rule of the governor of Syria, Cyrinius

- Luke probably did this because this governor had a relatively short reign, only 2 years from 3-2 BC, giving us a much more precise timeline for the birth of Christ

- But Luke's record does introduce a dilemma as well

- And though Luke doesn't mention it here, the governor of Judea at the time of Christ's birth was Herod the Great – Matthew tells us this

- History also records that Herod the Great dies in 4 BC,
- So Christ must have been born around or slightly before 4 BC

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- But history also tells us that Cyrinius was governor of Syria from 3-2 BC,
  - So how could Jesus be born while Cyrinius was governor and while Herod the Great was alive, yet Herod died before Cyrinius was governor?
- Well, the answer comes from the language in the text
  - In verse 2 we're told that this was the first census while Cyrinius was governor
    - The word for first, protos, has several possible meanings in Greek
    - It can mean "first," but it can also mean "prior" or "former"
    - In other words, the second verse could be understood to mean the census was taken "prior" to Cyrinius becoming governor, which would make sense

- In the end, all the evidence points to Jesus' birth occurring around 5 BC
- Shortly before Jesus' birth, they set out from Nazareth for Bethlehem, about 70 miles
  - This trip was very similar to the one Mary took 6 months earlier when she visited Elizabeth
  - Joseph brings Mary, but this is an interesting fact in itself
    - Joseph was engaged to Mary (bethrothed) though she was with child
      - He had not consummated the wedding, which would have been the normal thing to do
      - Wither he would have abandoned her or married her quickly to save her the embarrassment of being pregnant while engaged
    - Meanwhile, they would not normally spend time together in advance of their wedding, so a long trip together would have been very unusual

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- Mary's condition would have left her despised and scorned, and so it's likely that Joseph brought her along to protect her and provide support – treating as a wife but not calling her his wife

- This would have left Joseph looking like a fool to everyone – a sucker, someone with no self respect

- As Paul tells of his own experience:

1Cor. 4:9 For, I think, God has exhibited us apostles last of all, as men condemned to death; because we have become a spectacle to the world, both to angels and to men.
1Cor. 4:10 We are fools for Christ's sake, but you are prudent in Christ; we are weak, but you are strong; you are distinguished, but we are without honor.
1Cor. 4:11 To this present hour we are both hungry and thirsty, and are poorly clothed, and are roughly treated, and are homeless;
1Cor. 4:12 and we toil, working with our own hands; when we are reviled, we bless; when we are persecuted, we endure;
1Cor. 4:13 when we are slandered, we try to conciliate; we have become as the scum of the world, the dregs of all things, *even* until now.

- You could say that Joseph was the first fool for Christ

- Joseph was returning to Bethlehem, because the census required that each person return the their ancestral home

- For Joseph, as a member of the tribe of Judah, his ancestral home was Bethlehem, although he may never have lived there himself

- Bethlehem was the city of David's birth, and in Micah 5:2 we learn that the Messaiah was to be born there

Mic. 5:2 "But as for you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,
Too little to be among the clans of Judah,
From you One will go forth for Me to be ruler in Israel.
His goings forth are from long ago,
From the days of eternity."

- Was God simply telling us of what would happen, or did God want the Messiah to be born in Bethlehem?

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- This is important because it cuts to the core of what it means to be God – simply knowing the future or controlling the future?
- Consider the significance of why Jesus would be born in Bethlehem
  - He is a son of David and comes to rule like his "father" David
  - But He will be greater than David (Matt 22:45)
  - And so David is a picture of the Messiah ruling over a united Israel

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- If David is a picture of the Messiah, then even David's birthplace must have been used to picture the coming Christ
  - Since David was born in Bethlehem, God intended to bring the Christ from that town as well
  - So God must have been in control of even the circumstances surrounding the census to ensure that Joseph would learn Nazareth in time for the birth

- More importantly, why was Jesus brought up in Nazareth then. Why not be raised in Bethlehem?
  - We turn to Matt 2 to gain insight on this question
  - In Matt 2:23 we hear:

Matt. 2:23 and came and lived in a city called Nazareth. *This was* to fulfill what was spoken through the prophets: "He shall be called a Nazarene."

  - However, there is no reference in OT scripture to the Messiah being a Nazarene, nor is there even a single reference to the town of Nazareth – not one
  - So why was Matthew saying and what prophecy was he referring to?

- Again, the language is a key for us here as is some cultural understanding
  - The word Nazarene was commonly given to anyone who originated from the general region of Nazareth
  - Over the centuries the region became associated with despised and lowly people
    - Perhaps there is some lost history to explain this association
    - Perhaps it comes from the nazirite vows given in Numbers 6
      - The word Nazirite means consecrated or devote one

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- It was a practice one could take to devote oneself completely to the Lord for a period of time
    - To show you were under such a vow, you wouldn't cut your hair or drink wine
    - We know, however that Christ was not under such a vow, at least as an adult since He drank wine
- Those under such a vow would be shunned, much like John the Baptist was because of how he separated himself in the wilderness
- But the entomologies of the word Nazirite and Nazarene are actually different, so this connection is shaky at best

- For whatever reason, Nazarenes were despised and thought as lowly
    - And here is where I believe Matt is showing the fulfillment of scripture with Christ
    - Jesus was lowly and despised because He came from Nazareth
        - Remember they said of him in John "Can anything good come from Nazareth?"
        - He is always thought of as lowly and without honor
    - And this coincides with much Scripture

Psa. 22:1 ¶ My God, my God, why have You forsaken me?
Far from my deliverance are the words of my groaning.
Psa. 22:2 O my God, I cry by day, but You do not answer;
And by night, but I have no rest.
Psa. 22:3 Yet You are holy,
O You who are enthroned upon the praises of Israel.
Psa. 22:4 In You our fathers trusted;
They trusted and You delivered them.
Psa. 22:5 To You they cried out and were delivered;
In You they trusted and were not disappointed.
Psa. 22:6 ¶ But I am a worm and not a man,
A reproach of men and despised by the people.

- Or in Isaiah 49:

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Is. 49:7 Thus says the LORD, the Redeemer of Israel *and* its Holy One,
To the despised One,
To the One abhorred by the nation,
To the Servant of rulers,
"Kings will see and arise,
Princes will also bow down,
Because of the LORD who is faithful, the Holy One of Israel who has chosen You."

- Christ was despised for our sake, and in that the prophets testified to his being a Nazarene, though without using the word itself
  - Jesus had to be a Nazarne – he had to be despised – because He had to die – because our sins required it
  - He has a time to come win glory and to rule, but it had to be preceded by a cruel death – or he would have had no one to rule over in His kingdom
  - For all would have been deserving of death rather than life with their King

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Luke 2A

- Welcome to Christmas in July
- The story of Christ's birth is well known and often told
    - At least once a year we are reminded of the story of Joseph and Mary looking for room in the inn and forced to stay in a manger to give birth to their child
    - Of the shepherds and the angels and the wise men with gifts, etc.
    - Well, this year you get it twice
- But this story can and should be studied for its spiritual depth even as it's been enjoyed for its poetic beauty
    - But to do so, we're going to have to take a step back from the popular account and almost force ourselves to let go of the childhood storyline of which we've become so familiar
- So, we begin with Mary's labor and birth in Bethlehem

Luke 2:4 Joseph also went up from Galilee, from the city of Nazareth, to Judea, to the city of David which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and family of David,
Luke 2:5 in order to register along with Mary, who was engaged to him, and was with child.
Luke 2:6 While they were there, the days were completed for her to give birth.
Luke 2:7 And she gave birth to her firstborn son; and she wrapped Him in cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn.
Luke 2:8 ¶ In the same region there were *some* shepherds staying out in the fields and keeping watch over their flock by night.
Luke 2:9 And an angel of the Lord suddenly stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them; and they were terribly frightened.
Luke 2:10 But the angel said to them, "Do not be afraid; for behold, I bring you good news of great joy which will be for all the people;
Luke 2:11 for today in the city of David there has been born for you a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.
Luke 2:12 "This *will be* a sign for you: you will find a baby wrapped in cloths and lying in a manger."
Luke 2:13 And suddenly there appeared with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying,

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Luke 2:14 "Glory to God in the highest,
And on earth peace among men with whom He is pleased."
Luke 2:15 ¶ When the angels had gone away from them into heaven, the shepherds *began* saying to one another, "Let us go straight to Bethlehem then, and see this thing that has happened which the Lord has made known to us."

- Bethlehem was a small town in Christ's day, as it is even today
    - Dating back to one of the earliest church fathers, Hyppolytus in the 2nd Century, the time of Christ's birth has been estimated to be late December or early January 5-4 BC.
    - It would have been early winter, but probably the weather that year seems to have been unseasonably mild
        - For example, the shepherds are out at night with their flocks, indicating it was warm enough, even for a clear evening, to be outside
        - Wouldn't the Father have made sure conditions on Earth were favorable for the birth of his son - exposed as He was – as well all who would be called upon to travel that night
        - Of course, because we know He's caring enough to watch over every detail in His marvelous plan
- Much has been made about the manger birth and the evil innkeeper, whoever he was, who didn't make room for Christ that night
    - The innkeeper is getting a bum wrap here likely
        - The Greek word for inn kataluma means more generally a guest room – a secondary guest room in an Israeli house
        - Joseph and Mary were visiting Bethlehem because they had returned to Joseph's hometown for the census
            - He probably had relatives in Bethlehem, although they would have been little more than long lost cousins
            - But as a distant relative, Joseph could have expected to be warmly received under normal circumstances
            - And he might have expected the guest room in the house

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        - But either due to the census or because he had a woman with an illegitimate child, he was offered the manager instead

            - Most Israeli houses of that time had two main sections, a place for the family and an attached part of the home dedicated to the animals

            - If Joseph was told there was no room in the guest room, he was likely at least offered the chance to sleep in the manager

- Mary wraps the child in clothes, which was a traditional though modest way to keep the child warm

- Then having been born into this world, Christ is visited by shepherds, who were guided to Christ by instructions given by angels,

    - Shepherds were considered a lowly class of people, much as the Egyptians had seen them to be during the days of Israel in Egypt

    - Because shepherds were seen to be unclean and even untrustworthy

        - Interestingly, Luke doesn't make mention of the way the shepherds found the baby, by the star in the sky as Matthew mentions

        - Matthew was more interested in showing the fulfillment of Jewish prophecy concerning the Messiah (Num 24:17), while Luke simply wants to keep the narrative moving to the main events

Striking Scene

- Taking all the details together, the scene is quite striking

    - Here's the future and eternal King of Israel, the Son of David born in the city of David

    - Yet His circumstances are as lowly as could be

        - Parents are scorned, shunned

        - Born away from his family's home among strangers

        - Sleeping among animals

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- God has prepared since the garden for the arrival of His Son to save mankind
  - He has called a people to Himself, the Jews
  - He has given prophets countless pictures of Christ's coming
  - He has prepared every detail for His arrival
- Yet God places Him in the most humble of circumstances, out of way, away from the eyes of the world

- We can only conclude that the Father wanted to sure that nothing about Jesus' arrival could be associated with wealth, success nor privilege in the world's eyes
  - He was nothing like the savior the world expected and represented everything the world rejected
  - It should strike you as odd that God would choose to bring His Son into the world in this way?
  - Why not bring Him into the world in a glorious appearing, like He will appear in the end times?

- It's natural for us to want to jump to the end, to want the good without the bad
  - We like to eat our dessert before dinner
  - We like to know the ending of a book before we read it
  - We also tend to wish that God would simply get around to the end of His plan forgetting that He has also planned a beginning and a middle
  - Likewise, there is a beginning and a middle and an end to the story of our walk with Christ

Christ Comes To Die

- So in our study of Luke today, God has set the circumstances in the story of Christ's birth in such a way that we might understand more about His purpose in coming and of our response to His coming

- The story actually begins before Christ arrives

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- Paul tells us in Philippians that Christ existed before he was born as a man

Phil. 2:6 who, although He existed in the form of God, did not regard equality with God a thing to be grasped,
Phil. 2:7 but emptied Himself, taking the form of a bond-servant, *and* being made in the likeness of men.
Phil. 2:8 Being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.

- And Christ Himself testified in John 8:38 that he existed before Abraham did

- And of course, John 1 declares that Christ was with the Father in the beginning

- But Christ would be humbled to arrive as a man

Zech. 9:9 Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion!
Shout *in triumph*, O daughter of Jerusalem!
Behold, your king is coming to you;
He is just and endowed with salvation,
Humble, and mounted on a donkey,
Even on a colt, the foal of a donkey.

Matt. 11:29 "Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and YOU WILL FIND REST FOR YOUR SOULS.

- The Father had several reasons for having His Son arrive in a humble manner

  - First, we know on a practical level that he would come to die, and therefore lowliness and scorn go with the territory

  - But there is more than that going here

  - Christ was to set a perfect example in all things for men by living a perfect obedient sinless life

    - In doing so, He was to be an example of how we are to live

    - But Imitating sinless living is not the only thing Christ demonstrated

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- He also showed us what our purpose in living life and our approach to life itself should be

We Must be Humbled

- God speaks frequently and forcefully about the need to be humbled
  - How He will exalt the humble and bring down the proud

James 4:6 But He gives a greater grace. Therefore *it* says, "GOD IS OPPOSED TO THE PROUD, BUT GIVES GRACE TO THE HUMBLE."

James 4:10 Humble yourselves in the presence of the Lord, and He will exalt you.

Prov. 29:23 A man's pride will bring him low,
But a humble spirit will obtain honor.

Job 22:29 "When you are cast down, you will speak with confidence,
And the humble person He will save.

Is. 66:2 "For My hand made all these things,
Thus all these things came into being," declares the LORD.
"But to this one I will look,
To him who is humble and contrite of spirit, and who trembles at My word.

Psa. 76:9 When God arose to judgment,
To save all the humble of the earth. Selah.

- There are two kinds of humility at work here
  - First there is the humility that precedes faith, the humbling of the heart in response to the grace of the God
  - Secondly, there is the daily effort of contending with pride and exalting God rather than ourselves
  - The first form happens in an instant by God's power
  - But the second form of humbleness is the one that we Christians are to learn from observing Christ, beginning with His arrival on earth in a manger

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- Practicing humbleness is a daily exercise
    - I'm particularly proud of how humble I am
    - Seriously, humility is not something you just fake – it's like faking sincerity
    - But it something we can learn and endeavor to obtained with God's grace
- But the question is how? Christ gave the answer, at least in principle, when he spoke to Peter:

Matt. 16:21 ¶ From that time Jesus began to show His disciples that He must go to Jerusalem, and suffer many things from the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed, and be raised up on the third day.
Matt. 16:22 Peter took Him aside and began to rebuke Him, saying, "God forbid *it*, Lord! This shall never happen to You."
Matt. 16:23 But He turned and said to Peter, "Get behind Me, Satan! You are a stumbling block to Me; for you are not setting your mind on God's interests, but man's."
Matt. 16:24 ¶ Then Jesus said to His disciples, "If anyone wishes to come after Me, he must deny himself, and take up his cross and follow Me.
Matt. 16:25 "For whoever wishes to save his life will lose it; but whoever loses his life for My sake will find it.
Matt. 16:26 "For what will it profit a man if he gains the whole world and forfeits his soul? Or what will a man give in exchange for his soul?

- The thought of Christ being persecuted this way must have shocked good ol' Peter, so he foolishly comes to Jesus' rescue
- But Christ rebukes him – harshly.
    - Christ tells Peter that his mind is set not on God's interests, but upon his own
    - And then Christ speaks those famous words of taking up our cross to follow him – words spoken even before it was known that Jesus would be crucified.
- A life following Christ is a journey made possible by faith – yes
    - But it is taken in small daily steps of denying of ones' own desires and fleshly instincts – allowing them to be replaced by God's desires

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- Essentially, Christ was telling Peter that He intended to pursue a life directed by God and not by His own desires – desires that Peter was inflaming

- In my years as a Christian, I can't remember anyone ever stating the hard truth of those verses to me, so I don't want to make the same mistake for you, so allow me to explain

  - Christ's life on earth – beginning with his birth in a manger - was marked by a humbleness that led to a complete giving up of everything He had for the sake of obedience to the Father

  - First, He left heaven and His place of honor

  - Then to make matters worse, he became an object of scorn at the hands of men

    - And He did this simply because this was the Father's purpose for Christ coming to earth in the first place, so that He could save mankind by His death

    - Christ didn't consider equality with the Father something too great to give up for the sake of His obedience to the Father

    - Likewise, we can't offer any excuse for why we can't following God as He may direct our lives

- So, if we are to imitate Christ, it's not just about living a "good" life

- For that matter, what would a life completely dedicated to God's direction and desires look like?

- It would have to be a life marked by a giving up of everything we would count dear and accepting in its place anything the Father might demand of us – a Christ-like life

  - At the very least, God will demand we relinquish any material desires that may stand in the way of our complete obedience – **house**, car, toys, even our job

  - But what about our prejudices, our bad habits, our fears, our hatreds, our procrastinations, our weaknesses, our selfish interests, our false identities, our prideful self-image

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- In fact, I would argue that the degree of sinlessness in your life is less important than your obedience
- We too often choose to get the small things right and ignore the big things
    - What we say, what we see, what we approve of – so often the outward signs of righteousness
    - But we won't consider radical changes in our lives for the sake of obedience when called upon

- If you are going to walk with Him in obedience and receive whatever blessing He may have in store for you, He is first going to ask you to give up anything that might serve as a stumbling block for your walk – anything that might trip you up as Peter tried unknowingly to do to Christ
    - Things that can only distract us from serving Him and being used by Him
    - But do you count those things more dear than obedience to God? Our actions will reveal our true heart – words are cheap and meaningless
    - And in those moments when our flesh stands before us just as Peter stood before Christ and demands a retreat, and a return to the worldly things we used to delight in, we need to declare as Christ did, get behind me Satan
    - And resolve to refocus your mind on God's interests and not your own – preferring to store up your treasure in Heaven
        - For what good is it if we were to achieve everything last thing our flesh might desire – if the price for obtaining it is to lose our souls – as Christ said
        - Obviously, nothing is worth that, which is ironic because we tend to pursue those stumbling blocks as if they could compare in some way
- So we learn from the example God set for us, even in the way he began life, in humble and lowly circumstances
    - And because Christ was willing to be humbled in obedience, the Father was willing to exalt Christ by raising Him up
    - Ultimately, Christ returns in glory

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- Likewise, we must first be humbled so that we can be lifted up after death and we will see the fruit of our labor in a time of glory we share with Christ

Luke 2:16 So they came in a hurry and found their way to Mary and Joseph, and the baby as He lay in the manger.
Luke 2:17 When they had seen this, they made known the statement which had been told them about this Child.
Luke 2:18 And all who heard it wondered at the things which were told them by the shepherds.
Luke 2:19 But Mary treasured all these things, pondering them in her heart.
Luke 2:20 The shepherds went back, glorifying and praising God for all that they had heard and seen, just as had been told them.

- The shepherds visit and report their experience with the angels to Joseph and Mary
    - This produced wonder in their hearts and Mary treasured these statements
    - And the shepherds continue on in rejoicing and praising God
    - What a beautiful scene and what a great lesson for us all
        - We should never forget to marvel at God's works and keep them in our hearts, coming back to them repeatedly for the purpose of praising God and testifying about Him to others
        - Have you ever considered that trials and difficult circumstances through which God brings you through are intended in part to give you testimonies about Him? Do you use them that way?
        - Consider Mary…what were her 9 months of shameful pregnancy like?
        - And now she rejoices in a full awareness of the special miracle of this child – can you imagine her pondering all these circumstances?
        - And now she shares in a testimony of God's greatness
        - Look for your own opportunity to ponder and praise God's works

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Luke 2:21 ¶ And when eight days had passed, before His circumcision, His name was *then* called Jesus, the name given by the angel before He was conceived in the womb.
Luke 2:22 ¶ And when the days for their purification according to the law of Moses were completed, they brought Him up to Jerusalem to present Him to the Lord
Luke 2:23 (as it is written in the Law of the Lord, "EVERY *firstborn* MALE THAT OPENS THE WOMB SHALL BE CALLED HOLY TO THE LORD"),
Luke 2:24 and to offer a sacrifice according to what was said in the Law of the Lord, "A PAIR OF TURTLEDOVES OR TWO YOUNG PIGEONS."

- After 8 days, Jesus is circumcised as was the Jewish requirement
    - And then the days of purification had to pass before he could presented before the Lord in the temple
    - The purification was for Mary
        - According to the Law, the woman was considered ritually unclean for 33 days following the circumcision of the child
        - During this time, she couldn't enter the temple
        - On the 40th day after her son's birth, the mother would present a sin offering to atone for her uncleanliness following birth
            - The sin offering was a lamb, unless the family was too poor for a lamb, in which case two doves could be substituted
            - The fact Joseph and Mary choose birds could indicate their low economic status
    - The purification for the mother was not intended to suggest that childbirth was considered a sin
        - Atoning for ritual uncleanliness was not the same as purification for sins. All sin resulted in unclealiness under the law – yes - but not all uncleanliness was the result of sin
        - Mary was simply considered ritually unclean because of childbirth
        - But the fact that she had to be purified is proof that Jesus' birth was a true human birth – the Incarnation was a true event – Jesus was born like every other man

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Luke 2:25 ¶ And there was a man in Jerusalem whose name was Simeon; and this man was righteous and devout, looking for the consolation of Israel; and the Holy Spirit was upon him.
Luke 2:26 And it had been revealed to him by the Holy Spirit that he would not see death before he had seen the Lord's Christ.
Luke 2:27 And he came in the Spirit into the temple; and when the parents brought in the child Jesus, to carry out for Him the custom of the Law,
Luke 2:28 then he took Him into his arms, and blessed God, and said,
Luke 2:29 "Now Lord, You are releasing Your bond-servant to depart in peace,
According to Your word;
Luke 2:30 For my eyes have seen Your salvation,
Luke 2:31 Which You have prepared in the presence of all peoples,
Luke 2:32 A LIGHT OF REVELATION TO THE GENTILES,
And the glory of Your people Israel."
Luke 2:33 ¶ And His father and mother were amazed at the things which were being said about Him.

- As Mary and Joseph bring the Christ child into the temple, the Holy Spirit brings a man named Simeon there as well
- His names means announces, comprehends or obeys
    - God had revealed to this man that he would have the privilege of seeing the Messiah born in his day
    - Evidently he had been waiting for this day in anticipation, ready to declare it
    - And as he sees Mary and Joseph arrive at the temple, he apparently knows instantly who the Lord is – remarkable testimony to God's power to direct men to their messiah
        - He embraces him and blesses God
        - Having come to know who his Messiah is, he declares that he has no reason to go on living in this world
        - It's as if there is no other reason for him to exist but to accept the Christ – and now his purpose has been fulfilled leaving him with no other purpose of his own
- Exactly!

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- What a beautiful illustration Luke records of the life each of us have in Christ!
  - We all begin a life that feels empty in purpose, seeking something greater than ourselves
  - Somewhere along the way, the Holy Spirit begins to woo us in small ways, softening our heart and offering hope and promise
  - Then one day, the Holy Spirit directs toward our Savior, - just as clearly and just as surely as He did for Simeon in the temple that day
  - And we rejoice and bless the name of God
  - Finally, Simeon gives us a great example of how our life can serve no greater purpose than to know our Messiah and serve Him

- Who are you serving in your decisions today, this week, this month?

Josh. 24:15 …then choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve…as for me and my household, we will serve the LORD."

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Luke 2B

- Last time in Luke, we saw Jesus as an infant presented before the Lord in the temple
    - A man named Simeon had been waiting all his life to see the Messiah and now he has had his wish granted
        - He has held the child and thanked God,
        - And as we pick up in he lesson today, we hear him pronounce a prophetic blessing on the family

Luke 2:34 And Simeon blessed them and said to Mary His mother, "Behold, this *Child* is appointed for the fall and rise of many in Israel, and for a sign to be opposed—
Luke 2:35 and a sword will pierce even your own soul—to the end that thoughts from many hearts may be revealed."
Luke 2:36 ¶ And there was a prophetess, Anna the daughter of Phanuel, of the tribe of Asher. She was advanced in years and had lived with *her* husband seven years after her marriage,
Luke 2:37 and then as a widow to the age of eighty-four. She never left the temple, serving night and day with fastings and prayers.
Luke 2:38 At that very moment she came up and *began* giving thanks to God, and continued to speak of Him to all those who were looking for the redemption of Jerusalem.
Luke 2:39 ¶ When they had performed everything according to the Law of the Lord, they returned to Galilee, to their own city of Nazareth.

- Simeon gives Jesus' parents added insight concerning their son and his mission on Earth
- He gives three interesting details concerning Christ's purpose in coming
    - First, Jesus has been appointed for the fall and rise of many in Israel he says
        - Jesus will both Israel's Rock of salvation and the stumbling block spoken of by the prophets
    - On its face this statement is easy to understand
        - We know that the world can be divided into 2 kinds of people

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- Which group you belong to depends entirely on what you believe about Jesus
  - If you believe he is a myth, or a fraud or merely a good teacher – or if you don't think about Him at all, you are in one group
  - And if you believe He is the Son of God, the only way to the Father and the only name appointed in Heaven and on Earth by which men may be saved – then you are in the other group

- But there is actually another aspect to this statement equally significant
  - The nation of Israel is itself going to experience both sides of this child – both the fall against the stumbling block and the rise of the Rock of salvation
  - Isaiah 28:16 says:

Is. 28:16 Therefore thus says the Lord GOD,
"Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone, a tested stone,
A costly cornerstone *for* the foundation, firmly placed.
He who believes *in it* will not be disturbed.

- But Isaiah also said of the Messiah:

Is. 8:13 "It is the LORD of hosts whom you should regard as holy.
And He shall be your fear,
And He shall be your dread.
Is. 8:14 "Then He shall become a sanctuary;
But to both the houses of Israel, a stone to strike and a rock to stumble over,
And a snare and a trap for the inhabitants of Jerusalem.
Is. 8:15 "Many will stumble over them,
Then they will fall and be broken;
They will even be snared and caught."

- So, how is it that both aspects of the Messiah are true for Israel?
  - In their first encounter with their Messiah, the nation of Israel did stumble over Christ as they were unable to accept Him for who is was
    - The nation rejected their Messiah, turning Him over to be crucified, declaring Him to be a liar and not the true Christ

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- In practical terms, this was a result of the Jewish nation misunderstanding why their Messiah came and what He intended to accomplish

- But in spiritual terms, the issue is much more profound

1Pet. 2:7 This precious value, then, is for you who believe; but for those who disbelieve,
"THE STONE WHICH THE BUILDERS REJECTED,
THIS BECAME THE VERY CORNER *stone*,"
1Pet. 2:8 and,
"A STONE OF STUMBLING AND A ROCK OF OFFENSE";
for they stumble because they are disobedient to the word, and to this *doom* they were also appointed.

- Peter quotes the Psalms and then adds that the Nation of Israel's stumbling occurred because they were disobedient to the word – the scriptures in other words

- And then he adds something very important – and to this doom they were also appointed

- They would reject the Messiah and He would become a stumbling block not out of chance – but out of necessity – because they were appointed to that purpose

- Paul gives another piece to this puzzle in Romans 11

  - In explaining how the Jewish nation was appointed to reject their Messiah Paul says:

Rom. 11:7 ¶ What then? What Israel is seeking, it has not obtained, but those who were chosen obtained it, and the rest were hardened;
Rom. 11:8 just as it is written,
"GOD GAVE THEM A SPIRIT OF STUPOR,
EYES TO SEE NOT AND EARS TO HEAR NOT,
DOWN TO THIS VERY DAY."
Rom. 11:9 And David says,
"LET THEIR TABLE BECOME A SNARE AND A TRAP,
AND A STUMBLING BLOCK AND A RETRIBUTION TO THEM.
Rom. 11:10 "LET THEIR EYES BE DARKENED TO SEE NOT,
AND BEND THEIR BACKS FOREVER."

- God is the one who ensured they would reject their Messiah, by blinding them spiritually, essentially allowing their sin nature to condemn themselves without reprieve from the Holy Spirit

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- Finally, Paul explains why this happened:

Rom. 11:11 ¶ I say then, they did not stumble so as to fall, did they? May it never be! But by their transgression salvation *has come* to the Gentiles, to make them jealous.

- God is fulfilling His promise to Abraham that through Him all nations would be blessed

- The rejection of the Messiah by the Jewish nation gave opportunity for the rest of the world to know of Christ and be saved
  - Had Israel accepted their Messiah, there would not have been opportunity for the Gentile world to know Him, as He would have be given the throne of David and ruled the world in the Messianic kingdom – the Millennium kingdom

- But there is a time when the Jewish nation will accept their Messiah and he will no longer be a stumbling block for His people
  - At the end of the Tribulation, the nation of Israel will receive the outpouring of the Holy Spirit and they will call on their Messiah

Zech. 12:9 "And in that day I will set about to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem.
Zech. 12:10 ¶ "I will pour out on the house of David and on the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the Spirit of grace and of supplication, so that they will look on Me whom they have pierced; and they will mourn for Him, as one mourns for an only son, and they will weep bitterly over Him like the bitter weeping over a firstborn.

  - Zech goes on to say that in that day the Lord will return and will set up His kingdom on earth to rule from Jerusalem

- Returning to our passage in Luke, the prophecy of Simeon has two other details
  - He says this child will be a sign to be opposed
    - And that he has become
    - The World now is opposed to Christ and the church, every bit as much today as it was when Christ was crucified

John 7:7 "The world cannot hate you, but it hates Me because I testify of it, that its deeds are evil.

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        - The cross itself has become a sign that men will oppose and work to defeat in many places around the world

    - Finally, Simeon says that the thoughts of many hearts will be revealed by this child

        - One day after the Messiah has ruled in His kingdom on Earth, a throne will appear and books will be opened

            - And all those who have not placed their trust in Jesus will appear before that throne for judgment

            - And the thoughts of every heart will be revealed

- Simeon inserted one detail for Mary in passing – that she would be pierced even to her soul

    - No doubt Mary didn't understand Simeon's comment at the time,

    - But he was telling Mary of her own anguish in watching her son put to death

    - That as Christ is being crucified and his side is pierced by a Roman soldier's sword, his mother would look on and feel the sword within herself –

        - As if it had been directed against her – as if she had taken the blade herself –

        - Thus fulfilling Simeon's prophecy

- Like Simeon, there was a widow who essentially lived in the temple

    - She had been married a short while before becoming a widow, and she lived the rest of her life in the temple

        - Her circumstances weren't altogether unusual, as widows had few options for where to turn for support

            - She must have taken up residence in the House of the Lord depending on begging for subsistence

            - And the Lord had sustained her for many years

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- She is also called a prophetess, a woman given special insight by God
- By Luke's account, it appears she has been given the knowledge that this child is the Messiah and now she spends her days telling everyone that he has come
- But notice she is only speaking the truth to those looking for the redemption of Israel
    - In other words, her ministry is directed toward finding those who are willing to listen
    - To the remnant of Israel, to Jews who knew that a Messiah was required for the redemption of Israel, and they longed for his coming

- So Mary and Joseph's trip to the temple includes two strange characters who testified to the nature of their child and did so publicly for all who had ears to hear
    - Both these people are great examples of how the godly respond to their Messiah, praising Him, blessing His name and testifying about Him to all who would listen
- And they return to Nazareth

Luke 2:40 The Child continued to grow and become strong, increasing in wisdom; and the grace of God was upon Him.
Luke 2:41 ¶ Now His parents went to Jerusalem every year at the Feast of the Passover.
Luke 2:42 And when He became twelve, they went up *there* according to the custom of the Feast;
Luke 2:43 and as they were returning, after spending the full number of days, the boy Jesus stayed behind in Jerusalem. But His parents were unaware of it,
Luke 2:44 but supposed Him to be in the caravan, and went a day's journey; and they *began* looking for Him among their relatives and acquaintances.
Luke 2:45 When they did not find Him, they returned to Jerusalem looking for Him.
Luke 2:46 Then, after three days they found Him in the temple, sitting in the midst of the teachers, both listening to them and asking them questions.
Luke 2:47 And all who heard Him were amazed at His understanding and His answers.
Luke 2:48 When they saw Him, they were astonished; and His mother said to Him, "Son, why have You treated us this way? Behold, Your father and I have been anxiously looking for You."

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Luke 2:49 And He said to them, "Why is it that you were looking for Me? Did you not know that I had to be in My Father's *house*?"
Luke 2:50 But they did not understand the statement which He had made to them.
Luke 2:51 And He went down with them and came to Nazareth, and He continued in subjection to them; and His mother treasured all *these* things in her heart.
Luke 2:52 ¶ And Jesus kept increasing in wisdom and stature, and in favor with God and men.

- Luke gives us the only record of Christ as a young boy in this passage
    - We need to remember who Luke was writing this gospel account for – the Greek trained Christians like Theophilus
    - And the Greeks would have been most interested in how God interacted with men and his parents
        - Gods often came down to live among men in Greek mythology but they always remained separate and distinct
        - Jesus actually was a man who was also God – something different from the typical Greek experience
    - Luke makes extra effort to show how a man who is also God can live under parental authority while still answering to His Father in heaven – an interesting dilemma
- He begins by observing that Jesus was growing strong as a boy and increasing in wisdom
    - At first thought you might wonder why Jesus needed to grow strong in wisdom – wasn't he already able to know everything as God
    - The answer is yes and no
        - Though Jesus is God and therefore has all knowledge, he voluntarily gave up His exalted position at the right hand of the Father and took the form of man
        - He is now limited by his humanity
            - He depends on the growth of the body to allow for growth of knowledge
            - He depends on the Father to give Him direction through the Holy Spirit, as when he was in the desert undergoing temptation (Luke 4)

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- It's yet another stark reminder of how much Jesus was willing to do for our sake

- Then Luke turns to an account of Mary and Joseph visiting the temple with Jesus

- Jewish males were expected to make the trip to Jerusalem three times a year for the feasts of Passover, Pentecost and Tabernacles

    - If you couldn't afford to attend all three, you attended at least Passover and wives would typically accompany their husbands

    - A Jewish son would also attend occasionally especially as he reached the age of maturity, 13

- This trip included a new twist – Mary and Joseph lose the Savior of the World

    - You know I was pretty worried the day I lost my wallet, but can you imagine?

- Some people ask how this could even happen, but it's actually quite believable

    - First remember the times would have been very different than now

        - Can't leave your kid alone

        - In that day, children had little to fear from strangers

    - Secondly, in the culture of the day, men traveled with men and women with women, leaving the children to roam back forth or to join up with other children from relatives families

        - It was possible for a child to go unseen for the better part of a day

        - Only when they arrive at a stopping point would they have discovered that Jesus was not with the group at all

- Now that it is evening, they can't travel back to Jerusalem until morning, so they sleep that night before returning

    - Can you imagine how little sleep they probably got

    - Or maybe I should say can you imagine how little sleep Mary allowed Joseph to get?

    - And I'm sure the walk back the next day was pleasant as well

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        - Exactly how many roses do you buy to make up for losing the Messiah

- Now they arrive in Jerusalem the end of the second day and probably can't do much searching that evening due to darkness and the city shutting down
    - So the next morning (the third day) they begin looking for him, and sooner or later they have the idea to search at the temple
    - There they find him
- It's a curious scene, no doubt
    - The word used to describe his place in the crowd (midst – mesos) means middle
        - Christ is in the middle of the temple teachers – indicating that the focus was on Him and not them
        - The temple teachers would have been the older, more knowledgeable Pharisees
        - Men like Gamaliel, who trained Paul
    - Yet they are sitting around Christ, telling us that he was doing more teaching than learning
        - When Luke says he was listening and asking questions, it's more likely that he was asking them test questions like he does later to Pharisees
        - He was probably showing them the truth of scriptures they had never seen before though they knew them by heart
    - And of course they are amazed at his ability to answer their questions and show them insight
        - This same experience is ours as well
        - The scriptures are the living word, which means that the meaning is given only through the Holy Spirit to those alive in Christ
        - We can all read the words, but we depend on the Holy Spirit to make the meaning clear and relevant
        - Just as Christ was doing for the teachers in the temple

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- And then Mary and Joseph find their son and confront him
    - This scene poses some interesting questions
    - Mary and Joseph immediately confront their son as they find him in the temple
        - Mary addresses him and though she was probably astonished at the scene of her 12 year old boy teaching Israel's best and brightest, she is still too upset at him to note the significance of the moment
        - She chides him by asking why did he treat them this way? We've been looking everywhere for you
- All parents can identify with this moment
    - You have the unique mixture of anger, relief and joy brought together in a moment like this
    - You want to hug them and then hit them
- But what about Mary's accusation?
    - Did Jesus sin by his actions here?
    - Should he have at least told them he wanted to stay behind in the temple
    - And consider his response – that they should have known where he was, in his father's house
        - Jesus is about to become a man according to Jewish law, a point in time when he can stand on his own according to Jewish law
        - And Jesus seems to be making the statement here that he is ready to leave his earthly parent's control and return to his heavenly father, something that Mary and Joseph should have known themselves
    - But it is also seems that Jesus' comments indicate that the responsibility lay with the parents to know where there child was and not to blame him
        - They would have been in the temple together before leaving the city
        - In other words, Jesus didn't leave them, they left him

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- Pip in the church

- So Jesus makes his comment to them both the remind them of who his true father is and that they should have know where he was because they left him, he never left them

- How true that is for all of us

  - So often a Christian will drift away from their close walk with the Lord

  - They get out of the habit of studying the word, attending Bible studies or their devotional time

  - They make attendance in worship a irregular affair

  - They only pray at meals if at all

  - Finally, the choices they make, the company they keep, and the priorities they set reflect little or none of their Christian values and teaching, and then sin rules

- Who knows why Mary and Joseph overlooked Jesus as they left the temple, but I wonder if the temple visit had become somewhat routine

  - The ceremony was over and all they could think of was getting home

  - They nearly run their camel into another family's caravan in the parking lot

  - Perhaps they just weren't paying close attention to Jesus

  - But next thing they know, they're halfway home before they realize that they left Jesus back at the worship center in Jerusalem

- Boy, is that a message for today's Christian

  - Leaving Jesus behind at church is the rule for today

  - The typical Christian today is feeling pretty good about themselves if they spend their required 60 minutes in a church on Sunday, and then the rest of the week not another minute is given to a devoted pursuit of the Lord

    - Not in study of the His Word

    - Not in extended personal prayer

    - Not in service to the body of Christ

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        - Not even in fellowship with other believers

- Jesus tells Mary and Joseph that they should have known where he was – right where they left him – teaching those who were mindful of him
    - Likewise, Jesus is right where you left him
    - Not in this building, but in His Word, and as our intercessor in prayer
    - And as the Body of Christ gathered in any place in His name
- And He is telling us as well, that if you seek Him you know where to find Him
    - But if you wait to seek him only when you think you need him, you may have walked so far away, they it takes precious time to make the trip back
    - Don't stray far
        - If you aren't engaged in personal Bible study…
        - If you aren't in the habit of extended person prayer, then
        - If you don't make gathering with the Body of Christ – anywhere – a top priority, then re-evaluate your priorities
    - Because our hearts will stray so easily and without regular, focused attention on Jesus we will be left to ourselves, to our sinful nature and desires, our fears and our doubts.
- Jesus is in His father's house – and he is waiting for you to return and sit as his feet and listen to his teaching

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Luke 3A

- And the end of Chapter 2, Luke gave us a fleeting picture of how Jesus lived as a boy
    - And especially how he came to live as both a man, in submission to earthly parents
    - And yet also as the Son of God, in obedience to the Father
        - Ultimately all of us walk that same fine line, and must learn to keep our priorities straight yet never make obedience to God excuse for sin
- Now in Chap 3 we jump forward to the very beginning of Christ's ministry
    - And back to the story of John the Baptist

Luke 3:1 ¶ Now in the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar, when Pontius Pilate was governor of Judea, and Herod was tetrarch of Galilee, and his brother Philip was tetrarch of the region of Ituraea and Trachonitis, and Lysanias was tetrarch of Abilene,
Luke 3:2 in the high priesthood of Annas and Caiaphas, the word of God came to John, the son of Zacharias, in the wilderness.
Luke 3:3 And he came into all the district around the Jordan, preaching a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins;
Luke 3:4 as it is written in the book of the words of Isaiah the prophet,
"THE VOICE OF ONE CRYING IN THE WILDERNESS,
'MAKE READY THE WAY OF THE LORD,
MAKE HIS PATHS STRAIGHT.
Luke 3:5 'EVERY RAVINE WILL BE FILLED,
AND EVERY MOUNTAIN AND HILL WILL BE BROUGHT LOW;
THE CROOKED WILL BECOME STRAIGHT,
AND THE ROUGH ROADS SMOOTH;
Luke 3:6 AND ALL FLESH WILL SEE THE SALVATION OF GOD.'"

- Luke gives us some important historical markers at the beginning of this chapter
    - Markers for placing the time of these events
    - And for understanding some of the details that follow in the story
        - Pontius Pilate was governor of Judea from AD 26 to late 36
        - Herod Antipas ruled as tetrarch of Galilee from 4BC to AD39

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- His brother Herod Philip ruled northern Palestine from 4BC to AD 34
- No information is available on Lysanias
- It's interesting to see two High Priests named
  - Annas was the high priest from AD 6 to 15 until Romans removed him
  - Jews still regarded him as priest and he kept the title
  - Caiaphas was his son in law and served from AD18 to 37
  - We know from Matt that Caiaphas was the high priest serving in Jerusalem at this time

- So all these indicators tell us that John started his ministry between AD 26 and 37
  - Tiberirus' 15th year was probably AD 29, which is likely the best date

- John hears from God while in the desert wilderness
  - John has apparently been living away from home for an extended period of time
    - Both Matt and Mark tell us that John ate honey and locusts and wore crude clothing made of camel's hair
    - He was living the life of a wild man – away from civilization
    - He probably relied on no one – completely separated from the rest of his townspeople
      - As we read down through this account it seems almost as if he has disappeared for some years only to be forgotten and either assumed dead or avoided as possessed
      - How early he left home is unclear, but since he was the same age as Jesus, he probably spent most of his life living completely alone in the wilderness
  - It makes you wonder why God saw fit to give John such a unique life in preparation for this ministry

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- The answer to that question begins by recognizing the picture John provides for us in his ministry

- We've already said it was important that John prepare Jesus coming by gathering a following ready to respond to the call of Jesus

    - Much in the same way the Holy Spirit acts in the world today to prepare the hearts of those who are about to receive the Word of God which is Christ

    - The parable of the four seeds is a good picture of the relationship between the Holy Spirit and Christ in the work of bringing repentance and belief

        - The four seeds in the parable each see a different outcome based on the quality of the soil they find

        - The seed is always the same and it is the Word of God

        - But only in the good soil does the plant grow and prosper

    - And the Holy Spirit is the one Who prepares the soil of the hearer to receive the Word of God

    - Without that preparation, the word falls on deaf ears

- So John pictures the HS in ministry with Christ

    - And God called John the Baptist to ministry even while he was in the womb because He wanted John to be set apart from the world immediately

    - It could be that John left home even as a child, under the direction of the Holy Spirit

    - And his parents likely would have been given direction by the HS to allow him to leave

- And now he suddenly reappears in the local towns around the Jordon river preaching a need for repentance

    - This is a hard message and requires extreme integrity

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- John would have not had much credibility if one day he had simply started preaching repentance to his own home town
    - Began in his house, then his town?
    - Too well known
- God ensures that when he comes on the scene, he is a mysterious and compelling person
    - He has no baggage, though he no doubt had sin
    - His words aren't being filtered through a lens of familiarity

- Remember, even Christ said that a prophet is not without honor except in his own hometown and household
    - God ensures John's anonymity among the people of the Jordon to ensure they are willing to hear his message
    - It's always the case that the success of our preaching or witnessing turns on our reputation
        - If John had been known by these people, then at his first comments, they would have responded that he was one to talk
        - Pot calling the kettle black
        - In fact, in the next chapter you can see Christ confronting exactly the same issue (4:23)

- I believe the Holy Spirit gains a measure of success in us in this same way…(example)

- He importance of John's independence becomes especially clear when we see what his ministry was like
    - The passage we read ended with a quote from Isa 40, telling how he will make the crooked straight and the rough smooth, etc.
        - Now we know Isaiah is not referring to the geography of the Palestinian lands
        - It's speaking spiritually

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- John would bring men's hearts back to a place where they would receive their Messiah
- John would being the repentance process of turning hearts away from sin and toward righteousness, even before Christ appeared
- So watching how this happened in John's day would be especially insightful for us today…how oes God work to bring men back to himself

Luke 3:7 ¶ So he *began* saying to the crowds who were going out to be baptized by him, "You brood of vipers, who warned you to flee from the wrath to come?
Luke 3:8 "Therefore bear fruits in keeping with repentance, and do not begin to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham for our father,' for I say to you that from these stones God is able to raise up children to Abraham.
Luke 3:9 "Indeed the axe is already laid at the root of the trees; so every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire."
Luke 3:10 ¶ And the crowds were questioning him, saying, "Then what shall we do?"
Luke 3:11 And he would answer and say to them, "The man who has two tunics is to share with him who has none; and he who has food is to do likewise."
Luke 3:12 And *some* tax collectors also came to be baptized, and they said to him, "Teacher, what shall we do?"
Luke 3:13 And he said to them, "Collect no more than what you have been ordered to."
Luke 3:14 *Some* soldiers were questioning him, saying, "And *what about* us, what shall we do?" And he said to them, "Do not take money from anyone by force, or accuse *anyone* falsely, and be content with your wages."

- John isn't going to win any awards for motivational speaking now is
- John is preaching to crowds who come to him by the Jordon river
    - Some are attracted by the novelty no doubt
    - Some are curious what all the fuss is about
    - Some are attracted with false motives to undermine his ministry
    - And some feel compelled, they feel drawn, they are driven and they aren't even sure why
- And by the description in the text, it's also apparent that all manner of society are there

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- We have workers and we have tax collectors and even Roman soldiers
- And when we compare this account to Matt and Mark, we also find out that the Pharasee and Sagisees were coming down to investigate as well
  - In fact, these are the ones in view at the beginning of this passage who he calls vipers

Matt. 3:7 ¶ But when he saw many of the Pharisees and Sadducees coming for baptism, he said to them, "You brood of vipers, who warned you to flee from the wrath to come?
Matt. 3:8 "Therefore bear fruit in keeping with repentance;

- So how is the Holy Spirit working through John and also pictured by John in this moment going to make these crooked paths straight for Christ?
  - We get our first insight by how John addresses the Pharisees
    - He calls them a brood of vipers, and very sarcastically says who warned you about the wrath to come?
    - They had appeared at in the crowd seemingly interested in the same things as the rest of the crowd – to repent and be baptized
    - But John knew who they were and he knew their motives weren't pure
      - They were posing as regular people but merely to check out John and what he was saying
- Now John asks them who warned them about the wrath to come
  - Why would he ask them that? It's sounds like he's suggesting that only people who have been warned of God's coming judgment would have had reason to come to the river
  - And this is precisely what John is saying
    - John knows that he is acting out the part of the Holy Spirit, but the real Holy Spirit is still active in the world preparing hearts for Christ's coming
    - And these people who have been drawn to John are the people who the Holy Spirit has been wooing – speaking to their hearts about the coming judgment

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- And just like the soil that must be prepared to receive the Word of God, the hearts of these people are being tilled as it were by the Holy Spirit

- So here's John asking thee Pharisees who warned them?
    - His sarcastic tone is an indication that he knows they haven't been drawn there by the Holy Spirit desiring repentance
    - In fact, John is asserting that they do not have the Holy Spirit working in them, so they are not even aware they need repentance
        - Look at his next statements to them:
            - Bear fruit in keeping with repentance
            - And don't think that simply being born of Abraham is enough to assure you of salvation
            - He finally tells them that the tree they are a part of – the nation of Israel, on other words – is about to be pruned back for unbelief
    - John is calling them out as unbelievers, unrighteous men who need to repent, though they don't know it because they lack the ministry of the Holy Spirit to understand their own sinfulness
- So John's ministry to bring men and women back to the Lord begins with a reliance on the work of the Holy Spirit to drawn men to the work of redemption
    - Even John himself alludes to God's role in bringing men to Him in his rebuke of the Pharisees
        - He tells them not to rely on their heritage to find favor with God, because God doesn't need the heritage of Abraham to call men to Himself.
        - If needed, He could bring men from rocks to worship Him, making the point that it is the power of God that draws believers
    - Christ Himself said in John

John 6:44 "No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him; and I will raise him up on the last day.

- And the Father uses the Holy Spirit to draw men to Him, just as He is using John the Baptist to prepare men for Christ

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- Going back to Isaiah's prophecy of John the Baptist, how does God ensure that John is going to make straight paths for Jesus?
    - He begins by sending His Holy Spirit to draw men toward John, ready for a message of repentance, with hearts that have been prepared and seek righteousness
    - But is that enough? No.
        - If you till the soil in your garden, do plants automatically begin to grow (not weeds)?
        - No, you need seed of some kind
- As we look further at the passage, consider the instructions John gives the people who gather
    - He is giving examples of the fruit of true repentance, so they may know when repentance is genuine
        - These were examples that ran completely against the culture
    - He also is telling the people to do what they know is right, to be generous and be caring for one another
        - In a word, to show love for one another
        - Ultimately, he is pointing them to the author of Love – to Christ

Luke 3:15 ¶ Now while the people were in a state of expectation and all were wondering in their hearts about John, as to whether he was the Christ,
Luke 3:16 John answered and said to them all, "As for me, I baptize you with water; but One is coming who is mightier than I, and I am not fit to untie the thong of His sandals; He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire.
Luke 3:17 "His winnowing fork is in His hand to thoroughly clear His threshing floor, and to gather the wheat into His barn; but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire."
Luke 3:18 ¶ So with many other exhortations he preached the gospel to the people.

- Take note of the work of the Holy Spirit here
    - He has prepared these people so that the end result of all they are experiencing is to look forward to a Messiah

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        - They even ask if John is that Christ
        - But of course John says no
        - But then he points them to their Christ, and as it says he preached the gospel to the people

- And now we have the final piece for how John would accomplish the prophecy given in Isaiah.
    - Have been drawn by the Holy Spirit, then taught of the need to repent and seek after righteousness and love
    - Now they are pointed to their salvation
    - And when he arrives, the people will be ready and waiting
        - The paths for Christ to walk in redeeming his bride will have been prepared by John the Baptist
        - And their response to their new-found faith is to be baptized
            - Of course, the baptism they received by John was merely to picture the true baptism of the Holy Spirit that all believers would enjoy

- This is how the Holy Spirit acts within the world today
    - When God desires to being the knowledge of Christ to a man or woman, he prepares their hearts by the power of the Holy Spirit
        - He brings them to a recognition of coming judgment
        - He prepares the ground of their heart, giving them a desire to seek and to knock, as Christ puts it
    - But the fact that God must act first to draw man to Himself should never leave us to forget the second half of this process
        - As John the Baptist demonstrates, God purposes to work through men to bring the message of Christ to their hearts
            - We are the ones who must preach the gospel message, to deliver the hard message about turning from an unbelieving way and all the sins it produces

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- To persuade them to embrace the coming Christ
    - Yes, we work to persuade men

2Cor. 5:11 ¶ Therefore, knowing the fear of the Lord, we persuade men…

2Cor. 5:18 Now all *these* things are from God, who reconciled us to Himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation,
2Cor. 5:19 namely, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not counting their trespasses against them, and He has committed to us the word of reconciliation.
2Cor. 5:20 ¶ Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were making an appeal through us; we beg you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God.

- We persuade because we have been entrusted with this task
- And work to persuade because we desire to be the one through whom God will work
- But ultimately, each person must have a personal experience with Christ to know Him and believe
    - And they meet Christ through the Word of God (Rom 10:8)
- Therefore, we are to sow the Word of God liberally, like the parable says, all over the place
    - And when it falls on prepared soil, we are to persuade men of the truth of the gospel – as John did

- But did you notice how bold that preaching was
    - There is no soft sell here
    - John wasn't trying to sneak it in or make it more palatable
        - Wed night teaching
        - There must be offense if the hearer is to feel the pressure to decide and change
- And as will often happen when you preach the gospel unapologetically, John finds himself persecuted

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Luke 3:19 But when Herod the tetrarch was reprimanded by him because of Herodias, his brother's wife, and because of all the wicked things which Herod had done,
Luke 3:20 Herod also added this to them all: he locked John up in prison.

- Now we will have the opportunity to better understand the historical references that Luke gave at the beginning of the chapter
    - Herodias was the wife of Herod Philip I, one of the sons of Herod the Great
    - Herod Philip had a brother Herod Antipas who took a liking to Herodias and she to him
        - So Herod Antipas took Herodias from his brother and made her his wife, even though she was still married to Herod Philip
- It was this adulterous relationship that John criticized publicly that led Herod to arrest John and ultimately murder him at the request of Herodias' daughter
    - Interestingly, John continued to preach to Herod even while in prison

Mark 6:20 for Herod was afraid of John, knowing that he was a righteous and holy man, and he kept him safe. And when he heard him, he was very perplexed; but he used to enjoy listening to him.

- Don't be naïve about how much the enemy hates us for preaching the gospel boldly
    - So few Christians truly suffer persecution for their faith and their beliefs because so few of us are willing to actually make a bold proclamation anywhere

Matt. 5:11 ¶ "Blessed are you when *people* insult you and persecute you, and falsely say all kinds of evil against you because of Me.
Matt. 5:12 "Rejoice and be glad, for your reward in heaven is great; for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.
John 15:20 "Remember the word that I said to you, 'A slave is not greater than his master.' If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you; if they kept My word, they will keep yours also.

- Our persecutions need not include martyred for our faith, but how about just feeling uncomfortable

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Luke 3B

- If you were to answer the question, "Why did Jesus come to earth as a man?"
    - You could answer that question in multiple ways
        - Die for sin
        - Live a sinless life
    - More astute Bible student might also mention
        - To offer the Kingdom of God to the Jewish nation
        - To fulfill all prophecy
        - As the Son, He came to reveal the Father (John 14:9)
        - Gave an example to believers how to live out his faith
    - In the first two verses for today taken from Chapter 3, we can see those last three reasons on display
- We also have opportunity to understand better the purpose of both baptism and prayer in the life of a believer, as modeled by Christ

Luke 3:21 ¶ Now when all the people were baptized, Jesus was also baptized, and while He was praying, heaven was opened,
Luke 3:22 and the Holy Spirit descended upon Him in bodily form like a dove, and a voice came out of heaven, "You are My beloved Son, in You I am well-pleased."

From the parallel accounts in other gospels, we know that John had been busy as usual baptizing at the Jordon

- When one day, from a distance he caught sight of Jesus approaching
- John did not understand who Jesus was until this moment
    - In fact, from the gospel accounts there is no indication that John ever knew Jesus or that their mothers were related
    - Lived in different cities & John lived in desert
- In the Gospel of John, John says he didn't know Jesus was the Christ

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        - Until the dove descended on Jesus
        - Had been told to look for the sign
- And Luke tells us that Jesus came to John and John baptized him
- Following the baptism, Luke records that the Holy Spirit descended on Jesus
- The specific vision Luke records mentions a dove, which has become the symbol of the Holy Spirit
    - This is a theophany – God appearing in corporeal form – taking the form of His creation

- Knowing Christ is sinless naturally leads us to ask the question why would Jesus need to be baptized?
    - In fact, we really need to review the purpose for baptism as given to us before we can understand what it's purpose may have been for Jesus' ministry
- Baptizing was done to disciple a believer – not to create a believer
    - It was and is symbolic
        - Depicts the cleansing of sin
        - Depicts the death of the old man and resurrection unto life
        - In both cases, it is a depiction – a picture of something already done in the heart by the Holy Spirit
    - The Holy Spirit is the one with the ministry to bring this new life
        - He gives the new spirit in a believer
        - He brings an awareness of a forgiveness of sins – the confidence of a believer
        - He is the one that gives us an awareness and understanding of the Word of God
        - He is the one who indwells us and empowers us for ministry – anointing we call it

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- We use water to picture the salvation experience and we anoint men with oil to picture the anointing of the Holy Spirit

- We have these understandings from scripture, but in John's day, baptism was a new idea
  - John was called John the Baptist because he introduced the idea of washing in the river to signify repentance
  - So for John and all who had been exposed to this new ministry of a symbolic washing away of sin, there was no other purpose
    - This explains John's reaction to Jesus' request to be baptized in Matt

Matt. 3:14 But John tried to prevent Him, saying, "I have need to be baptized by You, and do You come to me?"
Matt. 3:15 But Jesus answering said to him, "Permit *it* at this time; for in this way it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness." Then he *permitted Him.

- John's confusion came because he understood only one purpose for the act of baptism – and he knew Jesus would not need that ministry
  - In fact, John incorrectly assumed that Jesus' ministry would include baptizing – but it never did

John 4:1 ¶ Therefore when the Lord knew that the Pharisees had heard that Jesus was making and baptizing more disciples than John
John 4:2 (although Jesus Himself was not baptizing, but His disciples were),

- John mentioned pointedly that Christ wasn't baptizing, because it was not the ministry of Jesus to baptize
  - We already mentioned His purposes in coming to earth
  - John's assumption that the primary focus of Jesus' ministry was to bring repentance and thereby the forgiveness of sins and ultimately baptism was wrong
    - We said last week that John the Baptist pictures the ministry of the Holy Spirit and Jesus' ministry stands apart from that of the HS

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- So if forgiveness of sins is not the purpose behind Jesus' own baptism, what is?
    - To better understand what's happening here, you only need to consider a couple things
        - First, consider that all three aspects of the Godhead are participating in this scene
            - God the Father speaks and His Spirit descends on Jesus
            - But we've already heard how it is that the spirit descends – in a very visible way
            - As a dove
            - Why so perculiar a way? In Texas at the wrong time of year, descending like a dove is exactly the wrong thing to do
- Consider the words of John concerning the same scene…

John 1:33 "I did not recognize Him, but He who sent me to baptize in water said to me, 'He upon whom you see the Spirit descending and remaining upon Him, this is the One who baptizes in the Holy Spirit.'
John 1:34 "I myself have seen, and have testified that this is the Son of God."
John 12:28 "Father, glorify Your name." Then a voice came out of heaven: "I have both glorified it, and will glorify it again."
John 12:29 So the crowd *of people* who stood by and heard it were saying that it had thundered; others were saying, "An angel has spoken to Him."
John 12:30 Jesus answered and said, "This voice has not come for My sake, but for your sakes.

- The words of Jesus tell us that the entire scene with the Holy Spirit descending & voices speaking was played out for the sake of those watching
- The fact that the Holy Spirit was made so visible even to the point of giving an image of a dove was so that the meaning of the events in this scene would be obvious to the crowd
- This was a testimony to who Jesus was
    - Some regard Jesus as a religious teacher or a prophet
    - Those pale in comparison to the portrait given in Luke

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- So Jesus came to be baptized so that His identity could be established before that crowd as the Son of God
- Before these people who John had prepared for Christ's appearing

- When we are baptized, we are actually achieving a similar function
  - The baptism of a believer is often a hotly debated piece of a theology because some have taken it to mean this is part of the salvation process,
    - otherwise why would Christ demand that it happen
    - So some are tempted to make it a requirement for salvation, which it clearly is not
      - The thief on the cross stands as a testimony
  - But then as we learn it is not essential for salvation, we can also make the mistake of going in the opposite direction…that is making it meaningless and optional
    - Forgetting that Jesus did command it of all believers.

Mark 16:16 "He who has believed and has been baptized shall be saved; but he who has disbelieved shall be condemned.

- Jesus says that believing and being baptized are so intimately connected that one should always go with the other
- But notice he condemns a man only for disbelief
- So again, what's the connection?
  - Faith coming as it does, baptism is an important marker in the life of a believer
    - Don't know the day I was saved…
  - It confirms a changed heart – can help prove to both the person and observers that the change is genuine
  - It provides opportunity for public confession

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Rom. 10:8 But what does it say? "THE WORD IS NEAR YOU, in your mouth and in your heart"—that is, the word of faith which we are preaching,
Rom. 10:9 that if you confess with your mouth Jesus *as* Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved;
Rom. 10:10 for with the heart a person believes, resulting in righteousness, and with the mouth he confesses, resulting in salvation.

- And like Christ, it declares our identity - who we are in Christ – a believer, a follower, a saint

- But Jesus was baptized for more than just demonstrating His identity
  - And from both Luke's and John's description, we see that as He is baptized He receives the Holy Spirit coming upon Him
  - In fact, at the moment the spirit descended, The Father was anointing Jesus for His ministry on earth - – a ministry that would require the power of God Himself
    - And immediately after this scene, Jesus begins His ministry in full
- It's helpful for us as we move into and beyond this point in the Gospel to gain a focused appreciation of what it truly meant for God to take human form in Jesus
  - Jesus was God but He was all man though without sin
    - So He was limited by His own choice to be without the capabilities that He once enjoyed at the right hand of the Father
    - While in human form, he was still aware of who He was and what He was there for, but He became much more dependent on the Holy Spirit to remain in connection with the Father
    - In the next chapter, we will see several references to how Jesus is led by the Holy Spirit or given power to accomplish His ministry
      - The picture being built here, especially by Luke, is that it was through the ministry of the Holy Spirit that Jesus was able to accomplish His supernatural work while in human form
      - We'll study this more as we move through the Gospel

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- But naturally, we see the same experience as well
    - Again baptism is a symbolic act, and not usually the exact moment when supernatural events occur, like indwelling
        - So as a believer you are already accompanied by the Holy Spirit before going into the water, otherwise why would you go?
        - But just as Jesus was see receiving the Holy Spirit at His baptism, we believers are now accompanied by that same spirit with that same power and connection to the Father that Jesus enjoyed
        - And just as He was charged to go forward with a new ministry, we likewise have been called into some form of ministry to the Lord and for His Kingdom
            - There is no one way to minister, but rather there is primarily one way for each of us
            - As members of Christ's Body, we are to specialize just as a member of the body has a special role
            - And by our spiritual gifting, we can now benefit the Body but only when we put our ability to use
            - Your baptism was your coming out party, and now you've expected to seek out ways to put your gifting to use
                - And if you don't know what your gifting is, then you need to pray and seek opportunities to get more directly involved in the work of the kingdom
                - The only way I know to remain unaware of your gifting is to stand still, spiritually speaking
- Typically, once a gifting and a calling extend beyond a normal level of service within one Body
    - and it's apparent that God has called a man to higher purpose, -
    - to a devotion of himself to the ministry
    - Then the scripture calls for men within that Body to recognize God's work in that man and anoint him with oil and pray over him

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- This is a work much the same as baptism – symbolic of what God has already done
- And it recognizes God, given Him glory for the work in this person, while making a public affirmation that this person is set apart for ministry
    - Sometimes our obedience to these measures come without our intending, almost as if God wants us to understand their importance before our will catches up with His
        - Examples…Confess, baptized, and anointing

- Finally, there is one more reason Christ was baptized – to obediently fulfill God's Word

Is. 42:1 ¶ "Behold, My Servant, whom I uphold;
My chosen one *in whom* My soul delights.
I have put My Spirit upon Him;
He will bring forth justice to the nations.

- The Father was pleased to put His Spirit upon His Son, to empower Him to do the work of righteousness
- As Christ said in Matt, it was necessary for the fulfilling all righteousness
- For Jesus to be baptized, in other words, was simply a matter of obedience to the Father

- Which of course brings us to the final parallel for all believers

Matt. 28:19 "Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit,
Matt. 28:20 teaching them to observe all that I commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age."

- If you are a believer but you have never been baptized
- Or you were baptized as an infant
- Then you have a test of obedience awaiting you
    - Your Lord has said instructed you to be baptized for all the reasons we have described

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        - Let your heart hear His words and obey – both for the sake of His Word and for the blessing that comes from obedience

        - We will have a baptism…

- And finally, before we move from these verses, consider how Jesus experienced His baptism – in prayer

    - Doesn't it strike you as strange that Jesus would need to exercise prayer to communicate with the Father though they are one/

        - Remember what we've said about the nature of Jesus as man

        - He lost His close intimate connection with the Father

        - He found His opportunity to pray so important because having known that intimate relationship, he desired it immensely

        - And He sought what for a man can only be found in prayer – divine communication and intimacy with the Father

    - Before Jesus died, such intimacy was possible only through a priest

        - Men prayed and God heard their prayers, but access to the Father was found in the temple by way of sacrifice and priests – men were held at a distance from God and knew it

            - Now we have what Jesus had as a man

            - Opportunity for intimate communication with the Father

                - But so often we take praying lightly because we don't have instant gratification

                - The apparent lack of instant response drives us to distraction and laziness

                    - Don't see your prayers like a message in a bottle

                    - See it more like an e-mail

    - We'll learn more about prayer as we watch Jesus use it throughout His ministry

- The next series of verses are the genealogy of Jesus

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Luke 3:23 ¶ When He began His ministry, Jesus Himself was about thirty years of age, being, as was supposed, the son of Joseph, the son of Eli,
Luke 3:24 the son of Matthat, the son of Levi, the son of Melchi, the son of Jannai, the son of Joseph,
Luke 3:25 the son of Mattathias, the son of Amos, the son of Nahum, the son of Hesli, the son of Naggai,
Luke 3:26 the son of Maath, the son of Mattathias, the son of Semein, the son of Josech, the son of Joda,
Luke 3:27 the son of Joanan, the son of Rhesa, the son of Zerubbabel, the son of Shealtiel, the son of Neri,
Luke 3:28 the son of Melchi, the son of Addi, the son of Cosam, the son of Elmadam, the son of Er,
Luke 3:29 the son of Joshua, the son of Eliezer, the son of Jorim, the son of Matthat, the son of Levi,
Luke 3:30 the son of Simeon, the son of Judah, the son of Joseph, the son of Jonam, the son of Eliakim,
Luke 3:31 the son of Melea, the son of Menna, the son of Mattatha, the son of Nathan, the son of David,
Luke 3:32 the son of Jesse, the son of Obed, the son of Boaz, the son of Salmon, the son of Nahshon,
Luke 3:33 the son of Amminadab, the son of Admin, the son of Ram, the son of Hezron, the son of Perez, the son of Judah,
Luke 3:34 the son of Jacob, the son of Isaac, the son of Abraham, the son of Terah, the son of Nahor,
Luke 3:35 the son of Serug, the son of Reu, the son of Peleg, the son of Heber, the son of Shelah,
Luke 3:36 the son of Cainan, the son of Arphaxad, the son of Shem, the son of Noah, the son of Lamech,
Luke 3:37 the son of Methuselah, the son of Enoch, the son of Jared, the son of Mahalaleel, the son of Cainan,
Luke 3:38 the son of Enosh, the son of Seth, the son of Adam, the son of God.

- Jesus' ministry began according to Luke at around the age of thirty
    - This age was significant, at least in part because it was consistent with the Biblical requirement that priests be 30 before serving
    - God recognizes that maturity come in part with age and experience, so here again Jesus sets an example under the law
    - Of course, He would be our High Priest in the order of Melchizedek, so His ministry was not begun until he reached the necessary age

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- The second thing to jump out at us is the phrase “supposed son”
    - We know He wasn’t actually Joseph’s son
        - But Luke wants to show the line coming from the father as would be appropriate
        - This issue actually plays into the next issue stemming from this genealogy
    - This passage is naturally compared with the similar passage in Matt
        - So we should highlight some of the differences between this passage and the one in Matt
        - Matt comes first and start , Luke’s comes in Chap 3
            - Matt: Highlighting Jesus as born to be the Messiah and hold the throne
            - Luke: Jesus ministry as a man and God together
        - Matt starts at Abraham and goes toward Christ, Luke backwards to Adam
            - Messiah for Jews vs. New Adam for the world
        - The two genealogies trace back through different names to Solomon
            - Several solutions have been proposed
                - Mary vs Joseph
                - Incumbents vs real family
                - Leverate marriage for Joseph’s father
            - Mary vs Joseph makes the most sense

Look forward to our baptism

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Luke 4A

- One day many, many years ago – in just a brief moment – all of history was both changed and established by the choice of one man
    - a very real man, a man who lived in perfect surroundings
    - His name was "earth," pronounced Adam in Hebrew
    - And without provocation, without threat or temptation, he made a simple decision – a decision to disobey the only authority he knew, breaking the only prohibition he had ever been given
    - And when he did, thousands of years of misery, suffering and death were immediately set in motion
- And the God who gave Adam that freedom could have judged his mistake at the very moment
    - But there was only one penalty possible for Adam's mistake
        - Adam brought sin into his body, and that body would forever contain sin within it, so it could never again be in God's presence
        - And to make matters worse, God had directed Adam to be fruitful and multiply
            - And because all his descendents must share in the nature of Adam, all men would share the same condemnation
        - So the only penalty God could employ was eternal separation for all mankind – eternal death
    - But God did not desire to see mankind suffer that penalty, though they deserved it
        - So He chose to respond with a plan of that can only be described as amazing grace
        - God would start the human race again – through a new Adam, but this new Adam would not fail in the way the first did
        - And God would allow this new Adam to multiply as well

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- And His descendents would share in his perfect nature rather than in the nature of the first Adam
- This new line of humanity would be able to enter God's presence since it was born of a perfect, sinless man
- These would be God's adopted children by faith

- Jesus was sent to Earth to be that second Adam – the one who not repeat the mistakes of the first Adam but rather obey His Father in all things
  - And we would be His children, the ones who could be born again, separating us forever from our earthly father Adam
  - And giving us a new birth in Christ,

- That brings us to our passage for today...

Luke 4:1 ¶ Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led around by the Spirit in the wilderness
Luke 4:2 for forty days, being tempted by the devil. And He ate nothing during those days, and when they had ended, He became hungry.
Luke 4:3 And the devil said to Him, "If You are the Son of God, tell this stone to become bread."
Luke 4:4 And Jesus answered him, "It is written, 'MAN SHALL NOT LIVE ON BREAD ALONE.'"
Luke 4:5 ¶ And he led Him up and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time.
Luke 4:6 And the devil said to Him, "I will give You all this domain and its glory; for it has been handed over to me, and I give it to whomever I wish.
Luke 4:7 "Therefore if You worship before me, it shall all be Yours."
Luke 4:8 Jesus answered him, "It is written, 'YOU SHALL WORSHIP THE LORD YOUR GOD AND SERVE HIM ONLY.'"
Luke 4:9 ¶ And he led Him to Jerusalem and had Him stand on the pinnacle of the temple, and said to Him, "If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down from here;
Luke 4:10 for it is written,
'HE WILL COMMAND HIS ANGELS CONCERNING YOU TO GUARD YOU,'
Luke 4:11 and,
'ON *their* HANDS THEY WILL BEAR YOU UP,
SO THAT YOU WILL NOT STRIKE YOUR FOOT AGAINST A STONE.'"
Luke 4:12 And Jesus answered and said to him, "It is said, 'YOU SHALL NOT PUT THE LORD YOUR GOD TO THE TEST.'"
Luke 4:13 ¶ When the devil had finished every temptation, he left Him until an opportune time.

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- In the last chapter of Luke, we witnessed the Spirit descend on Jesus to anoint Him for His earthly ministry
    - We said last week that He was so much a man that He shared the limitations of a man
        - He felt the emotions of a man, the temptations of the flesh, and knew the compelling nature of physical pain
        - He was also limited by His physical nature in that He relied on the Spirit to guide Him, comfort Him, strengthen Him and even provide Him with the supernatural insight to know men's hearts and to know the Father's will
    - So at the beginning of Luke's 4th chapter, Jesus is following the leading of the Spirit to enter into the wilderness and wander for 40 days
        - As the text tells us, Jesus ate nothing during that time, which we know would put a man near the end of his ability to survive
        - During this time as well, Jesus was encountering temptation by the devil
            - This was in addition to the three tests presented to Jesus later in the text
            - In Mark's account of this same scene, we are told that Jesus was tempted by Satan throughout the 40 day period, leaving the three specific incidents to the end
            - We don't know what kind of temptation Jesus was suffering through, but I imagine it was designed to probe His every weakness as a man

- Since we know that the Spirit was responsible for leading Jesus to this place, it raises a number of questions for us
    - First, why put Jesus through these temptations? In fact, why tempt Him at all?
    - As we listen to the story in Luke, we can't help but notice some interesting parallels to the past

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- For example, wandering in the desert for a period of 40 days seems remarkably similar to the Israelite's 40 years of wandering in the desert
- And the temptation to eat in the face of hunger also seems to connect Jesus' circumstances to the temptation in the garden to eat the forbidden fruit
- Is God trying to show us something here – well, most certainly

- First, let's take note of the entire scene provided by Luke and appreciate Jesus situation
  - After 40 days, Jesus is at His lowest point
  - Without the strength of the Spirit, He probably couldn't even stand
    - If you've ever experienced real hunger, perhaps in a fast or in wilderness training, then you might understanding a little of what Jesus was experiencing
    - In my experience, I've fasted – no food only water – for 24 hours on many occasions, but I took it to 48 hours on one occasion
      - The hunger pangs has subsided mostly, but I felt very weak and fatigued
      - I couldn't concentrate easily or think clearly at times
      - On the morning of the third day, I woke up stood up and nearly fell over
    - In my days in the military, I experienced a week of food deprivation, where I had only a couple of meals during that time,
      - I remember spending most of my waking hours thinking about and searching for food
      - As I sat with friends we talked about what we would eat when we got back – describing in detail the toppings on that pizza
      - You can't appreciate the way your body will focus all thought and attention on food as it begins to starve

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- Hunger is quite a test of the will over the flesh – more than any other test you can devise

- When scripture speaks of crucifying the flesh, it's talking about this struggle – the struggle to resist what the body will want by its nature and to listen to what the Spirit directs

  - Scripture tells us that the struggles of living a godly life come down to a fight within us between the sinful body we still occupy, and the new Spirit we've been given by God

  - And it is a fight…one we can win but we have to make an effort to train ourselves – this isn't magic – this is hard work

- Paul uses the comparison to an Olympic race to explain how we should do this

1Cor. 9:24 ¶ Do you not know that those who run in a race all run, but *only* one receives the prize? Run in such a way that you may win.
1Cor. 9:25 Everyone who competes in the games exercises self-control in all things. They then *do it* to receive a perishable wreath, but we an imperishable.
1Cor. 9:26 Therefore I run in such a way, as not without aim; I box in such a way, as not beating the air;
1Cor. 9:27 but I discipline my body and make it my slave, so that, after I have preached to others, I myself will not be disqualified.

- Paul uses a wonderful analogy – a sports analogy

  - When runners race, they know that the person who finishes in second place is called a loser

  - Only first place is considered the winner

  - And to ensure they reach the finish line first, the sensible athlete works hard before the race to discipline the body – to make it respond to the athletes will

    - The body is not naturally lean and strong, fast and able to burn oxygen easily

    - Those traits don't come naturally

    - The natural body is slow, lazy, soft and out of shape

  - Paul's analogy works in a spiritual context too, though

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- If we expect to win all our spiritual battles merely by desire, merely by wishing and hoping – then we're being just as unrealistic as that athlete who thinks wishing will get the job done

- There is a training process – and not just a training of the mind (Bible studies, prayer life, etc.)

- Paul says he disciplined his body, because there was a war underway between the spirit and the body and he was determined not to let the body's desires et in the way of him winning the race he was running – to win an eternal crown

- So by delivering Jesus over to this harsh, almost exaggerated time of bodily discipline – a 40-day fast – The Father was placing Jesus in a position where His reliance on the Father and the Father's Spirit was clearly evident – it was undeniable

    - Jesus' body – though it had no sin – it still had normal fleshly desire for food – but even in that Jesus disciplined his body to obey His spirit

    - Our culture – including our church culture has lost an appreciation for the connection between a regular discipline over the desires of the body and our spiritual walk as a Christian

    - Hear Paul's words again:

Gal. 5:16 ¶ But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not carry out the desire of the flesh.
Gal. 5:17 For the flesh sets its desire against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; for these are in opposition to one another, so that you may not do the things that you please.
Gal. 5:18 But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the Law.
Gal. 5:19 Now the deeds of the flesh are evident, which are: immorality, impurity, sensuality,
Gal. 5:20 idolatry, sorcery, enmities, strife, jealousy, outbursts of anger, disputes, dissensions, factions,
Gal. 5:21 envying, drunkenness, carousing, and things like these, of which I forewarn you, just as I have forewarned you, that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God.
Gal. 5:22 But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness,
Gal. 5:23 gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law.
Gal. 5:24 Now those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.

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Gal. 5:25 ¶ If we live by the Spirit, let us also walk by the Spirit.

- So we can understand the Father's desire to place Jesus in a place of deprivation and require Him to display amazing self-control, especially in the face of Satan's temptations
    - He was demonstrating His willingness to rely entirely on the Spirit rather than satisfy the urges of the flesh – which is the struggle of every believer of all time
    - But Paul also says that this struggle as it plays out for Jesus is intentionally designed to compare with the experiences of the Jewish nation in the desert
- From the earlier passage in 1Cor, I ended at the conclusion of Chap 9, but listen to what Paul says in the very next verses in Chap 10:

1Cor. 10:1 ¶ For I do not want you to be unaware, brethren, that our fathers were all under the cloud and all passed through the sea;
1Cor. 10:2 and all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea;
1Cor. 10:3 and all ate the same spiritual food;
1Cor. 10:4 and all drank the same spiritual drink, for they were drinking from a spiritual rock which followed them; and the rock was Christ.
1Cor. 10:5 Nevertheless, with most of them God was not well-pleased; for they were laid low in the wilderness.
1Cor. 10:6 ¶ Now these things happened as examples for us, so that we would not crave evil things as they also craved.

- Jesus' time in the desert is intended to evoke a memory of the Jews in the desert on the issue of temptation
    - In fact when we look at the three specific temptations taught by Luke, we see lessons that connected with the Jewish people in the wilderness
        - For example, in Exodus, God calls Israel His Son, His firstborn when speaking to Pharaoh – just as Jesus is God's Son
        - God has often used periods of 40 for testing or trial
            - Like Noah in the ark, Moses who fasted for 40 days in the desert himself, and of course the Jews who wandered for 40 years in the desert

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- Jesus' period in the desert also includes temptation, just as Israel experienced temptation in the desert, but we need to remember that though God will test us, James 1:3 tells us that He never tempts us
    - In fact, it is man who tests and tempts God to action in the face of our disobedience
    - But Temptation is the calling card of Satan

- Jesus' first temptation from Satan was over the issue of food
    - Naturally, Satan was going to attack at Jesus' weakest point
    - And Satan uses an old trick, one he has used ever since the garden
- Satan begins by tempting Jesus to use His supernatural power to turn stones into bread, something that only the Son of God could do
    - Satan is actually appealing to Jesus' flesh on two levels
        - First, he obviously is trying to get Jesus to break His fast – the fast that the Spirit has directed Him to undergo – by making for himself food
        - The way it's worded leaves us with the impression that Satan is asking Jesus to prove that he is the Son of God
            - But the statement in the Greek in verse 3 is expressed in the first class condition (You are the Son of God, therefore tell these stones…)
            - If Satan had been in doubt, the Greek phrase would have communicated uncertainty – something closer to "If you were the Son of God, you could tell these stones…"
        - The point here is that Satan is not only appealing to Jesus' need for food, he is also seeking to enflame Jesus' pride
            - You are the Son of God – you don't' need to suffer like this
            - You could make your own food anytime
            - Satan is trying to place some doubt in Jesus' mind over the Father's love by the fact that Jesus is being deprived of His honor

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- This is the old ploy of pride, the same one he used on woman
- And the same one the Jews in the desert experienced

- God reminded the Israelites of how He gave them a similar test while they were in the desert

Deut. 8:3 "He humbled you and let you be hungry, and fed you with manna which you did not know, nor did your fathers know, that He might make you understand that man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by everything that proceeds out of the mouth of the LORD.

- God humbled the Jews and allowed them to be hungry
    - Then He provided a food that no man before had ever known
    - A perfect food from God, so that they might understand how absolutely dependent they were on Him – so much that their very lives came from him and not from the bread they make for themselves
- But remember how they responded back in that day

Num. 11:4 ¶ The rabble who were among them had greedy desires; and also the sons of Israel wept again and said, "Who will give us meat to eat?
Num. 11:5 "We remember the fish which we used to eat free in Egypt, the cucumbers and the melons and the leeks and the onions and the garlic,
Num. 11:6 but now our appetite is gone. There is nothing at all to look at except this manna."
Num. 11:18 "Say to the people, 'Consecrate yourselves for tomorrow, and you shall eat meat; for you have wept in the ears of the LORD, saying, "Oh that someone would give us meat to eat! For we were well-off in Egypt." Therefore the LORD will give you meat and you shall eat.
Num. 11:19 'You shall eat, not one day, nor two days, nor five days, nor ten days, nor twenty days,
Num. 11:20 but a whole month, until it comes out of your nostrils and becomes loathsome to you; because you have rejected the LORD who is among you and have wept before Him, saying, "Why did we ever leave Egypt?"'"

    - The Israelites mistakes were instigated by greedy desires – but it can also be translated as lustful desires – sinful in other words
        - They rejected God by the nature of their grumbling

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        - It wasn't just complaining, but rather it revealed a heart that didn't trust or love the Lord – an unbelieving heart

    - Similarly, had Jesus given in to Satan's trick and satisfied his own greedy desires, He would have been denying the sufficiency of God – but He wouldn't do that

        - Jesus quotes Deut 8:3 which we read earlier – further demonstrating the connection between His experience here and the one the Jews had in the desert

- Satan doesn't give up, of course

    - He next appeals to Jesus in a new way

    - He takes Jesus – how we aren't sure – but he places him at a vantage point where He can see all the world's kingdoms

        - And he promises Jesus He can have all that He sees

        - This is an interesting offer, isn't it?

        - Specifically, Satan says that all that Jesus sees belongs to Satan – it was handed over to him – and he can give it to whom he pleases

        - Is he lying again?

- Not exactly. When Adam sinned, he lost dominion over this world

    - Hebrews tells us that through fear of death, which was introduced because of sin – Satan has control over all unbelievers in this world

    - Paul even calls Satan the prince of the power of the air

    - And Satan could give Jesus that same power if He only agreed to Satan's terms – to worship Him rather than the Father

- This is a powerful temptation for Jesus – probably more so than you may realize

    - Because at first you might assume that Jesus would have no interest in this offer

    - Why would Jesus even consider such an offer by Satan

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- Because Jesus had come to earth to gain exactly what Satan was offering
- Jesus came to redeem, to purchase, to gain control over the world
- But the Father's plan for how He would obtain those things involved an excruciatingly painful torture and death before Jesus would inherit His kingdom
- Satan was offering the world to Jesus without need for any of the suffering – and Jesus' flesh must have cried out for the opportunity to save itself from that suffering

- Jesus responds with words from Deut spoken to the nation of Israel
  - Jesus' choice of scripture reflects another poor episode in the history of that nation
    - God warns the nation to seek after Him alone, and not to mix with the people they find in the land
    - He tells them that these ungodly people will pollute them and draw them away into idol worship – to worship Baal, Satan himself
  - Of course, Israel ignores the warning and they fall just as God warned
    - Likewise, we so often are drawn away in a kind of worship of the ungodly culture around us too
    - Satan uses the appeal of the ungodly world to pull us toward other idols – thing we are willing to put our trust in rather than the Lord
    - And while as Christians we have the Spirit to prevent us from straying to the point of unbelief, we can still suffer many of the same penalties of living a life devoted to pursuing things that are not of God

- Finally, Satan must give one last try to bring Jesus down – to corrupt Him
  - Satan again moves Jesus to the top of the temple, probably 60-80 feet overlooking the temple mount

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- This Satan tries to use Jesus adherence to scripture against Him
- He quotes Psalms 91, a Messianic psalm speaking of the coming Christ
  - The psalm declares that the Father will always care for His Son to ensure He is able to complete His assigned mission
    - He takes scripture and misuses it in an attempt to give his cause legitimacy
    - He doesn't need scripture, necessarily, but his goal is always the same – twist truth into a lie, as he is the father of lies
    - And when he is dealing with someone who respects the authority of scripture, then it will be scripture that he uses to make his case
  - Of course, Satan appears to be using scripture appropriately, but in fact He is misusing scripture
  - The psalm declares that the Father will ensure that the Son will not fail in anything He has come to do
  - And it says that the Father will protect the Son in this way because of His love and obedience

Psa. 91:14 ¶ "Because he has loved Me, therefore I will deliver him;
I will set him *securely* on high, because he has known My name.

- So, ironically, if Jesus had followed Satan, he would have been contradicting scripture and therefore, He would not have been obeying and loving the Father
  - And so the Father would not have upheld Him

- But of course, none of those "ifs" were to happen
  - Jesus responded to Satan and to us that we are not to test God to prove that he will keep His promises
  - Jesus again quotes Deut 6

Deut. 6:16 ¶ "You shall not put the LORD your God to the test, as you tested *Him* at Massah.

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- And here we see Jesus making another reference to the Jews experiences in the desert
- The Jews tested God when they were thirsty and found no water
    - Though God was prepared to provide it as He had in the past, they continued to grumble and question His faithfulness
    - Through their complaints they essentially declared that God could not be trusted
    - The story is in Numbers, but Psalms 95 summarizes it succinctly

Psa. 95:6 ¶ Come, let us worship and bow down,
Let us kneel before the LORD our Maker.
Psa. 95:7 For He is our God,
And we are the people of His pasture and the sheep of His hand.
Today, if you would hear His voice,
Psa. 95:8 Do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah,
As in the day of Massah in the wilderness,
Psa. 95:9 "When your fathers tested Me,
They tried Me, though they had seen My work.
Psa. 95:10 "For forty years I loathed *that* generation,
And said they are a people who err in their heart,
And they do not know My ways.
Psa. 95:11 "Therefore I swore in My anger,
Truly they shall not enter into My rest."

- When we begin to insist that God give us proof that we can trust Him, we anger Him
    - We are provoking Him, because we are showing a lack of faith and we are forgetting who we are and who God is
    - Jesus wasn't about to show a lack of faith or to anger God
    - And so Satan failed again
    - Jesus had endured 40 days of physical trial and then constant temptation by the enemy, and He showed himself worthy to be the new Adam

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Rom. 5:19 For as through the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, even so through the obedience of the One the many will be made righteous.

- Now Satan withdrew, because he decided his best hope was to bring Christ down through evil men
    - Of course little did he know that Jesus' death was all a part of God's plan
    - And that even in going to the cross, Jesus was demonstrating the greatest of obedience to the Father
- And consider the lengths the Father went to demonstrate the superiority of His Son over the first Adam
    - Adam lived in ideal conditions, without deprivation
    - Adam had only one rule to follow
    - Adam was never tempted by Satan, he only had a simple offer to eat what his wife gave him
    - And Adam couldn't obey
- Jesus endured a very different test
    - He was starved nearly to death
    - He was surrounded by harsh conditions
    - He was constantly tempted by Satan
    - His obedience required the greatest of efforts
    - And He couldn't disobey
- And now it's our turn
    - We can't tell God that our test is too difficult
        - That we are facing physical conditions too difficult to overcome
        - That our circumstances in life make obedience impossible
        - That we face unreasonable temptations
        - That the devil made us do it

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- That our effort isn't able to match the test
- That we can't obey

- Because our Lord has been there before us
- And the same Spirit that gave him strength through his ordeals is in each of us
    - And if we are willing to discipline the body, then we can be led by the Spirit as He was

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Luke 4B

- The fourth chapter of Luke records the beginning of Jesus' ministry
    - In the previous chapter Jesus had received his authority to minister by the Holy Spirit
    - In the first third of today's chapter, we saw Jesus tempted but resisting in the wilderness, demonstrating His sinless nature and His obedience to the Father
    - The final third of the chapter next week we see the beginning of the record of his miracles, the means by which he demonstrated His power and authority and declared the kingdom had come
    - But before we get there, today we study the middle third of Chapter 4, the declaration of his ministry and announcement of the arrival of the Messiah
    - And as we'll see throughout the Gospel, Chap 4 also gives us the chance to see how the people of Israel reacted to Jesus' claims

Luke 4:14 ¶ And Jesus returned to Galilee in the power of the Spirit, and news about Him spread through all the surrounding district.
Luke 4:15 And He *began* teaching in their synagogues and was praised by all.
Luke 4:16 ¶ And He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up; and as was His custom, He entered the synagogue on the Sabbath, and stood up to read.
Luke 4:17 And the book of the prophet Isaiah was handed to Him. And He opened the book and found the place where it was written,
Luke 4:18 "THE SPIRIT OF THE LORD IS UPON ME,
BECAUSE HE ANOINTED ME TO PREACH THE GOSPEL TO THE POOR.
HE HAS SENT ME TO PROCLAIM RELEASE TO THE CAPTIVES,
AND RECOVERY OF SIGHT TO THE BLIND,
TO SET FREE THOSE WHO ARE OPPRESSED,
Luke 4:19 TO PROCLAIM THE FAVORABLE YEAR OF THE LORD."
Luke 4:20 And He closed the book, gave it back to the attendant and sat down; and the eyes of all in the synagogue were fixed on Him.
Luke 4:21 And He began to say to them, "Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing."

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- Leaving the high desert of the Galilee and heading south to the valley west of the Sea of Galilee, Jesus bean entering into the synagogues and teaching in towns throughout the region
    - We know He visit Capernaum on the north shore of the Sea of Galilee, perhaps Hazor near the Jordon river
    - If you were to look at a similar account in Matt and Mark, you would note differences in the accounts
        - In particularly, the timing of Mark and Matt seems to be later
            - M & M have disciples – Luke not till Chap 5
            - M & M have Christ performing many miracles, etc.
        - Essentially, there are two possibilities
            - More than one visit to Nazareth
            - Luke placed the event early to make the point that His ministry would be rejected not accepted
            - I like the multiple visit theory
- As Jesus arrived in the synagogues, he would always teach
    - Synagogue means to bring together, to assemble together
    - Luke provides a lot of detail on how synagogues operated
        - For the Greek reader
    - Synagogues existed as a worship and teaching extension of the temple
        - It wasn't the same as the temple – not a place of sacrifice
        - It was the primary gathering place for Jews to sing praises, to study the Torah, the Word of God, and to pray together
        - The teaching could be done by any adult Jewish male, after 13
            - Study of the Word and preparation to teach were part of preparation in youth
            - Not only did it encourage knowledge of God but also literacy and scholarship

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- Of course, it deteriorated into sects and men who looked to knowledge as a replacement for genuine love for God and obedience to God

- When a notable visitor arrived for the Sabbath service, they would commonly be given the honor of reading from the Word of God, which was comprised of the Torah, the Prophets and the Sayings

  - The practice in the temple was for the reading of God's Word to be done while standing

  - Then the reader would expound the passage for the audience

- Do these patterns sound familiar?

  - The gathering of God's people hasn't changed much in thousands of years – because of the Spirit of God is directing the worship of His believers

  - The Word of God, the singing of praise, the praying for one another, the sharing of fellowship, the looking forward to the fulfillment of God's promises for His faithful

- Yet the gathering do vary in adherence with this pattern and the integrity in which it's carried out

  - In the day of Jesus, no doubt he encountered some synagogues that were more healthy than others, more strict in their observance than others, larger than others, and so on

  - We know from the Gospels that the Jewish culture already included many who were apostate and acted out their faith merely as a cultural distinction

  - Jesus ran into all kinds

- It's interesting that Jesus nevertheless honored each city by entering their synagogue and participating in their services

  - It sounds as though He was a loyal and regular participant in worship regardless of where He found himself

  - He also played a useful and contributing role, teaching in every place, and the reaction we're told was always positive

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        - He came to benefit the people of God, even when they may have been a particularly sickly group – a group without much true spirituality to offer

        - He contributed what He came to give regardless of whether those in attendance were especially interested in listening

    - He also didn't forsake participating in the ceremony of the synagogue, even though it was never provided in scripture

        - The ceremony itself was not the key, but nor was it reason to reject the service

        - In other words, Jesus wasn't interested in finding the perfect service before He was willing to set foot in the building

        - In other words, He came for the sick not for the healthy

- These scenes painted by Luke look so familiar to us today

    - The essential elements of the service really haven't changed much

        - There are local gatherings in towns and cities the world over

        - They are all bound by similar if not exactly the same beliefs

        - Similar patterns of worship

        - A focus on the Word, on praise, on prayer and on fellowship more or less

    - But we also have our unhealthy patterns and sects

        - We have misunderstandings of faith and doctrine

        - And we have many who call themselves Christians and live the culture to some extent but don't truly have or live the faith

- And in His example, He demonstrated the importance of making gathering with others in worship a priority

    - Those who lived in those towns who refrained from gathering in the synagogues on the days Jesus visited would have missed Him – the Messiah

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- God was there everyday in His Word, but what a shame to miss the physical appearance of the Messiah
- I believe if Jesus were to return again and repeat his first ministry, but this time walking from church to church instead of synagogues
  - He would visit every church that gave opportunity
  - Remembering He came to heal the sick, not the healthy
- But it's also worth noting that reading and expounding the Word was his focus in every place he stopped
  - Ultimately, if church is to be church, the worship must be in Spirit and in Truth
    - And Truth is the Word of God and nothing else
    - When we remove the Word of God from the service, we have removed its power and purpose
    - The church today is so unhealthy in so many corners because the Word of God has been removed from so many pulpits
  - While preparing the Word of God is my contribution to this service, don't ever underestimate your own contribution
    - Jesus choose to approach people in the meeting places of his day, because the gathering is important to God
    - He could have said He didn't need to be there because the system was corrupt or because He didn't need instruction – but took every opportunity to be there
    - When you are absent from the gathering you are withholding your gifting and contribution from the Body of Christ

- And so Jesus is the distinguished visitor, Jesus is asked to read the Word from Isaiah, and he stands and reads Isaiah 61
  - The verses in Isaiah were Messianic, and even in Jesus' day they had always been seen this way

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- They begin with a reference to the Holy Spirit anointing His ministry, a prophecy Christ had just fulfilled with John the Baptist
- Then the verse begins to describe the ministry of the Messiah
  - It's important to note what the verses Jesus read say and what He leaves out
    - He will bring good news to the afflicted
    - He will bind up the broken hearted
    - He will proclaim liberty to captives and freedom to prisoners
  - In other words, Jesus' ministry was to be a ministry of reconciliation, of redemption, of healing both physical and spiritual – of freeing men from the bondage of sin
  - Finally, Jesus says He is declaring the favorable year of the Lord
    - To His Jewish audience this was an obvious reference to the Jewish Year of Jubilee
    - This custom came from the Las in Lev 25
    - It provided for a rest for the farm land one year out of every seven
      - God would provide enough yield in the seventh year to last past the Jubilee
    - After 49 years (7 x 7), the Jubilee arrived when all indentured servants and slaves were set free, land reverted back to it's original owners
      - In fact, the price of land was reduced proportionally according to how many years left until Jubilee

- The Jubilee provided for a rest for the land, which every farmer will tell you is good and necessary for the soil
  - But it's spiritual significance was its primary purpose, as all the Law points to Christ

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- Christ we already studied in Genesis is the Lord of the Sabbath – He is our rest from our work of salvation – so that the Sabbath it self is a picture of Christ
  - Now the Jubilee year is a reinforcement of that picture
  - The seventh year is a year when we do no work but yet God has provided all we need – the rest is ours since God did the work
- And the 50th year jubilees demonstrates the other have of Jesus' ministry
  - It pictures the freedom we all have in Him, a freedom from slavery, slavery to sin
  - And it pictures our inheritance being restored – our eternal inheritance

- So Christ reads the first verse and part of the second verse of Isaiah 61
  - But it's also notable that Christ stopped where he did
    - The second verse of Isaiah reads in full

Is. 61:2 To proclaim the favorable year of the LORD
And the day of vengeance of our God;
To comfort all who mourn,

- The next line of Isaiah also describes Christ's role as judge of the world
- It makes mention of his day of vengeance in Tribulation
- Jesus does not read this verse, because as He says in John:

John 3:17 "For God did not send the Son into the world to judge the world, but that the world might be saved through Him.

- Jesus is focused on the purpose of his first coming alone for now

- Having read the scripture, Jesus sits down for the exposition, as was customary, and he announces that these verses were fulfilled – they described this very moment

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Luke 4:22 And all were speaking well of Him, and wondering at the gracious words which were falling from His lips; and they were saying, "Is this not Joseph's son?"
Luke 4:23 And He said to them, "No doubt you will quote this proverb to Me, 'Physician, heal yourself! Whatever we heard was done at Capernaum, do here in your hometown as well.'"
Luke 4:24 And He said, "Truly I say to you, no prophet is welcome in his hometown.
Luke 4:25 "But I say to you in truth, there were many widows in Israel in the days of Elijah, when the sky was shut up for three years and six months, when a great famine came over all the land;
Luke 4:26 and yet Elijah was sent to none of them, but only to Zarephath, *in the land* of Sidon, to a woman who was a widow.
Luke 4:27 "And there were many lepers in Israel in the time of Elisha the prophet; and none of them was cleansed, but only Naaman the Syrian."
Luke 4:28 And all *the people* in the synagogue were filled with rage as they heard these things;
Luke 4:29 and they got up and drove Him out of the city, and led Him to the brow of the hill on which their city had been built, in order to throw Him down the cliff.
Luke 4:30 But passing through their midst, He went His way.

- The crowd had two reactions almost at once
    - First, they were edified by Jesus' teaching
        - His commentary seemed appropriate and was pleasing
        - It reaffirmed their faith in God's word
        - It marveled at God's grace toward them in the prophecy of the Messiah
    - But they also couldn't accept that Jesus was that person
        - There reason for not accepting Him was rather pitiful - He was too well known – Joseph's son
            - They had grown up around Him
            - In a small community in ancient times, without transportation, air conditioned homes, television, people were outside and knew one another
            - He would have been a well known child of the town
        - He was too ordinary, too much like them to be the Messiah

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- The irony is that strangers in another city were prepared to see Him as the promised Messiah but not those who knew him best

- But it also reminds us that the test of faith in Christ is more than a belief in the concept of a Messiah or the idea of God forgiving our sins because of His mercy rather than our works

  - Ultimately, salvation awaits those who believe in Jesus the person as the Messiah

  - We must come to the Gospel story as it is written in this book and accept these eye witness accounts as truth – as a testimony that a man named Jesus was born, lived and was crucified nearly 2,000 years ago

  - That was all man yet also God in perfection

  - If the concepts sound good but we never personalize the Messiah as Jesus Himself, then salvation never comes

Acts 4:12 "And there is salvation in no one else; for there is no other name under heaven that has been given among men by which we must be saved."

- Now Jesus of courses sensed the doubt and unbelief among those in Nazareth

  - He had traveled recently through Capernaum and had done many miracles there to a great response

  - That response had reached Nazareth even before Jesus Himself did

  - So now Jesus says what their thinking

    - He says they were expecting him to do the miracles at home He did in Capernum

      - Matt and Mark and Luke all record some of the miracles Jesus did in that city including some of the most dramatic healings

    - It's likely that His unwillingness to perform miracles further increased their skepticism

  - Then His famous quote that a prophet can't be successful in his hometown

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- The word for welcomed can also be translated accepted – prophets are never accepted in their own towns
- Natural but regrettable quality of our nature that we are only impressed by the new and different, never by the familiar

- The essential problem here was not their desire in seeing miracles, as it was their purpose in seeing them
  - In Capernaum, Jesus declared who he was and He delighted in performing miracles for them, which cemented their belief in His words
  - In Nazareth, Jesus knew their hearts would be skeptical no matter what He did, so He performed few miracles realizing that they would do no good
    - Throughout His ministry Jesus never indulged the hard hearted who were merely testing him
    - He remained silent before those who demanded that he defend Himself

- Then to prove His statement concerning prophets and hometowns, Jesus makes mention of two famous incidents involving prophets from Israel's past
  - The story of Elisha is in 1 Kings 17
    - God has brought a severe drought and famine for 3.5 years upon Israel for their sin
      - That period is always a period of judgment
      - And Elisha was sent by God to a Gentile city and to a widow and her son
      - The woman showed him mercy and kindness
      - She also acknowledged he was a messenger of God
      - God sent Elisha to those who would receive him without question while ignoring the citizens of Israel who rejected Elisha's words
    - Likewise, the story of Elisha demonstrates Jesus' point about faith without questioning and without demanding convincing proofs

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2Kings 5:1 ¶ Now Naaman, captain of the army of the king of Aram, was a great man with his master, and highly respected, because by him the LORD had given victory to Aram. The man was also a valiant warrior, *but he was* a leper.
2Kings 5:2 Now the Arameans had gone out in bands and had taken captive a little girl from the land of Israel; and she waited on Naaman's wife.
2Kings 5:3 She said to her mistress, "I wish that my master were with the prophet who is in Samaria! Then he would cure him of his leprosy."
2Kings 5:4 Naaman went in and told his master, saying, "Thus and thus spoke the girl who is from the land of Israel."
2Kings 5:5 Then the king of Aram said, "Go now, and I will send a letter to the king of Israel." He departed and took with him ten talents of silver and six thousand *shekels* of gold and ten changes of clothes.
2Kings 5:6 ¶ He brought the letter to the king of Israel, saying, "And now as this letter comes to you, behold, I have sent Naaman my servant to you, that you may cure him of his leprosy."
2Kings 5:7 When the king of Israel read the letter, he tore his clothes and said, "Am I God, to kill and to make alive, that this man is sending *word* to me to cure a man of his leprosy? But consider now, and see how he is seeking a quarrel against me."
2Kings 5:8 ¶ It happened when Elisha the man of God heard that the king of Israel had torn his clothes, that he sent *word* to the king, saying, "Why have you torn your clothes? Now let him come to me, and he shall know that there is a prophet in Israel."
2Kings 5:9 So Naaman came with his horses and his chariots and stood at the doorway of the house of Elisha.
2Kings 5:10 Elisha sent a messenger to him, saying, "Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh will be restored to you and *you will* be clean."
2Kings 5:11 But Naaman was furious and went away and said, "Behold, I thought, 'He will surely come out to me and stand and call on the name of the LORD his God, and wave his hand over the place and cure the leper.'
2Kings 5:12 "Are not Abanah and Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? Could I not wash in them and be clean?" So he turned and went away in a rage.
2Kings 5:13 Then his servants came near and spoke to him and said, "My father, had the prophet told you *to do some* great thing, would you not have done *it*? How much more *then,* when he says to you, 'Wash, and be clean'?"
2Kings 5:14 So he went down and dipped *himself* seven times in the Jordan, according to the word of the man of God; and his flesh was restored like the flesh of a little child and he was clean.

- Naaman was the captain of the forces of the Aramean nation

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- When Naaman travels to Israel, he takes great risk to travel to the camp of his enemy to request healing
- But it's a testimony of his faith in the girl's testimony of the prophet
- He does take gifts to appease the King of Israel, an amount of 750 lbs of silver and 150 lbs of gold

- The King of Israel is distraught over receiving the letter because he can't understand how the King of Armeans expected him to heal a man of leprosy
  - But Elisha steps in to the rescue and offers to see the man
  - He suggests that the man wash in the Jordon seven times
  - The repetition of 7 ensures that anyone hearing of the miracle would know to credit God for the healing
- The captain is upset because the suggestion seems powerless to help him
  - And he storms off indignant
  - This is like the people of Nazareth
    - They aren't willing to even consider that Jesus could be the Messiah because of his familiarity to them
    - This is also why Jesus' own brothers rejected him at least until after his resurrection
  - But then the servants say something very insightful
    - They remind him that he would have been willing to do something very difficult, very painful, very sacrificing if Elisha had asked it
    - So why not do the simple thing?
- So Naaman relents and agrees to do it
  - And sure enough he is cleansed according to the prophets words
  - And in that his obedience is rewarded
- Jesus has admonished the citizens of Nazareth for their unwillingness to believe something as simple and unimpressive as their own local boy returning declaring the gospel

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- And Jesus reminds the crowd that Elisha healed this Gentile, an enemy of Israel even as many lepers existed in Elisha's own country
- And the fact that God left so many of Israel in their state of suffering was a consequence of their rejection of His Word through the prophet Elisha
- Now the same fate was befalling the city of Nazareth for their hardness
  - Yet their neighbor Capernaum was receiving healing because they were willing to consider the message
  - And of course his suggestion angered them for they hated being compared to Gentiles

- The world we live in has much the same expectation as the people in Nazareth
  - When the Gospel message is presented, many will react as if the answer is too easy, not difficult enough, not dramatic enough
  - Where is the work? Where is the sacrifice? When you say salvation is the free gift of God because we can't earn it, the answer won't satisfy those looking for a different answer
  - But demands for spectacular proof or for difficult effort will always go unanswered
    - Faith is always the assurance of *things* hoped for, the conviction of things not seen
    - When we present the gospel to others we will often receive the same reaction from the world – skepticism and demands for proof
      - But once in a while we will find hat one who accepts the truth in the way Christ said it would happen – as the innocence of a child without doubt and without skepticism
  - And that is the faith the pleases the Father because it honors His son and His Word

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Luke 4C

- As Jesus begins to enter into His ministry, He will travel from city to city, encountering scoffers, enemies, demons, and crowds of enthusiastic supporters
    - In each town He will do a var1iety of miracles and signs
    - He will teach the scripture with authority in a way that amazes audiences and prompts questions about where did His authority come from
    - And He will rebuke unrighteousness and call out sin
- But all of this begs the question…what was His purpose in spending His time this way
    - His ultimate purpose in coming to Earth was established even before He was born
    - He had come to be the sacrifice
    - He had come to die
    - So why the time beforehand? Why move around and teach this way and do the miracles?
    - Chap 4 begins to helps us understand God's purpose in giving His Son the ministry He had on Earth

Luke 4:31 ¶ And He came down to Capernaum, a city of Galilee, and He was teaching them on the Sabbath;
Luke 4:32 and they were amazed at His teaching, for His message was with authority.
Luke 4:33 In the synagogue there was a man possessed by the spirit of an unclean demon, and he cried out with a loud voice,
Luke 4:34 "Let us alone! What business do we have with each other, Jesus of Nazareth? Have You come to destroy us? I know who You are—the Holy One of God!"
Luke 4:35 But Jesus rebuked him, saying, "Be quiet and come out of him!" And when the demon had thrown him down in the midst *of the people*, he came out of him without doing him any harm.
Luke 4:36 And amazement came upon them all, and they *began* talking with one another saying, "What is this message? For with authority and power He commands the unclean spirits and they come out."
Luke 4:37 And the report about Him was spreading into every locality in the surrounding district.

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- As I mentioned last time, Jesus has begun His ministry in the area of the Galilee
    - Apparently, He moves freely between the numerous towns in the region
    - Here He is seen returning to Capernaum, as He mentioned having been there earlier when he taught in Nazareth
        - Luke specifically mentions that He went down to Capernaum
        - Capernaum sits on the coast of the Sea of Galilee about 20 miles northeast from Nazareth, which sits in the hills of the wilderness
        - So Jesus descends in altitude from about 1,200 feet above to about 700 feet below
    - And as He enters Capernaum, He immediately begins to accomplish those things written about Him in the Isaiah passage He read in Nazareth
- Like in Nazareth, Jesus finds His first audience in a synagogue
    - On the Sabbath He teaches and the people are impressed by His teaching
        - As I read this simple description of Jesus' teaching, I have to admit being a little jealous
        - I would love to have heard what He taught that so amazed them
            - My guess is He took them through the OT passages they had heard taught so many times before, probably according to the teaching of the day
            - And when Jesus taught, He opened them up with the power of the Father by His Holy Spirit, Jesus revealed their true meaning and the crowds were amazed
        - I find it interesting that whatever He taught, they didn't react with skepticism
            - Certainly He was revealing new ideas through the scripture, otherwise why would they be impressed?
            - But if the information was so new, why didn't they cling to their tradition rather than accepting the new ideas presented by Christ?

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- I imagine that the power and truth of Jesus' teaching was self-evident
    - Although they might have been predisposed to accept their traditional teaching, the overwhelming truth of what Jesus spoke cut through the tradition and made an impact
    - Or perhaps many in the crowd had been so poorly taught before that they never paid much attention in times past when those passages had been exposited
        - So Jesus' version was the first time they found the truth so interesting that they actually paid attention
        - Either way, it was compelling and drew them in
- While we haven't seen Jesus in the flesh, we also can experience the same thing as these people in Capernaum
    - Before His departure from Earth, Jesus told His followers that they would receive the Helper, the HS who would teach them all things
    - The presence of the HS in all believers is the way by which the truth of the scripture become plain to us all today
        - If we devote ourselves to the study of scripture, we can have the same ah ha experiences that Jesus provided to this crowd in Capernaum
        - It won't come quickly and it will require a devoted effort, but that is like any relationship
            - To spend time with our Father and with our Lord is the way we grow that relationship
            - And we spend time with them through the Word of God – whether in self study or in organized studies
- But we also must be prepared to hear remarkable things – things that may not agree with the conventional wisdom concerning the passages we study
    - Just as Jesus brought fresh and unfamiliar explanations from the scripture, we may find that when we sit for instructions from the HS – whether by ourselves or under teachers – that conventional wisdom may be challenged
    - Just as it was in Jesus day

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- So much teaching on the scripture of that day had been corrupted by men who read the Word through unbelieving eyes
    - So that when Jesus corrected those errors in His day, it caught the crowd off guard and they were surprised by His teaching

- But if you were listening carefully to my words, then you should have immediately sense a danger sign
    - Because anytime someone presents a new and unfamiliar interpretation of scripture claiming that the conventional wisdom should be dismissed, we need to be careful and discerning
        - The claim to having new revelation is a common feature of false teachers
        - There is a fine but important line between bringing HS-inspired enlightening on a passage of scripture and teaching a false view of the Word
        - As Peter taught:

2Pet. 1:20 But know this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture is *a matter* of one's own interpretation,
2Pet. 1:21 for no prophecy was ever made by an act of human will, but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God.

- So how do we know the difference?
    - In Jesus day, why were the people willing to accept His radical reinterpretation of the scriptures, considering how long they have been interpreted differently?
    - And today, when someone brings new teaching from familiar scriptures, how do we know whether to accept it

- The answer to the that question, both then and now, is the same
    - There are three principle tests we should apply, as were likely applied even to Jesus teaching
    - First, is the interpretation consistent with or at least not in contradiction to all related scripture

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- Since all scripture is from God, then we know we should see no contradiction in interpretation because God does not change His mind or tell one thing one day and an opposite thing on another day
    - But we're not talking about pulling out one isolated verse to argue against another isolated verse
    - The danger here is that we can fall into Bible bingo, where we call upon individual verses in a game of one upsmanship - which often results in one passage after another being misinterpreted and misused
- The real key is to be so familiar with scripture generally that you have a foundation of truth from which to determine if a new interpretation is from the Lord or not

Acts 17:10 ¶ The brethren immediately sent Paul and Silas away by night to Berea, and when they arrived, they went into the synagogue of the Jews.
Acts 17:11 Now these were more noble-minded than those in Thessalonica, for they received the word with great eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily *to see* whether these things were so.

- So, when we hear scripture interpreted in a different or novel way, we should take time to consider all the Bible has to say on that topic and look for inconsistencies
    - Does this new idea fly in the face of sound teaching elsewhere?
    - Are the scriptures that the teacher is using to defend his interpretation being considered within their proper context?
    - Here's a classic example of not using context:

- Turn to 1Cor 15:29

1Cor. 15:29 ¶ Otherwise, what will those do who are baptized for the dead? If the dead are not raised at all, why then are they baptized for them?

- You may have heard that Mormons use this one single verse as a defense for baptizing dead relatives in the hope of ushering them into heaven
    - They teach that this passage says that we should baptize the dead

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- How would we know if that's a true interpretation?
  - Based on our first rule, we look at the rest of scripture only to find no other reference to such a practice
  - This teaching must rise or fall on the interpretation of this single scripture
- So, in examining this verse we should consider the context of Paul's discussion
  - The beginning of this chapter finds Paul trying to reassure the Corinthian church that resurrection from the dead was a reality to be believed
  - The second half of the chapter deals with the same issue – a proof through analogy that a body can be buried and brought back to life, just as a plant seed does the same
  - So stuck between them is this quick reference to baptism
    - It would seem that Paul's topic is not baptism but resurrection

- And this proves to be the key to understanding this verse
  - Baptism by immersion is a picture of our old self dying with Christ and our resurrection to new life
    - The going into the water is meant to picture going into the earth dead
    - And the coming out in new life is a picture of our resurrection – to a new spirit initially and ultimately to a new body one day to come
  - So Paul asks the Corinth church why they still practice immersion Baptism if they don't believe that resurrection actually takes place
    - Paul actually leaves unspoken an implied piece of this verse
    - In referencing the baptism of the dead, he is actually shorting a phrase he has been using in several places earlier in this same letter.
      - Look at verses 12, 13, and 21

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- You'll see Him reference the resurrection of the dead
- And in verse 29 he is still talking about that same event – the resurrection of the dead

- So the complete way to read verse 29 would be:

1Cor. 15:29 ¶ Otherwise, what will those do who are baptized for the resurrection of the dead? If the dead are not raised at all, why then are they baptized for them?

- Essentially, Paul is using the most specific and complete term for describing baptism – the baptism for the resurrection of the dead – our baptism, in other words
  - He's not talking about a special baptism for dead people
  - He's talking about the one and only baptism that every believer should experience
    - The one that is a picture of rebirth to new life – a coming back to life from the dead – a baptism for the resurrection of the dead
- The second rule for testing new teaching is to consider if the teaching is demonstrating an accurate picture of God's character and nature
  - Remember, all scripture exists to reveal God in all His glory and to draw men to him, in humility, service and obedience
  - If the teaching doesn't generally support those broad purposes, then it should be rejected
  - Many false teachings fall quite easily when we apply this test
    - Teachings that glorify man or credit man rather than God
    - Teachings that show God to be easily manipulated or capricious in His actions or words
    - Teachings that diminish your trust and obedience in God
    - Teachings that affirm your natural desires
  - All these are false by design and run counter to the overall tenor of scripture

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- Finally, the last rule is to test the message by the character of the messenger
    - The man himself should show the fruit of the Spirit – the One by whose authority he claims to teach
        - While we all should show fruit in our walk, it's especially the case that a teacher who is truly speaking in the authority of the Holy Spirit should be able to show the good work of the washing of the word in themselves
        - And this kind of familiarity requires time and diligence
        - If the man's message is from God then you can be sure that God will also be doing a work in this man as well
- And as we see verse 32, Jesus gives every indication of speaking with authority, His words passing the first two tests easily
    - Christ is teaching around the region not merely for the purpose of building up the people's knowledge
    - But more importantly, He was establishing His authority, but the power in which He spoke
    - Just as men today establish they have authority in the Holy Spirit by the power of their teaching
- Of course Christ went infinitely beyond what mere men do in establishing His authority, although the principle is the same
- And now it's time for Luke to record examples of how Christ passed the third test
    - Luke records Christ's actions in Capernaum, His miracles, which no doubt gave the audience even further reason to trust His words

- So in verse 33, Luke provides his first detailed record of Christ performing a miracle involves casting our demons
    - Christ enters the synagogue and comes upon a man possessed by an unclean demon
        - The reference to an unclean demon reflects the fact that demons by nature lead to uncleanliness, unholyliness

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- Luke probably made this double reference because the Greek mythology allowed for evil spirits that did good things on occasion

- The man with the demon cried out with a loud voice at the sight of Christ
  - The voice recorded by Luke is actually the voice of the demon
  - The demon would use the vocal cords of the human to speak
  - The demon spoke in the plural and his words were interesting
    - The first word in verse 34 is ea. This has been translated to "Let us alone" but that's probably a stretch
    - The actual meaning of ea is Ha! Like an exclamation – an indignant surprise
    - These demons are genuinely surprised to find Jesus there
  - Then the second statement (tis lesous) is probably best translated "Why this interference" or "What do we have between us?"
  - Then they ask have you come to destroy us, since they know who He is – the Holy One

- Before going any further, we can immediately see a few interesting features about the demonic realm
  - First – need I even say it – but demons are real
    - Jesus isn't interacting with a fake, an actor – and Luke didn't make this story up – Demons are very real
    - Demons are the one third of the angels, the host of heaven that Revelation tells us fell with Satan
    - These are his legion, his allies, his soldiers in battle
    - Our culture either treats them as myth, placing too little importance on them or treats them as gods, placing too much importance
    - They are neither. They have real power and can bring persecution, but only up to what God will allow, since they are created beings
  - The second thing we should notice is they can and do indwell men

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- They can take over the body in extreme cases and speak through the body
    - They can also impact thoughts and emotions
    - But they only have the influence over unbelievers
    - Because He who is in you is greater than he who is in the world, according to 1John 4:4
- Personally, I believe there are conditions of deranged behavior that are actually the result of demonic activity in a person
    - But our unbelieving secular medical world cannot accept that possibility
    - So they attribute it to unexplained psychosis
    - This isn't to say that all mental or emotion trauma are the result of demonic activity, but I do believe it is one potential cause

- The third thing to take note of is that demons are constantly waiting for Jesus to destroy them
    - They seem to now this will happen and they have no hope of standing against Jesus
    - Here they are surprised to see someone interfering with their work, and I believe they initially assume it must be the work of another demon
    - Then they realize they are dealing with the Son of God and immediately ask if He has come to destroy them
        - They know that He will do that one day, but they don't know if this is the day
        - And they then declare that they know Who He is
    - The desperation and unmatched evil of the demonic realm is a result – in part – of their desperation to avoid the judgment that they know is coming
- The final thing to note is that the demonic realm is not omnipotent

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- They didn't know that Jesus was even on earth at first – He surprised them
- They didn't know if this was His appointed time to destroy them
- And they obeyed His commands

- We should take heart to know that as real as they are, as a believer we are protected from their influence to the extent God desires
  - He may allow them some measure of success, only as a means of ultimately bringing Himself greater glory by how He defeats them in the end
  - Even Paul talks about handing over an unrepentant sinner to Satan

1Cor. 5:5 *I have decided* to deliver such a one to Satan for the destruction of his flesh, so that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus.

  - So it may happen that God will use the demonic realm to accomplish His discipline, but it's always under His control
  - In fact, in our account today Jesus dispenses with the demon with merely His word – and Jesus doesn't call upon any higher power
    - The crowd takes note of this, commenting on His authority and power
    - Normally in Jewish experience, men could (if empowered by God perform an exorcism
    - But it required that the one removing the demons invoke God's authority
  - Here the crowds sees a man casting out demons by his own word
  - With this miracle, Christ adds the third facet to his proof of believability, something He will do time and time again during His ministry

Luke 4:38 ¶ Then He got up and *left* the synagogue, and entered Simon's home. Now Simon's mother-in-law was suffering from a high fever, and they asked Him to help her. Luke 4:39 And standing over her, He rebuked the fever, and it left her; and she immediately got up and waited on them.

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Luke 4:40 ¶ While the sun was setting, all those who had any *who were* sick with various diseases brought them to Him; and laying His hands on each one of them, He was healing them.
Luke 4:41 Demons also were coming out of many, shouting, "You are the Son of God!" But rebuking them, He would not allow them to speak, because they knew Him to be the Christ.
Luke 4:42 ¶ When day came, Jesus left and went to a secluded place; and the crowds were searching for Him, and came to Him and tried to keep Him from going away from them.
Luke 4:43 But He said to them, "I must preach the kingdom of God to the other cities also, for I was sent for this purpose."
Luke 4:44 ¶ So He kept on preaching in the synagogues of Judea.

- After teaching at the synagogue, Jesus is invited to the home of Simon
    - Luke leaves out some details, but by reading Mark and Matt, we learn this is Simon Peter, the Apostle
    - And with them are John and James
- In Peter's house lived his wife's mother, who was ill with a high fever
    - The disciples take Jesus to her, and he orders the fever to leave her, which it does
        - And to show us how complete the healing was, We hear that she got up and served them
        - At first, this may sound a bit harsh, to expect this woman who was moments ago suffering from illness, to begin waiting on the men
        - But the purpose of the statement was not to emphasize the servant role of woman or anything of the kind
        - It was merely a way of Luke demonstrating the completeness and suddenness of the healing
            - It was so complete and so quick and the woman was healthy enough to resume her normal duties
            - I imagine that she was very grateful and happy to return a favor to Jesus for what He did for her!
- And naturally, Jesus becomes known for healing very quickly

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- The ancient world lived with disease far more than we do today
- Death and illness were very common in everyday life, and the appearance of someone who alleviate all that was certainly big news
- And they wanted Him to stay naturally

- But really things are much different today
  - In our own way, the world is just as sick – if not sicker
  - And healing is just as hard to come by
  - And people want healing anywhere they can find it
  - But Jesus has the power to heal, if it's His will to do so
  - Therefore, when you are not healing, there must be a reason in that as well, once we may not know entirely until we see Him face to face
  - But we can trust n His goodness nevertheless

- Finally, the chapter ends with Jesus saying that He cannot remain in that one place,
  - That He has a ministry that requires He move about
  - We will say more about that next time, but for now it's important to remember that Christ's ministry of travel was intended by the Father

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Luke 5A

- Jesus is teaching and moving around within the land of the Galilee
    - He's been teaching, healing, casting out demons and declaring the kingdom of God
    - At the end of Chap 4, Luke shows Jesus healing Peter's mother-in-law of fever
        - Mark shows Peter, Andrew & James, John were with Jesus at that time
- As Jesus has been teaching, as you would expect, he's begun to attract crowds, and followers that go with him everywhere He goes
    - But those crowds included all sorts of people – good, bad, ugly
        - And Jesus is intent on gathering around Himself a few specific individuals who He intends to train up for ministry after His death
    - Now in Chap 5 Luke begins to show us how Jesus began to gather His followers

Luke 5:1 ¶ Now it happened that while the crowd was pressing around Him and listening to the word of God, He was standing by the lake of Gennesaret;
Luke 5:2 and He saw two boats lying at the edge of the lake; but the fishermen had gotten out of them and were washing their nets.
Luke 5:3 And He got into one of the boats, which was Simon's, and asked him to put out a little way from the land. And He sat down and *began* teaching the people from the boat.
Luke 5:4 When He had finished speaking, He said to Simon, "Put out into the deep water and let down your nets for a catch."
Luke 5:5 Simon answered and said, "Master, we worked hard all night and caught nothing, but I will do as You say *and* let down the nets."
Luke 5:6 When they had done this, they enclosed a great quantity of fish, and their nets *began* to break;
Luke 5:7 so they signaled to their partners in the other boat for them to come and help them. And they came and filled both of the boats, so that they began to sink.
Luke 5:8 But when Simon Peter saw *that*, he fell down at Jesus' feet, saying, "Go away from me Lord, for I am a sinful man, O Lord!"
Luke 5:9 For amazement had seized him and all his companions because of the catch of fish which they had taken;
Luke 5:10 and so also *were* James and John, sons of Zebedee, who were partners with Simon. And Jesus said to Simon, "Do not fear, from now on you will be catching men."

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- Let me set the scene a little for you
    - Jesus is still in Galilee at the shores of the Sea of Galilee
        - He is in the plain of Gennesaret on the NW side of the lake
        - On the NW shore is a town that gets its name from the plain
    - Its morning, probably soon after sunrise
        - The air is still and cool, the heat of the day only a few hours away
    - Luke says there are two boats on the shore, fisherman standing nearby mending and cleaning their nets
        - And Jesus approaches the scene with a sizable crowd trailing behind
            - Jesus has been teaching the Word to establish the authority of His ministry
            - And he has been healing to establish His credibility
        - Naturally people have become attracted to Him
            - Some for the teaching
            - Some for the healing
            - Others for the spectacle of it all
        - And many in this group are desperate
    - And they come upon these fishermen
        - And Jesus asks one of the fishermen to allow him to go out on the boat
- Now remember, this is the same Peter who sometime earlier had hosted Jesus in his home and watched as He healed His mother in law
    - Perhaps he was surprised to see Jesus again, perhaps not
        - Maybe he had become accustomed to seeing Jesus wandering around the region and simply accepted him as the local rabbi

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- When Jesus asks to be taken out in the boat, I bet Peter knew immediately why
  - It wasn't so Jesus could join in the fishing
    - Watching these crowds press in upon Jesus must have been somewhat amusing to Peter and his brother Andrew
    - So Jesus was looking for a chance to put some distance between Himself and the crowd
  - By sitting in the boat and floating a short distance from the shore, Jesus gave himself a platform from which to speak without having people pressing against Him
    - Peter accompanied Jesus as did Peter's brother Andrew

- Jesus, Luke tells us, teaches from this vantage point for some time.
  - Isn't it interesting that Jesus felt it was so important that He be able to teach these people that He took the step of distancing Himself from the people
    - When He was there in their midst, completely accessible to their touch, they apparently made every effort to reach Him physically
      - They pressed against Him, we're told
      - They wanted to touch Him – most likely because they sought healing or some other supposed blessing
    - Today you see this with followers of religious movements centered on a single person
      - Even in the Catholic faith, people want to touch the pope, kiss his ring
      - They bring back trinkets blessed by the pope
    - It becomes a faith and worship focused on the material, physical – something that can be touched and seen
  - But scripture tells is that faith is trust in things unseen – specifically in the Word of God
    - Now, no doubt Jesus felt love and compassion for these people

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        - No doubt He wanted to reach out and contend with their infirmities
        - No doubt he wished to take away all their pain and suffering
    - But instead, he separates himself just enough that they can't get what they think they want but close enough to keep them by the shore
        - And while they stand there waiting for Him to come back to the shore, He speaks the Word of God to them

- Now I ask you, do you think they came for the Word of God?
    - Perhaps some did, but I'm willing to bet most didn't
        - I'm willing to bet that many came for the immediate relief from suffering that Jesus offered
        - They wanted healing, they wanted their needs met
        - What they received was the Word of God
    - What would have happened if Jesus had healed all of them?
        - Certainly the news would have produced even greater crowds as more streamed to receive what they wanted as well
        - But what would have happened to the ones who were healed?
            - They would have left…gone home celebrating their healing
            - And how many of them would have stayed to hear the Word of God?
        - How many therefore would have left as healed and content unbelievers, destined for destruction
            - Would that have been love, in the truest sense?
    - Rather than give them what they want, Jesus left them wanting while he taught them the Word
        - In fact, we know He must have withheld healing in many more cases than He actually healed
        - He left many more with infirmities, with trials, with demons than He chose to heal

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- Partly because of time and opportunity, I supposed
- But also because His real interest was in healing their hearts and souls

- And He knew that a man satisfied in his flesh will not seek for the Spirit
  - Nor will he feel a need nor a desire to sit for the Word of God

- Jesus does the same for us today, of course
  - We will not be spared all trials and difficulties
  - We will not have all our desires granted
  - We will not find satisfaction in this world
  - Because Jesus isn't primarily concerned that we achieve everything we want in this world
    - Nor if we receive everything we want
    - Nor that we lead a trouble-free life – though He has the power to grant us all those things
  - No, He is primarily concerned with our spiritual development, - our sanctification – our godliness, our knowledge of and obedience to His word

- And those things comes by only one way – by time spent in study of God's Word
  - And just as Jesus held the crowd at bay – literally – then delivered His Word to them
  - Similarly, if we find some of our prayers for our physical and material needs unanswered,
    - Perhaps Jesus is simply holding us at bay
    - Perhaps He knows that if He were to grant us those things, we would merely walk away to our own life leaving Him alone in the boat

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        - But because He loves us – just as He loved those in Galilee that day, Jesus has distanced Himself just enough to leave us seeking Him
            - And then He has sent His Word – washing us with the word as Paul says in Ephesians
    - Now if you go without attending to the one thing He has made available, then you will have nothing
        - God has really impressed upon me the singular importance of His Word
            - We should seek after it like we seek after food
        - How often do our daily thoughts revolve around food, yet how often do we make the Word of God our emphasis
            - It is not one of many spiritual choices we have as a Christian,
            - It is the only thing – nothing else compares, nothing else has its power, nothing else deserves

- After teaching the people, in verse 4 we see Jesus turn to Peter in the boat and ask him to put his nets back into the sea
    - This must have been a strange request to Peter
        - Luke makes the point that these men were halieus – fishermen
        - They are the experts in fishing,
            - If anyone would have known when to let out the nets, it would them
    - Peter says, respectfully, that there is no point in letting the nets out
        - He's fished all night and caught nothing
            - The type of net he's using is a diktau – a large dragnet
            - James and John were evidently fishing from the shore using an amphibleston - a smaller, round casting net
        - So Peter was skeptical - to say the least - when Jesus said to let down their drag net now

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- But he doesn't argue…he obeys

- I like this scene because it's so typical of all of us
    - Even when we are prepared to obey, we still feel the need to let Jesus know that His direction is pointless and bound to fail
        - We feel Him direct us to do the thing we are sure won't work
    - And even when we are willing to obey, which isn't always the case,
        - We still want Him to know that we want to go on record as having been against it from the beginning
        - It's as though we're distancing ourselves from the coming failure in advance

Bible teacher Donald Grey Barnhouse (1895-1960) told the following story: A young son of a missionary couple in Zaire was playing in the yard. Suddenly the voice of the boy's father rang out from the porch, "Philip, obey me instantly! Drop to your stomach!" Immediately the youngster did as his father commanded. "Now crawl toward me as fast as you can!" The boy obeyed. "Stand up and run to me!" Philip responded unquestioningly and ran to his father's arms.

As the youngster turned to look at the tree by which he had been playing, he saw a large deadly snake hanging from one of the branches! At the first command of his father, Philip could have hesitated and asked, "Why do you want me to do that?" Or he could have casually replied, "In a minute." But his instant obedience without questioning saved his life!

- Obedience is a sign of our love for our Lord
    - But there is a very practical, common sense reason for obedience too
    - We simply don't have as much information as God has
    - Like the story with the boy
        - He didn't know what His father knew
        - So he was right not to second guess his father's directive
    - Likewise, Peter didn't know what the Lord could know

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- For example, Peter hadn't considered that his failure to catch anything earlier that night was actually a part of God's plan
    - God has intended that Peter wouldn't catch anything prior to Jesus' arrival
    - So that now as cast his net upon Christ's direction, it would be filled miraculously, giving glory to Jesus in front of the apostles and crowd
- But instead, Peter rested on his own knowledge
    - He was the expert fisherman here
        - Christ was just a teacher
    - If an expert like himself couldn't catch a thing in an entire night, there simply wasn't a fish to be found in this part of the lake
- We are so much like Peter
    - How often have we experienced failure in some task, then heard God tell us to do it again
        - We hesitate to obey because we can't bear the thought of facing failure another time
        - And because we think we know better – we're the experts in our own lives
        - And because God's direction can so often seem completely counter to good thinking
    - But of course, God's ways are not man's ways
        - And because God can control all things, He can do the impossible and regularly does
        - We forget so easily that both our successes and failures rest with God
    - So it's in His control whether and when we succeed and when we fail,
        - So that even our failures may ultimately be His plan to bring Himself glory in some way

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- And as the story tells us in verse 6, Peter immediately finds his net holding so many fish that the net nears the breaking point
    - James and John are probably watching this from the shore wondering why Peter is being so stupid as to lower his net in the morning hours
        - But almost immediately, it becomes apparent this was a good idea
        - And Peter calls for them to get in their own boat and come help
            - Luke calls them partners of Peter and Andrew, which means they were in business together – fishing for a living
    - Eventually the two teams fill both boats with this extraordinary catch
        - Peter's reaction is quite natural
            - Peter knows immediately that he's just witnessed a miracle
            - After all he's a professional fisherman
            - Nothing like this happens to fishermen naturally
                - This is a supernatural event
                - This would be like having a major road construction project in Austin finishing on time and on budget
                - Things like this just don't happen naturally
        - And at the moment Peter recognizes that he has witnessed God at work in his presence
            - Peter has that unique experience of coming face to face with the power of God
            - And it has the natural effect of reminding him of his own inadequacies and sinfulness
    - This is the natural unavoidable consequence of fallen, sinful man having a personal encounter with his creator
        - This is why Adam and Eve hid in the garden at the approach of God after they had sinned

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- The holiness of God and the sinfulness of man are so wide apart, so opposed to one another
- There is no force in the universe more powerful than the convicting power of God's holiness upon the conscience of a sinful man

- And Peter does what every man in his place would have done – he asks Jesus to leave him alone
    - Why would he do that?
        - Because he can't imagine any other way for him to avoid this uncomfortable reminder of his unworthiness
        - This is what the Bible means when it talks about the Word of God being a two edged sword
            - It cuts us away from our the self-delusions we hold
            - Of how great and wonderful we are
            - How powerful we are
            - How capable we are
            - How much we have to be proud of
        - In it's place, we see our sinfulness, our inadequacies, our pride
            - This same moment is necessary for every man or woman who would follow Jesus
    - Today we experience this through the power of the Word of God
        - It reveals to us God's glory and power, just as Peter saw it in the person of Jesus
            - But it must also convicts us of our sin and show us for who we really are
        - And we don't like what we see – that's why it's called conviction – we have been shown how guilty we truly are
            - If a person says they have come to know Jesus – to be a believer

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- But they have never had this experience
    - The experience of becoming aware of their own unrelenting sinfulness,
    - So they have never repented of anything – at least not of what matters
- And until they recognize their true sinful nature and repent of that nature

▪ Then they will never truly received salvation – they are merely playing Christian

- And here's Peter, very aware of his sinfulness and without a solution except to ask for Jesus to leave
    - But as we expect, Jesus offers a better deal
        - Jesus says rather than demand he leaves, He will ask Peter to follow him – to fish for men
    - Christ' offer carried a certain amount of irony
        - Rather than catch live fish in their power so they may die
        - Now they were to fish for spiritually dead men so they may know true life
    - Can you imagine Peter's first thoughts?
        - Here's Jesus - this man of God – did Peter know he was God?
            - Probably not yet, but he certainly knew he held the power of God
        - So here's this man of God with the power of God asking Peter to follow with him
            - And consider that Peter may have just received a small fortune in fish –
                - He was walking away from life at the point where it was at its height in terms of success and blessing
        - Peter must have been astounded at the suggestion – and look how he responded in verse 11

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Luke 5:11 When they had brought their boats to land, they left everything and followed Him.

- I can specifically remember reading the gospels as a young adult and without the benefit of the insight of the Holy Spirit wondering at this very verse
    - It seemed so improbably that men would walk away from their life so easily and so impulsively
        - Did they not give any thought to such a radical decision?
        - How could they leave everything so easily?
            - Wouldn't a decision of such magnitude deserve at least a modicum of thought and consideration
            - Wouldn't the responsible thing be to at least give such a radical change some careful thought
        - After all it was Jesus Himself who also said

Luke 14:28 "For which one of you, when he wants to build a tower, does not first sit down and calculate the cost to see if he has enough to complete it?
Luke 14:29 "Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is not able to finish, all who observe it begin to ridicule him,
Luke 14:30 saying, 'This man began to build and was not able to finish.'

    - So shouldn't these fishermen have counted the cost before choosing to join Christ
        - The answer is they did
            - These men had seen and heard from Jesus back in Peter's house
            - They knew he was more than a mere man
            - They knew his power
            - And they counted the cost
        - Jesus goes on to add in Luke 14 this comment:

Luke 14:33 "So then, none of you can be My disciple who does not give up all his own possessions.

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- These men did exactly as Christ said would be required for a true follower
    - Their repentance is illustrated by their wiliness to turn from everything they valued in their life
        - And their faith is demonstrated by their willingness to follow Jesus as He asked them to do
    - Our following of Christ truly demands nothing less
        - In our culture there is probably nothing more difficult than leaving behind all our wealth and security for the sake of obeying Christ
- But if your life still feels like the a struggle for holiness, a struggle to overcome sin
    - If you can't find the comfort and peace Christ promises to those who know Him
        - If you begin to wonder if the Christian walk is merely slogans and false testimonies
    - Then perhaps you are still living the life of a fisherman
        - And that life provided some measure of comfort before Christ stepped into your boat
    - But after he's come and delivered his message to your heart,
        - You resisted leaving your boat and nets behind when He asked you to follow
        - You call yourself a disciple but there you are still fishing in your own power
    - Why not try what Peter did, as radical as it sounds
        - Leave behind the life you had when He found you and walk with him side by side
    - What does that look like for you?...it's different for each according to God's direction..

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Luke 5B

Luke 5:12 ¶ While He was in one of the cities, behold, *there was* a man covered with leprosy; and when he saw Jesus, he fell on his face and implored Him, saying, "Lord, if You are willing, You can make me clean."
Luke 5:13 And He stretched out His hand and touched him, saying, "I am willing; be cleansed." And immediately the leprosy left him.
Luke 5:14 And He ordered him to tell no one, "But go and show yourself to the priest and make an offering for your cleansing, just as Moses commanded, as a testimony to them."
Luke 5:15 But the news about Him was spreading even farther, and large crowds were gathering to hear *Him* and to be healed of their sicknesses.
Luke 5:16 But Jesus Himself would *often* slip away to the wilderness and pray.

- Collecting disciples in the early stage of his ministry
    - Moving throughout Galilee, always with a crowd
        - Still declaring the kingdom of God
        - Teaching with authority, in new ways
    - Healing within the crowd, as a demonstration of his power and authority
        - Also a reflection of his compassion
        - He comes to heal, yes
            - But the more important kind of healing is spiritual
        - Physical healing is a picture of that healing

- Teaches in cities and small towns and along the highway
    - More people in the cities, so that's where he goes
        - The healing ministry has the potential to overshadow his teaching ministry
    - When he enters a city, his presence stirs up the crowd and attracts interest, primarily for healing
        - Crowds would press in close

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        - But Jesus doesn't heal every last person
            - Because the healing is a means to an end
            - The end was to substantiate his claims as Messiah

- Leprosy
    - Widely misunderstood disease, even today
        - Infects 1,400 people daily worldwide
        - Bacteria, infects the entire body
        - It prefers to grow in the cooler parts of the body
            - Extremities, like fingers, toes, noses
        - It grows slowly in the tissues of the body
    - And as it grows it removes the pigment from the skin, turning it white
        - And it slowly destroys nerve endings, so that the parts of the body where it grows eventually become numb
    - It's difficult to catch
        - Roughly 95% of all people are natural immune
        - If you are exposed, it takes 8-10 years before symptoms are evident
            - Probably transferred by nasal droplets – sneezing, coughing
            - Can't be caught by touching or other physical contacts
    - The big problem with leprosy is the numbness
        - It's permanent
        - So as extremities lose their feeling, injuries cause damage to the extremities, and infections destroy the flesh, wearing it away
        - The growing damage to the body and the resulting infections eventually lead to more serious infections and death
    - Today it's easily treated with antibiotics

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        - After a few days, you're no longer contagious & can be healed in 2 years
        - Damage to the body is permanent
    - There was tremendous fear about this disease and stigma attached to the disease
- Lev 13 provides an entire chapter describes how lepers were to be treated in Jewish society
    - The emphasis in this chapter is whether a leper would be clean or unclean
        - Not all lepers were unclean
        - It depended on the state of the disease
            - You could go into remission
            - Then you were not unclean
        - The priests were the ones required to determine if a leper was clean or unclean
    - Lepers were typically treated cruelly
        - Even if they were clean for a time, they would still often be shunned by society
        - They lived a solitary life in many cases, very sad existence
        - They could be severely beaten or even stoned if they failed to keep their distance as required
    - In fact, in Jesus' day (and still today) leprosy was seen as God's judgment on a person for some secret or hidden sin
        - Obviously, e shouldn't see leprosy as a specific judgment by God,
        - They are under no greater condemnation than any other sinnwe
        - But it is true that the disease is used throughout scripture as a picture of sin and its effect on us
- Leprosy and sin are both more than skin deep

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- It impacts the entire body
    - Sin is a part of our flesh, not just a momentary decision
- Leprosy causes a separation for lepers because they defile everything they touch
    - Likewise, sin defiles and those who have sin are separated from fellowship with God
- Leprosy turns the body white over time, even leading to the point when the entire body is white
    - Periods of white skin are typically associated with periods of remission
    - Likewise, we say that when we have been forgiven, our sins are washed clean, washed white
- But ultimately, neither leprosy nor sin can be washed away simply by an external cleaning
    - Eventually, the leprosy leaves remission and becomes active again, causing further destruction of the body until it is destroyed
    - Likewise, anything we might do externally to address the problem of sin is temporary at best
- In the end, sin continues to infect and destroy the body
    - The only solution for either disease is found internally
    - The final answer for sin is an internal cleansing of the spirit that only God can accomplish in us
- And while today, we have antibiotics to cure the disease on the inside of our body,
    - In Jesus day the symbolism was even clearer, since the only hope for a cure of leprosy was also a miracle done by God
    - There was no human solution for the disease
- Finally, when a leper died, his body was burned and even his clothes and personal belongings were burned, in the hope of purifying them from the disease

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        - Similarly, if the body dies in sin, it will face the burning of God's judgment fire

- In the account, the leper falls to his face and declares that Jesus could heal if he wanted to do it
    - The leper's tactic here is easy to appreciate
        - Lots of sick people, trying to compete for Jesus' attention in the hope of healing
        - Like the people that greet you as you leave a cruise ship
        - They must have been doing anything they could to get Jesus' attention
            - He is an advanced stage of leprosy
            - It's all over him
            - Has deformities
    - He throws himself in front of Jesus, he clears the crowd
        - He uses his sad and frightening state to gain an audience with Jesus
        - He almost dares Jesus to heal him
            - He says, if Jesus wants to do it, He can heal him
    - The statement conveys a degree of faith
        - It acknowledges that Jesus had the power to heal, and that power was limited only by God's will
        - And therefore, the statement implies a belief that Jesus was God Himself
            - Because only God can heal according to His will
    - And in this statement, we have the simplest and clearest statement of Biblical truth concerning God's healing ministry
        - God can heal us at any time if He desires to do so

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- Sometimes God chooses to heal us, and sometimes He doesn't choose to heal us

- The fact that God sometimes answers no to our requests for healings is proof in itself that God does not desire that we always be healed
    - Why?
        - Some people live lifetimes in suffering from disease
            - Many people eventually succumb to some illness and die as a result
            - And then on other occasions, God may choose to heal us of an ailment
        - Often the healing comes through natural means, like medicine, a doctor or our own immune system
        - Other times God will heal supernaturally, where no natural explanation exists for the healing
    - But even in those circumstances where God permits healing, it doesn't change the ultimate reality that in the end, we all die of something
        - Something is going to take the life of our body
            - Maybe some other disease, maybe the same disease will return
            - Maybe we will die of an accident
        - The manner of death is irrelevant
            - The point is, our body is not supposed to live forever
            - God intends to replace it one day
        - And before he can give us a new body, he must do away with the old, either through death or the rapture itself
    - This fact alone means that should we ask God to heal us, as this man asks Jesus,
        - And should God choose to honor that request and grant us healing, His purpose in healing us can never be simply for the purpose of preserving our body

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- Since He intends to put it in the grave sooner or later, it stands to reason that preserving the body can never be an end in itself for God
    - Why heal you of pneumonia if He knows you will die of cancer 5 years later
    - Why heal you of cancer if he knows you will be hit by a bus next month
    - Why save you from the hurricane if He knows the rapture is coming next week?
- The only answer to that question is that God receives glory in some way by preserving your body in the short term
    - Perhaps he gains glory simply through the display of his might by the healing itself
    - Perhaps he gains glory because our preservation gives us opportunity to praise his name to others
    - Perhaps he gains glory because through our preservation, we have opportunity to raise godly children who serve him and glorify him
    - Perhaps he preserves us so that we might serve Him and his kingdom is some new way
- But the flip side of this truth is that God has no reason to preserve an otherwise dying body merely for the purpose of allowing us a few more years of selfish living
    - Simply because we fear death, a fear that no mature Christian should ever entertain
    - Simply because we long to accomplish some personal goal or experience some earthly pleasure

o So when we ask God to heal us, we must understand, that sooner or later the answer must be no

- If we hear teaching that tries to tell us that God will heal us anytime we ask so long as we are faithful enough or believing enough

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- That kind of teaching is self-evidently wrong

- We can never use a litmus test to measure God's willingness to heal us

  - For example, if someone teaches that God will heal us upon request as long as our faith is strong enough

  - And assuming that person asks for healing and receives it, what would that same teaching say when the person eventually succumbs to some kind of illness and dies, as they must one day do?

  - What do we say then? Do we say their faith ran out? Too bad they didn't keep their faith up, or God would have healed them again?

    - It's pure nonsense

    - You can't say that God's willingness to heal us has anything to do with whether we deserve it or earn it in any sense

- The only measure of whether God will heal us is His will and purpose in the healing

  - And it is true that long life is often spoken in scripture as a blessing from God, and that it is

  - But it is not the chief measure of God's pleasure in us nor his blessing upon us

- And I can offer you no great proof of this fact than to simply remind you of how brief our Lord's life was on earth, barely more than 30 years

  - Yet we know how very pleased the Father was with His son

  - So a short earthly life is not necessarily a life with less blessing nor offering less pleasure to God

    - Our days are numbered according to His will

    - For that matter, neither is a life free of illness or hardship a measure of God's happiness in us

- The apostles, the martyrs are testimony to the fact that God may bring hardship to his children, even as they seek to do His will

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- Jesus says I am willing, and stretches out his hand and heals the man
    - Then Jesus gives him some odd instructions
        - He says don't tell anyone that I healed you
        - Instead, present yourself to the priests at the temple with your offering
    - Why did Jesus tell the man to do this? Lev 13
        - Lev 13 is an exhaustive description of rules and regulations for how lepers were to live within society
        - It included instructions on how a leper might gain a declaration of cleanliness from the priests
            - The priests were to follow the steps in Lev to determine if a man was clean or unclean
        - And the instructions that Jesus gives this man were according to the requirements of Lev 13
            - This is why Jesus says do this as Moses commanded
            - And do it as a testimony to them, the priests
            - He wanted them to visit the priests and receive the judgment of the priests concerning their clean condition
    - What's going on here?
        - The Law in Lev 13 provided for how a Jew should be declared cured of leprosy
            - But up to the time of Jesus, no Jew had ever been cured of leprosy
            - The provisions of Lev for declaring a man cured of leprosy had never been used
        - Therefore, a Jewish teaching had taken hold that said only the Messiah would be able to cure a leper
    - In fact, there were three kinds of miracles that were uniquely attributed to the Messiah

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- One was healing a leper
- The other was casting a demon out from a mute man
- The third is healing a man born blind, John 9

- These miracles were uniquely miracles that proved the person was the Messiah
  - So as Jesus heals this man, he sends him to the priests as a testimony that the Messiah had arrived
    - This would have resulted in the Jewish leaders sending men to investigate the situation and declare if the Messiah had actually arrived

- But even before that can begin, notice that Jesus said this man was not to speak of his experience except to the priests
  - In Mark's account we hear how the man disobeyed Jesus' instructions

Mark 1:44 and He *said to him, "See that you say nothing to anyone; but go, show yourself to the priest and offer for your cleansing what Moses commanded, as a testimony to them."
Mark 1:45 But he went out and began to proclaim it freely and to spread the news around, to such an extent that Jesus could no longer publicly enter a city, but stayed out in unpopulated areas; and they were coming to Him from everywhere.

- Jesus asks this man to not sensationalize the event by declaring it in the wrong way
  - The problem was the man's report didn't communicate the full meaning and truth of the experience
    - The man declared that he had been healed by Jesus
    - This declaration brought great interest and attention
  - But the declaration he should have brought was that the Messiah had arrived
    - His message emphasized the way Jesus had cured his physical ailment
    - But it was missing the most important point, that Jesus was God living among us

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- What a powerful example of the danger of spreading a trivialized gospel…

- Now we can see the impact of this trivialized message
  - It leads to more and more crowds, but they follow Jesus for the wrong reason
    - And their determination to receive healing actually stand in the way of Jesus' teaching ministry
      - He must often retreat from cities and stay in more secluded areas
      - And he must seek seclusion from time to time
    - The message of his true ministry is drowned out by the self-seeking hordes

Luke 5:17 ¶ One day He was teaching; and there were *some* Pharisees and teachers of the law sitting *there*, who had come from every village of Galilee and Judea and *from* Jerusalem; and the power of the Lord was *present* for Him to perform healing.
Luke 5:18 And *some* men *were* carrying on a bed a man who was paralyzed; and they were trying to bring him in and to set him down in front of Him.
Luke 5:19 But not finding any *way* to bring him in because of the crowd, they went up on the roof and let him down through the tiles with his stretcher, into the middle *of the crowd*, in front of Jesus.
Luke 5:20 Seeing their faith, He said, "Friend, your sins are forgiven you."

- In Mark's account, we hear that this scene takes place Capernaum
  - The homes of that day often included a center area like a courtyard
    - Where the roof opened up to allow light into the center of the home
  - Jesus was probably in the home with a crowd in the courtyard
    - The men lower their friend into the courtyard
    - Trying to drop him directly in front of Jesus
  - The religious leaders of Israel had come up from Jerusalem to investigate the possibility that Jesus was the Messiah
    - Based on the healing of the leper as well as the rest of the Jesus' healings

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- The Pharisees were the conservative keepers of the Law in their day
    - Also present were the scribes, who had the duty of interpreting the law
    - The judges of the law
        - The first scribe was Ezra
    - Also Sadducees and Sanhedrin members
    - They were held in esteem by the people, though they weren't entirely appreciated
- So, here's a man who find himself in front of Jesus
    - And of course, his interest is to be healed
        - No one could help but notice that he was paralyzed
            - He wanted to be healed
        - Perhaps Jesus was teaching and as he's talking, the man is lowered in front of his face
    - Everything stops
        - Jesus witnesses their faith made evident by their bold act
        - And He also knows that the religious leaders are watching
- These are the men who have traveled to validate the claims reported by the leper
    - Jesus is healing lepers
        - He is doing the Messianic miracles
        - Perhaps the Messiah has arrived
    - But naturally, the leadership are skeptical
        - So they watch this scene unfold
        - And Jesus knowing they are watching says, you are healed?
            - No, He says your sins are forgiven
    - Do you think that's what the man wanted to hear

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- I doubt it
- But even more important, it's not what the Pharisees expected to hear
  - And these words were spoken for their benefit

Luke 5:21 The scribes and the Pharisees began to reason, saying, "Who is this *man* who speaks blasphemies? Who can forgive sins, but God alone?"
Luke 5:22 But Jesus, aware of their reasonings, answered and said to them, "Why are you reasoning in your hearts?
Luke 5:23 "Which is easier, to say, 'Your sins have been forgiven you,' or to say, 'Get up and walk'?
Luke 5:24 "But, so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins,"—He said to the paralytic—"I say to you, get up, and pick up your stretcher and go home."
Luke 5:25 Immediately he got up before them, and picked up what he had been lying on, and went home glorifying God.
Luke 5:26 They were all struck with astonishment and *began* glorifying God; and they were filled with fear, saying, "We have seen remarkable things today."

- The Pharisees take the bait
  - They begin to grumble again
    - They said only God can forgive sins
      - So either this man is blaspheming or he is God
  - This is exactly the observation that Jesus intended the leaders to make
    - He was either God or a fake
      - Like CS Lewis famously said: Liar Lunatic or Lord
  - The trap having been set, now Jesus closes in
    - He knew what they were speaking in their hearts, which must have been a real shock of course
    - He says what's easier, saying your sins are forgiven or telling a lame man get up and walk?
  - What he means of course, is that if I say your sins are forgiven, there is no way to prove my statement false

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        - You can't expose me as a fraud because we have no way to investigate the truth of that claim
        - Therefore, it's easy to say your sins are forgiven
    - But if someone says they can heal a lame man, it's a mush more difficult statement
        - Because it can be easily verified
        - You can't fake that one very easily
- So Jesus says, so that you know that I can forgive sins, I will also tell this man to walk
    - So that when I say the harder thing and prove my power in his healing
    - Then you will also know that I can be trusted when I say the easier thing, your sins have been forgiven
        - Jesus was setting up a proof for his claim as Messiah to impress the leadership
        - Though he could have healed the man first, he elected to save it for last so he could use the circumstance to His advantage in contending with the leaders of Israel
- Consider the people's reaction
    - The man healed praised God
    - The people were struck with astonishment and were filled with fear
        - We may see God do great things in our lives too
            - But it his willingness to forgive our sin which is the true miracle
            - Let's be sure that our interest in healing or other earthly needs never overshadow our thankfulness for his mercy

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Luke 5C

- Jesus is no longer an unknown quantity, and he has begun to make powerful enemies
    - The study of Jesus' ministry and the opposition provided by the religious leaders of the day is a focal point for Luke over the next several chapters
    - And it will be for us as well
        - This contrast offers us among other things the opportunity to understand better the difference between the bitterness of works verses joy of grace
        - Between restitution verses forgiveness
        - Between religion verses relationship
- Even as Jesus contends with the religious leaders and reveals them as the hypocrites they were,
    - He is also ministering to the lost and revealing the love of God to them

Luke 5:27 ¶ After that He went out and noticed a tax collector named Levi sitting in the tax booth, and He said to him, "Follow Me."
Luke 5:28 And he left everything behind, and got up and *began* to follow Him.

- In this day, the Roman Empire had made Judea a province subject to Roman rule
    - The key was money – the ability to tax
    - Just like the British in the American colonies
    - And the Roman's hired natives to perform the business of tax collecting
        - Taxes were often unspecified
        - Only the amount the collector must turn in would be set
        - Collectors could often collect anything they wanted and for anything they wanted

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- The booth here is likely a roadside stand
- Assess taxes on passing carts of goods
- Probably the main road between Hazor & Damascus
- Levy taxes on the goods, the animal, the cart itself, the wheels of the cart, etc.

- They had the backing of the Roman army to support their demands of the people

- Obviously tax collectors would not be well-liked
  - They were Jews who had sold out in the eyes of fellow Jews
  - In fact, they often had no friends or acquaintances other than other tax collectors
- But they were also often wealthy since they had ample opportunity to extort money while collecting the taxes

- Here we find Levi – or as he will be known after this point: Matthew
  - He's in his tax booth, and Jesus walks by
  - The scripture records only a brief exchange with Levi
    - Jesus stops at the booth and invites Levi to follow him
    - In the next verse we're told, he got up and left everything behind
      - Matthew is leaving behind his profession, he is walking away from his role as tax collector
      - And he is assuming a new role as Jesus' disciple, which means pupil, student
- Really, this isn't all that surprising if you consider Jesus' rising fame
  - The tax collector must have been flabbergasted that Jesus even stopped at his booth
    - Jesus was a rock star, the famous and mysterious prophet
    - And as a teacher, a rabbi, it was natural and expected that he would collect to himself disciples that He will instruct

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- Matthew must have been stunned that Jesus selected him of all people
- Perhaps that made his decision to follow easier in some way

- But I also believe that there is another reason Matthew left everything so easily – perhaps a reason we can all identify with a little
  - We've already said, Matthew was a hated man, a turncoat, a traitor
  - And ever since he had taken this role he had faced the contempt of everyone he knew
  - It's like he responded by increasing his tax demands, as a kind of retribution for their hatred
- And we can easily imagine what this spiral of hatred would have done to Matthew's reputation and social life
  - And even though he had become rich, he was empty
    - None of the money has satisfied, none of the power
    - He wasn't happy, and he wasn't fulfilled
  - And he knew that simply pursuing more of the things he had already pursued wasn't bringing him any closer to what he wished for
    - And I believe he may have even hated himself for who he had become
    - A Jewish traitor
    - A pariah among his own people
- He knew he was a disgrace, and yet he was trapped
  - He's got no future other than the one he's set for himself
    - Have you ever felt that way?
    - You regret some past decision(s) that have created your present circumstances,

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- And yet there seems no going back, no escape

- Then along comes a solution, so freeing, yet so radical it takes your breath away
    - Just walk away from it all
        - But not in defeat, not succumbing to your own sin and mistakes
        - But walk away to start again, a new way that leaves behind the old self
    - That must have been Matthew's perspective
        - The hope and rescue he never imagined could be possible
        - And Jesus made a way with one simple phrase…come follow me
    - And Jesus embraced Matthew, accepted him, and then directed him toward a new life
        - It was truly a new beginning

- And so do we
    - When Christ calls us out of the sad purposeless life we're leading and gives us a new calling, he says the same thing to us
        - You can forget who you were, your mistakes and the life they created
        - You are forgiven for what you've done – and what you will do
        - And so free of worry and condemnation, we direcet our full attention to becoming a pupil of our master
    - And we begin to learn a new life

- Wouldn't be a shame to hear Jesus call and experience that new start, but then choose to leave a life that looks exactly the same
    - It's as if we are Matthew and we hear Jesus offer and we agree to become his students
        - But we decide to stay in the toll booth and try to learn what we can by correspondence course

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- For Matthew the change meant leaving behind a profession of shame, of dishonesty and oppression
  - So that he become a man who collected new believers rather than money
  - A man who recorded one of the Gospels
- Who can imagine what God is prepared to do with each of us when we agree to leave behind our own life and seek to be His pupil
  - I can't say what God is prepared to do with each of you,
  - But one thing is for sure, we're not supposed to stay in that booth

- Look at Matthew's response to Jesus' invitation

Luke 5:29 ¶ And Levi gave a big reception for Him in his house; and there was a great crowd of tax collectors and other *people* who were reclining *at the table* with them.
Luke 5:30 The Pharisees and their scribes *began* grumbling at His disciples, saying, "Why do you eat and drink with the tax collectors and sinners?"
Luke 5:31 And Jesus answered and said to them, "*It is* not those who are well who need a physician, but those who are sick.
Luke 5:32 "I have not come to call the righteous but sinners to repentance."

- So what does someone do after he quits his job? He holds a party for all his friends
  - That's what Matthew does
    - Matthew holds a party in honor of Jesus,
    - From the short description of the event, we see confirmation that Matthew is as wealthy as we expected
  - We also notice that most of the crowd were other tax collectors, though there were others who come for the festivities
  - In fact, it seems to be an open invitation for anyone to come
    - The word for reception can also mean feast or a welcoming celebration
    - This is something that everyone could attend to welcome Jesus

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        - And even the Pharisees showed up

    - Together with the scribes they comment about Jesus' willingness to be seen with these people

        - The Pharisees are grumbling, we're told

        - The word in Greek literally means buzzing as bees

        - And they called the crowd tax collectors and sinners

            - Truly, they saw these groups as one and the same of course

            - And sinner here means specifically one who would not live under the Mosaic law

            - All men sin, but these were people who refused to atone for sin by living under the law, and even worse, they flaunted their unreligious lifestyle

- So the Pharisees approach not Jesus – but instead the disciples (verse 30)

    - Interesting isn't it that the Pharisees aren't willing to confront Jesus but instead are trying to influence his students concerning righteousness

        - Listening to them, what would you suppose they would want to see happen here?

    - Obviously, Jesus shouldn't go anywhere near this crowd

        - Instead, Jesus should condemn the unrighteous living of the tax collectors and their friends

        - Then Jesus should demand that the crowd go back to the temple and perform the ritual sacrifices required

        - They should pay retribution, return their money, pledge to stop collecting taxes, etc.

    - Then if they do all these things, the Pharisees might permit the crowd an audience with Jesus in a synagogue

        - But they would have to remain at the back of the congregation reflecting their lowly status

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- Why all this?
    - Because the Pharisees are far more interested in protecting a system of rules and prohibitions than in rehabilitate sinners
        - In fact, their particular adherences to the law was designed to limit who could be seen as righteous rather than open the doors wide
    - To be sure, God's law is not the problem here. It is perfect and holy
        - The problem was how the Pharisees in their unbelief misused it
        - These were evil, unbelieving hypocritical men who served themselves not God
            - And they fought with Jesus to protect a system rather than to seek truth
    - This is the pattern for all men who present themselves as holy but lack true faith
        - They always come with rules and regulations, prohibitions and restrictions
        - And they use the rules to control men and to strengthen their own position
        - And since the Pharisees hadn't yet figured out a way to bring down this prophet who was teaching this new, threatening viewpoint against their leadership
            - They do the next best thing: they seek to nullify His impact by peeling off His students, His disciples
    - And this spirit continues even today, among those who prosecute the fight by warring for your mind, for your belief in what is required by God
        - What is pleasing to God
- In this exchange, the Pharisees urge Jesus' disciples to refrain from associated with sinners
    - Their purpose is as easy to understand as it is repugnant
        - The Pharisees want the disciples to enforce a kind of public sentence of disgrace against these men

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- They were sinners and they needed to feel the scorn and displeasure of the righteous within society
    - How dare the disciples show their approval of these men by honoring them with their presence
- If these men wanted to be accepted within society, then they first needed to come to grips with their sin
    - In effect, the Pharisees wanted these men to take steps toward becoming righteous before they could be worthy of receiving the attention of good men like the Pharisees or disciples

- As usual, the unrighteous completely misunderstand what righteousness is

- Jesus gives the correct perspective
    - He says the Messiah's very mission is to seek after the unrighteous and call them to repent
        - Like a physician, Jesus is sent for those who are sick than those who are healthy
            - Oh how it would have shocked the Pharisees to know that they were just as sick as these tax collectors
            - They needed a physician every bit as much
    - This is the biggest impediment to any unbeliever coming to faith and receiving grace
        - They are convinced they are healthy
        - They aren't sick, and therefore they don't need a physician
            - They are just like these Pharisees
        - Their prideful self-righteousness was their own downfall
    - Secondly, Jesus points out the obvious
        - A physician has to make house calls to the sick people if you hope to have any chance to heal them
        - Jesus is celebrating with them, not lecturing them

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- In other words, He's living with them without condoning their sin nor participating in it
  - But still He's with them
  - Giving them the opportunity to see His wisdom and the truth of his words
- We can't all be like Jesus in our ability to heal, but we have the master's medicine - the truth of the gospel shared with those who welcome us

- Take note of the contrast Luke is building here
  - These men of the law are upset at anything that breaks convention
    - They seek retribution, penance and revenge rather than healing
    - In fact, in Matthew's own account of this scene, he records Jesus quoting from Hosea saying:

Matt. 9:13 "But go and learn what this means: 'I DESIRE COMPASSION, AND NOT SACRIFICE,' for I did not come to call the righteous, but sinners."

  - The law revealed sin, but it offered no solution for it other than condemnation – which is no solution at all
    - The more we understand that the more we look to God to provide a solution – as Paul calls it, a schoolmaster to drive us to Christ
    - And the Pharisees are intent on using the law in a false way –
      - On the one hand, to grant themselves a kind of self-made righteousness according to their ability to keep the law
      - And on the other hand, as a noose to tie around the necks of the people to forever keep them under a sentence of condemnation, as a form of leverage over the people

- Then Jesus walks onto the scene and begins acting as if the law isn't going to be good enough to make these people righteous
  - And that's exactly what he's saying to them and to us
  - Look at the next series of verses

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Luke 5:33 ¶ And they said to Him, "The disciples of John often fast and offer prayers, the *disciples* of the Pharisees also do the same, but Yours eat and drink."
Luke 5:34 And Jesus said to them, "You cannot make the attendants of the bridegroom fast while the bridegroom is with them, can you?
Luke 5:35 "But *the* days will come; and when the bridegroom is taken away from them, then they will fast in those days."
Luke 5:36 And He was also telling them a parable: "No one tears a piece of cloth from a new garment and puts it on an old garment; otherwise he will both tear the new, and the piece from the new will not match the old.
Luke 5:37 "And no one puts new wine into old wineskins; otherwise the new wine will burst the skins and it will be spilled out, and the skins will be ruined.
Luke 5:38 "But new wine must be put into fresh wineskins.
Luke 5:39 "And no one, after drinking old *wine* wishes for new; for he says, 'The old is good *enough*.'"

- In response to Jesus declaring that he was right to mix with these people, the Pharisees try to point to Jesus' own failings with respect to righteousness and propriety
    - They make mention of how his disciples did not fast regularly like other disciples of teachers
    - And interestingly, they use John the Baptist as the example
        - They could have used virtually any teacher of the day or even themselves as examples, because fasting was a common practice for Jewish students
    - In the life of a Jew, everyday brought trials and difficulties
        - The burdens of their life were difficult for us to appreciate today
        - The law and the societal customs had been piled upon one another to make living in the Jewish culture a very difficult and weary existence
            - In the case of fasting, fasting from sun up to sundown occurred frequently (usually twice each week) for every good religious Jew
            - This was on top of regular prayer intervals, temple sacrifices, synogogue worship, and regular work

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- In fact, one of the reasons a Jewish wedding is such a celebration is that these regular weekly practices were put aside for the week of celebration surrounding the marriage
    - This was one of the few times a young Jew could legally relax with no fasting, rituals, restrictions
    - And not only the bride and bridegroom but their guests were also free from these restrictions during the week-long celebration

- So Jesus uses that analogy to make his point
    - Jesus says you can't make the guests fast during the time they celebrate with their bridegroom
        - We know from scripture that Jesus is called our bridegroom and the Church is His bride collectively
    - And while He is with His disciples, there is only joy and celebration
        - Just as you would expect between a groom and bride
    - But fasting is a restriction upon joy
        - And as such, it is a sign of our waiting for a future time of rejoicing to come
    - So Jesus says that fasting will become part of the experience of Christ's followers once He is gone
        - I can't touch on these verse without making a momentary comment on fasting
        - It seems to me that fasting as a spiritual discipline is virtually lost in the church today
        - Fasting is seen throughout the gospels and the book of Acts, usually accompanying prayer
        - Here we see Jesus himself mentioning it's necessity importance
        - Why would denying ourselves food have spiritual significance?

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- The simplest answer is it's not the food that matters, but the denying of self and of joy itself that reflects both a willingness to submit to God and to wait for Him
    - It's a discipline of submission because it's the clearest way to connect our will to our flesh – to practice the submitting of the flesh to the will rather than the other way around
        - Our hunger is the strongest, ever-present reminder of the strength of our flesh
            - Of it's independent nature and desire
            - Of how it can control us even though it doesn't involve rational thought
            - Of how we can be forced to do things by it we don't desire
        - And if you practice the discipline of fasting regularly, denying yourself in a meaningful way in the area of hunger and food, then your flesh's control over you will slowly give way to your will
            - And the Holy Spirit in you will take ownership of your will, and with your flesh in submission, do great things
    - Secondly, the fasting process reduces joy and increases suffering
        - And we gain a reminder that in this world we are to suffer waiting for his return,
        - And that our suffering can only be fully removed by our joining with Him again
            - And then real joy will return
            - Just as for the guests of the bridegroom
- But as with everything, fasting isn't about us doing anything in our strength
    - Yes, we are trying to deny our flesh as an act of our will, but the strength of do that comes from God
    - Which is why prayer is intimately connected with fasting
        - As you fast, make time to pray

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- And every time hunger pangs tempt you to break your fast, turn that temptation into a moment of prayer, and watch the discipline grow as God strengthens you
- Then the next time you face a situation where you can't resist temptation, you can draw upon your discipline in fasting to know how reliance on God can address every temptation

- The Pharisees chastise Jesus for not requiring his disciples to fast more because for the Pharisees, the sacrifice of fasting was the means to holiness
  - They wanted to see suffering and sacrifice, and that by those things, men were made holy
  - But Christ says no, they are merely signs of waiting for God and submission to Him in the meantime
  - The real holiness, the true religion, is something altogether different

- Next week we will address the second part of these verses to complete the picture Jesus is drawing
  - And as we move toward the next ten chapters of Luke,
    - beginning in 6 with more arguments with the Pharisees
    - culminating with the three parables in Luke 15 and the prodigal son,
  - Luke builds the complete picture of the faith Jesus brings and how it brings life where the religion of that day brought only death and hardship

- How are we doing on this test, I wonder?
  - Do we represent our faith as joy or penance?
  - As freedom from restrictions that have no connection to righteousness or a lifestyle of burden and restrictions?

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- Obviously, a life of faith brings with it the desire to life in a way that pleases God,
- But do we see ourselves as rule enforcers making sure others always stay within the lines?
- Or do we see ourselves as rule breakers in need of God's grace everyday?
    - We know there is a place for exhortation and even rebuke in the face of unrepentant sin within the Body of Christ
    - But for every opportunity like that, we have 100 where we can show grace and be long suffering and patience and forgiving and loving with one another

- And what does the unbelieving world see in each of us?
    - Are we like the Pharisees at times? More interested in enforcing the rules than being the physician
    - More interested in making people pay their due sacrifice than in showing compassion
    - Once we understand that all of us have as much sin to answer for as the other
    - and that the solution to a sinful life is not rules set upon us but a law written on our hearts and the Spirit within us and the Word of God before us
    - Then we can become as physicians brings the message of the gospel through the Word of God to those who are sick, and then let the Great healer do the rest – as He has done and is doing for us even now.

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Luke 5D

- In Chap 5 last week, Luke gave us an early look at the conflict that would follow Jesus through out His Ministry
    - Jesus was back in Capernaum teaching the crowds and the Pharisees had begun to take notice of Him, with a suspicious eye
    - In particular, they were troubled by his immense popularity and the power He had gained over the people in such a short time
        - Pharisees we said were religious leaders in their, but in truth they were more properly thought of as religious politicians or powerbrokers
        - They were men whose power and prestige and very livelihood revolved around their control over Jewish society
        - They demanded the respect and obedience of the people
            - And they maintained their control by imposing a system of rules and regulations beyond the Law itself
            - They burdened the people with obligations that they could never meet, but the Pharisees prided themselves on how they had made the most of this system
            - So the last thing the Pharisees wanted to see was someone who presented an alternative to the system that favored the Pharisees
- Consider two of Jesus' teachings from earlier in this chapter
    - First we had the healing of the paralytic
        - Jesus first declared the man forgiven of sins, which offended the Pharisees
        - Jesus declared that God could in fact wipe away the debt that each man carried, the debt of sin
        - Now to be sure, the dilemma for the Pharisees in the moment was trying to discredit Jesus' claim to forgive sins yet being unable to explain away the miraculous healing they had seen

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- But there was an even more serious concern on their minds
    - The Pharisees had based their own power and authority on establishing and enforcing a system of righteousness based on the Law
    - It was based on the Law because it wasn't the law, not exactly
    - The Pharisees had taken the Mosaic law and distorted it, added to it, changed it, all the while making it more burdensome and difficult, as if the Law weren't difficult enough
- And here comes Jesus declaring that God could forgive sins without the necessity of a life of good works
    - Based purely on this man's willingness to appeal to Jesus for mercy and healing, Jesus could grant both physical healing and spiritual healing
    - What would happen if the people accepted this teaching? It would be madness
    - First, people would accept this free offer of forgiveness and then the next you know, they would be dispensing with all the rules and restrictions that the Pharisees had declared were essential to righteousness
    - Nevermind the Pharisees would lose their powerbase, their hold over the people

- Then secondly, Jesus goes to a tax collector, makes him a disciple, a pupil, and then accepts an invitation to feast with the tax collector and his unrighteous friends
    - This offended not only the Pharisees' sensibilities, it also frustrated their means of enforcing control
    - These men Jesus visited were a part of society that had refused to play the game of the Pharisees
        - Either they were prevented from playing, or more likely, they didn't want to have any part in it

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- They lived life as they pleased, without paying attention to Pharisee's rules and restrictions
- And they lived under the protection of the Roman legion, which enabled them to avoid the penalties of the Jewish law

- Now the Pharisees made sure that these outcasts were made pariah's in Jewish society
  - No upstanding Jew would have anything to do with them
  - This was their punishment, and the Pharisees wanted to make sure that these men stood out as examples of what would happen to anyone who didn't live according to the Pharisees rules

- But here again, Jesus comes on the scene, a man of God, a Rabbi, and he eats and drinks with these men and seems to give them approval
  - Talk about upsetting the status quo
  - If the people got the idea that even sinners were worthy of God's mercy, then what would be the incentive to earn God's favor by adhering to rules
  - The Pharisees would have no hope of keeping anyone in line once they got the idea that God would accept men as they were, sin and all

- Which brings us the end of Chap 5 and Jesus first substantial confrontation with the Religious leaders of his day
  - The Pharisees complain how the disciples of Jesus don't respect the customs of the other rabbi's disciples, like fasting
  - They looking for a way to indict and shame Jesus' ministry, hoping to discredit him now before he does anymore harm
  - And these confrontations will continue and grow throughout Jesus ministry, and in Luke's account they will take a recurring role on center stage for the next 10 chapters
  - Through those chapters, Jesus will work the whole time to illustrate the principle He first describes here at the end of Luke 5, at times contending with the disciples and at other times teaching the disciples

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- So, let's look at this principles – the central dispute between the Pharisees and Jesus – as Jesus introduces it Chap 5 verse 36:

Luke 5:36 And He was also telling them a parable: "No one tears a piece of cloth from a new garment and puts it on an old garment; otherwise he will both tear the new, and the piece from the new will not match the old.
Luke 5:37 "And no one puts new wine into old wineskins; otherwise the new wine will burst the skins and it will be spilled out, and the skins will be ruined.
Luke 5:38 "But new wine must be put into fresh wineskins.
Luke 5:39 "And no one, after drinking old *wine* wishes for new; for he says, 'The old is good *enough*.'"

- Jesus answers the Pharisees concerns over the behavior of Jesus disciples with a two-part parable
    - the first parable recorded in Luke
    - And as such, we need to consider it very carefully
    - The parable uses two different subjects to draw a contrast, and as attempt to understand his meaning, we need to take note of how parables typically work
        - A parable uses a common everyday setting or experience, and then draws a parallel to some deeper spiritual issue
        - The idea is really quite simple – if the audience can understand and appreciate the everyday experience , then they'll have a key for understanding the more complex spiritual issue
        - But since we're talking about the Word of God, the process is infinitely more complex than that
            - Before we have the teaching assistance of the HS, we can't see the connect in parables
            - In Matt 13, Just as Jesus answered his disciples when they asked him why he taught in parables, and He said:

Matt. 13:10 ¶ And the disciples came and said to Him, "Why do You speak to them in parables?"
Matt. 13:11 Jesus answered them, "To you it has been granted to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been granted.

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Matt. 13:12 "For whoever has, to him *more* shall be given, and he will have an abundance; but whoever does not have, even what he has shall be taken away from him.
Matt. 13:13 "Therefore I speak to them in parables; because while seeing they do not see, and while hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand.

- The Pharisees and other unbelievers were not granted the possibility of understanding Jesus' teaching in the day of His coming, as a part of God's plan
- So it requires God's allowing us to understand His Word, through the Holy Spirit, before we might understand these hidden mysteries

- So returning to our parable, consider Jesus' comment about the garment
  - He said imagine an old garment, a garment that is worn and falling apart – a pair of jeans, let's say
  - With holes and tears…the jeans can't be used any longer for the purpose for which they were made
    - The jeans should be thrown away
    - But there will be those who would desire to preserve them, to so they could continue using them
  - But if instead of repair the old garment, what if the garment maker provided you a new garment instead – a new pair of jeans
  - Jesus makes the point in the parable that no one who has been given a new garment would think to cut it up and take a piece of it and try to patch the old garment
    - First, taking the patch would completely ruin the new garment
    - Secondly, the patch when placed on the old garment just makes it look even more ridiculous
    - Anyone hearing this parable knows instinctively what should be done,…you throw away the old and start using the new dress
- Before we consider the larger spiritual issue Jesus is describing, let's move to the second comparison Jesus offers in the parable
  - He describes placing wine in wineskins

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- In Jesus day, people didn't have glass bottles to hold wine
- Instead, people used clay pots or jugs to hold wine
- But if you wanted to take wine with you, as you walked on a long journey, clay pots were impractical and too heavy
- So sacks made of animal skins – leather – were used to hold wine
  - When you put wine in a fresh wine sack, the skin is strong and flexible and it can withstand the pressure of the wine
  - Over time the skin weakens and if the wine inside weren't consumed, it would eventually leak out as the skin gave way
  - Since wineskins were used to hold wine for a short time, the wine was usually consumed before the skins gave out
  - But if you took a used wineskin and refilled it with wine, you were asking for trouble, it would almost certainly fail from the pressure
  - Instead, you must choose a new container to hold the new wine – the two containers remain separate

- So Jesus uses this well understood principle as he teaches once again, that it would be foolish to try to take something old and adapt it to a new use
  - Not only does it ruin the new thing – whether jeans or wine
  - But it ruins the old thing as well – they must remain distinct and separate

- So what is Jesus' larger point to the Pharisees and to us?
  - Well, as should be obviously by now, the old religious order of the Pharisees, the Mosaic Law and all the man-made rules that had grown up around it was destined to remain unrepaired, just like that old garment
  - It was to go away just as the old wineskin must be retired when the new wine is ready
  - And as God inaugurated a new covenant, one that brought new life, it must by necessity replace – not repair – the old

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- To the Jewish culture, the Jewish people, especially the Jewish leaders, the natural assumption had always been that the Mosaic covenant was the way to righteousness
- It was the means by which God would save His people
- And when the Messiah would come, naturally his ministry would just fit into the existing system, they assumed
- And of course, the Pharisees were just fine with that – because they were masters of this system
- In fact, they expected to be honored and celebrated by the Messiah as the best that Jewish society had to offer

- Even Christians today can fall back into that thinking from time to time
  - It's very common to hear teaching in the church that says – either by suggestion or directly – that the Law is still in some way a part of our Christian experience
  - The easiest way to see this tendency at work is in how we tend to hedge our bets whenever the question is posed what parts of the Law still apply to a Christian
    - The ones most Christians today will still say are applicable are the ten commandments
    - Some take an even stronger view, stating that the moral law is still in force for Christians, leaving only the sacrificial & ceremonial laws off the table
    - And a few supposed Christians would maintain that the law in its entirety still applies to Christians

- But Jesus argues that the two can never mix
  - If we were to try to place them together in some way, we ruin both
  - God never intended to combined these two vastly different covenants into some patchwork means of obtaining righteousness
  - And other scripture makes this very clear

- In Galatians, Paul uses the analogy of a child to illustrate how one covenant replaces another

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- He says that we are like a child – an orphan who is under a guardian - a tutor , a nanny – waiting for adoption as true sons of God
- But once we receive our adoption, we no longer need the tutor
- Likewise, once the Gospel has been made known and the grace of the new covenant has been revealed, we give no more thought to the Law

Gal. 3:23 ¶ But before faith came, we were kept in custody under the law, being shut up to the faith which was later to be revealed.
Gal. 3:24 Therefore the Law has become our tutor *to lead us* to Christ, so that we may be justified by faith.
Gal. 3:25 But now that faith has come, we are no longer under a tutor.

- In Romans, Paul also compares the transition from old to new using a widow released from marriage vows when her husband dies

Rom. 7:2 For the married woman is bound by law to her husband while he is living; but if her husband dies, she is released from the law concerning the husband.
Rom. 7:3 So then, if while her husband is living she is joined to another man, she shall be called an adulteress; but if her husband dies, she is free from the law, so that she is not an adulteress though she is joined to another man.
Rom. 7:4 ¶ Therefore, my brethren, you also were made to die to the Law through the body of Christ, so that you might be joined to another, to Him who was raised from the dead, in order that we might bear fruit for God.

Rom. 7:6 But now we have been released from the Law, having died to that by which we were bound, so that we serve in newness of the Spirit and not in oldness of the letter.

- Just like a wife who must be released from marriage to her first husband before she can be joined to another, we must be released from the law through death before we are available to be joined to a new covenant
  - Paul also says that like that widow, we have been released from the law by a death
    - But when did we die? If death is the only way to be released from the law, when did we get the chance to die so that we would have the opportunity to accept the new covenant?
    - Paul says we were made to die through the Christ's bodily death on the cross

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- When The Father put His Son to death, he was putting to death the body of all believers who were joined to Christ
- We never personally experienced this death Paul speaks of, because God the Father placed Christ on the cross in our place
- And as Paul says in Rom 7:4, we were joined to Christ, both in death and in new life
- So we have died to the law – it no longer has any relationship to us – no power to condemn us
- And we live in the new life of Christ, bearing fruit for God

- Still, some will not accept this substitution, preferring to stay with the old system
- The Pharisee couldn't get past the very suggestion that their system wasn't good enough – that it needed replacing at all
- And Jesus recognizes this fact about the Pharisees
- Consider how Jesus ends the parable
  - In verse 39, Jesus says that those who have tasted the old won't want the new wine, saying the old is good enough
  - Which wine is considered superior? New wine or old wine? You don't choose the youngest wine you can find
  - Once you've had old wine, you refuse to even consider someone's offer of new wine
    - You won't even try it, usually, because you already believe you know which one is better
    - As it was for the Pharisees, who had come to know and like the system they had – the Law and the pharisitical additions to it
    - This was comfortable and it gave them power
  - And here's Jesus, making subtle suggestions that he has been sent by God and is even to be the Messiah of Israel, yet he contradicts the Pharisees at every opportunity
    - He undermines their authority

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- He challenges their rules
- He doesn't respect their judgments over the people
- It's as if He is dismissing the very Law itself
- So they reject Him and his message without even considering it

- Today we have the opportunity to celebrate an important commandment of our Lord – a baptism of believers
  - We mentioned a moment ago that we have died to the law through Christ's death on the cross
  - And just like Christ we have been resurrected – first the resurrection of a new spirit and ultimately a resurrection into a new body
  - And to recognize that death and resurrection process, Our Lord gave us the practice of baptism
    - All believers are commanded to be baptized, having come to faith we are to show that new life by picturing the death and raising in the form of water baptism
    - Today we baptize Cameron and Moriah
- Before we call Daniel up to close our service today, I would like to pray over the two young people who will be baptized today

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Luke 6A

- In Chap 5, Luke began to show the growing conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders of his day
    - That conflict began essentially with Jesus challenging the Pharisees authority among the people
    - Jesus – and His teaching and healing – grabbed the imagination of the people and the Pharisees immediately recognized the threat He posed to their control and authority
- At the conclusions of Chap 5 Jesus effectively declared their religious system to be worn out and ready for replacement – that the two could never mix
    - So, naturally they have now targeted Him and His ministry, and they have begun – in a very disorganized and almost desperate way – to bring Him down in the eyes of the people
    - Chap 6 continues to show the almost comical way the Pharisees were intent on discrediting Jesus
        - They tried to catch Him violating their religious rules
        - They hadn't noticed that Jesus had already declared that their man-made rules weren't worth following in the first place
        - The Pharisees thought that catching violating their rules would diminish Him in the eyes of the people, but since the people hate the rules too, Jesus gained fame for standing up to the religious leaders

Luke 6:1 ¶ Now it happened that He was passing through *some* grainfields on a Sabbath; and His disciples were picking the heads of grain, rubbing them in their hands, and eating *the grain*.
Luke 6:2 But some of the Pharisees said, "Why do you do what is not lawful on the Sabbath?"
Luke 6:3 And Jesus answering them said, "Have you not even read what David did when he was hungry, he and those who were with him,
Luke 6:4 how he entered the house of God, and took and ate the consecrated bread which is not lawful for any to eat except the priests alone, and gave it to his companions?"
Luke 6:5 And He was saying to them, "The Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath."

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- From the scene Luke and the other gospel writers paint for us, we know Jesus and his 12 apostles were moving from place to place on a Saturday – the Jewish Sabbath
    - Specifically, they were moving through a grain field, likely a barley field, where the grain had grown to waist high and was ready for harvest
    - Obviously the disciples were hungry, so they had began to pluck heads of grain and rub them between their hands to remove the husks and the eat the grain – fast food
    - Under the Jewish Law, it was permissible for a man to remove heads of grain and eat them without being considered a thief

Deut. 23:24 ¶ "When you enter your neighbor's vineyard, then you may eat grapes until you are fully satisfied, but you shall not put any in your basket.
Deut. 23:25 ¶ "When you enter your neighbor's standing grain, then you may pluck the heads with your hand, but you shall not wield a sickle in your neighbor's standing grain.

- The concept expressed here in the law is straightforward enough
    - A man can take a small amount of another man's produce for the benefit of a quick meal, but once he starts collecting the produce in larger quantities, he's stealing
    - The law said nothing however about such an activity being outlawed on the Sabbath – it was never connected to the Sabbath at all
    - That came from the Pharisees
        - Remember I said last week that the Pharisees had taken the law given by God and had made it even more restrictive as a means of controlling and consolidating their power over the people
        - The more restrictive the law became, the more hopeless the people felt
        - The farther they felt from God and the more they looked to their spiritual leaders to rescue them and offer them hope that God would approve their pitiful efforts to keep the law
        - It was control through fear and guilt and it was entirely based on works

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- In this case, the Pharisees consider the apostles taking of the grain as a form of work
    - They consider the gleaning of the heads of grain as harvesting,
        - And they consider the rubbing of the grain in their hands as threshing
        - And they the consider the separating of the husks from the seed as winnowing
        - They considered the eating to be storing grain
    - In other words, the apostles were performing farming on the Sabbath, and that was a violation of the God's command not to do work on the Sabbath

Because of these rules, some Pharisees would not walk on the grass on the Sabbath day. If someone asked such a rabbi, "What is wrong with walking on the grass on the Sabbath day," his answer would be, "Nothing. It is permissible to walk on the grass on the Sabbath day." However, there is a problem. What looks only like a grassy field might have one stalk of wheat growing wild in it. A person walking through the field of grass might inadvertently step on that one stalk of wheat, separate the wheat from its stalk, and become guilty of reaping on the Sabbath day. Furthermore, if his foot came down and twisted the wheat just enough to separate the wheat from the chaff, he would be guilty of threshing on the Sabbath day. If he continued to walk, the outer hem of his garment might cause just enough breeze to blow the chaff away, and he would be guilty of winnowing on the Sabbath day. Finally, once the person had gone, a bird or rodent might see the exposed piece of wheat and swallow it, causing him to be guilty of storing the wheat on the Sabbath day.

    -
    - So the Pharisees try to use that to accuse Jesus
        - Wouldn't you agree that this is – at best – desperate measure?
        - It was in that day even as it would be for us today

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- Before we move on to Jesus response, I want you to consider something important from those first few verses
    - Rules never promote righteousness; they reveal unrighteousness
        - And that's how the Pharisees were using them here
        - The Pharisees were trying to find a way to reveal Jesus' unrighteousness
    - Rules are tools for accusation
        - They can never be a means to making men better
            - The speed limit doesn't make good drives
            - Did the 10 commandments make men holy?
            - To a certain extent, rules restrain sin
            - But sin restrained isn't the same as sin eliminated

Matt. 5:20 ¶ "For I say to you that unless your righteousness surpasses *that* of the scribes and Pharisees, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 5:21 ¶ "You have heard that the ancients were told, 'YOU SHALL NOT COMMIT MURDER' and 'Whoever commits murder shall be liable to the court.'
Matt. 5:22 "But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother shall be guilty before the court;
Matt. 5:27 ¶ "You have heard that it was said, 'YOU SHALL NOT COMMIT ADULTERY';
Matt. 5:28 but I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart.

- The Pharisees took the Law of God and twisted it and added to it so they could find even more ways to examine men's lives looking for sin
    - And they thought that the more rules the more righteousness
        - But in reality, the more rules, the more sin was revealed
    - So ironically, what they thought they were eliminating, they were merely magnifying
        - These rules didn't increase love – love for God or love for men

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        - They don't teach righteousness, forgiveness, mercy, charity or any of the things God says His children should demonstrate
        - And they certainly couldn't make men holy and righteous and perfect before God
    - They could only serve one purpose – to accuse men by
        - To point out mistakes, to bring guilt and judgment
        - And that is always the purpose of rules or laws
        - This is what Paul teaches in Romans 3

Rom. 3:19 ¶ Now we know that whatever the Law says, it speaks to those who are under the Law, so that every mouth may be closed and all the world may become accountable to God;
Rom. 3:20 because by the works of the Law no flesh will be justified in His sight; for through the Law *comes* the knowledge of sin.

- The Law like any other set of rules can never produce righteousness, it merely reveals unrighteousness
    - And the Pharisees are using their rules in the same way here
    - We need to always be careful to ensure that as we set out rules for behavior, we never become tempted to see them as a means to righteousness
        - Rather they merely help remind us of where we are yet still sinful
- But moving on, we understand the first part of the story easily enough, however it's Jesus' response that may cause us to ponder a bit
    - Jesus makes reference to a story involving King David in the temple, a story recorded in 1Sam 21
        - As you might expect, we need to give a moment to understanding Jesus' reference

1Sam. 21:1 ¶ Then David came to Nob to Ahimelech the priest; and Ahimelech came trembling to meet David and said to him, "Why are you alone and no one with you?"
1Sam. 21:2 David said to Ahimelech the priest, "The king has commissioned me with a matter and has said to me, 'Let no one know anything about the matter on which I am sending you and with which I have commissioned you; and I have directed the young men to a certain place.'

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1Sam. 21:3 "Now therefore, what do you have on hand? Give me five loaves of bread, or whatever can be found."
1Sam. 21:4 The priest answered David and said, "There is no ordinary bread on hand, but there is consecrated bread; if only the young men have kept themselves from women."
1Sam. 21:5 David answered the priest and said to him, "Surely women have been kept from us as previously when I set out and the vessels of the young men were holy, though it was an ordinary journey; how much more then today will their vessels *be holy*?"
1Sam. 21:6 So the priest gave him consecrated *bread*; for there was no bread there but the bread of the Presence which was removed from before the LORD, in order to put hot bread *in its place* when it was taken away.

- David has been anointed by the prophet Samuel as the next king, but the current King Saul is trying to kill David to prevent him from taking Saul's throne
    - David is the captain of Saul's army,
        - Arrives at the tabernacle with a few of his men
            - Tells the priest that he is on a mission from the king
            - Saul sent "troops" elsewhere
        - A lie. The king didn't send him…He's running from the king,
            - David often had trouble with the truth
        - David has come for refuge and to obtain provisions
    - He asks the priest for food for him
        - The priest says that all that was available was the showbread
            - Showbread was set out by the priests once a week on Sabbath
            - It remained there until it was replaced, then the priests ate it
- So David asks for the bread to eat
    - This was not an option according to the Pharisees' rules
        - The Law didn't prohibit it though,

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- The only thing the priest was concerned with was whether the men had been with women, which would have made them ritually unclean
- David assures the priests that the men were holy today, not defiled

- So the priest allows them to eat the bread
  - Jesus uses this situation to draw an analogy to His own actions
- Consider David's situation
  - He was trying to honor God's anointed even as he was being persecuted by him
  - He was running to save his life
  - He had needs and he came to the priests for sanctuary, to satisfy his hunger
- Now the priest had a choice:
  - The law didn't prohibit giving the bread, though the leader's rules did
    - But the account in 1Samuel never condemns the priests actions, as Jesus says
  - Obviously, his compassion for David was the right thing to do, despite the man-made rules to the contrary
  - Rather than observe man's precepts, the priests honored God's anointed king
    - The priest was showing his love for God and his neighbor by honoring the Lord's anointed, even if it meant dispensing with man-made rules

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- If we defining godliness in terms of hard fast rules, we inevitably lose our focus on what it means to follow Christ
    - We aren't called to follow laws, but rather a law giver
        - Who has written His laws on our hearts
        - For where a law will fail, the Spirit will not
    - In fact, sometimes showing love and obedience to the God requires that we ignore some man-made rules in favor of the higher commandments of loving God and our neighbor
- We do this today
    - For example, if we were walking down a street and came upon a house that was on fire, flames coming out of the roof at one end of the house
        - We run up to the opposite end of the house and look in the windows
        - Amid the smoke we make out the shape of a baby laying in a crib crying
            - Immediately, we pick up a rock and throw it through the window, breaking out the glass
            - We enter the house, take the baby and rescuing it from the flames
            - The baby is having trouble breathing so we take it to the hospital
- Technically, we have violated at least three serious laws
    - We have commitment vandalism
    - We have committed breaking and entering
    - And we have committed kidnapping
    - But no prosecutor in the world would press those charges against us because the greater good of saving the baby's life would have justified our actions under the law

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- The law was intended to ensure that citizens demonstrate considerate and respectful behavior among each other, looking out for the common good –
  - so the end was the common good, and the means to that end is out laws
  - But when we find that achieving the common good (like saving the baby) requires that we go against the means that were set forth to achieve that end, we are justified by the law

- And it is the same for God's law
  - Consider this example from the history of Israel in 2Chron 30
  - The King of Israel, Hezekiah, was trying to reunite the Northern kingdom of Israel with the Southern Kingdom of Judah
    - Most of the north was apostate, and to a lesser extent so was the south
    - It's been years since anyone in Israel has followed the law and performed the ceremonies prescribed by the law
    - Even the practice of the Passover had been forgotton
    - Then in Chap 30 Hezekiah calls the men of the north and south to return to the temple and repent and seek the Lord again
- Some of the people of Israel and Judah responded to Hezekiah's call, and they assembled to observe the Passover
  - However, it had been so long since they observed the law, no one in the assembly was ritually clean
  - No one had performed the cleansing required by the law, no one had made the necessary sacrifices
  - Yet it was time for the Passover celebration
  - What would they do? Miss the Passover because they hadn't met all the requirements of the law?
  - Here's what happened:

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2Chr. 30:17 For *there were* many in the assembly who had not consecrated themselves; therefore, the Levites *were* over the slaughter of the Passover *lambs* for everyone who *was* unclean, in order to consecrate *them* to the LORD.
2Chr. 30:18 For a multitude of the people, *even* many from Ephraim and Manasseh, Issachar and Zebulun, had not purified themselves, yet they ate the Passover otherwise than prescribed. For Hezekiah prayed for them, saying, "May the good LORD pardon
2Chr. 30:19 everyone who prepares his heart to seek God, the LORD God of his fathers, though not according to the purification *rules* of the sanctuary."
2Chr. 30:20 So the LORD heard Hezekiah and healed the people.

- The lesson here should be obvious to us all
    - God was much more interested in their faith response
        - The obedience to repent and return to Him
        - Their willingness to submit to the requirements for observing the Passover – a picture of the Lord's coming sacrifice – was what God wanted in the first place
        - So He pardoned them for not having met all the other provisions of the law and healed them
        - Here's the lesson
        - The rules were not the point to God…it was the heart of obedience that matter
        - And the rules were merely meant to direct behavior in keeping with a faithful heart
            - And since the right were already demonstrating faith in their behavior, denying them the opportunity to worship in the feast because of the rules would have meant the rules were working against God's purpose

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- And so Jesus tells of David's experience to make a comparison for the Pharisees
    - And the comparison was this:
        - If God was willing to overlook David's violation of some minor Pharisaical law when his actions otherwise showed his desire to obey God…
        - Then how much more should the Pharisees overlook Christ's ignoring their man-made rules – rules that had no purpose other than to restrict men and make life more difficult
        - Remember, Jesus and the disciples weren't even violating the law - they were violating rules that the Pharisees had put in place – they were man made rules
- But when Jesus says that the Son of God is Lord of the Sabbath in verse 5, he takes His argument one step further
    - The Sabbath was a rule given by God to men as a picture of Christ, something we studied all the way back in Genesis
    - So therefore, it's a rule for men – not for God
    - God is not bound by a Sabbath that He gave explicitly for men
    - So though his actions were not in violation of the Sabbath, it wouldn't have mattered if they were
- But if you sensed there was a larger issue at work here…
    - Larger than merely the principle that rules are means to an end and not the end itself
    - Bigger even than the principle that God does not need to follow rules set for men…then you're right
    - And the second story on the Sabbath given by Luke gives us the opportunity to completely understand the issue here

Luke 6:6 ¶ On another Sabbath He entered the synagogue and was teaching; and there was a man there whose right hand was withered.
Luke 6:7 The scribes and the Pharisees were watching Him closely *to see* if He healed on the Sabbath, so that they might find *reason* to accuse Him.
Luke 6:8 But He knew what they were thinking, and He said to the man with the withered hand, "Get up and come forward!" And he got up and came forward.

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Luke 6:9 And Jesus said to them, "I ask you, is it lawful to do good or to do harm on the Sabbath, to save a life or to destroy it?"
Luke 6:10 After looking around at them all, He said to him, "Stretch out your hand!" And he did *so*; and his hand was restored.
Luke 6:11 But they themselves were filled with rage, and discussed together what they might do to Jesus.

- This incident comes on some later Sabbath, so Luke is combining the two events for us so we can appreciate how they fit together
- Having gained a reputation for disrupting the Sabbath, Jesus has remained a target especially on the Sabbath
    - In fact, the Pharisees have taken to watching Jesus' every move
    - On this day, they were concerned with the possibility he might heal on the Sabbath
    - This will give you an idea of how completely warped the Pharisees' rules had become
        - They saw a supernatural and miraculous act like healing a paralytic man as somehow going contrary to God's law
        - Nevermind that the healing itself must have come from God Himself – it was a violation of God's law
        - So they stood ready to accuse Him
- Notice the scriptures say Jesus knew what they were thinking, so He decides to deal with them – not to avoid the conflict
    - He looks around the synagogue and sees a man with a withered hand
        - It was probably a birth defect – the word for withered literally means dry, as in dry up, useless
        - He calls the man up to the front, and by now Jesus' reputation is such that everyone naturally expects that he has called the man in order to heal him
        - Which is exactly what the Pharisees were waiting for
- But Jesus is going to use the moment to make a larger point, the same point being made in the earlier experience in the barley field

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- He asks the Pharisees does the law compel people to do good or to do bad on the Sabbath? To save a life or to destroy it?
  - Matt adds the question of what would they do if their sheep feel into a well on the Sabbath
    - Of course, they would rescue it and not think another thing of it
    - The need to save the life of a lamb would be more important than remaining still on the Sabbath
- Of course, the Pharisees don't answer, because they will not concede to Jesus' point
  - And of course they couldn't answer Jesus without supporting him
    - If they answer that it's always correct to do what's right on the Sabbath, they would have given him a green light to heal
    - And they were trying to stop him from healing

- I said earlier that rules can never create righteousness
  - They merely give opportunities to make accusations
  - And that's the larger issue here and in the previous account concerning the Sabbath
- The Pharisees had made their endless rules a measure of righteousness in two ways
  - First, the Pharisees had set themselves up within society as an example of righteousness – the rules were their proof that they knew and followed the way of righteousness
    - But the it was a rigged game…the fix was in
    - These men set the rules and then they were the judges as well
    - And they spent their time teaching the need to follow the rules then tried to catch everyone breaking the rules

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- The Pharisees had established a system of righteousness that pleased them, that gave them honor and made everyone else's life miserable
  - It's why we call it works…it's hard work
  - And yet being the hypocrites they were, Jesus rightly points out that anyone of them would have done right for themselves – rescuing a lost sheep for example – though they would condemn Jesus for healing a person

- So the Pharisees weren't interested in showing mercy or training people to live for God
  - The rules enabled them to discredit anyone they wished
  - They wanted to discredit anyone who threatened their power and control

- But James gives us the true measure of Now Jesus asks them if doing right or doing wrong was preferable on the Sabbath
  - The obvious answer is that doing right was the correct thing to do on the Sabbath

James 2:12 So speak and so act as those who are to be judged by *the* law of liberty.
James 2:13 For judgment *will be* merciless to one who has shown no mercy; mercy triumphs over judgment.
James 2:14 ¶ What use is it, my brethren, if someone says he has faith but he has no works? Can that faith save him?
James 2:15 If a brother or sister is without clothing and in need of daily food,
James 2:16 and one of you says to them, "Go in peace, be warmed and be filled," and yet you do not give them what is necessary for *their* body, what use is that?

- This is what Jesus was trying to contend with in the Pharisees
  - They were all judgment – according to their own rules, not God's
  - And they had no room for mercy
  - And James rightly says that this is indicative of those who have no faith – merely their works

- Then Jesus skillfully throws the whole situation in the face of the Pharisees
  - He commands the man to stretch out his hand and it is healed

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- Jesus does nothing but speak, so he can't be accused of breaking the Pharisee's senseless rules
- Yet He demonstrates the need to do good, to show mercy and not the serve man-made rules
- You have to know that this stunned the audience, embarrassed the Pharisees, and as we see, the Pharisees were infuriated
  - The other Gospel authors mention that this is the point where the Pharisees decided to kill Jesus

- It's easy to see the Pharisees as distant figures completely unlike ourselves
  - We should be careful to examine whether we are pursuing Christ by Faith or are we pursuing God by works according to our own rules
  - You'll know the difference by whether you seek to compare yourself to others on the basis of how well they measure up to your rules
  - But our call is to the law of liberty…
    - Doing good at all times regardless of the rules
    - Showing mercy rather than judgment

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Luke 6B

- We have just begun one of the meatiest chapters in Luke
    - This chapter is set inside a larger theme of the tension between Jesus and the unbelieving religious leaders of the day
        - Men who looked like the picture of righteous, men who assumed they would be first in line at the Pearly Gates but in fact were earning the wages of sin: eternal death
    - A second theme Luke will continue to develop is how Jesus, as man, must rely on the Father for guidance and support in a way He's never experienced before
        - As an example to us of how we as well must learn to reply on the Holy Spirit and not on our flesh
    - Now we see Luke introduce his third and final theme
        - Jesus was preparing a group of men who would be the nucleus for establishing something entirely new on Earth: the church
        - When we consider that Luke was the author of the book of Acts, we can really trace this theme all the way into that book
            - Today we see him plants the first seeds of that discussion as Jesus makes His choice of the twelve Apostles
            - And we'll look at the difference between apostles and disciples
- These three themes work together in a unique way
    - The first two explain the third
        - The Pharisee were not honest men of God, but scheming evil men determined to thwart God and His Son
        - The Son came to do the Father's will, and His will was that Jesus would die at the hands of these evil men
        - Finally, Jesus coming death meant He must spend His ministry on earth preparing a few to carry the church forward in His absence and according to His direction

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- So Luke portrays Jesus making a very important hiring decision

A guy with no arms goes to a big church to apply for a job as a bell ringer...The priest thinks "I can't discriminate against the handicapped" and he hires him.
The priest asks "How are you going to pull the ropes and ring the bells in the tower with no arms"..."No problem Father".... The guy runs up into the tower...He takes a running start at the bell and hits it real hard with his face....The bell let out a beautiful sound and the preist says "Son that is wonderful but your going to hurt your face"....
"No I won't father, watch this one"...He takes a runnung start and hits the bell dead on with his face again but this time he slips and falls out of the bell tower to his death.....A crowd gathers as the priest runs down to help. "Does anybody know this man?" asks the priest.
A bystander looks at him and says, "I'm not sure but his face sure rings a bell".

-

Luke 6:12 ¶ It was at this time that He went off to the mountain to pray, and He spent the whole night in prayer to God.
Luke 6:13 And when day came, He called His disciples to Him and chose twelve of them, whom He also named as apostles:
Luke 6:14 Simon, whom He also named Peter, and Andrew his brother; and James and John; and Philip and Bartholomew;
Luke 6:15 and Matthew and Thomas; James *the son* of Alphaeus, and Simon who was called the Zealot;
Luke 6:16 Judas *the son* of James, and Judas Iscariot, who became a traitor.

- Luke spent most of Chaps 4 and 5 providing an overview of Jesus' ministry
  - How he was anointed by the Holy Spirit into ministry
  - How he taught with power,
  - how he performed healings,
  - how he gained popularity with the crowds
- Then in Chap 5 and into Chap 6 Luke begins to reveal the effect Jesus' ministry had on the religious leaders of the day
  - Their disagreement with His methods
  - Their offense at his message
  - And most of all, their anger at the powerful effect he was having on the people

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- But now Luke takes a brief break from those themes to address the calling of the apostles
    - Jesus is about to bring along side himself 12 men
    - These men will be his students, his confidants, His friends
    - Ultimately, these 12 will become the early builders of Christ's church
    - And Jesus is going to select these men from among the many disciples that were now following him every where he traveled
- But before we look at who he selected, the verses we read this morning lead us first to consider how he prepared for that decision
    - Verse 12 tells us that Jesus went off for the night and spent the whole night seeking the Father in prayer
        - When you read in the gospels about Jesus – the Son of God – spending time in prayer seeking the Father, do you catch yourself wondering
            - Why would Jesus – who is God Himself – need to pray to God?
            - Wouldn't His thoughts already be the Father's thoughts and vice versa?
- Well consider some things we can learn from scripture

John 8:42 Jesus said to them, "If God were your Father, you would love Me, for I proceeded forth and have come from God, for I have not even come on My own initiative, but He sent Me.

John 10:18 "No one has taken it away from Me, but I lay it down on My own initiative. I have authority to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again. This commandment I received from My Father."

    - The Father and the Son are separate – so much so that the Father can command the Son and He obeys the Father
        - But scripture also teaches:

John 10:30 "I and the Father are one."

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John 17:22 "The glory which You have given Me I have given to them, that they may be one, just as We are one;

John 1:1 ¶ In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.
John 1:2 He was in the beginning with God.

- So the Father and the Son are one God, both existing from the beginning
    - Likewise, the Holy Spirit existed in the beginning in Gen 1:2
    - But the Spirit is separate from Jesus and the Father

John 14:26 "But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name, He will teach you all things, and bring to your remembrance all that I said to you.

    - So here again, the Holy Spirit is part of God and yet is separate.
    - The mystery of the Trinity – the reason it is a mystery – is that our God is three person yet one.
        - Try as we might, we cannot fully reconcile these two facts
        - Scripture teaches both truths and teaches them in such a way that they are not seen as contradictory statements
            - In other words, Scripture acknowledges both realities without the least concern for any apparent contradiction
            - Scripture simply represents as the truth the three part nature of our God
- One of the consequences of this truth is that God the Son, during his ministry on earth, took the form of man while God the Father remained in Heaven
    - Both were still God, yet by choice the Son of God assumed a form which placed a new barrier between them
    - So Jesus prayed to communicate with the Father because his human form inhibited the previously free flowing communication
        - And the Spirit became the means by which the Father restored that connection

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Phil. 2:6 who, although He existed in the form of God, did not regard equality with God a thing to be grasped,
Phil. 2:7 but emptied Himself, taking the form of a bond-servant, *and* being made in the likeness of men.

- So Jesus seeks a quite place to pray to the Father for guidance on who to select as apostles
    - As we consider the apostles, remember that there were many disciples of Jesus but only 12 apostles
    - Jesus had large crowds following him everywhere he went all the way up till he was arrested

Matt. 4:24 ¶ The news about Him spread throughout all Syria; and they brought to Him all who were ill, those suffering with various diseases and pains, demoniacs, epileptics, paralytics; and He healed them.
Matt. 4:25 Large crowds followed Him from Galilee and *the* Decapolis and Jerusalem and Judea and *from* beyond the Jordan.

- Now look again at verse 13 in Luke 6
    - Jesus called the disciples and choose 12 from among them
    - The distinction is this
        - The word disciple means pupil or student
        - But the word apostle means ones who are sent with a message or on a mission
    - All apostles are disciples but not all disciples are apostles
        - However, the Bible uses the word apostle to refer to the 12 men named in this chapter, to Matthias, the man selected to replace Judas in Chap 1 of Acts, and to Paul
        - So Biblically speaking, an apostle is anyone commissioned by Christ to plant the early church
            - The 12 apostles were selected by the Lord himself and Matthias was selected by God through a casting lots to fill the apostleship vacated by Judas

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- Paul was commissioned by Jesus to become his apostle to the Gentiles

- Today I would argue that scripture does not give us the freedom to award that term to anyone
    - Rather we can be disciples, overseers, bishops, pastors, elders, deacons, prophets, witnesses, etc.
    - These are the terms used to describe the various roles of leadership God has set out in His church
    - But yet we can still see similar distinctions in how calls men and women within the church
        - He calls all believers to follow Christ – to be disciples
            - To be learners, to understand and emulate the teaching of Christ – The Word
        - But He calls some of those disciples to be messengers of a different order
            - Call them ministers, missionaries, whatever
            - They are the ones who recognize a different calling to go out with a message to spread the gospel
            - Ultimately, no matter what our spiritual gifting, if we feel God's calling to that next step of ministry, then we must recognize we are called to carry the gospel message
                - Some by teaching and preaching
                - Some by music
                - Some by service in missions
            - But all have the calling to bring the gospel message

- I find it striking that before Jesus selects these 12 men, he spends the entire night in prayer to the Father
    - Never is prayer more important that when we are facing a difficult decision – so that's what Jesus is taking time to do here

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- But Consider for a moment that Jesus had walked with these men for some time already
  - It was Jesus, after all, who had selected many of them to follow him in the first place
  - He had no doubt formed ideas about who the apostles should be
  - Didn't He have enough information to make His decision
- I'm struck that Jesus was so determined to know and do His Fathers will, that even though He must have felt comfortable making the choice himself, He still spent the time in prayer
  - As should we, never taking for granted that any decision we make falls outside God's care and control

- Now the apostles are listed in order of importance, with some minor variation in order between Matthew Mark and Luke
  - But all list Peter first and Judas Iscariot last
  - And as we scan this list of 12 names, take note that there is not a qualified person among them
    - No religious leaders
    - No formally trained spiritual leaders
    - No one went to seminary
    - When Jesus came upon each of them, none were actively pursuing a religious profession or even a religious education
    - In fact at least a few were outcasts, unreligious people who were considered the lowest of sinners
    - In other words, they weren't just unqualified, you could say many of them were disqualified – at least in the eyes of people in that day

- But yet they were the ones Jesus selected
  - And not just Jesus, but the Father
  - Jesus reminds us of this in John's Gospel

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John 6:66 ¶ As a result of this many of His disciples withdrew and were not walking with Him anymore.
John 6:67 So Jesus said to the twelve, "You do not want to go away also, do you?"
John 6:68 Simon Peter answered Him, "Lord, to whom shall we go? You have words of eternal life.
John 6:69 "We have believed and have come to know that You are the Holy One of God."
John 6:70 Jesus answered them, "Did I Myself not choose you, the twelve, and *yet* one of you is a devil?"
John 6:71 Now He meant Judas *the son* of Simon Iscariot, for he, one of the twelve, was going to betray Him.

- Jesus reminds them that they didn't end up where they were because of their own choices
    - They didn't decide one day to be a apostle
    - That's like waking up one day and deciding to be a lottery winner
        - It doesn't work that way
        - God will choose those He wishes to elevate into His messengers
        - And the ones He chooses to elevate aren't the ones we may expect
            - They aren't necessarily qualified according to our standards
            - They may even seem to be disqualified according to our standards
            - But God's desire is to call them away from the world He finds them in, and give them a new mission

John 15:19 "If you were of the world, the world would love its own; but because you are not of the world, but I chose you out of the world, because of this the world hates you.

- But it's important to recognize that though God selected men who were unqualified, He didn't send men who were untrained
    - At this point in Luke's gospel, these men have no idea what's ahead of them

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- All they know at this point is they've been selected to be part of the special inner circle of a really cool rabbi with some impressive healing powers
  - Kinda like a Jewish version of American Idol
- Little do they know that God is going to put them through three years of training with the Son of God so to prepare them for their life of ministry
  - And this life of ministry will include beatings, imprisonment, starvation, humiliation and ultimately martydom
  - And they won't graduate knowing everything they needed to know
  - But the Holy Spirit continues to teach and guide them

- So it is for us now
  - God calls those He wants in ministry
  - And those He calls, He equips
  - But early in that process, we won't know where He's taking us
  - Our job is merely to listen to the Word, grow with each new experience and apply ourselves to learning from our mistakes
  - The whole time trusting God to get us where He is taking us

- Now Jesus, having selected the apostles, then proceeds to teach them in unique ways apart from how he generally taught the crowds that followed him
  - The next section, commonly called the Beatitudes (consummate bliss), begins with a transition describing the scene
    - The account in Mark and Matthew differs slightly from the one in Luke
    - In fact, the entire discourse in Luke is considerably shorted that the one provided by Matt
    - This has lead to speculation that these are two different discourses,

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- but the introductions have strong parallels
- That suggests that Luke simply condensed the account for the sake of his gospel

- Probably the biggest difference centers around location details in the two gospels

Luke 6:17 ¶ Jesus came down with them and stood on a level place; and *there was* a large crowd of His disciples, and a great throng of people from all Judea and Jerusalem and the coastal region of Tyre and Sidon,
Luke 6:18 who had come to hear Him and to be healed of their diseases; and those who were troubled with unclean spirits were being cured.
Luke 6:19 And all the people were trying to touch Him, for power was coming from Him and healing *them* all.

- Luke records that Jesus first went up the mountain to select the apostles
    - Then he returns to a level place to teach the huge crowds
    - But Matt records it this way

Matt. 4:24 ¶ The news about Him spread throughout all Syria; and they brought to Him all who were ill, those suffering with various diseases and pains, demoniacs, epileptics, paralytics; and He healed them.
Matt. 4:25 Large crowds followed Him from Galilee and *the* Decapolis and Jerusalem and Judea and *from* beyond the Jordan.
Matt. 5:1 ¶ When Jesus saw the crowds, He went up on the mountain; and after He sat down, His disciples came to Him.
Matt. 5:2 He opened His mouth and *began* to teach them, saying,

- Matt says that it was upon Christ's accent that began to teach the Beatitudes
    - While Luke says it was upon his decent to a level area
- These two accounts can be harmonized fairly easily, however
    - We know Jesus went up the mountain to pray before selecting the 12
    - By morning he had selected the 12, then he descended to a level place and began teaching and healing the crowds

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- But at some point the crowd became too immense and he retreated back up the mountain some distance to get away from the crowd
- It was up on the mountain that he began to teach the apostles
  - It's also likely that some of the crowd followed him up the mountain too

- And it was in this setting, having selected his 12 apostles, the men who form the early church against all odds
  - In a time when his name was growing famous
  - When the Pharisees felt their empire of status and power threatened
  - In this climate mixed with awe and hatred, reverence and spite that Jesus begins to teach his most sublime messages
    - On the difference between trusting in God vs. trusting in self
    - On the difference between demanding justice and giving mercy
    - On the difference between expecting your reward here and awaiting it in eternity
    - On the difference between a faith in works and the works of our faith

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Luke 6C

- Imagine for a moment, you're in Jesus' shoes
    - You have come to this world
    - You've started your ministry knowing you will die in three short years offering yourself for the sins of the world
    - And you know that You leave behind a worldwide church that carries your message forward until the day of your return
        - And you have selected 12 simple, untrained and even unstable men to be the first missionaries for this church
    - How do you prepare them for such a task?
        - You have three years with these men
        - They can't possibly understand everything about who you are, and why you've come and what will happen to you or to them
        - They can't possibly comprehend how different your message will be from the one carried by the religious leaders of the day
        - They can't possibly appreciate the resistance they will encounter in their missions
        - And you only have three years
- Quite a task, to be sure
    - Jesus, in last week's lessons had selected the 12 apostles who would accompany Him for the better part of three years,
    - And now He begins His formal training in earnest
        - Actually, all four of the Gospels essentially present a record of the apostles' training program from a third person perspective
        - They're like documentaries of how Jesus prepared the apostles even as he prepared for His own death
            - We see their weaknesses, their confusions, their questions and even a little of Jesus' frustration with them at times

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- And at some point in his ministry, Jesus provided the instructions known as the sermon on the mount - recorded here in the remaining verses of Luke 6.

Luke 6:20 ¶ And turning His gaze toward His disciples, He *began* to say, "Blessed *are* you *who are* poor, for yours is the kingdom of God.
Luke 6:21 "Blessed *are* you who hunger now, for you shall be satisfied. Blessed *are* you who weep now, for you shall laugh.
Luke 6:22 "Blessed are you when men hate you, and ostracize you, and insult you, and scorn your name as evil, for the sake of the Son of Man.
Luke 6:23 "Be glad in that day and leap *for joy*, for behold, your reward is great in heaven. For in the same way their fathers used to treat the prophets.
Luke 6:24 "But woe to you who are rich, for you are receiving your comfort in full.
Luke 6:25 "Woe to you who are well-fed now, for you shall be hungry. Woe *to you* who laugh now, for you shall mourn and weep.
Luke 6:26 "Woe *to you* when all men speak well of you, for their fathers used to treat the false prophets in the same way.

- We call these verses in Luke the Beatitudes and the Woes
    - Beatitudes means consummate bliss
        - The name comes from the fact that each idea begins with the world "blessed" which can also be translated happy spiritually
        - And that's our first clue in how to interpret the meaning of these verses – it's a spiritual happiness that we're talking about here
    - Woes mean alas or divine judgment
        - Only Luke gives us the woes in his gospel, and he presents them to punctuates the meaning of the blessing by illustrating the opposite condition
- Each of these four statements is a paradox
    - Each begins by listing something that is undesirable
        - Being poor, being hungry, being sorrowful, being hated
    - And each ends with the opposite condition

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        - Being rich in the kingdom, being satisfied, being happy, and celebrating being persecuted

    - I find these verses to be great family disciplining material

        - When my daughter comes to me complaining about not having enough money for some toy, I remind her that blessed are the poor…

        - When my son complains about being too hungry to wait until dinner, I point out that blessed are those hunger now…

        - Annette…

- It's in the paradox that we can understand Jesus' meaning, and we're going to explore the paradox in each

    - But before we do that, we need to dismiss two incorrect perspectives that are common today

    - First, this teaching is not simply a state of mind issue

        - Jesus is not proposing that turning lemons into lemonade is the answer to life's problems

        - His sermon is not suggesting that happiness in life is simply a matter of convincing ourselves to take on these better attitudes as a response to life's trials

        - But that's the message heard in too many pulpits today

        - It's become vogue in our world today – even in the Christian church – to apply pop psychology and motivational thinking to our interpretation of scripture

        - It's as if Jesus and the message He delivered was merely one giant attitude correction

        - That might have been true if our problems were merely bad attitudes – but that's the least of our concerns

- The second error in interpreting these verses is to think that Jesus is promising us a trouble-free Christian life: one of bliss and financial blessing on earth

    - The church today is being inundated with messages peddling the Gospel in financial terms

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- Teaching Christians to think of God and His word in strictly financial terms
- Every time the word blessing is used, it means money or financial prosperity
- That the real benefit in living the Christian life is in how it will improve our life here and now
- These are false, unbiblical teachings, by teachers that twist scripture and change it's meaning to suit their purposes

- Nor is Christ suggesting in these verses that our life on earth will be without trial or suffering

- So what does Christ mean
  - Well, consider the word blessing again
  - It's spiritual happiness
    - In other words, eternal things – the things of the eternal realm
    - So the first clue is that we're looking at a spiritual gain, not a material gain
  - Secondly, the proper interpretation of Jesus statements requires we know who He is talking to and what time He is talking about

- Jesus, the text tells us, fixed his gaze on the disciples
  - In Greek, this is a very specific action – it's the lifting up, the raising up of the eyes to meet the eyes of another
  - We would probably say "Looked them in the eyes and said…"
  - Luke's point here is to tell us that Jesus' audience was the disciples, not just a random group within the crowd
    - As I mention at the beginning today, imagine how difficult it was going to be for Christ to prepare these men for ministry
      - They had been raised in a culture that had completely distorted the truth of who God was and how it was that we could please Him

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- Religious leaders taught that men were righteous by works, by keeping the law
- And they demanded that the more righteous you appeared, you more you gave the impression of knowledge and obedience to the law, the more you should be honored

Matt. 23:1 ¶ Then Jesus spoke to the crowds and to His disciples,
Matt. 23:2 saying: "The scribes and the Pharisees have seated themselves in the chair of Moses;
Matt. 23:3 therefore all that they tell you, do and observe, but do not do according to their deeds; for they say *things* and do not do *them*.
Matt. 23:4 "They tie up heavy burdens and lay them on men's shoulders, but they themselves are unwilling to move them with *so much as* a finger.
Matt. 23:5 "But they do all their deeds to be noticed by men; for they broaden their phylacteries and lengthen the tassels *of their garments*.
Matt. 23:6 "They love the place of honor at banquets and the chief seats in the synagogues,
Matt. 23:7 and respectful greetings in the market places, and being called Rabbi by men.

- So, Jesus begins with His disciples to systematically tear down these false notions of righteousness so He can replace them with the truth

- And he does this through paradoxes that describe the righteousness that is eternal – that results in eternal life
- And contrasting that, Jesus pronounces woe on those who focus on obtaining the righteous that is worldly, and on the riches and pleasures that come from their own labors – their own work

- He begins the first Blessing in verse 20 saying that blessed are the poor, for they will have the kingdom of Heaven
  - Matt records the statement a little differently
    - In fact, if you want to find Matt 5 and place a finger in the page…
    - Matt 5:3, He says blessed are those who are poor in spirit
- So it's not those who are financially poor – it's those who are spiritually poor – but what does it mean to be spiritually poor?

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- When we consider Christ's purpose in contending with the religious teaching of the day, with countering the false religion of the Pharisees, we can understand what spiritual poverty is
  - It's being willing to recognize and understand that we are miserable, poor and desperate spiritually
  - That we have an evil, self-serving heart
  - That we are all born spiritually empty and utter hopeless

- But in that recognition, we have hope to know the truth
  - Our true righteousness lies in Christ alone, but before we can understand that, much less accept it, we must first be willingly to acknowledge our own inability to please God of our own effort
    - We call this repentance
    - An act of turning from our sin, but more specifically, turning from the sin of believing we can earn our own salvation
    - Turning from thinking ourselves spiritually rich
  - Remember, the Pharisees were constantly preaching a message of works – which is the opposite of spiritual poverty
    - Works theology is a view of self that believes we have the ability to earn our own ticket to heaven, and by doing good works, we are building up spiritual wealth, so to speak
    - If that's were your trust lies But Christ says, that to be blessed, we must first be spiritually poor

- Jump down to verse 24 and let's make the quick contrast
  - In verse 24, Christ says those who are rich are receiving their comfort in full
  - Christ says the same thing to an apostate, unbelieving church in Revelation 3, when He says:

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Rev. 3:17 'Because you say, "I am rich, and have become wealthy, and have need of nothing," and you do not know that you are wretched and miserable and poor and blind and naked,
Rev. 3:18 I advise you to buy from Me gold refined by fire so that you may become rich, and white garments so that you may clothe yourself, and *that* the shame of your nakedness will not be revealed; and eye salve to anoint your eyes so that you may see.

- Those who are content to earn their own righteousness, to trust in their own ability rather than in Christ are blind to their own predicament
- They are naked, exposed to God's judgment

- But to the one who recognizes his spiritual poverty and trusts in Christ, to him will be the eternal blessing – the Kingdom of God, salvation
  - By our spiritual poverty, we gain access to true spiritual wealth
  - We gain access to the Kingdom of God by faith in Christ
  - And in that Kingdom, ultimately, we will find our inheritance, all that God has in store for us in eternity
  - This promise is not of earthly wealth, but eternal riches

- The second beatitude follows in a similar pattern
  - Jesus says, blessed are those who hunger, for they will be satisfied
  - Again, look at Matt 5:6, and you'll notice that Jesus says hunger and thirst for righteousness
    - Those who understand the truth will hunger and thirst for the true righteousness that can only come from God
  - Christians understand this kind of hunger almost instinctively
    - A Christian yearns for true righteousness,
      - In our world
      - But mostly in ourselves
      - We hunger and thirst for it

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- The unbelieving world has no special desire for true righteousness, much less do they seek it in themselves
    - Remember, the Pharisees…they sought a form of righteousness that men can achieve and be recognized for
    - And they gained the benefit of their efforts in this world
    - They were filled, satisfied by their efforts, and therefore they had no hunger for true righteousness
- Generally, men obey laws and rules only when it suits their own selfish interests
- We break eve our own rules when it suits us (New Orleans)
    - And they are filled, satisfied with the righteousness found in the world
- The woe in verse 25 amplifies the point
    - Those who are satisfied now – in this world – byt the kind of righteous they can obtain in this world, they will have no part in the true righteousness to come

- But as Christians, we don't have to wait until Christ's return to see that righteousness at least in part
    - We can see it in ourselves by the power of the Holy Spirit
    - Even now, as we wait for Christ's return, He has begun a work in us to makes us more righteous – sanctification
- So the paradox here again is that those who hunger now for the true righteousness that Christ brings…
    - They will be the only ones who experience true righteousness in eternity
- Third, Christ says blessed are those who weep now, for they will laugh
    - Why would weeping now guarantee laughter later?
        - And looking at the woe, why would laughing now guarantee weeping later?
    - Well, we know we're talking about spiritual issues now, and therefore we're talking about a spiritual sorrow

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- Like the kind Paul mentions

2Cor. 7:9 I now rejoice, not that you were made sorrowful, but that you were made sorrowful to *the point of* repentance; for you were made sorrowful according to *the will of* God, so that you might not suffer loss in anything through us.
2Cor. 7:10 For the sorrow that is according to *the will of* God produces a repentance without regret, *leading* to salvation, but the sorrow of the world produces death.

- There is a worldly sorrow
  - A regret at making mistakes, a sorrow over sin's consequences
  - But that's not godly sorrow
- Godly sorrow is the sadness brought by the HS convicting us of our sins
  - And those who experience godly sorrow now, who literally weep and feel conviction over their sins are the ones being saved
  - And as such, they are the ones God is preparing to enter eternity, where

Rev. 21:4 and He will wipe away every tear from their eyes; and there will no longer be *any* death; there will no longer be *any* mourning, or crying, or pain; the first things have passed away."

- Finally, Jesus says that we are to consider ourselves blessed – spiritually happy – when men hate us, insult us or separate themselves from us - in the name of the Son
  - Another paradox
  - How can any of us truly feel blessed when we suffer those things
  - When your child comes home from school or the park or a friend's house crying because they were mocked or excluded on the basis of their faith, what parent can honestly say they feel happy about that?
  - When you lose a promotion or the good assignment because your faith is an obstacle, do you feel blessed?
    - And I'm not talking about suffering because of our own mistakes
    - The next time you get hauled into traffic court and receive a stiff fine for speeding, you can't stand up before the judge and say "At least my reward in heaven will be great.

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- We're talking about persecution here, not prosecution

- But the sad truth is today in America is that only a few Christians can even relate to the idea of being persecuted for their faith

- And it's not because our country is so accepting to Christians, though it is more so than many

  - And in S. Texas is better than many other places, to be sure

- But honestly, the real issue is not how much the world accepts Christians, the problem is how few Christians actually stand out from the world

  - If we really led a Christ-like life in all we did and said, would we have as many friends?

  - Would we be as accepted?

- And I'm not talking about running around making our faith known by casting harsh judgments on others and offending everyone we meet – Jesus actually deals with that problem later in this chapter

  - Nor am I talking about being stoned or burned at the stake before we consider ourselves hated

  - It's usually more subtle than that in today's world

  - Halloween example…

- But when that happens, Jesus says we can rejoice a little more

  - Why? He says because the prophets themselves were persecuted. Huh?

  - Jesus is illustrating that men and women of God – people willing to make a public show of their faith – will always be persecuted

  - And then when the world hates you because of Christ, they are unknowingly testifying that you are a child of God

John 15:18 ¶ "If the world hates you, you know that it has hated Me before *it hated* you.
John 15:19 "If you were of the world, the world would love its own; but because you are not of the world, but I chose you out of the world, because of this the world hates you.

- Can you see the joy in that?

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- How often do we experience moments of doubt about whether we are truly saved or whether we can really trust in God's promises of eternity
    - Jesus says, when you experience persecution at the hand of ungodly men on account of Christ, you have all the proof you need
    - Because if you were of their world, they would not persecute you – they simply wouldn't agree
    - But instead they persecute you because you stand as a testimony of their unrighteousness
- And in that difference, you have reason to rejoice,

- But as the final woe explains, when the world embraces you
    - When it loves your teaching
    - When it agrees with all you say
    - Woe to you
    - Like the Pharisees, who gained the praises of men
        - Who comfortable friends with the idol worshipping Roman empire as easily as they did the corrupt and self-serving Jewish Sanhedrin
    - Like the false teachers of our day who tickle men's ears with promises of wealth, power and eternally good health
        - These men are like the false prophets of the old
        - And their increasing fame and popularity among the world at large is all the warning they need to know they are in trouble

- So, Jesus begins his preparation of the disciples by challenging their understanding of righteousness
    - Obviously, the disciples were going to encounter all these things in a material sense as well: poverty, hunger, sadness, hatred

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- But spiritually, Jesus wanted them to understand that their focus needed to begin shifting to eternal issues – to a focus on true righteousness and godliness – and on their source: Jesus Christ

- So let that be our reminder for today as well

    - Let's leave here today focused – refocused – on things eternal

    - With a confidence in our spiritual riches, not obsessed with the materialism of this world

    - Let's walk out of here with a hunger for righteousness, for living a Christ-like life and for His Word

    - Let's continually weep over our sin look forward to a day when we will laugh in the joy of an eternity without sin

    - And let's expect but not worry over the hatred that may come our way, for it came to our savior in the same way for our sake

        - Take it as proof that we are children on the living God

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Luke 6D

- This morning we drop back into Jesus' first day of classes for his disciples
    - As we said last time, Jesus has the unenviable task of preparing the disciples for their ministry - to lay the foundations of the early church
    - But even as He desires to teach them the mysteries of God's grace and of the Kingdom to come, Jesus spends much of His time with them correcting their thinking concerning true love and righteousness
- Last week He had just begun the discipling process
    - He established the fact that there are 2 kinds of people in the world
    - These two different types can be illustrated in an infinite number of ways, but Jesus first chose to contrast their dispositions
        - On the one hand, you have those who are satisfied by this world
            - Who feel generally good about themselves and their achievements
            - Who feel secure in their future
            - Jesus speaks of this group as being well satisfied and laughing in verse 25,
                - As having need of nothing in verse 24
    - Essentially they are pleased with themselves, and by their disposition they betray themselves as lovers of self rather than lovers of God
        - They have not experienced the saving sorrow brought by the conviction of the Holy Spirit
        - Therefore they are sons of disobedience
    - These will have an eternity of misery as judgment for living their earthly lives in open rebellion to God, unrepentant and without a fear of God
- The second type of person is at all times the opposite of the first
    - Because of the conviction of the Holy Spirit and God's grace, he has become aware of his poor condition spiritually,

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- He weeps over his sins
- And He is hungry for true righteousness
- And because he turns his back on the world and turns toward God, the world hates him and rejects him
- But he will have his reward one day – in the Kingdom
- And he has become an adopted son of Heaven

- Knowing the difference is merely step one…
  - How should one side respond to the other, and for what purpose?

Luke 6:27 ¶ "But I say to you who hear, love your enemies, do good to those who hate you,
Luke 6:28 bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you.
Luke 6:29 "Whoever hits you on the cheek, offer him the other also; and whoever takes away your coat, do not withhold your shirt from him either.
Luke 6:30 "Give to everyone who asks of you, and whoever takes away what is yours, do not demand it back.
Luke 6:31 "Treat others the same way you want them to treat you.

- Take a moment and notice a couple of things about how this teaching is fit together
  - First, notice what preceded these verses
    - Jesus ended in verse 26 by warning us to expect hatred and not look for praise as one of His disciples
    - So it would seem that Jesus is taking a moment to explain how a disciple should respond to his attacker
- But Matt's account helps stitch these thoughts together even better
  - In his account Matt records Jesus exhorting the disciples to remain salt and light – to remain distinct in the world
  - Jesus first states that believing in Him and following Him – being a disciple of Jesus – will bring rejection and hatred by the world
    - So to the extent you make known that you are a follower of Christ, you will naturally find yourself at odds with the world

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- And yet, that rejection and hatred cannot be our excuse to shrink back from our responsibility to stand out and to stand for Christ in a lost an dying world

- Then as we shall see in this the text today, Jesus actually asks for His disciples to go one step further – an all but impossible step – we are to love our enemies

- Have you ever considered why Jesus says His disciples will be hated and yet we must stand out and remain a target, as it were

    - Why must your faith and obedience in Christ result in the world hating you? Can't they just ignore us?

        - In a word, no

    - The world can ignore falsehoods, but it won't ignore the truth

        - The lost and dying world is not threatened by false faiths and false beliefs – it embraces them, it shares them

        - They naturally love their own – as we quoted in John 15:19

            - If you were of this world, the world would love its own.

- But the world – propelled by the schemes of the evil one – will always hate the godly, the prophets, the disciples of the true living God

    - There are only two kinds of people…

Every morning when I wake up, I read the Bible and the Newspaper... Because I want to know what both sides are up to.

- It is <u>because</u> we hold the truth that the enemy wishes us to be opposed and hated

- And in fact, we too were once one of those who opposed God and opposed His children

- Paul explains it this way in Eph chapter 2

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Eph. 2:1 ¶ And you were dead in your trespasses and sins,
Eph. 2:2 in which you formerly walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience.
Eph. 2:3 Among them we too all formerly lived in the lusts of our flesh, indulging the desires of the flesh and of the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, even as the rest.

- Paul begins by calling his readers "dead" – nekros – a corpse
    - We were as walking dead men – like walking corpses
    - And it was according to the course of this world
        - Course (aion) means age or from the beginning of time
    - We were walking as the world has always walked – by the power of the enemy
        - And he calls us the sons of disobedience
        - We were by nature children of wrath – God's wrath
- Eph 2 goes on to explain that it was an act of God's grace to change us and by faith bring us into a new relationship with Him – to become children of God
    - Now we can hear and understand the truth of Jesus' words, if we have been born again by the Spirit and we now are believers
        - Jesus even began the passage today mentioning "for those who hear"
        - Not everyone can hear and understand His words – only those who have the HS teaching them truth
- And so now the enemy fiercely opposes those who are sons of God – because the enemy first opposed God Himself
    - This is why we rejoice at being persecuted for His name sake, because it confirms that we aren't on the side of the enemy any longer – for the enemy will not oppose himself
        - As Jesus says in Matt 12:25 that a house divided against itself cannot stand
- So, a disciples must by nature be hated

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- And yet we must stand out, being a target for Jesus
  - We aren't supposed to shrink back or hide so as to avoid persecution
  - Instead we greet our enemies head on, and forgive them

- Jesus says love your enemies, do good to those who hate you
  - He gives several interesting examples in the text of how we may be mistreated and he we should respond
    - He mentions being cursed, being struck on the cheek, having our possessions taken

- There is a certain sense intended here that may not be immediately apparent
  - Remember last week when Jesus said that we should count it joy when we are hated for the sake of the Son of Man – for Jesus' sake
    - We said then that we can't simple count misery for just any reason as being in our favor
    - But persecution in the name of Jesus is reason to rejoice
  - That same sense is still in view here
    - Who are the enemies of disciples? Those who oppose God and His Son
    - But as disciples we are to not hold it against the sons of disobedience when they oppose us because we are Christ's
      - Rather show them mercy and forgiveness

- Consider the specific steps Jesus says he expects His disciples to take in the face of this opposition
  - Bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you
    - Am I right in assuming that we have trouble remembering to pray for those we love, much less those who would curse us as Christians
    - What would you pray for? You say, sure I'll pray for them…I'll pray for them to fall into a deep pit filled with rattlesnakes,

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- We can be sure that's not what He meant, but what was it he expected?

- Or for the one who strikes you on the cheek

  - The words in Greek here actually draw a more violent picture

    - The word for strike here – tupto – is the same word used for how the soldiers beat Jesus or how Paul was being beaten to death by the Jews in Jerusalem before Roman soldiers stopped them

    - The word for cheek is literally jawbone

    - So we're talking about a punch to the jaw

  - When they strike you in that way, you turn and show no resistance to their beating

    - And we're not talking about being passive – about refusing to ever fight back

      - This isn't a lesson in the morality of self defense or violence in any form

    - It's about how we respond to those who oppose us for our faith in Christ

    - Again, why would we do this? What is Jesus asking of us here?

- And Jesus when they take your cloak, offer him you shirt too

  - The cloak was the out garment, the most valuable part of the person's wardrobe

  - The shirt was essentially the undergarmet – of less value than the cloak but more personal and private

    - The language here suggests a highway robbery – someone demanding your coat by force

    - But even in the midst of the robbery, Jesus demands that we try to make the other person feel comfortable and offer even more

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        - Again, what's the point here Jesus? How come I have to respond in these ways?

- Then Jesus gives us part of the answer in verse 31
    - Some often call this verse the golden rule – though Jesus was not the first to state it
        - This principle had been stated many times before Jesus day – a version of it can even be found in the Torah in Lev 19:18
    - But in every other case, it has always been phrased from the negative perspective: What you don't want done to you, don't do to others
        - Now Jesus states it in the positive sense
            - Do to others what you want them to do to you
    - We all know this rule and we understand it instinctively
        - But if you examine the situations Jesus mentioned carefully, you realize that Jesus is actually going a step farther
        - He gives example where the right thing isn't being done

- When someone has punched you in the jaw or cursed you or stolen your coat, they have already done the wrong thing unto you
    - They've already injured you
    - Your desire to have them do unto you has already failed
        - Now, you should be free to respond in kind, shouldn't you?
        - That's what the world would say
    - In Matt's account of this passage, the first verses begin with this:

Matt. 5:38 ¶ "You have heard that it was said, 'AN EYE FOR AN EYE, AND A TOOTH FOR A TOOTH.'
Matt. 5:39 "But I say to you, do not resist an evil person; but whoever slaps you on your right cheek, turn the other to him also.

- Jesus quotes from Exodus 21:24, where the Pharisees and others often went to justify their acts of revenge

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- The Pharisees just like the world today believed that once a wrong had been done, then the injured party had the right to respond in kind
- In fact, that rule had been given to limit the retribution of men, not to endorse it
  - The point of Exodus 21 was to emphasize that men shouldn't seek to take a greater step in response than what was done in the original offense
  - Much like when Jesus said that Moses allowed certificates of divorce because of the hardness of their hearts
    - That is, not because divorce was permissible but because men were leaving their wives and not giving them an opportunity to remarry

- And here's Jesus plainly refuting that principle
  - Jesus' golden rule goes beyond just trying to get a relationship started on the right foot
    - Jesus rule for His disciplines was that even after the relationship sours because of their error, we maintain our part of the bargain
  - So the golden rule isn't a two way street for a disciple
    - Their sin against you and I can never be our reason for responding in sin toward them
    - But here again, why? Simply to be nice?

- Well, consider where Jesus goes next, and we'll have our answer

Luke 6:32 "If you love those who love you, what credit is *that* to you? For even sinners love those who love them.
Luke 6:33 "If you do good to those who do good to you, what credit is *that* to you? For even sinners do the same.
Luke 6:34 "If you lend to those from whom you expect to receive, what credit is *that* to you? Even sinners lend to sinners in order to receive back the same *amount*.
Luke 6:35 "But love your enemies, and do good, and lend, expecting nothing in return; and your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High; for He Himself is kind to ungrateful and evil *men*.
Luke 6:36 "Be merciful, just as your Father is merciful.

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- Let those verses sink in for just a moment
    - This may come as a shock to you, but when you're nice to those who like you – to your family, to your friends, to those you congregate with
        - You get no credit with God
    - You are doing what the world does – what the enemy does – what the sons of disobedience do
    - In fact, you were doing those things before you ever became a disciple of Jesus – a believer in the gospel
    - So why is it that you would turn to God today and demand that He favor you simply because you do what is natural for all men
- Let's review Jesus instructions
    - Jesus started by describing two kinds of people
        - Then Jesus said these two groups will always be opposed
        - And the one will hate the other for the sake of Christ
    - But yet the disciple must remain distinct from the world, making sure the differences remain pronounced –
        - So that we remain a target rather than shrink back and fade into the wood work of our society
    - Then he says, when the attacks come, we should adopt these ridiculous, nonsensical responses –
        - Responses that could only come with the power of the HS, because we would never think to do them ourselves
        - In fact, Jesus says we can only get credit as a disciple when we act in this counter intuitive way, since even the unbelieving world favors those who like them
    - But then Jesus adds the final piece: we should do these things because our Father in heaven is kind to ungrateful and evil men
        - We should be merciful as our Father is merciful
        - I suspect even now, the enormity of this escapes us

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- Paul expressed it this way in Romans:

Rom. 5:6 ¶ For while we were still helpless, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.
Rom. 5:7 For one will hardly die for a righteous man; though perhaps for the good man someone would dare even to die.
Rom. 5:8 But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

- I don't know if when we've read this before, we've truly understood what Paul was saying
  - God in the man Jesus Christ – looked across all eternity at all humanity for all of time, and saw all men as sinners, as enemies of God – and then willingly died in their place even while they hated him
    - So when our Lord was paraded before the authorities on his way to the cross, and they spat on Him and cursed Him, we were there in the crowd spitting on Him – but he blessed His tormentors and prayed for those who cursed Him,
    - And when Jesus had his clothes ripped from his body, we were there agreeing heartily with the violence – and Jesus gave no resistance but let them take everything
    - And when the guards struck Jesus on the cheek and drew His blood, we were the ones throwing the punch – and yet Jesus turned the other cheek
    - And He did those things so that He might go sinless to the cross
  - Do see that when Jesus gave His life on the cross, He was dying for your sins and mine even while we opposed him – even as we were His enemies
    - Yet if he had responded as you an I might have desired – to strike back and oppose His enemies – He would have been opposing the Father's plan – He would have sinned
    - And had He sinned, His payment on the cross wouldn't have been valid for you and I
    - Think about that…be merciful because your Father in heaven was merciful to you
  - This is why Paul goes on to say:

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Rom. 5:10 For if while we were enemies we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son, much more, having been reconciled, we shall be saved by His life.

- So now I ask you, how might we pray for those who curse us or hate on account of Christ?
    - Pray for their salvation. Pray for them to know the truth. Pray for the Father to open their eyes as He opened yours
- And when they strike you because of your faith, why turn the other cheek? Or when they take from you or borrow from you taking advantage of your Christian generosity, why should you let them get away with it?
    - Because your Father in heaven has already forgiven us of so much more, we can never dare complain about injustice – about being owed anything
    - And because we are to be merciful as He is was merciful to us
        - For remember, the sons of disobedience who oppose you in the name of Christ will one day receive the full payment for their sins while you will go free
- Therefore, we have no basis to argue with Jesus when He says we are to show mercy to those who oppose us
    - And as disciples, our priority is not serving our own interests in any event – just as the disciples in Jesus day were being prepared to give their lives to the establishment of the church
    - We today are to give our lives to the spread and growth of the church
    - And by our actions when we follow these instructions we give opportunity to bear witness to our enemies of the Father's mercy – and perhaps persuade someone concerning Christ on the basis of our actions
- As James says, we are not to be merely hearers of the word, but doers
    -

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Luke 6E

- This is the fifth week in Luke chapter 6, and it will be our last
    - We've been working through a Christian disciple 101 training program
    - A program Jesus first laid out for his 12 apostles as He began their preparation for service to the Gospel
- In the first four weeks in this chapter, we've listened to Jesus teaching the disciples how they will be different from the world around them
    - First, we had the beatitudes, the lessons on how true faith brings sorrow and repentance in this life along with a hopeful expectation for restoration and for our rewards in eternity
    - Then, Jesus told them that this difference created by their faith would alienate them from the unbelieving world, which would persecute them for the sake of Christ's name
    - But Jesus adds that the fact that persecution will come is not to dissuade them to press on with the Gospel message
        - They will be targets yet they must accept this outcome
        - And furthermore, they must respond not in kind, as the world would do, but in love and generosity and forgiveness toward them
    - And finally, Jesus reminded the disciples that when they show mercy to those who hate them, they are merely following in Christ's footsteps
        - For the Father were willing to overlook our hatred of Him and give His Son over to death at our hands
            - So that He might giving the incomparable gift of salvation
            - So now we become little Christ's (Christians) in that we too will suffer at the hands of men at times so that the Father may deliver a message of mercy and grace to evil men – just as Christ did first
            - In fact, if an enemy were to take something from us, Christ says let it go and give them more – maybe an opportunity to spread the gospel – sovereignty

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- Now we're beginning to see better how Jesus is working to reset the disciples expectations for what righteousness looks like
    - This was radical stuff
    - There was nothing like this to be found in the teaching from the Pharisees of that day
- And now it's about to get even more radical…

Luke 6:36 "Be merciful, just as your Father is merciful.
Luke 6:37 ¶ "Do not judge, and you will not be judged; and do not condemn, and you will not be condemned; pardon, and you will be pardoned.
Luke 6:38 "Give, and it will be given to you. They will pour into your lap a good measure—pressed down, shaken together, *and* running over. For by your standard of measure it will be measured to you in return."

- You may have noticed I began in a verse we read last week
    - I did that because this is an important bridge verse in the discourse
    - It bridges two ideas
        - First, it helps explain the instructions immediately before it
        - Jesus says show kindness and compassion to your enemies because God was once merciful to you,
        - So be merciful just as your Father is
    - But it also explains the meaning of the next series of verse
        - When confronting an enemy who hates you for your belief in Jesus, be merciful and do not judge him
        - And that's the first thing you need to notice in these verses…
            - The term judge here is being applied in a specific sense
- It begins with the audience – your enemies
    - These verses all refer back to a group mentioned earlier – notice the reference to "they" in verse 38

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- "They" are the enemies mentioned in verse 35
- So we're talking here about how we might view our enemies

- And who are our enemies again?
  - Remember from last few weeks, we've watched as Christ has carefully built His teaching around a discussion of two kinds of people
    - There are the believers who by faith in Christ are changed and become adopted sons of God
    - Then there is the rest of the world, the sons of disobedience, enemies of God, a group we were once a part of
    - And once we changed sides, when we joined with Christ, we too are now considered enemies of the world
    - Because they hated Christ first, now they will despise us as well
  - So our enemies, spiritually speaking, are the world of unbelievers
    - And Christ says we should not judge that group
    - But what does He mean by judging and pardoning?
    - Does Jesus mean it in the eternal spiritual sense or in the temporal, human sense? The answer is yes…both

- Begin by looking at the entirety of verse 37
  - Jesus says don't judge, but He also says don't condemn
  - Then He adds that we should be prepared to pardon our enemies
    - Judging, condemning, pardoning…for what?
      - Well, what did Jesus say they were likely to do to you…what made them enemies?
      - Their attack on you for your faith, of course
    - How are we likely to judge someone who attacks our faith? How are we likely to condemn them? Why do they need pardon from us?

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- Because these are the apostle Jesus is talking to…His witnesses…the men who would bring the Good news to the world

- Should they only bring it to those who are nice to them? Only those who are already righteous?

- If we were take offense at our rough treatment at the hands of our enemies,
    - If in our anger, we were to make judgments about them and essentially condemn them in our own minds by refusing to bring them the gospel
    - We have in sense made ourselves to be their judges
- We may feel justified and just plain scared or embarrassed at the ridicule, but if we ever assume that God has no intentions of bringing them to faith
    - Then we've come to a judgment about their eternal destiny…we've condemned them – and that's simply not our right – God alone is the judge
        - We never have the opportunity to consider someone "unsavable" – because everyone is unsavable apart from God's grace and the power of the HS
        - You yourself were once unsavable, but if you are a believer now, it is proof that God sent His HS to you to prepare you to receive the Gospel message – amazing!
        - How can we ever say that He won't do the same thing to another person? Even on their deathbed
            - Thief on the cross example
- So Jesus tells the disciples to pardon their enemies for their persecution
- Are you surprised by what the text is saying?
    - Well, if you are like most people, you've heard these verses misused in so many countless ways you may be surprised to hear the correct usage
    - Here are the two most common ways they get misused
        - When we correct or rebuke a fellow believer, we get hit with the response, "Jesus said not to judge, therefore you can't judge me."
- This is simply bad use of scripture

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- First, we've already established that Jesus is talking about believers treat unbelievers, not each other
- Secondly, from the context its clear that Jesus is not talking about making discernments, assessments, or - judgments if you will - about appropriate or inappropriate behavior among believers
  - The NT is filled with very specific direction for how believers should conduct themselves and for how the Body should respond to those who stray outside these requirements
  - So, when someone responds to correction from another believer with comments about not judging them, it's simply a smokescreen to avoid dealing with the truth of the matter – with their sin

- But we all know that this area brings with it tremendous room for error and abuse
  - There is a thin line between rightfully calling a brother out for sin and incorrectly applying legalistic rules that are not intended to be measures of righteousness
    - Legalism is the cancer in many churches throughout the ages
    - It starts simply enough, with rules for good order and discipline
    - But soon those rules become yokes around the necks of the members of the church, rules that define righteousness rather than guidelines to promote it
  - In fact, if you find yourself spending significant amount of time thinking about what other Christians are doing wrong, then you've got a problem
    - Either you're in the wrong place for fellowship
    - Or you are investing way too much time worrying about other people's problems
    - But maybe you say that's not a problem for you…well jesus knew better
      - Even the way he begins verse 37…Do not judge
      - In the Greek language it is two words krino me, and it is the present imperative tense of the word judge…as in stop judging

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- Jesus knew men do this,…all the time
- He's not saying if you should ever think about judging, don't. He's saying Stop it…

- And there is a second may these verses are misused
  - Ironically, when an unbeliever says it to a Christian in response to some standard or expectation the Christian wishes to apply to the unbeliever
    - When we have an unbeliever throw your lifestyle back in their face – do they have any right to talk about judging?
    - Perhaps your unsaved buddy at work mentions that he's having an affair, and you respond in surprise and tell him that he should be loyal to his spouse
    - Or your unchristian neighbor mentions that he wants to hook into your cable connection to share your signal, and you tell him that would be stealing
    - Or an unbeliever you know at school asks to look at your homework before class and you say that would be cheating
    - In each case, the other person says what to you? Who are you to judge?
- And frankly, though their statement misunderstands Jesus teaching just as much as the first example, part of the mistake is also ours
- Even though your observations about their sin may have been correct, is that really the problem here? And are your comments really going to correct the real issue?
  - They are sinning, yes, and their sin is bad and it will hurt them…but folks, that's what sinners do. They sin.
  - That's the only thing they know how to do
  - They can't work their way to heaven, no more than you did
  - So giving them things to do differently won't help them in the long run
    - Lipstick on a pig
    - In fact, if you succeed, then you've really made things hard for them

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- What they need is the Gospel message. To know that sin will lead to spiritual death
    - But Jesus paid that price for them already, and if they believe in Him, then the Holy Spirit brings them the power to turn from a sinful life

- In fact, this change in the disciples is why Jesus can say that if they don't judge or condemn they won't find themselves condemned or judged
    - Because the only kind of person who would act this way toward their enemies because of the sake of Christ are people who have themselves already had their hearts change
    - These are the kind of people who by their willingness to forgive their enemies make known their own changed hearts – and give witness to their salvation by faith
        - Because they are willing to be merciful as their father in heaven is merciful

- As we move on, it's worth taking note of verse 38…
    - When left in context, connected to verse 37 and the discussion of forgiveness and then verse 39 and beyond which also discusses judgment…
        - Then it's clear the issue in view in verse 38 is forgiveness, not wealth
        - But unscrupulous teachers have taken this one verse out of context and used it to support teaching that says if you want to be rich, give a lot of money to the church
        - Some even turn it around and say that God will not bless us financially unless we are tithing properly
    - Putting aside the issue of tithing, let me just emphasize, that those principles are not Biblical, at least not as they are usually stated
        - And the only way you can find some form of Biblical support is to grab verse like this one out of context and distort their true meaning
        - This is a good example of why we prefer to study scripture verse-by-verse in context

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- But now Jesus begins to end His discourse by going back to where he started…to the false religious leaders of the day

Luke 6:39 ¶ And He also spoke a parable to them: "A blind man cannot guide a blind man, can he? Will they not both fall into a pit?
Luke 6:40 "A pupil is not above his teacher; but everyone, after he has been fully trained, will be like his teacher.
Luke 6:41 "Why do you look at the speck that is in your brother's eye, but do not notice the log that is in your own eye?
Luke 6:42 "Or how can you say to your brother, 'Brother, let me take out the speck that is in your eye,' when you yourself do not see the log that is in your own eye? You hypocrite, first take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take out the speck that is in your brother's eye.
Luke 6:43 "For there is no good tree which produces bad fruit, nor, on the other hand, a bad tree which produces good fruit.
Luke 6:44 "For each tree is known by its own fruit. For men do not gather figs from thorns, nor do they pick grapes from a briar bush.
Luke 6:45 "The good man out of the good treasure of his heart brings forth what is good; and the evil *man* out of the evil *treasure* brings forth what is evil; for his mouth speaks from that which fills his heart.

- Now Jesus returns to wedge He's been driving between the apostles and the religious leaders of the day
- He offers a short one verse parable…that a blind man cannot guide the blind
    - He's begun again to talk about the Pharisees and other leaders of their day
    - These men were spiritually blind – not knowing the truth nor seeking it
        - Yet they were telling others that they should follow them to know the truth
        - But if they themselves are blind, then other spiritually lost men who choose to follow them will perish with them...into the pit of hell
- Christ follows that with an equally short statement of fact…that pupils can only learn as much as their teachers know

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- More than that, a pupil will be molded after the teacher, learning what they know and following after their behavior until they look like their teacher

- Why did Jesus interrupt his discourse on forgiveness and judgment with those two verses?
  - Jesus is not only tearing down generations of false teaching on righteousness,
    - He's also needs to tear down the authority of the religious teachers on his day –
    - so the disciples will have no confusions about which teachings are true

- To do that, he begins by illustrating the dangers of judging others
  - The real danger in judging others is not in how you treat them…it's in how you see yourself
  - As we become more and more comfortable judging others
    - As we feel more comfortable deciding who is righteous and who is not up to the standard, the more comfortable we feel about our own situation
    - No one stands in judgment over others while at the same time thinking themselves guilty of the same crime
    - The more we judge others, the more we naturally see ourselves as righteous
    - And this was the calling card of the religious leaders of the day

- They had become so consumed with their roles as judges of society and men, that they were virtually sinless in their own eyes – and therefore they had no need for a savior
  - Jesus says, while you're busy working to remove the speck out of your brother's eye (karphos – literally a small dried stalk of a plant) A thin wisp of vegetation
  - First, why don't you take out that gianormous log out of your own eye (dokos) or beam of lumber, like an unfinished tree

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- It's like being a blind eye surgeon doing eye surgery…the height of irony

- We should be so careful to consider that effect in ourselves as well
  - There's no difficulty in become someone's judge…but there's little value – for them or for us
  - If you have a heart to root out sin and expose it and do away with it, you have the perfect opportunity in yourself…and you'll never run out of material
  - And then only if you should achieve perfection – a day when there is no log in your eye – then you'll be so qualified at log removal, you'll be in a perfect place to remove the speck from another's eye

- And then Jesus gives the parable of the two trees
  - This parable has really two issues in view
  - First Jesus is warning the disciples to judge teachers by their works
    - Are they hypocritical as was the case for the one removing a speck while sporting a log
    - If so, then stay away from their teaching as well, for it is coming from a fountain of unbelief
    - Matt in both the 7th and 12th chapters records Jesus saying similar things when addressing the Pharisees – accusing them of having false motives

- But Jesus is also reminding us of what should be our real goal for those people – the people with the log in their own eye
  - If we want them to produce good fruit, to live a life free from the corruption of sin and its negative influences…
  - Then they are going to need a heart that can produce such treasures
  - Because as long as they have an evil, unbelieving heart, they have no hope to produce anything other than bad, evil fruit
  - And so a heart transplant is the only cure for the disease that produces sin
  - Which again leads us back to the gospel message…you see how it all fits for Jesus here?

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- He wants us to be His disciples, his messengers
- But He isn't sending us to His friends, but rather to His enemies
- And though they hate us, love them
- And though they reject you, don't condemn them
- And though you may want to help them lead a life of joy, you can't bring them that joy merely from outward change
- You must bring them the Gospel and pray God brings an inward change

Luke 6:46 ¶ "Why do you call Me, 'Lord, Lord,' and do not do what I say?
Luke 6:47 "Everyone who comes to Me and hears My words and acts on them, I will show you whom he is like:
Luke 6:48 he is like a man building a house, who dug deep and laid a foundation on the rock; and when a flood occurred, the torrent burst against that house and could not shake it, because it had been well built.
Luke 6:49 "But the one who has heard and has not acted *accordingly*, is like a man who built a house on the ground without any foundation; and the torrent burst against it and immediately it collapsed, and the ruin of that house was great."

- Finally, Jesus ends this discourse with some of the most sobering verses in the chapter
  - He asks why would someone call Him Lord, Lord but not do as He says?
    - In Jesus day, the title Lord was actually common in Judaism
    - Disciples often called their teacher Lord, or any man of authority was often called Lord out of respect
    - Not everyone who called Jesus Lord meant it as we do today…some simple used it as a title of respect
- This was to be a central problem for the disciples in Jesus day
  - As they began to go out and plant the early church, they would often be confronted with men who were much like the Pharisees
    - Just as the Pharisees approached Jesus at times and called him Rabbi or even Lord, they didn't mean it the way they should

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- And just as with the false teachers, Jesus says those who are truly his followers can be known by their actions
    - There are two kinds of people in the world
        - There are those who hear the words of the Gospel – the words of Jesus – and they base all their hope and trust for eternity in those words
        - And that trust, having been placed in the right thing, it's unshakable
        - There is nothing that can undo the work of trust God has done in the heart of a true believer
        - And shaken, their faith will be
            - These disciples will go through tremendous trials before the end of their lives, and yet their faith having been secured to the rock, Christ, will not be shaken
            - Still others will not trust in what they hear
            - They will not follow Jesus words
            - Though they call Him Lord, they are not truly His
            - And when persecution comes, they will fall away, proving that they were not genuine in the first place
- In talking about these same people, Matt adds these interesting verses:

Matt. 7:21 ¶ "Not everyone who says to Me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter the kingdom of heaven, but he who does the will of My Father who is in heaven *will enter*.
Matt. 7:22 "Many will say to Me on that day, 'Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in Your name, and in Your name cast out demons, and in Your name perform many miracles?'
Matt. 7:23 "And then I will declare to them, 'I never knew you; DEPART FROM ME, YOU WHO PRACTICE LAWLESSNESS.'

- The thing that strikes me here about these verses is the sincerity of those who are perishing
    - They are sure they were going to be saved
    - They were able to perform miracles in His name to some degree – perhaps with supernatural power made possible by the demonic realm

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- And they also claim to have had prophecy
- But they are found to be unbelievers in the end…
- And once again, what does Jesus point to as evidence of the fact that they never knew him
  - That word for knew is the same word used to describe the kind intimate knowledge a husband has of his wife
  - This is not merely knowledge of someone in the sense of having heard of them or studied them,
  - It means a close personal relationship

- Folks, there will be people surprised to learn that they are not Christians
  - And they can be known now for they will be those who say Lord, Lord and do not follow what Christ says
  - They are those who never knew Him
  - And Jesus wanted his disciples to understand that these people would exist just as surely as those who might teach in God's name but in fact teach falsely
  - Ad in both cases, they can be known by their fruit, that they practiced lawlessness and were hypocrites

- Where are you today? Can you say that your life is a picture of Jesus teaching?
  - Do we call him Lord on Sunday, and live a life that looks like the unbelieving world the rest of the week?
  - It's not our actions that save us, that we know, but Jesus says it is our behavior that reveals our hearts. What is your behavior saying about your heart this morning?

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Luke 7A

- At the conclusion of Luke 6, Jesus had just finished His sermon – the sermon commonly call the Sermon on the Mount
    - Though the Sermon was addressed to the crowd overall, it was specially intended for the disciples
        - They've been receiving their crash course in righteousness training in preparation for the work to come in establishing the early church
        - During the course of this training, Jesus has taught on forgiveness, judgment, and the need to discern true followers and true teachers from the false ones
- Each of his lessons turned on its head some custom or teaching common to the day and common to the scribes and Pharisees of Jesus' day
    - So Jesus was not only preparing the disciples with the truth – He was also countering the misteaching of those false leaders
- Yet if Jesus had been satisfied with merely explaining the truth concerning righteousness, it's possible the disciples may never have been able to carry out their commission to spread the gospel
    - Because in addition to correcting their view on righteousness, Jesus still had to correct another major misconception held by all the disciples
    - But this new area of confusion was so strongly held – so deeply entrenched in Jewish culture, it could only be addressed through example
        - Mere teaching alone could never hope to correct it
        - And unless this error was addressed, Jesus knew the disciples could never fully comply with the Great Commission to bring the Good news to all the earth
    - In fact some of the disciples are so reluctant to let go of their past teaching on this issue and embrace what Jesus demonstrates that some of them, including Peter himself, will continue to struggle with it even after Jesus is crucified

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- So what was this new teaching that Jesus was to demonstrate to the disciples?
    - It was that God was about to set aside for a time the special distinction of being Jew and in it's place would emerge a gathering believers, both Jew and Gentile
    - Even more radically, with this change comes the end of the Law for all who believe

Luke 7:1 ¶ When He had completed all His discourse in the hearing of the people, He went to Capernaum.
Luke 7:2 ¶ And a centurion's slave, who was highly regarded by him, was sick and about to die.
Luke 7:3 When he heard about Jesus, he sent some Jewish elders asking Him to come and save the life of his slave.
Luke 7:4 When they came to Jesus, they earnestly implored Him, saying, "He is worthy for You to grant this to him;
Luke 7:5 for he loves our nation and it was he who built us our synagogue."

- Jesus ends His discourse, and returns to Capernaum
    - It's interesting to me that Jesus moves back and forth through a relatively small area of the Galilee during these early periods of His ministry
    - And it's worth remembering that earlier Luke recorded how Jesus was able to perform many miracles in Capernaum due to the faith and response of the people there
        - In contrast He wasn't able to perform many miracles in Nazareth for exactly the opposite reason
    - And this is at least the third time in Luke's gospel we've heard of Jesus entering Capernaum
- At first it seems that Jesus has no plan at all
    - He just wanders aimlessly from spot to spot – teach a little, move on , turn around, go back, etc.
    - If He were running His ministry this way today, He'd probably be given all kinds of advice on how to run His ministry more effectively

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        - You need a 5-year plan
        - You need goals and ways to measure your goals, etc.
        - Of course, there are advantages to being well organized and deliberate in your approach to ministry, but when does planning begin to replace reliance on the Holy Spirit for day-to-day direction?
        - What if He directed you to go somewhere other than where your 5-year plan was trying to take you?

- In Jesus ministry, we see a perfect embodiment of following the Spirit
    - And consider what it looks like from the standpoint of worldly values
        - He wandered, he had no vision, no plan
        - Sometimes follow God's direction won't look like the world expects it to look

John 3:8 "The wind blows where it wishes and you hear the sound of it, but do not know where it comes from and where it is going; so is everyone who is born of the Spirit."

- By the way, even though everything Jesus did during His earthly ministry was according to the Father's will and purposes, we shouldn't discount the sheer practicality of it either
    - Jesus went where His ministry was most effective – where He was received and His message bore fruit
        - He went to Capernaum because He could discern by the fruit it bore that this was the town where the Holy Spirit was at work
        - He didn't go back to Nazareth because of opposite condition – no fruit
        - And we should do the same thing
- Effective ministry depends entirely on the Father to work through His Holy Spirit in the hearts of men
    - So if we depend on the Holy Spirit to actually accomplish anything in ministry, it only makes sense to go where we see Him at work
    - And this is what Jesus is doing

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        - But neither can we get our mind so focused on our plans that we forget to follow the Spirit when he turns to a new direction
            - Like following the wind
            - We have to constantly be seeking the wind, looking for evidence of where it's going

- So Jesus goes into Capernaum again
- As He enters the town, a group of Jewish elders approached Jesus and asked Him to come heal a Roman centurion's slave
    - This is a bold request by the centurion
    - He really had little reason to expect this rabbi's help
    - A centurion was a noncommissioned officer in the Roman army and usually commanded about 100 men
        - Men would enlist in the army and remain for 25 years in order to receive Roman citizenship
        - And they were often hard men who had a hard life and low wages
        - But within their area of control they could wield significant power and authority
        - And it wasn't uncommon for a man in this position to use his authority to extort the local population – taking bribes, kick backs and other means if augmenting their income
- So for a Jewish rabbi, an occupying Roman soldier - a Gentile, a man who oppressed them and took their money - was hardly someone deserving of his mercy
    - Jesus was no ordinary Jewish rabbi and this man was no ordinary soldier
    - He was well respected and as the elders testify, he helped the Jews in his region
        - Helping Jews was smart politically, but in this case it was also clearly a sign of faith in the Jewish God
        - In fact, he is said to love the Jewish nation

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- We're told that this centurion has a slave that he cares greatly for
    - In fact, in verse 7 he uses a word for servant that can also be translated as son – it's an enduring term
    - Apparently, the elders must have taken pity on the centurion and perhaps they tell him about this amazing rabbi who's traveling around the region performing miraculous healings
    - Naturally, the centurion asks the elders if they could convince Jesus to come heal the slave
        - The fact that he uses the elders to seek after Jesus is part due to humility (as he mentions later) but it's a humility that comes from the distinction of Jew verses Gentile
        - The centurion would have imagined that no self respecting rabbi would come to the home of a Gentile, much less a Roman soldier
        - His only hope – and it was a small one – was that the rabbi could be persuaded by the appeal of Jewish elders
- As you study this account, remember that the disciples would have been thinking exactly the same thing
    - It's probably hard for us to fully appreciate the perspective of a 1st century Jew regarding gentiles
    - A Jew believed that by God's promise to Abraham, He had set apart the Jewish people forever – the descendents of Isaac – and that no other people could ever receive God's blessings
    - That all non Jews – gentiles – were condemned simply by virtue of not having been born Jew
    - This is an incomplete understanding of scripture, and though we don't have time this morning to explore all the reasons why that view is wrong according to scripture, we should at least understand some of the problems this view created for the Jews
        - First, it led them to see all other men as scum – unworthy of their compassion or even their fellowship
            - Consider how the elders try to convince Jesus to come to this man's aid:

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- They felt compelled to list reasons why he has earned their favor

- Secondly, it gave the Jew a sense of entitlement with regard to eternal matters

  - A Jew was saved simply because they were born Jew

  - We saw a hint of this earlier in this gospel when we taught on John the Baptist

  - The Pharisees at the river

Luke 3:8 "Therefore bear fruits in keeping with repentance, and do not begin to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham for our father,' for I say to you that from these stones God is able to raise up children to Abraham.

- In Matt's gospel account of the centurion, He records these words of Jesus following the centurion's show of faith

Matt. 8:11 "I say to you that many will come from east and west, and recline *at the table* with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven;
Matt. 8:12 but the sons of the kingdom will be cast out into the outer darkness; in that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth."

- Finally, their was an additional complicating factor mixed into this incorrect Jewish perspective

  - The Jew also understood the law was given to the Jewish nation – and no one else – because it was the secret recipe for getting to heaven

  - So Jews would work tirelessly trying to keep the law in order to make themselves righteous – and they lived a life of works as a result

- Remember, it's not just the Jewish leaders who think like this – most Jews more or less thought like this – including the disciples

  - It's how they've been trained – it's all around them in the culture

- Through this centurion's request, Jesus gets the opportunity to demonstrate a compassionate response to gentiles

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- And it's a perfect opportunity – because you couldn't do much worse in a Jew's eyes than a Roman soldier

- So Jesus starts off for the house, but before He gets there, the centurion himself comes out to intercept Jesus

Luke 7:6 Now Jesus *started* on His way with them; and when He was not far from the house, the centurion sent friends, saying to Him, "Lord, do not trouble Yourself further, for I am not worthy for You to come under my roof;
Luke 7:7 for this reason I did not even consider myself worthy to come to You, but *just* say the word, and my servant will be healed.
Luke 7:8 "For I also am a man placed under authority, with soldiers under me; and I say to this one, 'Go!' and he goes, and to another, 'Come!' and he comes, and to my slave, 'Do this!' and he does it."
Luke 7:9 Now when Jesus heard this, He marveled at him, and turned and said to the crowd that was following Him, "I say to you, not even in Israel have I found such great faith."
Luke 7:10 When those who had been sent returned to the house, they found the slave in good health.

- He says that He is not worthy for Jesus to come to his home – Jesus could heal the slave from where He stood – without ever having to be with the slave

  - Before Jesus can respond, the centurion feels compelled to explain his thinking

    - He says that he knows that Jesus can heal the slave simply by His word

      - He goes on to explain that he himself was a man under authority

      - Moreover, he also had men under his authority – so he understood better than most how real authority works

      - Real authority can accomplish something merely by a word – a command

      - And everything that is under that authority will respond to that word

- If you have been in authority, you understand this idea clearly

  - Parents, when kids are little, how do you measure whether they respect your authority? By whether they obey your word (the first time)

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- And how do you know when your authority over your children is waning – when a child no longer heeds your words
- Or as a former military officer, I can tell you that in times of conflict, a leader's authority must be unquestioned, his word must be obeyed without hesitation or lives can be lost
- Remember even in the beginning, all creation came to be merely on the power of God's word – and Jesus is the embodiment of the Word for us
- So real authority – and respect for that authority - is not demonstrated by might – rather it is most clearly seen when a mere word results in the desired outcome

- So what does it mean that this centurion told Jesus to simply give His word and he knew the slave would be healed?
  - Simply, it means that he believed in the power of Jesus' word – the word of God
  - Notice that he begins in humility admitting his own unworthy – perhaps a sign that he was experiencing the repentance brought by the Holy Spirit
  - Then he said he demonstrated what kind of authority Jesus had – that he had authority over the body of a man –
    - Something only the body's Creator could claim to have
  - In a word, this man had faith – faith that Jesus had authority over the creation and could exercise that authority with only his word
- Do you know the Biblical definition of faith?
  - We started by looking at the description of faith given in Hebrews 11:1

Heb. 11:1 ¶ Now faith is the assurance of *things* hoped for, the conviction of things not seen.

    - Faith is a trust in something completely without tangible proof
  - Then we considered what Paul gives us in Rom 8:24

Rom. 8:24 For in hope we have been saved, but hope that is seen is not hope; for who hopes for what he *already* sees?

    - Paul reminds us that if what we have faith in can be seen, it's not faith at all – it's merely self-evident

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        - True faith begins before proof arrives – because it is a future looking expectation

    - Ultimately, we come to the conclusion that faith is believing in God's promises – taking Him at His word

        - And then living your life in such a way that it demonstrates outwardly your trust in God's promises – in His word

- So, what would you say about this centurion's view of Jesus?

    - Well, Jesus said it Himself – no one in Israel had yet shown even this much faith

        - Jesus isn't just complimenting this man's understanding of Jesus' power

        - He's remarking on his willingness to live according to his faith

- And there's the true lesson who us in this account

    - Let's face it…when it comes to our faith, words are cheap

        - People can say they believe in a lot of things – usually things they can see or control (I believe in myself)

            - That's not true belief

        - We can say we believe in the gospel and in Christ's words concerning how we live or how we treat one another

            - But how do we actually live?

            - That's the test of whether our faith is real

- There's a term that's been coined recently by people who study trends in society and religion

    - The term is nominal Christian

    - The word nominal comes form the Latin root nomen which means name

    - It means "in name only" – Christians who are Christian in name only

    - The term was coined because in recent decades the researchers have concluded that there are far more people willing to call themselves

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Christians when responding to surveys than are truly Christians in the Biblical sense of the word

- So, today we have Christians and nominal Christians
    - How do you know the difference? Well, we can't know perfectly this side of heaven – only God knows
        - But one way we can get a good idea is to consider how they live their lives
        - I'm sure we can all imagine what it might look like to be a nominal Christian
            - They call themselves Christians, but they don't particularly care to attend the gathering of believers on a regular basis
            - They don't serve the Body with their gifts or offerings
            - They don't pray, they don't study the Bible
            - They make no effort whatsoever to conform their lives to Jesus' teachings or the expectations of scripture
            - And while some people who do these things are true believers who are living in complete rebellion, I would say that most probably never were believers at all
    - Now we are not made believers by our behavior and we're not in danger of ceasing to be believers because of our behavior
        - But consider this: those nominal Christians really think they're Christians – they're just as sure about themselves as you are about yourself
        - So just to be sure we're not one of those nominal Christians and don't know it, maybe we ought to be willing to subject ourselves to the same test that Jesus is applying here: are you living a life that reflect the faith you claim?
        - Do you trust in Jesus word or do you demand proof at every turn?
        - Can he give you His word through the scripture, and that be enough for you to respond

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        - Are you bothered when your life doesn't fall into line with God's word? Or do you make excuses for why your way is better

        - To be sure it's a hard test, because if we're truthful, we all fail it somewhere – fortunately, there's a big difference between being a perfect Christian and a nominal Christian

- But what of the disciples at this point?

    - Jesus has probably rocked their world a bit

    - Not only has He consented to visit a Gentile and then proceeded to heal his slave

    - He also credited this gentile as having the more faith than all Israel

    - We can't begin to imagine the dumbfounded look that must have been on the disciples faces at that moment

        - The gospel was to be preached to all the nations of the world – not just to Jews

        - And the reason it was to be preached far and wide is because God intended to send His Holy Spirit far and wide as well – to prompt men into a response of faith

        - And here was an early proof for the disciples of God's purposes to bring gentiles to faith

- This will remain a difficult concept for the disciples to grasp even in the years of the early church

    - It's so difficult in fact, that in Acts chapter 10, there is an account of the apostle Peter receiving a dream from God

    - In the dream, Peter is commanded to kill and eat a host of unclean animals – animals forbidden to be eaten under the law

    - Peter protests and declares that he has never broken the law in this way

    - But God tells him that what God has made clean he should not regard as unclean – so Peter takes this sign as license to finally minister to gentiles

- Later in Acts 11, Peter testifies before the other leaders in Jerusalem that gentiles were receiving the gospel gladly

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- But some church leaders still can't accept God would save Gentiles
- So Peter recounts his dream and says that if God intends to bring faith to Gentiles, who was he to stand in the way
- And the crowd reacts this way:

Acts 11:18 When they heard this, they quieted down and glorified God, saying, "Well then, God has granted to the Gentiles also the repentance *that leads* to life."

- You see, Peter was there to hear Jesus' teaching in Luke 6 and he was here to witness Jesus healing the centurion's slave and when Jesus did all His other miracles among the gentiles
  - But nevertheless, God still had to convince Peter of the fact that gentiles could be included in the plan of salvation
  - Next week, Jesus tackles what was probably even more difficult for the disciples – the fading nature of the Jewish law
- Today we have the opportunity to demonstrate our trust in Christ's words by showing obedience to one of His command - to share in communion
  - Jesus commanded his disciples to keep only two practices: baptism and communion
  - Both depict our new life in Christ
    - Baptism demonstrates our raising from the dead to a new live in Christ
    - And communion is our opportunity to remember that our new life comes from and is sustained in Christ – the One Who is the bread of life and who's blood guarantees that promise of eternal life
    - So we celebrate communion here our of obedience to our Lord
- If you are a believer in Jesus – if you trust in Him for your eternal salvation – then join us in this celebration by testifying to that belief through the taking of communion
  - For those with young children, I leave it with you to decide whether taking communion is appropriate for them
  - And if you aren't a believer, well it's not too late

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- If you know in your heart that the things you've heard here are true
  - That Jesus was God born as man
  - That He was sent by the Father to receive the Father's wrath for men's sins so that men might have the hope of glory in heaven
  - That when He died on the cross, your sins were judged and the penalty paid
  - Now all that's left is for you to accept this substitution
  - If you do, then God credits Jesus' payment to your account
  - But if you don't, God leave it to you to pay for your own sin – the payment He requires is eternal death – eternal separation from glory – Hell we call it

- So if you know these things are true, then confess it
  - As we close in prayer, join me and confess your faith to God and then demonstrate it to us in taking communion

Daniel prepares to play for us while we conduct communion

The elders will distribute the elements

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Luke 7B

- Christ's ministry on earth was first and foremost about suffering and dying for the sins of the World
    - But as Jesus went through the course of His earthly life, He was also using the time He had with His disciples to prepare them for His departure – and for their own ministries in telling the world about Jesus
    - That preparation had two parts – much like how we train people today
        - First came the didactic part – lecture or classroom training
        - But Jesus also took many opportunities to provide a second kind of training which reinforced the first
        - He often demonstrated the truth of His teaching by how He lived out His ministry
    - In Chapter 6 of Luke, we saw the didactic training begin, and it will continue all the way to the cross
    - And last week in Chapter 7, Jesus begins to provide the first of many demonstrations of these truths in His ministry
- Last week, we saw Jesus demonstrate that all men deserved God's mercy, even Gentiles – and all would enter on the basis of faith in the Messiah
    - Jesus having praise the Roman soldier for displaying a faith greater than anyone in Israel in that day
- Today we continue in Chapter 7 as Jesus moves to a new practical demonstration – the reality that the Law has not a means to righteousness
    - In fact, The Law stands in the way of God's mercy for those who misunderstand its purpose
    - And Jesus' demonstration takes place through the raising of a young boy from the dead

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Luke 7:11 ¶ Soon afterwards He went to a city called Nain; and His disciples were going along with Him, accompanied by a large crowd.
Luke 7:12 Now as He approached the gate of the city, a dead man was being carried out, the only son of his mother, and she was a widow; and a sizeable crowd from the city was with her.
Luke 7:13 When the Lord saw her, He felt compassion for her, and said to her, "Do not weep."

- Jesus leaves Capernaum again and this times he goes Southwest about 20 miles to a town in the Jezreel Valley called Nain
    - The town was located on a hill called the Hill of Moreh or Har-Moreh
        - Travel along a connecting road about 10 miles you reach another hill, called Meggido
        - Armeggedon
    - Har-Moreh has some significance in the OT, as it was the site where Elisha brought the son of a Shunammite woman back to life (2King 4)
    - Jesus must have understood the connection as he used this site for His first recorded raising of the dead
- You should also notice in Luke's description that Jesus is now continually followed by large crowds
    - Luke mentions that there are disciples and a large crowd in verse 11
    - Jesus was a spectacle now and His reputation eliminated any chance that he might travel incognito
        - As we've been doing already, then, it's important to take time to understand whether Jesus teaching is directed specifically at the disciples, the crowd or both
        - Sometimes the message can be different for the two different audiences
- The scene plays out in a straightforward manner
    - You have Jesus approaching the gate of the town of Nain
        - This gate would have been the only way into and out of the town, as it was surrounded by a wall for protection

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        - The other thing to know about ancient culture was they buried their dead outside the city walls
        - There was no space within the tight confines of the city for a cemetery
    - So essentially, Jesus is almost forced into contact with the funeral procession as they leave the town carrying the body prepared for burial
        - Their encounter in this moment creates an opportunity for Jesus to teach the disciples and the crowd another object lesson in true righteousness
- Jesus encounters the woman and this large funeral party proceeding out the gate
    - Because the procession is leaving the city, we know the body has been prepared for burial
        - It is wrapped in cloths, covered in drying powders like Myrrh
        - Which means the body has been dead for a day or two by now
        - To everyone involved in this funeral, there's no doubt this body is dead
- Luke tells us that the body is that of a man, the only son of a widow
    - This is a significant detail, because it ties the events of this moment to the events of 2Kings 4 & 1Kings 17
        - Which then sets up a series of events later in this chapter
    - Meanwhile, it adds emphasis to the suffering of this woman
        - A widow in that culture was a very vulnerable person
        - And if she was without a son to care for her, she was likely to live out her days begging or struggling to find a way to feed herself
    - And this detail helps explain Jesus compassion for this woman
    - But it was just as significant that Jesus even stopped to notice this woman and take pity
- Think about what it says about that society to know that a widow was the most vulnerable member of society

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- Consider for a moment that the society had so little regard for it's most vulnerable members that as a widow, unless you had a son to care for you, you might starve to death

- The entire story of Ruth exists in part because of this weakness in that culture

    - Compassion in the Jewish culture was a rare commodity

        - They were not accustomed to showing mercy and compassion,

        - They were the "eye for an eye, tooth for a tooth" culture

    - Their misuse and interpretation law had left them with a harsh, unforgiving , uncompassionate, judgmental view of life

        - Just as any legalistic approach to righteousness will do

- And so widows who were left without sons were simply being "judged by God" or were paying the price for their parents sin, etc.

        - Even the fact that there were many mourners in the procession and yet she was destitute and facing dire economic circumstances says a lot about how hard hearted these very religious people had become

- Then Jesus comes along,

    - He not only takes notice of this woman, but Luke tells us He had compassion on her – more importantly, compassion that rose to the level of taking action to help her

    - I'm sure many of the mourners in the procession had compassion of sorts for this woman, but it's doubtful any were willing to take her in and help her

- James wrote his letter because of this very problem carrying over from the Jewish culture into the early Christian church

    - Despite their profession of faith in Christ, they continued to be hard hearted toward one another

    - James was so concerned about this pattern, that he felt it put into question whether they were truly saved

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James 2:14 ¶ What use is it, my brethren, if someone says he has faith but he has no works? Can that faith save him?
James 2:15 If a brother or sister is without clothing and in need of daily food,
James 2:16 and one of you says to them, "Go in peace, be warmed and be filled," and yet you do not give them what is necessary for *their* body, what use is that?
James 2:17 Even so faith, if it has no works, is dead, *being* by itself.

- Just as when Jesus walked the earth, He still desires to show compassion to the least fortunate today, but He desires to do it through His Church
- And when His church merely shows compassion through words, it is no compassion at all
  - And James says that if a professing Christian lives their life that way – without visible compassion for the needs of others –
    - We have reason to question the legitimacy – or at least the usefulness - of their faith
  - What made Jesus compassion known was His willingness to act upon it – unlike the others around the widow who wouldn't do more than simply what was required by tradition

- Let's take note ourselves of Jesus as a compassionate Lord
  - It's easy to speak in compassionate words, to tell people that we'll pray for them, to go through the motions of obligatory protocol much like those mourners
  - But Jesus demonstrates what true compassion looks like – and we are told to be like Him
    - So, let's take note of those God places in our path, those who may be the overlooked and vulnerable in our culture
      - Without judgment, without excuse
    - Help doesn't always mean money – in fact, it usually doesn't mean money
      - Don't look for the easy way out – like money to the street begger
      - Ex. Jesus giving money to the widow

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- Compassion means a true concern for their needs, help means giving of your time and talents, help means taking a real interest in them and their needs
    - But always with the purpose of teaching men about the Lord so they might know him
    - Sacks to the homeless example

- As we are faithful to imitating Christ in this way, God can be seen showing His compassion through Christ again – this time through Christ in us

- When Jesus encounters this funeral procession, He actually stops it so He can help

Luke 7:14 And He came up and touched the coffin; and the bearers came to a halt. And He said, "Young man, I say to you, arise!"
Luke 7:15 The dead man sat up and began to speak. And *Jesus* gave him back to his mother.
Luke 7:16 Fear gripped them all, and they *began* glorifying God, saying, "A great prophet has arisen among us!" and, "God has visited His people!"
Luke 7:17 This report concerning Him went out all over Judea and in all the surrounding district.

- Jesus notices the procession, learns the woman's situation, and then He does something calculated to shock the disciples and the crowd
    - He touches the body
        - In verse 14, Luke records that Jesus touched the coffin, but the word in Greek (soros) literally means bier, or the stretcher they carried the wrapped body on
        - So Jesus was literally touching the body itself

- Why is this so shocking?
    - By touching the body, Jesus had rendered himself ritually unclean
        - The law made this requirement in Numbers 19:

Num. 19:11 ¶ 'The one who touches the corpse of any person shall be unclean for seven days.
Num. 19:12 'That one shall purify himself from uncleanness with the water on the third day and on the seventh day, *and then* he will be clean; but if he does not purify himself on the third day and on the seventh day, he will not be clean.

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Num. 19:13 'Anyone who touches a corpse, the body of a man who has died, and does not purify himself, defiles the tabernacle of the LORD; and that person shall be cut off from Israel. Because the water for impurity was not sprinkled on him, he shall be unclean; his uncleanness is still on him.

- By touching the man, Jesus was in effect making a very powerful statement to His disciples even as He went about demonstrating His power over death to the crowd
    - How can we be so sure that Jesus had this idea on His mind in the midst of this moment?
    - Well, we need to consider what Matt records in his gospel as part of the beatitudes
- Remember, I said that Luke recorded significantly less of the beatitudes than did Luke, and in particular, Luke left out passages that dealt more directly with the Jewish culture
    - Matt on the other hand focused his attention on teachings that were especially important to his Jewish audience
        - Consequently, Matt's gospel includes a significant passage about the law,
    - And this teaching is helpful background to understanding Jesus action here in Nain

Matt. 5:17 ¶ "Do not think that I came to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I did not come to abolish but to fulfill.
Matt. 5:18 "For truly I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not the smallest letter or stroke shall pass from the Law until all is accomplished.
Matt. 5:19 "Whoever then annuls one of the least of these commandments, and teaches others *to do* the same, shall be called least in the kingdom of heaven; but whoever keeps and teaches *them*, he shall be called great in the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 5:20 ¶ "For I say to you that unless your righteousness surpasses *that* of the scribes and Pharisees, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven.

- This passage was a part of what Jesus had just taught the disciples shortly before making his trip to Capernaum and now Nain
    - In Matt's account, Jesus uses a kind of reverse psychology to make a point about the law to the disciples

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- He says, don't think I came to say that the law is wrong or that God is prepared to ignore it

- In verse 18 He says that the law will not pass away until all that is in it has been accomplished

  - This has two meanings

    - First, God must be satisfied according to His law

    - He cannot by His very nature accept imperfection without passing judgment upon imperfection

    - And He has given the law to represent a holy standard

      - The law wasn't meant to be the complete list of all that holiness requires, but yet it was a standard of holiness

      - We know from Jesus teaching that true holiness meets the conditions of the law and then goes further to include even our thoughts and desires

    - So the first meaning of Jesus statement is that until God is satisfied that all flesh is judged according to the law – either by receiving glory for having kept it perfectly or receiving wrath for having violated it – until then, the law will remain in effect

  - The second meaning is a bit more complex

    - The law was given as part of a covenant from God through Moses to the Israelite nation

    - That covenant provided for certain obligations on the part of the Lord and Israel

  - Only a portion of those obligations have been fulfilled, so it awaits a future time for this covenant to be completely fulfilled

    - It will not be fulfilled until the time of Tribulation and the conclusion of the end times

- But as I said, Jesus is making this reference in an ironic sense, because he is essentially saying that unless the disciples are able to live perfectly, they can't depend upon the law for righteousness

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- He says that if someone annuls - (luo) which means breaks – even one of these commandments, you will be least in the kingdom
- To further clarify, Jesus adds in the next verse that unless you can present yourself even more righteous than the scribes and Pharisees, you cannot enter heaven
    - Now keep in mind, Jesus knew that the S & P were not truly righteous people,
    - But since they were seen by the society as representing the height of righteousness, Jesus used that fact to help Him make His point
        - You have to be better than you think them to be
- Jesus wanted His disciples to understand the extremely tough standard required under the law for righteousness
    - It's not simply enough to be very good at keeping the law
    - Anyone wishing to enter heaven by the standard of the Law can't be nearly flawless at keeping the law
    - They would have to be perfect in keeping the law

- The Jews – like people today – had deluded themselves into thinking that God graded on the curve
    - Surely God would recognize their good efforts to be good – to keep the law
    - Oh sure, they had blown it here and there, but come on. God would be reasonable, surely
        - Scale in the sky idea today
- No, according to God, a man working his way to heaven would have to exceed even the Pharisees' efforts at keeping the law
    - And these men were commonly believed to be the gold standard in Jewish society when it came to keeping the law
        - They lived their entire public lives devoted to that task, but it wasn't good enough Jesus said
        - Well, that left them wondering where to go next

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- So, having just concluded a teaching in chapter 6 on the impossibility of using the law as a means of obtaining righteousness, here's Jesus…
    - A few days later, intentionally becoming ritually unclean in order to minister compassionately to a widow in need
        - And in doing so, Jesus shows through a demonstration what true righteousness looks like
        - It's love and compassion for another at the expense of self
    - You see, a Pharisee would never have done what Jesus did in raising that man
        - Even assuming it were possible for a Pharisee to raise a dead body to life, if exercising that power had required that a Pharisee physically touch the dead body, none would have dared do it
        - Because keeping the law was more important to a Pharisee than showing compassion, than ministering to others
        - This was the essential concern Christ had when he responded to the Pharisees' criticism at him dining with tax collectors at Matthew's house

Matt. 9:13 "But go and learn what this means: 'I DESIRE COMPASSION, AND NOT SACRIFICE,'

    - Jesus understood that the Law was not given to make men righteous
        - Not only were the religious leaders misusing it for exactly that purpose,
        - It also had the effect of becoming an excuse against doing the very thing that righteousness often required – showing mercy and compassion
- And that's where the heart of the lesson was for the disciples and for us
    - Jesus was tearing down – brick by brick – the wall of separation that existed between the unholy works of selfish men and the true righteousness of God
        - The disciples needed to understand that the law couldn't make them righteous,

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        - But more than that, Jesus wanted to demonstrate how any attempt to use the Law in that way actually yields the opposite result

            - It becomes a way of pitting men against men

        - Because when it's used to measure men against one another, it robs everyone of compassion and mercy and love and replaces it with judgment, piousness and pride

- When men concentrate all their attention on trying to make themselves righteous by works – it results in a self-centered life absent any compassion or mercy – it is a self-centered pursuit

    - In an economy of works, the participants will always have a selfish outlook on the world

        - Everything they do is connected to making themselves look and feel righteous

        - There is no room for compassion and mercy

        - There is not concern for the world – only for self

    - Meanwhile, those who don't measure up to the rules are seen as deserving whatever bad comes their way

        - And we certainly don't owe them any compassion

    - Consider people you have known – whether Christian or not – who you would consider very rule-oriented, very legalistic in the practice of their faith – perhaps even people who are works-based in their religious beliefs

    - Now consider whether they are also relatively low in compassion and mercy for those they see as unrighteous

        - Are they quick to judge and condemn others

        - Are they often very self-absorbed in their own pursuits, especially pursuits that they believe are closely connected to their own righteousness, of what's right according to their system of beliefs

    - This is the nature effect of allowing our standard of righteousness be based on our actions, on a living out of the law – any law – regardless of how well-meaning it might be

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- Such a viewpoint is simply the opposite of grace in all respects
  - Consider that grace begins with compassion, because it is unearned favor
  - By definition, grace is an expression of mercy, because it seeks to give something that is undeserved
  - Grace precludes all judgment and condemnation, even though they are deserved
  - Grace can never be self-focused, because it is inherently motivated by a consideration for the needs of others
    - And it requires placing the needs of the other above any desire to demand retribution
- Jesus just taught in chapter 6 that our obligation to show others grace in this way comes from the fact that God was the one who first showed us grace, a grace we can never equal in all that we might forgive of others

- So Jesus touched the body to show His compassion and to demonstrate the importance of love over law
  - But don't assume that Jesus had violated the law by His actions
    - The Law didn't prohibit touching a body
    - It just demanded purification over three days afterward
  - So we would have expected Jesus to follow that requirement…except
    - Jesus may not have had to purify Himself in this case, because at the point when He touched the body and spoke the words, the man returned to life
    - So who could say that Jesus had come into contact with a dead body – where's the proof?
- And as the body rose up, the text says fear gripped the crowd…no doubt
  - Can you imagine? This would be fear in the truest form
  - Fear over the mystery of Jesus and His power and who He might be
  - Look at their statements

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- Some said a great prophet has risen among us
    - There's little doubt that this statement is connected to Elisha's famous miracle on this Hill centuries earlier
    - What Jesus had just done echoed Elijah and Elisha's miracles in several ways
        - Not only was did it occur in roughly the same location as Elisha's miracle, but it involved a woman receiving back her only son as in Elijah's miracle
    - So some of the people naturally began to believe this was the promised return of Elijah from Malachi
- Others said it was God visiting his people
    - This statement is interesting because it sounds so similar to prophetic description of the Messiah – Immanuel from Isaiah 7:14 which means God with us
    - This seems to be the earliest possible indication that people had begun to suggest that Jesus might be the Messiah
    - And this report goes out to the surrounding countryside

o And that's why we hear what Luke records next…

Luke 7:18 ¶ The disciples of John reported to him about all these things.
Luke 7:19 Summoning two of his disciples, John sent them to the Lord, saying, "Are You the Expected One, or do we look for someone else?"
Luke 7:20 When the men came to Him, they said, "John the Baptist has sent us to You, to ask, 'Are You the Expected One, or do we look for someone else?'"
Luke 7:21 At that very time He cured many *people* of diseases and afflictions and evil spirits; and He gave sight to many *who were* blind.
Luke 7:22 And He answered and said to them, "Go and report to John what you have seen and heard: *the* BLIND RECEIVE SIGHT, *the* lame walk, *the* lepers are cleansed, and *the* deaf hear, *the* dead are raised up, *the* POOR HAVE THE GOSPEL PREACHED TO THEM.
Luke 7:23 "Blessed is he who does not take offense at Me."

- John and his disciples heard the reports of Jesus, reports that must have included the suggestion from verse 16 that Jesus was the Messiah

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- Then John does something that seems a bit odd
- He sends two of his disciples to ask Jesus if He was the Expected One (erchomai) which literally means Coming One
  - Well, there was only one who was called the Coming One in Jewish culture
  - John the Baptist was talking about the One promised by the prophets to come to rescue His people
  - The Messiah, in other words
- What's curious about this is why John the Baptist would need to ask this question
  - Why would he be asking Jesus about His identity now?
  - Didn't he recognize who Jesus was when he baptized Him?
  - And the obvious answer, is no
- John the Baptist must have understood that Jesus was a special person, sent by God and holy
  - He may even have suspected that Jesus was the Messiah, but now he asks outright
  - And it's important to note that John's motives in asking are genuine
    - He says, are you the one, or should we continue waiting for someone else?
    - His desire is to know so that he may follow the correct person, be it Jesus or someone else

- And then notice Jesus' answer
  - He says plainly, tell John the Baptist that you've seen the proof
    - The Blind can see and the lame walk, the lepers are cured and the gospel (good news) is proclaimed
    - Jesus is reminded them of Isaiah's prophecies concerning the Expected One, the Messiah

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- It begins in Isaiah 35

Is. 35:4 Say to those with anxious heart,
"Take courage, fear not.
Behold, your God will come *with* vengeance;
The recompense of God will come,
But He will save you."

Is. 35:5 Then the eyes of the blind will be opened
And the ears of the deaf will be unstopped.

Is. 35:6 Then the lame will leap like a deer,
And the tongue of the mute will shout for joy.
For waters will break forth in the wilderness
And streams in the Arabah.

- Then it goes on to Isaiah 61

Is. 61:1 ¶ The Spirit of the Lord GOD is upon me,
Because the LORD has anointed me
To bring good news to the afflicted;
He has sent me to bind up the brokenhearted,
To proclaim liberty to captives
And freedom to prisoners;

- Jesus is giving John the answer he desires – and establishes that he is not just a prophet, He is not Elisha, He is the Annointed One, the Messiah.
    - And as we will see in coming chapters, Jesus is not so willing to answer so plainly to others who come asking the same question but with false motives
    - God desires to reveal Himself to the world but He is not going to do in their terms
    - He requires a humble heart first, a heart made ready for the good news, just as John the Baptist called people to make their hearts ready in his day
    - This is a wonderful point for us as well as we enter Christmas
    - Blessed is the he who does not take offense at Christ

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- Let's leave here ready to enter a world that celebrates Christmas but takes offense at Christ
- Let's bring them the good news, and more than that, demonstrate it through a love that shows compassion and mercy and grace

- And as Peter says, always *be* ready to *give* a defense to everyone who asks you a reason for the hope that is in you, with meekness and fear

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Luke 7C

- In Luke 12:51 Jesus says this:

Luke 12:51 "Do you suppose that I came to grant peace on earth? I tell you, no, but rather division;
Luke 12:52 for from now on five *members* in one household will be divided, three against two and two against three.
Luke 12:53 "They will be divided, father against son and son against father, mother against daughter and daughter against mother, mother-in-law against daughter-in-law and daughter-in-law against mother-in-law."

- It's a provocative statement, wouldn't you agree?
    - It causes us to pause at first, questioning whether He really meant what He said
    - Especially at Christmas, when we remember Christ's birth we sing, Peace on earth and goodwill to men
    - And yet Christ said his arrival would not bring peace but rather division
- Although we'll study the full meaning of this statement in a few weeks when we approach Chap 12, we will begin to understand it even today as we finish Chap 7
    - Luke story of Jesus follows several storylines or themes simultaneously
        - Last two weeks we watched as he demonstrated to his apostles the truth of what He had taught them in Chap 6 during the sermon on the mount
        - But then he is interrupted by the visit from John the Baptist's disciples, who ask Jesus to confirm that he was the Messiah who has come to fulfill prophecy
        - These events follow Luke's storyline of how Jesus prepared the disciples for their eventual ministry
    - But now Luke is ready to bring an earlier theme back to the foreground – his emphasis on the battle between Jesus and the religious leaders of the day who rejected Jesus ministry

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- Watching these groups plot and scheme against Jesus will become an increasingly important theme for Luke, but for now we're still in the early stages

Luke 7:24 ¶ When the messengers of John had left, He began to speak to the crowds about John, "What did you go out into the wilderness to see? A reed shaken by the wind?
Luke 7:25 "But what did you go out to see? A man dressed in soft clothing? Those who are splendidly clothed and live in luxury are *found* in royal palaces!
Luke 7:26 "But what did you go out to see? A prophet? Yes, I say to you, and one who is more than a prophet.
Luke 7:27 "This is the one about whom it is written,
'BEHOLD, I SEND MY MESSENGER AHEAD OF YOU,
WHO WILL PREPARE YOUR WAY BEFORE YOU.'
Luke 7:28 "I say to you, among those born of women there is no one greater than John; yet he who is least in the kingdom of God is greater than he."
Luke 7:29 When all the people and the tax collectors heard *this,* they acknowledged God's justice, having been baptized with the baptism of John.
Luke 7:30 But the Pharisees and the lawyers rejected God's purpose for themselves, not having been baptized by John.

- Remember, Jesus had entered Nain and raised a dead boy, causing fear among the people
    - Then word of this miracle made it's way to John, who is still near the Jordon river, presumably baptizing
    - And that prompted John to send his messengers to Jesus
    - It must have been sometime after Jesus had performed the resurrection that John's disciples had made it to Nain – at least a few days if not longer
- So as they arrive, they no doubt find Jesus in the midst of a crowd, as He was virtually all the time now
    - They ask their question, which Jesus answers by continuing to perform miracles within the crowd that's gathered
    - And now that they've left, He turns His attention back to the crowd
    - And He uses the occasion of John's disciples interruption to begin teaching the crowd again

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- Jesus turns the crowd and asks, sarcastically, what did they you go into the wilderness to see? In other words, what was their interest with John the Baptist? Who do they think he is?
    - The crowd had just heard Jesus answer John's question concerning His identity, but He did so in a veiled way
        - Those who knew God's word and believed in it would have instantly recognized the meaning of Jesus' answer – His answer being the nature of His miracles
        - But the rest of the crowd would have not understood the exchange
    - Now Jesus plans to put the crowd on the spot concerning their understand of the meaning of all these events
        - He asks if they thought they would see a reed shaken in the wind?
            - The word for reed is kalamos – like the tall, hollow grass reeds that grow by a river
            - In Greek mythology, there was a tale of two young boys who were close friends, names Karpos and Kalamos – who spent all their time playing together
            - One day, Karpos falls in the river and drowns
            - And in his grief, Kalamos turns into a water reed, and the myth says that the mournful song made by the wind rustling through the water reeds is Kalamos mourning his lost friend
    - Jesus is making a play on the word Kalamos when he calls John by that name
        - Just as a reed makes continuous noise as the wind blows in the wilderness, Jesus is asking the people if that's what they thought of John
        - Is he merely a noisemaker you came to observe and listen to – maybe like we slow down to see a car wreck on the freeway
    - Or perhaps they came to see a man dressed in fine clothing, Jesus asks sarcastically

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- A man of importance in his own right
- A celebrity, or a perhaps a religious leader
- Or a king, a new leader to support their particular political point of view
- Jesus rightly tells them that if that's who they're looking for, go check out the palace

- You see, Jesus knows the hearts of men – better then we know ourselves
  - When the men and women of Jesus day first heard of John the Baptist, they were curious and wanted to know more
    - But many of those who approached John at the side of the river were coming of reasons of their own
    - Some came for entertainment, the spectacle of a crazy man on the side of the river dunking perfectly clean people into a small dirty river
      - They cared little for his message, and none of its truth penetrated their cold, dead hearts
  - Then there were those who came down to see if John was the one they had been waiting for
    - The problem was, they were looking for the wrong thing
      - Some wanted a new political leader who would rise up and contend with Rome
      - Perhaps some wanted a new religious leadership who would agree with some particular point of view (Sag. Vs. Phar)
      - Perhaps others were simply looking for someone beautiful and charismatic to follow

- These desires are as old as the hills and as new as yesterday
  - Men and women today are exactly like the crowd who came down to see John
    - They have needs and desires, goals and agendas

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        - And when someone speaks up and brings a new message, everything that person says is filtered through the lens of their own desires

    - The news media loves to highlight the rapid growth of mega churches around the world

        - It's the latest phenomenon in the world – churches so big, drawing so many people, that they have to park in another zipcode

        - Now big isn't automatically a problem, of course

        - The crowds following Jesus were large, they reached sizes that must have rivaled even the biggest church today

            - Remember the story of Christ feeding the 5 thousand with fish and bread

            - The scripture says that the count was 5,000 men – plus the women and children

    - So large crowds are nothing new – but neither are all the reasons large crowds desire to gather around Jesus or his teaching

        - Just as Jesus accuses the crowd of following John for all the wrong reasons, it's no different today

        - People gather in churches every Sunday for all the wrong reasons

            - Jesus will be their source of wealth

            - Jesus will be their source for emotional comfort – something to use to escape the misery of the world

            - Jesus will be a social experience, an entertainment event – and the price is right

            - And as long a church doesn't ask much of the crowd, they stick around for the show

- But that's false religion – no different from any other

    - I guess if the choice is watching all those people sit at home on Sunday and watch football or going to a hindu temple or mosque, then sitting in a church for the wrong reason is certainly better

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- But it's a shame so many unbelievers can sit for so many years in so many churches and never feel any pressure to think differently much less act differently

- And Jesus isn't about to let this crowd get away easy

- Now that's he's chastised them for viewing John in all the wrong ways, He finally tells what they should think

  - He says that if they came to see a prophet, they were right

    - But John is more than just a prophet

    - Jesus quotes Malachi's prophecy that before the Messiah could come, another would precede him – a man who would come in the manner of Elijah

    - And Jesus is telling the crowd, this man John is the one Malachi spoke of..

  - John came as a forerunner to point people to the coming Messiah

    - John's importance was not his own – it was because of his association with the Messiah that John could be thought of as great

    - That's why Jesus says that he is more than just a prophet

    - John has the greatest honor among the old testament prophets, because he is the one with the privilege of introducing the savior of the world

    - Which should lead them to an obvious question – if John is the forerunner of the Messiah, then who is the Messiah?

- Remember, many of those who had originally come to hear John by the river, and had even been baptized, had now move on to following Jesus

  - After all, John the Baptist was good, but Jesus…

    - Jesus healed people, Jesus raised dead people, Jesus taught on dry land – no need to get wet

    - So now that Jesus was the big hit in this small region, John's ministry had dried up – so to speak

  - But it's so ironic in a way to see these people now following Jesus

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- John the Baptist was successful after all in gaining their attention – though many of them coming to John for the wrong reason – and then pointing them to Christ
- But the irony is that though they were directed to their Messiah by John, many of them aren't willing or able to recognize that Jesus is the Messiah
- Just as they came to John for the wrong reasons, they've now come to Christ for the wrong reasons.

- And Jesus knows that this crowd is fickle
  - That is includes both believers and those who are following Jesus for the wrong reasons
  - And look at the passage ends
    - Luke notes two different reactions to Jesus words
    - There are those who accepted the baptism of John
      - A group that includes all the people (and the tax collectors) – the ordinary sinful humble person who looks to Jesus for forgiveness
      - They declared God to be just – in the same as 1John

1John 1:9 If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

- Then there were the various religious leaders of the day who could accept Jesus' teaching because they never accepted John's teaching
  - Luke says they rejected God's purpose – once again proving that…
  - Without repentance from dead works - the work of the law - there is no interest in a new truth – the truth of the gospel of grace

- There must have been an obvious division in the crowd as Jesus challenged them for why they were following John and now Him
  - Some understood the meaning of Jesus message and agreed with it

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- And others, notably the religious leaders, objected and would not accept his message
  - Yet they continue to hang around…probably because of his miracles
  - And perhaps because they wonder if Jesus could serve their purposes

- And now Jesus begins to call them out, to return to the battle that is always awaiting him with the Pharisees

Luke 7:31 ¶ "To what then shall I compare the men of this generation, and what are they like?
Luke 7:32 "They are like children who sit in the market place and call to one another, and they say, 'We played the flute for you, and you did not dance; we sang a dirge, and you did not weep.'
Luke 7:33 "For John the Baptist has come eating no bread and drinking no wine, and you say, 'He has a demon!'
Luke 7:34 "The Son of Man has come eating and drinking, and you say, 'Behold, a gluttonous man and a drunkard, a friend of tax collectors and sinners!'
Luke 7:35 "Yet wisdom is vindicated by all her children."

- Now Jesus address the Pharisees directly
  - But talks about them in the third person – like they aren't there
  - Jesus says rhetorically, how can I best described what the men – the religious leaders - of this generation are like,…how can I describe their nature and their behavior
  - And then he makes a comparison to a common scene in the daily lives of Jewish citizens of every town
    - In the marketplace, children often gathered and played
    - And the games of that day weren't all that much different than today - except that their games didn't require batteries
    - Children often play imagination games where there is a required protocol for every participant
      - The games had a sort of script for the participants

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- If one child did a certain thing, like play a certain song on an instrument or sing a certain song
- Then as the game went, the rest of the children had to respond a certain way
- We have a game like that today – we call it Simon Says

- Jesus says the religious leaders of the day were like children playing Simon Says
  - They're only happy with one another so long as each is playing his assigned role
  - And everyone who wants in on the game must respond according to the rules
    - They must show the necessary respect for the leaders and do as they say
    - They must follow the traditions
    - They must teach according to the rules that have been established
    - And since Jesus wasn't willing to play according to these rules, he was being rejected by the leaders – just as they rejected John

- And to show how silly and insincere their rules and demands truly were, Jesus points out their hypocrisy in the way they criticized John and Himself
  - To John, a man who would rather eat locusts and honey than normal food, who refrained from wine or socializing with the people of his day
    - And him they call deranged or possessed
  - Then came Jesus who was willing to live a joyful life, especially with those who needed Him most – the sinners – even tax collectors – anyone who might be receptive to His message
    - To Jesus the religious leaders respond by saying he is discredited by the kind of company he keeps
  - They want to have their cake and eat it too – either socializing is good or its bad

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- But in reality, their problem was that neither man would dance according to the song of the Pharisees and play according to their rules

- I need to be clear with you, however, for why Jesus is criticizing these men
  - It's not merely their hypocrisy or their dishonesty that's a problem
  - It's their desire to preserve a system that meets their personal needs rather than truly seek after God's heart and His purposes
    - They assumed the role of God's representatives on earth – yet they were anything but
    - They served themselves, not God, and their reaction to John the Baptist and to Jesus is proof
      - When John came preaching preparedness for the Christ, the Pharisees didn't yield to the message – they rejected it
      - And when Jesus appeared to confirm John's ministry, they didn't recognize the meaning of his teaching and of his miracles, rather they rejected Him as well

- These men would have nothing to do with anyone who wasn't willing to work inside their system because their system made them powerful and satisfied their egos – their flesh
  - Just as in Jesus day, we have men and women like that today in the church
    - The church has always had people like this – people who serve themselves and not God and who reject the truth if it stands in the way of their own desires
    - Knowing that people like this exist is no secret to you, I'm sure
      - The bigger concern is that we might begin to think like them
      - Don't cling to tradition over truth, don't assume that the first thing your taught is always right,
      - Don't follow a teaching or minister because you like their style or their words

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- Follow Christ, follow the truth wherever He takes you

- Now Jesus ends his criticism of the Pharisees with a noteworthy phrase
  - He says that truth is vindicated by her children
    - In other words, you will know the quality of the tree by its fruit
    - And Christ being the embodiment of truth, the world will know the truth of His message by the children it produces
    - And Luke uses this statement from Christ to transition to an interesting story at the end of this chapter that He alone records
    - It's a story that illustrates the idea Jesus has just stated in verse 35

Luke 7:36 ¶ Now one of the Pharisees was requesting Him to dine with him, and He entered the Pharisee's house and reclined *at the table*.
Luke 7:37 And there was a woman in the city who was a sinner; and when she learned that He was reclining *at the table* in the Pharisee's house, she brought an alabaster vial of perfume,
Luke 7:38 and standing behind *Him* at His feet, weeping, she began to wet His feet with her tears, and kept wiping them with the hair of her head, and kissing His feet and anointing them with the perfume.
Luke 7:39 Now when the Pharisee who had invited Him saw this, he said to himself, "If this man were a prophet He would know who and what sort of person this woman is who is touching Him, that she is a sinner."
Luke 7:40 And Jesus answered him, "Simon, I have something to say to you." And he replied, "Say it, Teacher."
Luke 7:41 "A moneylender had two debtors: one owed five hundred denarii, and the other fifty.
Luke 7:42 "When they were unable to repay, he graciously forgave them both. So which of them will love him more?"
Luke 7:43 Simon answered and said, "I suppose the one whom he forgave more." And He said to him, "You have judged correctly."
Luke 7:44 Turning toward the woman, He said to Simon, "Do you see this woman? I entered your house; you gave Me no water for My feet, but she has wet My feet with her tears and wiped them with her hair.
Luke 7:45 "You gave Me no kiss; but she, since the time I came in, has not ceased to kiss My feet.
Luke 7:46 "You did not anoint My head with oil, but she anointed My feet with perfume.
Luke 7:47 "For this reason I say to you, her sins, which are many, have been forgiven, for she loved much; but he who is forgiven little, loves little."
Luke 7:48 Then He said to her, "Your sins have been forgiven."

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Luke 7:49 Those who were reclining *at the table* with Him began to say to themselves, "Who is this *man* who even forgives sins?"
Luke 7:50 And He said to the woman, "Your faith has saved you; go in peace."

- This scene is remarkable for several reasons
    - First, simply the interaction between Jesus and this Pharisee would make for great cinema – the room is think with tension and intrigue
    - These men are not friends, and this Pharisee has not invited Jesus into the room because he is a supporter much less a believer
    - But from the start it's worth noting that Jesus didn't shun the Pharisees
        - He has accepted Simon's invitation to eat at his home
        - But there are clues to Simon's true feelings
- Set the scene
    - Meals were often taken on tables set very near the ground
        - Diners were on divans reclined with feet away from the table
        - Head and arms were near the table
    - Secondly, it was not uncommon for the poor to come into a setting like this, especially if the meal was attended by a visitor, and beg for scraps
        - Simon's willingness to allow this woman to enter and be in the room would no doubt have been his effort to show generosity and piousness to the needy in front of Jesus
- As they eat, the woman begins to attend to Christ by kissing his feet and using her hair to anoint his feet with expensive oil
    - As she does this, Jesus is facing Simon and is not likely looking directly at the woman
    - But Simon who is facing Jesus from across the table, can see all that the woman is doing – and he knows who she is
    - She's poor and needy because she is a sinner, Luke calls her

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        - The nature of her sin is not known, but in the tradition of Jewish society, women who lived a life of sin were usually prostitutes

        - So they would be shunned from society

- Now Simon is getting quite a kick out of this scene

    - He knows this is a lowly sinner, one who is so despised that if she were to touch a holy man, a religious leader of the day, she would make him ritually unclean

    - This gives Simon great pleasure – Jesus is some prophet – he doesn't even know what this woman is really like

    - For if he did, he would never allow her to touch him the way she is

- Now Jesus knows what's in Simon's heart

    - So he speaks directly to Simon, and says I want to say something to you

        - Simon says, speak teacher

            - This is actually a disrespectful statement, because it was a lower station than prophet, which is what the crowd were calling Jesus

            - Simon was essentially lowering Christ's standing by how he addressed him

- Jesus then offers his story about the money lender

    - Now the story is easy enough to follow

        - Those who are forgiven great debts are far more appreciative than those who have little to forgive

        - We can understand the point certainly, but imagine the effect the story had on Simon

- You can hear his nervousness when Jesus asks him to answer his question about who would love more

    - Simon says I suppose it would be the one who owed more

    - He is hesitant to answer because he senses something is up

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        - Just a moment before he had been thinking about how poor a prophet Jesus must be

            - He didn't even know that the woman touching him was a sinner and not worthy to approach a rabbi

            - But now he was asking a question that seemed like a trap, but Simon couldn't figure out where the trap was going

            - When Jesus gives the answer, it must have knocked Simon over

- As Jesus answers and describes how the woman had been so much more loving to him than Simon ever was, it must have hit Simon between the eyes.

    - One moment he's think about how poor a prophet Jesus was since He couldn't discern who this woman was

    - And now Jesus is making commentary on private thoughts that were in Simon's head – he must have been rethinking his assessment of Jesus' abilities about now

        - But we don't want to leave today without recognizing who we are in this scene

- We know we're not Jesus, and I doubt any of us love like as of we were

    - But which of the other two people in this scene represent us

        - Jesus came into this home in part to demonstrate the truth of his statement earlier in verse 35

        - His children vindicate the truth – the woman proved that she believed Jesus could forgive her sins and would

    - But who are we

        - Are we Simon?

        - Do we live like we have little to be forgiven

            - Does God owe us heaven now

            - Having become a Christian, we can go back to our life and our rules and our own plans for serving our egos

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- Do we forget to show love to others except when it makes us look good or feel good
- Do we hold ourselves in the world as a pillar of righteousness

- Jesus said those things go together
  - Those who do not recognize their own sinfulness have no idea of how much they need forgiveness
    - The woman was a greater sinner than Simon, perhaps, but her awareness of her sin was what propelled her toward Christ
    - Simon had a hard unbelieving heart and yet his self-righteousness prevented him from knowing the truth

- There is only one right way to respond to your salvation
  - In the manner of this woman
  - In very real terms, she is no more a sinner than you or I
  - And we have no less to be forgiven than she
  - Yet how many of us spend time each day considering perhaps with tears how much we have been forgiven
  - How many of us would do for Christ even as she did, showing our love for all that he has done for us
    - Well, Christ says we still have that obligation to him, though He is not present with us for the time being
    - Rather, we show that love to others in His name – and we keep his commands

- The Pharisees could not accept Christ because He didn't fit their desires and they couldn't accept that they needed anything that Jesus offered – and as a result they showed no love – not to Jesus and not to their fellow man
  - Which is why we say that the World shall know us by our love

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Luke 8A

- If you were a Jewish farmer or tradesman following Jesus in the crowds
    - So you see this man of amazing power, you hear his teaching
        - You had seen his miracles
        - You've heard his teaching
        - You see His kindness and genuine concern for people, unlike the other religious leaders who seem to only serve themselves
    - And yet you marvel at the wide variety of reactions to him
        - There are the scoffers, chief among them the Pharisees and scribes
            - You heard the whispers in the crowd, some declaring he was a prophet, some declaring him to be possessed
            - They mocked Him, they say He was not to be believed
            - They accused Him of violating the law and encouraging others to do as well
            - They criticized Him for associating with sinners
            - They dismissed Him entirely
        - Then there are the opportunists
            - They've been attracted by the prospect of quick healing or whatever may come their way
            - But you can tell what they really think…they aren't any more interested in living the life Jesus proclaims than they are following the Pharisees
        - Then there are the ones who truly seem to feel a calling from Jesus
            - They admire Him, call Him a prophet
            - They seek to understand His teaching and follow it

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- Finally, there were those who had begun to ask the question of whether this was the son of David, the promised one, the Messiah
- Shouldn't his power and his wisdom be enough to convince anyone of who He was
- How could anyone see such wondrous displays and not come away convinced

- Why so many different reactions? Why do the same events have such different impact on so many people?
- And that question leads us into the events of Luke Chapter 8

Luke 8:1 ¶ Soon afterwards, He *began* going around from one city and village to another, proclaiming and preaching the kingdom of God. The twelve were with Him,
Luke 8:2 and *also* some women who had been healed of evil spirits and sicknesses: Mary who was called Magdalene, from whom seven demons had gone out,
Luke 8:3 and Joanna the wife of Chuza, Herod's steward, and Susanna, and many others who were contributing to their support out of their private means.

- Luke steps back for a moment from his story of Jesus' teaching in Galilee
  - He simply make note of the way Jesus was able to live the life of an itinerant preacher – traveling from place to place
  - No livelihood, no attempt to build an earthly fortune
  - Focused entirely on preaching the kingdom of God
- Following Jesus were the 12, of course, then woman Jesus had healed
  - First Mary Magdalene
    - Her name comes from her hometown, Magdala
    - She had seven spirits in her
  - Then there is Joanna, who is so faithful she is with Jesus when he is crucified and buried
    - She is also connected to Herod's household, meaning she had money or at least connections to money

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        - It also is interesting how high up Jesus' ministry had penetrated so quickly

    - Finally, there is Susanna, who must have been prominent in the early church and therefore known to Luke's readers, which might explain why he doesn't give any further details

    - And all these women and many others, Luke says, were contributing to Jesus' ministry

- I like the way Luke tried to provide details about Jesus that provide legitimacy to the story of Jesus

    - For those who might wonder how it was that Jesus could travel around without ever holding steady employment, Luke provides the question

    - The answer is Jesus lived like every fulltime minister who has come after him

        - He relied on the support of others who recognized the importance and necessity of His ministry

- In Jesus's case, a significant part of his support came from the kindness of women, especially women who had access to means

    - It's interesting that Luke, more than the other gospel writers, has made a point throughout his gospel of highlighting the role of women in Jesus life, and how Jesus showed them unusual kindness and respect for women for His day

        - And after this short aside, Luke returns to detailing Jesus' teaching

Luke 8:4 ¶ When a large crowd was coming together, and those from the various cities were journeying to Him, He spoke by way of a parable:
Luke 8:5 "The sower went out to sow his seed; and as he sowed, some fell beside the road, and it was trampled under foot and the birds of the air ate it up.
Luke 8:6 "Other *seed* fell on rocky *soil*, and as soon as it grew up, it withered away, because it had no moisture.
Luke 8:7 "Other *seed* fell among the thorns; and the thorns grew up with it and choked it out.
Luke 8:8 "Other *seed* fell into the good soil, and grew up, and produced a crop a hundred times as great." As He said these things, He would call out, "He who has ears to hear, let him hear."

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- Now Luke returns to describing Jesus' teaching and His effect on the crowds
    - And He tells one of the most famous – if not the most famous – parable of his ministry – the parable of the sower and the seed
    - There are at least as many ways to interrupt this parable incorrectly as there are to interpret it correctly
    - We want to pay close attention to all the details in this parable if we are to understand it correctly
    - Furthermore, we will need to keep in mind the context in which it is found, keeping in mind the teaching we've been following so far
- A Palestinian farmer would typically walk to his field along narrow worn paths, often passing other plots of land before reaching his own
    - As he walked there, he carried his seed in a cloth bag, stitched together by coarse thread
    - Occasionally the bag might leak and allow some of the seed to fall along the path as he walked
        - Or as he was sowing his field, some of the seed would fall out in places that were not tilled and prepared for planting
        - Then as he sowed his seed, the farmer would reach into the bag, grab a handful of seed and then drop it along the prepared rows in the field
        - Of course some of the seed dribbles out of his hand and falls around his feet, etc.
- Jesus uses this familiar picture to capture an important teaching to the crowd
    - We can see easily enough that there are four conditions represented in the parable
        - Each condition has difference and each shares some important details with the others
- Let's begin by looking at what each has in common
    - Each condition has the farmer
        - The farmer, though, is not the point of the parable – did you notice that?

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- There is no discussion of who the farmer is or how he does his work
    - In fact, if we had to rate the farmer's performance, it's fair to say that the farmer is fairly sloppy with his seed bag
    - He's throwing seed everywhere
        - Jesus says some seed falls on the road, some in rocky soil, some in the thorns
        - Only a portion falls on the good soil
        - It's as if he has an unlimited supply of seed, so there's no need to worry about being precise or stingy with it – just throw it anywhere and everywhere
    - So the farmer is probably not the point of the parable, wouldn't you agree?
        - The best we can learn from watching the farmer is that Jesus expects indiscriminant distribution of the seed
- Which brings us to the seed
    - The seed is also the same for each condition
        - We're not talking about good seed vs bad seed here
        - All seed has the same potential to bring growth and fruit

- So if the farmer is the same and the seed is the same, what's the difference here
    - Well there are two differences across the four conditions
        - First, there is a difference in the soil
    - In the first condition, we have no soil at all really
        - We have a worn path

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- If you have every gone camping or walking a trail in the wilderness, you know what a worn path is like
- It's dense, hard pack earth that can't be penetrated easily – certainly not by a seed falling to the ground
- And anything that does fall is easily seen – so birds quickly drop down and remove it altogether
- It never has the chance to germinate, much less grow

- Now in the second condition the soil is looser, more ready to accept a seed
  - But in the Palestinian region where this scene is set, there are many areas much like the ground here in South Texas
  - The earth is actually only a thin layer covering dense limestone rock
    - The ground is rocky not because it has rocks in it, but because the ground has no depth to the soil
    - Seeds that fall such soil actually sprout up more quickly than seed planted in deep soil, because it's closer to the elements it needs
    - It's closer to water and as it sprouts, it breaks free more quickly and receives sunlight sooner
    - This has the effect of causing quick growth at first
    - But as the root tries to establish itself, the rocky layer under the thin soil stops the growth short
- The third soil is actually just fine for causing growth
  - It's deep and rich enough, so growth takes place
  - But now the problem is that the soil is contaminated with unhealthy plants as well, plants that choke off the growth of the seed
  - Since it's choked from maturing, it never reaches the place where it can produce fruit

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        - Finally, there's the fourth condition where the soil is best, because it's been prepared specifically for the seed
            - The soil is soft and deep
            - And the contaminants have been removed
            - And growth produces fruit

- Now as Jesus presents the parable, He first lays out the parable then provides the interpretation, and so we'll move to the interpretation next as well
    - But first, what are we to make of his next comment regarding the reason He taught in parables

Luke 8:9 ¶ His disciples *began* questioning Him as to what this parable meant.
Luke 8:10 And He said, "To you it has been granted to know the mysteries of the kingdom of God, but to the rest *it is* in parables, so that SEEING THEY MAY NOT SEE, AND HEARING THEY MAY NOT UNDERSTAND.

- It must have been that this parable so caught the disciples off guard that they finally decided to ask the question that they had no doubt been thinking for some time
    - Why was Jesus teaching in riddles? Wasn't He trying to teach people?
    - Didn't He want people to know what He was saying?
- To that Jesus responds, that the disciples were to know the meaning of Jesus teaching, but not everyone
    - For them, the truth will come in parables – it will be inaccessible
        - It will interest them, it will catch their attention and puzzle them
        - They may even make some sense of it
        - But in the end, the true meaning will escape them
    - Only for those whom it is intended will the truth be known
- Understanding this principle is important because it fits into the rest of this chapter and in fact the whole of the gospel

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- The first thing we have to conclude is that Jesus understood that not all people were intended to understand the Gospel
    - Some interpreters have seen these verses and explained them this way
        - Jesus is telling his disciples that there are those who are willing to understand the truth and those who weren't
        - To those who weren't willing to understand the truth, the meaning of the parables would escape them and they would be left without the knowledge of the truth
- Adding support to that view is this verse in Matthew

Matt. 13:15 FOR THE HEART OF THIS PEOPLE HAS BECOME DULL,
WITH THEIR EARS THEY SCARCELY HEAR,
AND THEY HAVE CLOSED THEIR EYES,
OTHERWISE THEY WOULD SEE WITH THEIR EYES,
HEAR WITH THEIR EARS,
AND UNDERSTAND WITH THEIR HEART AND RETURN,
AND I WOULD HEAL THEM.'

- But this interpretation ignores the overall text
    - Jesus is speaking in riddles – his parables are hard to understand regardless of the state of your heart – they are not designed for everyone to follow
        - Even the disciples had to ask for an interpretation – and Jesus said to them that they had been granted the right to understand the truth
        - So clearly, the rest had no chance to understand
    - In fact, He says it has not been granted to the others to know the truth
        - Something or someone is standing in the way of the others understanding the truth
        - Jesus is purposes speaking in a veiled way – in a way that kept the real truth – the depth of His teaching – intentionally hidden
- So while the hearers are guilty for their lack of understanding, Jesus is teaching in such a way to affirm their situation and prevent it from changing

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- This has happened before in scripture
- In Isaiah..

Is. 6:8 Then I heard the voice of the Lord, saying, "Whom shall I send, and who will go for Us?" Then I said, "Here am I. Send me!"
Is. 6:9 He said, "Go, and tell this people:
'Keep on listening, but do not perceive;
Keep on looking, but do not understand.'
Is. 6:10 "Render the hearts of this people insensitive,
Their ears dull,
And their eyes dim,
Otherwise they might see with their eyes,
Hear with their ears,
Understand with their hearts,
And return and be healed."

- Later in the Gospel of John, Jesus confronts the Pharisees and declares that they can't see Him for who he is because of their nature will not permit it

John 8:42 Jesus said to them, "If God were your Father, you would love Me, for I proceeded forth and have come from God, for I have not even come on My own initiative, but He sent Me.
John 8:43 "Why do you not understand what I am saying? *It is* because you cannot hear My word.
John 8:44 "You are of *your* father the devil, and you want to do the desires of your father. He was a murderer from the beginning, and does not stand in the truth because there is no truth in him. Whenever he speaks a lie, he speaks from his own *nature*, for he is a liar and the father of lies.
John 8:45 "But because I speak the truth, you do not believe Me.
John 8:46 "Which one of you convicts Me of sin? If I speak truth, why do you not believe Me?
John 8:47 "He who is of God hears the words of God; for this reason you do not hear *them*, because you are not of God."

- The problem part the listener's disinterest in the truth and their own stubbornness
  - God does not revel a great truth to those who show contempt for the simplest of revelation
    - Christians often get caught in this trap they set for themselves

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- If we're not willing to devote ourselves to the hard work of hearing and learning God's word, then we shouldn't be surprised when He withholds understand from us on more difficult issues in scripture

- And this fact leads us to the other reason they don't understand
  - All men are born into the nature of Adam, the fallen nature we inherited from Adam
  - And that fallen nature leaves us incapable of hearing God's truth and responding to the truth
    - Having ears to hear requires that God first act to open the hearer's ears to pay attention to the message
    - And so for the Apostles, it had been granted for them to understand these mysteries,

Matt. 13:16 "But blessed are your eyes, because they see; and your ears, because they hear. but to those

- But for the rest of the crowd, it had not been granted
  - And unless it is granted, they cannot understand it

- Understanding the word of God is a supernatural experience
  - We are taught what the word means even as we read it or hear it by the power of the holy spirit Himself
    - Oh the ordinary person can make out the English in the sentence easily enough
    - They can read it and come away with some kind of understanding perhaps
    - But the depths of it, the purpose of it, the conviction of it, - those will be missing
  - And once understanding is granted, it immediately

- And so we come to the interpretation for those who can hear

Luke 8:11 ¶ "Now the parable is this: the seed is the word of God.
Luke 8:12 "Those beside the road are those who have heard; then the devil comes and takes away the word from their heart, so that they will not believe and be saved.

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Luke 8:13 "Those on the rocky *soil are* those who, when they hear, receive the word with joy; and these have no *firm* root; they believe for a while, and in time of temptation fall away.
Luke 8:14 "The *seed* which fell among the thorns, these are the ones who have heard, and as they go on their way they are choked with worries and riches and pleasures of *this* life, and bring no fruit to maturity.
Luke 8:15 "But the *seed* in the good soil, these are the ones who have heard the word in an honest and good heart, and hold it fast, and bear fruit with perseverance.
Luke 8:16 ¶ "Now no one after lighting a lamp covers it over with a container, or puts it under a bed; but he puts it on a lampstand, so that those who come in may see the light.
Luke 8:17 "For nothing is hidden that will not become evident, nor *anything* secret that will not be known and come to light.
Luke 8:18 "So take care how you listen; for whoever has, to him *more* shall be given; and whoever does not have, even what he thinks he has shall be taken away from him."

- Having applied ourselves to properly dissecting the detail, we are in a position to appreciate the full meaning of the text
- Jesus Himself gives us the big picture for this parable
    - First, Jesus says that the seed is the Word of God
    - The thing distributed so liberally and casually and even recklessly is the Word of God
        - So immediately we are faced with a parable about how the Word of God is spread and what impact it has on those who hear it
        - This is a timely message for the disciples and the crowd overall
            - Why is it that people react so differently to the Word of God
            - In Jesus Day, His words were the words of God, so in his day the issue was how the crowds and religious leaders reacted to Him personally
            - In our day, the Bible is the Word of God, so for us the parable explains how people react to Jesus in the form of the scriptures
            - But in either case the truth of the parable applies
    - Then Jesus explains the four conditions

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- The hard-packed soil is a picture of a heart so closed and hardened that nothing will penetrate – not even the Word of that heart's creator
- And when the Word arrives, it lies there without a place to root so the devil makes sure it doesn't stick around very long
- This is a hopeless unsaved sinner who will have nothing to do with God nor His word and who simply cannot be impressed with the gospel message
    - I wonder if this isn't the kind of person Jesus had in mind when he told his disciples not to throw pearl before swine

- Then we have the second condition
    - Jesus says the rocky soil is where we find people who give an initial reaction of faith
        - There is a quick bloom and the appearance of a good start, but at the first sign of testing they fall away
        - In the case of the plant, a thin rocky soil has little chance of providing enough nourishment to keep a plant alive at the first drought when the top soil dries up
        - In the case of the person, we're talking about trials – suffering that comes upon a believer because of their faith
- This is essential proof of faith
    - James says

James 1:2 ¶ Consider it all joy, my brethren, when you encounter various trials,
James 1:3 knowing that the testing of your faith produces endurance.
James 1:4 And let endurance have *its* perfect result, so that you may be perfect and complete, lacking in nothing.

2Cor. 13:5 ¶ Test yourselves *to see* if you are in the faith; examine yourselves! Or do you not recognize this about yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you—unless indeed you fail the test?

- And remember Jesus' words to the hypocrites who have been following him and accusing him

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Luke 6:46 ¶ "Why do you call Me, 'Lord, Lord,' and do not do what I say?
Luke 6:47 "Everyone who comes to Me and hears My words and acts on them, I will show you whom he is like:
Luke 6:48 he is like a man building a house, who dug deep and laid a foundation on the rock; and when a flood occurred, the torrent burst against that house and could not shake it, because it had been well built.
Luke 6:49 "But the one who has heard and has not acted *accordingly*, is like a man who built a house on the ground without any foundation; and the torrent burst against it and immediately it collapsed, and the ruin of that house was great."

- A test is designed to reveal the truth, and the testing of faith through trial reveals the truth about someone's faith
- This second condition, therefore, is a classic case of false confession
    - These are the folks who look like Christians but aren't
    - They initially respond in some superficial way to the message of the gospel
        - They make a confession, they start going to church
        - They begin attending a home group or Bible study
    - But then something shakes the foundations of their world
        - Perhaps a divorce, they lose their job, a death in the family
        - The kinds of things that drive a true Christian to the cross seeking the comfort and strength of Jesus will cause these fake Christians to dry up and fall away Jesus says
- Let's not be naïve
    - Our Lord is teaching that the Word spread indiscriminately as it should be will be heard by unbelievers who never buy it and certainly don't try to fake it – that's condition 1
        - They have a hard heart and they're proud of it
    - But sometimes it will lead to unbelievers who think they understand what it means to be Christian
        - So they put aside the dead works they were doing before they heard about Christ, and begin to do the works of Christianity

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- But it's still works – and they go along playing according to the new rules they've been given until one day perhaps it loses its appeal – then they're gone
- And not like Peter who ran out on Christ during His crucifixion
- But someone who turns and never looks back
- These are the people who proudly say "I used to be a Christian once"

- Putting condition 3 aside for the moment, let's address condition 4
  - Clearly this is the mature and fruitful Christian
    - They hear the word, their hearts (the ground) made ready for it by the HS
    - The word germinates, causes new life and then results in a slow maturing process
    - Eventually, the maturity of the new plant allows it to produce spiritual fruit – and fruit many times itself
      - It begins as a single seed, but the mature plant produces many times that
      - Likewise, a Christian that matures in his or her faith has the potential to add to the kingdom of God many times over

- So if Condition 1 & 2 demonstrate the two kinds of unbelievers, and condition 4 is certainly one kind of believer, then what are we to think of condition 3?
  - Well, the first thing to notice is that this is the first of the three conditions where the soil is good enough to produce a quality plant that survives the trials
  - The soil is no longer the principle problem

- The soil is so good, in fact, that it also capable of supporting all manner of unhealthy and harmful growth as well
  - So we're not focused on the difficulty in starting or sustaining the life of the plant here
  - Now the focus is on the kind of life the plant lives

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- Rather then maturing to the point of producing fruit as in the fourth condition, this plant never reaches maturity
- It's choked off by the cares and riches of this world so it produces no fruit

- Let's be sure to note that the cares of this world are not killing the plant, it still lives
  - But with no fruit – it's just a useless plant
    - So here's a Christian albeit a useless one
    - It produces no fruit, it does no measurable good in the kingdom for it never reproduces
    - And why?
      - Because the ability to produce anything is stopped by the cares of this world
      - The riches, the pleasures the distractions – the things that take our attention and energy away from the production of fruit
- Can you guess which condition best describes the Christian church today?
  - Well, for the most part it's not Condition 1 thankfully – for that's no church at all
  - For many churches, it's probably the second condition that best describes them
    - Churches that have many unbelievers in the pews, acting our a Christian lifestyle hoping it will get them what they want
    - But if any trial ever comes along, they will quickly walk away from this new found faith
  - And in every healthy church you can probably find a few that represent the fourth condition
    - These are the people who by their maturity and love in the faith reproduce many in the faith
- But what about condition 3

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- Wouldn't you agree that this is the typical Christian experience, especially in a rich country like ours
    - I mean, what exactly would a Condition 3 Christian look like?
        - Do you think you could pick them out in a line up?
        - What does being absorbed in the cares of this world look like?
        - What does pursuing the riches of this world look like?
        - In fact, where do we think the thorns and weeds come from except the enemy himself?

- I think it's entirely fair to say that far too many Christians today are a perfect reflection of condition 3 and don't care one bit
    - The shame of it is that by the time the realize what they were sacrificing in eternity for their willingness to forgo bearing fruit here it will be too late to go back and fix that terrible mistake
    - Christ is telling this parable because the crowd around him is a mixture of all these soils and only a fraction of his followers will ever bear fruit
        - And just as the unbeliever has two conditions – one that looks like an unbeliever and one that doesn't
        - So does the believer have two conditions in this parable – one that looks like a believer and one that doesn't
        - Can the world tell we are believers? Many days I have to wonder, because so few Christians I know are willing to turn their back on the cares and pursuits of this world and actually pursue spiritual maturity and the reproduction of their faith

- And when one day we all meet our Lord face to face, it won't be our bank accounts or our houses or our awards or our photo albums that impress him
    - It will be our spiritual fruit

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Luke 8B

- Last week we examined the parable of the sower and the four seeds
    - The definition of a good sermon: It should have a good beginning. It should have a good ending. And they should be as close together as possible.
    - But that's why we serve coffee before the service – to make sure you're fully awake when you drive home
    - This week the two ends should be a little closer together
- When we examined the parable last week, we paid close attention to the detail, we interpreted the parable by breaking it down into two halves
    - And each half could itself be divided into two conditions, leaving a total of four conditions
- In mathematics, you would call this breakdown a Latin Square
    - The first half of the parable, Conditions 1 & 2, we said were pictures of the unbelievers
        - One group showed an unbeliever who made no attempt to hide their disinterest for the Word of God
            - They were unbelievers with a hard heart and no interest in changing
        - The second group of unbelievers actually left an impression of being believers, at least at first
            - But after some time, a trial besets them or some test of faith comes upon them, and they reveal the lack of a root and they die – they give up the act and show their true nature
    - The second half of the parable, Conditions 3 & 4, we said were believers based on interpretation provided by Jesus Himself
        - But like the unbelievers, there were two kinds of believer depicted in the parable

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- In the fourth condition, for example, you had the strong, mature Christian
    - And their maturity was demonstrated by their ability to reproduce – to bear fruit –
    - Which we called seed, or the ability to spread the gospel or the Word of God and reproduce faith
- But the most troubling condition was Condition 3 – the Condition 3 Christian – the believer who never produces fruit

Mouse Trap Example

- You may have been wondering what the main point of Jesus parable
    - Was it merely the fact that the Word will produce different reactions among those who hear it?
        - Well, to a degree, yes, but that wasn't the main point
- Last week we read through verse 18, but I only exposited through verse 15. Today we will pick up in verse 16 again, because in 16-8 we learn the purpose of the parable

Luke 8:16 ¶ "Now no one after lighting a lamp covers it over with a container, or puts it under a bed; but he puts it on a lampstand, so that those who come in may see the light.
Luke 8:17 "For nothing is hidden that will not become evident, nor *anything* secret that will not be known and come to light.
Luke 8:18 "So take care how you listen; for whoever has, to him *more* shall be given; and whoever does not have, even what he thinks he has shall be taken away from him."

- Thought we may not have noticed it or fully appreciated it, Jesus transitions out of the parable to an application in these verses – and ultimately to a warning
- Lighting in Jesus day was nothing like it is today, of course
    - Light came from oil lamps
    - It's like when you go camping, for example, and you're inside a tent at night
    - You light a propane lantern or an electric lantern
    - The light for the room all comes from one concentrated source

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- You work hard to find just the right place to put the lamp, hang it high
  - You try to avoid blocking the light or casting shadows
  - Your ability to see your way around in the tent depends entirely on making sure the light is on and unobstructed
- Now in Jesus' day lighting a lamp was not necessarily difficult, but it wasn't trivial either
  - First, the effort to produce a flame was significant – no lighters, no matches
  - Secondly, the oil for a lamp was cheap – so burning a lamp was costly and not done without thought
    - Unlike today when we casually leave lights on for hours in empty rooms without concern

- So when Jesus says that no one after lighting a lamp covers it over with a container or puts it under a bed – He's really making a bit of a joke
  - The crowd might as well have laughed at this suggestion
  - Jesus says the person would place it on a lamp stand - naturally
- Now we don't have to work very hard here to understand what Jesus is saying in verse 16
  - The imagery is fairly obvious
  - But if that weren't enough, we have Matt's account to help us

Matt. 5:14 ¶ "You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden;
Matt. 5:15 nor does *anyone* light a lamp and put it under a basket, but on the lampstand, and it gives light to all who are in the house.
Matt. 5:16 "Let your light shine before men in such a way that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father who is in heaven.

- In Matt's account we hear Jesus say that believers - the church – have been elevated, raised up, like a city set on a hill
  - And in that position, you can't help but be noticed
- Just like a lamp that's been lit – and like a lamp, we are the light of the world

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        - Just like that camping lantern, we are the ones through whom God will shine the light of the truth of His word to the world

        - We are the ones who will demonstrate by our lives the power of God to save and transform – or at least that's supposed to be our purpose

- So why does Jesus feel the need to end his parable by saying that Christians, the light of the world, shouldn't hide their light under a bed?

    - It's seems Jesus was concerned that Christians might not want the world to know that they were different

    - And that was the main point of the parable?

        - Don't be a C3 Christian

    - This is exactly what some Christians, in fact many Christians, are doing and have always done

        - These are the Condition 3 Christians

        - They're the Christians who are hiding their light – withholding their witness to the world – never producing fruit

            - These are the Christians that hear the Word, and respond with some amount of healthy growth

            - But the cares and riches and pleasures of this world choke off the production of fruit

        - They are distracted by the interests and cares of this world

            - There's no time to be a mature Christian, no energy, no desire, no commitment

            - The things of this world are just too attractive, they seem too important, too demanding

            - Consequently, there's little energy left for spiritual development – and what is must be used exclusively for themselves – just to stay alive

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- That's the key to understanding the C3 Christian – it's self-centered Christianity…they are self-focused
    - Think about it like the plant surrounded by weeds
        - The plant produces no fruit because all it's energy is devoted to its own existence as the weeds taking so much of the plants energy – the sunlight and water
        - A C3 squanders their time, resources and energy on the cares of this world, so when it comes time to devote time and energy to the things that truly matter – spiritual things, they have nothing left to give.
        - They're selfish because they only have enough spiritual energy for themselves
        - This is like a field planted by the farmer, but all the plants it produces lack fruit…what a wasted harvest
- So spiritually speaking, here's what a C3 Christian might look like
    - First, they aren't necessarily devoid of any Christian-like behavior
    - They probably do many Christian like things
        - They go to church when it fits the schedule
        - They attend a Bible study now and then
        - They tithe when the budget allows
        - They volunteer when they have spare time
    - These are good things, fine things – necessary things
        - But these activities are not fruit
- So what's the point of the parable
    - First and foremost, we can't allow ourselves to be content with being a Condition 3 Christian
        - We all start there, to be sure, with our light hidden
        - But don't be satisfied to remain a closet Christian or a self-centered one

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- And it begins by recognizing that as a culture we devote too much time to the wrong things, including the wrong spiritual things
- And there is a price to pay for neglecting our responsibilities in this area

- Jesus presents a warning in verses 17 & 18 for those who neglect to hear this message

Luke 8:17 "For nothing is hidden that will not become evident, nor *anything* secret that will not be known and come to light.
Luke 8:18 "So take care how you listen; for whoever has, to him *more* shall be given; and whoever does not have, even what he thinks he has shall be taken away from him."

- If we are content to leave our witness buried, to fail to produce fruit, to remain a C3 Christian, Jesus warns us that there will be no secrets one day to come
  - All things will be known
    - The unbelievers will be known for who they are
    - And the Christians will be have their work tested

1Cor. 3:9 For we are God's fellow workers; you are God's field, God's building.
1Cor. 3:10 ¶ According to the grace of God which was given to me, like a wise master builder I laid a foundation, and another is building on it. But each man must be careful how he builds on it.
1Cor. 3:11 For no man can lay a foundation other than the one which is laid, which is Jesus Christ.
1Cor. 3:12 Now if any man builds on the foundation with gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, straw,
1Cor. 3:13 each man's work will become evident; for the day will show it because it is *to be* revealed with fire, and the fire itself will test the quality of each man's work.
1Cor. 3:14 If any man's work which he has built on it remains, he will receive a reward.
1Cor. 3:15 If any man's work is burned up, he will suffer loss; but he himself will be saved, yet so as through fire.

- Pauls reminds the Corinthian church that you though they were saved by their faith and not their works – to be sure - but much is still riding on their works
  - Today we live in an existence and an age where everything has a beginning and an end
  - We can't begin to comprehend eternity

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- But when we reach the other side of this life – we enter into a time and age where we come face to face with eternity
- No more death, no more transitions…just endless time
- And Jesus says that what we experience in that immense time is dependent on what we do with this handful of decades

- And here's the rule: whoever has, to him more will be given
  - Have? Have what?
    - Fruit, or more specifically, reward
  - And what will he be given? More opportunity to serve, to have responsibility and honor and perhaps other kinds of privilege in some form – we can't be sure of all that is to be handed out
    - Paul just calls it a reward

- But to the one who has nothing, even what he thinks he has will be taken away
  - What is it that this person has nothing of? Fruit.
    - What does he think he has…fruit
  - You see, the C3 Christian is living a life of fooling himself
    - He thinks since he's a mainstream Christian
      - A regular guy –he's just killing time on Earth waiting for his reward when he reaches heaven
    - The C3 Christian is self-deluded because he never took time to understand what the Word says about the expectations for fruit
      - So when the fire reveals the quality of this person's work, he will be found without fruit
    - He was too busy pursuing what this life offered –
      - It looked like he had everything but he sacrificed an eternity for it

- And just to be clear, there is another, complimentary meaning for these verses

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- To those in C2, the same comments have a dramatically different meaning
  - To the one who thinks he has salvation, Jesus says what he thinks he has will be lacking on the day of judgment
  - After all, only 2 of the four conditions can learn from this parable
    - C1 is hopelessly and decidedly lost
    - C4 is a mature Christian already leading the class
    - But C2 and C3 are the ones with a need
      - For C2 the need is to stop pretending and start believing
      - And for C3, the need is to stop pretending and begin maturing

- Are we taking this warning seriously?
  - Oh man, I hope so.
  - I hope we're not too proud to stop in our tracks and re-evaluate our lives to see if they measure up.
    - And if they don't, what are we prepared to do about it?
    - If we do nothing, I fear the day to come when we may deeply regret our shortsighted and foolish decisions to favor the needs of this world over those of the next

- To place an exclamation point on Jesus' teaching, Luke inserts a description of a passing moment in Jesus ministry

Luke 8:19 ¶ And His mother and brothers came to Him, and they were unable to get to Him because of the crowd.
Luke 8:20 And it was reported to Him, "Your mother and Your brothers are standing outside, wishing to see You."
Luke 8:21 But He answered and said to them, "My mother and My brothers are these who hear the word of God and do it."

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- Matt and Mark place this comment at a different point in Jesus ministry, back when he was confronted by the Pharisees over the disciples gleaning of the grain on the Sabbath
    - Perhaps Luke's careful investigation of the facts led him to conclude that this was the actual place it occurred
        - Or he decided that specific moment wasn't important and chose to insert it here to help make the point of Jesus' parable
    - It's apparent how large the crowds around Jesus had become by this point
        - They have to relay a message to Jesus that his family wishes to see him
        - Matt has Jesus in a house at this point, but either way they are not able to get close to him because of the crowd surrounding Jesus
    - Do you think they came to be His disciples? To hear his teaching? To follow him?
        - We don't know why they are trying to see Jesus
            - But I think it's safe to assume that they are probably amazed at what has transpired around Him since he left home
            - Perhaps they have come to understand what's going on or even be a part of it
- So why did Jesus dismiss his mother and brothers?
    - Well, first He doesn't criticize them – His comment isn't a slight against them
        - He may have received them eventually in fact
        - Really the only reason the event even warrants mention in scripture is because of what Jesus says at that moment
    - He uses their arrival as a teaching opportunity
        - Jesus says those who are in his family are those who hear the Word of God and do it

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- Coming on the heels of the parable, we can certainly understand it more fully
- Jesus statement makes even more clear that hearing the Word of God is the one and only means to becoming a part of the family of God
- As Paul says in Rom 10:17

Rom. 10:17 So faith *comes* from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.

- This statement would have been very surprising to his audience
  - In Jewish culture, family relationships (tribes) were all important
    - So to suggest that a family tie is secondary to faithfulness to the Word of God – as strange as it may seem to some of us now – would have been a radical statement
    - And it still is radical for many people today
  - We can expect that Jesus surely had normal loving relationship with his earthly mother and no doubt He had affection for his earthly brothers,
    - But once His ministry began in earnest, Jesus saw the things of earth with an appreciation that there was an eternity waiting
    - Jesus knew He had existed before Mary and his brothers were even born – before Adam was even created
    - And He knew that the earth and everything in it would end one day while God's children would continue on in eternity
  - There is no one who can say they were born into the family of God – not by the flesh
- I know what this feels like
  - I grew up calling myself a Christian – actually a Catholic
    - I was a Catholic because I was born a Catholic
    - And if you were to challenge that statement, I would get very offended – how dare you say what I am or am not

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- Jesus is saying it right here – His family are those who hear the Word of God and do it
  - Hear is "akouo" and it means listen, but in the sense of give heed
    - Not just hear it but receive it and then do it
    - Those who do these things are in the family of God – those who don't are not
  - Mary and James and the rest of Jesus family may have been related to Jesus in an earthly way,
    - But that didn't give them any special ticket into heaven
    - They, like every man, had to believe to be saved
    - The only kind of relationship that matters is the one we are given by faith

- Let's leave the teaching today fully aware of what Jesus – the Lord of all creation – is demanding of us
  - First, join His family or perish
  - And we join by faith in His Word – faith in His claim of who He is and in his provision on the cross for our sin
  - Secondly, we honor that gift of salvation by endeavoring to bear fruit
    - To build the kingdom
    - To spread the seed, the Word of God
  - In each week, there are 10,080 minutes
    - Many Christians spend 90 minutes per week on the things of God and the other 9,990 minutes on whatever interests them
    - Let's agree we will do better
      - Let's agree that our reputation as followers of Christ is that we followed him without regard for ourselves

2Cor. 5:15 and He died for all, so that they who live might no longer live for themselves, but for Him who died and rose again on their behalf.

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Luke 8C

- Jesus has been teaching his disciples and the crowds in Galilee,
    - Previously in this chapter He taught the parable of the sower and the seed
        - A powerful picture of the various reactions men will display when exposed to the Word of God
        - Now Jesus is going to begin demonstrating the truth of what He's preached through a series of miracles and teachings continuing through 8 and into 9
- For example, immediately after he finished teaching the parable, we saw last time how he corrected the disciples when they old Jesus that His mother and brothers were waiting for Him outside the crowd
    - Jesus said that those who hear and do the Word of God were truly in His family
    - Coming on the heels of his teaching of the sower, we can see that Jesus was reinforcing the point of the parable
        - Only those who hear the word and do it can be considered the children of God – believers in other words
        - The even gave Jesus a nice opportunity to
- The miracles in Chap 8 especially are designed to expand the disciples' understanding of Jesus as God and to expose them to a small sample of God's power
    - Remember what we've said Jesus is about doing in these early years of His ministry
        - He has a very limited time with the disciples and He must train them for a very difficult and trying mission
            - Hey will found the early church, in the face of all manner of persecution and hatred
            - They are not scholars or religious leaders – they must obtain a lifetime of training in a few short years

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- So Jesus not only must educate them, He must strengthen them for the ministry He will assign them

- So the events and miracles we'll study over the next few weeks in Chaps 8 & 9 are a major part of Jesus' work to demonstrate the power of the God they will be serving

- And to give the disciples the chance to stretch their own wings in learning to serve in that same power according to God's will

Luke 8:22 ¶ Now on one of *those* days Jesus and His disciples got into a boat, and He said to them, "Let us go over to the other side of the lake." So they launched out.
Luke 8:23 But as they were sailing along He fell asleep; and a fierce gale of wind descended on the lake, and they *began* to be swamped and to be in danger.
Luke 8:24 They came to Jesus and woke Him up, saying, "Master, Master, we are perishing!" And He got up and rebuked the wind and the surging waves, and they stopped, and it became calm.
Luke 8:25 And He said to them, "Where is your faith?" They were fearful and amazed, saying to one another, "Who then is this, that He commands even the winds and the water, and they obey Him?"

- When Jesus taught the parable of the sower, Matt tells us that he used a favorite technique to separate himself from the crowds – he sat in a boat while the crowd stayed on the shore

  - The sea Jesus was sitting on was the Sea of Galilee **(SLIDES)**

    - Galilee means "circle" - Freshwater lake

    - The Sea of Galilee lies roughly 212 m below the level of the Mediterranean, the 2nd lowest point on the earth's surface after the Dead Sea.

    - It is 13 miles long and 8 miles at its greatest width, covering about 41,000 acres with a circumference of 33 miles, and up to 158 ft deep.

    - Not a very large lake but it is substantial

      - By comparison, Canyon Lake is only 8,240 acres and is only 43 feet deep – Galilee is about 4 times larger

    - Depth can produce significant waves

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- Now we hear that Jesus brings the other 12 into the boat and commands them to depart to the other side
    - To give you some idea of the size of the boat, here's a picture of a 19th Century fishing boat on the Sea of Galilee
    - At the other extreme, here's a modern replica of a Roman Fishing boat
    - The one Jesus is in probably falls somewhere in between
    - (I'll make these images available on the website for download along with the teaching)
- As most astute Bible student right away, Jesus' command to the disciples included an assumption
    - He says they should get in the boat, because Jesus wants to visit the other side of the lake
    - Naturally, this means He intends to make it to the other side
        - Any understanding of who Jesus was and where His power came from would take great comfort – and certainty – from hearing Him say that they were going to reach the other side of the lake
        - He didn't say lets go sailing around the lake
        - His goal was to reach the destination
            - And knowing this, the disciples should have been able to rest in that promise, regardless of the circumstances
            - But the ability to enjoy that rest depended upon the extent of their faith
- So they set out, moving from the west side of the lake to the east side
    - And Jesus retreats to the rear of the boat and goes to sleep
    - Mark 4 says Jesus went to the stern of the boat and went to sleep on the cushion
    - Remembering this is probably a larger boat, the stern would have had a high point in the boat, probably protected from the rain by a covering
- Then a fierce gail descended on the boat

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- Now the sea is surrounded by mountain ranges, and so the winds can whip through this region unpredictably and harshly
- The speed of the winds are also prone to extremes – so sudden strong gails are not unheard of
- But the events of the story seem to suggest that the way this storm came upon them was unusually strong and unusually swift

- Luke describes the scene in the boat by saying they were being swamped
  - The word in Greek there is *sumplerro*, which means to fill up completely
    - Mark says that the boat had waves crashing on to it so that it was filling up and in real danger of going under
    - Matthew also says the boat was being covered by the waves
  - Clearly, this would be a hair raising experience
    - Remember these men were experienced fishermen on the Sea of Galilee, and they must have seen most everything in their day
    - Yet this storm makes them fear for their lives – extraordinary storm

- And then there's Jesus – asleep and the rear of the boat
  - The disciples must have been battling the sail and trying to bail the water – maybe just trying to stay in the boat, holding on for dear life
    - And every now and then, they look back toward the stern and keep expecting Jesus to get up anytime now
    - Interestingly, what were they expecting Jesus to do?
      - It's obvious from their later comments that they didn't expect Jesus to stop the storm
        - When He did that, it surprised them
      - So what was their point in watching to see if He had awaken?
      - They expected Him to be as worried as they were
      - Misery loves company

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- But finally, they can't take it any longer…one of the disciples – I always imagine it's Peter – venture to the rear of the boat and wake Him up
    - Imagine the absurdity of the scene
        - The boat is being tossed by huge swells
        - Waves crashing onto the boat and water filling up
        - And Jesus sleeping away peacefully
    - To the disciples, the whole set if circumstances must have seemed surreal, bizarre
        - And when they awaken Jesus, they tell Him they are perishing
            - The word in Greek there is *apullimi*, which means destroyed or brought to an end, dying
        - Mark adds an interesting detail – I think the more accurate record of the disciples statement
            - They are quoted as asking, "Do you not care that we are perishing?"
    - By that comment, it's clear that they were most bothered by Jesus not sharing their concern
        - If they were going to be afraid and panicked, they didn't appreciate that Jesus didn't seem interested in joining them
- Aroused from sleep, Jesus asks, "Where is your faith?"
    - Mark records it as, "Why are you afraid? Do you still have no faith?"
    - What if Jesus referring to? What faith is He talking about?
        - Does He mean they should have had faith that Jesus had power over the elements? - Perhaps
        - Did He mean that they didn't have faith that Jesus was sent by God and could save them? – Perhaps
        - But I think the clearest connection we can make from the events recorded in scripture is that Jesus was referring to their lack of faith in His word

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- What word? – Well, His instructions to cross to the other side, of course
    - Had they had faith in Jesus word, then the storm would have simply posed an inconvenience to their travel
        - It might have slowed them down
        - It might have added to their burden
        - But it certainly didn't mean that they wouldn't make it across the sea, much less that they were going to die in the process
        - Jesus admonishes them for their lack of faith in His word
- Remember in the parable of the sower, Jesus described a condition of the Christian who has true faith but the trials of this world choke off any fruit?
    - Condition 3 Christian we called that person
    - In my earlier teaching we talked a lot about how the pleasures and distractions of our lives can lead to this condition, but we didn't talk as much about worries
        - In Luke 8:14 Jesus says that the worries of this world pose just as much of a risk to our fruitfulness as our distraction by pleasures
        - For many Christians, I believe fear plays an even bigger role in distracting them from producing fruit than pleasures ever could
- We fear so many things in this world – poverty, rejection, discomfort, sickness, weather disasters, even death itself – all things that a Christian has no business fearing
    - Before the apostles can be used by God to produce fruit, they must be able to trust in His word and be willing to act upon it –
        - Because they will be expected to perform miracles with a faith that God will up when they need Him
        - This very issue is going to be front and center in Chap 9, as the Jesus empowers his disciples to go out in ministry for the first time
    - Likewise, we can't expect to produce fruit if we don't trust His word without fear
        - For if we truly understand what it meant to be a child of God

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        - to realize that He controls all things,
        - that even the day of death has been determined before we were born –
    - Then we would hear His word and act upon it with absolute assurance that whatever happens is according to His will
- For example, was this storm an unplanned accident for Jesus and the disciples?
    - I think it's clear from the events of the story that God Himself produced the storm as a test of faith for the disciples
    - He wanted an opportunity to show the disciples that are at risk of living a life like that Condition 3 Christian – the seed that grows up to a certain point but have their spiritual fruit choked off
    - And so the storm is their test of faithfulness
    - And they failed it miserably
- Remember, despite all that their eyes saw and their bodies experienced, they were in no danger,
    - Had they believed in Jesus words and God's power, they wouldn't have had to suffer in fear and panic
        - What a powerful lesson for all of us
        - We have every opportunity to know God's word and trust in it
            - To read His word and understand His promises and assurance
            - To hear His voice in prayer or in circumstances in our lives
            - And then rest in those promises
        - And when the storms of life come upon us, instead of worrying, wringing our hands, crying to God asking why He isn't saving us from the trial
            - Instead, we can be as restful as Jesus in that boat, demonstrating our faith in His word that we are going to reach whatever goal God has set before us
            - And why aren't we so peaceful in the face of trials

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- The only reason that makes sense is that we fear more than we trust

- But here's the main point
  - Even when our faith does fail us as it did for the disciples
    - Even when we assume the worst, and believe we are going to perish, God's plan doesn't change
    - If it's His plan for us to make it to the other side, so to speak, then we're going to make it – even when we don't believe it will happen
      - When the apostles woke Jesus, they had given up hope
      - But Jesus had already said they would make it to the other side
      - And sure enough, they did – despite their lack of faith
  - We can have little or no faith in His word, but he still keeps His word

2Tim. 2:13 If we are faithless, He remains faithful, for He cannot deny Himself.

- Our lack of faith is nothing more than a product of our own spiritual immaturity
  - Once we have been given the gift of faith and the Holy Spirit indwells us, we are adopted into the family of God and there's no going back
  - In the meantime, we may be weak in that faith from time to time, especially in the face of trials, but God doesn't forsake us
  - And He is somehow thwarted from working through us
- On the other hand, consider what we've lost when we fail to trust
  - It is us, not God, who suffer from our lack of faithfulness
    - We lack peace
    - We suffer from fear and apprehension and depression
    - And if this fear and concern is great enough and pervasive enough, it can get in the way of our producing fruit
- But the Word says:

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Phil. 4:6 Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God.
Phil. 4:7 And the peace of God, which surpasses all comprehension, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.

- Notice that a prerequisite for this incredible peace is to place everything in God's hands – make your needs known to Him
    - But the implication from these verses is that we make known these needs because we trust in God to handle them
    - And then we rest in that dependency and trust
    - And then we have peace that defies worldly understanding – Just like Jesus had in that boat
- And since the Father desires to see us prosper spiritually in that same way, He may bring trials upon us so that our strength may be a witness to others in the boat with us
    - Or as the case may be, He may bring trials so that our weakness in faith may be exposed
        - In that way we can see our mistakes and perhaps grow to trust in His word regardless of our circumstances
        - That's a Christian who can be used mightily for the Lord – who will do anything asked and won't hesitate because the worries or riches of this world hold back fruit
- Upon waking and criticizing the apostles, Jesus the proceeds to calm the water with only His word
    - Again a powerful demonstration of His word
        - This outcome continues to reinforce the teaching from the parable
        - Not only the fact that the disciples were still living life as Condition 3 Christians, but that God's word – the seed – is the thing with real power
        - And as expected, the scene left quite an impression on the disciples.

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Luke 8:26 ¶ Then they sailed to the country of the Gerasenes, which is opposite Galilee.
Luke 8:27 And when He came out onto the land, He was met by a man from the city who was possessed with demons; and who had not put on any clothing for a long time, and was not living in a house, but in the tombs.
Luke 8:28 Seeing Jesus, he cried out and fell before Him, and said in a loud voice, "What business do we have with each other, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? I beg You, do not torment me."
Luke 8:29 For He had commanded the unclean spirit to come out of the man. For it had seized him many times; and he was bound with chains and shackles and kept under guard, and *yet* he would break his bonds and be driven by the demon into the desert.
Luke 8:30 And Jesus asked him, "What is your name?" And he said, "Legion"; for many demons had entered him.
Luke 8:31 They were imploring Him not to command them to go away into the abyss.

- Having demonstrated his power over the forces of nature, Jesus is now ready to tackle the second major force in creation – the demonic realm
    - Interestingly, Matt records the entire scene with two demonics rather than just one, while Mark and Luke leave the story to only one
        - It's probably the case that Luke chose to record only one since the point of the event doesn't change if there is one or two men
    - Luke's description is detailed, probably reflecting his medical background
    - Here are the details he notes:
        - The man ran around naked – which was an affront and a great humiliation to him
        - The man had no home, but rather he lived in the tombs
        - He could not be bound and restrained because the demons would cause him to break his bonds, which implied the amazing strength he gained from the demonic possession
        - Marks adds that the man cut himself with stones and ran around the tombs day and night screaming
        - And all this due to demon possession
- This is an amazing scene

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- When scripture says that a man is demon possessed, are you tempted to see this description in a kind of mythical way
  - Does the idea that fallen angels, demons, can inhabit and actually control a man's body seem more like fairy tale than reality to us today?
    - It probably does
    - We probably live our lives today never thinking about people being demon possessed
    - If we were to suggest that possibility to someone, we are the ones who are thought to be crazy or gullible
    - The modern mental health community would never rely no that kind of diagnosis to explain the symptoms seen in this man

- And yet the scripture tells us over and over that this happens, and in Jesus day it happened commonly
  - People recognized that that the demonic realm had this power
  - Today, we're too sophisticated to consider that possibility
  - Which means, if you don't believe that demonic control over human beings is possible today, then one of two things must be true
    - Either the scripture is wrong – demonic possessions are not real
    - Or if you believe the scripture is true, then you would need to point to something that has happened since Jesus day to put an end to demonic possessions
    - Because otherwise, we have no reason to stop believing that such things exist
    - The demonic realm still exists – scripture tells us that
    - And scripture warns us of their power and how they can work through men

- Pauls says to the Corinthian church in his day:

1Cor. 10:19 What do I mean then? That a thing sacrificed to idols is anything, or that an idol is anything?

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1Cor. 10:20 *No*, but *I say* that the things which the Gentiles sacrifice, they sacrifice to demons and not to God; and I do not want you to become sharers in demons.
1Cor. 10:21 You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons; you cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the table of demons.

- Then he speaks of later days when he says:

1Tim. 4:1 ¶ But the Spirit explicitly says that in later times some will fall away from the faith, paying attention to deceitful spirits and doctrines of demons,

- No reason to say that demons are a constant presence in the world until the day that Jesus defeats them and throws into the abyss
    - If you believe scripture, then the only reasonable conclusion is that demons still exist and demonic possession is still a reality
    - And look at the behavior of the man in the tombs
        - Do we not still see people who act this way today?
        - Example in restaurant, example on death penalty case
        - But today, since we are enlightened, we look only for natural causes to such behavior
        - Even if we allow for the fact that sometime the cause of this behavior is natural and not supernatural, it's only fair to assume the opposite – but we never do
- That's the way the demonic realm wants it to be
    - They are very pleased that no one believes in them, or that we only see them as mythical figures
    - They are able to do so much more harm that way
    - Paul says we should see every battle of life, every act of opposition as coming from the enemy

Eph. 6:11 Put on the full armor of God, so that you will be able to stand firm against the schemes of the devil.
Eph. 6:12 For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the powers, against the world forces of this darkness, against the spiritual *forces* of wickedness in the heavenly *places*.

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- And even though we often won't recognize who are enemy is in this world them, they know that we are their enemy

James 2:19 You believe that God is one. You do well; the demons also believe, and shudder.

- Look at how the many demons inside this man's body react to Jesus
    - They see Jesus and fall down
        - Mark says this:

Mark 5:6 Seeing Jesus from a distance, he ran up and bowed down before Him;

    - Demons know that they are promised to be tortured in the abyss awaiting their final judgment (v28)
    - These demons are afraid that Jesus has come for them now
- Jesus begins by asking their name, which is an important detail
    - There was a tradition Jewish method for casting a demon out
        - Jewish religious leaders had done this in Israel in times past, and it was not terribly uncommon for people to be healed from their demon possessions by Jewish religious
        - The method required that the person performing the exocism learn the demon's name because it had to be cast out by name – later in chapter 11
    - The demons answer legion, which isn't a name at all
        - It's the word for a Roman military unit of about 6,000 soldiers – meaning thousands of demons indwelt the man
        - You may remember a story Jesus tells later in this gospel in chap 11

Luke 11:24 ¶ "When the unclean spirit goes out of a man, it passes through waterless places seeking rest, and not finding any, it says, 'I will return to my house from which I came.'
Luke 11:25 "And when it comes, it finds it swept and put in order.

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Luke 11:26 "Then it goes and takes *along* seven other spirits more evil than itself, and they go in and live there; and the last state of that man becomes worse than the first."

- We learn two things from this passage
    - To be cleansed of an evil spirit is not the final solution for a person who is possessed
        - Because the man is an empty house, spiritually speaking, he can be repossessed
    - Which gives us the second thing we learn
        - If we are filled by the Holy Spirit as we are when we become a believer, God hangs a giant no occupancy sign outside our bodies and the demonic realm has no access
        - A believer cannot be indwelt by anything except the holy spirit
- But an unbeliever has no such guarantee, so if a demon is cast out, it must accompany faith in Christ if that person is to remain free
    - The solution remains the same – repent and believe to be saved

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Luke 8:32 ¶ Now there was a herd of many swine feeding there on the mountain; and *the demons* implored Him to permit them to enter the swine. And He gave them permission.
Luke 8:33 And the demons came out of the man and entered the swine; and the herd rushed down the steep bank into the lake and was drowned.
Luke 8:34 ¶ When the herdsmen saw what had happened, they ran away and reported it in the city and *out* in the country.
Luke 8:35 *The people* went out to see what had happened; and they came to Jesus, and found the man from whom the demons had gone out, sitting down at the feet of Jesus, clothed and in his right mind; and they became frightened.
Luke 8:36 Those who had seen it reported to them how the man who was demon-possessed had been made well.
Luke 8:37 And all the people of the country of the Gerasenes and the surrounding district asked Him to leave them, for they were gripped with great fear; and He got into a boat and returned.
Luke 8:38 But the man from whom the demons had gone out was begging Him that he might accompany Him; but He sent him away, saying,
Luke 8:39 "Return to your house and describe what great things God has done for you." So he went away, proclaiming throughout the whole city what great things Jesus had done for him.

- Here it was Jesus desire to free the man from these demons – for what a wonderful testimony this man would have once freed
    - But before Jesus can say anything, the demons are so afraid that they are about to go into the abyss, they actually volunteer to leave the man if they can go into pigs instead of the abyss
    - Jesus gave them permission
        - What a powerful statement
        - They had to ask Jesus what they could do
        - Do you remember Satan talking to God about Job? How God had to grant every little aspect of Satan's authority
        - Then do you remember perhaps in Luke 22 when Jesus tells Peter:

Luke 22:31 ¶ "Simon, Simon, behold, Satan has demanded *permission* to sift you like wheat;

- Do you see the pattern? – God is in control

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- We have no reason to fear the enemy because he can only do what God allows

- If God is for us, who can be against us? That doesn't promise no problems in life, but it means that it is according to what God is allowing to suit His purposes – trust Him no matter what happens

- As the demons enter the swine, the swine apparently react so badly to the indwelling that they run head long into the sea

  - Which is interesting because the sea is often a picture in scripture of the abyss, so it seems the final end of the possessed pigs was intended to be a picture of the demons ultimate fate in the future

  - As a result of this event, word is going to spread about Jesus to the townspeople by way of the herdsman and ultimately this healed man himself

- Now look at the interesting range of reactions

  - This is the first time these people have probably seen Jesus

  - You have the herdsman who were telling people about the miracle – but they were probably also complaining about losing their pigs

  - The towns people were scared by Jesus' display of power, especially upon seeing the healed demonic looking normal

  - Then the man himself, who is so grateful, he wants to remain with Jesus

    - Jesus says no, go back and witness to what I've done

- Before we came to know Christ, we were probably not demon possessed

  - But we were a lot like that man

    - We were naked spiritually

    - We were living in the tombs, a walking corpse

    - We were under the control of the enemy, even if we weren't possessed

    - And we were an enemy of God

  - But he showed up in our hearts one day and freed us from that misery and clothed us and gave us a new life

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- And though we can't go with Him, he asks us to be His witness in the meantime

- Let's rememeber Jesus' words to that man:

Mark 5:19 And He did not let him, but He *said to him, "Go home to your people and report to them what great things the Lord has done for you, and *how* He had mercy on you."
Mark 5:20 And he went away and began to proclaim in Decapolis what great things Jesus had done for him; and everyone was amazed.

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Luke 8D

How did you like the sermon?" "I liked it fine," she replied, "but it seems to me you missed several excellent opportunities."
"Several opportunities for what?" he asked. "To quit." she snapped

Daddy, why do you close your eyes and bow your head for
a moment before you give the sermon?
Pastor: Because, my dear, I'm asking God for help with the sermon.
Daughter: Then why doesn't He?

- Declaring Jesus to be Messiah
    - John was considered the Messiah
    - Then Jesus was baptized and declared himself in Nazareth to be the fulfillment of Isaiah's prophecy
        - But no one believed
    - Then began to perform miracles, which attracted crowds
        - But still no mention of anyone declaring Jesus to be the One
    - Then Jesus cures a man of leprosy, a miracle only the Messiah was said to be capable of
        - Just ever larger crowds
    - Jesus confronts Pharisees, collects disciples, declares men forgiven of sin, teaches the Beatitudes…but still no declaration of Who He is
- Then Jesus hears from the Roman centurion who acknowledges that Jesus is the creator Himself
    - Faith that Jesus said He had not seen in all Israel
    - Then Jesus showed His authority over the wind, waves and demons
        - So where is Jewish recognition of their Messiah?
        - It's the elephant in the room for the reader

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Luke 8:40 ¶ And as Jesus returned, the people welcomed Him, for they had all been waiting for Him.
Luke 8:41 And there came a man named Jairus, and he was an official of the synagogue; and he fell at Jesus' feet, and *began* to implore Him to come to his house;
Luke 8:42 for he had an only daughter, about twelve years old, and she was dying. But as He went, the crowds were pressing against Him.
Luke 8:43 ¶ And a woman who had a hemorrhage for twelve years, and could not be healed by anyone,
Luke 8:44 came up behind Him and touched the fringe of His cloak, and immediately her hemorrhage stopped.

- This passage in Luke is really a miracle within a miracle
    - Luke begins by describing Jairus, an official of the synagogue
        - And this official asked Jesus to come heal his daughter
        - A synagogue official not a priest but rather a minister or caretaker of the local gathering place for Jewish worship
        - He has a 12 year old daughter who is near death and he implores Jesus to come heal her
        - He man's urgent request of Jesus suggests a strong faith in Jesus healing powers, though we don't know to what degree they possessed faith in Jesus as Messiah
    - But before Jesus makes it to Jarius' house, He has this experience with the woman in the crowd
        - It's interesting that all three of the synoptic gospels record these two miracles intertwined
        - There would appear to be a relationship between them
        - And certainly there is…
- Begin with the healing of the bleeding woman
    - Luke sets the scene for us with Jesus in a dense crowd
        - He's attempting to move toward Jarius' house, but naturally the crowd is making that journey very slow and difficult

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- And the crowd is working hard to get near Jesus, to seek healing or see the next miracle
- You can imagine the crowd is noisy and is shoving and pushing
- And Jesus is no doubt being jostled while the disciples are trying in vain to protect Him

- Somewhere from behind Jesus comes this woman
  - The scripture says she had been hemorrhaging for 12 years – she was bleeding internally in a way that caused her to be considered defiled and an outcast
    - Lev 15 gave the Jews strict rules for how to contend with a woman who was bleeding outside her normal menstrual cycle
    - She would be considered unclean, everything she touched would be considered unclean and those who touched her or her bedsheets or garments would be unclean
    - Basically, she was a pariah in the community – and this had been going on for 12 months

- So the woman began to approach Jesus without announcing herself
  - She did this probably for two reasons
    - First, she would have assumed that any rabbi, any holy man would not have been willing to touch her or even speak with her since she was an unclean member of society according to the law
      - So she believes she needs to come to Jesus secretly and touch Him without Him knowing she was there
    - Secondly, she would be afraid of telling anyone else in the crowd of her situation because they would have forced her away
      - Had they known that she was unclean, they would not have allowed her to approach Jesus for fear they would touch her and become unclean
      - So she wants to blend into the crowd and be invisible

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- The more important question to ask is why did the woman want to touch Jesus? Why did she think that would heal her?
    - Remember, there were throngs of people all around Jesus
    - He was being touched on all sides by people who desired healing, and it must have been evident that these other people in the crowd were not being healing in this way
        - Yes, Jesus was probably healing some of them from time to time, but only when He desired to heal them
        - The rest of the time, there is no reason to think that people were being healed merely touching Jesus
        - So, this woman is holding onto a unique idea
            - She believes that merely touching the fringe of Jesus' tunic will heal her
            - What does she know that the rest in the crowd don't?
            - Is this superstition on her part? Some kind of wishful thinking? No.
- To fully understand what's going on here, we need to take a few moments to become familiar with one of the more obscure prophecies of the Messiah out of the Old Testament
    - We'll begin with understanding the clothes that were typically worn by a Rabbi
        - Typically, men wore two garments, a light inner tunic, almost like underwear
        - And a heavier outer garment worn over the tunic called a tallit, sometimes called a prayer shawl today
        - At the corners of the tallit were tassels of knotted thread call tsitsityot
        - These tassles were knotted five times to represent the 5 books of the Torah: Genesis, Exodus, Lev, Num, Deut
        - Interwoven in the thread was as single blue thread to remind the nation of Israel that they were a kingdom of priests

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Num. 15:37 ¶ The LORD also spoke to Moses, saying,
Num. 15:38 "Speak to the sons of Israel, and tell them that they shall make for themselves tassels on the corners of their garments throughout their generations, and that they shall put on the tassel of each corner a cord of blue.
Num. 15:39 "It shall be a tassel for you to look at and remember all the commandments of the LORD, so as to do them and not follow after your own heart and your own eyes, after which you played the harlot,
Num. 15:40 so that you may remember to do all My commandments and be holy to your God.

- Over time, these tassels had become a very important part of Jewish society
  - They were a part of someone's very reputation and personality
    - To remove the hem of a Jewish man's garment was an act of humiliation
    - Tablets have been found with impressions of a man's tassels as his signature on a document
    - A man could divorce a woman by cutting off the hem of her tallit
    - Remember in 1Sam 24 when Saul is pursuing David in the wilderness, and as Saul is sitting using the bathroom in a cave, David sneaks up from behind and quietly cuts of the hem of his garment
    - He wasn't merely showing how he showed Saul mercy while he was vulnerable, he was adding to Saul's humiliation by removing the hem of his garment
- By Jesus' day, the tassled hem on the tallit also came to represent the status and importance of the wearer in society
  - Ordinary people only worn their tallit on special occasions
  - But Pharisees had taken to wearing them regularly as an outward show of piety and importance
  - In fact, the Pharisees took the practice even farther by increasing the length of their tassels beyond the customary length in an effort to show off their extreme religiousity

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Matt. 23:2 saying: "The scribes and the Pharisees have seated themselves in the chair of Moses;
Matt. 23:3 therefore all that they tell you, do and observe, but do not do according to their deeds; for they say *things* and do not do *them*.
Matt. 23:4 "They tie up heavy burdens and lay them on men's shoulders, but they themselves are unwilling to move them with *so much as* a finger.
Matt. 23:5 "But they do all their deeds to be noticed by men; for they broaden their phylacteries and lengthen the tassels *of their garments*.

- The phylacteries were small boxes tied to their hair that hung down around their head
- In the boxes were small sections of scripture
- This was done according to instructions in Exodus and Deut
- But the Pharisees taken to making these boxes larger and larger to show off

  - Likewise, they had started to lengthen their tassels to make a show to men – something that we all need to be on guard against – especially me

- In the OT, a prophecy had been given by the prophet Malachi that the Messiah when he came would have the power of healing in his tassels

Mal. 4:1 ¶ "For behold, the day is coming, burning like a furnace; and all the arrogant and every evildoer will be chaff; and the day that is coming will set them ablaze," says the LORD of hosts, "so that it will leave them neither root nor branch."
Mal. 4:2 "But for you who fear My name, the sun of righteousness will rise with healing in its wings; and you will go forth and skip about like calves from the stall.

- In verse 2, there is description of the sun of righteousness

  - The word for sun (shemesh) means the sun in the sky
  - The fact that it sounds likes son is just a consequence of the English language
  - In Hebrew the word son is ben
  - But the context of the verse still allows us to see the picture of the sun rising to be euphemistic of the rising of the Messiah

    - The context of Malachi chapter 4, in fact the entire book, reinforces this interpretation

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- The other interesting part of these verse is the reference to healing in his wings
    - Wings is another euphemistic way of describing the tassels on a man's garment
    - In fact, the word translated corner in Num 15:38 is kanaph, which means wing
    - So the Jewish nation had grown up with the understanding that the Messiah would have the power of healing in His wings or tassels
- So here we have in Luke 8 a woman who is quietly approaching the Messiah as he walks in a dense, pushing shoving crowd hoping to touch the Messiah
    - We know she is trying to get close enough to touch the tassels because in Matt's account we hear this detail:

Matt. 9:20 ¶ And a woman who had been suffering from a hemorrhage for twelve years, came up behind Him and touched the fringe of His cloak;
Matt. 9:21 for she was saying to herself, "If I only touch His garment, I will get well."

    - Clearly, the woman is thinking about the prophecy in Malachi and has decided that touching the Messiah will make her well
    - And of course when she reaches Jesus and touches his garment, she is instantly healed

Luke 8:45 And Jesus said, "Who is the one who touched Me?" And while they were all denying it, Peter said, "Master, the people are crowding and pressing in on You."
Luke 8:46 But Jesus said, "Someone did touch Me, for I was aware that power had gone out of Me."
Luke 8:47 When the woman saw that she had not escaped notice, she came trembling and fell down before Him, and declared in the presence of all the people the reason why she had touched Him, and how she had been immediately healed.
Luke 8:48 And He said to her, "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace."

- You can't help but smile a little as you hear the disciples' response to jesus' question
    - They must have looked back at him with this look that said you've got to be kidding?
        - They might have thought he was joking at first

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        - You're surrounded by people pushing and shoving, and you want to know who touched you?

        - As if He were bothered by the fact that someone touched him

- But as Jesus demanded to know, the crowd might have paused for a moment

    - And no doubt the woman must have shrunk back, thinking she was in trouble

    - And Jesus continued to search for her saying He was aware power had gone out from him

        - This is an interesting moment, if you think about it

            - Jesus doesn't seem to be fully in control of his own healing power

            - He knows he healed but he doesn't know who it seems

            - It seems to reinforce the point we've seen earlier where we saw that Jesus while a man had to rely on the Holy Spirit for insight and power to heal

            - So it seems that Jesus was aware that the Father healed through Him but he's not aware of who he healed

- Now the woman must have been terrified

    - She was sure he would never notice her, but not she realizes that she has been found out

        - The crowd must have begin to back off somewhat as Jesus pressed them for answer to His question

            - Finally the woman comes trembling through the crowd and falls down before Jesus

            - And she gives her public testimony for why she touched Jesus, at which point, Jesus and says her faith has healed her

- Now we can understand what He meant

    - He wasn't commending her faith in the ritual of touching his garment so much as her faith in Him as the Messiah

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        - A faith that was reflected in how she sought to touch his hem
        - Touching the hem of a rabbi's tallit had no special significance, but touching the hem of the Messiah had tremendous significance
        - She proved her faith in Him by how she behaved toward his garment

- Consider the dramatic contrast of that moment
    - Here are all these people surround Jesus…pushing to get close to him
    - All of them desiring healing every bit as much as this woman did
    - All of them making as much physical contact with Jesus as they could
    - And yet only she was healed
        - And the difference was only what they thought about who Jesus was
            - That is the only thing that mattered
            - And that's the only thing that matters today
    - Today, just like then, there are a lot of people who want o get close to the Jesus they've heard about
        - They here that he can make our lives wonderful
            - He can make us rich or he can heal us
            - Or he can solve emotional problems
            - So often Christians sell their faith to others as if it were a cure all

- So people who don't know the truth about Christ come into churches or other gatherings much the same way those people in the crowd came
    - They have high hopes and great expectations
    - They truly believe that Jesus can heal or provide or bless them in some way
    - And they are prepared to do whatever is required – whatever ritual, whatever sacrifice - to make it happen

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- The only thing that's missing is a faith in who Jesus is
    - Because that's the key – who do you believe Jesus is
    - Not believe in his power or his teaching or whatever else you may have heard about him
    - Do you believe in Who He was – the only true Son of the only true living God – God Himself – the One and only way to know the father
    - On that question rests everything
- Now consider the second miracle briefly

Luke 8:49 ¶ While He was still speaking, someone *came from *the house of* the synagogue official, saying, "Your daughter has died; do not trouble the Teacher anymore."
Luke 8:50 But when Jesus heard *this*, He answered him, "Do not be afraid *any longer*; only believe, and she will be made well."
Luke 8:51 When He came to the house, He did not allow anyone to enter with Him, except Peter and John and James, and the girl's father and mother.
Luke 8:52 Now they were all weeping and lamenting for her; but He said, "Stop weeping, for she has not died, but is asleep."
Luke 8:53 And they *began* laughing at Him, knowing that she had died.
Luke 8:54 He, however, took her by the hand and called, saying, "Child, arise!"
Luke 8:55 And her spirit returned, and she got up immediately; and He gave orders for *something* to be given her to eat.
Luke 8:56 Her parents were amazed; but He instructed them to tell no one what had happened.

- As the incident with the woman was ending, a messenger comes to tell Jesus not to bother coming to the house, for the daughter has already died
    - Jesus then turns immediately to the father, who must have still bee walking with Jesus and says don't be afraid but believe and she will be made well
        - Now imagine what was going through the mind of the father at that moment
        - He had just witnessed this woman being healed – but the point had been made in a very obvious way for that crowd that her faith had come because she believed in who Jesus was
    - Now the father had his opportunity to see healing on the basis of faith

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- Don't we see the grace and mercy of God even in this small detail?
    - A man who might have otherwise been given over to despair had reason to hope and believe because of the miracle God did before him as they walked to his house
    - That's the God we serve
        - He delights in building our faith one small step at a time, showing us little victories along the way – whether they are our own of someone else's
        - So that we will have reason to hope in Him and trust in Him

- Don't ever fail to take notice of the work of God in the people around you, because I assure you that God is not placing those events before you merely for entertainment purposes
    - He is trying to get your attention and teach you even as He may be preparing to do great things in your life according ot your faith in Him

- When Jesus arrives at the home, however, he is greeted by anything but faith
    - When Jesus declares that the girl is sleeping, the crowd laughs
    - Now we need to know from Matt that Jesus directed his comments about the girl sleeping to the crowd outside, and it was this group that was laughing, not the disciples and the parents
        - He probably limited those he brought into the room because of the small size of the girl's room
        - And He brought these disciples because they would be the leaders of the church
        - He then proceeds to go in and raise the girl from the dead, command that she be given food, which amazes everyone there

- When Jesus said she was sleeping, He wasn't joking and He wasn't speaking euphemistically
    - Jesus is saying that the death of the body is merely a period of time when the body is unavailable and the person is away from us in spirit

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- The person has not ceased to exist spiritually
- If we live our life thinking that all that exists is what we can see, then we're fools – life goes on spiritually after death one way or another
- And Jesus proves that He has the power over both realms when He raised people from the dead and places them back into their bodies – something no other religion can claim with the proof of Christianity
    - It was the very fact that Jesus could do what He did that threatened the Jewish and Roman authorities

- In these two miracles, Jesus demonstrates that he has come to heal the sick and raise the dead
    - For those who are spiritually sick and in need of healing from the effects of sin, Jesus is the one who heals
        - But his healing is reserved for those who believe
        - Likewise, Jesus has the power to raise from the dead, because ultimately the only solution for man's sinful condition is the end of this corrupt body and the receiving of a new body
            - But did you notice that though His power to heal us spiritually – to give us a new spirit and everlasting life is dependent on our faith
            - But the His ability to raise the body from the dead is not dependent on faith
            - When Jesus raised the little girl, he was surrounded by people who didn't believe he could do it
            - They laughed at his suggestion that the girl was only sleeping
            - But he did it anyway
    - One day every knee will bow and every tongue will confess – believe and unbeliever
        - And he will raise everyone from the dead, but some will be raised to destruction

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- As we seek to bear fruit by our faith and work on behalf of the kingdom, we must never let our good intentions and our desire to see men saved lead us to water down the truth of the gospel message
    - To believe is to believe in a person – in the person of Jesus Christ
        - Thinking He was a good person or a good teacher or a prophet as Muslins say, is pointless because such belief cannot save
        - To bring others to a knowledge of the gospel is first and foremost about bringing them to know who Christ is
    - Secondly, if they refuse to believe, then we should tell with as much love and concern as we can about the consequences for unbelief, for failing to trust for their salvation in Jesus
        - That one day they will stand before him and confess him, but it will be too late to receive His mercy – for they will have rejected him when the opportunity was given

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Luke 9A

A young man entered a monastery hoping to become a monk. The Order which he wished to join had a strict rule of silence. The abbot told him on his first day that he would be on probation for fifteen years. During that time he would be allowed to speak only once every five years and then only for one minute with the abbot himself. The young man accepted and was registered as a novitiate. Eventually the first five years passed and he was summoned to the abbot's study.

"How are you going on, my son?" asked the abbot.
"Oh, all right, thank you, Reverend Father," replied the young man.
"Have you any complaints?" asked the abbot.
"Well, Sir, yes, there is one thing. The porridge is always cold at breakfast. It would be so much nicer if it were hot."
"Right," said the abbot, "I will see to that. Time is now up."

The young man left and did not speak again to anyone for five years. Then he had to go again to the abbot's study.
"How are you going on?" asked the abbot.
"Oh, all right, thank you, Sir, I think," answered the novitiate.
"Have you any complaints?" asked the abbot.
"Well, Sir, there is just one thing, the bed is very hard and I find it difficult to sleep. Could I please have a little more straw in my mattress?"
"Right," said the abbot, "I will see to that. Time is now up." And the young man had to leave.

Another five years passed and the young man went to see the abbot for the last time.
"Reverend Father," he said, "my fifteen years' probation is at an end. Are you going to accept me as a full member of your Order?"
"Dear me, no," replied the abbot. "You have done nothing but complain since you got here!"

- Today we move into Chapter 9
    - This chapter marks a new division in the Gospel of Luke
        - Along the way we've been following several themes in Luke
        - First, Luke substantiated who Jesus was, the Son of God.
            - He detailed over several chapters how Jesus demonstrated his authority and power to the people and to the apostles
        - Secondly, Luke showed how Jesus contended with the Pharisees

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- The religious leaders who desired nothing more than to tear down Jesus because He posed a powerful threat to their empire

- Then in Chapter 7 we saw Luke introduce a third theme of how Jesus would begin to prepare to disciples for ministry in the church after His resurrection

- Today in Chapter 9, Luke continues to build and develop the theme
  - Of how Jesus prepared these 12 immature and untrained men for perhaps the most difficult ministry calling the world had ever seen
  - And Chap 9 also begins to introduce a fourth major theme of Luke's gospel – Jesus' long road toward Jerusalem and His preparation to face the cross
    - Luke takes great pains to demonstrate not only that Jesus had come to die
      - But that God's plan for the Messiah included this ending that was completely unexpected for the disciples
      - In fact, it was one the disciples wouldn't understand even as the event approached
  - Jesus' death carried an ominous consequence for the apostles
    - All of them would experience much the same persecution and even death as Jesus
    - Imagine how you prepare someone for that future – and yet still expect them to continue forward in that ministry

Luke 9:1 ¶ And He called the twelve together, and gave them power and authority over all the demons and to heal diseases.
Luke 9:2 And He sent them out to proclaim the kingdom of God and to perform healing.
Luke 9:3 And He said to them, "Take nothing for *your* journey, neither a staff, nor a bag, nor bread, nor money; and do not *even* have two tunics apiece.
Luke 9:4 "Whatever house you enter, stay there until you leave that city.
Luke 9:5 "And as for those who do not receive you, as you go out from that city, shake the dust off your feet as a testimony against them."
Luke 9:6 Departing, they *began* going throughout the villages, preaching the gospel and healing everywhere.

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Luke 9:7 ¶ Now Herod the tetrarch heard of all that was happening; and he was greatly perplexed, because it was said by some that John had risen from the dead,
Luke 9:8 and by some that Elijah had appeared, and by others that one of the prophets of old had risen again.
Luke 9:9 Herod said, "I myself had John beheaded; but who is this man about whom I hear such things?" And he kept trying to see Him.

- At some point following the events of Chapter 8, Jesus calls his disciples together
    - He gives them power and authority to do much as Jesus did – cast out demons and heal diseases
    - With those powers, He then sends them out to do two things:
        - Proclaim the kingdom
        - And perform miracles
- And Jesus gives them a few very specific instructions about how they should conduct themselves along the way
    - They shall take nothing with them
    - They can't take money, they can't take food, they can't take extra clothing
    - They are to depend on the people in the towns for a place to stay, not to stay in a hotel
    - And if they are not received, they are to leave them and testify that they have not received the kingdom they were offered
- Before we examine these instructions in detail, what is Jesus doing here? – Why send the disciples out in this way?
    - Well, one answer is probably fairly obvious
        - Remember we've been talking all along about how Jesus is already looking forward to the day He will depart the Earth and ascend into Heaven
        - On that day, He will leave behind 11 men who will need to understand how to pursue the spreading of the gospel in a hostile world

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- They will need to understand the lessons he taught them
- They will need to understand the persecution they will face
- They will need to understand the power that is available to them from God to ensure the success of their mission

- There is a second answer though, and that is this is the opportunity for the Jewish nation to receive their Messiah
  - We may know how the story ends, with Jesus rejected by His people and sent to the cross
  - And we know that this was God's plan from the beginning
    - The prophets foretold that the Messiah would die and be hung on a tree – a cross in other words
    - Jesus was to be a sacrifice for the sake of man
  - But God will also bring about a time of judgment for the Jewish nation in rejecting their Messiah
    - The Jews were supposed to be looking for a Messiah,
    - But God purposed for them to rejected the Messiah, Paul tells us in Rom 11, so that the Gentile world – who wasn't even looking for a Messiah - would have the opportunity to receive Christ
    - This was to fulfill the promise God gave Abraham when He said in Gen 22:18 that all the nations of the world would be blessed
  - So now as the disciples go out to the surrounding towns of Judea, they will be used by God to give the Jewish nation their opportunity,
    - They will hear but largely they will reject the truth,
    - So that God may be just in His judgment against the nation for its rejection of His Son
    - We will studied their rejection in detail in Chap 11, for now we can simply make note of it as one of the purposes in the disciples going out in this way

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- For both these reasons, this is the ideal time for Jesus to send them out
    - Send them out any earlier and they probably wouldn't have been ready for such a task
    - Much later and they probably would have faced too much persecution and opposition from the authorities
        - In fact, we heard that Herod is becoming disturbed by the fact that Jesus in attracting such crowds
        - He killed the last man who caused so much disruption, John the Baptist, and now he seems to have a ghost on his hands, or so he thinks
- Let's look more closely at how Jesus goes about conducting this practical training for the disciples
    - Luke says they received
        - power – dunamis – miraculous strength and ability
        - authority – exousia - dominion, jurisdiction to act
        - Luke alone mentions that they received both these things
        - Luke wanted to make especially clear that both are necessary and both come from God
    - Jesus grants them two specific powers
        - The power to cast out demons
        - And the power to heal
        - And they are to perform these miracles in connection with preaching the good news
- Consider power
    - Men do not normally have the ability to bring healing to another person in a supernatural way
        - Men do not naturally have power to contend with the demonic realm
        - Under normal circumstances, these things lie outside our power

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- But men can gain supernatural abilities in one of two ways
  - First, God Himself can grant these abilities
  - We see it here, obviously, but we've seen it before in scripture
    - God granted Moses the power to perform miracles
    - God granted Elijah supernatural abilities like raising from the dead and calling fire down from heaven
    - God grants Joshua supernatural abilities during battles

- But there is a second source of supernatural power
  - The enemy is the prince of the power of the air
  - He has true spiritual power
    - Not greater than God's and always subject to God's authority
    - But God gives Satan a lease if you will to do certain things, including granting to men supernatural power
      - When Moses had power, the magicians of Pharaoh had similar powers granted by the enemy
        - (yet Moses staff ate the magicians staff)
      - In Jesus day there were men who would heal or command out spirits, but they were often using the power of the enemy to do these things
  - The scripture calls this kind of power divination or sorcery or witchcraft

Deut. 18:10 "There shall not be found among you anyone who makes his son or his daughter pass through the fire, one who uses divination, one who practices witchcraft, or one who interprets omens, or a sorcerer,

  - The nation of Israel was corrupted in part through divination, and the Lord judged them for it
  - Saul turned to divination rather than relying on God and the prophet Samuel told him this:

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1Sam. 15:23 "For rebellion is as the sin of divination,
And insubordination is as iniquity and idolatry.
Because you have rejected the word of the LORD,
He has also rejected you from *being* king."

- In that verse, you can see the essential problem with divination
    - When someone seeks after that source of spiritual power, they have rejected the Lord
        - For you cannot serve two masters, and to serve the one is to reject the other
        - Seeking to tap into the power that Satan offers is to reject dependence on God
        - Our culture is obsessed with this source of power, and often they attribute it falsely to God
        - We need to be careful to show discernment…video games, music, movies – be careful what we approve

Phil. 1:9 And this I pray, that your love may abound still more and more in real knowledge and all discernment,
Phil. 1:10 so that you may approve the things that are excellent, in order to be sincere and blameless until the day of Christ;

- That brings us to the second thing Jesus granted the disciples
    - He gave them exousia – the dominion, the authority
    - Paul tells us in Ephesians that this world is the property of the enemy for a time

Eph. 2:2 in which you formerly walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience.

    - Though the world has been redeemed by Christ's blood, Christ is not yet exercising his authority over this world
        - He is waiting for the appointed time, when He will reign over the world as promised during the Messianic kingdom

- Meanwhile, the world is the dominion of the evil one

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- Though the disciples might have supernatural powers to contend with the enemy, just having the power is not enough
- They also need the jurisdiction in which to exercise that power
  - Consider the example of a state trooper who chases a stolen car to the state line
    - As the car crosses the state line, the trooper has to stop his pursuit
    - He still has the things that give him power to subdue the thief – his car, gun, his handcuffs, his physical strength
    - But he lacks the authority to use them
- Likewise, the apostles were given power to operate in the supernatural realm, but if that's all they had, they could have been thwarted by the enemy
  - The enemy could have stood his ground against them since he would have still had his authority
  - He could not have been subdued by their power – and they would not have succeeded in casting out demons or stopping disease brought about by the enemy
  - But God granted them authority for a limited time and purpose so that the enemy and his agents had no choice but to obey the commands of the disciples
- By the way, this is one of the reasons that the enemy can create such convincing demonstrations of supernatural power
  - He can fool people into thinking that the power they see is of God because it is true power and because it has authority in this world
  - False teachers, agents of the enemy can come in God's name and fool people because their audience is more interested in the signs and wonders than in the words of truth in the Bible

- And that's one of the most important things about understanding this passage
  - Christians don't generally have these kinds of powers or authority granted to us by God

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- They come only when He desires to grant them and for limited purpose
- They are not something every believe should expect and certainly not on demand

- And God wants it that way because the gospel is to be heard and believed on the basis of faith – not on the basis of what can be seen or proven to the satisfaction of a skeptic
  - Paul reminds us in Romans 10:17 that faith comes by hearing
  - He says to believe is to hope in something unseen

- God is not pleased to reveal Himself to those who demand proof before believing
  - Rather, He chooses to save those who, through a belief in something that seems foolish to the world, would place their trust in His word

1Cor. 1:21 For since in the wisdom of God the world through its wisdom did not *come to* know God, God was well-pleased through the foolishness of the message preached to save those who believe.
1Cor. 1:22 For indeed Jews ask for signs and Greeks search for wisdom;
1Cor. 1:23 but we preach Christ crucified, to Jews a stumbling block and to Gentiles foolishness,
1Cor. 1:24 but to those who are the called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.

- When Christians believe or are taught that they should want or expect to see such supernatural powers, it's not only unbiblical, it's dangerous
  - It's built upon an assumption that if Christ granted these abilities to the disciples then He must have granted them to us too
  - Which is simply a nonsensical argument
    - That's like saying the Apostle Thomas was allowed to place his hands in Jesus side, therefore I should have the same opportunity
    - Or the Apostle Peter was crucified upside down, so I should expect the same ending
  - One Christian's experience rarely mirrors another's, so how much less will our experience mirror the disciples?

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        - Our experiences differ because God's purpose for our lives and ministries are different

        - He does not act the same way through each and every believer

    - The early church was built upon these kind of special powers because they had no history, no frame of reference, little understanding of what the church was

        - So, having powers like those Jesus granted the disciples was important to propel the message and establish the church

        - And although God may chose to act similarly today from time to time, He is not obligated to do so

        - Now that the world has His word (the New Testament), we know of the acts of the apostles, we have the miracle of Pentecost, and the testimony of 2,000 years of the church history and the work of the Holy Spirit in the lives of millions of believers

        - So it's unnecessary for God to grant Christians widespread ability to manifest truth in such a way – it would negate the truth and sufficiency of His word

            - And our own experience demonstrates that to be true

- Even though we can't presume to receive the powers of the disciples, we can still learn a great deal from listening to Jesus' instructions concerning their first evangelism effort

    - Jesus says, take nothing for your journey

        - He says don't take a staff (though Mark's account said perhaps take a staff)

            - A staff would have been an implement to aid walking, especially in long distances – but a burden on a short walk

            - So don't assume you will need to do a lot of walking – make no assumptions about the journey

        - Don't pack a bag (suitcase) and don't take food

            - Again, these things implied we've made some assumption about the trip or how long they would be gone

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- They would also be something to depend upon and to sustain oneself – to allow a certain degree of independence

- Don't take two tunics

- Men often wore an additional tunic as protection against having one torn, soiled, etc.

- This is like telling someone to leave on a trip without an extra set of underwear

- Finally, Jesus tells the disciples they should expect to be housed in the homes that they preach to

  - Essentially, they will be doing cold calls all day with the expectation that before the day is done, someone will provide a place for them to stay

  - Or going to the town watering well and expecting someone to invite them home for dinner and a place to stay

  - And if they don't receive such a welcome, they were to demonstrate that judgment was upon these towns by dusting off their feet

    - Remember that one of the ways a person showed another hospitality was to offer to wash their feet

      - Walking in that day in that terrain with sandals left the feet caked with dirt and very uncomfortable

      - If they had not had their feet washed, then it meant they had never been received in a home

      - So they would show condemnation of that town by dusting off their dirty feet in a show of how poorly they had been treated– a terrible insult against a host

- What's Jesus doing? Jesus is training the disciples in several disciplines at once. First there is the very process of spreading the good news

  - These men need practice in preaching and delivering the good news

    - They will be armed with power and authority so that their message gains attention and can be proven

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- Remember, there's been no resurrection yet, no Pentecost, No New Testament, so no proof of the truth of their message
- Rather, their authority over the demonic realm will have to be the proof for the time being, so that the people might have something to point to know they are telling the truth
- To ignore all that and demand the same powers that the apostles had is simply unbelief

▪ And these men were probably pretty lousy at the evangelism at first, even with their powers

- They probably stumbled over their words
- They probably got embarrassed easily
- They probably got shouted down at times
- But then there were times that great, miraculous things happened

o If the disciples needed practice, then it's safe to say we all need practice

▪ We all need to practice our spiritual disciples, or they won't improve

▪ And we probably won't have the powers the disciples had, we have the Word and the Holy Spirit

- So first was practicing evangelism.
- Secondly, Jesus wanted them to experience the rejection that would often come in the face of the gospel message

o Did you notice the implied expectation that they would see rejection?

o Jesus knows that they will be rejected like He will be

▪ They needed to know that 99 rejections doesn't matter. They still go to #100 expecting success – it's all in God's hands anyway

▪ We are simply spreading seed without necessarily waiting to see if plants sprout in all cases

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1Cor. 3:6 I planted, Apollos watered, but God was causing the growth.
1Cor. 3:7 So then neither the one who plants nor the one who waters is anything, but God who causes the growth.

- Finally, Jesus is teaching them to rely on God for not only their power and authority, not only on God for their success, but also on God to sustain them through the hard task
    - Jesus' instructions told them to presume nothing about your journey
        - Don't take anything that suggests you have a plan, that you know where things are headed
        - Because as soon as you do that, you begin working your plan and not God's
        - Rely on Him, let Him lead, don't start working your own plan
        - Have no Plan B – no backup
        - Simply trust in God to provide
    - Why was this important for the disciples?
    - First, consider that in Matt's account we hear

Matt. 10:10 for the worker is worthy of his support.

- So this was a two way street
- On the one hand they were to be dependent on those they ministered to so that those who received something of value from these men could experience the blessing of offering something of value in return
    - There is truly a blessing in being able to reward those through whom God ministers to us (example of Alistair Begg)
    - We should not see support to ministry as a matter of obligation, but rather an opportunity for our own blessing
    - If the disciples were to remain so self-sufficient and independent
        - Pack their won lunch
        - Have their own means to house themselves

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        - Such that others were not required to support them with housing or food or clothing, then they've denied those people the opportunity to know the blessing of being used by God to support His work

- Secondly, and probably more importantly, self-sufficiency robs the disciples of the joy and strength that comes from watching God direct us

- Watching where and how He will makes provision and allow that to be a guide in itself

    - When are tummies are full, our closets are full, our garage is full, our bank accounts are full, then why would we think to look to God for provision or direction?

        - We're so self-satisfied that if God ever did direct us, we wouldn't be listening

    - So often God has to strip those things away to get our attention and draw us to a point where we are ready to hear him

        - If we're hungry and in need of food, then we'll be watching and waiting to see how He will provide

            - And maybe we'll be open to the invitation of a stranger who invites in and we get an opportunity to minister the very person God intended

        - When we're in need, when we have nothing to fall back upon – that's we're more likely to listen to him direct us to new opportunities where our gifts are needed the most

- The greatest impediment to our spiritual growth in this culture is our wealth and self-sufficiency

    - Like the church in Laodicea, we're blind to our own spiritual need because our physical needs are being met so well

        - Jesus wanted these men to be successful, and their success could come only if they were 100% dependent on God for power, authority, for success and even for their physical support

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Luke 9:10 ¶ When the apostles returned, they gave an account to Him of all that they had done. Taking them with Him, He withdrew by Himself to a city called Bethsaida. Luke 9:11 But the crowds were aware of this and followed Him; and welcoming them, He *began* speaking to them about the kingdom of God and curing those who had need of healing.

- So Jesus has given his disciples the opportunity to experience service to the Lord for the sake of the kingdom
    - They came back with wondrous stories, they would have been excited,
    - More than that, they came back with followers
    - Their ministry had produced fruit, and in Mark we hear:

, Mark 6:31 And He *said to them, "Come away by yourselves to a secluded place and rest a while." (For there were many *people* coming and going, and they did not even have time to eat.)

- But that's what we should all expect
    - Our ministry if we are obedient to our calling in whatever form it takes, will bear fruit in the form of new faithful
    - And we will lead people to Jesus
    - And He will receive them
- As we will see next week, Jesus then feeds this entire crowd with a few loaves and fishes
    - He can take care of as many as you can bring back to the party

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Luke 9B

- As we ended last week, Jesus had reassembled his apostles after having sent them out to perform miracles and proclaim the kingdom of God in the surrounding area
    - As we studied, the disciples had been somewhat successful, and they had managed to bring back crowds with them
    - Jesus and disciples try to retreat to a town nearby called Bethesda – city of fish – but the people follow and Jesus responds compassionately by teaching them and healing them
    - So here is this huge crowd was gathered around Jesus and the men, and there must have been a growing sense of helplessness in the moment for the disciples
    - How were they going to accommodate so many people? They may have even tried to send them away, but it became obvious they weren't going to leave as they hoped they would receive healing
- So the disciples turn to Jesus for help

Luke 9:12 ¶ Now the day was ending, and the twelve came and said to Him, "Send the crowd away, that they may go into the surrounding villages and countryside and find lodging and get something to eat; for here we are in a desolate place."
Luke 9:13 But He said to them, "You give them *something* to eat!" And they said, "We have no more than five loaves and two fish, unless perhaps we go and buy food for all these people."
Luke 9:14 (For there were about five thousand men.) And He said to His disciples, "Have them sit down *to eat* in groups of about fifty each."
Luke 9:15 They did so, and had them all sit down.
Luke 9:16 Then He took the five loaves and the two fish, and looking up to heaven, He blessed them, and broke *them*, and kept giving *them* to the disciples to set before the people.
Luke 9:17 And they all ate and were satisfied; and the broken pieces which they had left over were picked up, twelve baskets *full*.

- This is probably the most famous miracle Jesus performs
    - It's the only miracle recorded in all four gospels

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- Because of that, we can gain wonderful insight about this event by comparing the four gospels

- Start with some simple observation
  - The text tells us 5 thousand men were gathered, but the other gospels tell us that there were women and children present and they ate as well
  - So it's likely that the actual number of people was 10,000 or more
  - This is a huge crowd
    - Obviously, Jesus' ministry is now really starting to attract attention
    - Imagine if you are the authorities in the Jesus day – whether the Romans or the Jewish leaders
    - Either way, you're going to start feeling threatened by such large gatherings
      - If the crowds get big enough and devoted enough, you have an army

- The second thing we note from the text is it's late in the day, and the people are without food or shelter

- This is a concern for probably a couple of reasons
  - First, travel at night was dangerous and they rolled the street up at night
  - So out of concern for the people, the apostles wanted the people to leave while they still had a chance to find a place to stay and eat

- Secondly, the crowds are not only growing big, their growing more restless and nationalistic
  - When you look at the account in John after Jesus feeds the crowd, John tell us this

John 6:15 ¶ So Jesus, perceiving that they were intending to come and take Him by force to make Him king, withdrew again to the mountain by Himself alone.

  - John also tells us that verse 4:

John 6:4 Now the Passover, the feast of the Jews, was near.

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- The time of the Passover was a very nationalistic time for the Jewish nation
    - All the years that they were under Roman rule, the Roman authorities were always most concerned about the Passover time of year
        - Remember what the Passover meant to the Jews
        - It was the a remembrance of how the Jews were freed from bondage under and oppressor – the Egyptians
        - So every year as Passover approached, the Jews were primed and waiting for something or someone who might be the one to be a new Moses, someone who would free them from their oppressor
        - And here's Jesus, a man who seems to be the one God promised – the one who might have the power to defeat the Roman enemy and drive it out of the Jewish homeland
- So, John tells us that this was, in fact, the sentiment within this growing crowd
    - But clearly Jesus didn't want them to think of Him in that way
    - There was a plan to carry out, and it didn't include His sitting in the seat of David on this coming – that would wait for another time

- But at this point, the disciples have no clue about the larger plan
    - They're just getting a little nervous at the sight of this large, nationalistic crowd rising up in fervor over Jesus hoping to place Him on the throne
    - And if there's one thing worse than a large nationalistic crowd of Jews, it's a large nationalistic crowd of hungry Jews
    - So the disciples want to see them fed and seeing no way to do that, they beg Jesus to send them away
- So they ask Jesus to send them away
    - He replies feed them

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- Now before we try to understand what Jesus was expecting the disciples to do, John adds this detail:

John 6:5 Therefore Jesus, lifting up His eyes and seeing that a large crowd was coming to Him, *said to Philip, "Where are we to buy bread, so that these may eat?"
John 6:6 This He was saying to test him, for He Himself knew what He was intending to do.

- OK, so John tells us that Jesus was already preparing to feed the crowd
  - He knew that it would require a miracle and, in fact, it was a part of the Father's plan that a miracle take place
  - So why doesn't Jesus say to the disciples, stand back, watch me feed five thousand…

- Jesus was clearly using this moment to pose a test for the disciples
  - But kind of what test?
    - Is Jesus expecting the disciples to produce food for this huge crowd?
    - Again, the answer is obvious – no
      - John himself says that the purpose of Jesus' question was not to actually make the disciples feed the flock – Jesus was already expecting to feed them
      - The purpose was a bit deeper

- For a religious man in the day of Jesus, ministry didn't look anything like it does today for you and me
  - The religious leaders of Jesus' day didn't see themselves as shepherds
    - They weren't typically men who watched over their flock with an eye toward caring for them, helping them,
    - Rather, they were trained to be experts in the law and to hold that over the heads of the people
    - To be more like the assistance principal rather than the school nurse

- And Jesus is trying to help the disciples see the world a little differently

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- Unlike those who came before them, the disciples were going to learn a new manner of ministry
  - Rather than be on the top of the people, lording over them
  - Jesus was going to call upon the disciples to be under the people, serving them and supporting them
  - Here was a perfect opportunity to show them how that looks
- Jesus wanted the disciples to know that the people He brings them they would need to care for
  - Ministry in other words was about meeting people's needs – and not just their spiritual needs
  - Probably the best place to see this in scripture is in the Book of James

James 2:15 If a brother or sister is without clothing and in need of daily food,
James 2:16 and one of you says to them, "Go in peace, be warmed and be filled," and yet you do not give them what is necessary for *their* body, what use is that?
James 2:17 Even so faith, if it has no works, is dead, *being* by itself.

- James' point is really quite simple
  - If our faith motivates to do nothing more than merely speak words of comfort, then it's no faith at all
  - True faith bears fruit in the life of the individual in the form of love, mercy, forgiveness and charity
    - The fruit of the Spirit that Gal 5:22 gives us
    - e.g., love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control
  - These will be the hallmark of a Christian, and Jesus is working even at this early point to teach them that caring for people in ministry is not easy
    - it's not a matter of convenience,
    - it's not dependent on our own personal abilities

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- God will routinely give us greater demands than we can meet in our own power – that's how He gains glory through us

- We must understand and accept that as God gifts us and calls us to minister to others, that calling brings the burden of caring for others

- I'm not talking about ministry in the capital M sense – pastors, ministers

- I also talking about the kind of ministry most of us experience – ministry to friends and relatives in need

- Teaching, counseling, prayer, encouragement, visitations, etc.

- just as others will care for us in the Body of Christ

- The disciples didn't understand this – they just assume that its time to send these people away

- Now Jesus says to the disciples, what do you have for food?

- And the gospel of John tells us that Andrew finds a young boy selling fish and bread (5 loaves and two fish

- Clearly not enough food for the disciples, much less 10,000+ people

- But Jesus tells them to assemble the crowd in groups of fifty

- He orchestrates an orderly, calm process for distributing food

- The grouping of people is simply good sense

- It avoids riots over the food and helps makes the process of distribution efficient

- It's like how we feed people at the Flying W ranch – wait until your table is called

- At the end, there is enough left over so that each disciple had his share of the leftovers – 12 baskets full

- I often wonder how this actually looked

- Jesus probably divided the apostles into pairs, each pair received either a fish or a loaf of bread, with one left over, perhaps to remain with Jesus

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        - It's no coincidence that the total number adds to seven, of course – God's perfect number signifying that it was God providing the food

    - But as the apostles received their allotted portion, what do you think was going through their minds?

        - They must have glanced at the basket and the measly loaf of bread or fish, and then looked up at the huge crowd and thought this is ridiculous

    - That's often how ministry appears to us

        - The tasks God will give us seem all but impossible

        - We look at what we have to bring to the task and then consider the enormity of the work ahead, and are tempted to give up before we start

- But did you also notice how God works through us

    - Did Jesus sit the disciples down ahead of time and say here's what will happen…explain the details of how He would provide?

        - No…he expected them to take a step of faith in serving Him

        - Just like Abraham did when He followed God

        - Just like Moses did when He went to talk to Pharaoh, the most powerful man in the world

        - Just like Esther when she approached the king for the sake of her people

    - Each took a step of faith, without knowing where it would lead, but they trusted God to direct their steps and multiply their efforts

    - And each earlier step of faith gave them confidence to take the next

        - Just like the disciples, who took an earlier step of faith in going out to heal and cast out demons at the beginning of chapter 9

2Cor. 9:10 Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness;
2Cor. 9:11 you will be enriched in everything for all liberality, which through us is producing thanksgiving to God.

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- God is the one who provides our seed for sowing, which makes sense since it is His word that we are sowing – He provides that to us
    - And it is God who increases the harvest of righteousness that follows
    - And as we are personally enriched through our service –
        - Obviously, the first and most important way we can expect to be enriched is spiritually – by gaining the satisfaction and spiritual maturity that comes from sacrifice and service to others in the name of the Lord
        - Secondly, God will take care of those in service for their physical needs – 12 baskets for disciples
    - and as others come to the Lord by our efforts to spread the Word, He receives thanksgiving as He should
    - Don't let the appearance of impossible odds or lack of immediate success discourage you from serving in the ways God calls
    - The next time you see an impossible task, just remember what the disciples would have been thinking when Jesus told them to go feed 10,000 people with a picnic basket of food…

Luke 9:18 ¶ And it happened that while He was praying alone, the disciples were with Him, and He questioned them, saying, "Who do the people say that I am?"
Luke 9:19 They answered and said, "John the Baptist, and others *say* Elijah; but others, that one of the prophets of old has risen again."
Luke 9:20 And He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?" And Peter answered and said, "The Christ of God."
Luke 9:21 But He warned them and instructed *them* not to tell this to anyone,
Luke 9:22 saying, "The Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed and be raised up on the third day."

- The events of these verses most likely followed soon after the feeding of the 5 thousand, although there is no reason to assume it was the same moment
    - But throughout this chapter, Jesus identity is an issue
    - The time has come in His ministry for Jesus to begin revealing Himself to the disciples and the world for Who He truly is

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        - Remember earlier in this chapter, we heard Herod trying to understand who this man was
        - Herod eventually concluded it must be John back from the dead, Mark tells us
    - So Luke is beginning to allude the growing controversy over Jesus' identity
- By the way, this is why Jesus asks the question the way He does
    - He knows that rumors are flying
    - By crossing referencing Luke with John, many scholars estimate that the events we're studying today occurred in the last year of Jesus' ministry
        - So by then, He was well known and the suspense over who He was and why He had come was probably intense
- So finally, Jesus wants to know what His disciples have concluded
    - They've no doubt heard the rumors…
        - When they would go into towns to buy food or get water, they probably heard people talking about Jesus
        - They would have had their own ideas
    - But it's easy to carry around assumptions and ideas and play with them in our heads
        - It's another thing entirely to take a stand, to come to a decision and make a confession
        - That's what' Jesus is doing here…it's time for the disciples to take a stand
- Jesus says who do others say I am
    - And the disciples give the usual answers – John, Elijah, some other prophet
        - It's interesting that no one says that Jesus is being called the Messiah
        - No one mentions to Jesus that the rumors include Him being the one promised by God

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- Maybe they were afraid to suggest it
- Maybe they wanted to Jesus to say it first

- Instead, Jesus asks them directly
  - What do you think…who am I?
  - And Peter speaks up and says you are the Messiah, the Son of God
    - Peter isn't merely stating that Jesus is the promised deliverer, the Messiah
    - It's far more significant that Peter says you are the Son of God
      - This was not a general understanding of the Messiah
  - The Jewish understanding of the Messiah did not necessarily include the idea that Christ would be God Himself.
    - Yet Peter has somehow come to that conclusion
    - This is a remarkable statement, even from someone who has been with Jesus for some time
- In Matt's gospel we see how Peter came to know this important detail

Matt. 16:17 And Jesus said to him, "Blessed are you, Simon Barjona, because flesh and blood did not reveal *this* to you, but My Father who is in heaven.

- Jesus says that Peter's answer was proof that God had blessed Peter, because only by the power of the Holy Spirit could Peter come to this understanding
  - That it was one thing to know that Jesus had come by God's direction, but it was something else that Peter knew Jesus to be God – that insight required God Himself to provide it
  - This is the same for you and I today
    - In our own power and effort, it's possible to know about Jesus

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- It's possible to believe He was a man of God, a prophet, a messenger, a teacher, and all the rest
- But to truly believe that He was the Son of God requires that God Himself reveal that truth to a person
- And by our confession that Jesus is the Son of God, and therefore that He is God Himself, we are demonstrating that we have been blessed by God – that we have been given the faith that Paul calls a gift in Eph 2:8
- this is the only way a man may be saved

- Luke then adds on additional interesting detail
  - He records Jesus telling the apostles not tell anyone of what they know of Him
  - And then He says why: because Jesus must be rejected and die
    - In other words, don't try to interrupt God's plan for His Son – that the Messiah would have to die
    - By holding back what they knew, they were working in God's will to do His plan
    - They were essentially preventing widespread acceptance of the Messiah and helping ensure His rejection by the people

- It's interesting to note looking at Matt's account that this is where Peter steps forward to rebuke Jesus
  - I guess after having been complimented a moment earlier by Jesus over his correct confession, he thinks he can take charge
  - But as you know, Jesus rebukes him sternly
  - He says,

Matt. 16:22 Peter took Him aside and began to rebuke Him, saying, "God forbid *it*, Lord! This shall never happen to You."
Matt. 16:23 But He turned and said to Peter, "Get behind Me, Satan! You are a stumbling block to Me; for you are not setting your mind on God's interests, but man's."

  - Don't you just love Peter?

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        - The scripture says he takes Jesus aside and rebukes Him
        - You get the sense that Peter has gun to assume that he knows what's best now and wants to convince Jesus
        - But consider what Peter just said a few moments earlier
        - He said that Jesus was the Son of God – that Jesus was God Himself
        - But now he's ready to rebuke Him
    - Now either Peter doesn't have this God thing completely worked out or he's just plain stupid
        - It makes me wonder a bit about whether Peter even knew what he was saying a moment earlier
- Or perhaps it's a good reminder to all of us of how easily we can say in the one moment that Jesus is Lord and then in the next, we act like we're in control
    - Jesus calls it for what it is when He responds
        - He says that Peter has his mind on the things of men rather than on the things of God
    - And that's often our problem too
        - When we ever we think that God's plan isn't the best for us, and we replace it with our own, we have aligned with the devil
        - That's why Jesus called Peter Satan – it wasn't an insult, it wasn't' hyperbole
        - Jesus truly meant that in speaking those words, Peter was aligning with Satan, because when we work any plan other than God's we are working according to the enemy's desire
- It was God's plan to destroy His only Son
    - The Jews didn't kill Jesus
    - The Romans didn't kill Jesus
    - Satan didn't kill Jesus
    - The Father did – for us

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- One thing scripture will not lets us forget is that the Father is sovereign over every event in His creation, including the plan that His Son would come to the Earth but He must be rejected and killed

    - And the Father and Jesus Himself made sure that would happen, just as Isaiah foretold

Is. 53:6 All of us like sheep have gone astray,
Each of us has turned to his own way;
But the LORD has caused the iniquity of us all
To fall on Him.
Is. 53:7 He was oppressed and He was afflicted,
Yet He did not open His mouth;
Like a lamb that is led to slaughter,
And like a sheep that is silent before its shearers,
So He did not open His mouth.
Is. 53:8 By oppression and judgment He was taken away;
And as for His generation, who considered
That He was cut off out of the land of the living
For the transgression of my people, to whom the stroke *was due*?
Is. 53:9 His grave was assigned with wicked men,
Yet He was with a rich man in His death,
Because He had done no violence,
Nor was there any deceit in His mouth.
Is. 53:10 But the LORD was pleased
To crush Him, putting *Him* to grief;
If He would render Himself *as* a guilt offering,
He will see *His* offspring,
He will prolong *His* days,
And the good pleasure of the LORD will prosper in His hand.
Is. 53:11 As a result of the anguish of His soul,
He will see *it and* be satisfied;
By His knowledge the Righteous One,
My Servant, will justify the many,
As He will bear their iniquities.

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Luke 9C

- When you look at Chapter 9 of Luke, you might come to the conclusion that
    - The first half is devoted to demonstrations of Jesus' power as God to heal and provide
    - While the second half is devoted to discussions of Jesus' future martyrdom and glorification
    - And that would be reasonable
- But I believe there is a larger purpose in view here, once that centers as much on the disciples as on Jesus Himself
    - In the first have, Jesus is demonstrating His power as God before the disciples to encourage them to see how God will intend to work through them in growing and providing for His church
    - The disciples must have looked back upon these lessons as great encouragement, especially when they were confronted with so many challenges in the early church
- Now we enter into essentially the second half of Chapter 9, where Luke begins to highlight the theme of Christ's coming death and the disciples life walking in Jesus' place
    - You know, this is such a great opportunity for us to learn from Jesus Himself what it means to be His follower

Luke 9:23 ¶ And He was saying to *them* all, "If anyone wishes to come after Me, he must deny himself, and take up his cross daily and follow Me.
Luke 9:24 "For whoever wishes to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for My sake, he is the one who will save it.
Luke 9:25 "For what is a man profited if he gains the whole world, and loses or forfeits himself?
Luke 9:26 "For whoever is ashamed of Me and My words, the Son of Man will be ashamed of him when He comes in His glory, and *the glory* of the Father and of the holy angels.

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- Let's begin by breaking down this famous passage, beginning with verse 23
    - Jesus, we're told begins to speak "to them all"
        - And "all" here must mean the disciples – not the crowd in general, but His disciples
        - In other words, there are words for those who are professing allegiance and a desire to follow Christ – not merely those who are considering Jesus, those who are merely spectators
- Jesus comment in verse 23 comes immediately after his stunning announcement in verse 22 that He must be rejected and suffer and die
    - Can you imagine the looks on the faces of the disciples when they heard Jesus speak the words of verse 22?
        - There must have been a mixture of disbelief, confusion, distress, maybe fear
        - And Jesus turns from His comment in verse 22 to look the disciples in eyes, and say with great conviction…
        - "If anyone…
    - In that moment, I imagine there were at least a few disciples who might have begun to rethink following Jesus…to question whether this was what they wanted
        - And Jesus gives them the straight truth
        - He tells them that if the thought of Jesus dying bothers them, then they ought to know that the same possibility if not inevitability exists for each one of them
- Look at what Jesus says to them…
    - If you are going to follow me, you had better be prepared to pick up your cross
        - What does that phrase mean? How did it strike the apostles I wonder?
- Actually, I was interested to see what other preachers have said about this phrase, because it's so well known and it's loaded with shades of meaning

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- Or example, I found this comment taken from the sermon of one preacher:

Jesus' call to take up our cross and follow is a vision to keep us on the path. When we shrink away, it's because we don't believe our voices and actions can make a difference. But if we stop pursuing justice, peace, healing and wholeness, for our lives and for our world, we become supporters of that which we oppose."

- This kind of general spiritualization of Jesus' words is typical of what I found
  - And while I can't quarrel with this teaching, I do have to wonder about whether this is really Jesus' point when he spoke to the disciples?
  - Consider some details about Jesus' comment:
    - First Jesus has just told the disciples he expected to be put to death
    - More than that, Jesus said he MUST suffer and die
    - And the disciples would have naturally assumed that they would be in jeopardy too, simply by association
- Secondly, I want you to remember what a cross meant in that culture
  - Today we hear Jesus' statement with an appreciation of how closely connected it would be with His ministry
    - The cross has become the symbol of Christianity
  - But to the disciples, the cross had only one meaning
    - It was a symbol of an ugly death
    - The Roman style of execution had its origins in Persia or Greece 700 years earlier
    - But the Romans commonly made their prisoners carry the cross beam of the crucifix to the place of execution
  - So when Jesus said that to be His disciple, you must deny yourself and take up your cross to follow Him, He was communicating only one thought

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- To anyone who heard Him, he was affirming the reality of their own persecution
- Jesus was saying that following Me means you must be prepared for death if necessary
- After all, look at Jesus' next statements
  - If you are more interested in preserving your earthly life than obtaining eternal life, what you hope to gain in an earthly sense you are actually losing in an eternal sense
  - To do so is to be ashamed of Jesus and He will then be ashamed of you when He comes in glory
- What could we possibly gain by remaining alive in this world a day longer that we might be willing to exchange for eternal life? Nothing!

- Later in this gospel, Luke records a similar statement from Christ,

Luke 14:26 "If anyone comes to Me, and does not hate his own father and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters, yes, and even his own life, he cannot be My disciple.
Luke 14:27 "Whoever does not carry his own cross and come after Me cannot be My disciple

- There is even more we could say from what Luke records in chapter 14, but we'll wait to get there.
  - Meanwhile, we can see the connection with our text here this morning,
  - Jesus says that we must be willing, if necessary, to forsake all that this world holds – even a relationship with our family if necessary – in order to follow Him
    - To which He repeats the phrase, we must be willing to pick up our cross
- This is a sobering statement, wouldn't you agree?
  - I thought Christianity was sunshine and roses, happiness and victory
  - Jesus is saying, no…it very well could be rejection, loneliness, suffering, and even death

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- As I was researching for this lesson, I learned that in the Sudan, a country that borders Kenya, literally thousands of Christian Sudanese have been nailed to crude crosses in the Sudanese plains
    - The Arab network Al Jazeera reported in 2002 that 32 Christian ministers and other males had been crucified, include some in their early teens. They were whipped severely and then nailed to crosses with 6 inch nails through their arms and legs
    - My point here is not to disturb you but to make the point that Christ's statement to the apostles is just as relevant today
    - To be His follower means to be willing to suffer such things, because nothing in this life is worth forsaking eternity
- Do you seen how Jesus has just ratcheted up the seriousness of this business with the disciples?
    - If they had been thinking that walking away from fishing and tax collecting and following after Jesus was just some kind of new career move, maybe an exciting diversion from everyday life
        - Maybe the apostles were just playing around with the idea of being a rabbi like Jesus
        - Maybe they just liked the idea of being able to attract large crowds..
        - Whatever they were thinking, Jesus is telling them it's time they grew up and understood what being Christian means
    - These men were going to see many of the same things that Jesus saw
        - Many of the apostles were beaten, imprisoned, stoned, driven out of towns
        - They were despised, they were mocked, they had no life as others around them enjoyed
        - They completely sacrificed the normal life experience that others around them took for granted
        - And they gave all that up because Jesus called them to do it…and He said that if they shrunk back from that responsibility, they would be trading discomfort in this life for an eternity of hell

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- So are WE to do with this statement?
    - On the one hand, I'm fairly confident that the main point for us here is not what I read from the previous sermon
        - We're not just looking at some generalized exhortation to march onward despite life's difficulties, blah, blah, blah
        - True as all that may be, Jesus was talking about life or death with these men, so I can't see turning his statements into some kind of Christianity light
        - It's not merely a matter of "Let's all work together and we can make a difference."
    - Jesus was talking to 12 men who He knew were going to experience many of the same persecutions He suffered
    - And He wanted them to understand – to – count- the cost of being His disciple.
        - He wanted them to have their eyes open to what lay ahead
- For us today I think the message is more directly relevant to how we bring the good news to others
        - He is making clear that not only will His ministry bring His own death
        - But He is telling the disciples that they too must be willing to be humiliated, to suffer and even to die as a result of following Him
- There is no soft sell here for Jesus
    - Nor should there be one for coming from us when we present the Gospel message
        - This isn't a game, like the one they play with you at the car dealership
        - What do I have to do to get you into this new car today?
        - Every person who experiences a calling to faith should be prepared for discipleship with the stark reality of what it means to forsake the world and follow Jesus

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- Do you think those Sudanese men who were crucified understood the risks when they came to know Christ?
- Just as many other Christians do around the world

- But we're so polite here we can stand the thought of ever putting someone on the spot about whether they are willing to accept the costs of their faith
  - If you live the life of a disciple, you will bear a cross
    - You will not be accepted by the world

John 15:19 "If you were of the world, the world would love its own; but because you are not of the world, but I chose you out of the world, because of this the world hates you.
John 15:20 "Remember the word that I said to you, 'A slave is not greater than his master.' If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you; if they kept My word, they will keep yours also.

- Somewhere in the process of discipline new believers, we should begin to explain the cost of belief
  - We owe them that
  - And especially because as the costs become evident, we will be able to know if their hearts are true – if their confessions are true
- Unbelievers join and remain in churches without ever having true faith because it's so easy, so undemanding
  - But when real disciple ship is expected and when the costs are explained, you'll begin to see who's serious and who's not
  - And that was Jesus' point here

- In fact, Jesus is so serious, He has decided to reveal Himself in a special way to three of these men

Luke 9:27 "But I say to you truthfully, there are some of those standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God."
Luke 9:28 ¶ Some eight days after these sayings, He took along Peter and John and James, and went up on the mountain to pray.
Luke 9:29 And while He was praying, the appearance of His face became different, and His clothing *became* white *and* gleaming.

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Luke 9:30 And behold, two men were talking with Him; and they were Moses and Elijah,
Luke 9:31 who, appearing in glory, were speaking of His departure which He was about to accomplish at Jerusalem.
Luke 9:32 Now Peter and his companions had been overcome with sleep; but when they were fully awake, they saw His glory and the two men standing with Him.
Luke 9:33 And as these were leaving Him, Peter said to Jesus, "Master, it is good for us to be here; let us make three tabernacles: one for You, and one for Moses, and one for Elijah"—not realizing what he was saying.
Luke 9:34 While he was saying this, a cloud formed and *began* to overshadow them; and they were afraid as they entered the cloud.
Luke 9:35 Then a voice came out of the cloud, saying, "This is My Son, *My* Chosen One; listen to Him!"
Luke 9:36 And when the voice had spoken, Jesus was found alone. And they kept silent, and reported to no one in those days any of the things which they had seen.

- This is such a powerful scene, and not one I can fully examine with you today
    - I will introduce some of it's major themes and then pick up again here in two weeks when we return to Luke
- Let's begin with some observation concerning the scene
    - Jesus leaves the earlier conversation with the comment that some in the group would see the kingdom of God before experiencing death
    - As you may know, this statement has caused tremendous confusion in some Christian circles where it has been used incorrectly to teach that the kingdom Jesus promised arrived in 70 AD when the temple and Jerusalem were destroyed by the Romans
        - This view is amillennialist, which does not believe that there will be a true 1,000 year reign of Christ on earth, but rather the current time is the kingdom that Jesus promised
        - One of the things they point to is this verse
- What Jesus meant is so clearly demonstrated by the text itself
    - About a week later, Jesus takes Peter, John and James up a mountain
        - **Addendum**: *Audio incorrectly states James was the leader of the church in Jerusalem. This was in fact James the half-brother of Jesus. James, son of Zebedee, was the first apostle martyred (see Acts 12:2)*

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- And Jesus begins to pray and the other men fall asleep, which was typical
  - They were the most sleep deprived but of guys I've ever known
- They awake to see Jesus with Moses and Elijah, all three glorified

- The fact that this event comes immediately after the earlier conversation makes clear that this is the event Jesus was talking about
  - These men are seeing the Kingdom before them
  - Look in verse 29
    - Jesus' appearance is completely different
    - He didn't just light up, his face is different
    - This is similar to the description that John gives of Jesus when Jesus reveals himself to John in Revelation

Rev. 1:14 His head and His hair were white like white wool, like snow; and His eyes were like a flame of fire.
Rev. 1:15 His feet *were* like burnished bronze, when it has been made to glow in a furnace, and His voice *was* like the sound of many waters.
Rev. 1:16 In His right hand He held seven stars, and out of His mouth came a sharp two-edged sword; and His face was like the sun shining in its strength.

- Peter, John and James are given the privilege of seeing Jesus as He will appear in the kingdom of God
  - In fact, it's important to consider that to see Jesus in this way is to see the kingdom of God – not just a piece of it – but all of it
- The next important observation is to understand what it means that Moses and Elijah are standing with Jesus
- First, what were they doing with Jesus
  - Luke alone tells us that they were talking with Jesus about all that must happen in Jerusalem
    - It's possible that they are offering words of comfort to Jesus concerning him impending trial, but I can't accept that notion
      - I can't see how Jesus could be accepting advice and encouragement from men

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- He was the perfect obedient Son of God who had the Holy Spirit and the Father comforting Him in all He did

- I think a better explanation is that these men were being used as prophets by God to relay information to Jesus concerning the events that occur

- Remember, Jesus is limited by his human form, and so God the Father is communicating to His Son through His Spirit and apparently through these prophets

- It may also be the case that the conversation was purely for the benefit of the three disciples, that they might know about the coming passion of Jesus

- But the conversation was merely a piece of the puzzle – what is the main reason why these men were there

  - First we should understand that these men were immensely important figures in the Jewish consciousness, though I doubt their complete significance was understood by the disciples in the moment

  - By the way, do you wonder how they knew who these men were?

    - There were no pictures of Moses or Elijah in their wallets

    - My wife says they probably wore those "Hi, My name is Moses" names tages

- What is the significance of these men at this moment

  - Well, consider each for what we know of their lives

    - Moses was the redeemer of God's people – the man who brought the nation through the trials of the desert

    - But He died before the journey was complete, though no one ever found Moses body

Deut. 34:5 So Moses the servant of the LORD died there in the land of Moab, according to the word of the LORD.
Deut. 34:6 And He buried him in the valley in the land of Moab, opposite Beth-peor; but no man knows his burial place to this day.

- So Moses is a type of Christ in his redemptive work and in how His body will not be found afterward

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- Then there's Elijah
  - God predicted that it would be Elijah in the end times who would bring the hearts of his people back to their God

Mal. 4:5 ¶ "Behold, I am going to send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and terrible day of the LORD.

  - Secondly, Elijah's life ends when God ushers him straight into heaven

2Kings 2:11 As they were going along and talking, behold, *there appeared* a chariot of fire and horses of fire which separated the two of them. And Elijah went up by a whirlwind to heaven.

- So here's the connection
  - Jesus is seen standing next to the two men who God has used to depict the two fold nature of Christ's ministry
  - On the one hand Moses depicting Christ's redemption of God' people by His death
  - And Elijah representing Jesus' resurrection and ascension in glory
- Even Luke's choice of words in verse 31 suggests the symbolism in this moment
  - Departure is exodus, communicating the larger significance of Jesus coming departure – the departure was the resurrection – a new exodus for God's people

- When we pick up here again in two weeks, we will look at the disciples' reaction to this scene, and particularly Peter's poorly worded statements
  - But for now, let's dwell on the scene Luke has painted
    - Jesus in His glory – our Lord returned, chatting casually with two men who served Him well in their day
    - Consider with me right now, that you and I will one day do the same thing
    - We will have that opportunity

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        - We will have a chance to be in Jesus presence and to worship Him, but I'm convinced that we will also have plenty of time over the 1000 years of life on earth with Him to stand and speak with him like Moses and Elijah did
            - To stand and speak with Moses and Elijah for that matter
            - To ask The men of old what their lives were like
            - TO appreciate all the intricate detail God has woven to put all of time and history together for our sakes

- Let those thoughts get you excited, because that's what the scripture tells us to do
    - Look forward to that day that's promised ot each of us
        - Look forward with joy, and excitement, and let it motivate you to serve Him all the better even now
        - TO Love Him all the more and to show that same love to others in His name

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Luke 9D

- It was two weeks ago that took our first look at the transfiguration of Jesus on the mountain with James, Peter and John standing nearby
    - Today we will continue in our verse by verse study of Luke by returning to something we were in the midst of studying the last time I was here
    - Last time we took note of scene, including the two men who accompanied Jesus
        - We saw that each man stands as a picture to the two-fold nature of Jesus' ministry
            - Moses pictures the ministry of Jesus' first coming when, like Moses, He leads His people out of bondage
            - And like Moses, Jesus left no body behind, proving His power over death
            - And there was also Elijah, who pictured Jesus's present and future ministry as he ascends in glory only to return at the end to bring in the kingdom
    - This week, we will continue to look at these two men, as there is even more we can learn from seeing them next to jesus
        - And furthermore, we want to examine the meaning of God the Father's statement concerning Jesus
        - As well we want to look at Peter's comments regarding building three tabernacles and why Luke included his parenthetical rebuke of Peter
- To begin, let's reread the passage to familiarize ourselves with the text

Luke 9:27 "But I say to you truthfully, there are some of those standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God."
Luke 9:28 ¶ Some eight days after these sayings, He took along Peter and John and James, and went up on the mountain to pray.
Luke 9:29 And while He was praying, the appearance of His face became different, and His clothing *became* white *and* gleaming.
Luke 9:30 And behold, two men were talking with Him; and they were Moses and Elijah,

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Luke 9:31 who, appearing in glory, were speaking of His departure which He was about to accomplish at Jerusalem.
Luke 9:32 Now Peter and his companions had been overcome with sleep; but when they were fully awake, they saw His glory and the two men standing with Him.
Luke 9:33 And as these were leaving Him, Peter said to Jesus, "Master, it is good for us to be here; let us make three tabernacles: one for You, and one for Moses, and one for Elijah"—not realizing what he was saying.
Luke 9:34 While he was saying this, a cloud formed and *began* to overshadow them; and they were afraid as they entered the cloud.
Luke 9:35 Then a voice came out of the cloud, saying, "This is My Son, *My* Chosen One; listen to Him!"
Luke 9:36 And when the voice had spoken, Jesus was found alone. And they kept silent, and reported to no one in those days any of the things which they had seen.

- As Peter, James and John awake, they witness this amazing scene
    - Jesus has been transformed into a completely different image
    - His glorified nature
    - And along side him are glorified visions of Moses and Elijah
    - In all three cases, God is revealing something special to the apostles
        - They are seeing that Jesus – this rabbi they've been following – is altogether different from just another man
        - He is the Son of God, who one day will be seen in all His glory, though now He has been diminished in glory for a time
        - Likewise, the apostles see the past men of renown standing with Jesus glorified
- It's probably not too hard for us to understand the purpose of seeing Jesus glorified
    - Throughout Jesus ministry, the Father has interspersed these visions of His Son
        - They Shepherds saw the star and heard from angels
        - Zacharias and Mary heard from angels
        - The crowds saw Jesus anointed by the Holy Spirit at His baptism

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- So it's no real surprise to see yet another vision of Jesus' power and glory given to men to make the point of who Jesus truly was

- But then there's the issue of Moses and Elijah
  - Last time we saw how God chose these two men to picture the two-fold nature of Christ's ministry
  - But there's still more reason to choose these two men among all the OT saints God could have chosen
    - And to fully understand why God wanted Peter, James and John to see these two men next to Jesus, we first have to appreciate Peter's ill advised comments in verse 33

- Peter sees these three standing together and says
  - let us make three tabernacles: one for You, and one for Moses, and one for Elijah"
  - Luke then adds this commentary: —not realizing what he was saying
    - Why was Luke trying to explain Peter's words in this way?
    - Well, let's take a moment to consider what Peter was suggesting, then we can understand why it was wrong

- Peter suggests that the apostles build tabernacles for these three individuals
  - The word used here is skene, and it means tent or dwelling – the same meaning as booth in the OT
  - In the Law, God gave the nation of Israel a festival He called the Festival of Booths
    - It's found in Lev 23

Lev. 23:39 ¶ 'On exactly the fifteenth day of the seventh month, when you have gathered in the crops of the land, you shall celebrate the feast of the LORD for seven days, with a rest on the first day and a rest on the eighth day.
Lev. 23:40 'Now on the first day you shall take for yourselves the foliage of beautiful trees, palm branches and boughs of leafy trees and willows of the brook, and you shall rejoice before the LORD your God for seven days.
Lev. 23:41 'You shall thus celebrate it *as* a feast to the LORD for seven days in the year. It *shall be* a perpetual statute throughout your generations; you shall celebrate it in the seventh month.

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Lev. 23:42 'You shall live in booths for seven days; all the native-born in Israel shall live in booths,
Lev. 23:43 so that your generations may know that I had the sons of Israel live in booths when I brought them out from the land of Egypt. I am the LORD your God.'"

- So this festival memorialized the Jews living in temporary housing in the desert
- And it also can be seen as a picture of how we are living a temporary existence in this world as we await our permanent home to come from heaven

- A second piece to this puzzle is found in Zech 14

Zech. 14:3 Then the LORD will go forth and fight against those nations, as when He fights on a day of battle.

Zech. 14:6 ¶ In that day there will be no light; the luminaries will dwindle.
Zech. 14:7 For it will be a unique day which is known to the LORD, neither day nor night, but it will come about that at evening time there will be light.
Zech. 14:8 ¶ And in that day living waters will flow out of Jerusalem, half of them toward the eastern sea and the other half toward the western sea; it will be in summer as well as in winter.
Zech. 14:9 ¶ And the LORD will be king over all the earth; in that day the LORD will be *the only* one, and His name *the only* one.

- This is Zecharias' vision of the circumstances around the second coming of Christ
  - Jesus will arrive at the end of Tribulation to rescue the nation of Israel
  - He will come from heaven with the Saints (that's you and I) arriving with Him
  - And He establishes His kingdom on earth

- Then we hear about this interesting detail:

Zech. 14:16 ¶ Then it will come about that any who are left of all the nations that went against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, the LORD of hosts, and to celebrate the Feast of Booths.
Zech. 14:17 And it will be that whichever of the families of the earth does not go up to Jerusalem to worship the King, the LORD of hosts, there will be no rain on them.
Zech. 14:18 If the family of Egypt does not go up or enter, then no *rain will fall* on them; it will be the plague with which the LORD smites the nations who do not go up to celebrate the Feast of Booths.

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Zech. 14:19 This will be the punishment of Egypt, and the punishment of all the nations who do not go up to celebrate the Feast of Booths.

- When Jesus sets us His kingdom on Earth, the nations of the world will all be expected to observe the festival of booths
    - In fact, to not observe the festival brings judgment in the form of drought and punishment like that brought against Egypt will come upon that people
    - If you're confused about why there would be disobedience in the time of Christ's reign on Earth, you need to remember that though we will have entered the kingdom glorified and without sin, there will be other who enter with their sin natures intact
    - They continue the sin of the world until the very end of the 1,000 year reign, when all sin is finally put to an end
        - Check out the Revelation study
- So let's put this all together
    - Peter sees Jesus standing glorified – not just glowing but completely changed
    - He sees Moses and Elijah likewise
    - Earlier he declared that Jesus was the Messiah, so now he's overcome by the scene and believes he is watching the Messiah about to set up His kingdom on earth
        - So it's likely that Peter, a good Jew, would assume the prophecy in Zechariah is coming true before his eyes
        - So he believes it should the time to build the booths

Mark 9:5 Peter *said to Jesus, "Rabbi, it is good for us to be here; let us make three tabernacles, one for You, and one for Moses, and one for Elijah."
Mark 9:6 For he did not know what to answer; for they became terrified.

- So Peter is grasping at what to say in the moment
- And Zechariah's prophecy comes to mind

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- Well this seems like a reasonable mistake, so why does Luke add that Peter wasn't aware of what he was suggesting
    - Well, the problem lies in his statement that the apostles would build tabernacles for all three
        - Peter instinctively placed Jesus and these two famous prophets – Moses and Elijah – on a par with the Son of God
- This was instinctive because Jews had throughout their history seen God speak through a variety of sources
    - There was Abraham, and even prophets before Abraham (Abel)
    - There was Moses, who gave Jews their most sacred gift from God – the Law
    - And there have been numerous prophets in the generations that followed Moses
    - So Peter sees Jesus and the logical extension of this line of men of God
        - Yet another source of revelation
    - And standing next to Moses and Elijah, the connection seems especially obvious
- But Peter was wrong
    - Not only was Jesus not to be placed on a par with Moses or Elijah in terms of importance and honor
    - But Jesus was also not to be considered just another prophet in the line of God's messengers
    - The book of Hebrews says it best:

Heb. 1:1 ¶ God, after He spoke long ago to the fathers in the prophets in many portions and in many ways,
Heb. 1:2 in these last days has spoken to us in His Son, whom He appointed heir of all things, through whom also He made the world.

- God has been speaking to men since the beginning
    - And before Christ, God spoken through many men to varying degrees and in various forms

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        - He gave more revelation to some than to others
        - He spoke through a burning bush to one, dreams to another and visions to others
    - But now we are in the last days
        - And in these days, all revelation from God has come through His Son – through the Gospel record and in God's revelation of the New Testament given to men who received direct revelation from Jesus
- So here's Peter equating these three men
    - Moses, the man through whom God gave the Law
    - Elijah, a representative of all the prophets who received God's revelation
    - And finally God's Son, who brings the final and complete revelation of God
    - And God Himself steps in at this point to address Peter's mistake

Luke 9:34 While he was saying this, a cloud formed and *began* to overshadow them; and they were afraid as they entered the cloud.
Luke 9:35 Then a voice came out of the cloud, saying, "This is My Son, *My* Chosen One; listen to Him!"

- The Father will have no one misunderstand where His only Son falls in the array of revelators
    - There is simply no equal
    - With this scene we have Moses representing the law in all its significance
    - We have Elijah representing all the prophetic ministries that have come and gone
    - But in there midst, God does not declare
        - These are my prophets, hear them all
        - Here is my Son. Obey Him, remember the Law and the prophets
        - He says This is my Son – My Chosen One – Listen to Him

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- The disciples were not told to forget the Law or to dismiss the prophets, and neither should we
    - But in both cases, the Law and the prophets, we are to always see them in light of what we know about the Son
    - They were given to reveal Christ
    - They were given that men might know and understand their need for a Savior and how to recognize Him when He came
    - They can never hope to stand equal to Him but properly interpreted, they will always be in harmony with Him
        - This is why we teach verse by verse and without distinction for OT verse NT
        - We understand that all scripture is spirit breathed and profitable for teaching and correction
        - We seek God's will throughout His word, never pitting one part in opposition with another
        - But we never forget that ultimately, all men must hear and listen to God's Son – Jesus
        - Our study of the Bible, of the OT or the NT – can never be merely an intellectual exercise
        - We must listen to Christ – pay attention and heed His words
            - Not be merely hearers of the word, but doers, as James says
            - In that we please God
- Having heard the words of God, the apostles drop in fear, and Jesus leads them from the mountain

Luke 9:37 ¶ On the next day, when they came down from the mountain, a large crowd met Him.
Luke 9:38 And a man from the crowd shouted, saying, "Teacher, I beg You to look at my son, for he is my only *boy*,
Luke 9:39 and a spirit seizes him, and he suddenly screams, and it throws him into a convulsion with foaming *at the mouth*; and only with difficulty does it leave him, mauling him *as it leaves*.

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Luke 9:40 "I begged Your disciples to cast it out, and they could not."
Luke 9:41 And Jesus answered and said, "You unbelieving and perverted generation, how long shall I be with you and put up with you? Bring your son here."
Luke 9:42 While he was still approaching, the demon slammed him *to the ground* and threw him into a convulsion. But Jesus rebuked the unclean spirit, and healed the boy and gave him back to his father.
Luke 9:43 And they were all amazed at the greatness of God.

- Jesus returns from the mountain and He's confronted by a boy under demonic control
    - From the teaching you heard last week, I know this topic was front and center
    - The facts here present themselves very easily, and we're going to wait until next week to understand why this event has been placed at this point in the gospel record
        - Coming immediate after Jesus experience on the mountain and before his disclosure of his coming death on the cross
    - For today it's enough to look at this young boy and review once again a few basic truths about demons from scripture
- The young boy is under the control, of a demon who can force the boy to hurt himself and to act in a hysterical and bizarre fashion
    - The scene would no doubt scare anyone who might watch it
    - It would bring great fear, especially upon those who might sense the same could happen to them
    - And that was the enemy's principle purpose
        - The fear it created intimidated those who saw it
        - It brought doubt and dread into the minds of both the crowd and – no doubt – the apostles
        - It magnified the strength and power of the enemy in the minds of those who saw it
        - And it helped the enemy in his efforts to thwart God – not because of what happened to the boy, but because of what effect it had on people who saw it, especially on God's people

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- Isn't curious that the apostles couldn't cast out the demons?
    - Look at Jesus' reaction
    - He says you perverted and unbelieving generation
        - Perverted (diastrepho) means crooked and misled
    - Jesus says they were misled and unbelieving and he is clearly frustrated at them
        - The enemy has succeeded in leaving the crowd and the disciples doubting in God's power over the enemy, and in that the enemy has gained the very victory he sought
- But then Jesus steps in
    - And even as Jesus approaches the boy, the demon does his best to generate fear and demonstrate power
    - But of course, Jesus would have nothing of it
    - In short order, Jesus casts out the demon and heals the boy and returns him to his father
    - And then look at the crowds response
        - They were all amazed at the greatness of God
        - They were amazed because in their own minds, they had elevated the enemy and his power to be equal in some sense with God, and they had let their fear drive their perceptions
    - And God in His usual way, turns evil to good
        - He takes this inappropriate emphasis on Satan's power and uses it to glorify Himself by how easily He defeats it
        - Resulting in the crowd giving Him praise for His greatness
- If we learn nothing else about demons, remember this
    - He who is in you, is greater than He who is in the world (1John 4:4)
    - And though the enemy can bring attacks against us indirectly
        - By bringing men who might do harm to you or to your possessions

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        - By sending his allies to disrupt your life in any number of ways
        - Placing temptation in our path
    - But let's also be clear on this
        - Scripture never provides a single example of the enemy able to directly control a believer's body in the way depicted here
        - And much less could the enemy indwell it
        - On the contrary, Jesus' healing of demonic possession or torment, as in the case of this young boy, are all experiences that predate the person's conversion to faith – never after
        - So when we encounter someone exhibiting these kind of behavior traits, no matter what they may claim, God is showing us someone who is not His child – but rather someone under the control of the enemy
    - Therefore any temporary success the enemy may gain against a saint is a victory handed him by God
        - God has allowed the enemy to have the success he achieves, which then forces us to ask the question why?
            - What good purpose is God seeking to accomplish though this test or trial?
            - How does He desire to glorify Himself by our circumstances?
- So when we see such a display as described here, there is no cause for fear
    - Do not give the enemy the victory he seeks
    - Understand and respect the enemy's power, but do not be misled.
    - Do not be unbelieving
    - Do not fear the enemy who himself fears God

Rom. 8:15 For you have not received a spirit of slavery leading to fear again, but you have received a spirit of adoption as sons by which we cry out, "Abba! Father!"
Rom. 8:16 The Spirit Himself testifies with our spirit that we are children of God,

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Rom. 8:17 and if children, heirs also, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with *Him* so that we may also be glorified with *Him*.
Rom. 8:18 ¶ For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory that is to be revealed to us.

- Amen

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Luke 9E

- When we ended our study last week, we left a few things hanging unresolved
    - Jesus had just returned from the mountain where the disciples saw His transfiguration
    - After He came down, He was asked to heal a demon possessed boy
        - We watched Him perform the healing after the disciples were unable to do it
        - Last week we saw that the power of the enemy was on display in this boy, which had the effect of scaring the crowd
        - Yet Jesus demonstrated the far, far greater power of God over the enemy as He dispensed with the demon in a matter of a few words
    - And in verse 43, we noted that the crowd was amazed at how easily God could perform such a miracle
        - And last week I mentioned that this miracle was closely connected to event on the mountain and to the statement He makes to the disciples immediately following the healing
        - Let's look at this series of passages again before we examine the connection

Luke 9:43 And they were all amazed at the greatness of God.
¶ But while everyone was marveling at all that He was doing, He said to His disciples,
Luke 9:44 "Let these words sink into your ears; for the Son of Man is going to be delivered into the hands of men."
Luke 9:45 But they did not understand this statement, and it was concealed from them so that they would not perceive it; and they were afraid to ask Him about this statement.

- In the midst of this miracle as the crowd continues to marvel at the healed boy, Jesus abruptly mentions that in the near future, He would be delivered into the hands of men
    - Mark reports that Jesus also told them in this moment that these men would kill Jesus and that on the third day Jesus would be raised up

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- And Luke says the disciples couldn't understand the statement in the moment, and were scared to ask for clarification

- By itself, this statement seems to come out of no where
  - What was Jesus saying and why did He choose this moment to discuss it?
    - Let's consider His words
    - He says let this sink in – or listen carefully
    - The Son of Man – a Messianic term Jesus used to describe Himself frequently – will be delivered over to men
      - In Greek the words Jesus uses have some subtle underlying meaning
      - He says handed over – paradidomi – betrayed
      - Betrayed to the hands of men – anthropos – which can also be translated enemy
      - So His words suggest a double meaning
        - Jesus was telling them He would be betrayed into the hands of the Enemy by being handed over to men

- We know, of course, that's exactly what happened in Jerusalem
  - Jesus was betrayed by a disciple – one of the men who was standing with Jesus in this moment hearing these words
    - And the instigator for that betrayal and for the persecution that followed was none other than Satan Himself
  - But if understanding what Jesus meant is fairly straightforward, understanding why He chose to bring it up here is a bit more difficult

- To begin, we need to go back a few verses to the point where Jesus was returning from the mountain
  - Though Luke doesn't record it, Mark quotes Jesus making an interesting statement as He descends the mountain

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Mark 9:9 ¶ As they were coming down from the mountain, He gave them orders not to relate to anyone what they had seen, until the Son of Man rose from the dead.
Mark 9:10 They seized upon that statement, discussing with one another what rising from the dead meant.

- As Jesus descends from the mountain, he tells them to stay quiet about what they saw until after Jesus has been raised from the dead
    - Naturally, the disciples are startled by the statement and wonder what He meant by rising from the dead
    - Jesus it would seem was already beginning to plant seeds with the disciples regarding the end of His ministry
        - Imagine Jesus' dilemma: He has to find a way to bring the disciples along in their understanding of what's about to happen in Jerusalem
        - They need to begin to understand that their Rabbi will die and be raised from the dead – and that this is necessary for the establishment of the kingdom
        - This would be totally new thinking for them – and radically different from what they expected
    - So as Mark records, Jesus begins to introduce to the disciples the fact of his eventual suffering an death.
- Then strangely, both Luke and Mark move directly into the account of the demonic boy
    - In fact, as soon as the healing is over, Jesus returns to a discussion of His death by telling the disciples that He expects to be handed over to the enemy and killed
    - Doesn't it seem odd that this rather important discussion about Jesus' death is suddenly cut off by what seems like another routine healing?
- Perhaps at first, yes, but if we look closely, we can see how this moment actually supports the larger discussion of Jesus' betrayal
    - First, remember the essence of the lesson that Jesus taught through the healing of the boy

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        - We saw last week that Jesus was frustrated at the lack of faith shown by His disciples in the face of one of the enemy's displays

        - So He chastises the crowd and the disciples for their lack of faith in God's power,

        - And in the course of healing the boy, Jesus proceeds to display the awesome power of God in such a dramatic way that the crowd stands amazed

    - And now Jesus tells the disciples that the Enemy – the same enemy that Jesus so easily dispensed with - would gain the upper hand in Jerusalem and orchestrate Jesus' death

        - How absolutely bizarre that must have seemed to disciples

        - How can Jesus in one moment display such matchless power over the enemy and then in the next breath confess that this enemy would soon have the power to crush him?

- Well, as the text tells us, the disciples could reconcile these seemingly contradictory thoughts

    - In fact, verse 45 tells us that the statement was concealed from them in the moment

    - God – by withholding insight and understanding from the disciples – left them in this state of confusion

        - Which leaves us even more confused perhaps – why did the Lord go to the effort to tell the disciples something that He wasn't willing to let them understand?

        - The answer is that Jesus is planting seeds for another day, a day when the disciples will desperately need the understanding far more than they need it now

        - And in fact, if it were possible for them to fully grasp the truth in this moment, it would actually work against Jesus' purposes, in that they might have been prompted to try and stop the events God had ordained

- But one day soon, the understanding that eluded them here will be given them by the Holy Spirit, and when that time comes, it will be so very important

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- Because on that day to come, they will see their Lord crucified on the cross, having been put to death by the efforts of the enemy working through the hard hearts of evil men
    - They will begin to wonder and doubt
    - They will begin to question whether this man was who He said He was
    - And to be worried whether God's power was truly capable of overcoming the enemy's power
    - And in their doubt, they will be tempted to forget all they were taught
        - For example, we know that Peter after the crucifixion reacted to Jesus' death as if the whole experience was over and nothing had been gained
        - He's so disappointed, he initially returns to fishing
        - Until Jesus appears to Him after His resurrection and coaxes him back to lead within the church
- So the shock of the crucifixion could easily leave the disciple wondering what it all meant
    - And then there are these words of Jesus that are brought back to mind in that moment
    - And when it does return to their minds, it will come with memories of that little boy tormented by the demon
    - And of Jesus' easy victory over the enemy
    - Followed by His promise foretelling how the enemy would be used to accomplish the Father's will

- At the end of Luke's gospel, as Christ appears to the disciples and proves to them that He has risen from the dead, these are his parting words as recorded by Luke:

Luke 24:44 ¶ Now He said to them, "These are My words which I spoke to you while I was still with you, that all things which are written about Me in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms must be fulfilled."

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Luke 24:45 Then He opened their minds to understand the Scriptures,
Luke 24:46 and He said to them, "Thus it is written, that the Christ would suffer and rise again from the dead the third day,
Luke 24:47 and that repentance for forgiveness of sins would be proclaimed in His name to all the nations, beginning from Jerusalem.

- Don't you think those words would have been so encouraging and stirring for the shaken disciples
    - Finally understanding how it all fits together
    - Seeing that Jesus hadn't been defeated – far from it
    - He had demonstrated his victory over death and the Enemy
- But for now, the meaning is hidden and the disciples move on to a new thought

Luke 9:46 ¶ An argument started among them as to which of them might be the greatest.
Luke 9:47 But Jesus, knowing what they were thinking in their heart, took a child and stood him by His side,
Luke 9:48 and said to them, "Whoever receives this child in My name receives Me, and whoever receives Me receives Him who sent Me; for the one who is least among all of you, this is the one who is great."

- As the text presents it here, this discussion seems to come in the midst of what we already read
    - But as usual, a careful comparison of the gospels tells us more

Mark 9:33 ¶ They came to Capernaum; and when He was in the house, He *began* to question them, "What were you discussing on the way?"
Mark 9:34 But they kept silent, for on the way they had discussed with one another which *of them was* the greatest.

- So it was at a later time when this issue came up
- And it's interesting that Luke has chosen to place this account here at this point in his account
    - In fact, as I read the gospels, there seems to be two separate times in which the disciples engaged in a discussion of who is the greatest

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- We have this discussion here
- Then later in Chapter 22 of Luke we see it again, in the midst of the last supper
- Apparently the disciples were hungry for status and authority, yet they must have sensed that this thought was at the very least immodest and probably disrespectful to their teacher
- As Mark explains it, they were even a bit embarrassed at having been caught in the discussion

- There are actually two separate issues intertwined in this discussion, one of which Jesus addresses in these verses
  - And the other issue He addresses when the questions comes up the second time in Chap 22 – and we'll wait until that chapter to address it
  - As it happens, I recently taught on the verses in Chap 22 during my trip, so if you would like to know the second part of this message.,..
- For today, we'll consider the issue Jesus addresses here
  - After hearing the disciples arguing about who will get to lead
    - And in this context – the context of a Rabbi and his students – the issue is one of who will be the greatest following in the model of Jesus
    - They want to know who will be considered the greatest Rabbi, one who selects students, teaches them, just as Jesus is doing
      - Part of the problem for the disciples here is not just the arrogance and pride of their discussion, but the fact that it reveals a complete lack of appreciation about what Jesus is preparing them for
      - We can best see that when we look at what Jesus says to them in response
- He brings a young child near to Him, and uses the child as an example
  - He says that the one who is willing to receive a child – accept a child as one of their followers – would be greatest

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- Because by accepting a child, the disciples would be accepting Jesus Himself – and therefore the Father
- How does this follow?
    - Well, remember that a child was the least significant member of society, the one with the least status and the least value
    - Now imagine a disciple trying his hand for the first time at being the teacher, the rabbi
    - And as this disciple travels around the countryside looking for students, men he could call into his ministry, men who would accept his call and commit to follow the disciple, learn from, him and obey him
    - Just as the disciples followed and obeyed Jesus and called Him master
- Now imagine that disciple was only able to attract children to follow him
    - His only students were little boys and girls
    - It would be a humiliating outcome
    - A Rabbi who accepted – who received – children as his students would be considered a laughing stock, a man who's ministry was a complete failure – according to the world's standards

- And now here's Jesus responding to the disciples' debate about who would be the greatest by telling them that the greatest is the one who receives a child and counts it as success
- Consider the point Jesus is making here
    - While the disciples were busy trying to decide who would be the greatest teacher, who would attract the greatest following
    - Jesus is cutting them down to size by saying that the one willing to be content with a following of children would be the greatest
    - He's contending with their pride - causing them to reconsider what really matters in ministry

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- But there's even more going on here – more probably than even the disciples understood in the moment
    - Because Jesus' comment about receiving children is more significant than merely a jab at the disciples' pride
    - These men, in a very real sense, were going to attract a following of children
    - In Matt's account, we can see this second side to Jesus' statement

Matt. 18:3 and said, "Truly I say to you, unless you are converted and become like children, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 18:4 "Whoever then humbles himself as this child, he is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 18:5 "And whoever receives one such child in My name receives Me;

-
- The disciples were, in fact, going to attract children
    - Men and women who were willing and able to become like children
        - Like children in a spiritual sense, born again and soft hearted
        - People willing to be confess their unworthiness before God, to become humble and obedient, to recognize that they have nothing to offer of value – like children
        - And, like a child dependent on his parents, they must be willing to rely exclusively on the grace of God for the gift of eternal life in the kingdom
        - This would be the new mark of a faithful believer – which was a radical departure from the proud, pious nature associated with the Pharisees – men who appeared to portray godliness
            - Can you see how hard it was for Jesus to refashion in the disciples' minds what true righteousness would look like?
            - And the disciples had to understand the difference, otherwise they would be seek after the wrong thing – the very thing Jesus came to tear down

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        - And these spiritual children are the ones the disciples were not only to be willing to accept, but they were the ones the disciples should seek after

- Jesus' explanation of the nature of new believers was one of several important points Luke records at the end of Chapter 9 –

    - The beginning of Jesus' final preparation of the disciples for their role as ambassadors for the gospel

    - Chap 9 of Luke's gospel marks the end of the early years of Jesus' ministry, and Chap 10 marks the beginning of Jesus preparation to die on the cross

        - He's already spent the better part of 3 years with the disciples

        - He is on the verge of withdrawing his offer of the kingdom to the Jewish nation and moving directly toward his death on the cross

    - And as this shift begins, Luke records a few critical lessons for the disciples concerning the nature of the ministry Jesus was preparing to hand over to them

- For example, look at the next series of verses

Luke 9:49 ¶ John answered and said, "Master, we saw someone casting out demons in Your name; and we tried to prevent him because he does not follow along with us."
Luke 9:50 But Jesus said to him, "Do not hinder *him*; for he who is not against you is for you."

- On the heels of Jesus' statement that the disciples must be prepared to draw the least of the world rather than the best

    - John complains to Jesus that others are attempting to work in His name, though they don't follow Jesus as a disciple

    - And Jesus tells John essentially to get over it

        - Those who are working toward the same goals are on your side, don't oppose them

- At first, it seems very selfish and childish that John would care that others were working to advance the message that Jesus brought

    - John's comments sound petty

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- But we need to remember that the disciples are simply working from an understanding built from years of experience in their own culture
    - Rabbis often cultivated their own sects within the Jewish faith
    - And they selected their disciples carefully – it was an exclusive club
    - And when someone claimed to be a disciple when they hadn't been invited was an offensive against those who had been selected
        - Think of it like this…
        - You had won the Master golf tournament, and as a winner you were allowed to wear the green jacket and granted membership to play golf at the exclusive Georgia club
        - Then one day, you saw someone make their own green jacket and walk onto the course to play
            - You would be incensed
            - You would demand that the person be removed, since they were not worthy of the honor that you had won legitimately
- That's essentially what John was complaining about…men who were acting as Jesus disciples but yet weren't worthy the honor
    - Here again Jesus take the opportunity to correct their thinking
        - Those who act according to God's will are already on your team – and it is God's discretion to appoint those He wishes
        - The Disciples were to understand that this wasn't going to be an exclusive club of people
        - This was a club of misfits and God was the one who determined membership
        - Look what Jesus says in the next chapter:

Luke 10:21 ¶ At that very time He rejoiced greatly in the Holy Spirit, and said, "I praise You, O Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that You have hidden these things from *the*

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wise and intelligent and have revealed them to infants. Yes, Father, for this way was well-pleasing in Your sight.

- The kingdom would be populated by those who are not honored and esteemed and worthy
    - It will not be populated by the wise, the mighty, the ones the world honored
        - It will be populated by the children of this world
        - The unworthy, the humble, the meek
        - And the disciples are just beginning to comprehend what it means to follow Jesus and build the kingdom of God
    - Jesus teaches the apostles to see all those who work for the same goal as part of the same family, the family of God made so by the Holy Spirit
        - And they can't rely on the worldly standards for determining worthiness to be part of the club - for no one is worthy on his own merit
        - We all come into the family of God by God's grace – by His mercy

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Luke 9F

- Today Luke begins to document Jesus' long trek toward the cross
    - When we look at the Luke's gospel and then add to it Luke's other major contribution to the Biblical record, the book of Acts, we can see his focus clearly
    - In his gospel, Luke spends tremendous time developing the events leading up to Jesus' death,
        - In particular, the battle between Jesus and the Pharisees and the preparation of the disciples for ministry
    - And then in Acts, Luke begins records the work of the disciples after the ascension and the continuing battle between them and the same spiritual darkness of the enemy that had tried to crush Jesus
- As we end Chapter 9 today and enter Chapter 10, we'll see Luke begin to point the reader to that transition, to the death of Jesus and the continuing ministry of the apostles

Luke 9:51 ¶ When the days were approaching for His ascension, He was determined to go to Jerusalem;
Luke 9:52 and He sent messengers on ahead of Him, and they went and entered a village of the Samaritans to make arrangements for Him.
Luke 9:53 But they did not receive Him, because He was traveling toward Jerusalem.
Luke 9:54 When His disciples James and John saw *this*, they said, "Lord, do You want us to command fire to come down from heaven and consume them?"
Luke 9:55 But He turned and rebuked them, [and said, "You do not know what kind of spirit you are of;
Luke 9:56 for the Son of Man did not come to destroy men's lives, but to save them."] And they went on to another village.

- Up to this point in Luke's gospel, you should have noticed that Jesus was essentially wandering in the desert of the Galilee
    - He moved around from town to town, often returning to places multiple times to teach and perform miracles

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- And though His travels were not without a purpose, they certainly seemed to have no clear direction
- But now, His travel is focused on a single direction: Jerusalem

- I love the way Luke starts this transition
  - He says "when the days for His ascension were approaching"
    - The reason I like this phrase is that it places the emphasis on Jesus purpose squarely on His glorification rather than dwelling on his death
    - He was going to Jerusalem to ascend not merely to die
      - To be sure, death had to precede the ascension
      - But it reminds us that Jesus didn't come to earth as a man just to die
      - He came to die so that He could be resurrected and ascend to the right hand of the Father
      - And by His ascension, He demonstrated that He does truly have the power over death
      - And by displaying that power, He proves Himself to be the One in whom we should trust for our own eternal life
        - We want to trust the right source for eternal life
        - Jesus is the One who proved Himself trustworthy in all matters, including in having the power of life over death
        - Budda, Muhammed, Confucious, etc.
      - But Jesus came from heaven to earth for the express purpose of returning

John 3:12 "If I told you earthly things and you do not believe, how will you believe if I tell you heavenly things?
John 3:13 "No one has ascended into heaven, but He who descended from heaven: the Son of Man.

John 6:62 "*What* then if you see the Son of Man ascending to where He was before?

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- One of the criticisms I remember reading about the Passion of Christ was that it placed all it's emphasis on the death of Christ with virtually no attention given to the resurrection nor its meaning
    - Because the death of Christ without the resurrection is meaningless – it would offer no hope
    - Instead, we have the assurance of eternal life because we know by the eye witness accounts recording in scripture that Jesus rose and lived again and promised the same opportunity to all who believe in Him

- And so Luke says Jesus was determined to go to Jerusalem
    - He sends messengers ahead of him
        - What Jesus is doing here is essentially the same you and I do today when we travel
        - Before setting out on a road trip, we call ahead to make reservations at the local inn
        - But no phones or internet, so messengers were sent to make arrangements

- So these messengers – not the disciples – went ahead and picked a Samaritan village to find lodging
    - Samaria was a region south of the Galilee, directly between the Galilee and Jerusalem
        - The people living in the region of Samaria were called the Samaritans
            - They were Semitic people descended from Abraham, and so they could be called Jews
            - When the northern Kingdom of Israel was captured by the Assyrians in 722 BC, there were a small group of Jews were remained behind in the land – not all Jews were rounded up and removed from the land
            - And this small band of Jews eventually began to intermarry with the Assyrians who began to enter and occupy the land after the nation of Israel had been captured

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- When the descendents of the Jews taken into exile finally returned to the land, they refused to accept the Jews who had remained behind and intermarried as true descendents of Abraham any longer
    - They rejected Samaritans because the Samaritans had not kept to a purely Jewish bloodline
    - This set up a bitter and often violent rivalry between the two groups as to who the true descendents of Abraham were
    - Eventually, the Samaritans rejected virtually all things Jewish
        - They rejected all the writings of the Jewish prophets other than the Torah
        - They rejected Jerusalem as the seat of authority and established their own temple in Samaria
    - Consequently, the Jews and the Samaritans would have nothing to do with one another – treating each other as if they were Gentiles – unworthy of even being spoken to

- So when the messengers enter the Samaritan town and try to make room arrangements, we can see how it went
    - When the innkeeper found out that Jesus was traveling to worship in Jerusalem, they refused him lodging
    - If He had been traveling to worship in Samaria, they would have been willing to let him stay

- When Jesus reached the village with His disciples and they learned of the rejection, the disciples reacted angrily and asked if they should call down fire from heaven to consume the Samaritans
    - We can sympathize with the disciples
        - When you've been on the road all day and you reach the hotel only to find they lost your reservation, we would all enjoy the thought of watching the hotel go up in flame
        - But that's not the right reaction

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- Their suggestion of bringing fire down is rather comical actually
  - They are making reference to 2 Kings 17 where Elijah calls down fire from heaven to destroy the false prophets in his day
  - Do the disciples think they have this power? I would say no, they didn't
  - Rather they were asking for such power to satisfy their own selfish hatred
  - They wanted Jesus to give them that power so they could use it for their own purposes – to destroy their enemies
- The disciples reaction is largely driven by their hatred of the Samaritan people
  - And their rejection of the Messiah simply adds fuel to the fire, no pun intended

- Jesus rebukes them, we're told (epitomao – a stern warning)
  - He says He had not come to destroy lives but to save them
  - Again, reminding the disciples that Jesus' first coming was about the offer of the kingdom and salvation to all who believe
  - The time of judgment awaits His return

- The disciples request of Jesus reveals an interesting point along their path to spiritual maturity
  - It's like the saying that a little knowledge is a dangerous thing
    - The disciples had just enough knowledge at this point in their ministry under Jesus to appreciate a few things
      - They knew Jesus was the Messiah, the Christ
      - They knew that men must accept Him
      - They knew that God desired to work through men to display His power and reveal His Son
      - They knew that in faith they could be used by God to do miraculous things

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        - But yet, they still lacked the big picture – a full understanding of what Jesus taught on the kingdom, on righteousness and on the purpose of His ministry to save all men by faith – not just the Jew

    - So while they exist in this in between state, knowing some thing and yet ignorant about many others, they were actually more dangerous in some ways than when they were still completely ignorant and even unbelievers

        - Here they were prepared to destroy an entire city of people on the basis of how they responded to Jesus request for lodging – even though they had presumably not yet even heard about Jesus or His teaching

        - How wrong they would have been to place themselves in the role of judge, since that role belongs to God alone according to scripture

- And even if we aren't in the habit of asking for the power to bring fire down on our enemies – though some of us might have done it a few times – consider how we ourselves make this same mistake from time to time

    - In my experience, Christians are forever proving and reproving the adage that a little knowledge is a dangerous thing

        - We gain a limited understanding of scripture, of Christian doctrine, of the purpose and call upon God has placed upon our lives

        - Then we stop learning, stop listening, stop following

            - We get busy (eg), we get distracted, we get bored, we get offended

            - And we get away from the learning process that God says should be life long

            - Or maybe we have the opposite problem – we get too excited

                - That's what the disciples are doing here

                - They are so excited by the prospect of their ministry under Jesus, they are ready to jump forward without all the facts

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- They haven't learned near enough, they haven't experienced near enough, and here they are ready to jump out and barbeque entire town

- Now consider this:
  - The disciples lived all day, everyday with Jesus in the flesh for nearly three years at this point.
    - They saw His miracles firsthand
    - They heard His teaching from His mouth
    - They had the chance to ask questions
    - They had an intimate knowledge of the OT and of Jewish culture
  - And after that much time and experience, they are still lacking so much understanding and self-control, they are dangerous to Christ's mission
    - Jesus says that they don't even know what kind of spirit they speak from
    - He is saying that they are doing the work of the enemy by harboring such thoughts

Luke 9:55 But He turned and rebuked them, [and said, "You do not know what kind of spirit you are of;

- These guys aren't just a little wrong – they are doing the work of the enemy!

- So now, we should ask ourselves – do we think we've got enough training to serve God effectively in our life?
  - Have we studied enough?
  - Do we know Jesus heart well enough?
  - Do we know God's will well enough?
  - Have we spent enough time with the Father through His word and in prayer to be useful to Him or are we merely dangerous

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- Well, consider that the disciples had so long with him, and yet by this point they're still so far away
- I know I can often be tempted to think that because I've attended or even taught a few Bible studies, or because I spend 90 minutes in church once a week or pray here and there, that I should be ready to be used by God
    - Then I wonder why God isn't doing more in me and through me
    - Maybe it's a blessing that God hasn't elected to ask more of me, considering how dangerous I might be were He to do that

- But don't forget that Jesus had already begun to use the disciples despite their limited understanding – and that's the encouragement for us today
    - We are going to make the same dumb mistakes the disciples did – we're going to be rash, impulsive, and we're even going to go in directions that serve the enemy rather than God
    - But God doesn't give up on us, and He continues to use us, even as he continues to train us up in His ways
    - As long as we don't think we can rest on what we already know, thinking we've got it all together, then God is pleased to continue the training process even as He works through us

Luke 9:57 ¶ As they were going along the road, someone said to Him, "I will follow You wherever You go."
Luke 9:58 And Jesus said to him, "The foxes have holes and the birds of the air *have* nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay His head."
Luke 9:59 And He said to another, "Follow Me." But he said, "Lord, permit me first to go and bury my father."
Luke 9:60 But He said to him, "Allow the dead to bury their own dead; but as for you, go and proclaim everywhere the kingdom of God."
Luke 9:61 Another also said, "I will follow You, Lord; but first permit me to say good-bye to those at home."
Luke 9:62 But Jesus said to him, "No one, after putting his hand to the plow and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God."

- As Jesus continues toward Jerusalem, Luke strings together a number of what were probably isolated exchanges between Jesus and people He met along the way

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- It's unlikely that all these encounters happened at the same time or even along the same journey, since Matt and Mark record that some of these comments happened at other points in Jesus ministry
- But it could be that many of these comments were a part of Jesus walk to Jerusalem

- In any case, let's look at what's going on in each situation Luke captured
  - Someone tells Jesus I will follow you wherever you go
    - Do you get the feeling Jesus probably heard this a lot?
    - I do. I think Jesus must have had all kinds of bizarre offers, requests, pledges, promises, etc.
    - People must have come along and pledged their loyalty to Jesus in the same way this person did
- And Jesus gives an interesting response
  - He says even animals have the benefit of a home, a place to retreat at the end of the day – a place to rest
  - But Jesus was never to experience that kind of resting place during His first experience on earth
    - Far from it…Jesus would forever be without the peace of a home, a place that was truly a resting place
    - And anyone who would desire to call himself a disciple had to expect a similar burden
      - Look at the apostles…
      - None of them lived a "normal" life
      - Many of them moved about to spread the gospel
      - They were persecuted, which drive them to live a life of constant turmoil
      - They constantly looked beyond this world to a life that came afterward – to their true home

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Heb. 11:13 ¶ All these died in faith, without receiving the promises, but having seen them and having welcomed them from a distance, and having confessed that they were strangers and exiles on the earth.
Heb. 11:14 For those who say such things make it clear that they are seeking a country of their own.
Heb. 11:15 And indeed if they had been thinking of that *country* from which they went out, they would have had opportunity to return.
Heb. 11:16 But as it is, they desire a better *country*, that is, a heavenly one. Therefore God is not ashamed to be called their God; for He has prepared a city for them.

- Jesus point to the man, of course, was if you want to follow, you better be prepared for what it means
    - You need to be prepared for a life that forsakes completely – if necessary – the normal life of this world
- His next two comments build on this theme
    - The first man says I'll follow, but give me a chance to wait until my father dies
        - Now you might have assumed that the man's father had just died and he needed time to prepare the funeral, but that's not likely
        - In Jewish culture – much as it is today among Muslims in the Middle East, the dead must be buried within 24 hours of death
        - In Jesus day this made great sense, because the decomposition of the body occurred so quickly in a hot climate
        - So if the man is saying allow me to bury my father first, it's unlikely he's saying that his father has already died
        - More likely, he's telling Jesus he needs time to wait for his father to pass away, and then as a son he would have opportunity to do the honorable thing and bury his father
    - Jesus says allow the dead to bury their dead
        - The dead here refers to the spiritually dead – allow those who are unbelievers to go on living the life they consider normal
            - But if you have been awaken spiritually, if you know that this world isn't what's normal

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- Rather this world is passing away – it is only temporary – it should not be your focus or the thing you invest your time in

- Then you should be willing to leave it behind, even the traditions the world holds dear, like burying family member – if in fact God has called you to proclaim the good news

- Then a man asks if he can have even enough time to say goodbye to family

  - This hardly seems like an unreasonable request, right?

    - Surely saying goodbye isn't a bad thing

- But Jesus chastises the person and compares them to a farmer who begins to low the field and then looks longingly back at the easy life in the farm house

  - Jesus says that anyone who begins to do the hard work of ministry and then gives thought of the life they left behind – even for a second – is not truly a disciple

  - No one who truly understands the gospel and responds to the call of faith ever looks back longingly for the life they had prior to knowing Christ

- In light of where Jesus was headed in His journey – to the cross – it makes perfect sense to see Luke begin Jesus' rip with these three statements

  - Jesus was playing for keeps

  - He was willing to place His very life on the line – to allow Himself to be tortured and killed for the sake of the kingdom

    - And to truly follow Him required a willingness to forsake the comfort of this world

    - To forsake the cares of this world

    - To forsake a desire for this world

    - And to look only forward – forward to eternity in the kingdom

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- A true transformation – to become a new creation

- Are we together in this work? Have we all understood the call of faith and understood it in the way the Bible teaches it?
    - Do we all share the same single-mindedness for where our true home lies?
    - Do we truly understand the sacrifices God may ask us to make in our walk of faith
    - Have we put aside the cares of this world
    - And have we forsaken pursuing the pleasures of this corrupt and dying world
    - Or are we trying to live with one foot in two worlds?
        - Jesus says that if His answers to these three questions cause us to wonder about our own commitment to Him, then now is the time to stop wondering
        - Stop fooling ourselves
        - It's time we made up our mind for sure, put our shoulders to the plow and pressed forward – trusting in Christ, believing in His word and becoming His disciple

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Luke 10A

- Jesus heads out of the Galilee, passes through the region of Samaria, and toward Jerusalem
    - Last week we saw Jesus rejected by the Samaritans as He traveled South
    - And today we see Him speak of other regions that also rejected His message

Luke 10:1 ¶ Now after this the Lord appointed seventy others, and sent them in pairs ahead of Him to every city and place where He Himself was going to come.
Luke 10:2 And He was saying to them, "The harvest is plentiful, but the laborers are few; therefore beseech the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into His harvest.
Luke 10:3 "Go; behold, I send you out as lambs in the midst of wolves.
Luke 10:4 "Carry no money belt, no bag, no shoes; and greet no one on the way.
Luke 10:5 "Whatever house you enter, first say, 'Peace *be* to this house.'
Luke 10:6 "If a man of peace is there, your peace will rest on him; but if not, it will return to you.
Luke 10:7 "Stay in that house, eating and drinking what they give you; for the laborer is worthy of his wages. Do not keep moving from house to house.
Luke 10:8 "Whatever city you enter and they receive you, eat what is set before you;
Luke 10:9 and heal those in it who are sick, and say to them, 'The kingdom of God has come near to you.'

- Jesus, Luke tells us, appointed 70 more men to a mission of going before Him to announce His arrival
    - If you have an NIV version of the Bible, you will find that the Greek word **hebdomekonta** has been translated 72
    - This is a compound word made from two other Greek words, so it's exact meaning is open to interpretation
    - Of major translations, only the NIV renders it 72…all others choose to translate it 70
        - Seventy makes sense from a historical perspective, since 70 is a common number in the history of Israel, particular when we're talking about men sent to do the work of the ministry

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        - But honestly, whether the author meant 70 or 72 doesn't matter to the rest of the account

- Like we saw at both the beginning and the end of Chapter 9, Jesus sends men ahead to announce His coming
    - This group of messengers goes out for a different purpose than those that went at the end of Chapter 9
        - These men are not going out to find Jesus rooms
        - They are going out like the disciples did at the beginning of Chap 9
        - They are going to declare the kingdom and demonstrate its power ahead of Jesus arrival
    - There are some interesting details here
        - First, we here Jesus is sending them in pairs
            - There is an important principle being demonstrated here
            - Messengers are commonly seen in the NT going out in pairs
                - Paul and Barnabas went together
                - Judas and Silas went together
                - Later, Paul and Silas went out together
                - And Barnabas and Mark went together
                - Silas and Timothy are said to minister together
                - And on and on
            - In my own life, I've seen God place other men in my life to partner with me in ministry
            - I had the blessing of Kim's company in my trip to Kenya a couple of years ago
                - That experience showed me the value of a companion

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- I have men like Brian Jamison who god paired me with me…

- Even in our church, I have had the benefit of men like Danny and Matt

- So God brings men along side one another to serve in ministry

  - One reason to do so traces back to the Law and Deut, where we hear in chapter 19 that 2 or more witnesses were required to condemn a man for sin

    - In other words, these men were both ambassadors of the gospel to men who received the good news as well as witnesses against those who rejected it

    - We'll see a little more of that in a minute

  - But secondly, there were simple practical reasons to go out in pairs as well

    - Traveling in pairs increased protection and provided some degree of accountability

      - Let's face it, there is safety in numbers and one of the ways numbers give us safety is by protecting us from ourselves

      - We call this accountability, and it's essential in ministry

    - One of the reasons that Paul insists that Timothy appoint elders to assist him in the work of the church in Ephesus is to ensure that there was some for of accountability

    - Jesus sends these men out in pairs for their protection from the elements, from thieves, from adversaries and from their own sinful lusts and desires

- In verse 2 Jesus says that the harvest is plentiful but the laborers are few, so the disciples should pray for God to send workers into the field

  - The analogy is fairly simple

    - The field is the world of unbelievers

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        - The harvest are those within the field who are to be separated out, to be harvested

            - This imagery is common in scripture

            - You can see it in Revelation 14 when God tells His angel to put in his sickle for the hour has come to reap for the harvest of the earth is ripe

            - Therefore harvesting is commonly a metaphor for finding and collecting God's elect – those who will respond to the Gospel message

- In this context, Jesus is remarking that these 70 men as they go out are doing the kind of work Jesus is says is often lacking

    - The work of going out to collect – to reap – the harvest of believers from unbelievers

    - This is such an important principle, and I think we often miss the subtleties of it

        - The work of making believers is truly the work of the Holy Spirit

        - And that work takes place on with or without the contributions of men – God is never dependent on our obedience in ministry in order to bring men to salvation

            - Remember that Saul was converted into Paul on a lonely road without a man to bring the message

- Yet despite the fact that the work itself is relatively light for us, we still hesitate to do it

    - I think we tend to make the process of evangelism much more difficult in our own minds than it really is

        - We assume that we will have to convince, cajoal, persuade, argue, people into believing the gospel in order to find success

        - And even when we do find success, it will be fleeting

    - But Jesus says the harvest is plentiful

        - There is a field white for the harvest, He says in John 4:35

        - I'm fond of comparing it to an Easter egg hunt…

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- But instead we tend to imagine the worst,
  - We Imagine that people will never respond positively, and we're almost surprised when they do
- And that thinking actually drives us to poor results
  - And here's what I mean
  - When we assume that the power to save souls lies with us – with our abilities or with our technique or methods – then we let the impossibility of it discourage us from even trying
    - Because it truly IS impossible for us to bring anyone to salvation in our own power
  - On the other hand, if we see it more like an Easter egg hunt then we'll have the proper perspective and a reason to be motivated
  - We'll see each person as a potential convert and we'll approach them with an expectation that they will be one appointed to salvation

Acts 13:48 ¶ When the Gentiles heard this, they *began* rejoicing and glorifying the word of the Lord; and as many as had been appointed to eternal life believed.

- If we see a positive response, we give thanks to God for being the one through whom God worked to bring the good news
- If not, we move on, continuing to look for the easter egg
- Jesus calls us all to pray that God will stir the hearts of men to want to get up go out and become the ones through whom God will call new believers

- Then in the rest of these verse, we see Jesus giving instructions similar to those He gave the disciples when He sent them out earlier in Chap 9

Luke 10:3 "Go; behold, I send you out as lambs in the midst of wolves.

- Listen to Jesus words…He isn't saying be careful otherwise you will be like lambs in the midst of wolves
  - Protect yourselves and watch out for the wolves

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- No, He's saying that it is Jesus' purpose to send the messengers out in an intentionally vulnerable posture
  - Look at the following verses
  - They carry no money, no bag, no shoes – without even basic preparations for such a trip
  - Jesus also tells them to take what you are given, accept what you receive, expect those who minister to care for your needs
  - Eat what's put before you
    - In other words, depend upon God, as we said in Chap 9
    - Don't seek after the better things in this world, accept that whatever you get, whether it is what you want or not,, is coming according to God's grace,
    - So it is what God wants you to have – so be content with it and focus instead on your ministry – stay focused
  - Heal those who are sick – to demonstrate proof of your message
  - And by doing all these things, be able to declare the kingdom

- The point here is much like it was at the beginning of Chap 9
  - God will do the work of calling men to Him, but when He works, He doesn't want His work to be mistaken as the work of men
  - So He chooses to work through men in such a way that His strength is made evident

1Cor. 1:25 Because the foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men.
1Cor. 1:26 ¶ For consider your calling, brethren, that there were not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble;
1Cor. 1:27 but God has chosen the foolish things of the world to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to shame the things which are strong,
1Cor. 1:28 and the base things of the world and the despised God has chosen, the things that are not, so that He may nullify the things that are,
1Cor. 1:29 so that no man may boast before God.

  - Here, Jesus has set these men up, in a sense, to be like sheep among wolves

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- To be vulnerable and 100% dependent on Him
- So that their success is rightly attributed to Him

- Interestingly, Jesus also says they should greet no one along the way in verse 4
  - What He means by this is probably not what you think He means
    - A greeting of a stranger in the custom of the east was not a casual hello
    - It could extend for days on end and involve feasting and lodging with someone
    - Jesus doesn't want these men to get sidetracked in this way as they go about their work of the ministry

Judg. 19:4 His father-in-law, the girl's father, detained him; and he remained with him three days. So they ate and drank and lodged there.
Judg. 19:5 Now on the fourth day they got up early in the morning, and he prepared to go; and the girl's father said to his son-in-law, "Sustain yourself with a piece of bread, and afterward you may go."
Judg. 19:6 So both of them sat down and ate and drank together; and the girl's father said to the man, "Please be willing to spend the night, and let your heart be merry."
Judg. 19:7 Then the man arose to go, but his father-in-law urged him so that he spent the night there again.
Judg. 19:8 On the fifth day he arose to go early in the morning, and the girl's father said, "Please sustain yourself, and wait until afternoon"; so both of them ate.

- When they declare the kingdom, Jesus tells them to approach the people they visit in a specific pattern
  - When they enter a house, they are to declare that peace has arrived and has come upon this house
  - If the man inside receives the disciple's message, then the peace of God will be evident in His life
    - This man, if he is a man of peace, he will be seen to be living in the fullness of the spirit, demonstrating the love and peace of God outwardly
    - And by so doing, he is blessed all the more by the visit of the disciple and to hear the disciple's message

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- But if that peace is not evident, the disciple's declaration of peace will return to him, meaning it will not have found a sympathetic audience, and it return to the disciple, like a gift that's been rejected

Luke 10:10 "But whatever city you enter and they do not receive you, go out into its streets and say,
Luke 10:11 'Even the dust of your city which clings to our feet we wipe off *in protest* against you; yet be sure of this, that the kingdom of God has come near.'
Luke 10:12 "I say to you, it will be more tolerable in that day for Sodom than for that city.
Luke 10:13 ¶ "Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida! For if the miracles had been performed in Tyre and Sidon which occurred in you, they would have repented long ago, sitting in sackcloth and ashes.
Luke 10:14 "But it will be more tolerable for Tyre and Sidon in the judgment than for you.
Luke 10:15 "And you, Capernaum, will not be exalted to heaven, will you? You will be brought down to Hades!
Luke 10:16 ¶ "The one who listens to you listens to Me, and the one who rejects you rejects Me; and he who rejects Me rejects the One who sent Me."

- Jesus gives instructions, even more detailed than we saw in Chap 9, regarding how the messengers were to when they're message is rejected
    - Beyond repeating His instructions regarding dusting off their feet and moving on, Jesus adds some rather harsh comparisons
        - He says that any town that rejects this message would find their judgment even less tolerable than that merited out upon Sodom
        - And He says woe to Chorazin and Bethasida, towns on the Glailee
        - He compares them to Tyre and Sidon, Phoenician cities on the Med coast, saying if the same miracles had been done there, they would have repented
        - Which implies that the miracles didn't have the same effect in Chorazim and Bethaisda
    - The comparison here is more damning than even it sounds
        - Jesus isn't just comparing two different cities – He's comparing two different cultures

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- He's comparing how these Jewish cities responded to the arrival of their Jewish Messiah next to how Gentile cities would have responded to the same declaration
    - The Jews rejected the truth f a Messiah while the Gentiles would be willing to accept it
    - And the Jews had full knowledge of their Messiah
    - They had been taught and should have recognized Him when He came
- The Gentile cities would have had none of those insights or advantages, yet Jesus says they would have responded positively to His miracles had He gone there
    - Like the way Gentile city Nineveh responded to the preaching of the Jewish prophet Jonah

- Why would Jesus suggest these Gentile should respond positively when Jewish cities wouldn't?
    - Perhaps because the Gentiles had no preconceived ideas when it came to a Messiah – they hadn't even heard of such a thing
    - There was no established religious power structure that should see the declaration of the kingdom of God as an automatic threat in the same way that the Jewish authorities saw Jesus
    - And Jesus says that these cities – meaning the people in the cities – would receive an even greater punishment than those who were in Sodom – a difficult thing to imagine but true none the less
        - This concept of greater punishment can be explored further, but we'll wait until Chapter 11&12 of Luke to explore it further

- I find it especially interesting that Capernaum is mentioned as headed to Hades – Hell
    - Remember Capernaum? This was Jesus home base of operations in the Galilee
        - And it was the city that Jesus credited with responding positively to His miracles and teaching while His hometown Nazareth wouldn't accept them

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- But apparently they didn't do enough
  - It seems they never really saw Jesus for who He said He was
  - They loved the miracles, they admired the teaching, but they never accepted Him as the Messiah
  - You see the fine line here between being saved and simply looking like someone who's saved
    - You can acknowledge Jesus lived, that He had supernatural power to perform miracles, and that His teaching came from the mouth of God
    - You can have all those things…but unless you're willing to acknowledge Him as God, as the Messiah, who's death paid for your sin – then you are no better than those in Capernaum who are destined for Hades
    - It's such a fine line

- And Jesus has commissioned these 70 men to go out among the Jewish cities He will travel through on the way to Jerusalem and fine people willing to cross that line
  - When they find them, they declare peace
  - And when they find someone unwilling to cross over, they declare judgment
  - It's no different today…we are each potential workers in God's field and are called to go out to collect the harvest
    - This is not just the role for an evangelist like Brian Jamison
    - This is not a role restricted to a teacher like me
    - This is not something that only happens during revival meetings or evangelism trips to Mexico on Spring Break
    - Or when you have a visitor in church

- We are all supposed to leave this building this morning with an expectation that God will send men and women into our life everyday who we can harvest, like looking for Easter eggs
  - And we are supposed to persuade them in our own ability

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- We aren't supposed to trick them into coming to church
- We are supposed to cloak the gospel message in feel good double speak or conceal it under so much pop culture that it looks like an elaborate case of bait and switch
  - We are to go simply, in a vulnerable way, dependent on God to bring success
  - We lay it out on the line in simple terms, declaring peace
  - And where that declaration of peace in Christ finds a receptive audience, we find our success in God's power
  - And where it doesn't, that declaration of peace returns to us and we become a witness against that person for their rejection – should they never embrace the truth

- But in either case, we have done as God commanded and we are blessed for doing so
  - For as Jesus says in verse 16, the one who accepts the message that men bring concerning Jesus, are accepting Jesus Himself
  - And when we are rejected, they are rejecting Jesus Himself
  - We have nothing to lose, we are not the ones being rejected, and we have nothing to keep us from trying

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Luke 10B

- Last week Jesus sent out seventy messengers to declare the kingdom in advance of his arrival
    - And as we open in Luke today we see the joy of these men as they return from this mission
    - And Jesus feeds their excitement, giving them encouragement to rejoice in their work

Luke 10:17 ¶ The seventy returned with joy, saying, "Lord, even the demons are subject to us in Your name."
Luke 10:18 And He said to them, "I was watching Satan fall from heaven like lightning.
Luke 10:19 "Behold, I have given you authority to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing will injure you.
Luke 10:20 "Nevertheless do not rejoice in this, that the spirits are subject to you, but rejoice that your names are recorded in heaven."
Luke 10:21 ¶ At that very time He rejoiced greatly in the Holy Spirit, and said, "I praise You, O Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that You have hidden these things from *the* wise and intelligent and have revealed them to infants. Yes, Father, for this way was well-pleasing in Your sight.
Luke 10:22 "All things have been handed over to Me by My Father, and no one knows who the Son is except the Father, and who the Father is except the Son, and anyone to whom the Son wills to reveal *Him*."
Luke 10:23 ¶ Turning to the disciples, He said privately, "Blessed *are* the eyes which see the things you see,
Luke 10:24 for I say to you, that many prophets and kings wished to see the things which you see, and did not see *them*, and to hear the things which you hear, and did not hear *them*."

- If you look back a few verse in the text, you will remember Jesus' instructions to these men
    - In verses 8-10, Jesus gives instructions on how they should respond to rejection
        - As we read those verses last week, they certainly left us with the impression that the messengers were not likely to find much success

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        - And it's a safe assumption that they often encountered an unreceptive audience

        - But looking at the responsive of the messengers in these verses, it seems like they also met with a measure of success

    - We're told they returned with joy

        - And they exclaimed that even the demons were subject to them in Jesus name

            - What they mean of course is that they were given the power by the Holy Spirit to cast out demons, and they were amazed at that experience

            - By the sound of their statement, I would assume that they found themselves empowered to do a variety of things…even casting out demons

        - The sense from the text here is like that of a child with a new toy – there's obvious joy in the opportunity to join the Lord in His work of building the kingdom

            - But let's keep this in perspective

            - They must have had plenty of failures as well

            - Oh sure, they would have found at least a few who accepted them and embraced their message

            - But knowing what we know about how the nation of Israel largely rejected their Messiah, we can only assume that they were kicked out of towns, ignored, spat upon, etc.

            - Yet they come back to Jesus excited and joyful over their successes

- Whatever other successes they experienced, they are most excited over who they were defeating

    - In their service to the Lord, they instantly became soldiers in the battle against the enemy

    - When we serve the Lord, we ultimately join in battle against the enemy

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        - But these messengers mentioned an important detail that explains their success, of course

        - They said they found the enemy subject to them as they ministered in the name of the Lord

    - As you've probably heard me teach before, the idea of speaking in the name of another person had a very specific meaning in that day

        - It didn't mean simple using the name of the person like an incantation – like you were casting a spell

        - It had a legal connotation

        - It was something akin to a Power of Attorney

        - It meant the messenger was acting with the authority of the one who sent him and could speak and act on his behalf

- So when someone spoke in the name of another, it meant they had been granted permission to act in the place of the other person, as their legal representative

    - Therefore, these messengers had success against the enemy because they were acting in Jesus name, under His orders and according to His commissioning – as if Jesus was standing there with them

    - And after all, He was – in the form of the Holy Spirit giving them the power that God had told them to use

- Likewise for us today, when we act in ministry according to our Lord's direction, then we can expect to see whatever success He has determined for us

    - We are acting in His name – and not merely because we insert His name in a prayer or declare it publicly

    - Rather, we act in His name when we act according to His will and by the power of the Holy Spirit

    - And in acting in Jesus name, even the enemy will be subjected to us according to God's will

- How can we know the difference?

    - Well, first look at the messengers' reaction

    - The joy is clearly visible

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        - They have seen the power of God acting through them
        - They have seen the enemy retreat
    - On the other hand, if they had been acting presumptuously, what would have happened?
- When we act presumptuously, we will find out power lacking

Acts 19:13 But also some of the Jewish exorcists, who went from place to place, attempted to name over those who had the evil spirits the name of the Lord Jesus, saying, "I adjure you by Jesus whom Paul preaches."
Acts 19:14 Seven sons of one Sceva, a Jewish chief priest, were doing this.
Acts 19:15 And the evil spirit answered and said to them, "I recognize Jesus, and I know about Paul, but who are you?"
Acts 19:16 And the man, in whom was the evil spirit, leaped on them and subdued all of them and overpowered them, so that they fled out of that house naked and wounded.

- So there is joy to be found in serving the Lord according to His direction and in His power, and that joy will be found regardless of the degree of success we find – whether great or small
- In the next verse Jesus responds with an intriguing comment
    - He says was there in the beginning to watch the enemy fall from heaven
    - There are at least a couple of ways to understand Jesus' statement here
        - First, He could simply be sharing in the messengers' celebration by relating His own experience of watching the enemy cast down from heaven when He fell
        - The idea here is simple…Jesus is reaffirming the messengers' experience with the encouraging reminder that the enemy is subject to God just like the rest of His creation
        - As a side note, this is one of many places where Jesus clearly describes Himself to be God – here it is by virtue of having been present at the beginning of creation
    - But a second way to see this comment is as a mean of tempering their excitement a little
        - Look at Jesus' words in the next verses

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- He seems to be reminding these men that though they experienced success over the enemy in this moment, the battle began long before they joined the fight
- And it will continue long after they are gone
- But Jesus has been fighting it from the beginning
- And it will be His power that will ultimately defeat the enemy in the end, as He returns to crush him

- In verse 19 He tells them that He granted them power over the enemy and even to tread on serpents and scorpions
  - In other words, Jesus had ensured they would succeed in this mission, not only in how they contended with the enemy but also in their ability to withstand earthly threats
  - Jesus had protected them from all harm as a means of ensuring their success
  - There are other examples in the early church of where God granted such supernatural immunity, like at the end of Mark's gospel:

Mark 16:17 "These signs will accompany those who have believed: in My name they will cast out demons, they will speak with new tongues;
Mark 16:18 they will pick up serpents, and if they drink any deadly *poison*, it will not hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover."

- Just as in this example, Jesus was granting specific powers to specific individuals as part of the ministry of the early church
- The temporary nature of these protections are easy to confirm
  - Consider that the disciples were the ones who received these powers in the beginning
  - Yet virtually all of them were eventually destroyed in one way or another
- Furthermore, there is no implication here that these powers would extend to all Christians, though some misguided men and women have tried to hold to that claim

- But in the next verse, verse 20, Jesus steps back and tells the messengers not to rejoice simply over their temporary powers, but rather over their salvation

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- Jesus was cautioning these men not to take their eyes off what was truly important
  - Don't get excited because God granted them temporary power to contend with the enemy or to heal sickness
  - Doing that misses the real point, it confuses the means with the ends
- God had granted them these powers so that others would see the truth of the gospel message, and thereby glorify God
  - They had just returned excited over their successes and were rejoicing in their miraculous abilities
  - And Jesus reminds them not to focus on the wrong thing
    - We don't rejoice because He grants us victories over the enemy, or because we experience supernatural healing, or any of these temporary, earthly things
    - We rejoice over our salvation, the free gift He gives that makes all the rest even possible
  - So Jesus says rejoice that your names are recorded in heaven, as should we all

- Then Jesus speaks a spontaneous prayer to the Father recorded in verses 21&22
  - With this prayer Jesus alludes to a difference, a distinction among men
  - He says that the Father is to be praised for revealing the gospel message to the least of the world rather than to those who profess to be wise
    - He is referring to the Pharisees, the spiritual leaders of Jesus day who claimed to know God and how to please God
    - Yet they were anything but pleasing to God, and they led others astray by their deceptions
  - Meanwhile, God was content to reveal the truth to those who weren't looking for Him and who never saw themselves as righteous, but rather as sinners
    - And Jesus adds that the knowledge of the gospel is something reserved for those the Son wills to reveal to it to

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- A profound statement that causes those who understand it to rejoice even more, in thanks to God for having been one to whom God revealed His Son

- And this difference is the issue at the heart of the remainder of this chapter and even the rest of the Gospel as it comes up time and time again
    - Jesus ends this passage by turning to the disciples and reminding them how special their situation truly is
        - Throughout the history of the nation of Israel, holy men throughout the generations had understood the prophecies of the coming Messiah and longed to see that day
            - These men longed, Jesus said, to be able to see what the disciples saw and to hear what they heard
            - But they weren't appointed to that privilege
            - Instead these 12 ordinary men received that honor
- Do you see now what Jesus was saying about the humble chosen over the wise?
    - Here are these few, unremarkable men who were selected by God to receive the attention of the Messiah of the world – of all time
        - They do anything to deserve that honor
        - They didn't ask for it
        - They didn't pray for it
        - They certainly the most holy, the most pious
    - In fact, they didn't even fully know who Jesus was until after the resurrection
        - And Jesus is praising the Father for delighting to reveal Himself to ordinary people, even those who aren't looking for Him
        - That's the praise we should bring to our prayer and worship life
            - Don't forget that we aren't the wise, the privileged, the holy of this world
            - Yet the Father saw fit to bring the gospel to our hearts and allow us to serve Him

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- If the thought of that doesn't sink into your heart and cause you to well up with emotion, and gratitude and wonder and awe, then I'm not sure you really understand it

- The God of the universe reaching out to a creation that has turned its back on Him,
  - And While He leaves many in their pride and defiance,
  - He softened our hearts and granted us the repentance that leads to eternal life

Luke 10:25 ¶ And a lawyer stood up and put Him to the test, saying, "Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"
Luke 10:26 And He said to him, "What is written in the Law? How does it read to you?"
Luke 10:27 And he answered, "YOU SHALL LOVE THE LORD YOUR GOD WITH ALL YOUR HEART, AND WITH ALL YOUR SOUL, AND WITH ALL YOUR STRENGTH, AND WITH ALL YOUR MIND; AND YOUR NEIGHBOR AS YOURSELF."
Luke 10:28 And He said to him, "You have answered correctly; DO THIS AND YOU WILL LIVE."
Luke 10:29 But wishing to justify himself, he said to Jesus, "And who is my neighbor?"
Luke 10:30 Jesus replied and said, "A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among robbers, and they stripped him and beat him, and went away leaving him half dead.
Luke 10:31 "And by chance a priest was going down on that road, and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side.
Luke 10:32 "Likewise a Levite also, when he came to the place and saw him, passed by on the other side.
Luke 10:33 "But a Samaritan, who was on a journey, came upon him; and when he saw him, he felt compassion,
Luke 10:34 and came to him and bandaged up his wounds, pouring oil and wine on *them*; and he put him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn and took care of him.
Luke 10:35 "On the next day he took out two denarii and gave them to the innkeeper and said, 'Take care of him; and whatever more you spend, when I return I will repay you.'
Luke 10:36 "Which of these three do you think proved to be a neighbor to the man who fell into the robbers' *hands*?"
Luke 10:37 And he said, "The one who showed mercy toward him." Then Jesus said to him, "Go and do the same."

- Immediately after Jesus' statement to the disciples, we get an illustration of what He was teaching

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- A lawyer, apparently part of the crowd following Jesus, stands up to confront Jesus
    - Luke tells us that the lawyer's sole purpose in addressing Jesus was to put Him to the test
    - In other words, the lawyer isn't coming to Jesus with honest intentions or a true desire to be taught by God
    - Rather, the lawyer thinks he already knows everything, and his question is designed to trap Jesus into making a false statement

- Lawyers (nomikos) were men who were learned in the law
    - When we're talking about the laws here, we mean the Law of Moses
    - Remember, the Jewish nation was ruled by a government within a government
        - You had the Roman rulers with their laws
        - But if you were Jew, you also had the added burden of the laws of Moses, which were enforced by a separate bureaucracy of lawyers and Pharisees
        - These lawyers were men who had studied the Law of Moses and could answer any question of how to apply the law, no matter how obscure or remote

- So this lawyer would easily be considered one of the wise of Jesus day
    - He's a living example of exactly the kind of person Jesus said that the Father was not inclined to reveal Himself to
        - And His attempt to tear down Jesus is further evidence of the man's hard, unbelieving heart
            - We might ask why God is unwilling to reveal Himself to a man like this
                - After all, isn't his zealousness a sign of his desire to know God, to be godly himself?
                - Should this kind of zealous pursuit of righteousness be exactly the kind of thing God should want to reward?

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- Apostle Paul discusses this very question in one of his letters, the letter to the Romans

om. 10:1 ¶ Brethren, my heart's desire and my prayer to God for them is for *their* salvation.
Rom. 10:2 For I testify about them that they have a zeal for God, but not in accordance with knowledge.
Rom. 10:3 For not knowing about God's righteousness and seeking to establish their own, they did not subject themselves to the righteousness of God.
Rom. 10:4 For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.

- Paul sympathizes with us when we wonder why a man like this would not receive God's grace
    - Paul says that he too desires that the zealous Jews, men like this lawyer, would be saved
        - But Paul goes on to say that these men do in fact have a religious zeal about them
            - But their zeal is not in accordance with knowledge
            - With truth, in other words
            - They are zealous for the wrong thing
        - Not understanding God's righteousness – true righteousness, in other words
            - They seek to establish their own righteousness,
            - To work their own salvation by a system of rules that they have established and enforced
            - And having created their own system, a system that served their selfish interests, they did not subject themselves to the righteousness of God
            - They weren't interested in Jesus' way of righteousness, the true way
        - And then in verse 4, we hear the real reason for their discontent
            - For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness

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- The righteousness that Christ brings, by faith, means the end of the law for all who believe

- A lawyer who has invested all his time and effort in justifying himself through a knowledge of the law isn't much interested in a means of righteousness that spells the end of the law

- And God is not satisfied to bring glory to those who think they have earned I tin their own power, for as scripture tells us

Is. 2:9 So the *common* man has been humbled
And the man *of importance* has been abased,
But do not forgive them.
Is. 2:10 Enter the rock and hide in the dust
From the terror of the LORD and from the splendor of His majesty.
Is. 2:11 The proud look of man will be abased
And the loftiness of man will be humbled,
And the LORD alone will be exalted in that day.
Is. 2:12 ¶ For the LORD of hosts will have a day *of reckoning*
Against everyone who is proud and lofty
And against everyone who is lifted up,
That he may be abased.

- Next week we will examine the lawyer's question and Jesus' answer

    - This exchange sets the tone for the next couple of important chapters, as Jesus confronts the nation of Israel and confirms their rejection of His ministry

    - For the battle Jesus waged for the hearts of men is the same one we wage in his place today

        - We confront men like this lawyer, men who have ideas for how to please God

        - Each have devised a way to establish their own righteousness

        - And by doing so, they have become proud in their own hearts

        - And they will be brought low should they not understand the truth before the opportunity fades

- Remember that we were not rich and mighty

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- We were not wise and honorable
- We were certainly not holy and righteous
- We still aren't, though God has determined by His grace to credit us with that righteousness –
- Glory be to God!

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Luke 10C

- Last week we stopped in the midst of a well known exchange between Jesus and the lawyer who stood up to test Him
    - We introduced this passage last week by mentioning that this lawyer is a good example of the kind of Jew that Paul talked
    - He described in Romans the zealous Jews who rejected Jesus though they embraced the smallest detail within the Law given to Moses
    - And this exchange gives us an excellent opportunity to see how that group could understand the details of the law but yet miss the main point
        - We have term for this kind of blindness…we call it not seeing the forest for the trees
- Let's re-read those verses from last week…

Luke 10:25 ¶ And a lawyer stood up and put Him to the test, saying, "Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"
Luke 10:26 And He said to him, "What is written in the Law? How does it read to you?"
Luke 10:27 And he answered, "YOU SHALL LOVE THE LORD YOUR GOD WITH ALL YOUR HEART, AND WITH ALL YOUR SOUL, AND WITH ALL YOUR STRENGTH, AND WITH ALL YOUR MIND; AND YOUR NEIGHBOR AS YOURSELF."
Luke 10:28 And He said to him, "You have answered correctly; DO THIS AND YOU WILL LIVE."
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Luke 10:31 "And by chance a priest was going down on that road, and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side.
Luke 10:32 "Likewise a Levite also, when he came to the place and saw him, passed by on the other side.
Luke 10:33 "But a Samaritan, who was on a journey, came upon him; and when he saw him, he felt compassion,
Luke 10:34 and came to him and bandaged up his wounds, pouring oil and wine on *them*; and he put him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn and took care of him.
Luke 10:35 "On the next day he took out two denarii and gave them to the innkeeper and said, 'Take care of him; and whatever more you spend, when I return I will repay you.'

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Luke 10:36 "Which of these three do you think proved to be a neighbor to the man who fell into the robbers' *hands*?"
Luke 10:37 And he said, "The one who showed mercy toward him." Then Jesus said to him, "Go and do the same."

- As we said last week, this lawyer has stood up expressly for the purpose of tearing Jesus down
    - The question seemed legitimate enough – why was it a test of Jesus?
    - Actually, the question was a favorite question of the religious leaders of Jesus day
- The religious leaders in Jesus day spent countless hours debating and discussing ideas taken out of the law
    - One of the favorites was the question of how to obtain eternal life
    - For all their knowledge of the law and for all the scripture that had been given to Israel through the prophets, they had not found universal agreement for how to obtain salvation
        - That fact alone is a telling indicator of how these men could be experts in God's Word yet not understand it's true meaning – forest for the trees…
- These false leaders were fascinated with questions like how to obtain salvation or similar questions like the one asked by another lawyer in Mark 12 asking Jesus where he wanted to know which commandment was the greatest…
    - This kind of never-ending picking apart of the law was actually a natural consequence of how these religious leaders had distorted the law for their own purposes
    - Remember, these leaders had turned the entire Law of Moses into a yoke, a burden to be borne by men in an effort to obtain righteousness by their own work
    - And more than that, the leaders had added their own subtleties to the law with their complex interpretations and added rules for applying the law in everyday situations
        - Like when the disciples were picking heads of grain

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        - Sooner or later these religious zealots would encounter a situations where one law would seem to be in opposition to another

        - We sometimes face this question ourselves

            - Like the requirement to honor your parents and to not bear false witness (not to lie)

            - What if you father asks you to lie to your Aunt and Uncle when they ask if you like your birthday gift

    - The Jewish leadership had created for themselves countless such conflicts, and they spent their lives debating how to resolve them

        - Like we said last week, they loved the law because it served their own selfish purposes to manipulate and control their work toward righteousness

        - It let them be their own source of salvation, or at least they thought it did

- So to this lawyer's question, Jesus deflects the controversy by responding with His own question

    - Jesus asks the lawyer what answer he would see in the law…what does scripture teach him

        - The lawyer answers from Deut 6:5, taken from God's introduction to the restating the law to the nation of Israel

        - And from Lev 19:16, which is a summary of the requirements in the law regarding how people are to treat one another

    - This lawyer, whether by chance or perhaps spiritual insight given by the Holy Spirit, happens to give the correct response to his own question

        - So all that's remaining for Jesus to say is to command the lawyer to do as he teaches

- Before looking at the lawyer's reaction, let's ask the obvious question

    - Is Jesus telling us to work our way to heaven?

    - For example, could someone deny Jesus and yet do these things two commandments and therefore be saved?

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- The answer is no, and the easiest way to prove that is to simple recognize that these commandments are impossible to keep perfectly
  - No one who has ever lived – apart from Jesus Himself – has ever succeeded in keeping these two commandments without error
  - And so if these are the requirements for salvation, then no one can be saved
  - But since men are being saved, there must be more to the answer

- Well, let's look at those commandments again …
  - For example, in the first one we're told to love your God with all your heart…
  - Jesus states that to obtain eternal salvation, God requires that we love Him with our entire heart
    - And loving God with our whole heart requires that we also love His Son
    - Listen to what Jesus tells these leaders in John

John 5:37 "And the Father who sent Me, He has testified of Me. You have neither heard His voice at any time nor seen His form.
John 5:38 "You do not have His word abiding in you, for you do not believe Him whom He sent.
John 5:39 "You search the Scriptures because you think that in them you have eternal life; it is these that testify about Me;
John 5:40 and you are unwilling to come to Me so that you may have life.
John 5:41 "I do not receive glory from men;
John 5:42 but I know you, that you do not have the love of God in yourselves.

- Jesus sums up the state of the heart of these religious leaders
  - They have no love of God in them, which has been exposed by their hatred for Jesus
  - If someone loves God with their whole heart, then their love of God will bring them to a love of His Son as well
  - And their love of Jesus will therefore be their source of salvation

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John 14:23 Jesus answered and said to him, "If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word; and My Father will love him, and We will come to him and make Our abode with him.
John 14:24 "He who does not love Me does not keep My words; and the word which you hear is not Mine, but the Father's who sent Me.

- Furthermore, someone who loves God and His Son is to abide in the words Jesus spoke
    - So those who truly have a love for God hear the Word of Christ and abide in it - in other words believe it
- Then look a little further in verse 27
    - The commandment says to love God with all your mind
    - Mark's version translates mind (dianoia) as understanding
        - So obtaining eternal life rests not merely on some emotional response to an abstract idea of God
        - It's not the result of some religious trance
        - It depends upon loving God with our minds, through a clear understanding of God's word - including all He has to say about the source and person of our salvation – namely Jesus
- And the lawyers and Pharisees failed this test as well

John 8:42 Jesus said to them, "If God were your Father, you would love Me, for I proceeded forth and have come from God, for I have not even come on My own initiative, but He sent Me.
John 8:43 "Why do you not understand what I am saying? *It is* because you cannot hear My word.
John 8:44 "You are of *your* father the devil, and you want to do the desires of your father. He was a murderer from the beginning, and does not stand in the truth because there is no truth in him. Whenever he speaks a lie, he speaks from his own *nature*, for he is a liar and the father of lies.
John 8:45 "But because I speak the truth, you do not believe Me.
John 8:46 "Which one of you convicts Me of sin? If I speak truth, why do you not believe Me?
John 8:47 "He who is of God hears the words of God; for this reason you do not hear *them*, because you are not of God."

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- These men could not inherit eternal life because they would not love God with all their mind –
    - Instead they were seeking to do the desires of their father the devil
    - And only the lies of their father the devil appealed to them
    - The truth spoken by God through Jesus was ignored
- Likewise, we are of God – if we have heard the words of God, and heeded them

Rom. 10:17 So faith *comes* from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.

- So to receive eternal life, we must love God with all our mind, which requires we hear His Word and believe it

- Then came the second commandment
    - But it's merely a natural extension of the first
    - Having been changed by our faith to love God, we then have the capacity to truly love others

John 13:35 "By this all men will know that you are My disciples, if you have love for one another."

- So in His answer to the lawyer, Jesus didn't present salvation as a work
    - To the contrary…His statements reflected the impossibility of achieving salvation by our own efforts
    - And yet Jesus was, in fact, teaching how eternal life can be received – but it was according to faith
        - That a believer's heart must first be changed by God, to be given over fully Him
        - Believers are nothing more than sinners saved by God's grace
            - They are transformed by the power of the Holy Spirit into men and women who
                - have such a love for God,
                - such a desire to know Him through His word
                - and to obey Him,

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- That they gladly receive His Son and then show His love in their lives

- But the lawyer couldn't get see this

- In verse 29, Luke says the lawyer still wished to justify himself – to make himself look righteous

  - What's truly fascinating here is how this lawyer realized that Jesus beat him at his own game

  - When Jesus asked the lawyer what the Law taught him and then the lawyer gave his answer, he didn't realize that his answer was going to be his on undoing

  - Because the answer he gave Jesus actually brought into question the lawyer's own righteousness before the crowd

    - Everyone who heard the lawyer's answer knew that no one could ever hope to keep such demanding commandments

    - The lawyer was seeking to box in Jesus by giving the standard answer and expecting Jesus to argue with him over the definition of words and the meaning of the text

    - Instead, Jesus just says you're right, now go try and do it

    - And now the lawyer stands there looking foolish because the crowd wants to know how he expects to accomplish this

- So what does a lawyer do when he's boxed himself into a corner?

  - Naturally, he tried to change the terms of the discussion

  - He equivocates

  - He looks for loopholes that might allow him to escape from the corner he's in

  - Rather than admitting he is helpless and without an answer and requires God's grace if he has any hope of being rescued from certain judgment

- No, he simply responds by trying once again to trap Jesus

  - He asks who is my neighbor

    - How can I possibly know who my neighbor is?

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- Is it just the person who lives next to me, the person who works next to me?
- What about the person two house down the street? Or maybe on the next street?
- Or is it only those in my town or my tribe of Israel?
- How can we expect to be held to these rules, Jesus, when they're so ambiguous

- It's the kind of question unbelievers have loved to ask God and his followers since the beginning of time

Gen. 3:1 , "Indeed, has God said, 'You shall not eat from any tree of the garden'?"

- My personal favorite: can God create a rock so big He can't lift it?
  - The purpose behind these questions is not genuine curiosity or sincere desire to understand God and His nature or His purposes
  - They are tests intended to puff us up and diminish faith in God at the same time

- But God's foolishness is infinitely wiser than man's wisdom, so Jesus deftly addresses the lawyer's question
  - He tells the story of the Samaritan
  - You'll remember what we taught about Samaritans just a few weeks ago
    - These were the much despised inhabitants of Samria who thought themselves to be Jews, yet were seen as traitors and imposters by the true Jews
    - In other words, they were the farthest thing from a neighbor – they were scum
  - In the parable, a victim of a robbery on the road from Jerusalem to Jericho, a road famous for it's treacherous passages and frequent robberies
    - This poor man beaten close to death is left for dead by a priest

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- In the fact the priest goes out of his way to avoid even coming near the man – probably out of fear of becoming unclean from the bleeding man
- Of all men, the priest should have been one to show compassion as a servant of God

- Next comes a Levite
  - A Levite would have been someone of the priestly tribe who was not actively engaged in temple service, and therefore would not have been given the title of priest
  - Yet as a Levite, he would be seen as the consummate Jew, a man who epitomized the upright and proper Jew
  - Yet he did the man no better in ignoring him

- Finally, a Samaritan stops to help the robbery victim we're told
  - Now what hasn't been given us is the identity of the victim here
    - It isn't terribly important to the story, except that it was likely that the crowd listening to Jesus' parable would have assumed any man traveling from Jerusalem was probably a Jew
    - And that's significant because it means that a Jew in need was overlooked y two men of high standing in Jewish culture
    - And yet he was aided by the enemy of a Jew, a Samaritan
      - This is similar to what Jesus taught in Matt 5

Matt. 5:43 ¶ "You have heard that it was said, 'YOU SHALL LOVE YOUR NEIGHBOR and hate your enemy.'
Matt. 5:44 "But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,
Matt. 5:46 "For if you love those who love you, what reward do you have? Do not even the tax collectors do the same?
Matt. 5:47 "If you greet only your brothers, what more are you doing *than others*? Do not even the Gentiles do the same?
Matt. 5:48 "Therefore you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.

- So in describing the great lengths this Samaritan when to in helping this Jew, Jesus obliterates any concept of a limit to who our neighbor might be

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- The lawyer was busy trying to draw boundaries to limit his need to be loving to his neighbor

- And in one moment, Jesus erases every possible line and teaches that a neighbor is the person we consider the least, which naturally means that everyone must be considered our neighbor

- If the person we hate, the person who is our enemy must be considered a neighbor, then how much more so the person living next door or the stranger at the grocery store or in the car next to us in traffic?

- Jesus again boxes in the lawyer, leaving him with no where to go

  - If you desire to work your own salvation, then be prepared to love your God perfectly and to love humanity perfectly

    - And if you can't manage those two things, then may I suggest we do as Jesus is commanding here and rely on God's love available to us by His mercy and Grace through a faith in His Son

- And then to end this chapter, look at the final 5 verses

Luke 10:38 ¶ Now as they were traveling along, He entered a village; and a woman named Martha welcomed Him into her home.
Luke 10:39 She had a sister called Mary, who was seated at the Lord's feet, listening to His word.
Luke 10:40 But Martha was distracted with all her preparations; and she came up *to Him* and said, "Lord, do You not care that my sister has left me to do all the serving alone? Then tell her to help me."
Luke 10:41 But the Lord answered and said to her, "Martha, Martha, you are worried and bothered about so many things;
Luke 10:42 but *only* one thing is necessary, for Mary has chosen the good part, which shall not be taken away from her."

- While there is probably much we could say about this exchange, it's actually quite easy to fit into the larger context of this morning,

  - While this chapter begins with a look at the two chief commandment, loving God and loving your neighbor

  - It ends with two simple examples of each

    - First, in the parable of the Samaritan, Jesus illustrates what loving your neighbor means

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        - And here, Luke gives us a simple example of what loving your God before all else looks like

- Martha welcomes Jesus into her home, and her sister Mary is so captivated by Jesus
    - By his words, His power, his love for her
    - That she neglects to assist her sister in her normal duties of prearing a meal for the visitor
    - And Martha makes a biting comment to Jesus, correcting Him for distracting Mary away from her duties and not expecting her to help Martha
    - And Jesus gently responds, Martha, Martha
        - You are so worried about so many things
        - His comments leaves a sense that Martha must have been someone who was always worried,
            - Always troubled by the cares of her day
            - Always busy, always with demands on her time
            - Never enough time to attend to that which truly matter in her relationship with God
- You can almost see Jesus shaking his head as He spoke these words to her
    - What a shame Martha
    - If you only understood that you have the wrong priorities
        - Martha, Jesus says, only one thing is necessary
        - There is only one thing you need to worry about
        - There is only one thing that deserves this much energy and concern
        - It is the good part, the part Mary has chosen
        - To sit at Jesus feet and listen to His word
    - Can it really be that simple?

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- Is loving your God with all your heart, and mind and soul and spirit really as easy as just putting everything else aside in your life
- And making hearing the word of Christ the primary, the only thing to seek and to be concerned about?
- And the answer is yes

- This good part will never be taken away, while all the other things in our life that we cling to and elevate in our own minds
  - The activities, the routines, the hobbies, the entertainment, the various stresses and demands placed upon us by others and their expectations for us – none of that is eternal
    - But Jesus and His Word are eternal, and they bring contentment, they bring satisfaction, they bring real healing and growth and they bring eternal life
    - It really is just that simple

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Luke 11A

- As we move into Chapter 11, we appear to step aside from the larger arc of the gospel story and explore a side moment between Jesus and His disciples
    - It's a brief exchange recorded in only two of the Gospels, here and in Matthew
    - But it's a fundamentally important teaching on one of a Christian's primary disciplines – prayer
    - But as I said, it only seems to be off the topic, when in reality it is a continuation of what transpired at the conclusion of Chapter 10.
        - In Chap 10 Jesus taught the disciples how they were to relate to their neighbors in the parable about the good Samritan
        - Then at the end of Chapt 10, He taught them how to relate to Himself as the one who embodies the Word of God
        - Now in Chap 11, Jesus teaches the disciples how to relate to the Father through prayer
- Let's read the open verses in this chapter

Luke 11:1 ¶ It happened that while Jesus was praying in a certain place, after He had finished, one of His disciples said to Him, "Lord, teach us to pray just as John also taught his disciples."
Luke 11:2 And He said to them, "When you pray, say:
'Father, hallowed be Your name.
Your kingdom come.
Luke 11:3 'Give us each day our daily bread.
Luke 11:4 'And forgive us our sins,
For we ourselves also forgive everyone who is indebted to us.
And lead us not into temptation.'"

- Here we find Jesus asked by His disciples how to pray, and Jesus responds with the Lord's prayer, as we now call it
    - If you memorized the Lord's prayer at some point in your life, then I'm guessing this is not the version to memorized

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- The more familiar, more lengthy version in found at the beginning of Matt 6, and this is the version people typically memorize or recite

- These verses, especially the ones in Matt's account are well know by some many
  - Millions of people have memorized and recited the Our Father as the right way to pray to God
    - So as we come to these verses, we should take a moment to examine what Jesus was teaching the disciples and us as well
    - And what He expected us to do with this teaching

- As the disciples make this request of Jesus, they are really no different than any other student who would come to their teacher expecting instruction in an important disciple of their trade
  - These men understand from the upbringing and now from watching Jesus in His own prayer time that prayer was a critically important part of their relationship with the Father
  - It is the means by which God opens up a dialog with men
  - It's not just a one way conversation with us speaking to God, or even worse, just a conversation with ourselves in our own head
  - No, it's a time when we speak to God and when we submit ourselves to Him in that time, we can hear Him speak to us as well
  - It is a matter of effort and expectation
  - It comes down to our approach and our attitude
    - And those will be our outline or theme for today
    - Within our prayer life, what is our effort and our expectation
    - What is our approach and attitude in praying
    - And Jesus gives us the direction we seek here in these verses

- In verse 1 we see that the discussion ensues because the disciples see Jesus praying
  - Jesus clearly made prayer a constant companion to His ministry

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- He seems to look for every opportunity, day or night, to converse with the Father
- And at some point, the disciples ask for direction on how to do the same

- In verse 2 Jesus answers them by saying when you pray…
  - How easy it would be to pass by these simple introductory phrase, but we shouldn't ignore it
  - He says when you pray
    - not if you decide to pray,
    - not should you decide to pray
    - not if you find time to pray
    - But WHEN you pray
  - Jesus is already presuming that we know that prayer is an important part of our spiritual development
    - So our first point is to be mindful of our **EFFORT** in prayer
    - As believers, followers of Christ, we need to look for opportunities to engage in a healthy, active prayer life
    - In a Christian household, many of us if we were fortunate to grow up in a Christian home, probably assumed that prayer happens at three times and places
      - Before meals
      - Before bed
      - And in church
      - Some might add before a pop quiz
    - And those are fine times to pray
      - But in truth, they are merely convenient reminders of the need to pray
        - They are not the reason to pray

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- Do you see the difference?

- If we're not careful, we tend to associate the occasion for prayer with the purpose for prayer
  - In other words, I pray because I'm thankful for this meal
  - I pray because I'm in church
    - But that's like saying a husband only takes time to have a conversation with my wife because he needs information from her
    - I only speak with my friends when I need something
  - Now I can often slip into those selfish patterns, but I know they're wrong
    - And the same is true with God
    - If I only pray when an urgent need gives me the desire to communicate, I'm treating God no better

- So Jesus says <u>when</u> you pray because prayer should be an ever-present, on-going part of our daily lives
  - We should pray as Paul directs:

Phil. 4:6 Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God.

- We pray because God's word calls us to pray
- We don't see prayer as something that happens only when certain circumstances dictate it, because ALL circumstances warrant prayer
  - We pray because we will always have needs
  - We pray because the Father has revealed Himself to us and we want to know Him fully
  - We pray to know His will for our lives

- Jesus' instructions then take the form of a specific prayer
  - But as we examine the specifics, let's take note of the form, the model that Jesus presents

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- He starts with Father, hallowed be your name
  - So the first thing to note is that we pray to the Father
    - Within the trinity, scripture is always consistent in demonstrating that the audience for our prayers is always the Father
    - The Spirit gives us the words we pray (Rom 8:26)
    - Jesus by His sacrifice gives us the very opportunity to approach boldly with our petitions (Heb 4:16)
    - But it is the Father we approach, it is the Father who hears our petitions
  - And note that the word here for Father – pater – is the same as Abba in Aramaic
    - It is an endearing term for God – seeing Him as we see a loving earthly father, someone who desires to care for his children and enjoys hearing our needs and desires to respond
    - This was very different from what the disciples would have been taught before
    - God was never seen in such an intimate way under Jewish teaching
    - God was feared, God was fierce, God was mighty, God was unapproachably Holy
      - And He remains all these things today and evermore
      - But He is also a loving Father to His children
- Then we're told the declare his name to be hallowed
  - We don't use the word hallowed as much today
  - The word in Greek is hagiazo – which means holy, consecrated
  - But the phrase hallowed is your name is simply a expression of praise for the Father, and for His holiness, and His matchless name

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- It could be translated may everyone regard your name as holy as they should
    - God's name is important in scripture and in eastern cultures, because a name was seen to be the summation of a person's attributes, effectively your reputation among people
    - And when we pray, we should pray to see God's holy name revered as it should be for His glory
- But it also implies a fulfillment one day
    - It occurs in the aorist tense, meaning a future specific occurrence when His name will be understood fully
    - In other words, it is a declaration of God future plan to be seen universally in his creation for Who he is

- Interestingly, then Jesus says Your kingdom come
    - This is a petition, a request again, and again in the aorist tense in the Greek
    - It's a petition looking forward to the approach of God's kingdom on Earth
        - Anytime you see a reference in scripture to God's future kingdom, there is only one kingdom in mind - Messianic
        - If this kingdom were already in place in any form, then this statement wouldn't make sense
        - Because it points to a specific moment in the future when God's kingdom will come
        - So Jesus tells us to include petition for God's kingdom to arrive

- Before we move on to the rest of the prayer, as yourself this question
    - Why should be pray for these things?
    - Aren't they destined to happen anyway?
        - Isn't God determined to have His name revered throughout His creation?

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- Paul says in Philippians

Phil. 2:10 so that at the name of Jesus EVERY KNEE WILL BOW, of those who are in heaven and on earth and under the earth,

- And isn't His kingdom destined to arrive on the day He has determined? The entire scripture teaches that God's kingdom on earth will arrive one day
  - Ezekiel describes it in detail, Rev 20:6 announces it

- So why pray for these things? Will they somehow fail to happen if we don't pray?
  - In other words, we've come to our second point concerning prayer – our expectation when we pray
  - These requests are things that God has will happen
    - And yet Jesus says to include these petitions in your prayers
    - And in that dilemma we learn something critically important about prayer
      - Our prayers aren't about persuading God to do something
      - For His mind is not subject to being changed

1Sam. 15:29 "Also the Glory of Israel will not lie or change His mind; for He is not a man that He should change His mind."

- What He determines to do, He will do
  - And what He determines not to do, He won't do
  - It will be His will that is done, not ours

  - Which is why Matt's account includes that important addition
    - After your kingdom come, Matt's version adds Your will be done
    - We are praying to align our will with the Father's and not the other way around
    - Yes, we bring our petitions to Him even before we know His will, but in the course of our prayer life, we should pray for His will and His plan for the creation and then allow the Spirit to conform our will to His

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- Then as we mature in our spiritual walk, we are going to find increasingly that our will is His will, and we will be praying for His plan and not our own

- So Jesus begins by saying pray for God's name to be revered, pray for His kingdom to come, then Jesus lists specific earthly needs
    - Pray for your daily bread
        - This is a simple expression of daily provision
        - The phrase in Greek suggests day by day, enough for each day and no more

Prov. 30:8 Keep deception and lies far from me,
Give me neither poverty nor riches;
Feed me with the food that is my portion,
Prov. 30:9 That I not be full and deny *You* and say, "Who is the LORD?"
Or that I not be in want and steal,
And profane the name of my God.

    - Then pray for forgiveness of sins
        - Jesus even includes a reminder that we are to forgive others as we have been forgiven
    - Interestingly, are these things in less in doubt than the former?
        - Is God not going to give us our basic provisions in some form?

Matt. 6:31 "Do not worry then, saying, 'What will we eat?' or 'What will we drink?' or 'What will we wear for clothing?'
Matt. 6:32 "For the Gentiles eagerly seek all these things; for your heavenly Father knows that you need all these things.
Matt. 6:33 "But seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.

    - And what about forgiveness of sins?
        - Have we not already been forgiven by our faith?

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Heb. 7:26 ¶ For it was fitting for us to have such a high priest, holy, innocent, undefiled, separated from sinners and exalted above the heavens;
Heb. 7:27 who does not need daily, like those high priests, to offer up sacrifices, first for His own sins and then for the *sins* of the people, because this He did once for all when He offered up Himself.

Heb. 10:10 By this will we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.

- The Father has already determined our needs

Matt. 6:8 "So do not be like them; for your Father knows what you need before you ask Him.

- And we have already been forgiven, yet we are to ask for forgiveness

- And yet we are told by Jesus to pray in this way nonetheless

- So again we are praying for our benefit, not God's benefit

- Prayer isn't for God's benefit, but ours

- We learn things through prayer, we understand new things through prayer

- And this leads us to the third point for this morning – our approach in prayer

- Do you approach prayer with the expectation that unless you get what you want from the experience, it was a failure

- God didn't answer my prayer

- Some joke that God always answers prayers, but sometimes the answer is no

- That's trivializing God and prayer

- God always answers prayers and the answers are deep and complex and life-long

- They are never yes nor no

- "Heal my daughter" becomes a life of learning about God…

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- Prayer causes us to reconsider our desires and whether they are a part of God's will
    - Rather than want riches and fame, we pray for His fame and our daily needs
    - Rather than pray for revenge on our enemies, we remember our own sins and that now we are called to forgive others
    - Rather than seek our plan on earth, we seek His kingdom come
- And as we come to know God and see His will manifest in our lives, He receives glory through our prayers

- Finally, Luke records Jesus ending the prayer with the request that God lead us not into temptation
    - This is a Greek figure of speech, which is why it reads in this strange reverse way
        - It really means simply God help us remain faithful to You in the face of temptation
            - It's not that God would ever lead us into temptation – that phrasing is just a consequence of the reverse form of the Greek syntax
    - So our prayer example ends with a petition for God to strength us against ourselves
        - To strengthen us to endure and pass the test presented in temptations
        - This should be the constant cry of our heart in prayer, for we all have our temptations, those things we are especially prone to fall by
        - And we depend on His strength to withstand those temptations
            - 2Pet 2:9 teaches that our God knows how to rescue the godly from temptation

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- And we pray to recognize that God is doing just that in our lives, though we so often refuse to avail ourselves of that protection

- Preferring instead to proceed headlong into the teeth of the lion and suffer the consequences of our disobedience

- So what are we to do with this model? Or the disciples for that matter
    - In other words, our third point is to understand our **approach** to prayer?
    - For example, is this the prayer we are to recite anytime we speak to the Father?
        - Did Jesus expect His disciples to put aside other prayer and to adopt these words (or the words captured in Matt's account) and make them a memorized, recited prayer?
        - As you know, many faith traditions – both Catholic and Protestant - have done just that
        - I grew up in a family that attended Catholic church
            - Personally, I don't remember much of what I heard in the many years of sitting in Catholic pews, but I remember the recited parts of the service
            - They were engrained in my memory – the doxology, the Apostle's creed, the Catechism, the Our Father, the Hail Mary, etc..
            - Later as an adult, I attended Protestant churches of various denominations, and found many of them said many of the same things
                - They had their own version of the Our Father, but it was still a memorized, recited prayer

- So was that Jesus' point to the disciples – learn these specific words, memorize them, and repeat them over and over again every time you wish to dialog with the Father?
    - Before we look at an answer in scripture, let's just consider this logically for a moment
        - What was the purpose in the disciple's question to Jesus?

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- Teach us to pray
- Not teach us a prayer, but teach us to pray
- As His students, they desired to learn something they felt was crucial to their chosen walk in life

- What if Jesus had been a master carpenter, and these were his apprentices in the trade of carpentry
  - And they came to Him and asked Him how to frame a house
  - Wouldn't we expect Jesus to teach them the essentials of the task and use an example to illustrate the principles?
    - Wouldn't he discuss how to read blueprints, making measurements, swinging a hammer, building the structure properly, etc.
    - And then He would proceed to frame a house so they could see it all put together
    - But did He expect them to go off and build exactly the same house every time the set about framing?
  - Or as chef, if He was teaching baking, He would explain how to prepare ingredients, how to combine them in the right order, how to cook them properly
    - And He would probably demonstrate by making a cake
    - But He wouldn't expect them to go out baking the same cake over and over

- In both these cases, it's obvious that the teacher's point is to teach through a model, but not to expect the students to memorize the specific example
  - This would especially true in the case of prayer, because consider it's purpose
    - It's a dialog with the Father
    - It's an opportunity to learn from Him and ask Him to respond to our needs
    - If we always bring exactly the same words to that experience, what are going to learn? What kind of dialog would that be?

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- If I responded to my wife with exactly the same words every time we engaged in conversation, how would she interpret my response?

- So logic dictates that this teaching was not intended for us to memorize and mindlessly recite these same words over and over again
    - And then there's scripture
    - When Matt teaches the Our Father, he records Jesus introducing the teaching with these words:

Matt. 6:7 ¶ "And when you are praying, do not use meaningless repetition as the Gentiles do, for they suppose that they will be heard for their many words.
Matt. 6:8 "So do not be like them; for your Father knows what you need before you ask Him.

- Isn't it ironic that the two verse immediately before the Our Father prayer in Matt's gospel tell us in no uncertain terms NOT to pray in repetitious ways
- And what has the church done in so many places? We've turned the prayer that follows into just so many words, to use Jesus' term
- It's a mantra, a chant
- And when prayer becomes chant, it changes from dialog into monologue
- From a faithful petition before God to a superstitious work of our flesh

- And that brings us to our final closing point – our **attitude** in prayer
    - How do we approach the Father in prayer?
    - Do we see prayer as an attempt to justify ourselves through our good works rather than a sincere effort to know God's will and be confirmed to it?
        - Are we repeating meaningless words hoping to get God's or man's attention?
        - Even group prayer, our flesh can find opportunity to seek glory for itself rather than talk to God
        - Perhaps this is why Jesus gives us this instruction in Matthew

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Matt. 6:5 ¶ "When you pray, you are not to be like the hypocrites; for they love to stand and pray in the synagogues and on the street corners so that they may be seen by men. Truly I say to you, they have their reward in full.
Matt. 6:6 "But you, when you pray, go into your inner room, close your door and pray to your Father who is in secret, and your Father who sees *what is done* in secret will reward you.

- To be fair, many Christians recite memorized prayer or seek to draw attention to themselves in public prayer simply out of poor teaching or a misunderstanding of the purpose of prayer
    - I was once one of those misguided people praying Our Fathers and Hail Marys hoping that the more I did it, the more I might achieve spiritually
        - But scripture leaves no misunderstanding – Jesus is teaching us to seek the Father, to seek His will, to seek His goodness, and do so with an open heart to receive His word
        - To engage in a dialog to strengthen our relationship with Him
        - To seek him in a humble heart and with a focus obtaining an audience with God's and not an audience among men
    - And when He works His will, we can give Him glory for answering our prayers that were prayed in His will
- Now if this week you feel somewhat less motivated to conduct prayer, than don't be surprised
    - It's a natural first reaction – wrong, but natural
    - Jesus knew that, and next week he addresses those concerns in Luke

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Luke 11B

- Chapter 11 began last week with those well known verses on prayer, the Lord's Prayer
    - We spent all our time last week on those verses, because the Lord's prayer is so familiar and because it's important we understand what Jesus was teaching about the nature of prayer
    - But I suspect our lesson may have had the undesirable consequence of leaving you wondering why to pray or even whether to pray
        - And I say this because so often our motivation to engage in prayer to the Father comes from a misplaced desire
        - Said another way, the more we have need of something from God, the more likely we are to give ourselves over to prayer in hope God will give us what we desire
- So last week, as we broke down the model that Jesus gave the disciples for how to pray, we found ourselves confronted with a dilemma
    - Jesus instructed His disciples to pray that God's will and God's plan be done
        - We shall seek His name to be declared holy, His kingdom to be established, His will to be accomplished – things that are already destined to occur
        - We are told to ask for only our daily needs, yet He has already promised to provide our daily needs
        - And we are to ask for our sins to be forgiven, as we know they already have
            - And we are to pray that we be reminded to forgive others
    - In summary, Jesus' model instructs us to pray for things that are destined to be so and will never change according to God's word
- And here in lies the dilemma:
    - Jesus' model for prayer teaches us to pray with God at the center of our petitions rather than ourselves,

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- Does this model diminish your interest in praying?
- Didn't Jesus realize his teaching might have this effect on our motivation to pray?

- Well, I think it's clear from what Jesus says next that the answer is yes, He understood this was a risk
  - In fact, He anticipated it among his disciples
  - Which is why He moves from presenting the model of prayer in verse 1-4 verses to reinforcing our motivation for prayer in the next series of verses

Luke 11:5 ¶ Then He said to them, "Suppose one of you has a friend, and goes to him at midnight and says to him, 'Friend, lend me three loaves;
Luke 11:6 for a friend of mine has come to me from a journey, and I have nothing to set before him';
Luke 11:7 and from inside he answers and says, 'Do not bother me; the door has already been shut and my children and I are in bed; I cannot get up and give you *anything*.'
Luke 11:8 "I tell you, even though he will not get up and give him *anything* because he is his friend, yet because of his persistence he will get up and give him as much as he needs.
Luke 11:9 ¶ "So I say to you, ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.
Luke 11:10 "For everyone who asks, receives; and he who seeks, finds; and to him who knocks, it will be opened.

- This is a remarkable picture Jesus presents of the Father
  - Jesus gives us a window into the character of God and the purpose of prayer even as He offers motivation for why we pray
  - Jesus uses an interesting comparison to everyday Jewish life
    - In the story, there are two men, neighbors
    - And on one night, one of the men receives an unexpected visitor
    - And as it turns out, the man does not have enough bread prepared in his house to offer the surprise visitor a decent meal
  - In that culture and time, there was tremendous honor associated with performing the sacred duty of hosting a guest in your home

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        - But this man has a serious problem because it was considered a great dishonor to fail in caring for a visitor in your home

            - Ex: Remember the extent to which Lot went to care for the angels that visited him in Sodom?

        - So it's natural that the man would rush next door in the middle of the night and wake his neighbor begging for a loaf of bread

            - You couldn't drive down to local HEB

            - Most bread was baked at home

- Now the neighbor isn't the least bit interested in rising at midnight, opening the door, searching for bread and helping his neighbor

    - He's in bed, the children asleep, and he's not about to disturb the entire family for the sake of the neighbor's problem

        - One-room house where everyone, including animals slept together

    - It's interesting to note that the sleeping man is a friend to his desperate neighbor, nevertheless he isn't willing to get up and help him on that basis – friend or no friend, he's not getting up

    - In other words, a simple request between friends isn't always enough to achieve the desired outcome

        - If that desperate neighbor had been willing to take no for an answer the first time and walked away, he would have walked away with nothing

- But the man doesn't give up

    - Jesus says that if this man continues to knock, and bang on the door and yell for the neighbor to help him, he eventually gets what he wants

        - This story works so well in communicating the need to be persistent in prayer because the situation makes so much sense to us

            - There is probably no time of day when we are more willing to give in to persistence than when our sleep is at risk

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- When something is keeping you awake, you'll do practically anything just to restore peace and go back to sleep

- If my kids ever discover this fact, they'll start asking me for their allowance at 2 am in the morning

- Jesus uses this simple, well-understood fact of life – that some things can be achieved only through persistence – and He uses it to build a beautiful picture of how God wishes us to approach our prayer life

- But there are a few points to consider as we attempt to fit this into the teaching from last week

  - First, you'll notice that even thought the neighbor wasn't willing to help his friend merely on the basis of his friendship, yet without that friendship, there would have been no possibility of gaining assistance

  - These men were friends – Jesus says so in verse 5

  - If these men had been total strangers, if they hadn't known one another at all, then it would not have been possible for the man to make any request of his neighbor

    - The man's persistence would have simply resulted his neighbor getting angry and driving the man away

    - It was because they were friends in the first place that it was even possible for one man to impose upon the other

  - It would have taken a close relationship to withstand such a great imposition

    - The strongest friendships are the ones upon which we can make the greatest imposition and expect success

- So the man at the door knows his friend well

  - And he knows that with persistence, he can motivate his friend to action

  - And he also trusts that his friendship is strong enough that his persistence won't anger his friend

  - It will instead result in his friend eventually agreeing to his request

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- Jesus leaves it to us to make the obvious comparison to our relationship with the Father in prayer
    - First, we know that without a relationship with the Father through His Son, Christ, we have no hope of our requests being heard
        - Just like the neighbors who are able to make requests of one another on the basis of their friendship,
        - Likewise we can approach boldly before the throne of God only because we first have a relationship with the Father by our faith in His Son
        - Without that relationship, we have no hope for a response to our prayer

John 9:31 "We know that God does not hear sinners; but if anyone is God-fearing and does His will, He hears him.

    - Remember, simply praying by itself is not a proof of our spirituality or godliness
        - Anyone can pray to God
            - Pagans pray to their gods
            - There are many false religions with millions of followers who spend many hours praying to false gods
            - So the ability to pray isn't by itself proof of a relationship with the Father
        - But a relationship with the Father through His Son is a prerequisite for our prayers to be heard and to result in any benefit
    - So first, our prayers must come after we have a relationship with the Father
- The next thing to note is that we often approach before God's throne much as this man approached his neighbor
    - We don't seek something from Him in prayer until we reach a moment of desperation

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- Until we have a trauma in our life, a desperate desire, a troubling uncertainty, a fearful crisis
- Only then is our response to seek God in prayer
- So often our initial response is to simply seek a solution in our own power
  - I imagine that man spent a least more than a few minutes searching his home for bread, racking his brain to think of some easy solution that didn't require bothering the neighbor

- But when no easy solution presented itself, the man's desperation drive him to knock on the neighbor's door
- We should be in prayer continually

- Which leads us to the issue of persistence
  - The key lesson of the story, of course, is remaining persistent in our requests of the Father
  - Now right about now some of you are probably scratching your heads
  - Last week I was teaching that Jesus gave us a model for prayer that directed us to make petitions for things already ordained by God's will
  - Now this week, I'm teaching that we keep asking God in a persistent way for our needs so that we might achieve success
    - And so you might ask me, which is it then?
    - Do we ask for God's will or do we seek God persistently for those things that are on our minds?
      - And to that question I answer yes

- Yes, pray for God's will and we pray for God's plan
- And, yes, we petition Him persistently for those things we desire from Him
  - To understand how these two ideas fit together, we must first move on in the text because Jesus Himself is working to put these ideas together

Luke 11:9 ¶ "So I say to you, ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.

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Luke 11:10 "For everyone who asks, receives; and he who seeks, finds; and to him who knocks, it will be opened.
Luke 11:11 "Now suppose one of you fathers is asked by his son for a fish; he will not give him a snake instead of a fish, will he?
Luke 11:12 "Or *if* he is asked for an egg, he will not give him a scorpion, will he?
Luke 11:13 "If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will *your* heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask Him?"

- Often the easiest way to appreciate the character and nature of an all-powerful, invisible creator of the universe is to make comparisons to things we understand easily
    - So here Jesus compares our Heaven Father and His response to our prayers with a typical earthly father and his nature and character under similar circumstances
    - And through the comparison we gain important insight
- Jesus begins by stating that those who ask will receive
    - Those who seek something will find something
    - Those who desire opportunities of God will receive an open door
    - In other words, God will provide an answer to any of His children who seek Him earnestly
        - He will not ignore the requests of His children
        - Point #1 – God hears all prayers of His children

Prov. 15:29 The LORD is far from the wicked,
But He hears the prayer of the righteous.

Psa. 145:19 He will fulfill the desire of those who fear Him;
He will also hear their cry and will save them.

- Secondly, in verses 11-13 Jesus teaches that no loving earthly father would ever respond to the earnest request made by one of his children for something good by giving the child something bad
    - If you ask for a fish, you won't end up with a snake
    - If you ask for an egg, you won't receive a scorpion
        - Palestinian scorpions can look like eggs when curled up

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- And yet these earthly fathers are sinful, far from perfect, prone to doing evil – but yet they care for their children

- So consider the Heavenly Father
  - The Father without sin, perfect, all knowing – who can do nothing but good
  - Would we expect that He would fail to give good things to His children?
  - We know He will always hear our requests AND He will respond to always give us what is best
  - In fact, in verse 13 Jesus tells His disciples that the best God could ever give them is His Spirit, something that God was soon to do during Pentecost
    - Jesus reference to the asking for the Holy Spirit and receiving Him was a specific comment to the disciples
    - They would receive this gift at Pentecost, and it is the supreme gift for any believer – nothing else equals it

- So the first point to remember this morning is God hears the prayers of His children, He answers those prayers every time and He always gives us what is best
  - Doesn't that excite you just a little?
    - Doesn't that add motivation to your prayer time?
    - Do we really appreciate that when we take time from our day and devote it to prayer that we are receiving an audience with the God of the universe
      - He is hearing our every word, our every thought
      - Those requests are being entertained
      - And He has prepared an answer and He is working it out in His timing according to His will ensuring that we receive what's best
    - Can we ever appreciate the awesome privilege the Father has given us through Christ – that we might seek Him in so personal a way
  - But understand the significance of these verses, especially verse 13

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- The Father always gives what is best
- What if that child had asked his Father for a snake? Or a scorpion?
- What would a good father have done?
  - Naturally the good father, desiring to do what's best for the child would have said no
  - And would the child have been happy about that answer? Probably not

- I think as a culture, we've largely lost the significance of this point, though we claim to understand it
  - Not everything our children ask for is good for them
    - Children have all kinds of desires just like we do,
  - And they are not mature enough to appreciate why some of their desires are wrong
    - They don't always have complete information, they don't know the whole picture
    - They lack the perspective that can only come with age and experience
- So they must depend upon their loving parents to make judgments about what's best for them
  - And that role is one every parent should take seriously
  - Which means sometimes the right answer to a child's request sometimes is to say no, though they don't like the answer
- I think it's fair to say we live in a permissive culture,
  - Parents look for ways to simply say yes rather than considering what's best for the child and being willing to endure a child's disappointment and anger over our denial
- But giving our children what's best for them is the true measure of a loving parent

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        - We don't measure our child's love for us by how much they like our decisions
        - And we don't measure our love for our children by how often we can please them

- And so it is with our Heavenly Father
    - He always hears our prayers, He always answers we're told
    - And He always gives us what's best, which means many times He says no
    - Or He gives us something other than what we wanted
        - Are you beginning to see how these ideas fit together?
- Jesus taught that when we pray, we should place God at the center of our prayers, seeking His will rather than our own
    - Because the surest way to get what we desire is to pray for what the Father knows is best and for what He intends to do
    - Don't we do the same thing with our children?
        - Don't we say YES far more often to a child who asks for those things we know are best and proper?
        - Of course we do – in fact we encourage and teach our children to want the right things
            - We teach them to desire the tings we hold to be best and true – to follow after our ways
            - And our heavenly Father does the same thing
            - He desires that we would learn His ways and seek them rather than our own
- But we could ask how do we know the Father's will so we can pray for it?
    - The answer is simple…by seeking Him persistently in our prayers, by asking for those things that are on our heart and then waiting for the answer
    - And through our persistence, we begin to understand His will by how He answers our prayers

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- How does a child learn what his father approves and supports?
    - By repeated coming to that father and asking for things
    - Over time that child learns about his father's character and his father's values by observing the father's answers
    - If the father never approves the watching of R Rated moves, the child learns something
    - If the father will not approve staying out after midnight…
    - Over time the child learns about the father's character, his values, what He is inclined to do and what He will not do
- And so it is with our heavenly Father
    - In fact, let me summarize what Jesus has taught about the Father and prayer
        - Our father hears our prayers and always answers them
        - The Father will always give us what is best
        - So, sometimes the Father will not give us what we want since He has a better plan for us
        - But He asks that we seek him persistently, because only in persistence will we see our prayers answered
    - And what persistence achieves is not a persuading of God to change his mind or a wearing down of God's patience until He gives in
        - Rather our persistence gains us repeated opportunities to see what kinds of requests are granted
            - And we through those experiences we better learn and understand our Heavenly Father's will for us
            - And over time, His will becomes our desire and our prayers are more often answered yes
        - And in knowing our Father better and in understanding His will, we may pray for it and receive it
- In other words, Jesus encouraged persistence in prayer so that through our repeated petitions WE might be changed and conformed to the Father's image

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- Because the real work of prayer takes place in us, as we seek God and grow in our spiritual maturity and begin to appreciate what He appreciates and seek His will rather than our own

- God answers our petitions and brings glory to Himself as we pray in His will

- For the power of prayer is not in the prayer or the one who prays but in the God who answers prayer

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Luke 11C

- Having completed our miniseries on prayer during the first two weeks in Luke, we're now ready to move on to one of the most pivotal moments in Luke's gospel
    - I've been alluding to the significance of this chapter for sometime, and now that we've arrived here, we need to develop a number of issues from Luke's gospel and from elsewhere scripture
    - In fact, let's begin with a simple recap of where Jesus is and where he's going
        - Jesus is moving steadily toward Jerusalem, having spoken of his coming death and ascension in Jerusalem in Chapter 9
        - And yet in Chapter 10 He sent his disciples out proclaiming the Kingdom of God and calling the nation of Israel to repent and receive their Messiah
        - So it seems clear that while Jesus anticipated His rejection and His death, He was not hesitating to give the nation opportunity to receive their Messiah and the promise of the Kingdom
- And of course along the way to the cross, Jesus is still preparing His disciples for the work that lays before them
    - Which is why we have lessons like those that began this chapter, where Jesus takes time to answer questions on prayer or teaching them about true righteousness or to heal

Luke 11:14 ¶ And He was casting out a demon, and it was mute; when the demon had gone out, the mute man spoke; and the crowds were amazed.
Luke 11:15 But some of them said, "He casts out demons by Beelzebul, the ruler of the demons."
Luke 11:16 Others, to test *Him*, were demanding of Him a sign from heaven.
Luke 11:17 But He knew their thoughts and said to them, "Any kingdom divided against itself is laid waste; and a house *divided* against itself falls.
Luke 11:18 "If Satan also is divided against himself, how will his kingdom stand? For you say that I cast out demons by Beelzebul.
Luke 11:19 "And if I by Beelzebul cast out demons, by whom do your sons cast them out? So they will be your judges.
Luke 11:20 "But if I cast out demons by the finger of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon you.

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- As we study this important exchange between Jesus and the Pharisees, we must spend time studying this same account in Matthew as well
    - Because Matthew accounts offers some important additional detail, and Matthew's account places the event in a more likely sequence with the other events of Jesus ministry
- Before we look at Matt, let's consider what we see presented here
    - Jesus comes upon a man indwelt by a mute demon
        - Demons inhabit the body and use the vocal chords of the person
        - This demon had chosen to remain mute, meaning either the man himself could not speak or the demon merely refused to speak
    - In Israel, casting out demons was not unheard of
        - God had long given men the ability at times to cast out demons
            - You see evidence of that fact in these verse, where in verse 19 Jesus refers to the sons of the Pharisees casting out demons
            - You also see a reference to Jewish exorcists in Acts 19
- But removing a demon had a very specific process according to how God had made it possible
    - But a demon could be removed, the person performing the exorcism must first learn the name of the demon
    - Then once he knew the name, he could cast out the demon by name
        - You see examples of Jesus following this pattern in many cases where He cast out demons
            - Remember when Jesus met the demon-possessed man in the tombs and learns the name of the demon is Legion
    - But what if the man was mute or the demon refused to speak?
        - This created a dilemma for the exorcist, because without the name of the demon, no one could remove him
        - Example:

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Mark 9:17 And one of the crowd answered Him, "Teacher, I brought You my son, possessed with a spirit which makes him mute;
Mark 9:18 and whenever it seizes him, it slams him *to the ground* and he foams *at the mouth*, and grinds his teeth and stiffens out. I told Your disciples to cast it out, and they could not *do it*."

- Being mute, the boy's demon could not be removed by the disciples' power
- Then Jesus cures the boy and the disciples ask Jesus how He did it

Mark 9:25 When Jesus saw that a crowd was rapidly gathering, He rebuked the unclean spirit, saying to it, "You deaf and mute spirit, I command you, come out of him and do not enter him again."
Mark 9:26 After crying out and throwing him into terrible convulsions, it came out; and *the boy* became so much like a corpse that most *of them* said, "He is dead!"
Mark 9:27 But Jesus took him by the hand and raised him; and he got up.
Mark 9:28 When He came into *the* house, His disciples *began* questioning Him privately, "Why could we not drive it out?"
Mark 9:29 And He said to them, "This kind cannot come out by anything but prayer."

- Based on what we already studied concerning prayer, then you should know why it is that prayer alone can heal this boy
  - Because only God Himself has the power to remove a mute demon, since this is a power that God has reserved for Himself
  - He granted men the power to remove demons under certain circumstances, but He withheld it under these circumstances
  - And the reason God withheld it directly relates to the coming of the Messiah, as we are studying in Luke today

- Returning to Luke, we now have enough background to begin to make sense of the importance of this exchange
  - As we have learned, the ability to cast out a mute demon was something that the Jewish culture had long associated with God Himself
  - So Jewish tradition concerning the Messiah had taught that one of the signs of the Messiah was that He would have the power to cast out a mute demon, since it would be a miracle only God could do
  - Now look at the exchange in Luke

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- In verse 14, Jesus cast out a mute demon and the crowds are amazed
  - Their amazement stems from the fact that this is one of those Messiah miracles
  - But as the crowds stands amazed at Jesus, some in the crowd scoff and declare that this just proves Jesus is the devil himself

- We can see this exchange a little more clearly by paging over to Matt 12

Matt. 12:22 ¶ Then a demon-possessed man *who was* blind and mute was brought to Jesus, and He healed him, so that the mute man spoke and saw.
Matt. 12:23 All the crowds were amazed, and were saying, "This man cannot be the Son of David, can he?"
Matt. 12:24 But when the Pharisees heard *this*, they said, "This man casts out demons only by Beelzebul the ruler of the demons."

- Here, we learn two important additional details
  - First, the crowd makes an important exclamation in response to watching Jesus perform this miracle
    - They exclaim "This can't be the Son of David, can it?"
    - The term Son of David is a Messianic reference, a term for Christ common in Jewish teaching concerning the Messiah

Is. 9:6 For a child will be born to us, a son will be given to us;
And the government will rest on His shoulders;
And His name will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God,
Eternal Father, Prince of Peace.
Is. 9:7 There will be no end to the increase of *His* government or of peace,
On the throne of David and over his kingdom,
To establish it and to uphold it with justice and righteousness
From then on and forevermore.
The zeal of the LORD of hosts will accomplish this.

Matt. 9:27 ¶ As Jesus went on from there, two blind men followed Him, crying out, "Have mercy on us, Son of David!"

- The crowd is asking out loud, is this itinerant preacher from Nazareth truly the Christ? The Son of David?

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- And they are asking because Jesus doesn't fit their expectation for what the Messiah should be and how He will arrive
  - They wanted a conquering, military leader like David
  - They wanted a powerful, delivering prophet like Moses
  - They wanted rich and powerful world ruler like Soloman
  - They didn't see Jesus as fitting any model they assumed God would use to bring salvation and deliverance
- Perhaps more importantly, they hadn't been expecting God's salvation to take the form of a spiritual salvation
  - Rather they were looking for a material, earthly rescue
    - From the oppression of the Romans
    - From the oppression of their illnesses and their poverty
    - From the lowly circumstances of the Nation of Israel when compared to all the other nations of the earth

- So when Jesus came declaring the coming of His kingdom, He did so with an expectation that men would first repent and receive on the basis of faith
  - And then having come to Him in faith, then He would usher in His kingdom and with it all the material blessing they expected
  - But the people of Jesus day had reverse this formula
    - They wanted to see proof of Jesus' power
    - They wanted signs and evidence of his deity and strength to fulfill scripture
  - In verse 16 of Luke we're told that others in the crowd were asking Him for a sign – they were testing Him looking for Him to satisfy their demands for proof
    - And until He was willing to demonstrate His power, they would withhold their approval and allegiance
  - And people today are still following that same pattern
    - For too many, the promises offered in the gospel aren't believable

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- They demand proof before faith – but that requirement nullifies faith
    - By definition, faith is a conviction of things unseen
    - Being certain about the unprovable, about something that's yet to be revealed
    - That's why faith must be something of the heart, not the mind –
    - We don't weigh the facts, study the arguments, sift through the proof, and then come to an intellectual decision that the gospel is true
        - We may study stricture and recognize how it supports our faith
        - We might see how history, science and archeology and other support or enhance our understanding of our faith
        - But in all cases, faith comes first or it isn't faith at all

- That's why the crowd said what they did upon seeing the miracle
    - They didn't say Behold, the Son of Man
    - They didn't say, this must be the Son of Man
    - They didn't even say, "This could be the Son of Man."
- No, they said, this can't be the Son of Man, can it?
    - The sad thing here is they knew what to look for
    - They sign had done it's work, they had received what they were looking for
    - But when it came, they denied it

- The second thing we see in Matthew's account is the reaction of the Pharisees
    - Remember, these were the religious leaders of the day determined to undermine Jesus' credibility

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- They were desperate to diminish Jesus in the minds of the people and to explain away anything Jesus did that seemed to support His claims
- So when Jesus performs a miracle unique to the Messiah, they are forced to explain it away some how
  - This is not new for them…earlier in Matt we see a similar experience

Matt. 9:32 ¶ As they were going out, a mute, demon-possessed man was brought to Him.
Matt. 9:33 After the demon was cast out, the mute man spoke; and the crowds were amazed, *and were* saying, "Nothing like this has ever been seen in Israel."
Matt. 9:34 But the Pharisees were saying, "He casts out the demons by the ruler of the demons."

- Just as here in Chap 12 of Matt and Chap 11 of Luke, Jesus proves Himself through this unique miracle,
  - The crowd exclaims that this is unprecedented
    - No one in Israel has ever cast out mute demons before
    - But apparently, the Pharisees had taken to accusing Jesus of simply being demon-possessed Himself
    - Their argument was that since no mere man could cast out a mute demon…that only left the conclusion that Jesus was God
      - Not being willing to admit that conclusion, the Pharisees concoct this unique explanation
      - Jesus is Satan and therefore Satan can command his own army to do his bidding
      - Therefore, Jesus was able to cast out a demon because the demons obey their leader, Satan
- It's important to understand what's happening here
  - Scripture is teaching us a fundamental truth about our response to the deity of Christ
  - As the Pharisees come face to face with the recognition that Jesus was God Himself, they react by denying that revelation

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- And furthermore, they declare that the signs prove that Jesus is the enemy
  - They had already been maligning Jesus the man on many occasions
  - But now they had moved to a new level and were declaring that the signs Jesus was performing were the work of the enemy
- But whose work were they?
  - Who was performing these miraculous works through Jesus?
  - As we've said in the past, Jesus having taken the form of man became reliant on the Holy Spirit for all his supernatural power
    - We've already seen in Luke's Gospel that Jesus was led by the Spirit, directed by the Spirit, comforted by the Spirit, anointed by the Spirit and empowered by the Spirit
    - We've Jesus unable to perform miracles in Nazareth because the Spirit was not inclined to respond to a faithless people who demanded proof of Jesus' claims
- So when the Pharisees declare that the signs they've been given are not proof that Jesus is the Messiah,
  - But rather it is the work of Satan,
  - These religious leaders are not only maligning Jesus, they have begun to malign the Holy Spirit
  - And by association, God's revelation by the work of the Spirit

- The Gospel message is offensive by its nature
  - When someone is confronted by the clear, undeniable power of God
  - Whether through the Word of God or through the lives of His people or through our circumstances, God can use many ways to bring us face to face with the truth
  - And when someone decides to reject that revelation, to deny Christ, they aren't merely a neutral observer

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        - I think we sometimes think there are those who are adamantly for Jesus (Christians), those who are adamantly oppose to Jesus (atheists, Christian haters, etc.)
        - And then there are those who are neutral or undecided
        - Scripture doesn't support this conclusion
    - We'll see that more clearly here in a minute, but look at the Pharisees for a moment
        - They saw clear evidence of who Jesus was, and they rejected it
        - But it wasn't enough to reject Him, they had to ensure that others saw things the same way
        - They were determined to oppose Jesus in everyway possible
        - They were Jesus enemy and they had become an ally of THE enemy, Satan
- So look at how Jesus begins His response to their claims
    - In Luke 11 verse 17, Jesus begins by stating that any kingdom divided against itself will fall
        - The motto of Kentucky is United we stand, divided we fall
        - It expresses a simple idea
            - That when any single entity is made from smaller parts, those parts must work together toward a common goal
            - If one part of the whole is set against another part, it will tear itself apart and will never function successfully
            - This is especially true when that entity is engaged in battle against a common enemy
            - You can never be successful against an enemy if you are too busy fighting among yourselves
    - Jesus responds to the ridiculous comment from the Pharisees by reminding them that if He were Satan, it would have been the height of foolishness to go around defeating the very demons who work for Satan

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- Jesus was clearly opposing the demons through his work, so it was nonsense to claim that his power to oppose demons came from the chief demon

- Satan would never work against himself

- Then Jesus turns the attack back on the Pharisees

  - In verse 19, He says to the Pharisees that the sons of Israel are busy casting out demons too

  - With this comment, Jesus points out the Pharisees' double standard

    - Jesus is saying that if the Pharisees are willing to claim that Satan grants men the power to chase away demonic forces, then what power did their sons use to cast out demons

    - If Jesus' power came from Satan, then perhaps their cons got power from Satan too

  - But then Jesus makes point for the crowd in verse 20

- Jesus states the obvious conclusion that if you see a man doing things that only the finger of God can do, then you have only one conclusion left to make

  - That man is the Christ and His arrival means the kingdom of God has come to earth

    - The kingdom: meaning the promised kingdom that the Jews were looking and waiting for

    - And yet in the face of that clear, unmistakable conclusion, the crowd rejects Jesus and sides with the Pharisees

- Then Jesus says this:

Luke 11:21 "When a strong *man*, fully armed, guards his own house, his possessions are undisturbed.
Luke 11:22 "But when someone stronger than he attacks him and overpowers him, he takes away from him all his armor on which he had relied and distributes his plunder.
Luke 11:23 "He who is not with Me is against Me; and he who does not gather with Me, scatters.

- In this parable, Jesus illustrates how wrong the Pharisees are

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- In fact, the circumstances of the moment argue for exactly the opposite conclusion from the one the Pharisees proposed
    - Jesus tells the crowd that when a strong man guards his treasure, he does so with his full might
    - He is not going to easily relinquish the very things he values
- Only when someone stronger comes along and removes his armor will he be forced to give up his treasure
    - And from that simple story Jesus expects His audience to draw the obvious conclusion
    - Satan is a strong man in this world
        - He has certain power and ability
        - And his treasure are the souls of the lost
        - And when one of his demons takes possession of a lost soul and indwells a body, he will not give it up easily
        - He will only be willing to give up his treasure if forced by One who is stronger
- Jesus forced the enemy to depart a body, but that demon leaves reluctantly and only because Jesus as God has infinitely more power than the enemy
    - So Jesus' parable goes beyond merely illustrating the absurdity of the Pharisee's claims
    - It also teaches that there is a war underway, and everyone is on one side or another – there is no neutral ground

- Jesus says in verse 23 that if you are either for Jesus or against Him
    - I've often said there are only two kinds of people in the world
        - From God's perspective, there are not different nations, there are not different religions, there are not different denominations
        - There are only those who are with Jesus
            - Those who believe His claims

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- Those who have faith in His word
- Those who trust in Him

- And there are those who are against Him
  - Those who call Him a liar
  - Those who deny His claims
  - Those who ignore His call to repentance
  - Those who are like their father, the devil
  - Those who are the enemy's treasure

- Next week we celebrate Easter, our 3rd Easter together in our third facility
  - And as we approach Resurrection Sunday, I can't think of a better time to ask this question…which side are you on this morning?

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Luke 11D

- Open your Bibles with me to Chapter 11 of the Gospel of Luke
    - Follow with me as begin reading in verse 17
    - As we continue in our teaching from last week

Luke 11:17 But He knew their thoughts and said to them, "Any kingdom divided against itself is laid waste; and a house *divided* against itself falls.
Luke 11:18 "If Satan also is divided against himself, how will his kingdom stand? For you say that I cast out demons by Beelzebul.
Luke 11:19 "And if I by Beelzebul cast out demons, by whom do your sons cast them out? So they will be your judges.
Luke 11:20 "But if I cast out demons by the finger of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon you.
Luke 11:21 "When a strong *man*, fully armed, guards his own house, his possessions are undisturbed.
Luke 11:22 "But when someone stronger than he attacks him and overpowers him, he takes away from him all his armor on which he had relied and distributes his plunder.
Luke 11:23 "He who is not with Me is against Me; and he who does not gather with Me, scatters.
Luke 11:24 ¶ "When the unclean spirit goes out of a man, it passes through waterless places seeking rest, and not finding any, it says, 'I will return to my house from which I came.'
Luke 11:25 "And when it comes, it finds it swept and put in order.
Luke 11:26 "Then it goes and takes *along* seven other spirits more evil than itself, and they go in and live there; and the last state of that man becomes worse than the first."

- When Jesus stood before the crowds and the Pharisees and performed the miracle of casting out the mute demon, He had proved Himself to be the Christ, the promised Messiah who would deliver God's people
    - As we studied last week, Jesus' casting out of a mute demon provided unique, indisputable proof that He was Israel's Messiah
    - And when these people saw the miracle, once they had become witnesses to the testimony of the Holy Spirit, they had a choice to make
        - They could chose to accept the sign, a clear signs, a sign they obviously recognized as pointing to the Son of Man

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        - Or would they not believe what their eyes saw

    - The Pharisees made their choice

        - They declared the miracle was the work of Satan

        - The turned their back on the work of the Holy Spirit and on the person of Christ and hardened their hearts

- And Jesus turned to them, and He began to unveil the corruption of their hearts and the unimaginable consequences that their disbelief was to produce

    - In the last verse we read last week, verse 23, Jesus frames the issue in stark terms

        - These people were either for Him or against Him

        - No doubt there were those in the crowd who would have called themselves undecided

        - They hadn't made up their minds yet

    - But Jesus doesn't give the crowd that option

        - He says plainly that every human being has only two choices when it comes to Jesus

            - They either profess belief in His claims to be the Messiah

            - 'They witness the miracles or read the testimony in God's word concerning who Jesus is and they believe it

        - Or they to those who think they can remain undecided, Jesus says it can't be – look at His words in verse 23

            - The one who is not for Jesus – who does not profess faith in Him and believe His words – that person is automatically against Jesus

            - What's more, the one who is not working with Jesus, is automatically working against Him

            - And the reason that person is working against Jesus is because that person has become an agent for Satan

            - Everyone person who has come to faith in Christ, who does not have the indwelling of the Holy Spirit, is fighting

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against God – and is therefore an instrument for use by the enemy

- Look where Jesus goes next in the text
    - Jesus tells of a man who is possessed by an evil spirit
    - And should that spirit leave, whether on its own or perhaps because it has been cast out
    - It will not find rest for there is no place of rest for the demons, save the opportunity to inhabit fallen men
    - So eventually, it may return to the place it was, and when it comes back it may bring friends, making the last state worse than the first
    - At least before the demon was cast out, there was only one – now there are more
        - It would have been better left alone
- And this is the judgment Jesus is pronouncing on this generation
    - In Matt 12 Jesus adds this statement in verse 45

Matt. 12:45 "Then it goes and takes along with it seven other spirits more wicked than itself, and they go in and live there; and the last state of that man becomes worse than the first. That is the way it will also be with this evil generation."

- This generation, in rejecting the clear signs that their Messiah has arrived, turned their backs and rejected Him
    - Not only Him, but they were declaring the work of the Holy Spirit to be the work of Satan
    - And in these things, they lost their opportunity to welcome the kingdom of God
    - They have been swept clean, demons have been expelled, the sick made well, the word proclaimed and the glory of God made flesh
    - And yet they remain empty, and as empty vessels they are ready for the enemy to reclaim what is His – the unbeliever ready to be overtaken

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- The solution of course for this dilemma is to place the stronger man Jesus spoke of earlier in the clean house
    - One who can repel the attack of the enemy should he return expecting to reoccupy that house
    - In other words, the Holy Spirit indwelling the vessel becomes the permanent occupant of that home and can never be overpowered
    - John puts it this way

1John 4:2 By this you know the Spirit of God: every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God;
1John 4:3 and every spirit that does not confess Jesus is not from God; this is the *spirit* of the antichrist, of which you have heard that it is coming, and now it is already in the world.
1John 4:4 You are from God, little children, and have overcome them; because greater is He who is in you than he who is in the world.
1John 4:5 They are from the world; therefore they speak *as* from the world, and the world listens to them.
1John 4:6 We are from God; he who knows God listens to us; he who is not from God does not listen to us. By this we know the spirit of truth and the spirit of error.

- Do you see even John's letter speaks of the two-sided nature of the world
    - There is one spirit that is from God
        - And those who share that spirit are from God
    - And there is another spirit which is of the world
        - The spirit of the antichrist, of Satan Himself
        - Do you see what John's saying?
            - Either you are of the spirit of God, or you are merely just a part of the world
            - And all the world belongs to the enemy
    - But if you refuse to confess Christ, you are proving that you are of the world
    - But when you confess Jesus, you are demonstrating that you are from God

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        - And when you confess Christ, you leave the world
        - The world becomes your enemy
        - The world will no longer listen to you or agree with you
    - Yet John says that we have overcome the world, we are no longer a part of it
        - And the one who is in us, the Holy Spirit who confirms we are of God, He is the One who guarantees we have overcome the world
        - Because He is greater than the enemy, the one who controls the world of unbelievers

- I wonder if this scripture challenges us
    - On the one hand, do we know which side we're on
        - Are we like the Pharisees who thought they had the answers, who were sure they knew that they were leasing to God, though they were far from Him
        - Are we like the crowds who like to think of themselves as detached and undecided, though they were just as assuredly on the side of Satan as the Pharisees
        - We ought to be challenged by these verse this Easter morning at least enough to understand that unless we have on some occasion acknowledged Christ as savior in our hearts, and professed Him as Lord publicly with our mouths, then we have reason to be concerned
        - We may be fooling ourselves about where we stand before God
        - If that's you, don't leave this morning without making sure whose side you are on
    - On the other hand, if you know you are for Jesus, and not against Him
        - Then do find yourself doubting, wondering
        - And you plagued by doubt that God will stand by you despite your past or despite your present
        - Are you worried about the enemy and His power

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        - Or do you worry about life's problems

    - Then remember the words of John

        - Know that you have overcome the world

        - You are sealed by the Holy Spirit and though trials may come, He is with you and He will sustain you to the end

        - And when the end comes, you will enter His presence never to leave it again

        - So, as Hebrews 6:18 says, take hold of the hope that is set before us

- In Matt's gospel, as Jesus declares to the crowd that they are either for Him or against Him, Matthew records an important additional detail

Matt. 12:30 "He who is not with Me is against Me; and he who does not gather with Me scatters.
Matt. 12:31 ¶ "Therefore I say to you, any sin and blasphemy shall be forgiven people, but blasphemy against the Spirit shall not be forgiven.
Matt. 12:32 "Whoever speaks a word against the Son of Man, it shall be forgiven him; but whoever speaks against the Holy Spirit, it shall not be forgiven him, either in this age or in the *age* to come.

- I'm sure many of you have heard these verses before and perhaps wondered about their true meaning, but I believe the context makes clear their meaning

    - As Jesus stands before this generation and proves Himself through miracles performed in the power of the Holy Spirit, He is providing a firsthand witness unlike any the world has ever seen before or since

    - And these signs were gracious made available to one and only one generation in all of history

    - And for that generation to reject these signs was an unforgivable sin

        - It was a rejection for which there is no recovery, no second opportunity

        - Even after Jesus' death when the disciples walked in Jerusalem preaching Christ, this generation who rejected Jesus in the flesh would not get the opportunity to accept Him by messenger later

- But Jesus says this unforgivable sin would last for this age and the age to come

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- Meaning it was not merely an offense for that day
- It was an offense that could continue even today
- How then would someone commit the unforgivable sin today?
  - Remembering that the offense is against the work of the Holy Spirit to reveal the identity and authority of Christ, then the offense is to reject the Holy Spirit's revelation of Jesus
  - When the Holy Spirit brings a man or woman an undeniable understanding that Jesus is who He said He was –
    - the Messiah, the King of world, son to return and rule all nations, the only Son of God
    - The only way to salvation, the only Son of the living God
    - Then everything is on the line
- When that crowd saw Jesus cast out a mute demon, they knew what it meant
  - They had been taught since the day they were a young child that when the Messiah came He would do such a thing
  - And they knew from personal experience that no one else had ever been able to make such a thing a happen
  - Even Jesus' disciples couldn't do it as we saw last week
  - And yet when they were confronted with the proof, they turned their backs on Jesus,
  - they said no to the revelation of the Holy Spirit

- The same applies today
  - Anytime the word of God is preached, anytime a messenger brings a clear word of the truth of scripture
  - Anytime the Holy Spirit works to bring the truth of the gospel, to the ears of the unbeliever, and the truth of that message sets in, everything is on the line
    - The stakes have been raised infinitely

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- The time has come
- There are no neutral parties
- There is no way to remain undecided
- There is no more debating or waiting for another moment
- It's all or nothing
- And eternity is on the line

- And in that moment, that moment when the Holy Spirit has brought truth to the heart of the unbeliever, there remains a moment when that person's soul rests in the balance
- Where will that person spend eternity?
- Will that person come to know the Lord and become an adopted child of God?
- Or will they turn their back as the nation of Israel did in Jesus' day and commit the unforgivable sin

- This may be the moment for someone even now
  - Perhaps someone who has long considered themselves a good person, someone who felt they had it all together
  - Perhaps they even called themselves a Christian
  - But now, the Holy Spirit has impressed upon them the difference
  - Now as they consider the challenge Christ offers and they realize that all eternity lies in the balance, the words of the Paul in 2Cor6 come to mind

2Cor. 6:1 ¶ And working together *with Him*, we also urge you not to receive the grace of God in vain—
2Cor. 6:2 for He says,
"AT THE ACCEPTABLE TIME I LISTENED TO YOU,
AND ON THE DAY OF SALVATION I HELPED YOU."
Behold, now is "THE ACCEPTABLE TIME," behold, now is "THE DAY OF SALVATION"—

- Now is the day to receive Christ and to know that you are not against Him
  - To know that you are not of the world

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- To know that you are not working with the enemy, destined for eternal judgment

- For as surely as Jesus rose from the dead, the same thing is promised to all those who trust in Him for salvation

    - What better opportunity that on Easter Sunday, as we remember His life given up for the sins of the world

    - That we might be accept that sacrifice and be sure we are top spend eternity with Him not against Him

    - I pray no one would commit the unforgivable sin, the sin of rejecting the revelation of the Holy Spirit

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Luke 11E

- We jump back into Luke chapter 11 this morning, ready to complete our teaching on the Jews rejection of Jesus
    - For the past two weeks, including Easter Sunday, we examined the significance of the Jewish leaders and crowd doubting the obvious signs that Jesus was the Messiah
    - Secondly, the leaders went a step further and declared Jesus to be operating with the power of Satan
        - Keep in mind this accusation was not merely slander
        - It's not that these men were making up insults – no, they truly believed what they said
        - And in that misdirected belief, they assured themselves and their generation judgment
- But as we begin this morning, Luke inserts an interesting detail in passing – one that he uses to help emphasize the significance of Jesus' teaching in the moment

Luke 11:27 ¶ While Jesus was saying these things, one of the women in the crowd raised her voice and said to Him, "Blessed is the womb that bore You and the breasts at which You nursed."
Luke 11:28 But He said, "On the contrary, blessed are those who hear the word of God and observe it."

- Luke tells us that this woman's exclamation came in the moment as Jesus was saying these things
- The woman was essentially offering Jesus a compliment indirectly,
    - By complimenting Jesus mother, saying how special Jesus mother must have been, the woman was inferring how special Jesus was
    - The compliment seems natural enough
        - We sometimes say things like that to people
        - But this woman's comment reflected a deeper line of thought

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- This comment reflects a very Jewish way of seeing honor and glory,

- In fact, her thinking – that Jesus' mother was blessed to have such a good son - gives us added insight into the thinking of the crowd and of the Jewish leaders

- To address this woman's thinking, I first need to remind you of a couple of well-known teachings that Paul gives in Romans and Galatians

Rom. 9:6 ¶ But *it is* not as though the word of God has failed. For they are not all Israel who are *descended* from Israel;
Rom. 9:7 nor are they all children because they are Abraham's descendants, but: "THROUGH ISAAC YOUR DESCENDANTS WILL BE NAMED."
Rom. 9:8 That is, it is not the children of the flesh who are children of God, but the children of the promise are regarded as descendants.

- In these verses from Romans Paul explains that to be counted a child of God – to be blessed in other words - has nothing to do with your human bloodline

- There is not some special birthright that determines whether you are blessed

- Rather, those who are the child of the promise who are blessed

- Paul says it another way in Galatians

Gal. 3:7 Therefore, be sure that it is those who are of faith who are sons of Abraham.
Gal. 3:8 The Scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham, *saying*, "ALL THE NATIONS WILL BE BLESSED IN YOU."
Gal. 3:9 So then those who are of faith are blessed with Abraham, the believer.

- Paul tells the Galatian church that anyone who shares the faith of Abraham will be a sons of Abraham and inherit the blessings promised to Abraham and his descendents

- That the promised blessings were always intended for a spiritual birthright, not a physical birthright

- Those who would believe as Abraham believed would join the family of God and share in Abraham's blessings

- The reason Paul must spend time teaching these truths is reflected in this woman's thinking

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- Just like this woman, the churches in Rome and Galatia were prone to look upon their Jewish bloodlines as the reason they were blessed by God
    - They had been brought up to believe that the one and only way to be blessed by God and to be saved was to be Jewish
    - Now they had simply added the need to believe in Jesus to that list of must haves
    - Consequently, they were trying to teach Gentile believers that they must become Jews first and be circumcised before they could become Christians
- Paul said no, it was not their bloodline that mattered, not their Jewishness, but only their faith
    - In fact, he told the Roman church that those who call themselves Jew but don't believe in Jesus are actually not Jew at all – at least not in the meaningful sense of the term

- And this was exactly the kind of thinking that led this woman to exclaim this flattering phrase on Jesus
    - She assumes that any Jewish mother who had opportunity to birth someone like Jesus must be truly blessed
    - That family relationship, that blood relationship must mean that God had blessed the mother by giving her a son of such extraordinary talents
        - It was a blessing by association, in other words
    - This woman was simply making the same assumption common to her day, that blessing from God flows as a result of family relationships and bloodlines
        - And what tribe you belong to and whether you were born Jewish and how much honor you gained from all that

- Now, of course, Mary was blessed to have been given the honor to be Jesus mother, but Jesus would not agree to this woman's premise
    - He quickly responds back to the woman in the crowd saying, on the contrary
        - You've got it completely wrong

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        - You couldn't be more wrong

    - Then He says that the one who is blessed who hears the word of God and observes it or maintains it (*phulasso*) or guards it

        - Now, understand, Jesus is not insulting His mother, of course

        - He's not saying that His mother Mary was not blessed

        - Jesus was simply stating that Mary's blessing had nothing to do with her opportunity to birth and raise Jesus

        - Mary's opportunity to be blessed came in the same way it comes for every man or woman

            - By hearing and doing God's word

- Remember the words of Paul again

Rom. 10:17 So faith *comes* from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.

- And of James

James 1:23 For if anyone is a hearer of the word and not a doer, he is like a man who looks at his natural face in a mirror;
James 1:24 for *once* he has looked at himself and gone away, he has immediately forgotten what kind of person he was.
James 1:25 But one who looks intently at the perfect law, the *law* of liberty, and abides by it, not having become a forgetful hearer but an effectual doer, this man will be blessed in what he does.

- Those who hear the word of God, believe and then prove their belief by keeping the law of liberty, the law of Christ, these people will be blessed

    - Mary was blessed because she heard the word of the God, believed God and proved her faith by obeying God

    - To say that Mary was blessed on the basis of her role of motherhood would be to say that she was blessed on the basis of her works, which is false teaching

        - I think that's one reason why the Catholic church has falsely elevated Mary to the status an idol, the sinless mother of creation, co-redeemer with Christ the Pope says

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- It's because they have elevated her works above the fact of her faith
- Yet scriptures tells us that it is by grace through faith alone that men are justified, so that no one may boast
  - That no one includes Mary
  - Mary cannot boast before God that she was blessed and saved for anything she did – only by faith was she saved

- So Jesus has just begun to explain to the crowd the penalty for rejecting Christ's word, for rejecting the Messiah
  - And He responds to this woman's comment because it offers Him a perfect opportunity to make the point
  - If you want to be blessed, believe in my word
- And now He uses the exchange with the woman as a springboard for

Luke 11:29 ¶ As the crowds were increasing, He began to say, "This generation is a wicked generation; it seeks for a sign, and *yet* no sign will be given to it but the sign of Jonah.
Luke 11:30 "For just as Jonah became a sign to the Ninevites, so will the Son of Man be to this generation.
Luke 11:31 "The Queen of the South will rise up with the men of this generation at the judgment and condemn them, because she came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon; and behold, something greater than Solomon is here.
Luke 11:32 "The men of Nineveh will stand up with this generation at the judgment and condemn it, because they repented at the preaching of Jonah; and behold, something greater than Jonah is here.

- The crowds are still increasing
  - And as verse 29 explains, the crowds are continuing to ask for signs
  - So not only have they not believed the signs Jesus as sent them, they continue to ask for more
    - The text leaves us with the sense that the crowd has almost turned to mocking Jesus now
    - It's turning into a circus atmosphere

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        - They keep egging Jesus on to do more miracles and give more signs

    - This reminds me of the description of His time in Nazareth, where He couldn't perform miracles because the people wanted Him to prove Himself by performing miracles the way He did Capernaum

- Instead, Jesus declares that this generation is wicked and it's wicked because it demands signs

    - It's wicked in demanding signs because the signs it has already received were more than sufficient to prove the point that Jesus was the Messiah

        - So as they continue to ask for signs, they are proving their unbelief

    - I hope we appreciate the seriousness of this practice in our own lives

        - There are times in our lives when we ask God to gives us direction, guidance, a sign for how to respond in following Him

            - It might be concerning something big like a job decision, a serious family matter, a financial decision

            - Maybe it involves stepping out in ministry, or selecting a spouse, or selecting the right church

        - And God delights to answer those prayers, prayers seeking His will

1Chr. 28:9 ¶ "As for you, my son Solomon, know the God of your father, and serve Him with a whole heart and a willing mind; for the LORD searches all hearts, and understands every intent of the thoughts. If you seek Him, He will let you find Him; but if you forsake Him, He will reject you forever.

    - Like Gideon in Judges 6 who desires to know if God is with him before a battle, and he asks twice for God to give him a sign

        - Both times God responds

    - But the habit of asking for sign after sign from God can be evidence of lack of faith in God's word to us

        - It's one thing to misunderstand a sign or to miss it

            - Or in the case of Gideon to have second thoughts and ask for confirmation

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- But it's another thing entirely when we see a sign after sign and you recognize their meaning clearly, and yet we still fail to accept them and act upon them
    - And we go on demanding more signs
- What can be evidence of faith (as was the case for Gideon) can also become proof of no faith, of doubting God's word rather than believing it

- To the crowd, Jesus says no sign will be given
    - What He means of course is no more sign will be given, because they had already received many signs
    - But in declaring Jesus to be the devil, they had crossed a line and they would no longer receive the signs they desired
        - And it's because even if Jesus had given them what they wanted, it wouldn't have changed a thing
        - Their hearts were hard and their ears were closed

- Then Jesus emphasizes the point with two illustrations from their the history
    - Jesus reminds them of how the prophet Jonah had brought the Ninevites to repentance
    - And how the Queen of Sheeba had traveled a long distance to listen to hear the wisdom of Solomon
        - In the case of Jonah, the reluctant prophet…

Jonah 2:10 ¶ Then the LORD commanded the fish, and it vomited Jonah up onto the dry land.
Jonah 3:1 ¶ Now the word of the LORD came to Jonah the second time, saying,
Jonah 3:2 "Arise, go to Nineveh the great city and proclaim to it the proclamation which I am going to tell you."
Jonah 3:3 So Jonah arose and went to Nineveh according to the word of the LORD. Now Nineveh was an exceedingly great city, a three days' walk.
Jonah 3:4 Then Jonah began to go through the city one day's walk; and he cried out and said, "Yet forty days and Nineveh will be overthrown."
Jonah 3:5 ¶ Then the people of Nineveh believed in God; and they called a fast and put on sackcloth from the greatest to the least of them.

- The people of Ninevah saw a miraculous sign

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- They saw Jonah having come out of a fish, partially digested, white, hairless
- And based on this one sign, the entire city repents and believes in God
  - A city so big it was three days walk to cross it, that's bigger than San Antonio
  - And the people of this city will be their on judgment day to condemn the people of Jesus day for having neglected so great a sign as the Messiah in person

- And then there is the case of Queen Sheba, let's read the story

1Kings 10:1 ¶ Now when the queen of Sheba heard about the fame of Solomon concerning the name of the LORD, she came to test him with difficult questions.
1Kings 10:2 So she came to Jerusalem with a very large retinue, with camels carrying spices and very much gold and precious stones. When she came to Solomon, she spoke with him about all that was in her heart.
1Kings 10:3 Solomon answered all her questions; nothing was hidden from the king which he did not explain to her.
1Kings 10:4 When the queen of Sheba perceived all the wisdom of Solomon, the house that he had built,
1Kings 10:5 the food of his table, the seating of his servants, the attendance of his waiters and their attire, his cupbearers, and his stairway by which he went up to the house of the LORD, there was no more spirit in her.
1Kings 10:6 Then she said to the king, "It was a true report which I heard in my own land about your words and your wisdom.
1Kings 10:7 "Nevertheless I did not believe the reports, until I came and my eyes had seen it. And behold, the half was not told me. You exceed *in* wisdom and prosperity the report which I heard.
1Kings 10:8 "How blessed are your men, how blessed are these your servants who stand before you continually *and* hear your wisdom.
1Kings 10:9 "Blessed be the LORD your God who delighted in you to set you on the throne of Israel; because the LORD loved Israel forever, therefore He made you king, to do justice and righteousness."
1Kings 10:10 She gave the king a hundred and twenty talents of gold, and a very great *amount* of spices and precious stones. Never again did such abundance of spices come in as that which the queen of Sheba gave King Solomon.

- When the Queen appeared in Soloman's court, she was anything but convinced that Solomon was who he claimed to be
  - In verse 7 she says, she didn't believe the reports of Solomon

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- She had heard miraculous things, things that testified to God's work through Solomon
- But yet she didn't believe those reports
- Yet she had enough curiosity to come for a closer look

- And when she sits in Solomon's court, and she presented him with difficult questions, as a test of whether he was truly who he claimed to be – a man who speaks with the wisdom of God
  - And we're told in verse 3 that nothing was hidden from Solomon, meaning God gave him all the right answers
    - And when the queen hears the wisdom of God and sees the splendor of the kingdom that God had bestowed upon Solomon and the nation of Israel
    - She has a change of heart
    - In verse 6 she admits what she's heard is true
    - And in verse 9 she acknowledges that God is the source of that blessing and blesses the name of the Lord

- Sadly, she likewise will judge the generation that rejected Christ
  - Because unlike the Queen, when they came in disbelief and curiosity and heard the wisdom of God spoken through His only Son, they remained in their unbelief
  - They refused to turn their hearts toward the truth

- And most stinging of all, both these examples are of Gentile people who received God's blessing of faith
  - And God says they will arise on the judgment day and condemn the Jewish people who were given the unequaled privilege of receiving the Messiah in the flesh
  - And so with these examples, Jesus pronounces the judgment that will fall upon this generation – judgment and condemnation
    - Not for everyone person alive in that generation, obviously
    - But for the unbelievers in that generation, there is no second chance –

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- they will received judgment for rejecting the most superior revelation
- while others that come before them and after them will know the truth on the basis of lesser revelation

John 20:29 Jesus *said to him, "Because you have seen Me, have you believed? Blessed *are* they who did not see, and *yet* believed."

- Jesus concludes His discourse with a familiar comparison, one He uses from time to time in His teaching to make a number of related points

Luke 11:33 ¶ "No one, after lighting a lamp, puts it away in a cellar nor under a basket, but on the lampstand, so that those who enter may see the light.
Luke 11:34 "The eye is the lamp of your body; when your eye is clear, your whole body also is full of light; but when it is bad, your body also is full of darkness.
Luke 11:35 "Then watch out that the light in you is not darkness.
Luke 11:36 "If therefore your whole body is full of light, with no dark part in it, it will be wholly illumined, as when the lamp illumines you with its rays."

- We've seen Jesus use this example of a lamp before
    - In connection with the parable of the four seeds
        - He taught that those who have been enlightened with the truth should seek to reflect that changed life to the world
        - To produce seed, like the Condition 4 Christians
    - This time He uses it in a similar way, but applies it differently
        - In the first time he used it in Chap 8, the focus was on the one producing the light, the new believer
        - Here's the focus is on the ones who see our light, or in this case, who see the Light of the World, Jesus
- Jesus begins to speak of the eyes of those who might happen to see this light of the truth
    - If the eye is clear – meaning unobstructed, open to the truth, able to received the light –
        - That person will be filled by the light, by the truth

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- But when the eyes of the unbeliever are bad, meaning not open to seeing the truth, not willing to accept what they are seeing
    - That person's body is fill of darkness
    - Take note that there is no mixing here
    - They are either filled by the light of the truth or they are consumed by darkness and ignorance
    - Once replaces the other

- Jesus warns them to consider whether the light in them is not in fact darkness
    - He is saying that for those – particularly the Pharisees – who think they already know the truth, what they think is truth is in fact false
        - Thinking they are filled with light, their hearts are actually dark
    - Jesus ends by saying that if they were to reject the darkness completely, leaving none of it, they could be filled by the light of the truth and become a light for others

- Isn't it remarkable how consistent the message of scripture is on the issue of salvation
    - From Genesis to Revelation the storyline never varies
        - Either we serve the enemy or we serve God
        - Either we are children of disobedience or we are children of God
        - And it all depends on where we place our trust and faith
        - For those who trust in themselves or other false Gods, their hearts are darkened and they will not receive the truth
        - For those who trust in God – and God alone – there is mercy and grace everlasting

- Next week we conclude Chapter 11 and enter Chapter 12, as Jesus accepts another invitation to eat in the house of one of these unbelieving Pharisees

- Let's leave today resolved as a church family to everything God calls us to do in spreading the truth to others
    - To being that witness to the world

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- To being used by God to hopefully keeping as few as possible of our generation from making the same mistake that those of Jesus generation made

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Luke 11F

- As we have been marching through Chapter 11 of Luke, we're watching as Jesus confirms His rejection and moves to the next stage of his ministry
    - There are consequences to this rejection – immediate consequences and long term consequences
    - The long-term consequences are probably obvious to us all
        - When the Pharisees rejected the work of the Holy Spirit through Christ and blasphemed Him, they were assuring themselves judgment
        - And not just them, but anyone from that generation who followed their example, their leadership
- The short-term consequences, however, are a bit more subtle.
    - First, Jesus alters His teaching style
        - This is more difficult to see in Luke's gospel, but it's very obvious in Matt's gospel
    - In Matt's gospel, the rejection of Christ occurs in Chap 13 (vs Chap 11 of Luke)
        - In the chapters of Matt's gospel leading up to Chap 13, Jesus teaches in a very open style
        - He sent His disciples out proclaiming the arrival of the kingdom of God (Luke 9)
        - When Jesus teaches the crowds, He says things like:

Matt. 11:27 "All things have been handed over to Me by My Father; and no one knows the Son except the Father; nor does anyone know the Father except the Son, and anyone to whom the Son wills to reveal *Him*.
Matt. 11:28 ¶ "Come to Me, all who are weary and heavy-laden, and I will give you rest.
Matt. 11:29 "Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and YOU WILL FIND REST FOR YOUR SOULS.

- But after the Pharisees reject Jesus in Chap 13 of Matt, from that point forward, Jesus only teaches in parables

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- He begins to hide his teaching from the Pharisees and crowds, choosing to teaching the apostles only

- So the first short term consequence of the rejection is Jesus veils the Message of the Gospel from the nation of Israel, thus confirming their rejection

  - A second short-term consequence can be seen in today's teaching

  - Jesus rejects the leadership of the Pharisees and lawyers and declares them to be illegitimate spiritual leaders

  - We'll see this in today's scriptures

Luke 11:37 ¶ Now when He had spoken, a Pharisee *asked Him to have lunch with him; and He went in, and reclined *at the table*.
Luke 11:38 When the Pharisee saw it, he was surprised that He had not first ceremonially washed before the meal.
Luke 11:39 But the Lord said to him, "Now you Pharisees clean the outside of the cup and of the platter; but inside of you, you are full of robbery and wickedness.
Luke 11:40 "You foolish ones, did not He who made the outside make the inside also?
Luke 11:41 "But give that which is within as charity, and then all things are clean for you.
Luke 11:42 ¶ "But woe to you Pharisees! For you pay tithe of mint and rue and every *kind of* garden herb, and *yet* disregard justice and the love of God; but these are the things you should have done without neglecting the others.
Luke 11:43 "Woe to you Pharisees! For you love the chief seats in the synagogues and the respectful greetings in the market places.
Luke 11:44 "Woe to you! For you are like concealed tombs, and the people who walk over *them* are unaware *of it*."

- At the conclusion of Jesus statements to the crowd, He's invited to eat with a Pharisee

  - This was a very crafty move by these leaders

    - To the crowd, it appeared they were showing Jesus respect by inviting Him into their homes and sharing a meal with him

    - But in reality they were really just trying to figure out what made Jesus tick and how to either bring Him down or bring Him to their side

- Luke tells us that the Pharisees were immediately bothered by the fact that Jesus didn't bother to wash ceremonially before the meal

  - What was this ceremonially washing all about anyway?

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- Well, as the name implies it was a ceremony
  - It was not merely washing hands to remove germs – they didn't even know about germs or the transmission of disease
- The custom that had grown up in the Jewish culture was to engage in a ceremonial washing procedure before eating
- Mark describes it this way in his gospel

Mark 7:3 (For the Pharisees and all the Jews do not eat unless they carefully wash their hands, *thus* observing the traditions of the elders;
Mark 7:4 and *when they come* from the ma rket place, they do not eat unless they cleanse themselves; and there are many other things which they have received in order to observe, such as the washing of cups and pitchers and copper pots.)

- Notice that Mark says this was the tradition of the elders
  - This was not a part of the law – meaning this was not God's rule
    - Like most of the Pharisees rules, it was a man made rule
  - It's purpose was to demonstrate piety
    - But more specifically, it was a symbolic way to demonstrate that the person was sinful and required cleansing
      - In fact, the word used here for washing is baptizo in the Greek
      - It reflects the same sense of washing away spiritual impurities
  - This was something the elders had established because it offered them an opportunity to demonstrate righteousness through their works
  - It had become an act of piety, a work of the flesh that was not accompanied by any true repentance or desire to appeal to God
- So when the Jewish religious leaders invited Jesus to eat with them, they naturally Jesus to follow the customs of the day
  - Jesus promptly ignores the ceremonial washing and proceeds to recline at the table

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- The Pharisees look upon him in amazement and wonder why He didn't wash
  - So, why didn't Jesus wash?
  - Was He just trying to provoke the Pharisees?
  - Perhaps Jesus avoided participating in the washing merely to bait the Pharisees into accusing Him?
- The answer would be no, that's not the reason

- The reason has to do first with the fact that the practice is a rule of men, not of God, and as such held no value spiritually
  - God provided ceremonial cleansing under the Law at various times and for various reasons
    - For example:

Ex. 30:17 ¶ The LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 30:18 "You shall also make a laver of bronze, with its base of bronze, for washing; and you shall put it between the tent of meeting and the altar, and you shall put water in it.
Ex. 30:19 "Aaron and his sons shall wash their hands and their feet from it;
Ex. 30:20 when they enter the tent of meeting, they shall wash with water, so that they will not die; or when they approach the altar to minister, by offering up in smoke a fire *sacrifice* to the LORD.
Ex. 30:21 "So they shall wash their hands and their feet, so that they will not die; and it shall be a perpetual statute for them, for Aaron and his descendants throughout their generations."

- The primary reason ceremonial washing exists in the Law is to remind men that they stand before God unclean and in need of purification for their sin
- But the washing the Pharisees are doing here in Luke 11 was not one prescribed by God,
  - This practice had originated by elders, we're told, and for self-serving reasons
  - It was not being used by the Pharisees to remind themselves of their impurities, but rather they were using it demonstrate to others their piety

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- It was an gratuitous act – it was an effort to look pious outwardly without actually being pious inwardly
- The Pharisees were famous for this kind of superficial practice (praying on street corners)

- So Jesus properly ignored this custom, because it was not honoring to God
  - The practice actually stood in opposition to God in that it glorified works over faith

- But there is a second reasons Jesus would ignore this ritual in this particularly situation
  - As the text demonstrates Jesus is about enter into a discourse with the Pharisees over the issue of outward appearances of a man versus the inward reality
    - And in this context, Jesus sends a clear message to this group by His actions
    - Unlike them, His outward actions are a perfect mirror of His inward nature

- What do I mean?
  - Well, remember why God instituted the idea of ceremonial washing
    - It was a symbolic reminder of the need for sin to be removed
    - It didn't actually remove the person's sin, but it stood as an outward sign of repentance on the part of the person
    - And it was an acknowledgement that they were unworthy to approach God apart from His power to forgive – to cleanse – sin
  - Now take Jesus

2Cor. 5:21 He made Him who knew no sin *to be* sin on our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him

1John 3:5 You know that He appeared in order to take away sins; and in Him there is no sin.

- Jesus was without sin of his own

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        - And having no sin, there would be no point for Jesus to wash ceremonially in this way
        - If Jesus did wash, it would be a contradiction
            - His outward actions of washing away sin ceremonially would stand in contradiction to the inward truth that He in fact had no sin to wash away
    - Instead, Jesus chose to act in a consistent manner
        - Since He had no sin inwardly, there was no point in washing away sin outwardly

- Now consider the Pharisees
    - They wash outwardly but without a contrite and repentant heart
    - They wash with a prideful expectation that their self-righteousness would be acknowledged by men
        - They are communicating to the world that they are sinful and in need of God's forgiveness
        - Because if that was truly what was on their hearts, their actions would reflect that belief

Luke 6:45 "The good man out of the good treasure of his heart brings forth what is good; and the evil *man* out of the evil *treasure* brings forth what is evil; for his mouth speaks from that which fills his heart.

    - And the Pharisees are consistently seen in scripture demonstrating evil thoughts and intentions, revealing the nature of their hearts
    - And yet while their hearts remain evil and unrepentant, they scrupulously engage in outward washing
    - It's a completely hypocritical practice, and Jesus refuses to join them in their hypocrisy

- In verse 39-44, Jesus responds to their hypocrisy
    - It's especially noteworthy that He uses the word Woe, and specifically they Jesus uses it three times against the Pharisees
        - They number 3 in Scripture is the number of the Godhead

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        - It always represents the person of God or His divine action
        - And Woes are by definition divine judgment
    - So Jesus is declaring God's divine judgment on these men, not only for their personal rejection of Jesus
        - But also for how they have brought down a generation of men and women with themselves
    - He calls them hypocrites
    - He accuses them of worrying about tithing to the point they measured out a tenth of their garden herbs, while neglecting charity and the needs of others
    - He says they love the honor they get from the people for their outward acts of righteousness
    - And He calls them tombs that people unknowingly walk over
        - What Jesus means is that coming in contact with a tomb defiled a Jew
        - And yet these men were so corrupting in their influence, that they were defiling unsuspecting crowds who followed their teaching
        - And in that, they were like hidden graves that defiled people who came into contact with them
- Most insightful of all is the ridiculous picture Jesus paints of their hypocrisy using cups
    - Imagine young people that you have volunteered to do the dishes after dinner
    - And after you finish, you invite the parents to come inspect your work
        - As the parents return to the kitchen they immediately notice all the dishes from dinner sitting on the counter, stacked neatly and ready to be put away
        - They sparkle they're so clean
        - And they begin to praise the work of the children

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- But as the parents approach the stacks of dishes to help put them away, they are surprised to notice that inside every bowl and cup are the remnants of the meal
    - There's uneaten food inside every bowl, there's a swallow of milk in the bottom of every glass
    - What would the reaction of the parents be to this discovery?

- What holds true for cups and dishes is also true for human beings spiritually
    - Its possible for men in their own effort and by their own hand clean up the outside
        - We can make ourselves look righteous to the world
        - When viewed from a distance, we can give others the illusion of righteousness
            - When they don't know us very well
            - When we never let down our guard
            - We can act well enough to fool anyone if it's important to us
    - But the best we can hope to achieve is an outward type of cleanliness
        - It's an act, it's merely useless works
        - It gains the praise of men, but the praises of men can't gain us anything on the day we stand before our creator and give account for our life spent on earth
        - Lipstick on a pig

- But unlike the cups, we can't gain access to our inside
    - And the Pharisees had never experienced this inward change
        - They were still filthy inside – full of robbery and wickedness
    - Likewise, I can't clean up myself spiritually
    - I can't change my own nature without the work of the Holy Spirit in my heart

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- The only way to clean up a dirty vocabulary is not to brush your teeth but to cleanse your heart
- I will forever be a pig until the day that God, by faith, changes my nature
- I become a new creation in Christ

- And the old has been put to death and the new has arrived,

2Cor. 5:17 Therefore if anyone is in Christ, *he is* a new creature; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come.

- Clean people before saving them…resist the urge

- In response to Jesus' cutting comments, the lawyers seated around the table pipe in

Luke 11:45 ¶ One of the lawyers *said to Him in reply, "Teacher, when You say this, You insult us too."
Luke 11:46 But He said, "Woe to you lawyers as well! For you weigh men down with burdens hard to bear, while you yourselves will not even touch the burdens with one of your fingers.
Luke 11:47 "Woe to you! For you build the tombs of the prophets, and *it was* your fathers *who* killed them.
Luke 11:48 "So you are witnesses and approve the deeds of your fathers; because it was they who killed them, and you build *their tombs*.
Luke 11:49 "For this reason also the wisdom of God said, 'I will send to them prophets and apostles, and *some* of them they will kill and *some* they will persecute,
Luke 11:50 so that the blood of all the prophets, shed since the foundation of the world, may be charged against this generation,
Luke 11:51 from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the altar and the house *of God*; yes, I tell you, it shall be charged against this generation.'
Luke 11:52 "Woe to you lawyers! For you have taken away the key of knowledge; you yourselves did not enter, and you hindered those who were entering."
Luke 11:53 ¶ When He left there, the scribes and the Pharisees began to be very hostile and to question Him closely on many subjects,
Luke 11:54 plotting against Him to catch *Him* in something He might say.

- My guess is that that lawyer is wishing he had just kept quiet, don't you?

- Actually, the lawyer's comment was intended to distance himself from the Pharisees

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- Though the two groups were distinct, they often acted alike
- And Jesus doesn't let the lawyer disassociate himself from the criticism

- This section is actually the culmination of Jesus' condemnation of the religious leaders in Luke following the official rejection of Jesus ministry
  - In fact, if you were to scan your eyes ahead in the Bible to Chap 12, beginning in verse 1 and continuing verse 10, you'll notice that Jesus begins to go over the heads of the Pharisees and speak directly to the crowds
  - Warning them that they must believe in Him or they will answer for their unbelief
- So here in Chap 11 Jesus is completely His statement of condemnation of the leaders
  - Like with Pharisees, Jesus pronounces three woes on the lawyers
- The first woe Jesus pronounces comes because the lawyers placed burdens on the people
  - In how they interpreted the Law of Moses, the lawyers created countless rules
    - Needless, senseless rules that had no spiritual value whatsoever
    - More importantly, they had the opposite effect
    - They discouraged people, they gave a sense of helplessness
    - They created guilt leading to hopelessness
  - And to make matters worse, the lawyers never even attempted to keep the very rules they lay on others
- There is an important lessons in this for every Christian
  - As believers, we aren't like these lawyers – who were not faithful men
    - But we can make a similar kind of mistake in dealing with our Brothers and Sisters in the Lord
  - We can create rules that have no value for righteousness

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- We can make the mistake of hearing God speak to us about something He wants us to do in obedience to Him
- But then we go too far and assume God wants everyone to do the same thing
- If we continue down that road trying to take away another Christian's liberty according to our own rules, we are acting like these lawyers
    - Burdening men needlessly
    - We need to take great care anytime we declare a rule for living that is not specifically given to us in scripture
    - And that includes taking the OT law and applying it selectively to Christians, since we know the Law of Moses no longer applies to those in Christ – we have died to the law (Rom 7:4)

- Jesus' second Woe on the lawyers credits them with persecuting the prophets to their deaths
    - In past centuries, God sent prophets to the nation of Israel to point out their sin and chastise them back to the path of obedience
    - And in their day, the prophets were persecuted and murdered by the same kind of men as the modern-day lawyers of Jesus day
        - And yet it was the lawyers who took great pride and public praise for maintaining the prophets tombs
        - How ironic that the lawyers would take it upon themselves to preserve the prophets' tombs even though they were exactly the kind of men who would turn their backs on the prophets were they alive today
        - In fact, they are turning their backs on Jesus even now
- To prove their hearts to be false, Jesus foretells how God will send new prophets in their day
    - And just like their fathers did in earlier generations, these lawyers are going to persecute these coming prophets – which we know to be the apostles

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- And in their hypocrisy and hatred of the truth, they will bring judgment on their own heads,
  - In fact, we are told they will be charged with the death of all the prophets from the first martyred prophet, Abel to the last martyred prophet, Zechariahs
  - In past generations as the nation had persecuted and murdered the prophets, God had withheld his judgment against the nation for those sins
  - But now at the rejection of His Son, God would bring his stored wrath down upon this generation for the death of all prophets
  - A wrath that culminated in the destruction of Jerusalem in AD70

- And if we're tempted to think we can't fall into this mistake, think again
  - We may not be murdering prophets, but don't we engage in character assassination of men who speak God's truth
    - Do we always respect what they say and do it?
    - Do we receive their correction with a teachable heart?
    - Or do we shut our ears and stick to our pointless rules?

- Finally the sixth and last woe is the climax
  - It is the chief sin
  - The lawyers (and the Pharisees as well) took away the key of knowledge
  - What is the key Jesus is talking about?
    - The knowledge Jesus is referring to is the knowledge of the truth
      - The knowledge of the Messiah, and of Jesus specifically
    - And so what is the key to that knowledge?
  - Well, considering the role of the lawyer – to interpret the law and Torah generally
    - Yet they distorted the truth of the Word
    - They turned it into a burden that weighed men down

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- So the key that the lawyers took away was the true meaning of the Torah – of God's word given to Israel
    - By robbing the Jewish people of the truth of their scriptures, they have taken away the key of knowledge
    - After all, God had given the nation of Israel the scriptures so that they might know of a Messiah and know Who he was
    - And in taking away that key, they doomed their generation
- Jesus adds that they never entered into that knowledge themselves and they hindered those who were entering

- There is nothing more important to God than His word
    - And what we do with it, what we believe about it will determine everything for each of us in eternity
    - Rather than hinder ourselves and others in how we see and use the Word, lets make sure we always place it above anything else we devote ourselves to in ministry and in our Christian walk

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Luke 12A

- Two weeks ago we ended Chap 11 with Jesus declaring woe on the Pharisees and lawyers
    - Woe is an expression of eternal judgment, which we understood meant that Jesus was condemning these evil men for their hypocrisy
    - And as we move into Chap 12 this week, we'll being with the last two verses of Chap 11 because of how they form a transition to the next discussion

Luke 11:53 ¶ When He left there, the scribes and the Pharisees began to be very hostile and to question Him closely on many subjects,
Luke 11:54 plotting against Him to catch *Him* in something He might say.
Luke 12:1 ¶ Under these circumstances, after so many thousands of people had gathered together that they were stepping on one another, He began saying to His disciples first *of all, "*Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy.
Luke 12:2 "But there is nothing covered up that will not be revealed, and hidden that will not be known.
Luke 12:3 "Accordingly, whatever you have said in the dark will be heard in the light, and what you have whispered in the inner rooms will be proclaimed upon the housetops.

- At the end of Chap 11 and the beginning of Chap 12 there are thousands of people around the Jesus
    - The word for thousands, murias, is translated myriad, which literally means 10,000
    - And like we've seen before, they're pushing and jostling to get close to Jesus
        - They were stepping over one another
        - The word for stepping katapateo which means trampling
        - This is a very excited and anxious crowd – not sitting patiently
        - Then we're told that "under these circumstances" Jesus began saying…

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- The circumstances are important because the disciples were beginning to feel the pressure that they would become accustomed to feeling in the future
    - Their message would bring excitement and confusion
    - And it would bring powerful enemies
        - Look at the end of Chap 11, the Pharisees were even more anxious to trap Jesus
        - Trapping was a serious thing – it meant death
            - The Pharisees had real legal power within Jewish society to prosecute violators of the their law
            - And the penalty could be death
            - This is eventually how the Jewish leaders brought Jesus to death
            - And these disciples were beginning to feel the heat that came with being associated with Jesus
        - And so they had the officials hating them and waiting for them to saying something they could use against them
        - And then there was the crowd of thousands waiting for Jesus to do something dramatic, encouraging Him to break the Pharisees' yoke
    - It's under these circumstances that Jesus begins to teach the disciples
- Jesus begins by telling the disciples to beware the Pharisees leaven, which is hypocrisy
    - It's interesting that Jesus doesn't say beware the Pharisees
        - He doesn't warn them to be worried about the men
        - Only beware of their bad influence, the hypocrisy
        - Jesus says avoid the hypocrisy, which He compares to leaven, or yeast
- Yeast or leaven is often used in scripture as a symbol or picture of something bad that contaminates

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- Now yeast itself isn't a bad thing in real life
  - It's quite useful, in fermentation and for making dough rise
  - But in the Bible it's commonly a picture of sin in some form
    - And just like when I add a small amount of yeast to dough, over time it reproduces itself rapidly and spreads throughout the dough
    - Likewise, sin – or in this case, hypocrisy – starts small but it spreads and infects everyone eventually

- Hypocrisy in this context, by the way, is simply pretending to be something you're not
  - For the Pharisees, hypocrisy meant pretending to love God and God's law and pretending to honor God, while at the same time remaining an enemy of God
    - Their true purpose in what they did was to glorify themselves and win the praises of men
    - The hypocrisy of the Pharisees meant they were condemned to hell because they never repented of their sin

Prov. 28:13 He who conceals his transgressions will not prosper,
But he who confesses and forsakes *them* will find compassion.

- They never repented of trying to earn heaven on the basis of their works – on the contrary, they thought their works would ensure them heaven

  - But what worse, the Pharisees set themselves up as the gold standard among the Jews
    - So other unsuspecting Jews saw everything the Pharisees did as worthy of being mimicked
    - So the unsuspecting Jewish man or woman who desired to reach heaven spent their lives trying to copy the absurd lifestyle of a Pharisee and obey their commands
    - The Pharisees would naturally give birth to a thousands of little Pharisees among the people

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- Just like leaven spreads throughout the dough

- I wish I could say that hypocrisy was a phenomenon unique to the Pharisees in first century Palestine

    - Hypocrisy has always existed in the church and it exists today

Gal. 2:9, James and Cephas and John, who were reputed to be pillars, gave to me and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship, so that we *might go* to the Gentiles and they to the circumcised.
Gal. 2:10 *They* only *asked* us to remember the poor—the very thing I also was eager to do.
Gal. 2:11 ¶ But when Cephas came to Antioch, I opposed him to his face, because he stood condemned.
Gal. 2:12 For prior to the coming of certain men from James, he used to eat with the Gentiles; but when they came, he *began* to withdraw and hold himself aloof, fearing the party of the circumcision.
Gal. 2:13 The rest of the Jews joined him in hypocrisy, with the result that even Barnabas was carried away by their hypocrisy.
Gal. 2:14 But when I saw that they were not straightforward about the truth of the gospel, I said to Cephas in the presence of all, "If you, being a Jew, live like the Gentiles and not like the Jews, how *is it that* you compel the Gentiles to live like Jews?

- Paul got upset at Cephas (Peter) because Peter was practicing hypocrisy

    - Peter knew that the gospel put an end to the law

        - And Peter had begun to put aside the requirements of the law, allowing himself to eat with Gentiles, which he should

    - But when men from James – Christian Jews from Jerusalem – came to visit Antioch, Peter reverted to his prior habits of observing the law and shunning the Gentiles

        - And eventually the other Christian Jews in the Antioch church began to mimic Peters behavior causing a split in the church between gentile and Jew

        - Even Barnabas followed Peter's lead

- Can you imagine how frustrated Paul must have been?

    - He says when he saw that they were not being straightforward with the truth, he confronted Peter in front of everyone

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- Paul shamed him to correct his behavior
- This is a great example of how hypocrisy works
  - It begins with someone wanting to look like something they are not
  - Peter wanted to look like a good Jew to the Jewish men from Jerusalem, even though Peter had already abandoned the Jewish practices under the law
  - So He begins to act in a hypocritical manner
- Then his bad behavior draws other with him, like Jesus said.
  - It's like leaven spreading throughout the dough
- But how do we fix hypocrisy?
  - Do we hide the truth? Do we shrink, back to avoid confrontation
  - We shouldn't – we should do as Paul and root out hypocrisy
- Because the same danger exists today as it did in Paul's day
  - If we don't stop hypocrisy whenever it rears it's ugly head, it will infect a church body and drag it down
  - But one day, all that falseness will be stripped away and the truth will be known

- And that's what Jesus reminds the disciples about
  - Jesus starts by saying there is nothing covered up that will not be revealed or made known
    - Jesus has said this same thing to the disciples once before, immediately after the parable of the sower and the seeds
      - Listen to it again from that chapter

Luke 8:16 ¶ "Now no one after lighting a lamp covers it over with a container, or puts it under a bed; but he puts it on a lampstand, so that those who come in may see the light.
Luke 8:17 "For nothing is hidden that will not become evident, nor *anything* secret that will not be known and come to light.
Luke 8:18 "So take care how you listen; for whoever has, to him *more* shall be given; and whoever does not have, even what he thinks he has shall be taken away from him."

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- Seeing that statement in this context helps us understand what Jesus is talking about here as well
  - Back in Chap 8 Jesus was reminding the disciples to commit themselves to maturing in their faith and producing seed, meaning reproducing their faith in others through the Word of God
  - And Jesus says that they understand that they are working toward a greater reward in eternity,
    - For they can't forget that in the day of judgment everything they have done will be brought to light – both the good and bad
    - And they can expect to be rewarded on the basis of what they have done with what God has given them
- So here again Jesus uses that phrase, but now from the negative perspective
  - That everything the Pharisees have done in hypocrisy – hiding their true nature while pretending to be the most holy men around – will be shown for what it is

- Then Jesus moves beyond that thought into verse three and says that what they are too afraid to speak except in private, they should be willing to proclaim boldly from housetops
  - Matt's gospel puts it this way

Matt. 10:27 "What I tell you in the darkness, speak in the light; and what you hear *whispered* in *your* ear, proclaim upon the housetops.

- In other words, Jesus is encouraging them to speak boldly what they know to be true – especially in the face of the Pharisee's hypocrisy and opposition
  - And just so they know they can do so without fear, look at what Jesus says next

Luke 12:4 ¶ "I say to you, My friends, do not be afraid of those who kill the body and after that have no more that they can do.
Luke 12:5 "But I will warn you whom to fear: fear the One who, after He has killed, has authority to cast into hell; yes, I tell you, fear Him!

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Luke 12:6 "Are not five sparrows sold for two cents? *Yet* not one of them is forgotten before God.
Luke 12:7 "Indeed, the very hairs of your head are all numbered. Do not fear; you are more valuable than many sparrows.

- These verses are so tender and encouraging
    - In fact, this is one of the few places in the Gospels where Jesus addresses the disciples as friends
    - He's speaking to them as a friend telling them something they can trust in and be comforted by
- Jesus tells them not to fear those who would kill the body, but fear God
    - Why is it important not to fear those who can kill us?
        - Isn't it natural to be afraid of someone who can harm our body?
        - Yes it's natural but it's damaging
            - Here's why…fear leads us to do stupid things
            - Whatever we are most afraid of will usually determine how we act
        - For example, if a person was faced with a choice of arriving to late for work or getting a speeding ticket trying to race to work on time, they would probably choose to arrive late to work because they are more afraid of the speeding ticket
            - Unless this the 4th time they've been late and they're sure they'll be fired if they arrive late this time – so they speed and take their chances at getting a speeding ticket
        - Whatever we fear the most, will rule our behavior
- Knowing that, Jesus tells the disciples to fear God not men
    - Because though men might kill the body, but that's the limit of their authority
        - But God, after He has taken your earthly life Has authority over your spirit as well

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        - That's the one you should fear
        - Let His ways and His expectations rule your behavior and not men's
            - This is what we mean by fearing God – respecting His power and authority so much that nothing on earth can rule our behavior
    - I like the way Jesus puts this statement
        - He says fear the One who after He has killed the body, can cast you into Hell
            - He reminds us that the death of the body is actually under God's control
            - So even when we are tempted to fear men, we need to remember that it is God who holds the power of life and death
            - And we won't die until God permits
            - So we have no reason to fear men

- Now if Jesus' words don't strike you as very comforting just yet, well let's remember the rest of the verses I read
    - Jesus tells the disciples that even something as a sparrow, as little as a sparrow is worth, God does not forget even one of them
        - Can you imagine that?
        - How incredible is God's power? How could we ever hope to understand it?
        - There must be billions of sparrows on the earth, and yet God knows all of them
            - And if He knows all the sparrows, He knows all the other billions of animals on the earth and in the sea
            - And all these were created for you and I to enjoy and benefit from
        - So certainly God knows each person

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- More than knowing each person, He knows each hair on the head of each person

- So don't be afraid to serve Him and do as He asks, because you have nothing to fear if God knows you and cares for you

- Are we all living like that? Are we living the way Jesus is telling His disciples to live?

    - Do we ignore outside pressure from the world so we can be free to follow the Lord's leading in our lives?

    - And by outside pressure, I mean the pressure to succeed, to make a good living, to save for retirement,

        - Would it challenge you if I proposed that trying to to fit into the suburban lifestyle that typifies the American dream – a good income, two cars, 2.5 children, IRAs, 401Ks, etc., etc. – would it bother you if I suggested that this is exactly what giving into fear looks like

            - It certainly isn't fear of God that produced this pattern, because it's exactly the same pattern that the unbelieving world follows

            - So either we're doing it too because God just happened to ask us to live a life that looks very much like the unbelieving world

            - Or, we're living in fear of what the world fears rather than living in fear of God

        - Because if we truly feared God more than what the world feared, wouldn't our lives look radically different?

        - Wouldn't we be doing crazy things in the world's eyes?

            - Like not spending time so much time worrying about retirement or trying to accumulate more wealth

            - Or by not being afraid to set aside careers to follow God's direction on our lives

            - Or maybe not being afraid to stand on a street corner and declare the gospel to strangers who pass by

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- You see, that's what Jesus was most concerned about for the disciples
    - He was concerned that the hypocrisy of the Pharisees would slowly creep into their own view of the world
    - And the next thing you know, they're living just like the word, mimicking the Pharisees and the rest of the world
    - Rather than risking death so that they might spread the good news in face of fierce opposition by the enemy
    - So to spur them onward, Jesus reminds them who to fear and who to serve
- Then Jesus says

Luke 12:8 ¶ "And I say to you, everyone who confesses Me before men, the Son of Man will confess him also before the angels of God;
Luke 12:9 but he who denies Me before men will be denied before the angels of God. him; but he who blasphemes against the Holy Spirit, it will not be forgiven him.
Luke 12:11 "When they bring you before the synagogues and the rulers and the authorities, do not worry about how or what you are to speak in your defense, or what you are to say;
Luke 12:12 for the Holy Spirit will teach you in that very hour what you ought to say."

- The reason Jesus wants these men to stand firm and do the work of the ministry despite opposition and despite fearful circumstances is because the stakes are so high
    - Those who confess Christ will be saved and those who deny Him will be condemned
        - And these men had been given the privilege and the responsibility to carry that message to the world
    - And just as we have studied earlier, those in Jesus day who stood with the Pharisees and accused Jesus of being Satan, we're never to receive a second chance to believe
        - Rather, they had blasphemed the Holy Spirit and could not be forgiven
- These were the stakes

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- And to make sure the disciples understood how serious things would be for them in this mission, Jesus ends with this sobering comment
  - They would be persecuted
  - They would be accused by the Pharisees
  - They would be dragged into court
  - And they would be condemned to death by these evil men
- But the Holy Spirit will give them the proper words, according to God's purpose and His will
  - So don't fear men – but serve God

- The stakes are the same for us today – truly
  - I'd love to say you won't be hauled into court for the sake of Christ, but I can't – not even in the US – not any longer
    - But regardless of whether the kind of persecution we face is different or not, I can tell you that we are no different than the apostles in terms of the mission we have been given
    - If we don't appreciate that we are expected – we are required – to carry the message of the gospel far and wide continually in all we do
      - Then we are guilty of fearing men more than fearing God
      - Because that is Christ's expectation for His church, that we would bring the good news to the world
    - We are not in control of who believes, but we are accountable for what we did in this life with the gifts and calling God gives us
  - And as Jesus told the disciples, when we encounter difficult moments because of efforts to spread our faith, the Holy Spirit will guide us in what to say
    - And we can trust God who has numbered the hairs on our head to care for us according to His will for our lives

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Luke 12B

- Today we leave the larger discussion of the Pharisees' rejection of Jesus and their negative influence on the people
    - For the rest of Chap 12 and into Chap 13 Jesus turns toward an important topic
    - In fact, this is one topic that receives the most attention in the gospels of any single earthly issue – the issue of pursing wealth and security
    - And if there is a more relevant topic for today's church, I don't know what it is
- We begin in verse 13 as Jesus is interrupted by a man asking Jesus to settle a family dispute

Luke 12:13 ¶ Someone in the crowd said to Him, "Teacher, tell my brother to divide the *family* inheritance with me."
Luke 12:14 But He said to him, "Man, who appointed Me a judge or arbitrator over you?"
Luke 12:15 Then He said to them, "Beware, and be on your guard against every form of greed; for not *even* when one has an abundance does his life consist of his possessions."

- As a respected Rabbi or Teacher, Jesus was expected to be able to answer life's difficult questions,
    - So when someone was embroiled in a dispute of some kind, it was common for the complaint to be brought before a Rabbi asking for a ruling
    - The teacher didn't have authority to actually compel the parties to do anything
    - But if the teacher was respected, his opinion could carry significant weight and be very persuasive in settling the dispute
- This man approaches Jesus and ask Jesus to side with him in a family dispute over an inheritance
    - Take note with me of a couple of important details

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- First, the man is seeking to bring Jesus into this matter on the basis that he assumes that Jesus has authority that his brother will respect
    - The man must ascribe some sort of authority to Jesus, otherwise why would he expect Jesus' opinion to have any effect on his brother's decisions
    - Obviously, the man hopes Jesus will agree with the man's interpretation of the facts, and order the brother to split the family inheritance
    - Which means that this man has reason to expect his brother to do what Jesus says
    - He sees Jesus as having authority

- The second thing to note is that the subject of the man's concern is wealth
    - Apparently, the man's father had died, and the brother had gained control of the family wealth and was refusing to share it
    - So the man is appealing for Jesus to help him gain the wealth he has been cheated out of
    - And we should add that the request is legitimate, in that it sounds like he has a reasonable complaint against his brother

- So what does Jesus say in response to this man's request?
    - Jesus asks the man who appointed me as your judge?
        - It's a clever question, because it draws the man's attention to his assumption about Jesus' authority
        - The question forces the man to consider why it is that he believes Jesus can solve his problem and compel his brother to do anything
        - Just why does the man value Jesus' opinion on this matter?
    - We can only assume by what little the scripture gives us here (only Luke records this story) what the man thinks of Jesus
        - But perhaps the man sees Jesus as an influential teacher who can persuade the religious authorities to bring about justice

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- Or maybe he sees Jesus as a wise man, much like Solomon in his day, someone who can propose a creative solution to break their impasse
- Or maybe he assumes someone with miraculous power to heal like Jesus could cast a spell on his brother to compel him to act
- Or maybe he's just desperate to seek allies from anywhere in his battle against his brother

- But even if none of those possibilities is true, one thing we know for certain
  - The man did not approach Jesus as the Messiah, the Christ, as God

- Ironically, Jesus says the man wants Jesus to act as his judge
  - It's ironic because Jesus is the judge of the world

John 5:22 "For not even the Father judges anyone, but He has given all judgment to the Son,

Acts 10:42 "And He ordered us to preach to the people, and solemnly to testify that this is the One who has been appointed by God as Judge of the living and the dead.

  - But the irony here is that the man has asked Jesus to be his judge in this earthly matter and yet at the same time the man doesn't recognize Jesus as the true and righteous judge of heaven and earth

- It would be very easy for us to look down on this man with scorn for how he diminished Jesus' significance to that of merely a small claim court judge
  - As his soul is perishing for lack of faith, he's worried about how much wealth he can accumulate in his lifetime
    - And his only interest in Jesus is for what Jesus can help him get in this life
  - We shouldn't race by this moment too quickly without first examining ourselves at least a little
    - Because this is the perhaps the chief mistake of our generation, if not of all generations

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- Many have heard of Jesus, they may have even been raised in a family who attended church regularly
- Yet their perspective of who Jesus is and what they can expect from a relationship with Him is completely self centered

- Our culture has largely reduced Jesus to nothing more than a genie in a bottle
  - When we need something miraculous, something that will meet our desires for comfort or security or something that builds our ego or takes away adversity, then we rub the bottle and poof, we expect Jesus to come to our aid
    - And when this formula doesn't work the way we expect, we're told that it's our fault
    - We never stop to think that it wasn't God's will that he indulge our selfish desires
    - No, we're told we didn't rub the bottle right
      - We didn't pray right, we didn't have enough faith, we didn't repent of some hidden sin
      - So we try harder next time, expecting better results
  - And in between these moments of need, we expect Jesus to stay inside that bottle and leave us alone
    - We don't want to think about changing our lives or our desires
    - We aren't interested in what He has to say about sacrificing of ourselves in service to God
    - We don't want to know about the need to endure trials in joy
    - We can't stand the thought of forsaking the world for the chance to earn treasure in heaven

- We might want to dismiss this man as just another unbeliever blind to the truth, but consider who Jesus is taking to when he speaks in verse 15
  - Jesus transitions into a warning of greed,

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- And if you jump down to verse 41, it's apparent that even Peter was swift enough to pick up on the fact that Jesus has His disciples in mind as he delivers His lecture on greed and wealth
    - And He has you and me in mind in these verses too
    - The poor unfortunate man who asked Jesus the question is merely the first casualty here, but Jesus begins to work on every heart in the crowd with His response

- Jesus says that life does not consist of what we accumulate in this world – we are not our possessions
    - This fact remains true even if we have an abundance – some might say this is <u>especially</u> true if we have an abundance
    - If I asked you to define greed, how would you define it?
        - The truth is most people simply think a greedy person is someone who gets more than they do
            - There's one piece of pie left, and someone eats it before we can take it
            - That person was greedy
            - The neighbor has a fruit tree in the back yard, but won't allow you pick any of his fruit
            - Clearly, he's greedy
        - That's the wrong definition of greed
            - The Biblical definition of greed is probably best found in Ps 10:

Psa. 10:3 ¶ For the wicked boasts of his heart's desire,
And the greedy man curses *and* spurns the LORD.
Psa. 10:4 The wicked, in the haughtiness of his countenance, does not seek *Him*.
All his thoughts are, "There is no God."

- The picture of greed given in the Bible is someone who spurns the Lord and does not seek Him
- His thoughts are that there is no God

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- Put simply, we are greedy when we want more than what God intends for us to have
- The best example out of scripture is the nation of Israel in the desert
  - God was providing them with all they needed, but they were greedy and wanted more

Num. 11:4 ¶ The rabble who were among them had greedy desires; and also the sons of Israel wept again and said, "Who will give us meat to eat?
Num. 11:5 "We remember the fish which we used to eat free in Egypt, the cucumbers and the melons and the leeks and the onions and the garlic,
Num. 11:6 but now our appetite is gone. There is nothing at all to look at except this manna."

- God answered that greed with a month of meat, until they had meat coming out of the nostrils, scripture tells us
- It was greed that led them to want more than what God had determined to provide them
  - This is what scripture means when it tell us to be content

Heb. 13:5 *Make sure that* your character is free from the love of money, being content with what you have; for He Himself has said, "I WILL NEVER DESERT YOU, NOR WILL I EVER FORSAKE YOU,"
Heb. 13:6 so that we confidently say,
"THE LORD IS MY HELPER, I WILL NOT BE AFRAID.
WHAT WILL MAN DO TO ME?"

- The man who addressed Jesus was not content with what God had seen fit to give him
  - He felt that his loss of the inheritance had to be rectified
  - It left him without something he had coming to him, and he was determined to get what he had coming
    - Now there was nothing wrong with him receiving part of his father's estate
    - The problem was in the effort he was expending in trying to get what he thought was his

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- Rather than saying what the writer of Hebrews said (verse 6)
- He was preoccupied with obtaining the wealth that had been denied him
- He was so preoccupied with that wealth, that when he stood before the Son of God, he wasn't asking about eternal life or how to reach heaven
    - He was asking for Jesus to help him obtain wealth
    - His preoccupation with the wealth of this world had blinded him to the need to pursue true lasting riches

- And this is not just a problem of unbelievers….believers are increasingly losing any distinction in the issue of wealth
    - We have become the world: same goals, same lifestyle, same desires, same pursuits
    - And just like the unbelieving world, we're senselessly storing wealth up in earth rather than heaven
        - Don't we understand…it's a matter of limited time, limited energy, limited opportunities
        - We only have so much time on this earth and if we use that time accumulating earthly wealth, we've wasted our time

- Look where Jesus goes next:

Luke 12:16 And He told them a parable, saying, "The land of a rich man was very productive.
Luke 12:17 "And he began reasoning to himself, saying, 'What shall I do, since I have no place to store my crops?'
Luke 12:18 "Then he said, 'This is what I will do: I will tear down my barns and build larger ones, and there I will store all my grain and my goods.
Luke 12:19 'And I will say to my soul, "Soul, you have many goods laid up for many years *to come*; take your ease, eat, drink *and* be merry."'
Luke 12:20 "But God said to him, 'You fool! This *very* night your soul is required of you; and *now* who will own what you have prepared?'
Luke 12:21 "So is the man who stores up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God."

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- This farmer is blessed with the ability to produce more than he needs
    - His farm land produces in abundance
    - And with such abundance, you would expect that his life was carefree
        - He would have had the freedom not to worry about income or provision
        - He should have had so much time to serve God and use his wealth to further God's work
    - But instead what did this do with the abundance?
        - He worried about it, he spent more time trying to figure out how to store it
        - So he wasted how many additional years planning and building warehouses to store the excess of what he received
            - What does it mean when we hoard and store the excess of what God provides?
            - It could mean we are so untrusting of God's promise to provide, that we feel the need to create a little insurance of our own
            - Insurance against the possibility that God might not keep His promise to provide
        - And some might say, Steve what about Joseph? He stored up what God gave Him?
            - True, but he also had a specific instruction from God to do so
            - And when the famine was over, he stopped hoarding and storing because He trusted God to provide
            - Unless we've had a dream lately with lean cows and withered stalks of grain, we shouldn't use Joseph as our excuse
- And the tragic ending of the parable simple points out the foolishness this man's wasted time

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- Once he achieves his life goal of creating a storehouse filled with enough wealth to ensure he will always be comfortable, God takes his soul off the earth
    - The man wasted his whole life serving himself because he didn't trust the Lord for a provision enough to let go and spend his time serving Him
    - And the irony or ironies, the moment he had finally achieved security, he loses his life
    - Jesus says that the man who stores us treasure for himself in this way is not rich toward God
    - No, he's a fool (definition in Ps 14 is someone who disregards God)
- Could we ever count the number of people who waste their entire lives amassing a huge retirement account only to leave it to their kids
    - And when we stand before Christ on our judgment day and He evaluates our work for His glory and His kingdom, how much credit do you think we're going to get for leaving our kids a big inheritance
- But what if we spent every day God gave us on earth serving Him, without a minute's thought to how we would find food or clothing?
    - Can we even imagine how amazing that kind of life would be?
    - Or to be sure, we'd probably have a less impressive house, car, clothes, 401K
    - But on the other hand, think about how content we would be? Think about how rich we would be in eternal blessing? Think about how pleased our Lord would be.

- But right about now, reality hits us again
    - Our fear returns
        - We ask ourselves can I just walk away from my job?
            - Well, did Jesus say walk away from a job? Or our house? Or our savings?

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- No, but He says don't let the decisions you make in your life be determined by those things
    - They are not what matters in life
    - Life is made meaningful by our opportunities to know and serve the Lord
    - And if we're too busy trying to accumulate those other things, we won't have time or energy or interest in doing what God wants

- Jesus emphasizes the need to let go and trust God in the next verses

Luke 12:22 ¶ And He said to His disciples, "For this reason I say to you, do not worry about *your* life, *as to* what you will eat; nor for your body, *as to* what you will put on.
Luke 12:23 "For life is more than food, and the body more than clothing.
Luke 12:24 "Consider the ravens, for they neither sow nor reap; they have no storeroom nor barn, and *yet* God feeds them; how much more valuable you are than the birds!
Luke 12:25 "And which of you by worrying can add a *single* hour to his life's span?
Luke 12:26 "If then you cannot do even a very little thing, why do you worry about other matters?
Luke 12:27 "Consider the lilies, how they grow: they neither toil nor spin; but I tell you, not even Solomon in all his glory clothed himself like one of these.
Luke 12:28 "But if God so clothes the grass in the field, which is *alive* today and tomorrow is thrown into the furnace, how much more *will He clothe* you? You men of little faith!
Luke 12:29 "And do not seek what you will eat and what you will drink, and do not keep worrying.
Luke 12:30 "For all these things the nations of the world eagerly seek; but your Father knows that you need these things.
Luke 12:31 "But seek His kingdom, and these things will be added to you.

- Jesus begins, "For this reason…"
    - For what reason?
    - For the reason mentioned in the preceding verses
        - The man who spends the time God gives him on this earth storing up treasure for himself is not rich toward God
        - He is not devoted to God's desires and God's glory but his only desires and his own glory

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- For that reason, don't worry about your life
  - Meaning, don't worry about where your ability to provide for yourself and your family is coming from
  - Stop worrying about it…now…Stop right now.
  - Because if we keep worrying, we have returned to what the man in the parable was doing
  - We have returned to serving ourselves instead of God
    - Remember what we said last week, whatever we fear most will determine our behavior
    - And if we fear that God will not provide, then we begin to fear poverty, financial insecurity, the inability to fund a four-year degree for each and every child, etc., etc.
    - But instead, serve God and leave it to Him to take cvare of those provisions

- And just in case we should start to doubt whether God is capable of providing our needs, Jesus makes an argument of logic called from the lesser to greater
  - He says first thing to get straight is aren't in as much control as you think you are
    - All this worrying we're doing to ensure we have enough money, and enough stuff and a big enough house to put it all in isn't doing what we think it is
    - Think about the farmer…God had ensured that his land would provide an abundance, so what did his hoarding really accomplish? Nothing more than he would have had anyway by the hand of God
      - Meanwhile, he wasted his life storing up grain that just rotted when he died
    - God is in control, and no matter what we do, we'll only achieve what He wants allows us to achieve
  - So point number 1 is we aren't achieving even what we think we're achieving when we worry about our earthly needs

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- Secondly, Jesus says you can know that God will provide because He is faithfully providing everyday for billions of creatures far less valuable to Him than you and I are
    - He feeds billions of birds everyday, though not a single one has lifted a finger to a plan for tomorrow
    - He brings new flowers every year, clothed in wondrous beauty, without then working a day to make it happen
    - He covers fields with a blanket of grass only to have it collected and burned, so won't He at least clothe the bodies of His beloved children?
        - And when we nod our heads to these verse and agree in our hearts that our God is faithful to keep His word
        - But then we leave this place and return to our daily worry for those very things, what does it say about our willingness to trust our Lord
            - How foolish will we feel the day we stand before Him as we finally grasp the truth of His promise to provide and we reflect on how much our life we wasted by not living according to that promise
- Finally, in the last verse we read today Jesus delivers one of the single most important truths we could ever hope to understand in our walk on this earth
    - If we will spend our time and energy seeking His kingdom
        - Seeking it first within ourselves as we study His word, learning His character and nature and listening to the counsel of the Holy Spirit
        - Then seeking it in our world, by our words, our priorities our choices, where we spend our time and energy
    - Then He will add to our lives all those basic things we need
        - He will bring us the food we need, the housing we need, the clothing we need
        - He may not bring us the mansion on the water, He may not give us filet mignon for every meal, He may not bring us designer jeans and the latest toys

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- But He'll bring us contentment and He'll bring us peace beyond anything we could hope to achieve through those material things
- And he will reward us in His kingdom

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Luke 12C

- Last week Jesus transitioned into an extended discussion of the dangerous of wealth
    - It was the compliment to His earlier teaching on the distractions of fear
    - Now's He's begun addressing the pitfall of being rich in earthly terms while at the same time being poor toward God
        - Of worrying so much about our material needs that we become distracted in the doing the spiritual work of serving God and serving the work of the gospel
        - Of saving dollars instead of saving souls

One Sunday a pastor told the congregation that the church needed some extra money and asked the people to prayerfully consider giving a little extra in the offering plate. He said that whoever gave the most would be able to pick out three hymns. After the offering plates were passed, the pastor glanced down and noticed that someone had placed a $1,000 bill in the offering. He was so excited that he immediately shared his joy with his congregation and said he'd like to personally thank the person who placed the money in the plate. A very quiet, elderly, saintly lady all the way in the back shyly raised her hand. The pastor asked her to come to the front. Slowly she made her way to the pastor. He told her how wonderful it was that she gave so much and in thanksgiving asked her to pick out three hymns. Her eyes brightened as she looked over the congregation, pointed to the three handsomest men in the building and said, "I'll take him and him and him!"

- If you want to sum up the verses we studied last week, Jesus said:
    - When His disciples – you and I – are distracted by how much wealth we can accumulate, we waste our time, eternally speaking
    - Because everything we're working for God will gladly provide in some measure, according to our needs
    - Meanwhile, our seeking of wealth accomplishes nothing meaningful
        - And we risk losing so much more eternally

- There's an old phrase we've all used at some point in the past
    - We trot it out anytime we encounter into someone who would rather store up their wealth than put it to use

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- We say "you can't take it with you"
  - Meaning you can't take your money with you when you die, so why collect it but never use it? What good will it be to you after you die?
  - In fact, the Bible teaches that not only is the love of money the root of all evil (1 Tim 6) but even the storing up of wealth is a sin

Eccl. 5:10 ¶ He who loves money will not be satisfied with money, nor he who loves abundance *with its* income. This too is vanity.
Eccl. 5:11 When good things increase, those who consume them increase. So what is the advantage to their owners except to look on?
Eccl. 5:12 The sleep of the working man is pleasant, whether he eats little or much; but the full stomach of the rich man does not allow him to sleep.
Eccl. 5:13 ¶ There is a grievous evil *which* I have seen under the sun: riches being hoarded by their owner to his hurt.

- Last week, Jesus said to His disciples:

Luke 12:31 "But seek His kingdom...

- Seek His kingdom? Isn't that what I'm doing, they probably asked?
  - The disciples understood the meaning of kingdom – the promised kingdom of God on earth when the Christ would lead the nation of Israel over all the nations of the earth
    - The kingdom when the promises to Abraham would be fulfilled
    - The kingdom when all true sons of Israel would reign with Christ and receive their rewards for faithfulness
  - So Jesus says seek the kingdom and all the earthly necessities would come their way by God's hand
    - Probably the part that concerned the disciples the most as Jesus spoke these words was the prospect that they might miss the kingdom
      - After all, Jesus said seek the kingdom – does this mean they might miss it? Is it possible they might miss the kingdom, they wondered?

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- Jesus knew their concerns, and His next statements seem designed to address those concerns a bit

Luke 12:32 "Do not be afraid, little flock, for your Father has chosen gladly to give you the kingdom.
Luke 12:33 ¶ "Sell your possessions and give to charity; make yourselves money belts which do not wear out, an unfailing treasure in heaven, where no thief comes near nor moth destroys.
Luke 12:34 "For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.
Luke 12:35 ¶ "Be dressed in readiness, and *keep* your lamps lit.
Luke 12:36 "Be like men who are waiting for their master when he returns from the wedding feast, so that they may immediately open *the door* to him when he comes and knocks.
Luke 12:37 "Blessed are those slaves whom the master will find on the alert when he comes; truly I say to you, that he will gird himself *to serve*, and have them recline *at the table,* and will come up and wait on them.
Luke 12:38 "Whether he comes in the second watch, or even in the third, and finds *them* so, blessed are those *slaves*.
Luke 12:39 ¶ "But be sure of this, that if the head of the house had known at what hour the thief was coming, he would not have allowed his house to be broken into.
Luke 12:40 "You too, be ready; for the Son of Man is coming at an hour that you do not expect."

- Jesus moves immediate from His statement about seeking the kingdom to reassuring the disciples
    - He says do not be afraid – do not be afraid about whether the kingdom will be yours –
        - Because God has chosen to give it to them and to all those He gives the gift of faith
        - The kingdom will come and they will be in it
    - In other words, the point here of Jesus' teaching is not how to obtain salvation, but rather the point here is having been saved, how are you spending your time while you await the kingdom
- So if the kingdom is already assured, then Jesus challenges the disciples to sell their possessions and give the wealth to charity
    - From the context it's obvious that Jesus isn't demanding that we abstain from owning anything as a prerequisite for pleasing God
        - Rather, we must not be owned by what we have

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        - We must not be distracted by what we have, especially if we are compelled by our earthly wealth to spend time serving that wealth (obtaining, maintaining, storing, etc.)

            - By the way, you don't have to have a lot of money to be owned by it

        - It would be far better to put them all aside and focus on a different treasure

- We should turn our attention to a different kind of treasure, once that won't fade and isn't temporary

    - A treasure waiting in heaven

        - Look, we all understand the need to work for what we want

        - We are trained as children that we have to earn the things we want

        - Most of our adult lives are spent working to obtain the things of life

    - Jesus isn't trying to change that principle

        - In fact, He's reinforcing it

        - He's telling the disciples make yourselves a money belt

            - The word for make is po-i-eo means to accomplish, produce, to bring forth

            - He's talking about a process of earning – not just sitting around expecting good things to happen

- The solution isn't in pursuing a different, but rather a different object of our desire

    - Before faith came, it made some sense that we would spend our days working for earthly wealth – because that was the only kind of treasure we would ever have

        - Now that we know Christ and look forward to the kingdom of God, our focus should change, the object of our desire should change

        - Our desire should now be to earn treasure in that everlasting kingdom, not in this temporary fallen world

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- For where our treasure is, there our hearts are also
    - Those who serve their earthly desires do not have a heart to serve and please God,
    - Because you cannot serve both God and wealth

- Jesus reinforces this truth with a remarkable parable, probably the clearest teaching on the relationship between our opportunities to serve here and our expectations for reward
    - Jesus uses a familiar relationship, that between a master and slaves
        - The master is always Christ and the slave is usually a believer,
            - Paul calls believers slaves to Christ in 1 Cor 7:22
        - Often parables about masters and slaves will also include a slave who is unbeliever, who is pretending to be a Christian
            - We would call these false disciples Condition 2 Christians from the parable of the sower and the seed
            - The one who looks like a Christian but is truly not'

- In this parable, a master has left his house to attend a wedding feast
    - The mention of the wedding feast is significant for at least two reasons
    - First, it serves as a useful device in the parable because it's responsible for the uncertainty surrounding the masters return
        - Wedding feasts could last a long time (many days), and the exact time of the man's return could not be known in advance
            - The only thing to know for sure is that the longer he's away, the closer is the time of his return
    - The second reason this detail is significant is that the Jewish wedding is a common picture in scripture of the Church's relationship to its groom, Christ
        - And that connection confirms that the relationship between the slaves and the master in this parable is a picture of our relationship with Christ

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- Jesus introduces the parable by giving it's point up front in verse 35
    - Be ready for the masters return
        - Since we are already slaves, already believers, already assured our salvation, then what does "be ready mean"
        - Well, the rest of the parable explains what "being ready" means
    - Jesus starts in verse 36 saying be like this
        - Be like men waiting for the masters return, watchful and ready to open the door
    - Imagine yourself as the master returning after many days away
        - What do you hope to find?
            - You hope to find the slaves working on the tasks you assigned
            - You expect them to be vigilant, attentive to your return
        - We can understand this even as parents
            - Now that our children are older, we will leave them alone in the home for a while
            - When we do, we may leave them with assignments, things to do while we're gone
                - I wonder if they have done what we asked?
            - If we walk in and find nothing done and the children busy in their own pursuits, entertaining themselves, we are disappointed
                - There is much weeping and gnashing of teeth
            - If we return and find the work done and the children anticipating our return, there is much rejoicing
        - The expectations are the same for this master

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- The slaves who have been faithful in this way, Jesus says in verse 37, are going to be well rewarded by the pleased Master
    - Take note the blessing is something out of reason with anything the disciples might have expected
        - The Master will gird himself to serve the servants, waiting on them as they sit around the table
        - Much like a Husband would attend to his precious bride on their wedding day
        - This was a reward beyond anything the disciples could have imagined under the circumstances
    - In verse 38 Jesus adds that this return could happen at any hour (1, 2 or 3 watch)
        - In Jewish society, watches were the night duty of a soldier
            - First watch was 9 pm to midnight
            - Second watch was midnight to 3:00 am
            - And third was 3:00 to sunrise
        - Even if the master were to return at the unlikely hours of 3:00 am, the slaves were to be ready, taking nothing for granted
    - Jesus ends the parable with a surprising statement
        - When the Son of Man finally does return, His return will take everyone by surprise
            - The implication here is that even some believers will have stopped expecting the return to some degree
    - So how do we prepare? The answer is obvious, isn't
        - By treating everyday as if this is the day of our Rapture or our death and spend every hour doing what He asked us to do
        - Don't get distracted by the cares of this perishing world and get caught off guard by your master's return

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- Embarrassed that when he knocked on our door, we were busy entertaining ourselves and pursuing the wealth of this world rather than seeking His kingdom

- This is exactly the reason Jesus embarked on this entire discussion of wealth
  - He is warning his disciples – then and now – that we can't let wealth distract us from our assigned task
    - And like our kids left at home, if we lose sight of the master's imminent return, we get lazy, we get satisfied, we give up trying

- What is the work Christ is expecting us to be doing upon His return?
  - For each of us it will be slightly different, just as we have different walks of life and different spiritual gifts
  - But the unifying quality will always be that we are glorifying God and testifying to His Son is all that we do
    - Perhaps the best verses of scripture to sum up this responsibility are found in Rom 12

Rom. 12:1 ¶ Therefore I urge you, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, *which is* your spiritual service of worship.
Rom. 12:2 And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect.

- Your body, your very life, is to be a sacrifice to God
  - Deny yourself, don't seek what you want, don't be conformed to this world
    - Conforming doesn't just mean in thought
      - The word in Greek means sharing the same form
      - It means pursuing what the world values, patterning your a life after the lifestyle the world values
      - The Bible says don't do that

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- But rather prove in yourself what is the will of God by doing what he wants you to do with your life
- And this act of worship will require a sacrifice – it will not be easy
  - Following God's will over our own will inevitably mean making sacrifices in this world – sacrificing the world's approval, sacrificing the pleasures and comforts and riches of this world

- These are the acts of readiness God is expecting us to pursue as we await His return

- Now the disciples are getting a bit confused
  - Remember, they don't expect that Jesus will be leaving them
    - They assume that Jesus is here to establish kingdom and he intends to remain
    - So to hear him talk about the master leaving confuses them
  - So Peter speaks up and asks in verse 41

Luke 12:41 ¶ Peter said, "Lord, are You addressing this parable to us, or to everyone *else* as well?"

- Peter wants to know if Jesus is only speaking to the disciples here or to the entire crowd
  - He probably whispered this, perhaps a bit embarrassed to admit he wasn't following it
  - Jesus' next statement answers that question

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Luke 12:42 And the Lord said, "Who then is the faithful and sensible steward, whom his master will put in charge of his servants, to give them their rations at the proper time?
Luke 12:43 "Blessed is that slave whom his master finds so doing when he comes.
Luke 12:44 "Truly I say to you that he will put him in charge of all his possessions.
Luke 12:45 "But if that slave says in his heart, 'My master will be a long time in coming,' and begins to beat the slaves, *both* men and women, and to eat and drink and get drunk;
Luke 12:46 the master of that slave will come on a day when he does not expect *him* and at an hour he does not know, and will cut him in pieces, and assign him a place with the unbelievers.
Luke 12:47 "And that slave who knew his master's will and did not get ready or act in accord with his will, will receive many lashes,
Luke 12:48 but the one who did not know *it*, and committed deeds worthy of a flogging, will receive but few. From everyone who has been given much, much will be required; and to whom they entrusted much, of him they will ask all the more.

- Peter wanted to know if Jesus' instructions were unique to the apostles or meant generally to all of Jesus' follows
    - So in His response, Jesus offers the distinctions that Peter was looking for
        - But this situation falls into one of those situations where if you don't want to know the answer, don't ask the question
    - Jesus had been talking to all disciples, but in response to Peter's questions, now Jesus zero's in on leaders
    - Let's study Jesus response, remembering that we're looking at a description of how leaders in the Church will be judged
- Let's begin by mentioning that in Jesus' day, it was common for a master to place one slave over other slaves in authority
    - Typically, this was the most trustworthy and mature slave
        - You can see examples of this elsewhere in scripture
        - Remember Joseph in Potipher's house
    - So Jesus compares the role of apostles – or more generally leaders in the church – to that of a head slave
        - And you notice that the chief responsibility of that leader? To feed the other slaves

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- At the risk of carrying the details of the parable too far, we can say that the chief aim of those who lead God's people is to feed them, to teach them the Word of God
- As Jesus asked of Peter shortly before He ascended
  - Three times Jesus asked Peter if you love me, feed my sheep

- And in the parable, Jesus says that a faithful head of the household will feed the others until Jesus' return

- And the reward for that faithful head of the household will be to have authority over a much greater responsibility in the coming kingdom

- Now, on the other hand, if that one placed in charge acts in an unworthy manner, essentially acting as though the master's return is never going to happen
  - He abuses the other slaves
    - He beats slaves – both men and women – a particularly damning accusation
    - He eats and gets drunk – a complete abuse of power and reckless disregard for his responsibility
  - When the master returns, the head slave will experience a fate equal to unbelievers, meaning this slave is actually an unbeliever
    - A man like the Pharisees of Jesus day
      - Or today, a false teacher leading God's people, as a wolf in sheep's clothing
    - This slave doesn't believe the master will ever return
      - After all, if you believe the master is returning, you would never act this way
  - So the first distinction Jesus makes in his answer to Peter is
    - Between the good leader who feeds God's people and looks forward to His return
    - And the false disciples who abuses God's people and will be justly condemned

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- But then Jesus goes on to make a more compelling and interesting comparison
    - In verse 47, He launches into a slightly new direction
        - We're still talking here about leaders in light of Peter's question
    - Now, however, the distinction is between two leaders in light of what the Master revealed to each of them concerning His will
        - For the first slave, we're told he knew the Master's will
            - In the context of the parable, we're talking about knowing the Master's instructions
            - A leader who clearly understanding the Master's instructions to serve Him in a certain way
            - But for whatever reason, the slave chose to ignore those instructions and was not ready for the masters return
                - This slave will receive discipline
    - It's important to note the difference between this slave and the previous one
        - The previous one beat other slaves and disregarded all responsibility
            - This slave merely neglected his work
        - The first slave was an unbeliever and was judged accordingly
            - The second slave is disciplined, not cast out
    - But most interesting of all, Jesus says there will be leaders who are less informed about their Master's will
        - And they acted exactly like the first slave
            - That's what is meant by the statement "committed deeds worthy of flogging"
            - Just like the first slave who received a slogging for his deeds, this slave committed similar deeds
        - Yet he will receive few

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- Keep in mind this slave is not completely excused for his inaction or unpreparedness
- Merely, he received a lesser discipline

- Jesus sums up the difference between these two disappointing leaders by saying of everyone who is given much, much is expected
    - With this statement, Jesus transitions back to speaking to the crowd and ties the teaching together
        - For leaders, Jesus explains that the more insight one has been given
            - The more skill, the more knowledge, the more responsibility
            - Then the more will be expected of our service
        - And for everyone, this principle holds true as well
            - If we have been given more than others in the Body
                - More opportunity, a greater exposure to and knowledge of scripture
        - Or even those who have been clessed with greater wealth and influence
            - More is expected

- More service, more commitment, more impact for the kingdom
    - More vision, more urgency, more energy, more selflessness, more seriousness, more of whatever God demands to reach the lost and disciple the saved

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Luke 12D

- Today our study in Luke brings us to the conclusion of the first half of the gospel
    - Chapter 12 has been a chapter rich in exhortation
        - It began with Jesus warning the disciples to beware the hypocrisy of the Pharisees
            - Because God knows everything and those who fear men more than God and behave accordingly will one day give an account for that foolish decision
            - And Jesus warned the disciples that they would face persecution from these false men
            - But they should not fear, for God will care for them until they have accomplished what God has ordained
        - Then the chapter took a turn toward a discussion of wealth, and specifically on how our misplaced desires for wealth become an obstacle to serving God
        - Then the teaching turned again toward differences in how servants – believers in others words – are evaluated in their service to the Lord
            - That the more we understand about God's plan for our lives and His will for us, the more responsibility we bear for what we do in response
    - Now this week we conclude the chapter with another turn into a new discussion
        - Doesn't this seem to be a strange mix of commentary from Jesus
            - What's the thread tying it all together? Is there one?
    - Well, we'll look at that today as we conclude Chap 12

Luke 12:49 ¶ "I have come to cast fire upon the earth; and how I wish it were already kindled!
Luke 12:50 "But I have a baptism to undergo, and how distressed I am until it is accomplished!

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- Jesus was teaching on our responsibility to serve faithfully as men and women in ministry
    - Then He abruptly begins to speak about casting fire on earth and a distressing baptism
        - Verse 50 reminds me of my baptism in January in Colorado in a light snow fall
            - As we waited to get into the water, we were huddled under blankets shivering and then we stepped into the slightly warm hot tub only to have to get out and walk through the cold air to the house
            - Standing there freezing I could have repeated verse 50
    - But Jesus isn't referring to His water baptism here
- But actually this transition makes good sense because of what He was teaching in the earlier verses
    - Jesus taught about a master who was to return
        - And as we said last week, the disciples probably had no idea that the master leaving was a picture of Jesus' death and eventual return
        - So in these verse Jesus takes the opportunity to give an extended discussion about His purpose on Earth
- In verse 49, Jesus says He came to cast fire on earth, but the fire is not yet kindled
    - First, the statement implies the fact that the final step to Jesus' ministry could not happen in the disciples' day
        - Jesus has all authority and judgment given Him by the Father
        - And He will exercise that authority by bringing fire to destroy the earth and replace it with a new world absent sin
    - But As Jesus said those words to the disciples, He said the fire had not yet been kindled
        - In other words, the day for the destruction of the earth has not yet come

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John 12:47 "If anyone hears My sayings and does not keep them, I do not judge him; for I did not come to judge the world, but to save the world.

- In fact, in verse 50, Jesus makes clear that He is not looking forward to the baptism He must undergo during this first coming – meaning His death on the cross of course

- Jesus didn't come the first time for judgment, but rather to save the world from sin

  - As obvious as this fact may be to us today, Jesus' words gives us an chance to examine for a moment Christ's purpose in two comings

    - Specifically, why didn't Jesus come the first time to save men and to judge – why didn't He do both at the same coming

    - Why did Jesus have to leave the earth and then promise to return another time

- First, we need to acknowledge it is a conscience effort on God's part to wait

  - Scripture tells us that Jesus Himself is currently upholding the world and everything in it by His power while He waits

Heb. 1:3 And He is the radiance of His glory and the exact representation of His nature, and upholds all things by the word of His power.

  - Were Jesus to cease holding the world together, it would cease to exist

    - It is the supreme demonstration of God's grace, mercy and long suffering nature that He would continue to uphold a world so full of sin and hatred toward God

    - At any point, on the Father's direction, Jesus could remove His upholding power and the world and all that is in it would be cast into the judgment which God's holy justice demands

  - Yet He continues to maintain this evil and unbelieving world

    - And He does so as grace toward us

    - Peter puts it this way:

2Pet. 3:7 But by His word the present heavens and earth are being reserved for fire, kept for the day of judgment and destruction of ungodly men.
2Pet. 3:8 ¶ But do not let this one *fact* escape your notice, beloved, that with the Lord one day is like a thousand years, and a thousand years like one day.

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2Pet. 3:9 The Lord is not slow about His promise, as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing for any to perish but for all to come to repentance.
2Pet. 3:10 But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, in which the heavens will pass away with a roar and the elements will be destroyed with intense heat, and the earth and its works will be burned up.

- This world we're told is being reserved (saved like a treasure) or kept (tereo - guarded) by God for a specific day in the future when it will undergo judgment
    - It requires an active effort by God to even allow the earth to remain in the meantime
    - But one day God will cease to uphold this world, and Jesus will judge it
        - As believers, we will escape that judgment – in fact we will participate with him in judging unbelievers

1Cor. 6:2 Or do you not know that the saints will judge the world? If the world is judged by you, are you not competent *to constitute* the smallest law courts?
1Cor. 6:3 Do you not know that we will judge angels? How much more matters of this life?

    - Those who are unbelievers, on the other hand, will be the recipients of that judgment

- Peter says that while we wait for that day, the day when the fire will be kindled that
    - Some in the last days we will interpret the long wait for His return as a reason for doubt concerning whether He will ever return
        - So Peter reminds us that the wait required for Jesus' return is not a matter of slowness
        - It's not that God is a procrastinator
        - Jesus hasn't forgot to return or changed His mind
    - No, the day for judgment is still just as sure today as it was yesterday
        - So what possible reason does God have for not sending Jesus to return to us right now? Or for that matter, on any day in the past 2,000 years?
        - Why hasn't He already come back?

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- Peter tells us why in verse 9
    - God's delay is grace toward men
    - And specifically, His delay is grace toward those throughout history who are to receive the gift of faith and come to believe
        - Remember, before you and I could believe in Jesus, we had to be born and grow up
        - And before we could be born, our parents had to be born, and our grandparents before them, and so on all the way back to the day of Christ
- Scripture tells us that God's plan for each us began long before we were born
    - In the eternal counsel of His will, He determined the day of our birth and the day of our death
        - But obviously, God's plan requires that He wait for the natural course of history to play out
        - For the birth process to produce the lives of billions of people over thousands of generations
        - Meanwhile, God must hold back Jesus' to return until all those He had purposed be born, repent and believe in Jesus
    - So as Peter teaches, God is not slow about His promises, but rather He is patient wishing that none would perish
        - God is patient toward us, his children, not wanting any of us to miss out on the chance to be born and to believe
        - So God continues to wait while time passes and His plan for believers plays out over the course of history
        - Allowing those who would be His children to be born, come to repentance and believe
    - But knowing this, we must remember that other side of this coin is equally clear
        - On the day when that last man or woman appointed believes, Jesus' waiting will be over and His return will happen

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- And as Peter said, the judgment will follow, complete with fire for the earth

- And as Jesus says in the gospel of Luke, He wishes that the fire had already been kindled

- Then Jesus discourse seems to take yet another turn in moving onto another topic, one of division

Luke 12:51 "Do you suppose that I came to grant peace on earth? I tell you, no, but rather division;
Luke 12:52 for from now on five *members* in one household will be divided, three against two and two against three.
Luke 12:53 "They will be divided, father against son and son against father, mother against daughter and daughter against mother, mother-in-law against daughter-in-law and daughter-in-law against mother-in-law."

- If we pay close attention, we can see how this comment fits with the prior one

- To those who were thinking that Jesus would only come once and then stay, their assumption was that the Messiah's coming was specifically to set up the kingdom of God on earth

- So if Jesus was the Messiah, then peace would reign

  - The kingdom would be established

  - The people of Israel would be united under their king

- But Jesus says if you think I came to grant peace, forget it

  - That's not going to be the result of this visit

  - On the contrary, my visit to the earth this time will produce division

- Jesus gives examples

- From now on, families will seek division over the name of Jesus

  - In a home of 5 there will be 2 on one side and three on the other or three on the one side and two on the other

    - The divisions will run deep

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- Different family members aligned against one another, splitting families

- This, Jesus says, will be the state of life from now on

- Jesus' meaning should be fairly clear to anyone who's been following our teaching through Luke so far

  - The person and work of Jesus produces, requires division

    - You simply can't be on the fence when it comes to assessing who Jesus was and what He did when He died

      - On the one hand, you believe He was who He said He was

        - God in the flesh, the one who made everything in the universe

        - The One with the power to judge everything

        - And when He died, His death on the cross was a perfect payment for our sins before God the Father

        - Believe in Him and be saved from your sins

      - Or believe <u>anything else</u> about Jesus and remain dead in your sin one day to be judged for your sin

        - It's an all or nothing issue

        - And there is no third position

- Did you notice that the example of the family included 5 family members

  - And yet the division was 3 vs 2 or 2 vs 3

    - There was no third group

    - This is a division on the basis of a yes or no question

      - Do you believe in Jesus

      - And this question is so important that it transcends all earthly relationships and bonds

  - That's a measure of the importance of this ministry Jesus was handing to the disciples

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        - So important that even family relationships must take a back seat

- But if we study this carefully, we also note that Jesus isn't saying that we should forget about our obligations to our parents or children

    - Some would misuse these verse to claim that we can abandon unbelieving family members

        - Some cults use verses like this one that way

    - But the issue here is simply the fact of division on the basis of who Jesus is

        - And that division will stand in the way of true peace

        - Rather, there will be disagreements and friction and even hatred over what people believe concerning Jesus

    - But this fact doesn't change our obligations to one another, especially those obligations found in scripture

        - We simply can't let those obligations cause us to step back from our belief in Jesus, even when that belief causes friction or division in our families

- Finally, Jesus turns to his finally topic in this discourse

Luke 12:54 ¶ And He was also saying to the crowds, "When you see a cloud rising in the west, immediately you say, 'A shower is coming,' and so it turns out.
Luke 12:55 "And when *you see* a south wind blowing, you say, 'It will be a hot day,' and it turns out *that way*.
Luke 12:56 "You hypocrites! You know how to analyze the appearance of the earth and the sky, but why do you not analyze this present time?
Luke 12:57 ¶ "And why do you not even on your own initiative judge what is right?
Luke 12:58 "For while you are going with your opponent to appear before the magistrate, on *your* way *there* make an effort to settle with him, so that he may not drag you before the judge, and the judge turn you over to the officer, and the officer throw you into prison.
Luke 12:59 "I say to you, you will not get out of there until you have paid the very last cent."

- This interesting commentary again hinges on the previous line of discussion

    - Jesus just finished saying that His appearance has the effect of bringing division on the basis of what we believe

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- And before that he was telling the crowd that His appearing means that a fiery judgment of the earth is coming soon
    - So what will the crowd makes of these signs?

- So with that, Jesus decides it to place this crowd on the spot
    - He wants to force them to decide how they are going to view Him and His ministry
        - We've seen this before in other places, where Jesus places the crowd, or an individual or the Pharisees on the spot concerning His identity
    - Jesus point is that it's not the hard for them to know that He is the Messiah, if they are only willing to believe the obvious signs
        - Jesus makes his point with the comparison to predicting the weather
            - Jesus says you have become pretty good at predicting the weather
                - You see certain patterns developing in the sky, and you say it's going to rain or that it's going to be a hot day
            - And though you have the ability to understand signs for something as unpredictable and unimportant as weather, but you understand the circumstances of the present time?

- Then Jesus calls them hypocrites
    - This is a hard word
        - It would have been better if Jesus had said you morons
        - Or maybe you blind and deaf
    - No, He says they are hypocrites
        - Remember what a hypocrite was?
            - Someone who pretends to be someone they are not

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- They were pretending to be people who couldn't discern the signs of the day
    - They were pretending to be ignorant of Jesus' claims to be the Messiah
    - They were pretending to be unaware of the importance to receive Him
    - It was as if they cold just pretend to be undecided and they wouldn't be held accountable for their mistake
- It's like the claim of ignorance a driver might make to the policemen when they get pulled over for speeding
    - They didn't know that the speed limit in the neighborhood was only 30 and not the 60 mph they were traveling
    - But the signs were there, the speed limit signs were up
- And when the driver says they didn't see the signs, the policeman smiles and writes the ticket anyway

- Likewise, ignorance will not be an excuse for this generation standing with Jesus and the disciples, because the signs were everywhere
    - And Jesus, who knew their hearts, says that they are hypocrites for claiming to not be able to decide who Jesus was
        - He had just finished teaching on the division His ministry would produce, which by itself implies we all have a choice to make when it comes to the man Jesus
        - Jesus looked squarely at the crowd and said that you can't hide behind your supposed ignorance
            - Either believe or face judgment
    - The problem wasn't in their ability to understand the signs
    - It was in their unwillingness to accept and act upon what they saw
- And just in case any in the crowd were fooling themselves regarding the reality of that judgment,
    - Jesus reminds them of how when they are being called before an earthly judge, they are motivated to make peace with their enemy

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- This is just good sense
  - As they make their way to the judge, they know they are guilty
    - They know that they broke the law and their accuser is going to succeed in making a case against them
    - If they continue in their defiance and opposition to their accuser, they will not succeed in fooling the judge
      - They are going to be found guilty and they are going to pay for their mistake to the full extent of the law
  - And knowing this, the accused is very motivated to escape out from under the penalty of the law
    - So the accused is going to try to negotiate a settlement with the accuser before they reach the judge
    - If they can settle their dispute, then the judge will never need to render judgment

- So Jesus reminds the crowd of this common sense thinking so they might have reason to consider their present circumstances
  - Jesus just taught them that He would be their judge one day
    - And they are the guilty ones, guilty in their sin
    - And Jesus will judge that sin one day, provided they haven't settled their debt beforehand
    - So knowing the signs and realizing who Jesus is, he asks them to apply common sense
      - Settle your debt with me before I return as your judge
    - Otherwise, you will pay the price of your sin, every cent
      - And the price of sin against the living God is an eternal death
  - The problem isn't
  - One of the problems for this crowd and perhaps for us today is that we forget that judgment is sure and unavoidable

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- For that guilty man in Jesus' example, he felt the pressure of the coming judgment, because with each step toward the judge, he was one step closer to receiving his penalty
- The thing for us to remember is that for an unbeliever, their walk through this life is very much the same
  - Each day brings them one day closer to their judgment
  - A judgment that is sure and firm
- But today, they may not realize that they are headed in that direction, so the sense of urgency is not there
  - But it's our responsibility to help bring that sense of urgency and show them the signs
  - Just as Christ does to this crowd in His day

- So how do we put this chapter together
  - Simply put, it's a chapter on discipleship for the apostles, and therefore it's a chapter on discipleship for us as well
    - Jesus began teaching we should be transparent in who we are because God knows everything and will reveal everything in a coming day
    - Therefore, fear God and not men
    - And our fear of God will lead us to serve Him and confess Him before men, testifying to Him
    - And as you turn your back on the world to serve Him, do not fear or worry over your earthly needs
    - And don't become greedy for money, which is itself a sign of fear rather than trust in God
    - At all times, be ready for Jesus return
    - Meanwhile, serve the body of believers faithfully, according to what you've been given
    - For there is a judgment coming, when you will be evaluated for what you've done

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- And ultimately, the unbelievers will be judged, though they are not without the signs to know the truth

- As we suspend our study of Luke for a time, I invite you to consider and meditate over the points I just listed

- Over Chap 12 of Luke

  - As a disciple, as one called to follow Jesus and represent Him to this lost and dying world

  - Can we honestly say we measure up to these expectations?

    - When someone says good discipleship is praying, studying the Bible, going to church, serving others

    - True, but what about the things Jesus told his disciples here?

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Luke 13A

- When I last taught Luke, we ended in Chapter 12
    - Since we had such an extended pause in our study, I want to take a few minutes to review the transition that Luke himself takes to move from Chap 12 to Chap 13;
    - I called Chapter 12 one of the best chapters in the Bible on Christian discipleship
        - Christ taught the disciples on the importance of maintaining the right priorities in life and in ministry
        - On maintaining a steady reliance on God rather than ourselves,
        - On not allowing our fears and worries drive our decisions
        - And if you weren't able to hear our past teaching from Chap 12, I encourage you to listen to a CD and remember the content of that rich chapter
- But the end of that chapter, Jesus' focus changes somewhat, and He begins to speak of the need to recognize signs, and settle our debts, and make a decision
    - For example in 12:54-56, He reminds the crowd why if they can pay close enough attention to the skies to predict coming weather,
        - Then why couldn't they pay enough attention to the signs Jesus was performing to recognize Him as the Messiah?
        - They can't claim ignorance, in other words, because Jesus says they are fully capable of recognizing what they are seeing
        - In fact in verse 56 He calls them hypocrites, which means they are <u>claiming</u> to be ignorant, but in reality they know exactly what the signs they're seeing mean
    - In verse 58 Jesus teaches about a guilty man who's being taken to the judge for his day in court
        - And Jesus says that guilty man knows enough to make amends with his accuser before reaching the judge

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- Otherwise if remains unrepentant to the end, the judge will condemn him for his crime and he's pay the price
- Jesus' story at the end of Chap 12 strongly suggests to the crowd that they are in danger of facing the judge unless they first settle their debts with the one who has a charge against them

- What 's Jesus up to here? What's Jesus expecting this crowd to do?

- Well, this is an interesting discourse and at the end of chapter 12, Luke leaves us hanging with the tension building
  - It's an effective transition into where Luke takes us next in Chapter 13
  - The first half of Chap 13 is unique to Luke – no other gospel provides what Luke provides here
    - So it interesting in that Luke felt a particular need to capture these events in Jesus' ministry while other Gospel writers decided to overlook these events

Luke 13:1 ¶ Now on the same occasion there were some present who reported to Him about the Galileans whose blood Pilate had mixed with their sacrifices.
Luke 13:2 And Jesus said to them, "Do you suppose that these Galileans were *greater* sinners than all *other* Galileans because they suffered this *fate*?
Luke 13:3 "I tell you, no, but unless you repent, you will all likewise perish.
Luke 13:4 "Or do you suppose that those eighteen on whom the tower in Siloam fell and killed them were *worse* culprits than all the men who live in Jerusalem?
Luke 13:5 "I tell you, no, but unless you repent, you will all likewise perish."

- Luke begins chapter 13 with words "on the same occasion"
  - As Luke moves out of Chapter 12 and into Chapter 13, he mentions that some were present who gave a report to Jesus
  - From the text we're left with the impression that as Jesus was teaching, some in the crowd had come down from Jerusalem to where Jesus was at this time (probably still in Samaria)
  - As they arrive, they begin to share the news they brought from Jerusalem with others in the crowd

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- It's unlikely that they arrived for the express purpose of telling this story to Jesus
- More likely, they were simply sharing of their experiences in Jerusalem with those they met in the crowd,
- To include this juicy little detail about Pilate and the Galileans

- But now as Jesus overhears their report, He responds with this intriguing response
  - He disputes the conclusions the crowd had made from what they had heard
  - So to fully appreciate why Jesus said what He did, we must first appreciate what was going on in the minds of the crowd as they heard the story about those poor Galileans

- Let's begin by reviewing who the Galileans are
  - Simply put, Galileans are residents of the Galilee (the land in northern Israel surrounding the Sea of Galilee)
    - Northernmost district of Israel, territories of Zebulin and Naphtali
  - Jesus grew up in the Galilee as did most of the disciples
    - He appeared there to his disciples

- As the story goes, Pilate mixed their blood with the blood of their sacrifices
  - This is a curious event
    - We have no other mention of such an event, either in scripture or elsewhere
    - From the text, we can surmise that these Galileans had traveled to Jerusalem to offer sacrifices
    - This would also mean that the occasion of their death was likely Passover, since only at Passover could a non-priest offer their own sacrifice in the temple
    - And apparently while they were there, they were slain by Roman soldiers under Pilate
    - Thus their blood mixed with the blood of the animals they were sacrificing at the time in the temple

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- Others have taken the speculation to greater degrees, but the safest conclusion we can make is this one

- Of greater importance to us today is why this event was of such interest to this crowd

    - After all, Pilate and other Roman authorities were well known as men who persecuted Jews

    - A death at the hands of Pilate was not very newsworthy

        - In this case the news might have been more interesting because of where they were killed

        - Sacrificing at the Temple during Passover was the single most important religious act of the year for an individual Jew

        - It was the one time when a Jew could personally make amends with God for their sin

        - Failing to observe the Passover carried a strict penalty under God's law

Num. 9:13 'But the man who is clean and is not on a journey, and yet neglects to observe the Passover, that person shall then be cut off from his people, for he did not present the offering of the LORD at its appointed time. That man will bear his sin.

    - So the fact these Galileans were struck down in the midst of a Passover sacrifice might seem to the average Jew to be evidence of a particularly strong rebuke by God Himself

    - To this Jewish crowd it implied that these were particularly sinful men, such that God wouldn't even allow them to sacrifice to Him nor recognize their attempts to atone for their sin

- Now look at Jesus response

    - In verse 2 He asked the crowd:

        - Do you think these Galileans were worse sinners that all other Galileans because of the way they died?

    - Just by the way Jesus asked the question, we learn that the crowd had come to that very conclusion

        - The crowd had assumed that Galileans got what they deserved

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- Why? Simply because of the circumstances of their death
  - Bad things happen to bad people
  - They had somehow brought this kind of tragic end upon themselves
- To them, this relationship between righteousness and circumstances in life was an absolute rule

- The Jewish culture in Jesus' day often saw bad things happening to people as Divine judgment for past sins

- This kind of thinking is wrong for at least two fundamental reasons
  - First, we diminish God's sovereignty
    - We suggest a cause and effect relationship between a person's life and God's plan for that person
    - This is a relationship that doesn't necessarily exist, or at the least, it's a premature judgment about God's ultimate plan for someone
  - Remember in John 9:2 when the disciples questioned Jesus about a man born blind?

John 9:2 And His disciples asked Him, "Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he would be born blind?"
John 9:3 Jesus answered, "*It was* neither *that* this man sinned, nor his parents; but *it was* so that the works of God might be displayed in him.

- This exchange is so interesting because here we have a man born blind
  - So the disciples can't blame his condition on his own sin
  - So instead, they reach even farther back in time and assumed this man's condition can be traced to the sins of the parents
  - But look at Jesus' response then as we consider Jesus' response now
    - He says it had nothing to do with the sins of the parents

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- Rather God made this man blind so that God's mighty works might be displayed in him
- And Jesus then proceeded to heal the man of his blindness
  - Did you ever think about that?
  - For God to reveal Himself through His Son, He desired to have His Son perform miracles of healing
  - But before there could be an opportunity to heal, there must first be infirmity
  - And here Jesus says in no uncertain words that the various infirmities that He encountered were brought about by God to allow opportunity for God's might to be shone through Jesus
- God, in other words, may choose to bring calamity, to bring illness, to bring "bad things" in order that He might receive glory

- Does our view of God leave room for this truth of the Bible?

- What about at Job
  - In one moment he hears that all his children have died, all his herds have been taken and all but three of servants were killed
    - Later he suffers horrible physical ailments, again by God's providence
  - Did it come because of some serious sin in Job's life?
    - Even his friends tried to convince Job that his misfortune must have been because Job did something to anger God
  - But we know it wasn't Job's sin that brought the misfortune
    - It was his righteousness that caused it

Job 1:8 The LORD said to Satan, "Have you considered My servant Job? For there is no one like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, fearing God and turning away from evil."

- When bad things happened to Job, they came at the hand of the enemy, yes, but ultimately they came because God permitted them to happen

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- After all, God was the first one to mention Job to the devil
- And God said the reason that the Devil should focus on Job was due to Job's righteousness
- Is our view of God big enough to accommodate the fact that sometimes God permits bad things to happen to good people merely because it brings Him glory?

- So the first problem with the crowd's thinking is they have cut God out of the picture and created a cause and effect relationship that isn't true – God alone sovereignly determines a man's steps

Prov. 16:9 The mind of man plans his way,
But the LORD directs his steps.
Prov. 20:24 Man's steps are *ordained* by the LORD,
How then can man understand his way?

- The second problem with their thinking is that it makes them a person's judge
  - When we decide someone's poor circumstances are due to their sin, we become the person Jesus was talking about when he said
    - Take the log out of your own eye before you take the splinter out of someone else's eye
  - Flip side…what's more, we have assumed that our own relative lack of misfortune must be because God is pleased with us
    - After all, if we were so bad, God would have brought similar calamity down on our heads too
  - Judging others always brings with it an attitude of superiority
    - Like the parable suggests – I must overlook my own mistakes in order to pick at someone else's
- The best way to avoid falling into the trap is to remember we all have sin and no sin is more worthy of punishment than another
  - None of us is any less deserving of God's displeasure – of God's wrath and ultimately of His judgment – than anyone else
    - We all equally deserve to suffer any fate God might choose to bring our way

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- If Job, the most righteous man in the world in his day, could experience the calamity he saw by God's providence, then what should we expect?
- We can't make judgments about another person's standing before God on the basis of the events in their life
  - Missionaries that die in Africa
  - Martyrs in the early church

- And what about Jesus comments to the crowd in Luke 13?
  - Jesus says to the crowd in verse 3, I tell you no
    - Meaning, no, those men were not worse than other Galileans
    - They are not worse than you
    - Or said another way, you are just as sinful as they are
      - And unless you repent, you will likewise perish
  - Now did Jesus mean they too would die at the hands of Pilate while sacrificing at the temple?
    - Clearly not
    - But He did mean that just as these men and women met a tragic end in their sin, the crowd could likewise expect a tragic outcome at the end of their lives unless they repent and receive their Messiah

- In the next couple of verses, Jesus emphasizes his point further by bringing up his own example, probably another recent example from the headlines
  - In verse 4 Jesus talks about a tower that fell on 18 people in Siloam
    - This is a reference to the famous pool of Siloam mentioned in John 9
    - Apparently, a tower of some sort fell on visitors to the pool and 18 died
      - We know nothing more about this incident either, except what's mention here in the text,

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- But Jesus draws a parallel to the moment and says when you heard about the 18 dying at the pool, did you assume they were worse than average sinners as well?

- And again Jesus says that the crowd is no different than those people

- So it doesn't matter how their lives end

- They could be killed by Pilate or have a tower fall on them or whatever

- But all who go to their grave unrepentant of a sinful life lived apart from God will all receive a similar measure of judgment

- Do you see what Jesus is doing here?

- It's been said that the thing that keeps most people from reaching heaven is that they aren't bad enough

- People live their lives focused on the here and now and measuring their righteousness by what they see according to earthly standards of right and wrong

- As long as we can find someone around us or in the news who lives a life more depraved, more disobedient and self-centered than our own, then we can feel good about ourselves by comparison

- And then if we're not careful, we take it another step and begin to look at people who suffer tragedy and explain their tragedy as nothing more than a consequence of their sin – as just desserts

- When we do this, aren't we forgetting that we too are sinners

- In God's eyes, were we to stand before Him and answer for our lives on the basis of our own actions, we would be found no less guilty than those who suffered worse misfortunes

- It is only by His grace and Christ's sinless life that we can hope to stand in His presence and not come under judgment

- The standard of righteousness is not whether we are worst than other people

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- The standard is are we living a life less than God's holiness? Less than the example Christ gave us through His life? The answer for all of us is yes
- So what are we to do about this dilemma? What are the people in the crowd to do in response to Jesus' comments?

- So, then Jesus calls upon them all to repent!
  - You can't believe in a Messiah until you believe you need a Messiah
    - Or said another way for you and I today, you won't ask to be saved until you believe you need to be saved
    - And the first step for a man or woman to come to faith in the Gospel is to recognize that they have sin and need for forgiveness
      - And Jesus commands them to take this step when He calls on them to repent
  - They are no better than the rest and they have as much reason to fear a tragic end to their lives as did the others
    - Not just in terms of the way they will meet their death
    - But more importantly, they have every reason to expect the judgment Jesus spoke about at the end of Chap 12 as all other sinners
- Consider the parable He gives in the following verses to make His point:

Luke 13:6 ¶ And He *began* telling this parable: "A man had a fig tree which had been planted in his vineyard; and he came looking for fruit on it and did not find any.
Luke 13:7 "And he said to the vineyard-keeper, 'Behold, for three years I have come looking for fruit on this fig tree without finding any. Cut it down! Why does it even use up the ground?'
Luke 13:8 "And he answered and said to him, 'Let it alone, sir, for this year too, until I dig around it and put in fertilizer;
Luke 13:9 and if it bears fruit next year, *fine*; but if not, cut it down.'"

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Luke 13B

- As we begun Chapter 13 last week, we were confronted with Jesus challenging the crowd that gathered around Him to see themselves for who they truly were
    - They were sinners before God
    - He wanted them to understand they all had sin worthy of judgment
    - And therefore they all had need to repent and appeal to God for mercy
- And to emphasize His point, as He usually did, Jesus taught through a parable
    - We ended the teaching last week in the verse leading up to this parable,
    - And after the we finished the formal teaching, we spent time as a class studying the parable, but today I'd like to revisit it as part of today's teaching
    - So let's begin by reading the parable in verse 6

Luke 13:6 ¶ And He *began* telling this parable: "A man had a fig tree which had been planted in his vineyard; and he came looking for fruit on it and did not find any.
Luke 13:7 "And he said to the vineyard-keeper, 'Behold, for three years I have come looking for fruit on this fig tree without finding any. Cut it down! Why does it even use up the ground?'
Luke 13:8 "And he answered and said to him, 'Let it alone, sir, for this year too, until I dig around it and put in fertilizer;
Luke 13:9 and if it bears fruit next year, *fine*; but if not, cut it down.'"

- The elements of this parable are very important to understanding its meaning
    - The most prominent actor in the parable, of course, is the fig tree itself
        - The tree is part of a vineyard
        - In other words, the tree exists for a specific reason
        - It's not simply a wild fig tree
        - Rather, it's a tree that someone planted with the specific purpose that this tree might produce fruit for it's owner

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- Another actor is the owner of the field who came to the tree at some point looking for the fruit that he expected the tree to produce
    - When he arrives, we're told, he finds no fruit
    - This is a pathetic sight
        - A fruit tree that does not produce fruit is pretty useless, isn't it
        - It's one purpose for existing is to produce fruit for its master, and here it is without any fruit at all
        - Useless
- Finally, there is a vineyard keeper working for the master
    - He is caretaker for the tree, prompting it to produce fruit
        - And when the owner finds the tree empty of fruit, he tells the vineyard-keeper to get rid of this worthless tree
        - We should take not here that the owner never seems to blame the vineyard keeper
            - The vineyard keeper isn't the reason the tree produced no fruit
            - If anything, we can assume the vineyard keeper is doing everything he can to make the tree produce

- As the parable goes, the vineyard keeper responds to the owner's disappointment and anger over the useless tree…
    - Let's try something else
    - Before we destroy this tree, let's see if a little more care and feeding will fix the problem
    - At this request, the owner agrees to give more time
        - It's already been three years and now he permits it to wait one more year
        - While it's possible to see the 3 + 1 years to have specific meaning (represent the years of Jesus ministry on earth)

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- More likely, it's probably just a general reference to God's appointed period for patience

- Of greater significance is the fact that the master sets a deadline
  - In other words, the owner isn't willing to wait forever
  - He doesn't have infinite patience
  - There will be a day of reckoning for this tree
  - If the tree won't produce fruit, it will be struck down

- So what's Jesus teaching here?
  - Well, remember that immediately before the parable Jesus had just been teaching the crowd that they must repent or face judgment
  - So with that context in mind, we have the key to understanding the parable

- We begin with the fig tree
  - It's a classic picture of Israel in scripture
    - You can see references to Israel as a fig tree in Hosea 9:10; Jer 8:13 and many other places
    - In fact, in Luke 21:29 we hear Jesus compare the regathering of the nation of Israel in the last days to the appearance of leaves a fig tree in the Spring

Luke 21:29 ¶ Then He told them a parable: "Behold the fig tree and all the trees;
Luke 21:30 as soon as they put forth *leaves*, you see it and know for yourselves that summer is now near.
Luke 21:31 "So you also, when you see these things happening, recognize that the kingdom of God is near.

- So if the parable is talking generally about the nation of Israel failing to bear spiritual fruit
  - In light of the earlier context of Jesus' teaching, it seems appropriate to conclude that He's referring to an unfruitful Israel in His day
    - That nation was planted by God for a reason

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- He established the nation of Israel for His reasons
- Not just so that the nation might exist for itself

- And when the Messiah came to them as the Father promised,
  - They received Him for the whole world's sake
  - But they were not bearing fruit
  - They were not receiving their Messiah

- You should also remember at about this point that we're nearing the end of the three act drama represented in Chapters 11-13.
  - This is the pivotal point in Luke's gospel where Jesus is rejected by the nation and He confirms their rejection by withdrawing His offer of the kingdom
  - This is a point of no return
  - So through this parable, Jesus warns the nation that Father won't have infinite patience with them
    - If they won't bear fruit by accepting their Messiah, there will finally be a day when he cuts down the tree
    - A day when He brings the nation low
    - Though never without a remnant, Israel will suffer greatly for their rejection
      - Because if they don't receive their Messiah, what use are they to God?
      - They are like a tree that doesn't produce fruit

- To put an end to our discussion on the parable, let me take you to Isaiah 5
  - In a former day when Israel was given the command to repent, God spoke to them through their prophet Isaiah and this is what the Lord said:

Is. 5:1 ¶ Let me sing now for my well-beloved
A song of my beloved concerning His vineyard.
My well-beloved had a vineyard on a fertile hill.

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Is. 5:2 He dug it all around, removed its stones,
And planted it with the choicest vine.
And He built a tower in the middle of it
And also hewed out a wine vat in it;
Then He expected *it* to produce *good* grapes,
But it produced *only* worthless ones.
Is. 5:3 ¶ "And now, O inhabitants of Jerusalem and men of Judah,
Judge between Me and My vineyard.
Is. 5:4 "What more was there to do for My vineyard that I have not done in it?
Why, when I expected *it* to produce *good* grapes did it produce worthless ones?
Is. 5:5 "So now let Me tell you what I am going to do to My vineyard:
I will remove its hedge and it will be consumed;
I will break down its wall and it will become trampled ground.
Is. 5:6 "I will lay it waste;
It will not be pruned or hoed,
But briars and thorns will come up.
I will also charge the clouds to rain no rain on it."
Is. 5:7 ¶ For the vineyard of the LORD of hosts is the house of Israel
And the men of Judah His delightful plant.
Thus He looked for justice, but behold, bloodshed;
For righteousness, but behold, a cry of distress.
Is. 5:8 ¶ Woe to those who add house to house *and* join field to field,
Until there is no more room,
So that you have to live alone in the midst of the land!
Is. 5:9 In my ears the LORD of hosts *has sworn,* "Surely, many houses shall become desolate,
Even great and fine ones, without occupants.

- Just as he did in Isaiah's time, God is now speaking again through His Son to Israel demanding their repentance and their acceptance of their Messiah

- But now Luke moves away from this moment and into a new sequence which continues to build to a climax in verse 35

Luke 13:10 ¶ And He was teaching in one of the synagogues on the Sabbath.
Luke 13:11 And there was a woman who for eighteen years had had a sickness caused by a spirit; and she was bent double, and could not straighten up at all.
Luke 13:12 When Jesus saw her, He called her over and said to her, "Woman, you are freed from your sickness."
Luke 13:13 And He laid His hands on her; and immediately she was made erect again and *began* glorifying God.

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- There's an obvious transition here from the scene moves that began in Chapter 12 and continued into Chapter 13
    - These events may have transpired hours or days or even weeks later
    - But Luke places this teaching here because it fits so neatly with the main theme of these chapters
    - And it also forms an important teaching sandwiched between two related thoughts
        - First, between Jesus' call at the beginning of 13 for the nation to repent
        - And then secondly, it introduce Jesus' discourse in verse 18 and beyond on the nature of God's coming kingdom

- To understand this transition a little better, let's take a look at the details in these verses
    - First we note that Jesus is teaching in a Synagogue on the Sabbath
    - This was Jesus' custom, but it also meant that He would be a target of the Pharisees who had turned the Sabbath into the religious equivalent of police speed trap
        - It was the best day of the week to catch someone doing something wrong
        - Especially to catch Jesus healing – something their traditions and teaching considered to be a violation of the Sabbath
- Luke tells us there was a woman who has suffered for 18 years with a paralysis that causes her to be bent over double
    - The number of years (18) may have spiritual significance, but frankly I'm not sure what it means
        - I do find it more than a little interesting that 18 is the sum of 3 sixes – as in 666
    - This is especially interesting given that we're told her paralysis is caused by a demon

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- In other words, the woman is in the grips of a debilitating sickness that has as its origin the enemy
- Obviously, she's unable to cure herself of the enemy's curse and it's slowing destroying her body

- Isn't interesting that the demonic presence in this woman resulted in a sickness that would appear to anyone today to be merely a muscular skeletal deformity?
  - Our culture have become naive to the work and presence of the enemy around us
  - CS Lewis once said:

    "There are two equal and opposite errors into which our race can fall about the devils. One is to disbelieve in their existence. The other is to believe, and to feel an excessive and unhealthy interest in them. They themselves are equally pleased by both errors and hail a materialist or a magician with the same delight."

- So Jesus takes note of this woman in the crowd and He calls her over and heals her instantly
  - It's important to note that there's no indication that she asked for the healing
  - Jesus decided in His mercy and love to heal the woman
  - Doesn't it seem odd that in the midst of this deep discussion on the coming kingdom and the need to repent and the receiving of the Messiah
    - That Luke inserts this simple story of Jesus healing another woman
    - Well there is an important reason, and the reason explains not only why Luke places it here, but also why Luke alone decided to include this event in his gospel

- First, consider that Jesus just taught that the nation must repent and settle their debts with the judge
  - That they were just as worthy of destruction as the Galileans who died in the temple

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- But if they are unworthy sinners, sinners who justly deserve God's judgment, how can they hope to recover and bear fruit?
  - In other words, if the nation is like a sick, worthless tree unable to bear the fruit, then what can save them from the coming judgment?
  - How can they be made to bear fruit?
  - Remember the fertilizer in the parable? The vineyard keeper is the solution

- Now returning to our story of the woman in the synagogue
  - Let's notice again the details of the woman's situation
    - She has been crippled, in the grip of the enemy
    - Her body suffering and likely dying from the paralysis
    - She is unable to help herself and she doesn't even have the inclination to ask God for help
      - As we said, she never asks Jesus to heal her
      - He takes mercy on her and by His grace He determines to heal her
      - Appropriately enough, He heals her on the Sabbath, giving her rest from her affliction
    - And after she is healed, she bears fruit
    - She glorifies God

- So Luke places this account here in these verses to make the connection for the reader between
  - The sinful hopeless state the nation of Israel finds itself in
  - And the one hope they have been given from God to rescue them from their spiritual affliction
    - Sin is a spiritual paralysis brought about by man's disobedience and nurtured and magnified by the power of the enemy

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- And without God's intervention through grace and mercy, men would remain condemned to suffer in their sin and ultimately to receive their just punishment
- But just like the woman in the Synagogue, all Israel can look to Jesus for healing required before they may bear fruit for God and avoid His judgment
- If only they would receive Him

- But what do the leaders of Israel say in the face of this miracle?

Luke 13:14 But the synagogue official, indignant because Jesus had healed on the Sabbath, *began* saying to the crowd in response, "There are six days in which work should be done; so come during them and get healed, and not on the Sabbath day."
Luke 13:15 But the Lord answered him and said, "You hypocrites, does not each of you on the Sabbath untie his ox or his donkey from the stall and lead him away to water *him*?
Luke 13:16 "And this woman, a daughter of Abraham as she is, whom Satan has bound for eighteen long years, should she not have been released from this bond on the Sabbath day?"
Luke 13:17 As He said this, all His opponents were being humiliated; and the entire crowd was rejoicing over all the glorious things being done by Him.

- The Synagogue official becomes indignant and chastises the synagogue crowd telling them to come back for healing on any of the other six days of the week
    - How absurd
        - A man has just performed a miracle in your midst, in a gathering of God's people
        - And the official's first concern is that the healing took place on the "wrong day"
        - It's hard to believe that anyone could be that oblivious to what's happening before him
        - It's like complaining to your wife that she chose to go into labor on the wrong day and ruined your plans to play golf

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- This is an interesting because we're not talking about a Pharisee necessarily, but rather the synagogue official
  - This would be roughly equivalent to the worship leader or pastor of the synagogue
- So here again is another official within the nation of Israel unwilling to acknowledge Jesus for who He was
  - And He essentially demands that the crowd depart and not seek after Jesus except on the days men like him have determined are appropriate
  - In his hardness of heart, this man has become a barrier to people accepting their Messiah

- Finally, consider Jesus' response
  - In a tone that almost sounds angry – righteous anger
    - Jesus again calls them hypocrites
    - He says they say one thing and do another
    - Essentially, they are trying to convince the people that they shouldn't follow Jesus because he violates the rules (man made rules)
    - Therefore, anyone who violates rules can't be worthy of their admiration – that's the logic

- Jesus responds to their faulty logic and exposes their hypocrisy by making an argument from the lesser to the greater
  - Jesus points out that these men were willing to overlook the very same rules for lesser reasons, like the needs of an animal
    - But they condemn Jesus for violating the man-made rules to care for people's needs on the Sabbath
  - In verse 16, Jesus says that when it comes to God's willingness to free his people from their bondage –
    - Whether a bondage of demon possession or a bondage of sin
    - Waiting even one day longer for that freedom is asking too much

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- And that's what these leaders are doing to the nation of Israel
  - They are essentially demanding that the nation of Israel overlook Jesus
  - And by doing so, they are condemning the nation to continue in their sin and bondage to the man-made system of rules and regulations
  - So Jesus humiliates them even as He prepared to dismiss

- Now the scene is set for the conclusion of this important chapter
  - In Chap 11, Jesus has shown Himself before all the people and the leaders of Israel as the one promised, as the Son of David
    - He has been declared to be the devil himself
    - He declared woe – or judgment - on the Pharisees and lawyers
  - In Chap 12 He taught the disciples of what to expect as they confronted the enemy and those who are under the enemy's power
    - He warned of persecution
    - He warned of traps and temptation
    - Then Jesus began to call on the crowd to repent of their hypocrisy and to acknowledge the signs they understood
    - Finally, Jesus warned of coming judgment
  - Now, in Chap 13 He's warned that a nation that doesn't bear fruit is useless to God
    - That the Jews shouldn't take satisfaction in thinking that they were somehow exempt from judgment because of their Jewishness
    - If they persisted in failing to bear fruit for God, they would be judged too
    - Finally, Jesus demonstrates once again that He can heal the nation just as He healed the woman in the synagogue
    - But alas, the leadership persists in trying to turn the people against Jesus

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- Next week, we see Jesus confirm this rejection as Chap 13 ends
    - It's an important moment for several reasons, and we'll take a close look at it then.

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Luke 13C

- Today, we dive back into the end of Chapter 13 to conclude the 3-Act drama represented in chapters 11-13 of Luke's gospel
    - So far in chapter 13 Luke has moved the reader along a line of thought beginning with…
        - Jesus' call to the nation of Israel to wake up and recognize that they would face judgment for rejecting Him – for failing to bear fruit
        - And secondly, Luke relates the story of Jesus' healing in the synagogue as a simple but effective way to illustrate that Jesus was the one sent to free them from their bondage
            - He alone could heal them, free them from the enemy and enable them to bear the fruit God intended – if only they would receive Him
        - Finally, we saw the leader of the synagogue follow in the footsteps of the other leaders when he rejected Jesus and continued to place impediments between Jesus and the people
- Add this to what Luke revealed in his preceding chapters where Jesus proves his deity time and again, and yet time and again the leaders and the crowd refused to acknowledge what they saw, and now the stage has been set
- So now, Luke takes a turn for the home stretch and brings us to the conclusion of this repeated rejection
    - Remember, the whole point of Chapters 11-13 is to illustrate in detail the way the nation of Israel came to the point of rejecting their Messiah
        - Luke is working carefully to explain to his Gentile, Greek audience why God would be rejected by His creation and eventually put to death
        - That apparent contradiction had to be explained to a potentially skeptical audience
        - So Luke has been walking the reader patiently through a description of the deceit and hypocrisy of the people and their

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leaders, so that when rejection comes, it's understood to be a mistake, to be a result of sin and evil

- And now as Luke prepares to conclude this part of the Gospel, he introduces Jesus' discussion of the kingdom
    - Because after all, that's what Jesus has been offering to Israel – the kingdom on Messiah
        - But as we enter into that part of his discussion, I want you to understand how Jesus presents His discussion of the kingdom
        - Jesus knows that one of the reasons why the crowd has been unwilling to accept him is that they share the Pharisees' mistaken view of the kingdom and who will enter it
        - We'll examine that issue in detail tonight, but as we begin, it's important that we note how every description Jesus offers of the kingdom is counterintuitive
            - The descriptions of the kingdom are all opposite or reversed from what the Jewish nation expected and from what they had been taught
- So it seems only fair that Jesus would include in his teaching references to the very kingdom He was prepared to establish for the sake of Israel
    - So as the offer comes to a close, Jesus begins to offer commentary on the nature of the thing He was offering - on the kingdom itself

Luke 13:18 ¶ So He was saying, "What is the kingdom of God like, and to what shall I compare it?
Luke 13:19 "It is like a mustard seed, which a man took and threw into his own garden; and it grew and became a tree, and THE BIRDS OF THE AIR NESTED IN ITS BRANCHES."
Luke 13:20 ¶ And again He said, "To what shall I compare the kingdom of God?
Luke 13:21 "It is like leaven, which a woman took and hid in three pecks of flour until it was all leavened."

- Jesus begins with a rhetorical question
    - He asks what is the kingdom like?
    - More specifically, he says what is the kingdom of God like?

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- What is the kingdom of God?

- Well there is a wealth of scripture available in the Bible, especially in the OT to give us understanding of what God means by His kingdom

  - The OT had promised to the nation of Israel a Messiah who would rule of them during a time of peace and He would usher in a kingdom of righteousness

  - In fact, virtually all that we may know about the nature of the kingdom except duration comes from the OT

  - The NT adds only a few missing details, most notably the length of one stage of the kingdom – 1,000 (Rev 20:4)

Rev. 20:4 ¶ Then I saw thrones, and they sat on them, and judgment was given to them. And I *saw* the souls of those who had been beheaded because of their testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God, and those who had not worshiped the beast or his image, and had not received the mark on their forehead and on their hand; and they came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.

  - But in fact, the 1,000 years is not the entirety of God's kingdom, but rather it's a demarcation between two stages of the kingdom

Luke 1:31 "And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you shall name Him Jesus.
Luke 1:32 "He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David;
Luke 1:33 and He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and His kingdom will have no end."

Rev. 11:15 ¶ Then the seventh angel sounded; and there were loud voices in heaven, saying, "The kingdom of the world has become *the kingdom* of our Lord and of His Christ; and He will reign forever and ever."

- We could spend all Spring talking about the kingdom and it's nature as described in scripture, but the essential points for today's teaching are these:

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- First, the term kingdom can mean slightly different things in scripture at different times, so we use context to understand which aspect or which period of God's kingdom is in view
- I want to go to Matt 13 for a short time to examine a great series of verses that parallel the ones we read today from Luke
- In these verses, we get a chance to see the term kingdom of God used in a variety of ways to help illustrate what I'm talking about

Matt. 13:24 ¶ Jesus presented another parable to them, saying, "The kingdom of heaven may be compared to a man who sowed good seed in his field.
Matt. 13:25 "But while his men were sleeping, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went away.
Matt. 13:26 "But when the wheat sprouted and bore grain, then the tares became evident also.
Matt. 13:27 "The slaves of the landowner came and said to him, 'Sir, did you not sow good seed in your field? How then does it have tares?'
Matt. 13:28 "And he said to them, 'An enemy has done this!' The slaves *said to him, 'Do you want us, then, to go and gather them up?'
Matt. 13:29 "But he *said, 'No; for while you are gathering up the tares, you may uproot the wheat with them.
Matt. 13:30 'Allow both to grow together until the harvest; and in the time of the harvest I will say to the reapers, "First gather up the tares and bind them in bundles to burn them up; but gather the wheat into my barn."'"

- After Jesus gives this description of the kingdom, He interprets this parable for the Disciples later in verses

Matt. 13:37 And He said, "The one who sows the good seed is the Son of Man,
Matt. 13:38 and the field is the world; and *as for* the good seed, these are the sons of the kingdom; and the tares are the sons of the evil *one*;
Matt. 13:39 and the enemy who sowed them is the devil, and the harvest is the end of the age; and the reapers are angels.
Matt. 13:40 "So just as the tares are gathered up and burned with fire, so shall it be at the end of the age.
Matt. 13:41 "The Son of Man will send forth His angels, and they will gather out of His kingdom all stumbling blocks, and those who commit lawlessness,
Matt. 13:42 and will throw them into the furnace of fire; in that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

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Matt. 13:43 "Then THE RIGHTEOUS WILL SHINE FORTH AS THE SUN in the kingdom of their Father. He who has ears, let him hear.

- Here Jesus tells us that the kingdom of God (heaven) is comparable to the way Jesus plants seeds in the world (i.e,. He brings men and women to faith) even as the enemy is busy sowing seeds by bringing up unbelievers
    - Then in the last days as Christ returns, the wicked are gathered from the four corners of the earth and removed from the earth as Jesus ushers in His 1,000 year reign on Earth
    - So note what learn here
        - The kingdom is not merely the point of Christ's return
        - It actually begins at Christ's first coming as the citizens of his kingdom are planted like seeds, one by one
        - Now look at verses 31 & 32 in Matt
- Here we see the same parable we just read in Luke
    - But in Matt, it comes right after Jesus declares that the kingdom of God begins with the making of the first believers,
        - Then we hear that one characteristic of the kingdom is that it will start very small
        - But despite all expectations and against all odds, it will grow remarkably big
        - In fact, it will grow to the point where birds nest in the tree
            - Or said literally, to the point where strangers will find a home in the kingdom
            - Those strangers, of course, are the gentile nations – you and I
        - In fact, if you want further confirmation that the birds represent that gentile nations, you only have to look at Daniel 4
            - In Dan 4 you see Nebachanezzer experience a dream where a tree fills the earth a tree that has birds nesting in it and beast resting in its shade

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- And Daniel tells the king that the tree represents his kingdom, and therefore the animals that inhabit the tree are the various nations of the world that make up the kingdom and depend on him

- It's a great parallel to help us understand the picture being given here

- The point of the mustard seed parable, therefore, is to illustrate that it will be a remarkable, unexpected sight to watch the kingdom of God grow from such meager, humble beginnings to such a dramatic final state

  - And that point is reiterated in the parable in Matt 13 verse 33 (leaven)

- So now we understand how the term Kingdom of God is being used in these verses as well as our in original verse from Luke

  - When Jesus teaches to the Kingdom of God in these verses, He is referring to the growth of the Church

  - In fact His reference to the birds nesting in the tree is a reference to the way the kingdom (i.e, the Church) will ultimately draw in people from all the nations (not just Jews)

  - And it's growth will be complete only when Christ returns and removes the remaining unbelievers from the world and sets up his kingdom on earth

    - Among many places we can go in the Bible, Jeremiah gives us the picture of that kingdom on earth in Jer 23

Jer. 23:2 Therefore thus says the LORD God of Israel concerning the shepherds who are
tending My people: "You have scattered My flock and driven them away, and have not
attended to them; behold, I am about to attend to you for the evil of your deeds,"
declares the LORD.
Jer. 23:3 "Then I Myself will gather the remnant of My flock out of all the countries
where I have driven them and bring them back to their pasture, and they will be fruitful
and multiply.
Jer. 23:4 "I will also raise up shepherds over them and they will tend them; and they will
not be afraid any longer, nor be terrified, nor will any be missing," declares the LORD.
Jer. 23:5 ¶ "Behold, *the* days are coming," declares the LORD,
"When I will raise up for David a righteous Branch;
And He will reign as king and act wisely

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And do justice and righteousness in the land.
Jer. 23:6 "In His days Judah will be saved,
And Israel will dwell securely;
And this is His name by which He will be called,
'The LORD our righteousness.'

- So although the phrase "kingdom of God" can mean several different things, in these verse in Luke it specifically refers to the period of time when Christ is building His church one believer at a time
    - And it is being used by Jesus to dispel a myth in the minds of the Jewish crowd present around Him
    - As I introduced today's teaching, I mentioned that Jesus' teaching on the kingdom was counterintuitive to the crowd
        - It was nonsensical or at least paradoxical
        - It defied their conventional teaching
        - And here you can see one example of how that's true
            - While the Jews had been taught that the kingdom of God would come suddenly, all at once, in a moment
            - And it would only come for the Jews
            - Jesus just taught that it would start modestly, almost imperceptibly and it would grow to include representatives from all the nations of the world
            - In fact, once Jesus returns, the kingdom on earth will be established with 100% believers,
                - Because all unbelievers we are told will have been removed from the earth at Christ's appearing (second coming)
    - So the people have prepared to reject Jesus as their Messiah because the kind of Kingdom He was in the process of establishing looked nothing like the kind of kingdom they were expecting
- Look how Jesus continues this paradoxical teaching moving forward in Chapter 13

Luke 13:22 ¶ And He was passing through from one city and village to another, teaching, and proceeding on His way to Jerusalem.

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Luke 13:23 And someone said to Him, "Lord, are there *just* a few who are being saved?" And He said to them,
Luke 13:24 "Strive to enter through the narrow door; for many, I tell you, will seek to enter and will not be able.
Luke 13:25 "Once the head of the house gets up and shuts the door, and you begin to stand outside and knock on the door, saying, 'Lord, open up to us!' then He will answer and say to you, 'I do not know where you are from.'
Luke 13:26 "Then you will begin to say, 'We ate and drank in Your presence, and You taught in our streets';
Luke 13:27 and He will say, 'I tell you, I do not know where you are from; DEPART FROM ME, ALL YOU EVILDOERS.'

- Before we dive into these verses, notice how it begins
    - Jesus is walking and teaching as He heads toward Jerusalem
        - We're still talking about Jesus heading ever steadily toward the city of His death
        - He remains steadfast in His mission, and though He is teaching along the way, His travel is purposeful
        - What a haunting feeling it must have been for Him to know what lay ahead and yet to keep walking without hesitation
    - The other thing to note about that opening verse is that it means what Luke records next happened at a later time
        - So we can infer that Luke places it here to make a connection for us between what's happened earlier in chapter 13 and what is said now
- Looking at the teaching itself, hopefully by now we're a;; starting to see the pattern emerge more clearly
    - Jesus is asked are just a few being saved?
        - And for a Jew, being saved meant entering the kingdom of God
        - But notice how backward this teaching on the kingdom would sound to a Jew
        - It's even remarkable that someone would think to ask the question

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- Because the typical Jewish teaching and thinking was that all good Jews were going to the kingdom
  - That's why God even promised the kingdom
  - For the Jew, for all Jews

- So when Jesus is asked if just a few are being saved, you need to realize that the questioner was only thinking about Jews
  - No one in the Jewish culture expected Gentiles to be saved
  - Even after Christ was resurrected, Peter himself struggled with the thought that the Gentiles might be intended to participate in God's plan for salvation
  - So when Jesus is asked if just a few are being saved, the implication is are a few being saved or are all Jews being saved?
    - That was a debate of the day among religious leaders
  - And the likely reason the question was even asked was because of disputes between Sagasees and Pharisees over what things were required of a Jew to be saved

- But Jesus answered in a surprising way
  - He first confirms that only a few are being saved – but then He goes even further
    - Strive to enter through a narrow gate, He says
      - Which is a euphemistic way of saying that there is a narrow path that grants entrance into the kingdom
  - Major cities in Jesus day had high walls to protect the city and naturally they had gates to permit entry
    - Cities like Jerusalem had a variety of gates,
      - Some were large and elaborate, very inviting and very easy to pass through
        - These wide, inviting doors obviously allowed the greatest number of people to pass through and so they were by far the most popular entry points into the city

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- But most cities might also have smaller, cramped and difficult entry points built into the walls at various points in the wall
    - These narrow gates were off the beaten path
    - They were unpopular and rarely used
    - They didn't allow you to bring much baggage, so they were typically used only by solitary travelers

- So Jesus says they should strive to enter by the narrow gate
    - They should strive to enter through the gate that few others are willing to take
    - They should ignore the attractive, easy options others chose to take in hope of entering the Kingdom
    - Because he goes on to describe what will happen to those people
        - One day in the future when their moment of judgment arrives, they will expect to receive their reward in the form of the kingdom
        - And they will come before Jesus, and they will be surprised to learn that the path they chose to gain entry will have been the wrong path
- In verse 25 we see Jesus saying I do not know where you are from, or as Matt records it in Matt 25 , Depart from me, I do not know you
    - And these people will appeal to Jesus on the basis of a loose association
    - We know you! We ate and drank with you (referring to the Pharisees)
    - We listened to you teach in our streets (referring to the crowds)
    - And He responds with depart from me evildoers
- In other words, they could enjoy Jesus' company all day long, but remember His earlier teaching
    - Those who are not form Him are against Him

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- You can't be a friend and not receive Him for who He said He was
- No matter how cordial their relationship was while He was on earth, when it comes time for judgment, they will either be in or out – there is no in between

- We know there were many people choosing the wide gates in Jesus day and equally today
    - We are surrounded by people who are looking for the easy, popular way to secure their future with God
        - Of course, many of those wide, easy paths are paths that have nothing to do with Jesus and the gospel message (
            - Beliefs like Islam, New Age mysticism, Buddism, Taoism, Wicca, you name it)
            - Paths that offer a variety of ways to earn God's praise and to earn entry into the kingdom they imagine exists
            - And these paths are easy not because they don't involve sacrifice on the part of the individual
            - Not because they don't involve effort (they usually involve lots of effort)
        - No, they are wide and easy because they do not involve a work of God
            - They are easy because they don't involve a changed heart
            - And they are easy because they don't depend on the suffering death of God's only Son
            - They easy in the sense that they are cheap, and meaningless
            - They are the road to destruction

- But what's even sadder to consider is that for many who sit in the pews of Christian churches every week, the same can be said
    - There are many in the church – perhaps many in our church- who are like these people represented in Jesus' parable

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- They are regularly eating and drinking with the savior, during communion or during fellowship with other Christians
- They are regularly sitting under his teaching, anytime the Word of God is taught in their presence
- But when it comes to their ticket into the kingdom, they have chosen a wide, popular door
  - Perhaps they have come to Christianity through a false Gospel like the Prosperity Gospel
  - Or perhaps they have been pulled into one of the many false churches like the Mormon church which preach a distorted and false view of Jesus and the salvation He brings
  - Or perhaps they have merely never believed anything, and they just fill a spot in the pews for reasons we don't even understand
  - Those are the wide gates of our day – the easy way in, the painless and popular way to enter the kingdom

- But whatever the reason, the Word they have heard concerning Christ and the gospel is like the seed falling on the worn path of their hard hearts
  - And it never takes root and it is stolen away by the enemy
  - Or it is like the seed that gives a quick appearance of life only to disappear forever at the first testing

- These people know about Jesus
  - They spent time in the company of His children
  - And they feel safe and secure

- But one day when they reach the end of their life journey, and they stand before Jesus, they are surprised to learn their fate
  - They wonder how they could be excluded from the kingdom
    - But despite their surprise, they will be excluded because Jesus never knew them
  - The security that you and I enjoy as Christians (knowing that we will be a part of God's kingdom both today and forever) comes not because of what we do, but because of who we know

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- We know Jesus as our savior, and we trust that He will save us because we believe he has already bought our ticket
- And we know we have decided to enter into must enter into that relationship through the narrow gate, through the door that is Jesus Himself

- Jesus declares he is that door for entry

John 10:9 "I am the door; if anyone enters through Me, he will be saved, and will go in and out and find pasture.

- To be saved is to have turned our back on the wide gates promising entry into the kingdom and to have placed our trust in the small, insignificant gate that most people are overlooking or rejecting outright

- And returning to the moment when Jesus spoke these words, can't you see the counterintuitive message here again for the Jew? Not all Jews are being saved
  - In fact, look at the punctuation point Jesus adds at the end

Luke 13:28 "In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth when you see Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and all the prophets in the kingdom of God, but yourselves being thrown out.
Luke 13:29 "And they will come from east and west and from north and south, and will recline *at the table* in the kingdom of God.
Luke 13:30 "And behold, *some* are last who will be first and *some* are first who will be last."

- Jesus makes the point even further by noting that while the patriarch will be there – just as every Jew would expects
  - But then Jesus drops the bomb
  - Yourselves will be thrown out
- And to add insult to injury, Jesus teaches that the table set in the kingdom will include people from east, west, north and south
  - This is a clear reference to the other nations of the world – the Gentiles – being accepted at the kingdom table
  - This is virtually heresy to a Jew in Jesus day, and even to orthodox Jews today

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- He tells them that some are last who will be first and vice versa
  - Referring to the Gentiles and Jews alluded to in the previous verse
  - Though the Jews assumed that all Jews would be first in God's eyes and all Gentiles would be last, or excluded in other words
  - Jesus reverses that, saying some who are last in the Jews' eyes will be first in God's plan
  - And many who assume they are first because of their Jewish birthright are doomed to be last in God's eyes

- Jesus illustrates why He has been rejected by the leaders and ultimately but the crowds
  - He is not who they expected the Messiah to be
  - He is not like they expected the Messiah to be
  - And He is has not brought the kind of kingdom they expected the Messiah to bring

- So then Luke records the Pharisees telling Jesus to stay away from Jerusalem
  - And they use the scare tactic that Herod wants to kill Him

Luke 13:31 ¶ Just at that time some Pharisees approached, saying to Him, "Go away, leave here, for Herod wants to kill You."
Luke 13:32 And He said to them, "Go and tell that fox, 'Behold, I cast out demons and perform cures today and tomorrow, and the third *day* I reach My goal.'
Luke 13:33 "Nevertheless I must journey on today and tomorrow and the next *day*; for it cannot be that a prophet would perish outside of Jerusalem.
Luke 13:34 "O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, *the city* that kills the prophets and stones those sent to her! How often I wanted to gather your children together, just as a hen *gathers* her brood under her wings, and you would not *have it*!

- The Pharisees try to get Jesus to retreat from Jerusalem with a ploy that Herod was after Him
  - We know from Luke 9 that Herod wanted to meet Jesus and when he finally does in Chapter 23 he asks Jesus to perform a miracle, as if he sees Jesus as little more than a magician
  - Finally he mocked Jesus when Jesus refused to play his games

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- But it seems unlikely that Herod had any desire to kill Jesus
- It's unlikely he ever saw Jesus as a threat

- But even if he had, Jesus wasn't about to be swayed by this comment by the Pharisees
  - And I love his response, because built into it is a significant jab at the Pharisees
  - Jesus says go tell that fox what I think say
  - In other words, he was treating the Pharisees as if they were Herod's messengers
    - Since they had taken it upon themselves to deliver a warning to Jesus, He turns to them and gives them a message to deliver back to Herod
      - Obviously Jesus didn't expect them to actually take that message back to Herod
      - He was insulting them by treating them as if they were in Herod's employment
      - Like a tax collector who was working for the Romans
      - It was a terrible insult to the pious and proper Pharisees
  - Then the message Jesus delivers is actually a message for the crowd who is listening around
    - He says tell Herod I cast out demons, I perform cures and on the third day I will reach my goal
    - In that declaration, Jesus reminds the Pharisees and the crowd that He has proven Himself to them
      - They have witnessed the proof
      - They know Jesus has met any test they could conceive to prove He was the promised one
    - And regardless of who might oppose Him…
      - Whether it be the crowd, or the Pharisees or Herod himself

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- Jesus will not be denied His goal – his goal of reaching Jerusalem where He was appointed to die

- By the way, Jesus' reference to "today, tomorrow and the third day" is not a literal description of the length of time remaining before He dies or even until he enters Jerusalem

  - We can know from all the remains in the telling of Luke's gospel that Jesus has more time remaining before he reaches Jerusalem than just three days

  - So Jesus' meaning here is that he will reach his goal on the appointed day

  - And then Jesus comments that a prophet cannot perish outside Jerusalem

    - Not that prophets have never been killed outside Jerusalem

    - But more likely Jesus is referring to the inevitable destiny of all true prophets sent to a disbelieving and rebellious Israel

      - They were rejected and killed because they spoke a convicting truth

      - Jesus was no different, and what's more, as the Messiah he was appointed to die in Jerusalem, so he couldn't avoid that outcome

- Finally, Luke concludes the Chap 13 with the climatic verses of these three chapters

  - Jesus ends his commentary on Jerusalem by lamenting her history as well as her future

  - He says this is the city that kills its prophets, stones those sent to her by God to bring her to an awareness of how distant her people were from the one they professed to follow

  - Jesus says how often He wanted gather her children, the Jews of Jerusalem like a Mother hen with her chicks

    - To protect and guide them and help them grow

    - But so often they would not have it

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- You see every time a prophet when to Israel and brought God's word, it was Jesus coming to Israel
- Every time God delivered his word through a famine or a pestilence or drought on a stubborn Israel
- Every time He brought destruction through Israel's enemies, it was Jesus speaking though the creation to Israel
  - Because Jerusalem here is merely the representative for the entire nation
  - Jesus uses Jerusalem figuratively to mean the whole nation of Israel
  - And they would have nothing of God's word, neither when it came by the prophets nor when it came in the flesh

- So now the moment arrives for Jesus to declare His rejection of this generation of Israel for their rejection of Him
  -

Luke 13:35 "Behold, your house is left to you *desolate*; and I say to you, you will not see Me until *the time* comes when you say, 'BLESSED IS HE WHO COMES IN THE NAME OF THE LORD!'"

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- Jesus declares that Israel's house is being left to her desolate
    - This is a reference to physical destruction of the temple and the city, which we know occurs when the Roman army breaches the walls of the city in AD 70 and puts down a Jewish rebellion
        - In that assault the temple is destroyed and the city burned and literally millions of Jews are murdered
        - This is the harsh reality of the judgment that came upon the city for the nation's rejection of their Messiah
    - Daniel prophesied this when he wrote

Dan. 9:26 "Then after the sixty-two weeks the Messiah will be cut off and have nothing, and the people of the prince who is to come will destroy the city and the sanctuary. And its end *will come* with a flood; even to the end there will be war; desolations are determined.

- Then Jesus adds the last comment he directs to the nation as a whole
    - He says they will not see Him again until they say Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord
    - This is a very important phrase
    - In fact, all our understanding eschatology (the doctrine of end times events) rests on this phrase
        - Jesus has just declared that the nation of Israel
            - The nation that God promised a Messiah
            - That nation will set eyes on their Messiah again until the day arrives when that nation will have a change of heart concerning Jesus
            - The entire nation of Israel on some distant future day will need to reverse the decision made in Jesus day on earth
            - Since they rejected Him while He walked the earth offering the kingdom, He will never return to establish that kingdom for them until they reverse that decision

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- Corporately, the nation of Israel will need to admit their sins, recognize their Messiah and when that happens,, He will return to them
    - This is the basis of Christ's second coming
    - But what could possible propel the entire nation of Israel to come to that conclusion?
    - Scripture shows us how and when

Zech. 12:9 "And in that day I will set about to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem.
Zech. 12:10 ¶ "I will pour out on the house of David and on the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the Spirit of grace and of supplication, so that they will look on Me whom they have pierced; and they will mourn for Him, as one mourns for an only son, and they will weep bitterly over Him like the bitter weeping over a firstborn.

- Zech goes on in Chap 14 to add that on that day

Zech. 14:5 … Then the LORD, my God, will come, *and* all the holy ones with Him!
Zech. 14:6 ¶ In that day there will be no light; the luminaries will dwindle.
Zech. 14:7 For it will be a unique day which is known to the LORD, neither day nor night, but it will come about that at evening time there will be light.
Zech. 14:8 ¶ And in that day living waters will flow out of Jerusalem, half of them toward the eastern sea and the other half toward the western sea; it will be in summer as well as in winter.
Zech. 14:9 ¶ And the LORD will be king over all the earth; in that day the LORD will be *the only* one, and His name *the only* one.

- To summarize the end of Chap 13, the offer of the kingdom has now been irrevocably withdrawn from the nation of Israel because they have refused to accept Jesus as their Messiah
    - And just as Jesus taught in earlier, the patience of the master is run out
        - It's time to cut down the worthless tree that won't show fruit
    - And Jesus declares that they will not see Him again until that repent and call out for Him
        - And not just some Jews, as is happening every day even now

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- But rather, the entire nation of Israel as it exists on a future day determined by God must have this response
- And therefore, only by God's hand, by His power can that day ever come to pass
- And on a day to come, at the end of tribulation, the Jewish nation finally comes to understand and believe in their Messiah and receive Him
- And He returns for them together with us, the Saints, to rule with him for a 1,000 years

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Luke 14A

- End of Chapter 13, we witnessed the point where Jesus declared
    - Israel had lost their opportunity
    - He would not grant them the kingdom until they declared Him to be their Messiah
- And now that Luke has given us this dramatic turn, where does he go next?
    - Well there are still quite a few chapters remaining before the crucifixion
    - Which means the lens of Luke's gospel begins to narrow considerably and time slows a bit
    - We focus down on Christ's teaching to his chosen ones as He prepares to leave them to difficult task of building the church
    - So these lessons in the following chapters are especially relevant to Christians then and today
        - The lessons come mainly through parables spoken to the disciples and crowd
        - And in the form of Jesus' confrontations with the Jewish and Roman authorities
- And just like with Chap 13, the first half or so of Chap 14 is completely unique to Luke, so let's dive into Chapter 14 and follow Luke as he moves forward in his narrative

Luke 14:1 ¶ It happened that when He went into the house of one of the leaders of the Pharisees on *the* Sabbath to eat bread, they were watching Him closely.
Luke 14:2 And there in front of Him was a man suffering from dropsy.
Luke 14:3 And Jesus answered and spoke to the lawyers and Pharisees, saying, "Is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath, or not?"
Luke 14:4 But they kept silent. And He took hold of him and healed him, and sent him away.

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- Here again Luke records a moment when Jesus accepts an invitation to eat with the Pharisees
    - Like we've learned in the past, anytime the Pharisees offered Jesus the chance to share a meal, the atmosphere was never cordial nor the purposes benign
        - The Pharisees had two primary purposes in extending the invitation
            - First, they enjoyed portraying themselves to the crowds as generous and hospitable, especially toward a popular figure like Jesus
            - Secondly, they hoped to find an opportunity trap Jesus in something worthy of punishment under the Law
                - Look at how Jesus begins in verse 1
                - They were watching Him closely
                - Watching = paratereo = observe scrupulously
        - And Jesus wasn't accepting the invitation merely for the sake of a free meal
            - He certainly knew their intentions
            - And even more interestingly, He would purposely walk straight into their traps
            - Yet He never committed any sin so as to give them opportunity to make their accusation
            - And the confrontations gave Him opportunity to point out their hypocrisy and sin
- Now look carefully at verse 2
    - Luke (alone) records that Jesus is confronted by this man with dropsy
        - Though the text doesn't say specifically, the language Luke uses here strongly suggests that the man was placed in front of Jesus by the Pharisees to trap Jesus
            - First, note how Luke says that "there in front of Jesus was a man" – suggesting the man is placed there conspicuously

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- BTW, Dropsy is an antiquated term for edema – a swelling of tissues due to fluid retention – usually extremities
- Can be caused by malfunctioning of the lymph systems, heart or kidney failure
- This condition was commonly believed to be the result of immorality, so people with this condition generally received little sympathy

▪ This is a Sabbath meal in a home

- Which means the Pharisees would not normally have opened their home to a man seen as immoral
- Making his presence before Jesus even more suspicious

o Basically, it seems clear that the Pharisees have set up this entire moment specifically for the purpose of enticing Jesus into healing on the Sabbath

▪ Something they considered to be wrong under the law

- So how does Jesus react?

o Jesus begins as He often did

▪ He asks a question of His would-be accusers

▪ He asks them is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath or not?

- Now the question was simple enough
- And had anyone else asked the question at any other time, the Pharisees wouldn't have hesitated to answer Jesus
- They would have said no, it's not lawful
- In fact, they have had confrontations with Jesus over this same issue at times past

▪ The Pharisees don't answer – they remain silent

- They were intimidated into silence
- Had they answered no, they would have been expected to support their conclusion

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- And there was no direct reference in the Law to support their conclusion
- And having seen Jesus' knowledge and command of scripture, they dared not invite a confrontation with Him over the legalities of the Sabbath

- On the other hand if they had said yes, it was lawful to heal, then they lose the chance to accuse Him

- When they don't answer Him, He does the merciful thing and heals the man, which must have been a very dramatic moment
  - It must have resulted in obvious physical changes in the man
  - The Pharisees couldn't help but marvel at the healing even as they hated Him for it
  - Then Jesus does something very interesting
    - It says he sent the man away
    - Presumably this took place before the meal even began or at least before it finished
    - So, as Jesus dismisses the man, in effect Jesus was saying to the Pharisees that I know you brought him here merely as a pawn in your fight with me
    - So Jesus gives the Pharisees what they wanted and then let's the man leave
  - In effect, Jesus highlights the fact that the Pharisees had no real interest in the man's company – which only added to their hypocrisy

- After the man leaves, Jesus turns his attention back to the Pharisees

Luke 14:5 And He said to them, "Which one of you will have a son or an ox fall into a well, and will not immediately pull him out on a Sabbath day?"
Luke 14:6 And they could make no reply to this.

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- Jesus' challenge to the Pharisees mirrors one recorded in Matthew during another Sabbath day healing recorded in Matt 12
    -

Matt. 12:11 And He said to them, "What man is there among you who has a sheep, and if it falls into a pit on the Sabbath, will he not take hold of it and lift it out?
Matt. 12:12 "How much more valuable then is a man than a sheep! So then, it is lawful to do good on the Sabbath."

- As Matt records this different incident, he captures Jesus giving the conclusion we all anticipated
    - The Sabbath was giving by God for men that they might benefit from earthly rest
    - And more importantly, the Sabbath day was given to men so that they might understand it as a shadow, a picture of their Savior, who was to become our spiritual rest
        - A believer rests from his works because he rests in the work of Jesus on the cross
    - But here's Jesus, the Lord of the Sabbath, the one the Sabbath pictures
        - Doing the work that only He can do
        - And so when the One who is the living reality of the Sabbath comes to do the Father's will, then that work cannot be opposed to any Law given by that same Father
            - His work of mercy was consistent with the purpose of the Sabbath – to give men rest in the ultimate sense of the word
            - Rest from work, from judgment, from sin, and from the effects of sin
        - Doing this good could never be inconsistent with God's purposes in giving the Sabbath day
    - Of course the Pharisees had so distorted the meaning of the Sabbath that it had become a yoke

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- A burden on the people that actually restricted the opportunity to do good
- And Jesus' example illustrated not only the Pharisees' distorted perspective but also their hypocrisy

- And naturally, the Pharisees could make no reply to this
  - In other words, Jesus had disarmed them in the moment
  - They could not turn His healing into a cause for making an accusation
- Now Luke moves forward into a new moment during this same Sabbath dinner

Luke 14:7 ¶ And He *began* speaking a parable to the invited guests when He noticed
how they had been picking out the places of honor *at the table*, saying to them,
Luke 14:8 "When you are invited by someone to a wedding feast, do not take the place
of honor, for someone more distinguished than you may have been invited by him,
Luke 14:9 and he who invited you both will come and say to you, 'Give *your* place to this
man,' and then in disgrace you proceed to occupy the last place.
Luke 14:10 "But when you are invited, go and recline at the last place, so that when the
one who has invited you comes, he may say to you, 'Friend, move up higher'; then you
will have honor in the sight of all who are at the table with you.
Luke 14:11 "For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles
himself will be exalted."

- This event occurs apparently during the same Sabbath meal that began the chapter
- As the meal begins, Jesus observes something curious
  - We're told He sees some of the guests picking out places of honor around the table
  - In Jesus day, an important meal of this kind would normally take place around a low table only a few inches off the ground
  - The table was shaped like a U
    - The host would recline at the bottom of the U, facing to the left
    - And the guests would be positioned around the U also reclining to the left

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- The most honored positions were the positions immediately next to the host
- The least honored were farthest away at the ends of the U

- So the guests were seeking to claim positions near the host
  - What this meant was they were also presuming how much honor they had in the host's eyes
  - It's like someone who sits down at their computer and created their own high school diploma, prints it out and hangs it on their wall
  - They are attempting to appropriate an honor that can't be obtained merely by appearances
    - No matter how close they sit to the host, it won't change the actual amount of honor that they are truly owed
    - So, as Jesus teaches, when the host finally decides to recognize the ones who are truly due honor, the imposters are going to be exposed
    - And they won't be allowed to gain honor in illegitimate ways
    - The point here is that pride can often be a dishonest shortcut but in a day to come, the truth will be known by all

- Since we know that Jesus taught this parable in response to the guests' inappropriate behavior,
  - It's important that we ask who were these guests
  - Were they just the Pharisees mentioned earlier in this chapter?
  - I have a theory about who the primary audience was for this teaching in that moment
    - And I don't believe it was the Pharisees
    - Obviously, the Pharisees were supposed to hear this message too, since we know they were there too, but only in a limited sense
  - While they might appreciate the simple ethical point of humility, Jesus didn't expect them to gain the benefit of the underlying spiritual meaning of this parable

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- So if not the Pharisees, who was the true audience?

- Well, look again at some of the details of Jesus' teaching
  - First, for the setting of the parable, Jesus chooses a wedding feast, which is different than the moment at hand, a Sabbath meal
  - So He must have a reason for changing the setting
    - If His only purpose in teaching the parable was to correct their dining etiquette, He wouldn't have needed to change the setting
    - So, the reasonable conclusion is that the setting has significance to understanding the meaning of the parable and identifying the audience

- A wedding feast is a common picture of the celebration to be held upon Jesus' marriage to His Bride, the Church
  - In Matt 22, Jesus compares the kingdom of god to a man who gave wedding feast for his son
  - In Matt 25, Jesus refers to a day to come when the bridegroom will return for his brides, but only those ready and waiting for him will be taken away for the wedding
  - Just a chapter earlier in Luke we heard Jesus talking about a day when the patriarchs will feast at the Lord's table together with people from all the nations of the world
  - The OT as well often uses the picture of a wedding feast as the moment of glory for the sons of Israel
  - So, if the occasion is a wedding feast, we must be talking about those who have been invited to participated
    - In other words, the church
    - In fact the word church (ekklesia), two Greek words that mean made from invited guests
    - And more specifically the disciples, since they would have no doubt been invited to this meal with Jesus

- So the true audience for the parable were the disciples as you and I today and not the Pharisees

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- Remember Jesus' words to the Pharisees recorded elsewhere in John's gospel

John 8:47 "He who is of God hears the words of God; for this reason you do not hear *them*, because you are not of God."

- Furthermore, Jesus tells the disciples in Matt 13 that he speaks in parables so that the Pharisees won't understand the true spiritual meaning of his teaching

- So, the Pharisees get nothing more out of Jesus' teaching than the ethical and practical lesson in the parable

- So what is Jesus teaching the church (and more specifically the disciples)?

- The parable says that guests invited to the wedding invitation will be seated according to honor

    - But it will be an honor that the host decides, not one that the guests themselves can decide for themselves

        - In fact, if they think too much of themselves, they risk humiliation when the host reveals their true measure of honor

    - So a smart guest will practice humility, and leave it to the host to bestow any honor

    - For whoever humbles himself, he will be exalted, and whoever exalts himself, will be exalted

        - In passing, I should note that this statement can also be used to explain the two different eternal outcomes due believers and unbelievers

        - A believer is one who has humbled himself before God, confessed his sin and unworthiness, and so God will lift him up to glory

        - Conversely, the unbeliever remains stubbornly proud and unrepentant, and so he will face judgment, the ultimate humbling experience

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- But what about believers, what's the message here? And why does Luke place this teaching here?
    - Well, the full answer to that question awaits the conclusion of this chapter, but for now we can say this much
    - From the end of Chapter 13, Jesus is going to refocus his teaching in two ways.
        - First, we said that he has confirmed Israel's rejection of Him, so He has ceased to extend the offer of the kingdom to them
            - This means Jesus is no longer teaching the message of the gospel openly to the nation'
            - Rather, He has begin to teach in a veiled way, through parables
            - You'll quickly notice as we progress through the remaining chapters that cover Jesus' teaching that His public teaching is almost exclusively in parables now
            - While his private teaching to the disciples is always focused on their coming roles as ambassadors for Christ
        - Here we see some of both taking place in the parables of Chapter 14
            - Not only does the parable conceal it's true meaning from the hard-hearted Pharisees
            - But it also conveys an important lesson to the disciples
                - They must remain humble and wait while trusting in their host, God, for their honor which will be bestowed upon them at the wedding feast
- Is this a lesson the disciples need?
    - Well remember the argument the disciples had earlier in Chap 9 of Luke
        - We're told that they had a dispute about who would be the greatest in the kingdom of God
        - A dispute means they seriously disagreed among themselves about which one had the greatest honor and worth to God

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        - This is bound to be a real problem for these men if they aren't taught otherwise

    - And my theory from what I see in the text is that the disciples were the ones who jostling for the honored positions

        - And Jesus sees their behavior, and intervenes to teach on humility

        - And the teaching reflects not only the general spiritual truth about humility, but it also communicates a specific promise to believers

- The promise of the parable to believers is that God the Father is the one who will bestow the appropriate honor upon His invited guests on the day when He conducts His wedding feast

    - And if we spend our time now during these days we have honoring ourselves, propping ourselves up in our own eyes

        - If we go about printing our own diplomas, spiritually speaking – seeking short cuts so as to convince others we have God's approval

        - Seeking to gain through deception what we haven't earned legitimately

    - Then realize the ruse will only last so long

        - We might be able to fool people now in this life for a time

        - But ultimately, we will be the ones humiliated

- Because the time God has given us here and now is not time for our own pleasure

    - If God were primarily interested in our personal pleasure, then He would just take us home to heaven this instant

    - Because He can grant us infinitely greater pleasure in His presence than could ever be possible in this life

        - So it's self-evident that our personal pleasure is not His first concern for us here and now

        - Rather, He has given us His grace and granted us the privilege of serving Him in His work to build His kingdom

        - And He is looking for loyal servants

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- And the more loyal the servant, the greater the honor on the day when all things will be made known
    - He who is faithful with a little, will be trusted with even more, Jesus tells us in a short while in Luke Chap 16

- And just to emphasize this point even further, look how Jesus ends this part of the teaching in Luke 14 :

Luke 14:12 ¶ And He also went on to say to the one who had invited Him, "When you give a luncheon or a dinner, do not invite your friends or your brothers or your relatives or rich neighbors, otherwise they may also invite you in return and *that* will be your repayment.
Luke 14:13 "But when you give a reception, invite *the* poor, *the* crippled, *the* lame, *the* blind,
Luke 14:14 and you will be blessed, since they do not have *the means* to repay you; for you will be repaid at the resurrection of the righteous."

- Jesus moves from talking to the guests (His disciples) to talking to the host of this dinner
    - Jesus advises the host that his honor will be measured by who he shows grace
        - Don't invite those who have the means to repay you
        - In other words, do select your guests on the basis of their own honor
            - You should not select men and women who are worthy of invitations, because to do so gains the host no credit or glory
            - After all, to invite those who deserve an invitation is really just the expected thing – how could the hot get credit for doing what would be natural or expected?
        - Rather the host should strive to pick those who least deserve the invitation

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- The ones who could never do anything to repay the host by their own hand
- And by favoring those who could never earn the favor, the host will receive a much greater reward at the resurrection of the righteous

- There is a wonderful double meaning present in these verses Jesus is teaching
    - First, there is the simple message that the church must understand that our honor from God will be greatest when we act out of heart of service rather than selfishness
        - When we show mercy and charity to the least fortunate
        - Those who could never give us any personal reward in this life
        - Then we are trusting in God for our reward, and when we come into His presence, we will experience a rich payday or eternal reward for our service
    - But the second meaning is even more significant
        - Remember that we said that at the wedding feast the host will be the Father Himself
        - And that the Father's own glory is be the point of all that has happened and will happen in His creation
        - Therefore, Jesus is explaining why it is that God chooses the least of the world to call His children
- Remember Paul's words in the first chapter of 1Cor:

1Cor. 1:26 ¶ For consider your calling, brethren, that there were not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble;
1Cor. 1:27 but God has chosen the foolish things of the world to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to shame the things which are strong,
1Cor. 1:28 and the base things of the world and the despised God has chosen, the things that are not, so that He may nullify the things that are,
1Cor. 1:29 so that no man may boast before God.
1Cor. 1:30 But by His doing you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, and righteousness and sanctification, and redemption,
1Cor. 1:31 so that, just as it is written, "LET HIM WHO BOASTS, BOAST IN THE LORD."

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- The Father's glory will be all the greater on the day when the last believer comes to glory and the wedding feast begins
    - Because on that day the Son's Bride will be made from those who had no hope apart from Christ
    - People who could never repay the host for the grace and mercy they have received
    - People who reflect even greater glory upon the Father because by their unworthiness, they magnify His generosity that much more
- And essentially Jesus is teaching this host and His disciples, and us today
    - Be like your Father in heaven
        - Show mercy as He has shown mercy
        - Seek your reward in Heaven, not among men
    - And just as your Father, the Host of Heaven, will receive greater glory for having favored the unworthy
        - So will you receive greater glory for having served the least deserving among the world

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Luke 14B

- When we last met, Jesus was in the middle of a very interesting meal
    - He had been invited into the home of a leader of the Pharisees
    - With Him are the disciples, we said
        - Jesus has already managed to embarrass the Pharisees by healing on the Sabbath
        - He corrected the disciples for desiring honor in the eyes of men when they should have been focused on remaining humble and seeking honor for their heavenly father
        - Finally, Jesus taught his host to expect reward from God only when he shows favor upon the least deserving
            - Rather than currying favor with those who possess the means to pay you back
    - No ordinary dinner party here
        - And Jesus is no ordinary guest, of course
- As we pick up again at this intriguing dinner party, let's take a moment to consider where Luke is going in this chapter
    - We've said already that Luke alone captures much of what's written in this chapter, so why did He present it to his readers?
    - We began to answer that last week when we took note of how Jesus has embarked on a new focus for the remaining months of His ministry
        - First, He is no longer offering the kingdom to Israel by its leaders, so His message to the leaders has become one of challenging their authority and speaking in parables to conceal his meaning from His adversaries
        - Secondly, to the crowds His message has become very black and while – a dividing line of belief verses judgment
            - He will increasingly emphasize that Jesus Himself represents a demarcation between those who enter the kingdom and those who don't

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        - Finally, Jesus's teaching to the disciples grows in urgency, stirring them in ever greater ways to be ready for the challenges they lay ahead

    - Chap 14 of Luke is a great overview of these three areas of emphasis for Jesus in His remaining time before reaching Jerusalem

        - Let's pick up again in verse 15 as we finish the chapter today and try to put it all together

Luke 14:15 ¶ When one of those who were reclining *at the table* with Him heard this, he said to Him, "Blessed is everyone who will eat bread in the kingdom of God!"

- I'll pause here just briefly to remind us of the circumstances that led to this spontaneous statement by the guest

    - First, remember what Jesus had just done

        - In verse 12-14, Jesus gave his host some advice

        - And without repeating the meaning of Jesus message, let's just say that it probably wasn't seen as a compliment

        - In other words, if you had been sitting around the table in that moment and heard Jesus' words to the host, this is what you might have heard

            - The Host was wrong to invite the privileged

            - He should have invited the least of the world

    - It's hard to avoid the conclusion that Jesus has subtlety insulted his host, which was a huge faux pax in that culture

        - A host's honor came from who he hosted, and the guests in turn were expected to honor the host's efforts

            - So here Jesus has just managed to say something that not only insulted the host, but He also maligned the guests, which further insulted the host

- Have you ever been in a social setting where someone said something embarrassing or created an uncomfortable moment

    - That's what Jesus just did

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- And I imagine there is a pregnant pause, with everyone waiting for someone to say something to break the silence and propel the meal past this awkward moment

- Then some brave individual decides to seize on something Jesus said

  - In verse 14, Jesus had said the host will be repaid at the resurrection of the righteous

  - This is a phrase that every Jew would have understood to mean a time when the Kingdom of God would be established and the Jewish nation would reign with Christ

- So the guest says the first thing that comes to mind in response to Jesus

  - He says, Blessed is every man who eats bread in the kingdom

    - It's something of a throw away line…a passing comment intended to illicit universal agreement

    - When the moment is awkward and there's tension, you want to say something to get past the moment

    - And the best thing to say is something that everyone can agree upon

  - Surely, all the good Jews seated around that Passover table could look forward to spending eternity sitting around God's table eating in the kingdom

- But this poor guy can't win

  - Jesus responds by launching into a parable to counter this guy's comment

Luke 14:16 But He said to him, "A man was giving a big dinner, and he invited many;
Luke 14:17 and at the dinner hour he sent his slave to say to those who had been invited, 'Come; for everything is ready now.'
Luke 14:18 "But they all alike began to make excuses. The first one said to him, 'I have bought a piece of land and I need to go out and look at it; please consider me excused.'
Luke 14:19 "Another one said, 'I have bought five yoke of oxen, and I am going to try them out; please consider me excused.'
Luke 14:20 "Another one said, 'I have married a wife, and for that reason I cannot come.'
Luke 14:21 "And the slave came *back* and reported this to his master. Then the head of the household became angry and said to his slave, 'Go out at once into the streets and lanes of the city and bring in here the poor and crippled and blind and lame.'

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Luke 14:22 "And the slave said, 'Master, what you commanded has been done, and still there is room.'
Luke 14:23 "And the master said to the slave, 'Go out into the highways and along the hedges, and compel *them* to come in, so that my house may be filled.
Luke 14:24 'For I tell you, none of those men who were invited shall taste of my dinner.'"

- The example Jesus gives here illustrates how many in this dinner crowd were going to miss the very meal they were assuming was to be theirs
- To start, Jesus' parable shows a man giving a big dinnr
    - This is a special meal, a real event
    - So big, in fact, that he sends out invitations long before the meal is actually ready
        - There is a delay – a rather long one based on the kinds of excuses he hears
        - But even as the meal is being prepared, the guests have already been identified
            - The ones the master expected to attend the dinner were told well in advance that the meal was coming and the meal was intended for them
            - But meanwhile, the guests go about their lives
- Then the day comes for the master to hold his feast
    - In considering the real feast to be held in God's messianic Kingdom, the millennial kingdom, the Jews had been told of the coming feast in the kingdom
    - As one example, consider Isaiah's prophecy of that moment:

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Is. 25:6 ¶ The LORD of hosts will prepare a lavish banquet for all peoples on this mountain;
A banquet of aged wine, choice pieces with marrow,
And refined, aged wine.
Is. 25:7 And on this mountain He will swallow up the covering which is over all peoples,
Even the veil which is stretched over all nations.
Is. 25:8 He will swallow up death for all time,
And the Lord GOD will wipe tears away from all faces,
And He will remove the reproach of His people from all the earth;
For the LORD has spoken.
Is. 25:9 And it will be said in that day,
"Behold, this is our God for whom we have waited that He might save us.
This is the LORD for whom we have waited;
Let us rejoice and be glad in His salvation."

- This is the kind of promise that the nation of Israel had been looking forward to for centuries
    - They've been waiting along time
    - And the invitation had been extended to the entire nation
    - And among the self-righteous like the Pharisee and other corrupt leaders, the assumption was that they were going to be the first at the table
    - And Jesus had just chastised the crowd – Pharisees and disciples – for seeking honor for themselves
        - But honor would come to those who humbled themselves and served the Father in humility
- And then the appointed day arrives for those guests to be received at the meal
    - And the host sends a representative to invite the guests
    - It's important to note that the host himself doesn't leave his home to gather the guests
    - But his representative goes out for him
        - Obviously, we can begin to draw some obvious parallels from the parable

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- The host here is God the Father, the one who promised the kingdom to Israel,
- The slave or servant here is Jesus, the one who was appointed to offer the kingdom banquet to the nation of Israel

- But when the time comes to make assembled the dinner party, look at the responses the slave receives
    - Each guest tries to use excuses he hopes will sound reasonable
        - Sort of a polite way to be rude
        - Because it would have been very rude for these guests to have agreed to attend at one point, and then made excuses for not attending once the time arrived
        - In the example of a big dinner, it would have been rude to refuse because of the tremendous expenses and effort required to prepared such a lavish meal
        - In kingdom terms, refusals are ultimate a rejection of God Himself
- One guest says I have bought land and I need to inspect it
    - To the savvy Jew, this was an obviously pathetic excuse
        - When someone purchased land in that day – much as it would be today – there was always a careful inspection before the price was paid
            - No sensible man with the financial means to purchase land would have done so without first checking it over carefully
            - Knowing if it was fit for his purpose, whether to find water or farm or as pasture for livestock, etc.
    - So when the man says he can't attend the banquet because he must inspect land he has already purchased, it's clear that he's searching for any excuse to avoid the banquet

- The second man says he just bought five oxen and wants to try them out
    - Here again the reason is obviously just an excuse

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- Like the land, the man would have inspected his oxen before making the purchase
- But there's an additional crack in the façade in this case
    - Five oxen in Jesus day would have been a very substantial purchase
    - A common Jew could afford one or maybe two oxen for the purpose of working his land
    - Think of them as work trucks, pick ups
    - Most families were one-ox families
        - Some might have a pair of oxen, since it would make the work go more quickly
- But for a man to buy 5 oxen at once would be like someone saying he bought a fleet of trucks to work his land
    - This is a rich individual, a man with a lot of resources at his disposal
    - And any man with that kind of wealth isn't going to try out his oxen
    - He isn't going to work his own land
    - He would have slaves and hired men working the land
- So an excuse that he couldn't make the banquet because he needed to try out his oxen was pathetic and obviously disingenuous

- In addition to the fact that these first two examples are obviously pathetic excuses, there is another common quality to them
    - They both emphasize a love for the world and its riches
    - A love for what these men possessed combined with a disregard for the grace and provision being offered by the host
        - The world was the trap that kept them from joining the meal
        - And their own lusts and desires were the catalyst for their rude behavior

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- Most importantly, these are excuses
  - These men don't want to attend, so they are using pathetically weak excuses in an attempt to gain some legitimacy for themselves
    - They hope that they will remain in the favor of the host even though they are being rude
    - They hope that their reasons will allow them have their way without paying the penalty of incurring the Host's wrath

- Then there is the final excuse
  - A man with a wife can't come
    - This is interesting because it's not immediately clear why having a wife would prevent the man from attending
    - Unless you assume that his point was in reference to the law
    - There was a law in Deut that provided for a newly married man to be excused from war for one year

Deut. 24:5 ¶ "When a man takes a new wife, he shall not go out with the army nor be charged with any duty; he shall be free at home one year and shall give happiness to his wife whom he has taken.

- So perhaps the man is hiding behind to this rule of the law as his excuse
  - Obviously the law has nothing to say about attending a banquet
  - In fact, if the man had wanted to attend the banquet, no one would have quoted him Deut 24:5 as a reason why he couldn't attend
  - In other words, the man was free to attend, but he was trying to suggest he's would have been violating the law had he left his wife to attend
    - Again, it's an excuse
  - But this final excuse introduces a new issue in that it adds the issue of the law
    - These men in the parable were absorbed by the world's burdens and by their possessions

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- But they were also unavailable to attend the meal because they were wedded to another – to the law and they liked it
    - They were not interested in leaving behind the one they married
    - Like we heard in Luke 5:37

Luke 5:37 "And no one puts new wine into old wineskins; otherwise the new wine will burst the skins and it will be spilled out, and the skins will be ruined.

- You can't combine the old and the new – you can't add them together – Christ brought a new covenant to replace the old
- But these men wouldn't leave the old behind in order to join the new
- In the end they rejected the Host's feast because they preferred the arrangement they already had under the law

- Now consider the host's response
    - Despite their attempts to avoid his anger, the host sees through the guests' pathetic excuses
        - Just like the Pharisees hearing this parable would have also seen the excuses as unreasonable
    - The Host instructs his servant to gather those who were not originally expected to attend the banquet
        - They were the ones in the streets of the same city
        - But they were not the ones the city expected should be invited to such an elaborate celebration
        - These were the unlikely guests
    - And within the nation of Israel, they represented the lowly who had come to Jesus in faith and believed that He was bringing the kingdom
        - They accepted the invitation and they would be welcomed in place of the nation's leaders who refused the offer

- But then the servant tells the Host that there is still room at the table

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- So the Host tells the servant to reach beyond the city and look for men along the highways and hedges
  - Again, poor downtrodden people, but more importantly, people outside the original community of invitees
  - The gentiles, in other words
  - Because the original group of invitees refused the invitation and did so on such inconsiderate terms, the Host makes a point to invite an even wider audience
    - The point here is not only that the Host is replacing the bad guests with new ones
    - But it's also the point that Host is going out of his way to illustrate how rude the original guests were by the nature of who He chooses as replacements

- We know that is exactly what the father did to the nation of Israel as a result of their rejection of His son
  - Paul explains it this way

Rom. 11:7 ¶ What then? What Israel is seeking, it has not obtained, but those who were chosen obtained it, and the rest were hardened;
Rom. 11:8 just as it is written,
"GOD GAVE THEM A SPIRIT OF STUPOR,
EYES TO SEE NOT AND EARS TO HEAR NOT,
DOWN TO THIS VERY DAY."
Rom. 11:9 And David says,
"LET THEIR TABLE BECOME A SNARE AND A TRAP,
AND A STUMBLING BLOCK AND A RETRIBUTION TO THEM.
Rom. 11:10 "LET THEIR EYES BE DARKENED TO SEE NOT,
AND BEND THEIR BACKS FOREVER."
Rom. 11:11 ¶ I say then, they did not stumble so as to fall, did they? May it never be! But by their transgression salvation *has come* to the Gentiles, to make them jealous.

- What Israel is seeking (e.g., entrance into the promised kingdom) it as a whole has not obtained
  - Some have obtained it, the chosen Paul calls them

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        - These are the ones in the parable who are found in the city streets and come to banquet after the initial group refuse the invitation

    - But the rest are hardened

        - These are the ones mentioned in verse 24

        - The ones who will not share in the banquet no matter what

            - These are the ones who make up the evil generation

            - The generation that rejected Jesus in his day

    - And then look at verse 11 in Roman 11

        - Paul says that the transgression of the nation of Israel in rejecting the Messiah is in the end grace and salvation for the Gentiles who are invited in their place

            - These are the ones by the highways who come in to the banquet

            - That's you and me, my friends

            - We have been graciously invited to join in a banquet that was ultimately prepared for the nation of Israel

- And in case you didn't know, that offer of the banquet will once again be extended to the Jewish nation in a future day

    - Paul finishes chapter 11 this way

Rom. 11:25 ¶ For I do not want you, brethren, to be uninformed of this mystery—so that you will not be wise in your own estimation—that a partial hardening has happened to Israel until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in;
Rom. 11:26 and so all Israel will be saved; just as it is written,
"THE DELIVERER WILL COME FROM ZION,
HE WILL REMOVE UNGODLINESS FROM JACOB."
Rom. 11:27 "THIS IS MY COVENANT WITH THEM,
WHEN I TAKE AWAY THEIR SINS."

    - There is yet a day to come when the nation of Israel receives grace and a new generation will come to know about their Messiah and will receive Him

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- And they will join us around that table

- You can see Luke's theme emerging here in Chap 14
  - Jesus used this dinner as a picture to illustrate all that was happening around Him now that His offer of the kingdom had been rejected by the nation
  - First, Jesus taught on the need for personal humility and not seeking honor through false pretense
    - Rather, each man should know that our honor is based on what the Host sees in us – not on what we can fake by our own efforts
    - Furthermore, the Host will gain greater honor by inviting those who are least deserving,
      - So to the extent we try to make ourselves look more worthy, we are risking an embarrassment when the truth about us is revealed
      - And we are actually working to reduce the Host's own glory, since he will receive more glory when we are humble
  - Secondly, Jesus says that those who claim to be looking forward to the honor of an invitation at this dinner are actually destined to be left behind
    - The cares and desires of this world will trap them
    - As will their love for a law that serves their selfish, deceitful purposes
    - And when they reject the banquet offer, they will be insulting their host
      - Which is very ironic when you consider that it was Jesus in this moment who was seen as insulting His host
      - Jesus tells a parable that turns the tables on the men around that table
        - He reveals that it is they who are insulting far greater host

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- The parables told so far illustrate the changing circumstances of Jesus ministry
    - He no longer is offering his Kingdom to the privileged within Israel
        - His Master has instructed Him to reach out to a different crowd
            - The lowly in Israel
            - And the Gentiles
    - And here we are today, coming in Jesus' footsteps
        - And I want you to give some thought to how these circumstances repeat themselves today
            - Consider how (and if) you preach the gospel to others
                - Who do you reach out to?
                - The privileged? Those who live in the same zip code?
            - Is it a coincidence that the greatest receptiveness to the gospel comes among the poorest and least privileged?
            - While most of Western Europe, many of the most affluent areas of the United States and the richest countries in Asia and the third world are the least interested in the gospel
            - Could this be a continuation of the pattern Jesus mentions here?
- Well, certainly any man or woman is a legitimate target to receive the gospel and we shouldn't discriminate against any one
    - But are we afraid to reach out to the less fortunate with the gospel out of fear or discomfort because they are not like us
        - I hope not
        - God's glory is greater because of who He has invited, and we are called to bring the message to the four corners of the world

- With the time remaining, I want to push through and finish 14 today if we can

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Luke 14:25 ¶ Now large crowds were going along with Him; and He turned and said to them,
Luke 14:26 "If anyone comes to Me, and does not hate his own father and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters, yes, and even his own life, he cannot be My disciple.
Luke 14:27 "Whoever does not carry his own cross and come after Me cannot be My disciple.
Luke 14:28 "For which one of you, when he wants to build a tower, does not first sit down and calculate the cost to see if he has enough to complete it?
Luke 14:29 "Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is not able to finish, all who observe it begin to ridicule him,
Luke 14:30 saying, 'This man began to build and was not able to finish.'
Luke 14:31 "Or what king, when he sets out to meet another king in battle, will not first sit down and consider whether he is strong enough with ten thousand *men* to encounter the one coming against him with twenty thousand?
Luke 14:32 "Or else, while the other is still far away, he sends a delegation and asks for terms of peace.

- Luke's narrative moves forward to a new context
    - And he also transitions to the other side of Jesus' post rejection message
    - While the first part of the chapter presented a series of illustrations of how to enter the kingdom and who shall enter
        - Now the focus turns to those who have accepted the invitation
- Jesus begins by addressing the large crowds that followed Him
    - These crowds were going along with Him
        - Going along with Him meant moving away from home and leaving a regular life behind
        - Because Jesus is moving toward Jerusalem – He has no home
    - And this group is huge, thousands and maybe tens of thousands we were told in an earlier chapter
        - To this group He gives a two-part requirement for discipleship
        - Followed by two illustrations

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- First, Jesus says that if one wants to be his disciple, they must hate their immediate family and even their own life

    - This is a phrase widely understood to mean by comparison that discipleship with Christ means placing all earthly relationships second

    - To include our own personal desires

    - Mirrors what Moses said was true about Levi in how he assumed his role as priest for the nation of Israel

Deut. 33:8 ¶ Of Levi he said,
"*Let* Your Thummim and Your Urim *belong* to Your godly man,
Whom You proved at Massah,
With whom You contended at the waters of Meribah;
Deut. 33:9 Who said of his father and his mother,
'I did not consider them';
And he did not acknowledge his brothers,
Nor did he regard his own sons,
For they observed Your word,
And kept Your covenant.

- Furthermore, Jesus says that a disciple has to be willing to carry his own cross

    - This is a graphic picture of crucifixion, since the condemned carried their cross beam to the place of execution

    - We might say something like pull on your own noose, or take a seat in your electric chair

    - A graphic depiction of being willing to follow Jesus into death

        - Is Jesus making these things to be tests of salvation?

    - By Disciple, does Jesus mean any believer?

        - Must all <u>believers</u> be willing to see these things happen, or else they can't be a believer?

            - The fairest reading of the text would say clearly no

                - The word disciple can be used to mean any pupil or follower of Jesus

                - But in this context, it means a lot more

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- It means someone who would follow after Christ and live a similar life

- Jesus is talking about the person seeking after the honor and rewards he mentioned during that dinner party

- Walter Wiersbe said it this way:

"Salvation is open to all who will come by faith, but discipleship is for believers willing to pay a price. Salvation means coming to the cross and trusting Jesus Christ, while discipleship means carrying the cross and following Jesus."

- As we've said, Luke has narrowed his focus in his presentation of Jesus' teaching

  - He wants to demonstrate how Jesus' teaching reflects two divergent audiences

    - And to each audience, Jesus is delivering a different messages

    - To the Pharisees and other leaders of Israel and to those who follow these corrupt men,

      - Jesus preaches on lost opportunity and awaiting judgment

      - They have lost any opportunity to be included in God's plan, as have any in the crowd who follow after the Pharisees

      - He will continue to preach that they are blind to the truth and cannot please God by their hypocrisy

      - To this crowd, Jesus teaches in parables only

    - Then to the believers around Him, and especially to the disciples

      - Jesus preaches on kingdom lessons designed to prepare these men for what lies ahead

      - He wants them to be prepared for the costs

      - To not shrink back

      - And to appreciate the rewards and honor that await any disciple who would persevere

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- Look at the illustrations Jesus uses to make the point of discipleship
    - A man wanted to build a tower (purgos) which is a common farm building
        - Difficult, costly work
        - And if the work is finished, there is a reward
            - The usefulness of the building, and a testimony to the builder's resourcefulness and planning and determination
            - An accomplishment that brings the builder honor
    - But if the person starts without thinking through what it will take to finish, then when the work becomes hard or the costs too great, he abandons it
        - Now in it's partly completely form, it stands as an embarrassment
        - It stands as a witness against him
        - That he didn't have the steadfastness to finish what he began
        - That he hadn't thought it through before he started
    - So make sure you know what you're signing up for before you start something significant
        - It's interesting to me that this is the second lesson in this chapter that seems to emphasize the embarrassment that could come upon a disciple due to poor behavior in this life
- Then he tells the second parable of the man who prepares to battle an enemy
    - Now the stakes are higher
    - If the disciple isn't prepared to consider the costs and plan accordingly, He won't survive the battle
        - In His example Jesus cites how a king must decide in advance if he can defeat an enemy with a small force
        - If he doesn't think he can win, he's a fool to go forward anyway
        - There is a saying that the one who draws a sword, throws away the scabbard

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- There's no going back once you make a decision to enter battle,
- Retreat or hesitation means destruction

- So is Jesus suggesting we make peace with the world? Only if we don't think we have the stronger force
  - Remember, the king might have decided that his 10,000 were strong enough to defeat the 20,000
  - If this is what he believers, then he can enter the battle confidently
  - But he goes forward with no looking back – he's all in

- So Jesus' point here is that we need to know that if we want to be a disciple, we need to be prepared to go all the way in the spiritual warfare that lies ahead
  - We came to the cross, but now are we ready to be one of those who will carry it with Jesus
  - And if so, we should understand that there is great honor and reward for those who battle hardest in Jesus name but without giving in to sin
  - And even when the forces against us look strong, remember that God's army will always accomplish what God desires

- Jesus sums up the lessons this way

Luke 14:34 ¶ "Therefore, salt is good; but if even salt has become tasteless, with what will it be seasoned?
Luke 14:35 "It is useless either for the soil or for the manure pile; it is thrown out. He who has ears to hear, let him hear."

- Salt is good
  - In ancient times, salt was a critical resource
    - It was needed to sustain life, both humans and animals needed it in small amounts
    - In small amounts, it was used to fertilize land directly

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        - And it was even used to slow the decay process in manure so manure could be preserved and used as fertilizer

    - Salt came mostly from marsh lands rather than evaporating sea water, so the salt had impurities in it

        - Therefore, if the salt stores weren't protected from moisture, the actually salt itself could leech out leaving behind only the impurities

        - In this way, the salt could lose its saltiness and become useless

        - It was thrown away, and couldn't even be used to salt the ground or manure piles

- What is Jesus' application here?

    - If a believer is to be a disciple, that person must be useful to God as salt is to men

        - Like salt the disciple must bring life and rejuvenation

        - The disciples must be an antidote to decay

        - But it does these things by standing out, by being like Christ in a world so unlike Christ

        - And discipleship comes with a cost, though it brings eternal rewards

    - Matthew says it things way

Matt. 5:11 ¶ "Blessed are you when *people* insult you and persecute you, and falsely say all kinds of evil against you because of Me.
Matt. 5:12 "Rejoice and be glad, for your reward in heaven is great; for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.
Matt. 5:13 ¶ "You are the salt of the earth; but if the salt has become tasteless, how can it be made salty *again*? It is no longer good for anything, except to be thrown out and trampled under foot by men.
Matt. 5:14 ¶ "You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden;
Matt. 5:15 nor does *anyone* light a lamp and put it under a basket, but on the lampstand, and it gives light to all who are in the house.
Matt. 5:16 "Let your light shine before men in such a way that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father who is in heaven.

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Luke 15A

- Today we begin Chapter 15 of Luke
    - There are few if any chapters of the Bible more familiar to Christians and non Christians alike than this one
    - And just as has been the case for the previous two Chapters of Luke, most of the content of this chapter is completely unique to Luke's gospel
        - Which is really quite remarkable when you consider the power and impact of this chapter and of it's hallmark feature – parable of the Prodigal Son
        - It's so amazing to me to think that the other three Gospel writers
            - Two of the writers were Apostles themselves and the third was a protégé of the Apostle Peter,
        - These three writers overlooked arguably this, the greatest of all the parables
            - When they first heard it, wouldn't it have stuck with them like it does us today?
            - Nevertheless, God in His wisdom left it to Luke to record this parable
                - A man who never met Jesus in person
                - The only Gentile author in the New Testament –
                - Perhaps there is something in this fact
                - Or perhaps it was that Luke simply had the strongest interest in parables – 20 unique parables
- But as we study this remarkable chapter, we face at least a couple of challenges
    - First, we need to fit the events of Chapter 15 into the larger canvas of Luke's Gospel
        - To understand why Luke places these events here, or even why they were included at all

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        - To see it as part of the larger Gospel story rather than just an isolated story we learned in Sunday School

    - Secondly, we need to find a way to come into the events of this chapter from a fresh perspective

        - For both the teacher and the student, it can be difficult to learn when the material is so well known

        - So we want to take our time and work to understand the circumstances and events portrayed in the three parables that comprise Luke's

- I should also state upfront that in my preparation to teach this parable, I have tried to come into the text in a fresh way, looking to the Holy Spirit to guide me to the answers I sought

    - Yet I realize that few other places in Scripture have inspired as much good teaching as has the Prodigal Son

    - Yet only a fool would ignore so much helpful teaching

        - And not wanting to be a fool, I decided to consult other's teaching on this parable to a far greater degree than I usually do,

        - And I am indebted to many other gifted teachers for the insight I received from their exposition of this text

- With that, let's begin with the first few verses of Chapter 15 of Luke

Luke 15:1 ¶ Now all the tax collectors and the sinners were coming near Him to listen to Him.
Luke 15:2 Both the Pharisees and the scribes *began* to grumble, saying, "This man receives sinners and eats with them."
Luke 15:3 ¶ So He told them this parable, saying,
Luke 15:4 "What man among you, if he has a hundred sheep and has lost one of them, does not leave the ninety-nine in the open pasture and go after the one which is lost until he finds it?
Luke 15:5 "When he has found it, he lays it on his shoulders, rejoicing.
Luke 15:6 "And when he comes home, he calls together his friends and his neighbors, saying to them, 'Rejoice with me, for I have found my sheep which was lost!'
Luke 15:7 "I tell you that in the same way, there will be *more* joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.

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- Perhaps the first question we should ask as we approach this text is to consider how it connects to what came before it
    - And actually, without going past verse 1, we get our answer, at least in part
    - Verse 1 of Chapter 15 tells us that all the tax collectors and sinners were coming to Jesus to listen to Him
    - Why is this significant?
        - Well, consider what Luke just detailed a little over one chapter ago
        - He left the reader with the stunning news that Jesus had been rejected by the very group He came to liberate from sin
        - And now that He has declared them to be an evil generation due judgment, where does He go next with His message?
    - Then add to this the last comment He makes at the end of Chapter 14
        - Jesus says in verse 35 that any would-be disciple will have ears to hear His message
            - In other words, there are still going to be those who hear Him and believe the message
            - Even amidst the crowd of scoffers, and hard-hearted Pharisees, there will yet be a receptive audience for His words of life
    - And now at the beginning of Chapter 15, Luke begins to explore who was the audience for Jesus' message
        - Sure enough, Jesus' message is received by sinners and tax collectors
            - The spiritually needy outcasts of Jewish society
            - Those who had no other hope
                - Certainly they could not hope in themselves
                - They didn't have self-righteousness to fall back on
                - And of course, that was to their advantage

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        - It was the pious, self-righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees and those like them in the crowd that left them unreceptive to Jesus' message

- So Luke presents Chapter 15 to make the case for why:
    - God would welcome into His family these unworthy sinners
    - While hiding Himself from the privileged religious establishment of Israel
        - And he begins by simply noting the chasm in the first two verses
            - The sinners and tax collectors (which is a general way of saying all the lowest in Jewish society) were receiving Jesus
            - And then in verse 2 the religious establishment is grumbling (murmuring among themselves)
    - Jesus, they say, is receiving and eating with sinners
        - What they are saying, in a sense, is that Jesus is giving them opportunity to be made whole in some sense without due penalty being paid
            - They were objecting to the way in which Jesus was willing to restore these people to a respectable standing in society by his associating with them
            - You see, the Pharisee's primary weapon against those who lived a life in open rebellion against the law and the rule of the Pharisees was to ostracize them from the rest of Jewish society
            - To shun them
            - Because Roman rule had limited their ability to apply the penalties of the Law
    - And here was Jesus removing the stigma that these people carried
        - He received them, it says, which means accepted them, even cherished them
        - And He ate with them, which is a sign of fellowship

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- Can you imagine how this treatment impacted these dispossessed groups of society
- They were receiving the thing they probably longed for the most – and the love of God led them to a true repentance
- Rom 2:4 – the kindness of God leads to repentance

- So as we begin Chapter 15, we're immediately struck by the obvious tension that exists between the acknowledged and repentant sinners and the unrepentant self-righteous religious leaders
    - A tension created by how God views and responds to each group
        - His willingness to show mercy to the undeserving while overlooking the apparently worthy
    - Now, some of us can easily understand why God responds this way
        - It makes perfect sense to some of us
            - To those of us who have been in the shoes of the sinner
            - The one who has come to a recognition of his or her own unworthiness
            - The one who has been broken by the realization of how much our sin has wounded God
            - The one who is despondent knowing that there is nothing he can do to rescue himself from his predicament
            - To those of us who have turned from that predicament and turned to God's grace through Jesus Christ,
            - To us the contrast makes perfect sense
    - But to those who are like the Pharisees
        - Those who believe they deserve God's favor
        - To those who are sure they are in the "in crowd"
        - To those who feel they have worked for what they deserve

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- To this group, the idea of God extending grace to sinners makes no sense
- The rules seem upside down, backwards, unfair, ridiculous

- So in response to the religious leaders and their inability to comprehend God's grace and mercy, Jesus tells three parables
  - And that's the second thing to note about Chapter 15
    - Once Jesus begins to teach in verse 3, it's all teaching through the end of the chapter
    - Three parables back-to-back, all intended to address this basic issues – the Pharisee's inability to comprehend how God could find joy in reaching out to the spiritually needy and broken

- The first parable sets the stage for all that follows
  - It's important, I believe, to note how Jesus begins the first parable
    - He says to the Pharisees – who are the audience for these parables – What man among you – or which one of you…
    - Jesus essentially places the Pharisees in the place of God
      - He says, you should be able to understand why God does what He does
      - You can understand why He acts the way He does IF you first appreciate what God sees when He looks upon these destitute and miserable and wretched people
  - If they could stand in God's place, and then look down on sinners, they would see what a shepherd sees when he discovers a lost sheep
    - First, it would have been easy for the Pharisees to identify with the life of a shepherd, though they themselves would never have lowered themselves to such a position
      - Shepherds were probably the most common occupation
    - Secondly, Sheep are a great example of sinners
      - Sheep are notoriously dim witted animals

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- They prefer to remain in flocks and follow the herd
- But they can absent-mindedly graze a distance away from the flock and the shepherd
- Without the flock, they get lost and can stray into circumstances that are harmful

- And in thinking like a shepherd, the Pharisees could certainly appreciate why a shepherd would want to rescue the lost sheep
  - Sheep had real valuable to a shepherd
  - Shepherds had to watch their flocks carefully
  - They usually counted them at night, and if one was missing, they would go look for it, leaving the other sheep behind

- Jesus uses sheep and shepherds to teach the Pharisees that this is the relationship God has with His lost children
  - God see value in his flock and has love for them
  - And He knows them all personally, individually
    - Even while the sheep is lost, he's still a sheep
    - He's still the property of the shepherd
    - Yet the shepherd must take action to reclaim the sheep from the world in which it is lost
  - And until the one lost sheep is found, the shepherd's joy is incomplete
- Likewise, as long as even one piece in God's mosaic of adopted and chosen children remains missing, God is relentless in pursuit of that missing piece
  - Until He succeeds in finding it and returning it to the fold
  - And when the one is found, there is joy over finding the one
- The finishing touch to the first parable is in how Jesus refers to the other 99.
  - These are sinners who have no need for repentance
    - This is actually a sarcastic reference to the Pharisees

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        - They are actually in great need of repentance, of course, but Jesus is referencing their view of self
        - They view themselves as not having need of repentance
        - And this is why they find it so hard to understand why God rejoices over the sinner rather than over them
    - What the Pharisees wanted Jesus to do was congratulate them
        - To fawn over them and their piety
        - To commend them for the strict lifestyle
        - And then condemn the others for not doing likewise
        - They wanted credit for their hard work at being religious
- So while the Pharisees could understand what it meant to be a Shepherd seeking a lost sheep
    - They couldn't yet understand how God might see people in this way, as something worth saving
    - So, Jesus takes a step closer to home with the second parable
    -

Luke 15:8 ¶ "Or what woman, if she has ten silver coins and loses one coin, does not light a lamp and sweep the house and search carefully until she finds it?
Luke 15:9 "When she has found it, she calls together her friends and neighbors, saying, 'Rejoice with me, for I have found the coin which I had lost!'
Luke 15:10 "In the same way, I tell you, there is joy in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner who repents."

- As if to emphasize the value of these lost souls, Jesus changes both the nature of the example and the quantity
    - In this example, a woman loses a silver coin – or more specifically, they are drachmas
        - That's the word here in the Greek for silver coin
        - It's about a day's wage – not a tremendous amount of money
    - And to find the coin, the woman does some extraordinary things

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- First, she lights a lamp
- Houses in Palestine traditionally didn't have windows, so it would be necessary to light a lamp even in the day to find something like a small coin in a dusty dark house
- And she sweeps carefully to find it
  - Because the floors were dirt and probably littered with pebbles or leaves, she had to sweep the entire house
  - Then she would separate the items she swept up until she found the coin
- But if the woman spent a long time looking, she could have spent a significant portion of the coins value looking for it
  - Because the oil in the lamp was costly in itself

- So, the extraordinary effort the woman took to find the coin can't be explained entirely by the coin's intrinsic value
  - It means more to her than simply a day's wage
  - And in fact, Palestinian woman often wore a necklace of drachmas around their necks as a dowry or even their savings
    - So the coin completed a collection that had value as a collection – 1 of 10 where each one had significant worth in terms of the collection
      - Like a mint set
    - It's a case of the whole being worth more than the sum of its parts
    - And Jesus says its like that for God and his children
  - When the missing piece in God's family is found, the collection is complete so to speak
    - As is God's joy
  - And in both parables, the catalyst for joy in Heaven is a sinner's repentance

- There are some interesting parallels between these parables

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- In both parables, the one seeking is a lowly members of Jewish society
  - Shepherds were the lowest class of society above only sinners and tax collectors
  - While women were generally regarded as having little or no value apart from their husbands
  - The parable suggested the Jews since the lost were sheep who had left the fold
  - While the second parable suggested the Gentiles, since the object was a Greek coin

- But in neither case did the Pharisees make the connection
  - They could identify with the shepherd's concerns for the sheep
  - They could identify with the woman's desire for her coin
    - But did they understand why God looks upon the lowly and forgotten of the world as worthy of effort and cost to be saved?
  - They could appreciate the shepherd's happiness at having found the sheep
  - They could appreciate the woman's happiness at having found her lost coin
    - But could they ever understand how God finds joy in restoring a desperate sinner to fellowship in His family
    - Undoubtedly no

- So without missing a beat, Jesus tells one more parable – The Podigal Son
  - And as we begin this parable, I want to draw your attention to something you may have missed in all the times you may have read this parable in the past
    - This parable is misnamed
    - This is not a parable about a son
    - This is a parable about 2 sons – look at verse 11

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Luke 15:11 ¶ And He said, "A man had two sons.
Luke 15:12 "The younger of them said to his father, 'Father, give me the share of the estate that falls to me.' So he divided his wealth between them.

- This is a story about a man, the father of a wealthy estate, and his two sons
    - The story is usually called the prodigal son because the protagonist in the story is a son who squanders his inheritance
    - That's what prodigal means: wastefully extravagant
    - But that name ignores the antagonist of the story: the other son, the righteous son or perhaps the dutiful son would be a better term
    - In fact, if you count the verses of the story, the prodigal son's story is told in 13 verses, while the older sons' story takes up 8
    - So the parable is truly a story about two sons
- So the first son decides to ask the father for his share of the inheritance
    - By inheritance, the son literally means his portion of all the father owns in life
        - The portion of his father's estate that would legally pass to him upon his father's death
    - Under Jewish law, the older son was entitled to a double portion of whatever was due the rest of the siblings
        - So in this case, the older son would have received 2/3 of the estate while the younger received about one third
    - So this is a most remarkable request
        - The son is basically saying I wish you were dead
        - Or you are dead to me
            - It's a completely selfish, self-centered act
            - It shows no regard for the interests or wishes of the father
            - It is utterly disrespectful and shameful

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- And since the father's wealth was wrapped up in his way of life,
    - The son's statement also means he has no interest in the father's business or in the father's name
    - He wishes to completely disassociate himself from the father

- This request is so brash and unprecedented that the only thing that could shock the audience more than hearing of such a demand was to hear the father's response
    - In an even more surprising move, the Father agrees to the request
        - The Father agrees to allow the separation the son requests
        - The story implies that without the Father's consent, the son's fall into misery could never have happened
        - That he would have remained behind in the family much like the older son
            - But had that been the case, consider for a moment what kind of relationship the Father would have had with that son
            - He would have been there in body but not in spirit
            - And the father would have him by his side but knowing all along that the son didn't want to be there and resented the father's control
        - Had the father simply kicked the son out penniless for his insurrection against his authority, then the son would have been destitute from the start
            - And from then on, he could have blamed the heartless father for his pitiful condition

- Rather than do that, the father did the one thing he could do if he wanted to preserve a chance for reconciliation
    - He gave the son the freedom he demanded
    - It's helpful to understand what must have been involved in Jesus' day for a Father to divide the inheritance in this way

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- The inheritance was the family's wealth
    - Which meant it was the home, the land, the farm buildings, the equipment, the slaves, the servants, the animals
    - Everything the father owned
- So if the father was to truly honor this request, the father must first liquidate the family's assets
    - In that day, much as we do today, you could sell a future interest in something of value
        - So, the father could have found buyers willing to purchase the rights to the family property upon the death of the father
    - So the family would receive payment today,, but hold onto the property until the father's death, at which point the new owner would take possession
        - Because this was a future interest, it meant that the inheritance was sold at a discount
        - A future interest is worth less today – like a savings bond

- So this son's demand for his inheritance amounted to a demand that the father liquidate his assets at a loss (a discount) and immediately give the younger son his third
    - Knowing this makes the father's agreement even more remarkable in this story

- But remembering how all these parables were pictures of God's desire for repentance of sinners and His redemption of the lost
    - Then let's consider how this story up to this point represents the story of God relationship with his lost children
    - All those who will one day be redeemed, must begin as lost sinners
    - We are all like this son who runs away from God
        - But in reality, it wasn't us who initiated the running away

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        - That distinction belongs to Adam in the garden

        - Adam was the one who, like this son, decided one day that he wasn't willing to be under the Father's authority

- Adam decided that some portion of what belong to the Father should be his

    - And not content to exist with the Father in sharing the Father's wealth and abundance and provision

    - Adam demanded options, freedom, choices

        - And that demand took the form of disobedience

    - And in response to Adam's selfish behavior, the Father had three choices

        - He could have restricted Adam's ability to even break free

            - He could have eliminated the tree in the garden

            - Or put a fence around it or made the branches so high they couldn't be reached

        - Adam would have been unable to accomplish his desires, but his desires would have remained nonetheless

            - And the father would have still lost the loving relationship he desired

        - Or he could have reacted in anger to the act of disobedience and disrespect by giving Adam what he deserved for his behavior

            - But had God done that, Adam would have immediately perished and all mankind with him

            - Again, the Father would have lost the loving relationship He desired

        - So the final option for the Father

            - Permit Adam's demand to be met

            - Just as the father in the parable agreed to the younger son's demand

                - Not because he agreed with it

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- But because he saw no other way to restore His son to Himself

- And so this is where our story ends today
  - The Pharisees unable to see why God shows favor to sinners
  - Jesus teaching how sinners are a thing of value to God and worthy of being counted, of being found and restored
  - Of a story where a rebellious son longs to distance himself from a Father's authority
  - And a patient father willing to grant the son his distance so He might ultimately preserve the relationship

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Luke 15B

- Today we conclude Chapter 15 of Luke
- As we ended last week, we saw that
    - The Pharisees unable to see why God shows favor to sinners
    - Jesus teaching how sinners are a thing of value to God and worthy of being counted, of being found and restored
    - Of a story where a rebellious son longs to distance himself from a Father's authority
    - And a patient father willing to grant the son his distance so He might ultimately preserve the relationship
- So we pick up in Chap 15 at that point…

Luke 15:13 "And not many days later, the younger son gathered everything together and went on a journey into a distant country, and there he squandered his estate with loose living.
Luke 15:14 "Now when he had spent everything, a severe famine occurred in that country, and he began to be impoverished.
Luke 15:15 "So he went and hired himself out to one of the citizens of that country, and he sent him into his fields to feed swine.
Luke 15:16 "And he would have gladly filled his stomach with the pods that the swine were eating, and no one was giving *anything* to him.

- The son gathers his property together, squanders it, and then finds himself in ever increasing desperation, trying to work his way out of his predicament
    - Go back to something else I mentioned at the end of last week
    - I said that Adam's fall in the garden was pictured in the way the young son rejected the authority of the father
        - Let's review that picture
        - The effect of Adam's sin was that man had placed an infinite separation between mankind and the Creator

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- We could no longer be in His presence
- And we have inherited an evil heart that does not trust in God nor look to Him but only trusts in its own evil desires

- And there were consequences for Adam's rebellion against the Father
  - He began to rely on himself rather than on Father
- But the son made poor decisions when left to run his own life, according to his own desires
- And then when his own resources ran out, the unexpected occurs
  - The famine occurs
  - The abundance of food disappears
  - God produces a stress on the earth, a trial
  - And in the testing and in the trials, the man is brought face to face with the consequences of his sin
- Scripture tells us that we are enslaved by our sin
  - We are in bondage to our sin, a slave to sin, Paul calls us
  - Just like this prodigal son who has become a slave to some master

- And yet despite his hard work, he was not finding satisfaction
  - He's cleaving to someone he believes can give him what he needs
  - He's doing hard work
  - He's doing everything he can in his power to make up for his mistakes and to correct for his errors
    - Yet he still can't seem to earn enough to make good
    - He can't get ahead
    - And he's still hungry
    - He can't find the kind of peace and fulfillment he needs, despite his hard work

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        - He's absolutely desperate and without alternatives and seemingly without hope

    - This is the state of sinful men in the world

        - Men work their whole lives to work their way out of a fear of death and the desperation that sin creates

            - They long for an inner peace or satisfaction in life
            - But in our own work, we only fall farther behind
            - Because the wages of sin are death
            - Work just isn't the answer to our problem
            - The answer is grace

- And in this moment of desperation, something remarkable happened

Luke 15:17 "But when he came to his senses, he said, 'How many of my father's hired men have more than enough bread, but I am dying here with hunger!
Luke 15:18 'I will get up and go to my father, and will say to him, "Father, I have sinned against heaven, and in your sight;
Luke 15:19 I am no longer worthy to be called your son; make me as one of your hired men."'

- He came to his senses we're told

    - Heautou – conscious, as in he became conscious
    - Just as Rom 2:4 tells us that the kindness of God leads you to repentance

        - As it was here, that the Father's kindness is on the mind of the young man as he comes to his senses
        - Just as Paul explains our entry into faith by grace:

Titus 3:3 For we also once were foolish ourselves, disobedient, deceived, enslaved to various lusts and pleasures, spending our life in malice and envy, hateful, hating one another.
Titus 3:4 But when the kindness of God our Savior and *His* love for mankind appeared, He saved us

    - Upon the son's return, the father went to an extreme to shield the son from public humiliation and scorn – he ran to meet him

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- The Father protected his son against the shame by taking the shame upon himself
    - Just as Christ did the same for lost sinners the world over
- And so the son returns, and the Father welcomes him
    - And the Father places on the son are symbols of sonship for a son who has been restored
    - A robe, a ring, and sandals
    - The son has regained his entire claim to sonship with the father
        - And what did the son do to earn it?
        - Nothing of course
        - He done nothing more than had a change in conscious, made a decision to repent
        - And returned to the Father and expressed that repentance
        - And the Father accepted him joyfully
- So as the earlier parables taught, the father is ready to celebrate
    - He throws a party
        - And the celebration is the same celebration Jesus taught in the first two parable
        - The joy of a repentant sinner
        - A son restored
    - But that's only the first half of the story
        - Like we said, this is a story of two sons, not one
        - So now Jesus turns his attention to the other son who has been discussed sine the opening verses of the parable

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Luke 15:25 ¶ "Now his older son was in the field, and when he came and approached the house, he heard music and dancing.
Luke 15:26 "And he summoned one of the servants and *began* inquiring what these things could be.
Luke 15:27 "And he said to him, 'Your brother has come, and your father has killed the fattened calf because he has received him back safe and sound.'
Luke 15:28 "But he became angry and was not willing to go in; and his father came out and *began* pleading with him.
Luke 15:29 "But he answered and said to his father, 'Look! For so many years I have been serving you and I have never neglected a command of yours; and *yet* you have never given me a young goat, so that I might celebrate with my friends;
Luke 15:30 but when this son of yours came, who has devoured your wealth with prostitutes, you killed the fattened calf for him.'
Luke 15:31 "And he said to him, 'Son, you have always been with me, and all that is mine is yours.
Luke 15:32 'But we had to celebrate and rejoice, for this brother of yours was dead and *has begun* to live, and *was* lost and has been found.'"

- The older son is in the field
    - This is interesting, since we already know that this is a wealthy family with plenty of hired servants
    - As the sole remaining son, the older boy had little reason to invest his time working in the field
    - They would have had servants over other servants
        - It gives a picture of a son working overtime to please his father
        - Going overboard to show his faithfulness and his willingness to work hard to earn his father's favor
        - There would have been little other reason for him to be in the field
    - And he's so far from the house and so far from the events of the family, that he has to ask a servant to bring him up to date on the family news
        - He doesn't seem to have a very close relationship with the father
        - He asks what's going on in my father's house

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- And when he learns that his father has shown grace and mercy and lovingkindness to his wayward son, he becomes angry
    - In some ways it's an understandable reaction to us
    - We might share his anger at seeing someone receiving favor when they don't deserve it
        - Until we remember that we would want the same grace if the roles were reversed
        - But the older son couldn't understand that concept, because the older son didn't need grace
        - He had earned his father's praise, he thought
- The son is so upset, he refuses to join the celebration
    - He won't go into the Father's house
    - He stays away pouting over the situation
    - He demands that the Father come to him
        - And the father graciously comes near to hear his complaint
        - And the older son says I have served you for years
        - I have paid careful attention to all your commands
        - Yet I never received any celebration for my effort
            - You never prepared me a goat much less a calf
            - But you celebrate with a man who used your wealth to buy prostitutes
- Did you notice some of the important details in that conversation?
    - The son wants a celebration for his effort
    - And had their been a celebration, he wanted the Father to host the party but the celebration would have been with his friends, not with the father himself
        - In other words, He need the father to do things for him because he had earned them

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        - But there was no love, no shared joy, merely privilege earned
        - Even the way he addressed the father in the moment was "Look!"
            - You don't speak to the father that way
            - You say Father, I am here.
            - Or Speak, Father
            - Something respectful
    - And now he was angry because someone less deserving was receiving the Father's love
- Then the father tells the older son, why are you complaining
    - Why do you feel shortchanged?
    - You always had access to all that I had
    - You could have received all that I could give you,
        - You only had to come to me in love
        - You can't earn that love
    - But when the lost come to their senses, we have to celebrate
- Finally, to apply this parable to the world once again, do you see the connections?
    - Both these sons were sinners and in rebellion to the Father
        - One was overt, obvious and unabashed
        - The other was the hypocrite, the one who was determined to earn the favor he desired
        - One was brought low and brought to his senses
        - The other remained indifferent and unrepentant
        - One returned to the Father with a new heart and a new desire to serve
        - The other remained steadfastly proud and separated from the Father, demanding the Father come to him

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        - One is restored to sonship though deserving of judgment
        - The other remains outside the family celebration though expecting to be rewarded for diligent service

- Jesus teaches this parable to illustrate not only wht God will celebrate in the lost being found
    - But Jesus is also explaining why the Pharisees are not receiving Jesus' message
        - Why Jesus has turned his back on them and left them on the outside looking in
        - And why the poor, destitute sinners and tax collectors – the ones who did have ears to hear – bring joy to heaven
- Luke includes Chapter 15 for us to explain how and why Jesus turns his back on the religious establishment
    - And why He found a receptive audience with the lowest in society
    - And having answered so clearly the basis for the Pharisee's rejection of Jesus, Luke makes a significant shift at the end of Chapter 15
        - He moves into an extended series of chapters looking almost exclusively at the disciples and his preparation of them for ministry
        - It's a wonderful series of chapters for us too on how we should approach our ministry on earth

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Luke 16A

One Sunday, a preacher was speaking one what it would take for the church to become better. He said "If this church is to become better, it must take up it's bed, and walk." The congregation said "Let it walk, Preacher, let it walk."

Encouraged by their response, he went further. "If this church is going to become better, it will have throw aside it's hindrances and run!" The congregation replied, "Let it run, preacher, let it run!"

Now really into his message, he spoke stronger. "If this church really wants to become great, it will have to take up it's wings and fly!" "Let it fly, Preacher, let it fly!" the congregation shouts.

The Preacher gets louder. "If this church is going to fly, it will cost money!" The congregation replied. "Let it walk, Preacher, let it walk."

- Money can be an unpopular topic
    - Or at least it used to be
    - In many churches today it seems to have become the only topic
        - Rather than preachers talking about our support of ministry
        - They often talk about how God desires to make us rich
- In many corners, the church seems to have become completely obsessed and distracted with money and wealth?
    - Many messages from the pulpit these days deal in part or even exclusively with wealth and prosperity
        - Just ask yourself how many church billboards advertise Sunday messages or entire series on wealth or finances?
        - Not surprisingly, the bigger and more prominent the ministry, often the more it seems to focus on money topics
        - Consequently, how many Christians today see their faith exclusively within the context of a discussion of wealth – or to the use the Christianese – in terms of blessings?

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- The Bible does talk about wealth extensively
    - But if addresses it very differently than the way many false teachers would prefer to preach it
    - Christ taught a parable specifically for the purpose of teaching us the proper attitude toward Earthly wealth
        - But if we're going to appreciate God's view of wealth and His purpose in giving it, then we're going to have to really be prepared for a shock
        - Because God's ways are not man's ways

Luke 16:1 ¶ Now He was also saying to the disciples, "There was a rich man who had a manager, and this *manager* was reported to him as squandering his possessions.
Luke 16:2 "And he called him and said to him, 'What is this I hear about you? Give an accounting of your management, for you can no longer be manager.'
Luke 16:3 "The manager said to himself, 'What shall I do, since my master is taking the management away from me? I am not strong enough to dig; I am ashamed to beg.
Luke 16:4 'I know what I shall do, so that when I am removed from the management people will welcome me into their homes.'
Luke 16:5 "And he summoned each one of his master's debtors, and he *began* saying to the first, 'How much do you owe my master?'
Luke 16:6 "And he said, 'A hundred measures of oil.' And he said to him, 'Take your bill, and sit down quickly and write fifty.'
Luke 16:7 "Then he said to another, 'And how much do you owe?' And he said, 'A hundred measures of wheat.' He *said to him, 'Take your bill, and write eighty.'
Luke 16:8 "And his master praised the unrighteous manager because he had acted shrewdly; for the sons of this age are more shrewd in relation to their own kind than the sons of light.
Luke 16:9 "And I say to you, make friends for yourselves by means of the wealth of unrighteousness, so that when it fails, they will receive you into the eternal dwellings.
Luke 16:10 ¶ "He who is faithful in a very little thing is faithful also in much; and he who is unrighteous in a very little thing is unrighteous also in much.
Luke 16:11 "Therefore if you have not been faithful in the *use of* unrighteous wealth, who will entrust the true *riches* to you?
Luke 16:12 "And if you have not been faithful in *the use of* that which is another's, who will give you that which is your own?

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- Thomas Constable wrote that this is the most difficult parable in scripture to interpret
- And at first reading, it's not hard to see why
    - We're immediately struck by the parable's paradoxical message – by what appear to be several internal contradictions
        - The master is ready to fire his manager for mismanagement
            - But then the master praises the manager for being shrewd in what appears to be a scheme to cheat the master out of even more money
        - This manager looks like a genuinely detestable character who embezzles from his boss at every opportunity
            - Yet in the end, Jesus seems to praise his behavior
    - The parable is throwing contradictions at us
- And then there is this reference to unrighteous wealth
    - What is unrighteous wealth anyway?
    - Well, let's sort this out
- As is usually, the case a little background is necessary
- In Jewish culture (as in our culture today) wealthy businessman often employed managers to handle their business affairs
    - These managers would attend to every detail of the master's business, including purchasing and selling goods and extending credit to customers
        - But under Jewish law, specifically Deut 23:19, it was unlawful to charge usury interest
    - So it became a custom in Jewish society for a manager such as this one to overcharge a customer by adding his own fee directly to the bill for the goods or services
    - So when the bill was repaid, the manager took his share off the top and gave the rest that was due to his master

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- It was not uncommon for a manager to charge a 100% fee on top of the bill owed the master

- So, the first thing to understand is that the fee these clients owed to the master was in part money owed to the master himself and part money owed to the manager for his services

- Now the second thing to understand as we study this parable is what comparison Christ is making in verse 8

  - In verse 16:8, Jesus makes the comparison between the sons of this age (in other words, unbelievers) and the sons of light (believers)

    - And He uses a very important phrase

      - He uses the term "in relation to their own kind"

    - In other words, he's not making a comparison between how believers deal with unbeliever or vice versa

    - He's making a comparison between how unbelievers deal with other unbelievers vs. how believers deal with other believers

  - So the second point is that the Church (us) can learn something about how to deal with one another in the area of money from what we see unbelievers doing with one another with their wealth

- So looking at the deals, we find a manager who has not been reliable in his position of authority, and the master tells him he is ready to fire him

  - But notably he doesn't fire him yet – technically the manager is still on the payroll

  - But before releasing him, the master tells the manager to give an accounting of his management

    - The master wants to look over the books and see how bad things are

- Now the manager sees his chance to help himself

  - He knows that his firing is imminent – he's about to leave this comfortable world he has grown accustomed to

    - And he doesn't know what he will find on the outside how will he be received?

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- He probably wasn't well liked, for being a tough negotiator or unforgiving creditor for his master

- So he wants to develop a plan to help break his fall when he is fired

- Something that will make his life easier and better when he finds himself on the other side

- So he devises a shrewd scheme

  - He realizes that all the debts that are currently owed to his master include a portion that belongs to him – his fee added to each debt

    - Since he knows he's going to be fired before those customers repay their debt, he stands to lose all that money

  - So why not at least gain some advantage out of his loss

    - He runs to each of his master's debtors and while he still has the master's authority, he reduces their debts by the amount of his fee

      - This is perfectly legal because the manager is still employed as the master's representative

    - Since only the manager's fee was deducted from each bill, the master's original debt is still going to be paid

      - The master has not lost a cent

- Meanwhile, the manager builds good will among these clients in the hope they will look favorably upon him when he is unemployed and looking for help

  - The Master praises the manager because this is such a smart move

    - It's a win-win-win

      - The master's business benefits from the positive reaction of the clients to the discounts

      - The clients save money,

      - The manager gains the favor of the clients,

    - So Jesus isn't praising his previously poor management style

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- He simply praises the manager's shrewdness in knowing how to use money for the greatest gain in his world

- But here's where the parable can get's tough…
  - Jesus says that the sons of light (us) could learn something from how this manager responded to his situation
    - Jesus says that the unbelievers are more shrewd than Christians
    - And it's clear from the text that Jesus is not praising the manager's previous mismanagement
      - He's praising his creativity in light of his limited opportunity
  - In a nutshell, Jesus tells the disciples that we should use the wealth of unrighteousness to make friends for the sake of eternity
    - The problem most people have with truly understanding this parable is that we don't understand the difference between the wealth of unrighteousness and the wealth of righteousness
    - Did you assumed that the wealth of unrighteousness meant wealth gained through dishonest means?
      - It doesn't
      - The wealth of unrighteousness is the money of this world – the treasure of earth
        - The money that the sons of this age seek after
        - The money that perishes along with everything else in this world when it burns up
        - The money that people store up here rather than in storing a treasure in heaven
      - It's called unrighteous because it is the money that the unrighteous world values
        - The money that the unbelieving world puts it's trust in

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- Now you can put all this together and understand why Jesus compliments the sons of this age and criticizes the believers
    - Jesus says we should learn from how the unrighteous use their wealth
        - Like the manager, unbelievers are willing to influence people and win friends and gain all the benefits that their money can give them in this world
        - For unbelievers, the money of this world is all they have to depend upon and trust in – it is their treasure
            - And they make the most of what their money will buy them in this world, until their time is up
    - But the sons of light are criticized for not dealing with one another as shrewdly as unbelievers deal with each other
        - And here's the secret
            - Because we live as if we were sons of this world
                - As if we had no future in eternity either
                - As if the money we have right now is our treasure in heaven
            - But it's not
                - The money God has given you right now is the wealth of unrighteousness
                    - It will burn up when this world ends
    - But what if I told you there was a way to turn it into real tresure in heaven
        - That you could deposit it in your bank in heaven so that when you leave this world and enter eternity, you would have it there waiting for you
            - And it will never perish there
            - It can't be stolen
            - It can't wear out

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- It's actually very easy – spend it on the work of the kingdom now
  - And I'm not talking about tithing – at least not exclusively
  - Look at what Jesus says in the parable
    - Verse 9 – make friends with your earthly money, but who are the friends of the sons of like? Other sons of light?
- And what will these sons of light do if you use your wealth for their benefit? They welcome you into eternal dwellings
  - Unlike the favors that the unrighteous earned with their money – favors that perish when this world ends, the rewards you earn, the eternal friends you win for Christ bring eternal benefits
  - Whether you're helping fund outreach ministries that establish new believers
  - Or supporting the Body of Christ by funding Christian organizations
  - Or providing financial aid to the widow or poor or sick living down the street,
  - Or just placing an extra check in the offering plate, or whatever God lays on your heart,
  - When you use unrighteous wealth to gain eternal benefits, you are that shrewd manager – but one working for an eternal master – one who will remember your good management

- Look at what Jesus says at the end of the parable
  - Of the unrighteous wealth that God has given you here…
    - Wealth that has no true value
    - Wealth that will all burn up anyway
    - Wealth that you can't take with you
    - Wealth that will be completely forgotten in eternity
  - If you aren't willing to spend that wealth now for His glory and for the benefit of His kingdom – if you would trust in it and store it up even though you know it won't be with you in eternity

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        - Then Jesus asks what kind of true riches do you expect to have in eternity? Why should God trust you with eternal riches?

- You want a prosperity message from scripture? Brother and sisters – that's the true prosperity gospel

    - God gives you what He determines, and then He watches what you do with it

        - If you horde it, focus on it, worry over it and spend your whole life trying to get more, save more, earn more and glorify yourself with it – then you better enjoy it while you can

            - Because in eternity you'll have very little to bother over

        - But if you live contently with whatever God has given you, determined to put every penny you can to work for the glory of God and for his kingdom, winning friends who will greet you in eternity – then you will certainly see eternal treasure

    - In other words, just like the manager who turned his worthless unpaid bills into true gain, Christians should use the worthless wealth of this world to build up treasure in heaven

        - And if we truly recognized the perishable nature of this world's wealth, we would never hesitate to use it for the gain of eternal riches

        - Consider Christ's words at the end of that parable

Luke 16:10 ¶ "He who is faithful in a very little thing is faithful also in much; and he who is unrighteous in a very little thing is unrighteous also in much.
Luke 16:11 "Therefore if you have not been faithful in the *use of* unrighteous wealth, who will entrust the true *riches* to you?
Luke 16:12 "And if you have not been faithful in *the use of* that which is another's, who will give you that which is your own?

- First, Jesus says we have been entrusted with a very little thing

    - Our earthly ministry is a very little thing in the view of eternity and in the view of all that God has at his disposal

        - And we are asked to be faithful to it

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- Which means doing with it what He asks us to do

- But if we are unrighteous in such a very little, we will be unrighteous if given a lot

- So don't expect God to give you a lot – either now or in the age to come

- And if you are unrighteous in the use of this worthless Monopoly money that the world worships

- Then God has good reason to expect that you would be equally unrighteous with true kingdom riches

- So don't expect to inherit anything of value

- Finally, If you aren't faithful in using something that is not your own (world's money)

- Something you should be even more willing to use for God's purposes

- Then how will you expect God to entrust you with something that is truly yours

- In other words, riches in heaven awarded to you

- The obvious answer to all these questions is you won't be rewarded

- You will lose your reward

- Remember the words of Christ in Matt….

Matt. 13:44 ¶ "The kingdom of heaven is like a treasure hidden in the field, which a man found and hid *again*; and from joy over it he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field.

- We are trading one treasure for another

- And the irony is that only one is of any lasting value

- Only one should mean anything to us

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- Jesus ends with one of the most powerful statements on wealth in the Bible:

Luke 16:13 "No servant can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will be devoted to one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and wealth."

- This verse implies two very important principles
    - First, money is either a tool to please God or it is your God
    - And the test to determine whether you see money as a tool or as your god is this
        - If you view money as merely a tool – a means to pleasing God
            - Then you will despise money
            - You will use it when needed to accomplish your mission
            - But you will have no love for it
            - You will not relish it
            - You will not enjoy working with it
            - It will not capture you attention
            - It will not excite you
        - For Jesus says if you love one, you will hate the other
        - If are devoted to one, you will despise the other
    - And so it goes in reverse
        - If you are in love with money
        - If you are focused on your money and what it can do for you
        - Then you are despising God or worse – hating Him

- This is a hard lesson, but never before has the church been so rich
    - And so weak, and so fickle, and so complacent

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- Paul said it best

2Tim. 3:1 ¶ But realize this, that in the last days difficult times will come.
2Tim. 3:2 For men will be lovers of self, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant, revilers, disobedient to parents, ungrateful, unholy,
2Tim. 3:3 unloving, irreconcilable, malicious gossips, without self-control, brutal, haters of good,
2Tim. 3:4 treacherous, reckless, conceited, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God,
2Tim. 3:5 holding to a form of godliness, although they have denied its power; Avoid such men as these.

- And in the next two verses, we see why Jesus chose to teach the disciples on this point

Luke 16:14 ¶ Now the Pharisees, who were lovers of money, were listening to all these things and were scoffing at Him.
Luke 16:15 And He said to them, "You are those who justify yourselves in the sight of men, but God knows your hearts; for that which is highly esteemed among men is detestable in the sight of God.

- Jesus knew that the chief stumbling block of the Pharisees was their love of money and men's approval
    - But Jesus rightly calls them for their hypocrisy and their love of money rather than their love of God
        - Again, it's one or the other
        - Their every action and thought was directed around building themselves up – either financially or publicly
        - And Jesus is teaching His disciples to learn from the mistakes of these men and not to repeat them

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Luke 16B

- Last week we studied the remarkable parable of the unrighteous manager
    - We saw Jesus lecturing the disciples on the true purpose of money and on the way to store up treasure in heaven
    - And then following the teaching, the Pharisees began their usual carping
        - Which prompted Jesus to respond that they were men who justify themselves in the sight of men
        - They made themselves look holy and righteous in how they behaved
        - Yet their true heart was known by God, and He knows they were merely hypocrites
        - They had no true righteousness because they had never confessed their sins and repented
    - And so this chapter continues the pattern we've seen for several chapters now
        - Luke alternates between showing Jesus teaching the disciples how to see the world truly
        - And then contending with the false pretense of the Pharisees and other leaders in Israel
- And so that's where we go next in Chapter 16
    - Jesus transitions smoothly from his topic of money well spent to another illustration to expose the Pharisees true nature to the group

Luke 16:15 And He said to them, "You are those who justify yourselves in the sight of men, but God knows your hearts; for that which is highly esteemed among men is detestable in the sight of God.
Luke 16:16 ¶ "The Law and the Prophets *were proclaimed* until John; since that time the gospel of the kingdom of God has been preached, and everyone is forcing his way into it.
Luke 16:17 "But it is easier for heaven and earth to pass away than for one stroke of a letter of the Law to fail.

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Luke 16:18 ¶ "Everyone who divorces his wife and marries another commits adultery, and he who marries one who is divorced from a husband commits adultery.

- I re-read the final verse from last week to help give us some context
    - Jesus is explaining why these evil men are pursuing Him and denying Him and leading so many astray
    - He says they seek to be esteemed with men rather than God by glorifying what men glorify
        - Jesus is using their earlier scoffing at his comments about money as the basis for His accusations here
            - They love money, they love the esteem of men
            - God sees desiring money for the sake of accumulating wealth as detestable
            - And God views any attempt to win the praises of men as detestable
- But then Jesus offers these interesting observation about the Word of God
    - The Law and the Prophets were proclaimed until John, Jesus says
        - It should be clear to all of us that Jesus is referring to the Law – the Books of Moses – and the books of the Prophets
        - And logically, we sould also include the third part of the Hebrew Bible, the Writings, which includes the Psalms, Proverbs, Songs of Solomon, prophetic books, historical books, etc.
    - These words of God were proclaimed until John
        - John refers to John the Baptist, whose ministry preceded and announced Jesus own ministry
        - In fact, John the Baptist was the last OT prophet
    - What does Jesus mean that the OT was proclaimed until John?
        - He's referring to the consummate purpose of those proclamations
        - In other words, Jesus is referring to the very purpose God had in giving men those writings

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- He delivered His word through Moses and the prophets so that men might know and understand that God would establish His kingdom on earth
- And more specifically, God's kingdom would come through and by a Messiah, a Savior, a King who would rule the world
- And these books of God's word told the Jewish nation that they would have opportunity to enter into that kingdom
    - Provided they accepted the one Who God would send to inaugurate that kingdom
    - As long as they accepted their Messiah

- And until John's day, the only voice God offered His people to help them recognize the Messiah was His Word
    - But it was more than enough
    - The entire Bible is a testimony to Jesus Christ
    - And to His ministry on earth
    - And to His coming reign on earth
        - Every page of the Bible teaches of Christ
        - Open a page and I can find Jesus on that page
        - He is represented in a variety ways
            - Sometimes he's present on the page as the Angel of the Lord
            - Sometimes he's pictured by the events of a historical individuals like Isaac or Joseph or David
            - Sometimes he represented in the pattern of God's ordinances as is the case in the design and furnishing of the temple
            - Sometimes He's represented in God's commandments as He is in the Sabbath Day or the festivals

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- Often He's depicted prophetically in the writings of the prophets or the Psalms
- Sometimes Jesus is represented by the actions of individuals or through historical events, as when Boaz redeems Ruth, or when David invites Mephiboshef to his dining table
- And on and on…

- The entire Bible is a testimony in details great and small to Jesus and Him Crucified and Him Risen and Him ruling
    - And this went on until John's day, Jesus says
    - Because once John came and proclaimed the arrival of the Messiah, the message suddenly changed
        - Rather than tell the nation that God would send a deliverer
        - Rather than saying that the Messiah was a promised future event
        - Now John declared the present reality of that promise
        - The messiah was here
        - And even John's ministry was foretold by those same Prophets, so that there could be no doubt that when it happened, everyone would know it and recognize it
        - So long as they were looking for the kingdom that God was promising – the one foretold in scripture
    - What's more, the Jesus Himself has been proclaiming the kingdom of God Himself
        - And He's been proclaiming it with power and wisdom
            - With miracles and compassion
            - He has met every qualification and his credentials are undeniable
            - He is the perfect fulfillment of all that had been written before concerning Him

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- Those who had heeded the earlier messages through the Law and Prophets couldn't help but know that Jesus was the one promised

- But then Jesus says something interesting
    - He says that everyone is forcing his way into it
        - Matthew has a similar verse in Chapter 11 that reads this way

Matt. 11:12 "From the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven suffers violence, and violent men take it by force.
Matt. 11:13 "For all the prophets and the Law prophesied until John.

    - Both Matt and Luke describe a similar situation
        - The kingdom of God is a specific kingdom
        - It has a specific form, and it is offered under specific circumstances to certain people on a certain basis
        - And all those specifics are decided by God Himself
        - It's His kingdom
        - He determines who He invites and who He accepts into it
    - And He determined the kingdoms and nature according to His sovereign will
        - And He revealed this will concerning the kingdom through His word and through His son
        - And He issued His invitation through His word, as Jesus said
    - But nevertheless, violent men are trying to take it by force
        - Or as Luke words it, men are forcing their way into it
        - Who are these violent men?
            - The Pharisees of course

- The Pharisees wanted to make their own rules for how to approach God and enter His kingdom

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- They wanted to come on their own terms
- Like the older son in the prodigal son parable, they demand that the Father award them what they deserve on the basis of their hard work and diligence
  - But they forget that the Father has the sole prerogative to offer His grace and mercy to whom He wishes and on the basis He wishes
  - And Jesus is teaching at this moment the fact that even as He preaches the true kingdom, these violent men are determined to define their own path to God
    - To force their way into the kingdom if it were even possible
    - And they eventually prove His words true, as their violent nature drives them to put Jesus to death at the hands of the Romans

- But then Jesus makes the obvious and yet profound statement putting got rest the issue of who will enter the kingdom
  - Jesus says that it's easier for heaven and earth to pass away than for one stroke of the Law to fail
  - In fact, in Luke 21:33 Jesus says that Heaven and Earth WILL pass away, but Jesus Words – God's words – will never pass away
    - Given How Jesus began this section
      - Talking about the Law and prophets in verse 16
    - And then considering his comment from chapter 21
      - I believe it's fair to say that He's not talking strictly about the Law
      - But rather He's referring to all of God's word, the Law and everything else God has recorded in His Word
      - None of it will fail or be ignored or forgotten

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- Thought the Pharisees would like to ignore it and find their own satisfaction, they can't succeed
    - God's word will stand
    - And more to the point, His word regarding the Kingdom and how men may enter it will stand
    - And no one may force themselves into the kingdom on the basis of anything other than an understanding of God's word
        - Not in Pharisee's day
        - Nor in our Day
        - Paul says that Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the word of Christ, in Rom 10:17
        - It is the one divinely appointed way that God will reveal Himself and call men to Himself and welcome them into the kingdom
- And just to prove His point concerning the unchanging and uncompromising quality of God's word, Jesus reminds his audience of the hard truth taken from God's word
    - He cites one simple example on divorce
    - But it was a point on which the Pharisees were particularly vulnerable
        - Jesus states the Biblical truth concerning divorce
            - That is to divorce and remarry is adultery
            - And to marry someone who has been divorced is also adultery
        - The principle here is that marriage is defined by God as one man and woman becoming one flesh
            - To join ourselves to another in a sexual union under virtually any circumstances is a adultery
            - Paul emphasizes this idea at several different points in his letters
    - Now I said virtually any circumstances because Jesus Himself makes an exception for one situation

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- Twice in Matt Jesus adds a disclaimer that if the partner commits adultery while in the marriage, then the other partner is free to remarry
- The idea here is that the first partner's act of adultery has already destroyed the marriage covenant leaving the second partner free to remarry if desired
    - Jesus doesn't mention the exception here in order to keep His point before the Pharisees pure and uncomplicated
    - God's law is inviolate and will not change, not even for the whims and desires of men
        - Men like these Pharisees who loved to change God's rules in order to suit their own desires

- In Jesus day the Pharisees had become a law unto themselves
    - And this was never more evident than in the area of divorce
        - The Pharisee had created rules and procedures around divorce
        - And it had become very political
            - They claimed to never allow it because God forbade it
            - But they often granted it
                - Usually would occasionally grant a divorce to a man but they almost never granted it to a woman who requested it
                - And the man who was powerful or wealthy would be far more likely to be granted a divorce from the Pharisees
                - While the common man stood virtually no chance
        - In this way, the Pharisees could both profit from the way they dispensed their largess upon those who could repay them
        - And at the same time they could appear strict and uncompromising to the public when people of no consequence requested divorce

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- And amidst this kind of abuse and hypocrisy, Jesus says plainly that everyone who divorces commits adultery
    - Not just some, but all
    - And He wants to make the larger point, that God's word is not subject to men's manipulations or whims or evil desires
    - What is true in God's word will remain true forever no matter how much we may wish it were otherwise and no matter how much we might try to change it to suit our desires
- And then Jesus loves directly into a fascinating story – some say parable – further illustrating His point

Luke 16:19 ¶ "Now there was a rich man, and he habitually dressed in purple and fine linen, joyously living in splendor every day.
Luke 16:20 "And a poor man named Lazarus was laid at his gate, covered with sores,
Luke 16:21 and longing to be fed with the *crumbs* which were falling from the rich man's table; besides, even the dogs were coming and licking his sores.

- This story begins very much in the style of a parable
    - It begins with the Greek article de
    - Suggesting that this story is connected to the previous topic or thought
    - And it features a classic parable figure
        - A rich man living the quintessential privileged life
    - But the story quickly takes an unexpected turn
        - The next character is named with a first name
            - The name of the man is Lazarus, which is the Greek form of Eliezer, which means God is Help
        - If this is a parable, this would be the only one where Jesus names one of the characters
            - This fact raises the possibility that this story isn't to be seen strictly as a parable

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- While it may also be true that the events of this story are fictionalized and therefore it's not strictly speaking a literally historical event
- It's also likely that this isn't a completely imagined scenario either

- In other words, what we see happening here is a fictional account but it is representative of what actually happens in death
- That the events of this story are more than mere fable intended to teach a spiritual truth
- They are also a reasonably accurate portrayal of how God holds the dead for their day of judgment

- So looking at the details, we see the rich man living the life of luxury
  - The details of the parable make clear his wealth is very great
    - He dresses "habitually" in purple and fine linen
      - Purple dye was very expensive
      - Enough to make purple robes required tremendous wealth
      - Wearing them habitually, was absurd wealth
  - While Lazarus is suffering and hungry
    - His suffering accentuated by the dogs licking his sores

- Then the story continues…

Luke 16:22 "Now the poor man died and was carried away by the angels to Abraham's bosom; and the rich man also died and was buried.
Luke 16:23 "In Hades he lifted up his eyes, being in torment, and *saw Abraham far away and Lazarus in his bosom.
Luke 16:24 "And he cried out and said, 'Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus so that he may dip the tip of his finger in water and cool off my tongue, for I am in agony in this flame.'
Luke 16:25 "But Abraham said, 'Child, remember that during your life you received your good things, and likewise Lazarus bad things; but now he is being comforted here, and you are in agony.

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Luke 16:26 'And besides all this, between us and you there is a great chasm fixed, so that those who wish to come over from here to you will not be able, and *that* none may cross over from there to us.'

- Both men die, though one is carried by angels and the other is just buried
    - So immediately the distinctions between the two begin to reverse
        - With the rich man now unfavored and the poor man favored
    - Then we find them in Hades
        - Hades is the name the Bible gives to the place where God holds all the souls of the departed unbelievers who await resurrection and judgment before the Great White Throne
        - Hades is part of a larger place the OT calls Sheol
        - Sheol is the place all souls went during the time before Christ's resurrection – both believer and unbeliever
            - For example, Jacob himself declares that he expects to go to Sheol in Gen 37:35
        - The reason men when to Sheol in the days before Christ was due to the need for Christ to be resurrected first
            - This required two places
                - Hades
                - Abraham's Bosom (comfort)
- So, in this story, Jesus uses real places and uses them in a consistent manner
    - So it lends support to the idea that this is more than a parable
        - Now why would the rich man be in torment and poor man not?
        - Is being rich automatically bad?
        - Is being poor automatically righteous before God?
    - Well, the lives of these two men, particularly the rich man, suggest the reason

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- The rich man showed no compassion for the poor man, though he obviously knew his name
- He recognized him
- But he did nothing to aid his circumstances, though it would have taken very little to make a big difference
  - This callousness and absence of love reveals a hard, selfish heart
  - And this heart is the man's problem
  - He is an unrepentant sinner due judgment

- From the circumstances of the story we could only conclude as well that the poor man was a man of faith
  - Suggesting among other things that God perfectly willing to leave a faithful follower in destitute circumstances should it be suitable to His eternal purpose
  - We need to be careful anytime we make conclusions about what God's is prepared to do to support our lifestyles
  - Likewise, we need to remember James' teaching that

James 2:15 If a brother or sister is without clothing and in need of daily food,
James 2:16 and one of you says to them, "Go in peace, be warmed and be filled," and yet you do not give them what is necessary for *their* body, what use is that?
James 2:17 Even so faith, if it has no works, is dead, *being* by itself.

- There are other interesting details here to consider
  - They can see one another
  - The unbeliever is in constant torment
    - We need to keep this fact at least in the back of our minds
    - When we have opportunity to witness the gospel, let your mind consider the penalty due to someone who refuses to believe
    - Let that be your motivation for why you push through shame, conflict and rejection

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        - That's the true measure of love

    - How much worse was the torment for those who now see what they could have had by faith!

    - Then the dialog begins

    - And among other things we learn that no one can cross

        - It's interesting, because it suggests that even if someone were so motivated as to want to help, they can't

        - The chasm suggests that such a desire might exist

- But then we get to the point of the story

Luke 16:27 "And he said, 'Then I beg you, father, that you send him to my father's house—
Luke 16:28 for I have five brothers—in order that he may warn them, so that they will not also come to this place of torment.'
Luke 16:29 "But Abraham *said, 'They have Moses and the Prophets; let them hear them.'
Luke 16:30 "But he said, 'No, father Abraham, but if someone goes to them from the dead, they will repent!'
Luke 16:31 "But he said to him, 'If they do not listen to Moses and the Prophets, they will not be persuaded even if someone rises from the dead.'"

- Then the rich man has another idea

    - If he can't save himself, perhaps he can be of help to those he left behind

    - He says, please send Lazarus back to warn my family

        - Why Lazarus?

        - Presumably they knew him

        - They would recognize him

        - Yet they knew he died

        - And knowing that he died and was walking around again, they would immediately recognize supernatural power at work

        - And then whatever Lazarus said, they would heed

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- It seems sensible

- Abraham responds that these brothers already have the Law and Prophets
  - Here we go again talking about God's gracious provision of His word
    - These brothers were Jewish, obviously
    - Because they had the Word given to their fathers
    - They had the most complete record possible to explain God's character, nature, and expectations
    - They had a complete record to warn them of judgment, to exhort them to Godly living through faithful obedience
    - They could know God's expectations and the results for failing to heed His word
    - They need only consult the Book
  - But this man knows His family all to well
    - After all, they are probably just like him
    - They know where the word of God is
      - On a shelf gathering dust somewhere
      - Hey hear it on the Sabbath
      - They probably memorized it as youth like everyone else did
      - There's nothing very exciting there, nothing to get their attention
      - Certainly noting as revolutionary as a man walking around having come back to life
        - That's something to get their attention

- O the rich man says no Father Abraham, send Lazarus back from the dead
  - That will convince them
  - Why?

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- Because it's spectacular
- Because it's convincing
- Because it doesn't depend on faith

Rom. 8:24 For in hope we have been saved, but hope that is seen is not hope; for who hopes for what he *already* sees?

- In other words, to convince someone through spectacular events, through displays of power and other manifestations is not faith
  - It may accompany faith, but if it's necessary in order to prompt agreement, it's not faith
  - It's simply self-evident
  - And God's word says faith is required for entry into the kingdom
- So Abraham responds
  - If they aren't going to accept the kingdom on the basis of faith in God's word, then they will never accept it
  - And they won't accept it even if they see someone who has risen from the dead
    - There are really two messages here

- First, the simple truth is that you stir faith in the heart of a man through proof
  - Whether human proof or even supernatural miracles
  - The human heart is so depraved and closed to the truth that it will not be open to the truth unless and until God Himself opens the heart to hear the word
    - Jesus is the author and perfecter of our faith (Heb 12:2)
    - God brings men the gift of faith (Eph 2:8)
    - No one may come to Christ unless the Father would first draw them
  - This rich man's family would either be convinced on the basis of God's word , having been quickened to it's truth by the work, of the Holy Spirit

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        - Or they will remain dead to the message

- But there's a second message here
    - The Pharisee themselves, who are the audience for this story, are in view here
        - They have had the law and the prophets their whole lives
        - And they study it and preach it
            - Though they don't live it
    - And they are forcing themselves into the kingdom on their own basis
        - Hoping that they can enter on their own terms
- To this point, they have witnessed supernatural act after supernatural act performed by Jesus
    - And yet none of it has changed their minds
- And one day they will be witnesses to a resurrected man, to Christ Himself risen
    - But even that won't change their minds, incredible as it seems
    - Only God's word has that Power
    - Because God Himself has declared that His Son is His word, and He has determined that His word is the one means by which men will be saved

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Luke 17A

- As we ended chapter 16 last week, we watched as Jesus put the Pharisees in their place…again
    - Last week the issue was one of recognizing the purpose in God giving men His word
    - And more specifically, we saw how the Pharisees had completely missed the point of their Hebrew Bible
        - That it had been given to tell men of the coming Christ and how they must accept Him on faith
    - Since the Pharisees missed this purpose in the Word being given, they inevitably misused the Word for false and unholy purposes
        - They turned it into a yoke of burdens on the people, as Jesus stated in Luke 11
        - And by their error and misuse of the Word of God, these evil men misled a generation of the nation of Israel
        - They caused any number of Jews in Jesus' day to stumble spiritually speaking
            - They mistaught the Word and they misled the population, and so when the Messiah came, the people stumbled so as to not accept the Messiah
            - And this fact leads Jesus directly into His next sequence of teaching, as we begin Chapter 17

Luke 17:1 ¶ He said to His disciples, "It is inevitable that stumbling blocks come, but woe to him through whom they come!
Luke 17:2 "It would be better for him if a millstone were hung around his neck and he were thrown into the sea, than that he would cause one of these little ones to stumble.
Luke 17:3 "Be on your guard! If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him.
Luke 17:4 "And if he sins against you seven times a day, and returns to you seven times, saying, 'I repent,' forgive him."

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- Jesus moves out of the story at the end of chapter 16 into a teaching to His disciples concerning sin within the Body of Christ
    - He begins with the intriguing comment that it is inevitable that stumbling blocks come
        - In light of what Jesus had just been teaching in Chapter 16, it's easy to see that he's referring to the Pharisees and their false teaching when he says stumbling blocks
        - In other words, it's inevitable that men will come, claiming to be men of God, yet teaching heresy that places a stumbling block before God's children
            - Which immediately tells us two important things about the nature of Jesus concern here
- First, He's speaking about men who present themselves as ministers of God – just as the Pharisees did
    - Think about it…who can cause a person seeking after God to stumble so as to never find the true God?
        - Clearly, it must be someone who has credibility in the eyes of the seeker
        - It must be someone who has reason to be believed on matters of God
        - It must be a false teacher
    - That's why Jesus is talking to the disciples when he says this word
        - His concern is that someone within the church might repeat the error of these Pharisees by presenting himself as an authority though he is without a genuine faith
        - And as a result, he leads others astray by his false beliefs
        - Paul warns the church at Corinth about this same concern in these words:

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2Cor. 11:13 For such men are false apostles, deceitful workers, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ.
2Cor. 11:14 No wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.
2Cor. 11:15 Therefore it is not surprising if his servants also disguise themselves as servants of righteousness, whose end will be according to their deeds.

- False apostles, deceitful workers, disguising themselves as followers of Christ, Paul says
    - And they follow the pattern set by their master, Satan
    - But they will receive their just punishment
- The second thing we learn about these men by Jesus' application is that they cause people to stumble through their misuse of the Word of God
    - Remember it was the Pharisee's misuse of scripture that Jesus cited in Chapter 16 to indict their leadership
    - So it will be with anyone who is a stumbling block
        - These will be men who are false disciples of Christ
        - And they misuse God's word
            - But more specifically, they misuse it in the same manner, I believe, that the Pharisees misused it
            - Rather than teaching it in such a way that it reveals Christ and draws men to Him
            - Instead they teach the word in a way to build up themselves in the eyes of men and to enrich themselves
                - Like the Pharisees before them, these stumbling blocks will be men who seek the praises of men and have a love of money
                - The Apostle Peter puts it this way:

2Pet. 2:1 ¶ But false prophets also arose among the people, just as there will also be false teachers among you, who will secretly introduce destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them, bringing swift destruction upon themselves.
2Pet. 2:2 Many will follow their sensuality, and because of them the way of the truth will be maligned;

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2Pet. 2:3 and in *their* greed they will exploit you with false words; their judgment from long ago is not idle, and their destruction is not asleep.

- He says there will be false teachers
    - Who introduce heresies
    - Who malign the way of truth
    - Many will follow them even as they malign the truth
    - They exploit people out of greed
        - Doesn't this sound exactly like the kind of people the Pharisees were
        - And these are the people Jesus is warning the disciples about
            - Not that Jesus believes these men will become like these false teachers (other than Judas of course)
            - But rather so that they might be on guard against such men and protect the flock against them
    - And did you notice that Jesus said these men will come
        - You can't prevent it
        - He says its inevitable
    - They have existed throughout the time of the church
- So what is Jesus expecting the Disciples to do with this knowledge?
    - First, Jesus uses it to remind them of the certain judgment that awaits these men
        - Jesus says they would be better to end their life early by drowning then to go forward with a life that leads men astray
        - It seems to suggest that the punishment reserved for the wicked carries with it degrees of severity, so that some will receive a greater punishment than others
        - Yet the punishment for all is eternal, so we obviously don't have a complete understanding of what this will be like

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- Thankfully, we never will

- The second thing Jesus tells them top do in response to the coming false teachers is in verse 3

  - Be on guard he says

  - Meaning, as undershpherds, they must be on guard against false teaching so as to protect the sheep

    - This is the basic and most important duty of anyone in church leadership

  - And it's a principle repeated throughout the NT

    - In John 21:16, Jesus leaves Peter with the command to Feed His sheep if he loves Jesus

      - Feeding being a picture of feeding spiritually, meaning through the teaching of the word

      - And I might add the meat of the word

    - Because the proper and consistent delivery of God's word to His people is the essential duty of church leadership

      - That's what Paul means when he tells Timothy in his second letter to preach the word

      - When you look at that passage from 2Tim 4, you find Paul saying that the reason it was so important for Tim to preach the word is because there is so much false teaching going around

    - In other words, the solution to false teachers who might make men stumble is to counter the false teaching with sound Biblical teaching

- Now consider where Jesus goes next in this teaching in verse 3

  - Since the disciples must be on guard at all times against false teaching, it was necessary for them to be ready to challenge anyone they might find teaching wrongly

  - But Jesus doesn't want His direction to be misapplied, because after all everyone teaches error sooner or later (except me of course)

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- Every teacher is fallible, so sooner or later false teaching will occur
- But there is a world of difference between false teaching and a false teacher
    - False teaching is simply a fact of life for all of us
    - We all will make mistakes in our teaching from time to time
- But false teachers are unbelievers who can never help but teach false things because they do not have the Spirit of God and therefore they are not of God

- So Jesus wants us to be careful not to jump to the conclusion that everyone who teaches falsely is going to suffer the fate of the Pharisees and men like them
    - So He instructs the disciples to be ready to rebuke one another in the face of sin
        - And though I believe this direction applies to any kind of sin, of course
        - I also think it's specifically directed toward the sin of false teaching
        - The sin of misleading God's children
    - And if the leadership observes this happening, the first step is to rebuke (epitimao)
        - Meaning a stern warning or a censure (cutting off from teaching)
    - And if this results in repentance then the leadership should forgive
        - Which could include restoring the person to teaching
    - But what's implied here is if the rebuke doesn't result in repentance, than the rebuke stands
        - Meaning the censure stands
        - The person is no longer to teach if they don't' teach according to truth

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- If their sin in teaching error (or any other sin for that matter) causes God's children to stumble, then they should remain outside a position of influence

- And then to illustrate the point one step further, Jesus adds that if this cycles repeats itself many times, then the disciples are to show inexhaustible patience toward this person

  - So imagine a person who keeps trying and failing in their best efforts to teach or disciple or lead others in the church

    - But they consistently fall into sinful ways, whether through wrong teaching or wrong conduct

    - So they must be rebuked at each turn

    - And likewise, if each rebuke results in true repentance, then the leadership cannot hold this against them

      - Even more dramatically, they can't hold the pattern against them

- Can you appreciate the significance of this statement?

  - It's one thing to forgive someone for an occasional mistake and restore them afterward

    - But what if the person makes mistake after mistake time after time? The same mistake even

      - And yet what if they are declare they are sorry (repentant) for each one?

    - At first we are willing to forgive

      - But sooner or later, doesn't our patience wear out?

      - And don't we begin to doubt the confessions they make?

  - In fact, in the face of repeated sin, aren't we tempted to say I think it would be best if you stayed out of a leadership role altogether

    - We would assume that they have proven themselves to be unworthy of our trust

    - Despite the fact that they are repentant, we simply say they have run out of chances

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- Jesus says we can't do that
    - There is no limit to the number of mistakes someone may make
        - Perhaps Jesus means that his rule applies so long as we believe they are sincerely repentant, yet the scripture isn't stated that way
        - So we need to be careful about coming to that conclusion
    - In fact, when we have someone who has fallen into a pattern of making multiple mistakes
        - And sought our forgiveness multiple time,
        - Don't we begin to feel like that person owes us something?
        - Don't we begin to feel like a debt is owed to us for our willingness to show so much forgiveness
    - You may never have thought if it that way, but if we're honest with ourselves, I bet you would agree that you share in that tendency
        - We are forgiving, but forgiveness only goes so far
        - But Jesus says, it has no limit
            - What a remarkable teaching
            - For a Jew, asking for forgiveness was a way of incurring debt
                - When you required someone's forgiveness, you were placing yourself in their debt
                - So to say that you must extend grace and forgiveness to someone indefinitely was a very difficult teaching to accept
                - It implied we would be willing to allow someone to incur an infinite debt to us
                - While this concept isn't quite as concerning to us today, in Jewish culture it was a huge expectation
        - Which explains the disciples' response in verse 5

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Luke 17:5 ¶ The apostles said to the Lord, "Increase our faith!"
Luke 17:6 And the Lord said, "If you had faith like a mustard seed, you would say to this mulberry tree, 'Be uprooted and be planted in the sea'; and it would obey you.

- The disciples are so taken aback by the requirement to show such limitless forgiveness, they exclaim that Jesus must increase their faith
    - What they are telling Jesus is we don't know if we can do what you just asked us to do
        - Hey are saying that unless you do something to supernaturally prompt us to this behavior, we're not sure it will happen on its own
    - But Jesus will hear none of it
        - He tells them that they have more opportunity to obey then they recognize
        - And He teaches them this through an interesting comparison
- Jesus says that if they only had the smallest amount of faith, it could be sufficient to do something unimaginable
    - A mulberry tree can stand nearly 35 feet tall and it has a very extensive root system
    - So Jesus picked this example to emphasize the difficulty of the task
        - But only a very small amount of faith would be necessary to accomplish such a difficult task
        - That's the point of referring to the mustard seed
            - Such a small seed represents the smallness of the faith required
    - This is a direct rebuke of the disciples, speaking of rebukes
        - He tells them that He doesn't buy their excuses
            - If they want to obey His seemingly impossible command to forgive the brethren a limitless number of times
            - They only need the smallest amount of faith

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- Why? How is that possible? When is the last time you commanded a tree to go into the ocean?
    - Yet don't you have at least enough faith to equal a mustard seed?
    - Here's what Jesus meant.

- The word faith can't stand by itself
    - It implies an object
    - Faith must have an object
        - You have faith in something
        - To say I have faith yet not specify the object of that faith is like saying I have love
            - Love of what you would ask? Dogs, chocolate, sunsets, people?
    - Likewise, when Jesus says they only need the faith of a mustard seed, we should ask what is the object of faith Jesus is speaking about
        - I think the only natural and reasonable answer would be faith in the thing the disciples were referring to
            - In other words, faith in Jesus' words or more generally faith in God's will
            - It was Jesus' words as He taught the Father's will that prompted the disciples to say they needed more faith if they hoped to obey
            - To which Jesus responded they need only have a small amount of faith, meaning faith in God's will, to accomplish great things

- Now consider this…if a tree were to come out of the ground and land in the sea, how would that actually happen?
    - What force would be responsible for that event?
        - God Himself, of course
        - The power would come from God

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- And His power doesn't vary in relationship to our degree of faith in Him
- No matter whether we have a little faith in Him or a lot of faith in Him, His power to do what he wills has never diminished

- All that is required is that we seek His will and remain in it
  - So if God revealed to us His intent to pull up a Mulberry tree and deliver it to the ocean
    - And He asks us to command the tree according to His word,
    - Then we could believe that word from God with only a modest amount of faith, and yet great things would still happen because God is the one doing the work
    - Remember Jericho? Only a little faith on the part of the people resulted in walls falling down
    - Remember the nation of Israel at the edge of the Red Sea? Barely any faith among the people, the faith of Moses was enough to see God act to save His people
  - So when Jesus says to the disciples that they should forgive one another many times, they only need a little faith to see that through
    - Because the real work will be done by God Himself in their hearts
    - And they have heard that it is God's will that forgiveness would reign

Eph. 4:32 Be kind to one another, tender-hearted, forgiving each other, just as God in Christ also has forgiven you.
Eph. 5:1 ¶ Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children;

- So Jesus rebukes them to stop looking to themselves and remember that the real power lies with God
  - They are merely God's servants who will do as God directs
  - Consider when their wrong thinking would eventually lead them one day

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- If they believed it was their own degree of faith that determined what God could do through them
    - Then when they did accomplish something significant for God, they could boast of how must more spiritual they were than others in the Body of Christ
    - They might get the wrong idea that they were better material for God and therefore they were able to do more for God
    - And what would be worse, they might expect God to reward them for their superior character
- To contend with this thinking Jesus tells this parable

Luke 17:7 ¶ "Which of you, having a slave plowing or tending sheep, will say to him when he has come in from the field, 'Come immediately and sit down to eat'?
Luke 17:8 "But will he not say to him, 'Prepare something for me to eat, and *properly* clothe yourself and serve me while I eat and drink; and afterward you may eat and drink'?
Luke 17:9 "He does not thank the slave because he did the things which were commanded, does he?
Luke 17:10 "So you too, when you do all the things which are commanded you, say, 'We are unworthy slaves; we have done *only* that which we ought to have done.'"

- In this parable, several things are immediately apparent
    - Jesus is the Master and the disciples are the servants, just as was the case in the time Jesus walked on earth with the disciples
    - The servants have many tasks to perform in support of the Master
        - Just as the disciples are called upon to obey Christ in many ways and concerning many issues, like forgiveness
    - And Jesus appeals to their thinking by comparing their situation to another one they were all familiar with: slaves working in a home
        - You never thanked a slave for doing what he was told – that is simply the expectation
        - Slaves were disciplined for not doing the right thing
        - They weren't rewarded for doing as they were commanded

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- Can you imagine the sillyness of a slave asking for reward or recognition simply because they obeyed the master?
    - Likewise, when the disciples are told to forgive one another and they respond that Jesus will need to increase their faith
        - Meaning He will need to increase their willingness to comply with His expectations
        - Jesus says, you only need to recognize what the master's will is and then act accordingly
        - Don't try to hide behind some imagined limitation of faith
            - Your faith is sufficient, you only need to follow God's will to do great things
            - And since it will be God's power accomplishing the work, don't let pride creep in either
            - God wills, God commands, God does the good work through us
                - We are simply the obedient slave who in the end must acknowledge
                - We have only done what she ought to have done

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Luke 17B

- As we ended chapter 16 last week, Jesus was rebuking his disciples
    - Jesus had just taught them to be watchful for false teaching
    - More specifically, to be willing to rebuke a brother over his sin, including the sin of false teaching
        - If he repented, he must be forgiven
        - If he sins over and over again, but repents at each turn, then forgiveness must follow
        - For Jesus is trying to distinguish between the false teacher,
            - who never repents in the face of correction
        - And the brother or sister
            - who merely teaches incorrectly or lives a life of habitual sin and requires instruction
        - The former is to is to be shut out while the latter is to be forgiven
            - And forgiveness must be available without limit
- And to that command, the disciples responded, somewhat flippantly, that they needed Jesus to increase their faith before they might hope to obey that instruction
    - And Jesus corrected the disciples by teaching that the problem wasn't the amount of faith
        - Rather the problem was their willingness to do what they were told
        - In other words, faith is the prerequisite to living a life of obedience
            - But obedience is an expectation of God, and it does not depend on the degree of faith
            - It should come merely as a matter of course for every believer

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- In the verses we study today, Luke offers a simple illustration of Jesus' point

Luke 17:11 ¶ While He was on the way to Jerusalem, He was passing between Samaria and Galilee.
Luke 17:12 As He entered a village, ten leprous men who stood at a distance met Him;
Luke 17:13 and they raised their voices, saying, "Jesus, Master, have mercy on us!"
Luke 17:14 When He saw them, He said to them, "Go and show yourselves to the priests." And as they were going, they were cleansed.
Luke 17:15 Now one of them, when he saw that he had been healed, turned back, glorifying God with a loud voice,
Luke 17:16 and he fell on his face at His feet, giving thanks to Him. And he was a Samaritan.
Luke 17:17 Then Jesus answered and said, "Were there not ten cleansed? But the nine—where are they?
Luke 17:18 "Was no one found who returned to give glory to God, except this foreigner?"
Luke 17:19 And He said to him, "Stand up and go; your faith has made you well."

- Back in Chapter 9, we're told by Luke that Jesus had set his mind on going to Jerusalem for His ascension
    - And as we studied that trip, we learned that Jesus would need to travel southward from the Galilee and through Samaria to reach His destination
    - And we also learned that the Samaritans were a despised group of imposters
        - A group of people of who had long ago departed from the true Jewish heritage
        - They had set up a competing temple while abandoning the Torah and many Jewish beliefs
        - They regarding themselves as the true descents of Abraham
    - And of course, the Samaritans hated the Jews as well
- And we hear of a group of 10 lepers who ask Jesus for mercy
    - As we learn later, the group consists of 9 Jews and one Samaritan
    - But for now the primary description of them is that they are lepers
        - Lepers as we've taught before outcasts

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- Partly because they were usually unclean under the Law
- And partly because the disease was contagious and greatly feared

- And this would also explain why they are standing at a distance and not approaching close to Jesus
  - Society insisted that they maintain a distance for the sake of others

- As the call out for mercy, they use the term "master"
  - They say Jesus, Master, have mercy
  - At first glance, we have to assume that all ten were believing in Jesus as Messiah, which is why they call Him Master
  - The Greek word for Master is "epi-sta-tes" and in all the Bible, only Luke uses this term as a title for Jesus
    - It means commander or chief, and Luke occasionally shows the disciples using this term to address Jesus
- Curiously, one of those occasions is in chapter 5 when Jesus finds Peter on his fishing boat after a night of unsuccessful fishing
  - If you remember, He instructs Peter to lower his net again
  - Peter is bemused by this request, but complies nonetheless
  - And as he does he says, "Master, we worked hard all night and caught nothing, but I will do as You say *and* let down the nets."
  - But then the net comes up full of fish, at which point Peter falls at Jesus' feet and says, "Go away from me Lord, for I am a sinful man, Oh Lord."
  - First it was Master, then it became Lord
    - And more importantly, the first title was used in a moment when Peter's trust in Christ was somewhat in doubt
    - But his use of the term Lord came as part of a moment of obvious repentance and worship of Jesus as God
- In this example we learn a useful insight we can apply to the circumstances of Luke 17

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- The lepers call Jesus Master
- And the word Master can have a wide range of meaning,
  - The disciples occasionally used it to refer to their Lord
  - But it can also be used more generally as a simple term of respect for anyone on authority
- In other words, calling Jesus Master doesn't necessarily mean that the person has a true faith in Him as the Messiah
  - After all, even Jesus Himself says in Matt 7:22 that on the day of judgment, there will be those who called Jesus "Lord, Lord"
  - And yet Jesus says He never knew them
- So just because we use a title, doesn't mean we believe all that it suggests about Jesus

- So the lepers call out Master
  - Jesus' response to them is that they should go present themselves before the priests
    - Why would Jesus make this request?
    - Well, this was in accordance with the Law
      - In Lev 13, the Law provides instructions on how lepers were to be dealt with Jewish society
      - Lepers could considered clean under certain circumstances
        - Namely when their skin was free from open sores
        - During this time, they could be certified clean by the priests
        - It was a temporary certification, of course, because inevitably the sores returned
        - And when they did, the leper was again unclean for as long as the outbreak lasted

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- As the disease progresses, the sores are more persistent and the individual eventually becomes perpetually unclean

- So, Jesus' command to them to present themselves before the priest carried with it an implied promise to heal them

  - The only reason for them to go before the priest was to be certified as clean

  - Since they were standing at a distance when they cried out to Jesus, it's obvious that they weren't clean in this moment

  - So, when Jesus says go present yourselves before the priest, He's essentially promising that they will be healed by the time they reach the priest

- Sure enough, in verse 14 we're told that as they went to the priests, they were made well

  - At this point, one of the ten, a man Jesus calls a foreigner, turns back to give Glory to God

    - So the Samaritan comes back but the other nine Jewish lepers never return

    - The man that did return, we're told is worshipping God, and he does so by falling at Jesus' feet and giving Jesus thanks

    - And while this scene is going on, Jesus asks rhetorically, where are the other nine?

      - That's an interesting question, really

      - He asks the question in such a way that suggests that coming back to give thank was a test of sorts

      - Jess adds insult to injury by asking are only foreigners willing to give God glory?

    - The word for foreigner is interesting (allogenes), in that this is the only time it's used in the Gospels

      - In fact, as has been the case over and over again lately, this story is only found in Luke's gospel

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- The word means one of another race
- In other words, Jesus is emphasizing his surprise that God would receive glory from someone outside the very nation He came to

- This scene is interesting for another very important reason
    - Remember the scene of Peter on the boat
        - One moment he's calling Jesus master, but doing so in a rather dismissive way
        - After Jesus performs a miracles, Peter quickly changes his tune and falls before Jesus calling Him lord and acknowledging Him as Lord
    - In other words, whatever Peter may have thought of Jesus before that, once the truth was revealed clearly, Peter knew how to respond
        - He let all pretense drop and He acknowledged Jesus as God
- Now we have 10 men who are following a similar pattern
    - Yet only one returns and praises Jesus and gives him the honor reserved for God
    - It's apparent that this man is faithfully acknowledging Jesus as God
    - And I would suggest that it's equally obvious that the other nine are not
        - Look at Jesus' comment to the man who returned
        - In verse 19, Jesus says your faith has made you well
            - This statement makes no sense if Jesus merely means that his faith has made him physically well
            - Because that healing has already taken place
            - That's why the guy returned
        - No, I believe this statement is a spiritual healing
            - Just as Jesus tells men and women, your sin is forgiven, go and sin no more.

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- Likewise, here I believe Jesus is saying your faith has healed you spiritually
- Your faith has saved you, in other words

- A foreigner willing to receive the Messiah while the Jews reject Jesus

- And the best evidence of this difference is found in Jesus command to the group
  - Jesus said go and present yourselves to the priests
    - The act of presenting yourself before the priests in Leviticus was a symbolic appeal to God for atonement
    - Although it concerned an earthly illness and ceremonial cleanliness,
      - it was symbolic of coming before God with a spiritual disease called sin
      - And seeking a spiritual cleansing from God, through an intercessor, the priest
  - And so where do the nine Jews go after having been cleansed?
    - To the temple we presume to present themselves before the Levi priests who mediated the Law of Moses
    - And they worshipped there, because they didn't recognize that their God, their Messiah had arrived in their midst
    - So they persisted in following the old way, oblivious to the new way in their midst
  - On the other hand, the Samaritan, having been cleansed, says why do I need to go before a bunch of men who intercede on behalf of a God who has arrived in person?
    - Why do I need them to call me clean, when I know I have been cleansed truly?
    - I why worship in a temple when the living temple of God is present in our midst?

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- Now I don't know whether this man understood the finer nuances of this situation, but he didn't have to understand in order for God to use the situation to educate you and I
    - Jesus is clearly making a point to the Pharisees and disciples through this man's circumstances
        - The King has arrived, and the kingdom is in their midst
        - Yet the ones intended to receive that kingdom have turned their back on the King
        - They are persisting in following a dead Law that was given in the first place that men might know their Messiah and receive Him
        - But the Jews have missed the big picture
            - Yet a nation of foreigners, of tax collectors, of sinners are embracing their Lord
            - The beginning of a Gentile church emerging out of the rejection of Israel
- From this brief lessons, the Pharisees, we're told, begin to question Jesus about the coming Kingdom

Luke 17:20 ¶ Now having been questioned by the Pharisees as to when the kingdom of God was coming, He answered them and said, "The kingdom of God is not coming with signs to be observed;
Luke 17:21 nor will they say, 'Look, here *it is*!' or, 'There *it is*!' For behold, the kingdom of God is in your midst."
Luke 17:22 ¶ And He said to the disciples, "The days will come when you will long to see one of the days of the Son of Man, and you will not see it.
Luke 17:23 "They will say to you, 'Look there! Look here!' Do not go away, and do not run after *them*.
Luke 17:24 "For just like the lightning, when it flashes out of one part of the sky, shines to the other part of the sky, so will the Son of Man be in His day.
Luke 17:25 "But first He must suffer many things and be rejected by this generation.

- It's natural for the Pharisees to have jumped on the topic of the kingdom for several reasons
    - First, Jesus Himself has mentioned the kingdom on a number of occasions, so the topic is out their in their minds

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- Secondly, the situation they just witnessed with the lepers might have triggered the question, simply because the leper is praising and worshipping Jesus as the Messiah

- So the Pharisees throw out the question to Jesus asking when will the kingdom come

  - I expect their question was more of a test than an honest desire to know what Jesus thought

  - And you can see that in how Jesus answered them

- He basically dismisses their question without giving them an answer

  - He says to the Pharisees that the kingdom isn't going to come like they expect or assume

    - No one will say, Look there it is!, meaning it won't come in such an obvious way that you will see it coming from a distance

    - It won't appear in a way to draws attention to itself initially

    - Its initial appearing will be more subtle - under the radar

  - Then Jesus makes the point that the leper himself was basically witnessing to earlier

    - The kingdom is already in their midst

    - How ironic

      - They ask when will it come

      - And Jesus says too late, it's already here

    - Let me tell you folks, if you're asking how will I know when the kingdom comes, and God responds by saying it's already here, then you missed it

      - And the Pharisees had obviously missed it

      - Which is all that Jesus had to say to them on the subject

- But then we're told Jesus begins to teach the disciples further on the kingdom

  - Jesus tells them in an ominous way that there will come a day when they will long to see the very thing that was in their midst in that moment

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- The Son of Man
- The Messiah

- This is the latest attempt by Jesus to clue them in on his coming death and departure
  - He's given clues about this already, particularly in Chap 9:22 when he said

"The Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed and be raised up on the third day."

  - Here again, Jesus tries to educate them on he necessity of Jesus' rejection and death

- When those days come, the disciples will wish they could have Jesus back in their presence
  - But there is a danger in that desire
    - When you want something bad enough, your desire can turn into impatience
    - And impatience can become the motivator to follow after the wrong things
  - So knowing He would depart and knowing He would not return for a while, Jesus gives the disciples the logical warning
    - When you are wishing I was still here and others tell you that there He is, don't believe them
    - Because the Son of Man will have His day, and that day will be obvious
      - It will be like lightening coming out of the sky
      - Bright, brilliant, attention grabbing, obvious
      - You won't need to worry about looking closely to see the Son of Man in that day because His return will be so obvious

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- So meanwhile, don't fall for someone who tries to convince you that Jesus has returned

- Now doesn't that sound a bit contradictory?
    - One moment he's telling the Pharisees that the kingdom will not come in obvious ways, and in fact it's already here
    - The next moment he's telling the disciples that they need not worry about missing the Son of Man when he comes in His day because it will be so obvious
        - The answer here should be easy for us all to appreciate
            - To the Pharisees, Jesus was talking about the establishment of God's kingdom in it's early stages
            - The kingdom as it is established in Jesus' first coming
            - The kingdom of believers that began with the apostles and grew to cover the earth with believers
        - That is the form of the kingdom we know today
            - It is no less a kingdom, because a kingdom is two things
            - It is land and it is subjects
            - A kingdom has subjects and a kingdom occupies land
            - As we speak, God is building his kingdom one believer at a time – God's subjects for his kingdom
        - But on a time to come, the second part of the kingdom will be established
            - The Lord will return to earth to occupy the Land on earth that was promised to Him
            - The borders of Israel promised to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob
            - The nation of Israel elevated above all other nations
            - Jesus ruling the world from Jerusalem
            - Jesus, the King, with His kingdom, both subjects and Land

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- And when Jesus comes in that day, there will be no mistaking His arrival

    - Rev 19 describes it this way:

Rev. 19:11 ¶ And I saw heaven opened, and behold, a white horse, and He who sat on it *is* called Faithful and True, and in righteousness He judges and wages war.
Rev. 19:12 His eyes *are* a flame of fire, and on His head *are* many diadems; and He has a name written *on Him* which no one knows except Himself.
Rev. 19:13 *He is* clothed with a robe dipped in blood, and His name is called The Word of God.
Rev. 19:14 And the armies which are in heaven, clothed in fine linen, white *and* clean, were following Him on white horses.
Rev. 19:15 From His mouth comes a sharp sword, so that with it He may strike down the nations, and He will rule them with a rod of iron; and He treads the wine press of the fierce wrath of God, the Almighty.
Rev. 19:16 And on His robe and on His thigh He has a name written, "KING OF KINGS, AND LORD OF LORDS."

        - There will be no mistaking that day

    - So when Jesus address the Pharisees, he tells them the kingdom has already come, and you missed it

    - Yet to the disciples he says though you will want to see me, don't fall prey to imitators – my day will be easy to know and recognize

    - To the Pharisees, Jesus was speaking of His first coming

    - And to the disciples, Jesus was talking about His second coming

- And then in verse 25, Jesus brings it together to give the disciples yet another prediction of His coming death

    - In other words, Jesus continues to try and prepare the disciples for the unimaginable

        - Jesus' first coming doesn't result in the full establishment of His kingdom

        - Just the beginnings of it

        - The kingdom's subjects will be established

        - And in the coming generations, many will wish to see Jesus in His day, but His day will not come until the appointed time

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        - But when it comes, it will be glorious

    - What a hard message to accept when you are expecting the whole enchilada at once

- Two lessons for us here

    - Don't allow our desire to see Jesus return and to see His kingdom established lead us to believer foolish things

        - We must remain prepared to see the kingdom appear in any moment, but we cannot force the day

        - And though we live every day expecting His return that day, we must be prepared to wait a lifetime and even beyond this life until the day comes

    - Secondly, if we are now subjects of the king, waiting for the future arrival of the king's land

        - Then we are still obligated to live under the rules and expectations of the king and of His kingdom regardless of where we live

            - And as it happens, we live in a world that is not the kingdom

            - We are strangers, wanderers in a foreign land waiting for the chance to go home to our kingdom

            - What kind of subject are we for our king? Are we ready for His return tonight perhaps?

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Luke 17C

- As we broke our study two weeks ago in Chapter 17, we had just seen Jesus Giving seemingly opposite answers to the Pharisees and His disciples regarding the question when is the kingdom coming?
    - In verse 20 & 21, Jesus had told the Pharisees that the kingdom would arrive so imperceptively that it would be difficult to notice at first
        - Similar to His previous description in chapter 13 of the kingdom as a mustard seed or a small amount of leaven placed in dough
        - The kingdom being very small and almost invisible at first, but over time it's existence and impact will be known to everyone
    - But then in verse 22, Jesus begins to direct his answer to the disciples
        - And when He does, the nature of his answer seems to change
        - Now Jesus began to talk in stark and obvious terms
            - You won't be fooled by the Messiah's return
            - It will be like lightening crossing the sky
- And when we studied these verse last time, we understood that the seemingly different answers were really just different points in time
    - To the Pharisees, Jesus described the way the kingdom would be established in Christ's first coming
    - To the disciples Jesus transitioned to His return at the Second Coming, which will take place in a far different manner than His first
        - And we ended in verse 25, where Jesus explains that this stunning and triumphant arrival must first wait for a far more humble and humiliating event – Jesus' rejection and death
    - And from this point, Jesus continues in today's verses to elaborate on the nature of time and circumstances surrounding His return

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Luke 17:25 "But first He must suffer many things and be rejected by this generation.
Luke 17:26 "And just as it happened in the days of Noah, so it will be also in the days of the Son of Man:
Luke 17:27 they were eating, they were drinking, they were marrying, they were being given in marriage, until the day that Noah entered the ark, and the flood came and destroyed them all.
Luke 17:28 "It was the same as happened in the days of Lot: they were eating, they were drinking, they were buying, they were selling, they were planting, they were building;
Luke 17:29 but on the day that Lot went out from Sodom it rained fire and brimstone from heaven and destroyed them all.
Luke 17:30 "It will be just the same on the day that the Son of Man is revealed.

- I reread Verse 25 from our last lesson to help give context to these verses
    - But it's important to note right from the beginning that there were two principle events referenced in Jesus' discourse in this chapter
        - The first event Jesus referenced in this chapter was the comment he made to the Pharisees about establishment of the kingdom in their midst
            - This was His reference to the kingdom in it's earliest stages
            - The time period of the early church as it was first established and nurtured in the decades and centuries following Jesus' resurrection
            - That was the time period Jesus began talking about, but He quickly left that moment in history and transitioned to discussing a different moment
        - The second event Jesus was talking about was His return, His second coming
            - And this is the period of history in view for the remainder of the chapter
            - In other words, once Jesus makes the transition to the times surrounding His second coming in verse 22, He stays there

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- The context of what he says makes clear that he never moves away from a discussion of His second coming or the times surrounding that event

- So let's see what we can learn about the nature of the times surrounding Jesus return

- First, we hear that the days of the Son of Man will be similar to the days before Noah's flood or the days prior to destruction of Sodom in the days of Lot

  - So what can we learn about the days prior to Jesus' return from these stories?

  - Well the story of Noah begins in Chapter 6 of Genesis

    - Here's what we hear about the nature of days prior to the flood

    - In Chapter 6, the enemy had become especially active in the events of earth, even to the point of angels having sexual relations with women

Gen. 6:1 ¶ Now it came about, when men began to multiply on the face of the land, and daughters were born to them,
Gen. 6:2 that the sons of God saw that the daughters of men were beautiful; and they took wives for themselves, whomever they chose.

    - Many have seen these verses to refer to demons mating with women

      - In the fact, the Hebrew word for sons of God is used in only here and in Job

      - And in Job, the phrase is used clearly to refer to angelic beings

      - So it seems reasonable to assume that's how it was meant to be interpreted here

    - So the point is that the days prior to Noah were marked by extreme levels of demonic activity among men

- Secondly, Genesis tells us that man's own wickedness had reach a peak:

Gen. 6:5 ¶ Then the LORD saw that the wickedness of man was great on the earth, and that every intent of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually.

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Gen. 6:11 ¶ Now the earth was corrupt in the sight of God, and the earth was filled with violence.

- Men has always been wicked, since the day Adam left the garden
    - But in the days before the flood, the Bible makes a point that the wickedness on the earth had reach extreme proportions
        - The very fact that the flood was even necessary illustrates how serious the situation had become
        - God's only recourse in light of all that was happening on earth was to wipe out virtually all inhabitants and start again with a family of 8
        - Extreme circumstances call for extreme measures
    - So again, we can expect that the days immediately prior to Christ's return should be marked by extreme depravity
    - We only need to reference the story of Lot in Sodom to find further confirmation of Jesus' point
        - Extreme sinfulness will make the nature of people and society in the days before His return
        - This is important for a number of reasons, but one reason in particular interests me tonight
            - There is teaching within the church that says Jesus' return to earth is predicated on the entire world becoming believers
            - There are multiple reasons why this thinking is flawed and contradictory to scripture, but here's one clear example
            - Rather than a world converted to the faith, Jesus' return is prompted by a world of unbelief and depravity
            - Just glace ahead to Jesus rhetorical question in chapter 18:8, where He asks will He find faith on the earth when He returns?
                - As we will see next week, the answer to that question is no, He won't

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- So up to this point, we understand Jesus is teaching that the days prior to His return will be marked by strong demonic activity and extreme human depravity
    - Now we know this is a barometer we can use understand in relative terms how close we are to Jesus' return
        - And when we look toward the end of the Bible and understand the events of Revelation, we see a perfect picture of that kind of time
            - A time when the enemy is actually ruling the earth through one man, the antichrist
            - We see a time when the depravity of men on earth has reached…well…Biblical proportions
            - When persecution on believers reaches it's zenith
        - But I also want you to understand that you don't reach this moment overnight
            - Rather , we should expect to see a steady slide toward that point
            - And if I'm right, then the times we live in now are certainly indicative of the kind of slide you would expect in the years leading up to Christ's return
            - Are we years away, decades away, centuries away?
- Jesus gives us still more insight into those days
    - He says people will be oblivious to their circumstances
    - Like in Noah's Days and Lot's days, they will be carrying on in normal ways
        - They will be eating, drinking and giving in marriage
        - Or in Lot's day, they were buying, selling, planting, building
    - In other words, God will not give them any special insight to know that judgment is about to befall them
        - Life will seem normal, unchanged from the way it's been since the beginning of time

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- And there will be no warning of the approaching judgment, no sudden heavenly announcement that judgment was coming soon
- In other words no one should be depending on some last minute awareness of judgment to be the thing that converts them
- When it comes, escape will not be possible

- But speaking of escape, there is something else important we learn about those last days from Jesus' comparison to Noah and Lot
    - In both those circumstances, God made a provision for the righteous of the day so that they would not be caught up in the judgment
        - In the case of Noah, the righteous of Noah's family were able to enter the Ark
            - Interestingly, they enter the ark seven days prior to the arrival of the flood waters
            - But once it arrived, they were carried to safety while the rest of the world experienced the judgment of the flood waters
        - In the case of Lot, angels are sent to remove Lot and members of his family immediately before the judgment falls from the sky on Sodom
    - So again, in the days of the Son of Man we should expect that God has a plan to rescue the righteous before His brings judgment on the earth
        - We know from other scripture that this rescue takes two different forms
        - First, there is rescue for the church saint who are still present on the earth before God's period of judgment commences
        - We call this perod the rapture, after a Greek word Paul uses in one of his letters.
            - It will be a sudden removal of all believers, body and soul from the earth to meet Christ in the clouds
        - And the earth of unbelievers who are left behind will be subjected to increasingly severe waves of God's wrath and He prepares to pour out judgment on the earth

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- But the Book of Revelation also tells us that there are yet more believers produced during this time of tribulation
    - And this second group brings about the second form of rescue that God provides before His final culminating moment of judgment when Christ returns and crushes all who oppose Him

- In verse 31 and beyond, Jesus goes on to describe that second rescue of the righteous using another comparison to the days of Lot

Luke 17:31 "On that day, the one who is on the housetop and whose goods are in the house must not go down to take them out; and likewise the one who is in the field must not turn back.
Luke 17:32 "Remember Lot's wife.
Luke 17:33 "Whoever seeks to keep his life will lose it, and whoever loses *his life* will preserve it.

- The verses begins with that phrase again with on that day – on the day of the Son of Man –
    - Those who are aware of his arrival must not turn back to retrieve earthly possessions
    - The image here is the same as the one provided by the story of Lot's wife
        - In the account of Genesis 19, the angels sent to rescue Lot and his family had managed to remove the family from the city
        - But as judgment had begun to fall on the city, Lot's wife disobeyed the angels' commands and looked back at the city
            - The implication from the Genesis text is clear – she looked back as if longing to still be a part of that city
            - In light of the enormity of the circumstances, her disobedience became clear evidence of an unrepentant heart
                - She was still attached to the city and all it represented
                - Her rescue was never possible because her heart had never been persuaded to trust in God rather than the world

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- Jesus uses a picture of someone who, in the middle of an escape from dire circumstances, stops and returns to retrieve a trivial possession
    - A person in a burning house who leaves only to return to retrieve their coat perhaps
    - Or perhaps a worker in the field who is running away from certain destruction, stops and returns as if to pick up where he left off in his work
    - Both circumstances demonstrate the utter foolishness and absurdity of such behavior by anyone who appreciates their circumstances
- But remember, that the days of these events will be such that the world of unbelievers will not recognize the coming judgment
    - They will be like those who return to the house to get their coat
    - Or return to the field to complete the job
    - In other words, they won't appreciate the finality of the moment
    - They will act as if there is still more time to come, not recognizing that for them time has come to an end
    - So in that sense, their behavior in that moment is a perfect reflection of their heart
- Jesus sums it up this way
    - Whoever seeks to keep his life
        - In the face of impending judgment , the one who acts to preserve his life in this world,
        - Who persists in the patterns of regular life
        - Someone who holds to the values of this world,
        - Who wishes to retain what he's gained in this world
    - That person will forfeit eternal life
    - On the other hand, the one who leaves it all behind

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- The one who counts nothing of this world worthy of his interest and adoration
- The one who willingly gives up his life in every form
- The one who has the insight to see the last days for what they are and respond accordingly
    - Like Noah did in giving up 100 years in order to build an ark when there was no rain
    - Like Lot who willingly left his home and all he had merely on the words of strangers who promised destruction to the city
- That person will receive their life in eternity

- Christ's return will be such a moment
    - A moment when the new saints made during the tribulation and who have survived until the end of tribulation will be separated from the rest of the earth's unbelieving population
    - And Jesus goes on to describe to some extent how that moment may look

Luke 17:34 "I tell you, on that night there will be two in one bed; one will be taken and the other will be left.
Luke 17:35 "There will be two women grinding at the same place; one will be taken and the other will be left.
Luke 17:36 ["Two men will be in the field; one will be taken and the other will be left."]
Luke 17:37 And answering they *said to Him, "Where, Lord?" And He said to them, "Where the body *is*, there also the vultures will be gathered."

- Jesus begins by saying "on that night"
    - What night
    - Well, if we trace it back in the text, it's the same night as the day mentioned in verse 31
    - Which is the same day as mentioned in verse 30…the day of the Son of Man
        - Which is itself a clear reference to the day of Christ's return

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        - The day Jesus first described in verse 24

    - In other words, what Jesus is about to describe is the day of His Second Coming

        - I mention all this because I want to be clear about what we're looking at here

        - This is not a picture of the rapture

- in Christ's return, would you prefer to be taken away or to remain behind?

    - Well, if we know that Christ is returning and plans to stay on earth ruling for a 1,000 years as scripture tells us

    - Then naturally, we would want to remain on the earth with Him

        - To be removed from the earth at the point where Christ returns is a bad thing

        - So though we want to be the one removed during the rapture, the opposite is true here

            - It's always a matter of wanting to be where Christ is

            - Since at the moment of the rapture Jesus doesn't come to the earth much less stay, you want to be the one caught up in the clouds, and taken away

            - But here, you want to be the one left to rule with Christ

        - I believe it's this distinction that largely explains the various misinterpretations of the events surrounding the end days, especially the rapture

            - There are two moments of rescue described in scripture

            - One involves the removal of the church from the earth prior to tribulation

            - The other revolves around the removal of the unbelievers from the earth at the point of Christ's return

- To further illustrate this principle, we can look at a parable in Matthew 13

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Matt. 13:24 ¶ Jesus presented another parable to them, saying, "The kingdom of heaven may be compared to a man who sowed good seed in his field.
Matt. 13:25 "But while his men were sleeping, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went away.
Matt. 13:26 "But when the wheat sprouted and bore grain, then the tares became evident also.
Matt. 13:27 "The slaves of the landowner came and said to him, 'Sir, did you not sow good seed in your field? How then does it have tares?'
Matt. 13:28 "And he said to them, 'An enemy has done this!' The slaves *said to him, 'Do you want us, then, to go and gather them up?'
Matt. 13:29 "But he *said, 'No; for while you are gathering up the tares, you may uproot the wheat with them.
Matt. 13:30 'Allow both to grow together until the harvest; and in the time of the harvest I will say to the reapers, "First gather up the tares and bind them in bundles to burn them up; but gather the wheat into my barn."'"
Matt. 13:36 ¶ Then He left the crowds and went into the house. And His disciples came to Him and said, "Explain to us the parable of the tares of the field."
Matt. 13:37 And He said, "The one who sows the good seed is the Son of Man,
Matt. 13:38 and the field is the world; and *as for* the good seed, these are the sons of the kingdom; and the tares are the sons of the evil *one*;
Matt. 13:39 and the enemy who sowed them is the devil, and the harvest is the end of the age; and the reapers are angels.
Matt. 13:40 "So just as the tares are gathered up and burned with fire, so shall it be at the end of the age.
Matt. 13:41 "The Son of Man will send forth His angels, and they will gather out of His kingdom all stumbling blocks, and those who commit lawlessness,
Matt. 13:42 and will throw them into the furnace of fire; in that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.
Matt. 13:43 "Then THE RIGHTEOUS WILL SHINE FORTH AS THE SUN in the kingdom of their Father. He who has ears, let him hear.

- In the day Christ returns, the earth will be a mixture of believers and unbelievers
    - This confirms that the days of tribulations will produce more believers and those believers will continue to exist to some degree until the very last day of tribulation
    - And then look at what happens to the unbelievers
        - They are the ones gathered up by the angels
        - And they face destruction

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- And the ones left behind will shone forth as the sun in the kingdom of their father
    - The believers will remain behind to rule with Christ

- So Jesus says one will be in the bed or at the mill – conducting everyday life in other words
    - And the one will be gone
    - And to further confirm that the ones leaving are the ones who face judgment, look at what the disciples ask next

Luke 17:37 And answering they *said to Him, "Where, Lord?" And He said to them, "Where the body *is*, there also the vultures will be gathered."

- The disciples as where Lord
    - What do they mean by where?
    - Well consider what Jesus just said
        - He just said two would be in a given place, and one would left
        - The obvious question that comes to everyone's mind is what happened to the one that was taken
        - Where did he or she go?
    - Which is what the disciples immediately asked Jesus…where , Lord?
        - To which Jesus gave this somewhat veiled answer
            - It's not really that veiled, at least not to you and I who the Holy Spirit guiding us
            - Jesus says where the body is, there the vulture is also
            - The place this person will be involves death and decay
            - This person is going to a place of death and judgment
            - The person being removed in not in a happy place

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- As we come to an end of the chapter and to tonight's teaching, where does Jesus' discourse leave us in Luke's narrative overall?
    - Well, first Jesus is very near the point of His arrival in Jerusalem
        - So, it certainly makes sense that as He nears His departure, He would begin to introduce the topic of His return
    - But more specifically, the Pharisees had opened the question of when will the kingdom arrive
        - So Jesus had simply elaborated on the details of that special day
        - He will return to this topic in even greater detail in Chapter 21
            - In fact, when we study Chapter 21 of Luke, we are actually going to do an extend analysis of Luke's chapter in comparison to Matthew and Mark's treatment of that same topic
            - Because only by studying all three can we get the complete picture of what Jesus is teaching
    - Next week, we will move into Chapter 18, but even as we end tonight, look at what opens the Chapter:

Luke 18:1 ¶ Now He was telling them a parable to show that at all times they ought to pray and not to lose heart,

- The Second Coming of Christ will not come in their life times, of course, so Jesus even now begins to prepare them for the need to not lose heart in the waiting for that day
    - Likewise us, consider each day as if it were the last day…

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Luke 18A

- As we go back into the Gospel of Luke, let's take a brief moment to remember what was happening at the end of Chapter 17
    - Jesus was addressing his disciples on the kingdom and specifically on His future return
    - And he mentioned to the disciples that in the day of His return that judgment will come for those who are not looking for His return
        - To those who are oblivious to the coming judgment and the Christ's return, the end will come suddenly and judgment will be the result
        - Those unbelievers who are on the earth at that moment will be gathered up by Christ's angels, we saw in Matthew's Gospel
            - And they will be brought before Christ to face the end of their earthly life as described in Rev 19
    - And when the disciples ask about where these people go, Jesus gives this haunting response at the very end of Chapter 17
        - He says where the body is, there also the vultures will be gathered
        - Meaning literally that these people will experience death and decay
    - More importantly, we learned from Chapter 17 how the end days would be characterized by a rise in depravity and demonic activity upon earth
        - Similar to the days of Noah and Lot
        - Those days would see a world filled with violence and few believers
- And this week beginning in the opening verses of Chapter 18, we see Jesus building on this point right from the start

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Luke 18:1 ¶ Now He was telling them a parable to show that at all times they ought to pray and not to lose heart,

- Here again we find a parable recorded only in Luke's gospel
    - And Luke places directly after the discourse on His return
    - Though that doesn't necessarily mean it happened in the same moment
    - It just as likely that Luke felt it was appropriate to place it here because it had a bearing on the previous conversation
- This opening parable in Chapter 18 and the one that follows in verse 9 also share a somewhat unique characteristic among Luke's parables
    - They both begin with a statement about why Jesus told these particularly stories
        - In this case, we're told that Jesus wants the disciples to pray and not to lose heart
        - And the phrase translated lose heart (egkakeo) can also be translated to mean grow weary or faint
            - Meaning, Jesus wanted to give the disciples reason not to give up or be discouraged in their appointed work
            - And that they should continue to pray in their afflictions
- This was a natural issue to raise at this point in light of what Jesus had taught in Chapter 17.
    - Jesus Had given the disciples a grim report of what to expect in the days immediately before His return
        - A depraved world where the enemy seemed to be taking control
            - And even though the disciples had no idea how long it would be prior to Jesus' return
            - Every generation of believers since Christ has seen persecution of the church somewhere in the world

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- So no matter how close any given generation may be to Christ's return, it could still identify with the thinking that underlies this verses
    - When persecution comes, don't lose heart, don't grow weary of keeping the faith and doing the master's will

- In the case of the disciples, it would be natural to grow weary and discouraged in light of what they faced in their lifetime
    - Virtually all the disciples experienced martyrdom, and they experienced many other trials along the way to their deaths
    - Considering how they must have all been assuming that the Messiah's coming to earth would usher in peace and justice
        - The thought that it wasn't going to happen for some time would be discouraging all by itself
    - So discouragement would have been an easy thing to experience
- But this discouragement is hardly limited to the disciples
    - The opening verse using language that makes clear Jesus is talking about a larger periscope of time
    - The term "at all times" (pantote – evermore) is a specific reference to the period between Jesus' departure and His return to judge the world
        - His discussing at the end of Chapter 17 gives us the proper context for coming to this conclusion
            - The time until the Day of the Son of Man is the period in view
            - This is the time period when all disciples are serving their Master in His physical absence
    - So every disciple should hear these words of Christ
        - Don't lose heart and keep praying, even though your circumstances may be bleak or the enemy
- And to prove this point, Jesus tells a parable about a widow and an unrighteous judge

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Luke 18:2 saying, "In a certain city there was a judge who did not fear God and did not respect man.
Luke 18:3 "There was a widow in that city, and she kept coming to him, saying, 'Give me legal protection from my opponent.'
Luke 18:4 "For a while he was unwilling; but afterward he said to himself, 'Even though I do not fear God nor respect man,
Luke 18:5 yet because this widow bothers me, I will give her legal protection, otherwise by continually coming she will wear me out.'"
Luke 18:6 And the Lord said, "Hear what the unrighteous judge *said;
Luke 18:7 now, will not God bring about justice for His elect who cry to Him day and night, and will He delay long over them?
Luke 18:8 "I tell you that He will bring about justice for them quickly. However, when the Son of Man comes, will He find faith on the earth?"

- This parable and the one that follows are also somewhat unique in that they are both structured as contrasts rather than as a comparisons
    - Do you remember that from your high school English classes?
        - Your teacher tells you to compare and contrast two types of writing
        - To compare was to find similarities
        - To contrast was to look for differences
    - Most of Jesus' parables are designed to draw a comparison
        - Kingdom and mustard seed
        - Slaves and masters
    - But this is one of the few parables where the main point is made by drawing a contrast
        - Though you can also find lessons comparisons being made as well
        - So lets sort this out
- In the parable we have a judge and a widow
    - These characters are interesting because they form a contrast of their own
        - A judge was one of the most powerful people in Jewish society

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- Since the Romans had conquered the Jews, all the powerful governmental positions were help by Romans
    - So the only positions of power available to the Jewish society were the judges of the Jewish Law, the Torah
    - So this man was about as powerful as a Jew could have been in Jesus day
- And on the other end of the social scale, you had the widow
    - She was by far the least powerful member of Jewish society
        - She had no inheritance, no income, no protector
        - This is why you see the scriptures give so much attention to the fate of widows
            - Acts 6, 1Tim 5, James 1
- So immediately we're struck by the contrast between the least powerful of society making appeal to the most powerful of society

- We're told this judge is unrighteous
    - Specifically, he doesn't fear God nor respect man
        - This is pretty dramatic when you consider that his role is to judge according to God's law
        - Today you wouldn't be very surprised to find judges who don't fear God nor respect men
        - But in Jesus day it would have been a bit scandalous to hear of such a man
    - Then there was a widow who continues to approach this judge asking for protection from her opponent
        - It's important to note at this point that she's asking the judge to do his job
            - A judge is supposed to provide justice to those who deserve it
            - Jesus uses the word protection (**ekdikeo**) which means to vindicate

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- So you could read this to give vindication from her enemies

- The point is she is confident of her own innocence before God's Law and yet she is being accused of violating the Law

  - So she is asking the judge to vindicate her, to declare that she isn't in violation of the law

  - To show that she is righteous and her opponents are the guilty ones

- And this is something the judge should certainly do

- We're told the judge is unwilling to give protection at first

  - But due to the woman's persistence the judge relents

  - And he gives her what she requests

    - Interestingly, the phrase in Greek that's translated wear me out is hypopiaze

      - Which is actually an idiom translated literally as to strike under the eye

      - Lest she give me a black eye

      - In other words, the man is saying I need to do what I should to protect this woman otherwise I she might give me a black eye – or she will ruin my reputation

    - So what motivates this unrighteous judge to finally do his job is his own concern for his reputation, as stained as it may be

- So then Jesus helps us by making the contrast

  - Remember, this isn't a comparison, so we're not suggesting that God is like an unrighteous judge

    - We're saying he's Unlike an unrighteous judge

      - Now there is a small comparison in the midst of the overall contrast

      - We are like the widow in that we have very little power and practically no standing in this world

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- And like the judge in the parable, God is infinitely more powerful and he's the only one we can appeal to for justice and protection from our enemies

- And since we know that God is a truly righteous judge, how much more should we expect Him to do what's right?

- If the unrighteous man was finally willing to do what's right on the basis of protecting his reputation

- Shouldn't we expect God to do what's right for the sake of His name and His reputation?

- But what do we learn from the parable?

- It's not enough to simply say that the parable is teaching that God answers our prayers for protection and justice

- That's true, but we didn't need this parable to teach us that and nor did the Disciples

- They would have had little reason to doubt that God would do those things

- The problem comes when you combine this parable with what Jesus taught in the earlier Chapter

- The disciples are going to experience a lifetime of waiting

- And more than their own lifetime, the waiting is going to continue long after the disciples are gone

- The point of the parable is the wait for God to bring His justice is going to lead to doubt and losing heart

- That's the one feature of the parable that's easy to overlook

- The woman got what she had reason to expect from the judge, but it took time to get it

- She had to wait a long time before she got justice

- And in the meantime, she suffered under persecution

- But in the end, her persistence was met with satisfaction

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- And here the parable offers one last opportunity for comparison rather than contrast
    - Like the woman's situation, we can expect that our persistence for justice will result in satisfaction
        - But are you prepared to wait your entire lifetime and even longer?
        - Are you prepared to hear that our God will not bring the justice and protection we are asking until the Day of the Son of Man
        - Can you wait that long and still not lose heart? Not cease to pray for protection and justice, even knowing that it might not happen in your lifetime?
            - What true measure of persistence and faith…
            - Being willing to pray and maintain trust in God to act even if it doesn't happen in time to save you from your own perils
                - Remember the Disciples were all martyrs
                - They never saw God act in their day to remove persecution or bring ultimate justice
    - Now this doesn't preclude God from taking intermediate action on behalf of his children in the meantime, and He does this all the time
        - Missionaries saved from hostile tribes
        - Churches saved from financial ruin
        - Families and individuals saved from any number of hardships
        - But ultimate justice can only come upon Christ's return
- And just in case the disciples were tempted to measure their own success by what they see with their eyes, Jesus gives the sobering postscript in verse 8
    - He says when this time of waiting ends
    - When the judge finally returns and answers those persistent prayers for justice
        - What will He find?

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- Will He find faith on the earth?
- Will He find an earth full of those waiting to receive Him and welcome Him?
    - Will those who preach the Gospel have succeeded in persuading the world to the truth?

- To all these questions, the implied answer is clearly no
    - Therefore, don't lose heart
    - Don't cease praying
    - Don't let your eyes and ears deceive you
        - Don't begin to think that because your own efforts to carry the gospel forward haven't been met with a revival at every turn cause you to doubt the mission
        - Don't let the fact that the message brings criticism and persecution rather than acceptance and joy leave you feeling discouraged over the prospects for the future
            - Yes there is a bleak future for the earth as a whole, which is why you can't use the state of things on earth as an excuse to give up hope
            - The opposite is true
            - The hopelessness of the earth is your reason to persevere and press forward in bringing the news of God's love through Christ so that by our obedience and perseverance, God may save some

- Some might ask why persist in prayer for God's justice when the day of it's arrival is already determined and set
    - Remember, that prayer is a privilege God grants His children
        - And when we exercise that privilege we benefit from the opportunity to spend time in His presence regardless of the circumstances
        - We may never realized the benefits until we are glorified and all things are made known

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- But secondly, our continued faithful prayers for Jesus' return and for the justice that He will bring form a faithful witness to the world
    - Who knows how many people might be positively influenced by our prayerful expectation of Jesus' Second Coming

- And then Jesus backs up this parable with a second one, another contrast

Luke 18:9 ¶ And He also told this parable to some people who trusted in themselves that they were righteous, and viewed others with contempt:
Luke 18:10 "Two men went up into the temple to pray, one a Pharisee and the other a tax collector.
Luke 18:11 "The Pharisee stood and was praying this to himself: 'God, I thank You that I am not like other people: swindlers, unjust, adulterers, or even like this tax collector.
Luke 18:12 'I fast twice a week; I pay tithes of all that I get.'
Luke 18:13 "But the tax collector, standing some distance away, was even unwilling to lift up his eyes to heaven, but was beating his breast, saying, 'God, be merciful to me, the sinner!'
Luke 18:14 "I tell you, this man went to his house justified rather than the other; for everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but he who humbles himself will be exalted."

- Like the first parable tonight, Luke begins by explaining the purpose of the parable
    - The parable illustrates the two places people put their trust
    - Two men went up to the temple in Jerusalem to pray
        - As in the earlier parable, Jesus draws immediate contrasts
            - The Pharisee were a symbol of righteousness in the Jewish culture
                - Much like the world may have seen Mother Theresa as the symbol of righteousness
            - Then there was the tax collector, who easily had the lowest reputation within Jewish society
        - The parable plays effectively on these two extremes by reversing the roles of honor

- Consider the words and actions of the Pharisee
    - The Pharisee stands close in within the temple (standing was normal)

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        - He has no concerns over approaching God in His temple

    - When the Pharisee prayed, Jesus says quite pointedly that he prays to himself

        - This isn't to say that he is praying silently

        - The word for himself literally means one's conscious

        - He's making an appeal to his own conscious, rather than making an appeal to God

    - And then look at the content of his prayer

        - He comes before God to declare his own righteousness

        - He gives thanks to God, but really when you look at the overall purpose and content of the prayer, He is really praising himself

            - That's like me hosting a dinner to honor my parents, and then giving a speech before the crowd declaring how thankful I am for my parents giving me so much intelligence and good looks and some a humble personality

            - The only person receiving praise in that moment is me

        - Likewise, the only person receiving praise in the moment with the Pharisee is the Pharisee

- But there's something even more insidious about the supposed prayer he makes

    - He makes a comparison to others around him who would seem self-evidently to be less worthy of God's favor

        - He mentioned the various sinners of his day who the Pharisee felt certain would experience God's judgment because they hadn't escaped their sin the way he had

    - Pharisees led the most scrupulous and austere lifestyle

        - They typically fasted twice a week when the norm was once

        - They tithed on the smallest things

        - And it was in these actions that he felt justified before God

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- But did you catch the judgmental nature of his prayer?
  - The inevitable consequence of those who would desire to stand before God on the basis of their own self-made righteousness is that they are forever making comparisons between themselves and others
  - And the comparisons are always for the purpose of finding fault with others so that they might see themselves as better by comparison
    - And in my experience one is always a sign of the other
    - A person who is self-righteous and relying on their own goodness to earn God's favor will naturally adopt a judgmental attitude toward others
    - Likewise, someone who exhibits a judgmental attitude toward others is resting – if even for a moment – in their own righteousness as an insurance before God
      - And Christians are often the most guilty of this
      - Even a person who has placed their trust in Christ for their salvation and who understands grace not works saves them
      - Nevertheless, they can fall back into a fleshly pattern of judging others so that they might feel better by comparison
      - And this is a hurtful and destructive patterns wherever it appears, especially within the church

- What's the solution to this problem? To both the Pharisee's trusting in self and to our own tendency to become judgemental?
  - The answer is found in the attitude of the other man in the temple
  - He is the epitome of a sinner
    - He is someone who can't escape his sin before the world

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- He couldn't walk around as the Pharisee sis pretending to be without sin
- His very profession testified against him, much like prostitutes and drunks and thieves
  - He couldn't escape the obvious conclusion that he had offended God and was due judgment

- And when he is ready to come before God to seek forgiveness, his behavior and his words reflect a heart that recognizes his own unworthiness before God
  - He stands at a distance, to afraid to approach for fear of God's judgment
  - He is unwilling to lift his eyes, not willing to look upon God's holiness, sensing instinctively the offense that God's takes at his sin
  - His only statement to God is a plea for mercy while acknowledging his sin
- Jesus says, this man was justified in God's sight
  - Clearly he couldn't have been justified because of his works before God
    - He had no "good" work
  - He was justified on the basis of his genuine repentance and faith in God's mercy
- As Jesus concludes, to be exalted by God requires a willingness to recognize and acknowledge our unworthiness before Him
  - But for those who do not recognize they are unworthy, who instead exalt themselves before God, they will be humbled in the eternal sense
  - They will receive the judgment they assumed was reserved for those who they had made comparison with

- This man's heart condition is the solution to world's predicament

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- Jesus is giving the disciples the solution to the problem He had just identified
    - The world will not receive Him and faith will not be present on the earth upon His return, though faith is the only way to be justified
    - While the world was busy devising all manner of ways to reach God, they all share one thing in common
        - They place their trust in themselves
        - No matter the system nor the set of rules that are followed, they all come down to a trust in self
        - A trust in what we can accomplish by ourselves
        - And these works hold absolutely no value to God
        - And unless accompanied by faith, they cannot please God
- So the solution is to abandon all trust in self and place all our trust in God for His mercy through His Son

- These parables and the verses that follow in 18 provide a culmination point in the teaching that Luke records during Jesus' trip from the Galilee up to Jerusalem
    - So it's only fitting that the entire Chapter tackles the issue of faith as the only means of salvation
    - These two parables introduce the basic issue of faith
        - Of faith being the key ingredient for a relationship with God,
        - Yet faith will not reign on earth in the day Jesus returns.

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Luke 18B

- We're picking up again in Chapter 18, so let's review where we let off
    - We had studied through the first 14 verses of the chapter
        - Two parables
            - Widow and the Unrighteous Judge
            - Encouragement to pray and not lose heart
            - Because the Father will bring justice to His elect
            - But the disciples must be prepared to accept that the entire world will not receive the Messiah
                - Rather Jesus' own rejection is but a forerunner for the disciple's own persecution
                - And for the persecution of the church throughout the ages
        - Second parable on the tax collector and Pharisee
            - True faith is based on repentance and a turning toward God for mercy
            - In contrast to the world's false religion of worshipping a God made in our own image
                - A god that favors us because we are deserving of his favor, having earned it through good works
                - This is a false religion, one that leads to hell
    - Already in these opening verses of chapter 18, a pattern has begun to emerge in Luke's narrative
        - There is a recurring topic addressed in these opening verses
            - And it's going to repeat throughout the rest of the chapter
            - And this recurring topic is the nature of faith and its power to bring men into the kingdom

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Luke 18:15 ¶ And they were bringing even their babies to Him so that He would touch them, but when the disciples saw it, they *began* rebuking them.
Luke 18:16 But Jesus called for them, saying, "Permit the children to come to Me, and do not hinder them, for the kingdom of God belongs to such as these.
Luke 18:17 "Truly I say to you, whoever does not receive the kingdom of God like a child will not enter it *at all*."

- This is an interesting scene, and at first it seems somewhat disconnected from the rest of the chapter
    - It follows the story of the Pharisee and tax collector
    - And it precedes a story of a man asking Jesus how to inherit eternal life
    - But even in those references, you can begin to see the patter again that I mentioned
        - The connecting theme here is the nature of true faith and it's power to save
        - So what do we learn about faith from these verses and the ones that surround them?
- First, let's look at the scene Luke describes here
    - First, the scene Luke describes in very brief, but knowing a little about Jewish culture and human nature can help us fill in the gaps
        - From Luke's text we know that Jesus was in the midst of crowds as He traveled
        - And these crowds were adoring, at least at this point
        - So people were bringing their infants to Jesus to have Him pray over them and lay hands on them
            - The word for babies is brephos, which means infants or newborns
            - So Luke emphasizes that these are children who are very young – far too young to understand who Jesus was or what He might do for them

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- And this was a tradition in the Jewish culture as it still is today
  - People bring their babies to famous people – the Pope, presidents, Elvis, you name it
  - But here the situation is a little different in that the point of bringing the babies was for a spiritual blessing
  - People often brought their children before rabbis for a blessing
- We can see this more clearly by looking at Matthew's gospel
  - In Matthew's gospel it would seem that Jesus addressed this issue of children more than once during His ministry
  - Because there are two separate places where Matthews records similar statements by Jesus
    - In chapter 18 and again in chap 19 of Matt we find Jesus talking about children coming to him
    - For example, in Chap 19 Jesus says

Matt. 19:13 ¶ Then *some* children were brought to Him so that He might lay His hands on them and pray; and the disciples rebuked them.
Matt. 19:14 But Jesus said, "Let the children alone, and do not hinder them from coming to Me; for the kingdom of heaven belongs to such as these.

- From Matthew's account, we learn the purpose of why the parents wanted to bring their babies to Jesus
  - They wanted Jesus to pray over the children and lay hands on them
  - They wanted a spiritual blessing for their child
- And when you look at the disciples' reaction, you have to wonder what was bothering them
  - We're told they rebuked the crowd
    - They were telling the crowd that it was wrong to bring their children to Jesus to ask for a blessing
    - Perhaps they thought this kind of courtesy was beneath Jesus

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- Or perhaps they felt that it was a pointless exercise
  - After all, the disciples knew the children weren't old enough to understand who Jesus was
  - They couldn't possibly know what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah
  - How could they possibly benefit from approaching Jesus
- It's as though they viewed the whole exercise as superstition and unworthy of Jesus' time
- So the disciples chastise the crowd and try to dissuade them from approaching Jesus in this way

- To which Jesus responds that they should permit the children to come to Him
  - Don't hinder them
    - The word for hinder is koluo, which means forbid
    - It comes from a Greek root which means to punish
    - So Jesus is saying that their should be no prohibition from children seeking Him
  - Based on these verses by themselves, we might conclude that Jesus was merely speaking about the practice of asking for a blessing for children
    - But we have a couple of ways to know that there is something much more foundational on Jesus' mind when He makes this statement
    - First, it simply makes no sense to think that Jesus was teaching in the literal sense of bringing children to him physically
      - Jesus is only going to be on the earth for a few more weeks at this point
      - What value is there in this teaching if it merely refers to allowing children to come sit on Jesus lap while He walks the earth
      - It would barely even warrant a mention in the Gospel if that's all it meant

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- No, it must have a more lasting purpose, one that still applies today

- Which leads us to our second piece of evidence found in the second of Matthew's descriptions of Jesus welcoming children found in Chap 18

  - Turn to Matt chapter 18 and read with me the entire discourse Matt records around this moment

Matt. 18:2 And He called a child to Himself and set him before them,
Matt. 18:3 and said, "Truly I say to you, unless you are converted and become like children, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 18:4 "Whoever then humbles himself as this child, he is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 18:5 "And whoever receives one such child in My name receives Me;

- The context of Matthew reveals a great deal more of Jesus' motives as He tells the disciples not to hinder the children

  - But that those who receive the kingdom must do so as they do

  - First, verses 3-4 place the entire discourse that follows squarely in the context of salvation and the nature of saving faith

    - Verse 3 talks of a conversion and of entering the kingdom of God

    - Verse 4 talks about humbling ones self (as in repentance) and again entering the kingdom of heaven

  - So clearly Jesus is using the children to make a clear statement about the nature of salvation and the kind of faith that leads to salvation

    - This isn't merely a conversation about bringing children to Jesus for the purpose of being blessed

  - Then in verse 5 Jesus moves the conversation to the issue of receiving children in His name

    - And since the overall topic of the discourse is focused on salvation, the only reasonable interpretation of Jesus comments in verse 5 is this

      - Whoever accepts a child's confession of faith and receives that child into the brotherhood of the church has received Christ Himself

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- In that we have received the work of Christ in the heart of that child
- The child's sincere confession of Christ is to be accepted on its face without preconditions or prejudgments and without any other test
- And when we accept a child's genuine confession, we are receiving Christ in that moment, because it is proof that God is at work in that Child's heart

- Consider the rest of Jesus' statements in verses 10-14 of Matt

Matt. 18:10 ¶ "See that you do not despise one of these little ones, for I say to you that their angels in heaven continually see the face of My Father who is in heaven.
Matt. 18:11 ["For the Son of Man has come to save that which was lost.]
Matt. 18:12 ¶ "What do you think? If any man has a hundred sheep, and one of them has gone astray, does he not leave the ninety-nine on the mountains and go and search for the one that is straying?
Matt. 18:13 "If it turns out that he finds it, truly I say to you, he rejoices over it more than over the ninety-nine which have not gone astray.
Matt. 18:14 "So it is not *the* will of your Father who is in heaven that one of these little ones perish.

- Jesus teaches the famous parable of the lost sheep and it's notable that Matt places this parable in the middle of Jesus' teaching on allowing children to come to Him
  - He compares the child to one of the lost sheep of His fold
    - And in the parable we have the classic picture of God searching for his lost sheep
      - There are 100 sheep in God's fold, but only 99 are currently safe and found
      - One is missing
      - And the shepherd searches until the one that's missing is found and He brings it home
    - And without taking time to teach the depths of this parables, for tonight it's sufficient for us to take note that this lost sheep is considered to be one of God's fold even before its found

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- While it is yet lost, God still sees it as one of His
- And it remains lost only as long as it takes for the shepherd to retrieve it
- Once found, it's brought home to complete the number of God's fold, a number which was predetermined by God from the foundations of the world (according to Ephesians 1)

▪ And take note of verse 14

- It is not the will of the Father that even one of His fold will perish
- Meaning, it was never in doubt that this lost sheep would one day be found

▪ God would never be content to have only 99 of His sheep

- The sheep wasn't a goat that turning into a sheep
- It was always a sheep, it was merely lost for a time

o And Jesus compares the lost sheep to a child and says that even it will not perish

- So by what we learn in Matthew, we see that Jesus is talking about something much more important than merely a religious ritual of blessing infants

o He's teaching that God's elect will include children, including very young children

o And therefore the disciples must not hinder them

- In fact, consider what Jesus' comments mean in light of Luke's overall narrative in Chapter 18

o We said already Luke is portraying a series of events in this chapter to explain the nature of saving faith

▪ In verse 7 of chap 18, Jesus makes reference to God bringing justice for His elect, meaning for His chosen children

▪ And then in verse 8, Jesus ends his first topic by adding that haunting comment will the Son of Man find faith on the earth when He returns?

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- So right away, Jesus begins making references to God's faithfulness toward His elect
- And to the fact that faith itself will be in short supply upon earth at His return

- So now Luke records this incredible new detail concerning the nature of saving faith
  - Saving faith can come upon even children
    - That the faith that saves men, may enter into the heart of even small children
  - Therefore, when that faith is displayed in them, do not forbid them from being received as believers
  - For when we receive them, we are acknowledging that their acceptance of Christ is evidence of the work of God in them to draw them to Jesus
    - Therefore, when we receive them, we receive Jesus
    - What an incredible revelation
      - This is so different from the Jewish culture and mindset of the day
        - Children were first circumcised
        - Then they studied the Torah, the Prophets and Sayings to understand the foundations of the faith
        - They memorized large tracts of scripture
        - The performed the rituals of the faith and observed the festivals and feasts
        - In early teens boys were expected to demonstrate their readiness to enter into the assembling of Israel
        - And they began practicing the sacrifices required under the Law
  - In other words, the Jewish culture had come to see acceptance into the assembly of Israel as a condition for acceptance by God Himself

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- And therefore they would have had a difficult time accepting that a small child could be acknowledged as a rightful member of the kingdom merely on the basis of a desire to be received

- But that's exactly how it happens

- Though there is more we can say about this revelation, we'll hold it for a time while we consider the next series of verses

    - Because Jesus Himself comes back to this point as He continues to develop on the theme of saving faith

Luke 18:18 ¶ A ruler questioned Him, saying, "Good Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"
Luke 18:19 And Jesus said to him, "Why do you call Me good? No one is good except God alone.
Luke 18:20 "You know the commandments, 'DO NOT COMMIT ADULTERY, DO NOT MURDER, DO NOT STEAL, DO NOT BEAR FALSE WITNESS, HONOR YOUR FATHER AND MOTHER.'"
Luke 18:21 And he said, "All these things I have kept from *my* youth."
Luke 18:22 When Jesus heard *this*, He said to him, "One thing you still lack; sell all that you possess and distribute it to the poor, and you shall have treasure in heaven; and come, follow Me."
Luke 18:23 But when he had heard these things, he became very sad, for he was extremely rich.

- This is a classic exchange, probably one you've heard many times before

    - In contrast to the innocence of children, a rich ruler

        - The word for ruler in Greek could mean an official of some kind, a magistrate or prince

        - Clearly, a man of authority and wealth

    - And when He approaches Jesus here, his intentions seem sincere

        - He sincerely seems to want to do what's required to be in ther kingdom when it arrives

        - And Jesus seems to be the one with all the answers

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        - So the ruler poses the question, what do I need to do to get into the kingdom

    - So here again, we're in a discussion of salvation and the nature of saving faith

- Jesus' first words to the man at first seem to be off the point a little

    - Jesus asks the man why he is willing to describe Jesus as "good"

        - Then He reminds the man that only God Himself can be accurately described as good

        - What a profound statement

        - Think about what's wrapped up in that simple comment

            - Jesus has stated three things in that one sentence

                - First, Jesus is reminding us that the definition of good is not based on a range but on a point

                - God isn't a sliding scale or a comparison between relative standards

                - Rather it's a single standard that is unforgiving

            - You are either good or you are not

                - You can't be mostly good or a little good

                - Like a little pregnant

                - You are or you are not

            - The second thing Jesus said is that when it comes to qualifying for heaven, the standard for what it is required to be good is established by God

                - If being good is an all or nothing proposition and not a sliding scale, then the only standard we should are about for measuring goodness is the one that God uses

                - To use any other standard for determining whether we are good is merely an expercise in fooling ourselves

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- Only God's standard for what is or isn't good should matter to us – if our concern in getting into the kingdom

- Finally, the third thing Jesus taught was the only God can meet His standard of good
  - Only God is good in the true sense of the word
  - No man can reach the standard required for God to declare us good and therefore enter His kingdom

- So when the ruler called Jesus good, he was declaring Jesus to be God, though of course he didn't realize the true meaning of his own words
  - And Jesus' response gave the ruler the fundamental answer to his question, though again, he didn't appreciate it

- Then Jesus moved on to answer the man's question more directly
  - Jesus cites the 5th through 9th commandments
  - These are the commandments that relate to man's relationship with other men, with one notable exception
    - That exception is the 10th commandment, which deals with coveting
    - Of course, the earlier commandments are also missing from Jesus' list, including the first commandment to not have any god's before the Lord

- To this the man gives his bold answer
  - He says he has kept them since his youth
    - Obviously, it's extremely unlikely that this man has kept even these five commandments perfectly as he claims,
    - But nevertheless, Jesus humors him for the moment and doesn't argue the point
  - He simply lowers the boom in response
    - Jesus says you still lack one thing…just one more thing
  - Give up your wealth and worship me

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- In that phrase Jesus adds the tenth and first commandments
    - In giving up wealth, Jesus is demanding that the man repent of his preference for material wealth over heavenly wealth
        - Are you tempted to think that this is an unreasonable demand?
        - Well, remember that all the disciples left everything behind to follow Jesus
        - This is the pattern of those who believe in Jesus and want to follow Him
    - And that's the other commandment captured in Jesus statement
        - He asks the man to follow him, to worship him
        - This is the essence of the first commandment
        - Follow God and not the world
        - Put Him first in your heart and don't ask him to compete with other things that you find attractive and comforting in this world

- Then Luke records that Jesus' response left the ruler very sad, because he had great wealth
    - The other Gospels record that this man left Jesus at this point in his sadness
    - Why did he leave?
        - Because he wasn't willing to do what was required to follow Jesus
        - He couldn't turn his back on the world and leave it behind
        - His attraction to the world and to it's wealth was so great, that not even a sincere interest in reaching heaven was enough to pull him away
    - But maybe the more interesting question is why did he go away sad?
        - He could have left angry in disagreement with Jesus' terms

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- Or he could have left confused or pondering Jesus point
- Or he could have simply lost interest and left
- But he leaves sad, very sad even
    - The only conclusion we can make is that somewhere inside the conviction of Jesus' words had left its mark on the man's heart
    - He knew Jesus was right
    - But that fact alone wasn't enough to bring him around to a faith that would prompt him into action
    - He felt conviction and perhaps even a repentance of sorts, but not a repentance leading to salvation

- So this man's encounter with Jesus came a s a result of his search for the formula that would grant him salvation, entrance to the kingdom
    - But he came with the wrong supposition
    - He assumed that reaching the kingdom came on the basis of works
    - And in His opening statement, Jesus says that the standard for reaching God is so unapproachable, that only God Himself meets it
        - But if you're interesting in going down that road, it won't take to find somewhere you're lacking
        - And when Jesus points out the deficiency, the only result is sadness, for the man lacked the power to turn away from the sin that condemned him

- And now the final two verse for today, where we put the entire days' teaching together

Luke 18:24 And Jesus looked at him and said, "How hard it is for those who are wealthy to enter the kingdom of God!
Luke 18:25 "For it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God."
Luke 18:26 They who heard it said, "Then who can be saved?"

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Luke 18:27 But He said, "The things that are impossible with people are possible with God."

- As this pathetic man walks away from Jesus and to the assurance of damnation, Jesus remarks to the disciples how hard it is for those who are wealthy to enter the kingdom
    - In fact, it is easier for a camel to go though a needle…
        - In other words, it's impossible
            - There is no trick or secret to this statement
            - Jesus means it the way it reads
        - Can a camel walk through the eye of a needle? No
            - Similarly, a rich man cannot go into the kingdom
    - How can this be? After, we expect to find men like Abraham, David and Solomon in the kingdom, and all three were very rich men – God made them rich
        - Remember the context of Luke's chapter – speaking of the nature of saving faith
        - And consider the earlier discussions in the chapter
            - Jesus saying that those who humble themselves will see the kingdom
            - Those who recognize they have nothing to offer God rather than those who assume that have everything going their way
- Then consider what Jesus means by rich
    - You see the ruler wasn't just rich in the sense of his worldly wealth
    - He was rich in the sense that he had already obtained everything he needed to meet God's test for the kingdom
        - Remember his statement in verse 21 – I had kept all these since my youth

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- Compare it to the statement of the Pharisee in verse 11 & 12 – he had everything too

- They were both rich in the sense of verse 25

  - It was impossible for these rich men to inherit eternal life, because they were banking on the wrong things

    - They misjudged God's standard of goodness

    - They never realized that their spiritual wealth amounted to filthy rags before God

    - So they hadn't humbled themselves like the tax collector or the children

  - In fact, children have nothing to offer God and they never assume that they have earned anything before God

  - In contrast, these men felt they had earned God's favor

- The point of this chapter is reinforced even further with the disciples' question in verse 26

  - Then who can be saved Jesus? What does it take to please God then?

    - If this man who has keep the law since his youth could never expect to be granted entrance to the kingdom, what hope is there for anyone?

    - Can anyone possibly meet God's test of perfection? Who could be good enough to enter?

      - Do you see how even the disciples had not yet grasped the nature of saving faith?

- And then Jesus gives the answer that ties everything together

  - What's impossible for people is possible for God

    - Again, Jesus says two profound things in that statement

      - Jesus declares saving faith to be an impossible act for men

      - Men cannot in their own power come to salvation

  - This fact was best illustrated in the rich man's response to Christ's call

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- When you consider how Jesus called the disciples, he used much the same words
- But the disciples followed when this ruler didn't
- And the difference was their wealth
- But not the wealth of their earthly fortune
- But their spiritual wealth

- Remember, blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven
  - But until a man has been brought to a recognition that there are poor in spiritual terms
  - In debt to God and without a hope of their own making
  - Only then will they turn to God with a humble heart and seek His mercy
    - And until that moment, they will walk away in sadness like that ruler did – incapable of ever changing their own heart

- And then Jesus gives us hope, for He says that all things are possible with God
  - While we cannot hope to act to save ourselves, God is capable of saving us
    - By reaching into our hearts and giving us a new spirit, He enables us to respond to the Gospel and to believe
    - And by God's power, we come as children, with nothing to offer and with complete trust and dependence upon God
    - And through faith, God credits us with His Son's righteousness
      - And this impossible conversion made possible by God happens for his lost sheep on an appointed day according to His will
      - And it can happen for a child
  - In this way, Christ will build His church, one heart at a time

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Luke 18C

- As we go back into Chapter 18 today, we will rejoin a conversation that Jesus is having with the disciples concerning the nature of saving faith
    - The last piece of this conversation concerned a rich young ruler who walked away sad because he couldn't bring himself to meet the test for eternal life that Jesus presented to him
        - This man presumed he could be worthy of eternal life because of his righteous living
        - But Jesus pointedly illustrates that his life wasn't nearly as perfect as the man assumed it was
            - Jesus says if your heart's desire is truly to seek after the kingdom, then sell all that you have and follow me
            - Obviously, Jesus wasn't giving a recipe for earning our salvation (e.g., those who sell everything get automatic entrance into heaven)
            - Rather, it was a matter of repentance
    - Before we can receive the Messiah as our salvation, we must first reject all other forms
        - Our belief in the Messiah must be an exclusive allegiance
        - We cannot hold Jesus to be important and necessary while still holding to other things, including material wealth, as essential
        - Christ and His call on our life must reign supreme, above all else, or we are merely playing religion
        - This man was playing religion, as we studied last week
        - He was hoping to gain assurance from Jesus that he had discovered the magic formula and was going to receive his reward
        - But Jesus threw him a curveball
            - Jesus said if you honestly desire the kingdom, then do away with the one thing that stands in your way in your heart

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- But the man couldn't do it
    - Because the unregenerated man can't change his own heart, and his heart will betray him
    - SO the man walked away sad

- Then the disciples exclaimed, "Who can be saved?"
    - Because if this upstanding member of society couldn't meet the test, who could?
    - Jesus answers that for a man to find salvation on his own is impossible, but by God a man might be saved
    - Which leads us to tonight's starting point

Luke 18:28 ¶ Peter said, "Behold, we have left our own *homes* and followed You."
Luke 18:29 And He said to them, "Truly I say to you, there is no one who has left house or wife or brothers or parents or children, for the sake of the kingdom of God,
Luke 18:30 who will not receive many times as much at this time and in the age to come, eternal life."

- As usual good ole Peter speaks up to defend himself and the group
    - He says we've left our homes and followed you, Jesus
        - That opening word, behold, is such a Biblical term,
        - In fact the NIV just ignores it
        - but it's really exactly the same as a word that many of you would use to begin your own sentences
        - Especially when you're trying to make a point emphatically, as Peter is doing here
            - The word in Greek is idou, but it can also be translated look
            - So you could translate, "Look, we've left our homes…"

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- It should be pretty easy for all of us to see why prompted Peter to make this exclamation here
    - In listening to Jesus teaching, Peter may not have understood all that Jesus was teaching but he made one connection
        - He heard Jesus say that his rich man who couldn't bear to part with all that he owned was not going to inherit eternal life
        - And you can almost see the wheels turning in Peter's mind
            - If being unwilling to part with your possessions leaves a person in jeopardy, then I better clarify something with Jesus
    - So Peter says we've given everything up…
        - To which he hopes Jesus will respond that's he's safe
- Can you imagine a smile on Jesus' face as he hears Peter's words?
    - I think Jesus was understanding of Peter's concerns and wanted to allay them
    - But perhaps Jesus was also a bit amused at Peter's rush to exonerate himself
        - Jesus responds with an answer that both satisfies Peter's concerns and gives him something new to think about
- Once again, the topic here revolves around the nature of saving faith
    - In this case, the sacrifices and rewards that come with true faith
- Jesus says that those who make sacrifices in this age for the sake of the kingdom will be vindicated
    - Look at the list
        - House
            - Give up the security and comfort of a home, a permanent place to live
        - Wife
            - This doesn't mean leaving a wife as in divorce

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- It either means leaving the opportunity of marriage or the separation that might be required to perform ministry

- Brothers, parents, children

- While this may also refer to separations due to ministry work

- I believe its greater meaning is to be found in the separations that occur over the gospel itself

- Our belief in the gospel and our desire to obey Christ results in division within the family, just as Jesus promised it would

- This is often the kind of sacrifice we must be willing to make if necessary to follow Christ

- Consider all that Jesus is suggesting here

- To the rich man, Jesus had demanded that the man's wealth could not stand in the way of his obedience

- And not because Jesus hates rich men

- But because for that ruler, his riches took precedence in his heart over the call of the Gospel

- The gospel is an all or nothing proposition

- If we are truly believers in the Gospel and have our hope for eternal life in Christ, then we would never trade it away for anything found in this world

- Hebrews puts it this way

Heb. 3:14 For we have become partakers of Christ, if we hold fast the beginning of our assurance firm until the end,

- Hebrews says that the definition of one who is a partaker of Christ (a believer in the Gospel) is one who holds fast the beginning of our assurance firm until the end

- Those who show an initial interest in the Gospel some way and even make a confession of faith

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- but later find reason to move on to some new hope are giving proof that their initial confession was false

- Jesus tells the man that he must demonstrate his true reliance and trust in Jesus to inherit eternal life by dispossessing himself of all he owned

  - For that man, this was the test necessary to prove his heart true

  - And as Jesus knew would happen, the test merely proved the man's interest in Jesus to be insincere

- But to those who are truly in the faith, then we should expect that at times we may be called to dispossess ourselves of something that stands in the way of our complete trust in and obedience to Christ

  - Things like our possessions and security

  - Like our opportunities for a spouse

  - Or our opportunities for close family relationships, if necessary

    - Remember Paul teaching to the church in Corinth

1Cor. 7:29 But this I say, brethren, the time has been shortened, so that from now on those who have wives should be as though they had none;
1Cor. 7:30 and those who weep, as though they did not weep; and those who rejoice, as though they did not rejoice; and those who buy, as though they did not possess;
1Cor. 7:31 and those who use the world, as though they did not make full use of it; for the form of this world is passing away.

- Paul describes our time on this earth as a time that has been shortened

  - He's speaking about urgency in our lives

    - The New Testament is abundantly clear that we should look for Christ's return on any day

    - Or at the very least we should consider that everyday is our last day of life

    - And that urgency should compel us to stop living a normal life

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- We should live a radically different life

- Though we may be married, we should live as though we are not married
  - In the context of chapter 7 of 1Cor it becomes clear that Paul is talking about the demands and distractions that come with marriage
  - Though we have commands to love our spouse and perform our duties in marriage
    - We cannot use those obligations as excuse for not obeying Christ's call to be a disciple
- Similarly, look at Paul's other examples
  - Those who weep must live as those who do not weep
    - Which means we cannot use our sorrows in life as an excuse or a barrier to discipleship and obedience
  - Even when we have reason to rejoice, we should live as one without rejoicing
    - We can't let our triumphs in life distract us away from our calling in response to the Gospel
  - Nor can we let our possessions become our distraction
  - And Paul sums it up this way
    - Even though we must live in and use this world to accomplish the mission God has given us
    - We cannot live as though it is this world that matters to us
      - It must not matter to us except as we can use it to accomplish God's desires through us
      - For as Paul reminds us, this current form of the world is passing away
      - It is not meant nor can it last

- So Jesus confirms for Peter the fact that they (and we) are going to be called upon to make sacrifices like that rich man for our faith

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- When we make necessary sacrifices, the reward will be great
- And it will come in two forms
  - Jesus ends with the comment that these sacrifices are ultimately rewarded with eternal life
  - Remember, this was the implied concern that Peter had
    - So Jesus makes sure to provide Peter with the reassurance he sought
    - When you makes these kind of sacrifices, you are demonstrated a heart that is true to the Lord
      - You are not earning salvation
      - But you are giving evidence of it
- But interesting, Jesus also mentions that these sacrifices will result in compensation even now in this age
  - What would such compensation look like?
    - How are we supplied with a house or a wife or family?
- Well I believe there are distinct parallels in the life of a believer to the list Jesus offers
  - Consider that our fellowship with other believers will bring us into the family of God
  - And in this family, we will have the deep abiding love that the world longs for and seeks through marriage and normal family experiences
    - The love of other believers
    - The emotional and even material support of each other within the family of God
    - The instruction of old women with young women
    - The iron sharpening iron of elders and younger men
    - And most importantly, the spiritual support or prayer and encouragement of one believer for another

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- And each case, the depth and meaning of these relationships will far exceed what is possible among unbelievers, even within natural families and marriages
  - But of course, these kind of compensating benefits are only fully realized for those who would give priority to gathering together in fellowship
    - It's like the phrase we get out what we put in
    - If we treat our church relationships as merely a social club with people we visit once or twice a week, then we should expect to miss out on much of what Jesus is promising here

- But having reassured Peter, Jesus then turns to his third warning about his coming death

Luke 18:31 ¶ Then He took the twelve aside and said to them, "Behold, we are going up to Jerusalem, and all things which are written through the prophets about the Son of Man will be accomplished.
Luke 18:32 "For He will be handed over to the Gentiles, and will be mocked and mistreated and spit upon,
Luke 18:33 and after they have scourged Him, they will kill Him; and the third day He will rise again."
Luke 18:34 But the disciples understood none of these things, and *the meaning of* this statement was hidden from them, and they did not comprehend the things that were said.

- As I mentioned earlier, this is not the first time Jesus has spoken of his coming death
  - In fact, in all three of the synoptic gospels, Jesus predicts his death three separate times
    - In Luke, we see Jesus mention the necessity of his death first in chapter 9, when he departs for Jerusalem
    - Later in Chapter 9 Jesus warns the disciples again
    - And then here in 18 we see the most detailed prediction of the event

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- What's so interesting in all three cases, and particularly here, is that the disciples can't understand the reference
  - What makes this fact so interesting here is that the prediction is so specific and plain spoken
  - How can these guys not follow what Jesus is saying?
    - Well, the text tells us
    - It says that it was hidden from them
    - In fact, in the second warning we also saw Luke comment that the meaning of the warning was concealed
- So what's going on here? Why give warnings but then conceal their meaning?

- Well, we covered this in detail when it first came up Chapter 9, so I won't repeat it all now, but I will remind you of the basic issue
  - The point in giving the disciples this information is not so that they may understand the future
    - Self-evidently, if the information was given but the meaning was hidden, then the reason it was given cannot be so that they might understand the future
    - So what other reason would God give men information like this without the understanding?
      - The same reason God gave men his word in the scriptures yet did not give men the ability to understand all of it immediately
  - Many places in scripture were only to be understood many generations after they were given to men
    - Many of the prophecies of Jesus weren't understandable until after His crucifixion
    - Many of the prophecies of Israel could only be understood after Jesus was rejected and the temple was destroyed

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- Many of the prophecies of the end times could only be understood completely once Israel was made a nation again in 1948

- In other words, God will often give men His word without immediate understanding because He desires to reveal it in a future day

  - And then when it is revealed, it's truth is made even more powerful when we recognize that it was given beforehand

  - God's ability to reveal the future and yet do so in such a way that we don't understand it until he's ready to reveal it to us magnifies his sovereignty and trustworthiness

  - Consider what Jesus does at the very end of Luke's gospel

Luke 24:44 ¶ Now He said to them, "These are My words which I spoke to you while I was still with you, that all things which are written about Me in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms must be fulfilled."
Luke 24:45 Then He opened their minds to understand the Scriptures,
Luke 24:46 and He said to them, "Thus it is written, that the Christ would suffer and rise again from the dead the third day,
Luke 24:47 and that repentance for forgiveness of sins would be proclaimed in His name to all the nations, beginning from Jerusalem.
Luke 24:48 "You are witnesses of these things.

- In other words, when the time was right, Jesus was able to refer back to the things He had spoken earlier to these men and demonstrate to them that all is going according to plan

  - And what's more, the fact that God could predict it in advance only served to reinforce the trustworthiness of Jesus' words to them

- Finally, Luke ends this chapter on faith with a story of a blind man

Luke 18:35 ¶ As Jesus was approaching Jericho, a blind man was sitting by the road begging.
Luke 18:36 Now hearing a crowd going by, he *began* to inquire what this was.
Luke 18:37 They told him that Jesus of Nazareth was passing by.
Luke 18:38 And he called out, saying, "Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!"
Luke 18:39 Those who led the way were sternly telling him to be quiet; but he kept crying out all the more, "Son of David, have mercy on me!"

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Luke 18:40 And Jesus stopped and commanded that he be brought to Him; and when he came near, He questioned him,
Luke 18:41 "What do you want Me to do for you?" And he said, "Lord, *I want* to regain my sight!"
Luke 18:42 And Jesus said to him, "Receive your sight; your faith has made you well."
Luke 18:43 Immediately he regained his sight and *began* following Him, glorifying God; and when all the people saw it, they gave praise to God.

- Luke records this incident to provide a capstone to this chapter on faith
    - The story itself is very simple and straightforward though there are couple of issues to mention
        - Luke tells of a blind man met on the way into Jericho
        - But in Mark's and Matt's accounts, the blind man is met on the way out of Jericho
        - And in Matt's account there are two men
    - Well the issue of one man verse two is not unusual
        - It's not uncommon for one gospel writer to focus on one character in a situation while ignoring others that were included by a different gospel writer
            - Matt choose to record both men while Mark and Luke chose to focus on only one
            - With Mark even going so far as to name one of the men as Bartimaeus
    - The second issue of arriving or leaving Jericho is answered more than likely by the fact that in Jesus' day there were actually two Jerechos
        - There was the old city, the original ruins of Jericho mentioned in Joshua
        - Then there was the modern town of Jericho where the population actually lives
        - They were very near one another and the road to Jerusalem connected the two
            - So you walked out of one to enter another

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- So if the blind men were sitting on the road between the cities, then one writer could say enter Jericho while the other said leaving Jericho and both would be correct

- But to the content of the account itself, as I said, it's very straightforward
    - As Luke tells it, a man is blind and sitting on the road
        - He hears the crowd passing by and hears that the crowd is following Jesus
        - Having heard that Jesus is nearby, the man cries out for Jesus to notice him and have mercy
        - For some reason the crowd tries to silence him, especially those who are leading the crowd
            - It's likely that the leaders in this case were the Pharisees who were always trailing Jesus anywhere he went
            - And they would have been in the place of honor within the crowd, at the front
            - And they didn't appreciate it anytime someone called out to Jesus as the Messiah
            - In fact, their objection to his calls is probably our best proof that the blind man's calls were a proclamation that Jesus was the Messiah
        - Despite the leader's objections – or may be because of them- Jesus takes note of the man, calls him to himself, and asks him to state his desire
        - The man says I want my sight
        - And Jesus heals him physically and spiritually, saying your faith has made you well
        - Finally, the man immediately follows Jesus, giving God glory and causing the people to give praise to God

- A simple story,
    - So simple, in fact, we are tempted to skip over it perhaps
        - Or see it as just another example of Jesus healing the needy

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- But consider the story a little more closely
  - Place it in the context of a chapter organized around the nature and manner of saving faith
  - And then consider the story as a perfect picture of how God does the impossible – saves men

- First, consider we have a blind man – a man who cannot see
  - This man represents every sinner, a man who is spiritually blind to the truth and without hope
  - And then his attention is drawn to something new, and hears of Jesus, the Christ
    - And as Paul teaches us in his letter to the Romans, faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ

John 5:25 "Truly, truly, I say to you, an hour is coming and now is, when the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God, and those who hear will live.

  - And hearing that Jesus is near, the sinner cries out for mercy
    - But even as he does, the unbelieving world will work to thwart the sinners response to the Gospel
  - Then Jesus takes note of the sinner and calls him to Himself
    - For ultimately, every saved sinner is called into a relationship with God by God Himself through the Holy Spirit
  - Then Jesus poses the question that every sinner must answer – what do you expect of Jesus
    - Rom 10:9 - if you confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved
  - The sinner asks to be healed, have his sight, to see with spiritual eyes
    - To which Jesus responds positively, for whoever asks shall receive
  - Then having his request answered, the sinner immediate becomes a follower of Jesus

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        - As all believers are called and expected to do

    - And then the eternal purpose of the sinner's salvation is made clear

        - The sinner gives glory to God for his salvation

        - And his renewed life and testimony to the world results in the crowds giving glory to God

- This is the gospel played out in a simple vignette to end Luke's 18th chapter

    - How fitting that Luke would place this event at the end of chapter that illuminates the nature and manner of salvation

    - Does this pattern sound familiar to you? As a believer, you should see yourself in this story and chapter

    - And if you don't?

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Luke 19A

- We leave Luke's chapter on faith, chapter 18, and we move into chapter19
    - Before this chapter is over, Jesus will have arrived Jerusalem, riding in like a conquering king, arrived in the temple and thrown out the money collectors
    - So we're entering the climactic chapters within Luke's gospel account
    - But before we get there, Luke has another encounter with a needy sinner to relate to us
    - An intriguing story only recorded here in Luke of a man named Zaccheus

Luke 19:1 ¶ He entered Jericho and was passing through.
Luke 19:2 And there was a man called by the name of Zaccheus; he was a chief tax collector and he was rich.
Luke 19:3 Zaccheus was trying to see who Jesus was, and was unable because of the crowd, for he was small in stature.
Luke 19:4 So he ran on ahead and climbed up into a sycamore tree in order to see Him, for He was about to pass through that way.

- At the end of chapter 18, we were told that Jesus met the blind begger as He was approaching Jericho
    - And now Luke records a scene that occurs in the city
        - Remember, Jesus is moving ever closer to Jerusalem and with each step the crowds will grow and so will the excitement surrounding Him
        - There is a real hope that Jesus might be successful in defeating the Roman occupation through some kind a rebellion similar to the Macabbees revolt
    - And then Luke turns his attention to a tax collector called Zaccheus
        - A publican, a Jew who had become a traitor in the eyes of his brethren
        - Easily the most despised member of Jewish society

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- And more than that, he was the chief tax collector
- Which would explain his great wealth

- This man made immense wealth by taking advantage of the people, taxing them almost at will and with impunity
  - If you are one to get a little angry whenever you realize how much of your pay goes to taxes of various kinds, imagine your anger at a man who took your money on a whim and gave it to your oppressors
  - This man was no doubt despised by everyone
- And to make matters even worse, he was probably disliked even by other tax collectors, because he was the boss
  - He demanded payment from them too
  - This guy very well may have had absolutely no friends
- And to top it all off, his name would have been another source of ridicule
  - It's an abbreviated form of the name Zachariah, which means righteous one
  - Certainly, the irony would not have been lost on his neighbors

- Like the blind man in the earlier story, Zaccheus hears that Jesus is approaching the city
  - And apparently he's heard something about Jesus
    - At least enough to pique his curiosity
  - And Zaccheus is so short, it seems, that he has no hope to catch a glimpse of Jesus as He passes by
    - Imagine for a moment how big the crowds have become, that it's impossible to even see Jesus walking by
      - It's not hard to understand the crowd being too dense in a place here or there

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- But this crowd is so dense for miles in either direction that Zaccheus can't solve the problem by going left or right
    - His only choice is to go up

- So Zaccheus climbs a sycamore tree to catch a glimpse

- The scene here is so compelling as you begin to imagine it in your mind
    - Here's a man who's a pariah in his community, alone and isolated
        - And he's been trying to break through the crowd to see Jesus
        - But you know that crowd wasn't about to let him through
    - So he does the only thing he can think to do
        - He climbs a tree
        - As simple as this seems, this is something extraordinary
            - As a Jewish man, Zaccheus would have been expected to adhere to strict rules of decorum in public
            - Add the fact he was a prominent public official, hated though he was, and you would expect him to observe certain rules of behavior
            - And those rules most certainly didn't include climbing trees
        - Climbing the tree exposed him to even more ridicule in the moment
            - He was lowering himself, losing his dignity to climb a tree like a child
            - His legs and perhaps even backside in full view of those who looked upward – something no Jewish man would ever think to do
    - It's a remarkable scene, even more so if we understand the culture
        - And this moment when Zaccheus is sitting up in a tree by himself and away from the crowds was a fitting picture of his life overall
            - Separated and alone

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- Disgraced and humiliated

- And yet it also revealed his heart – filled with childlike excitement to see Jesus – like Jesus said, come to me like a child

- Even at this early point, this story seems remarkably similar to the theme of the previous chapter, where Luke described the nature of saving faith

  - It shares parallels with the blind begger's experience

    - A man without hope but attracted to Jesus

    - But in this case, Zaccheus does nothing overtly to call for Jesus

      - He is simply content to get a look at Him

Luke 19:5 When Jesus came to the place, He looked up and said to him, "Zaccheus, hurry and come down, for today I must stay at your house."
Luke 19:6 And he hurried and came down and received Him gladly.
Luke 19:7 When they saw it, they all *began* to grumble, saying, "He has gone to be the guest of a man who is a sinner."
Luke 19:8 Zaccheus stopped and said to the Lord, "Behold, Lord, half of my possessions I will give to the poor, and if I have defrauded anyone of anything, I will give back four times as much."
Luke 19:9 And Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house, because he, too, is a son of Abraham.
Luke 19:10 "For the Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost."

- As Jesus approached, Jesus must have looked up over the crowd and seen Zaccheus in the tree

  - So Jesus calls out to Zaccheus to come down quickly and hurry because Jesus will be staying at his house

    - What a astonishing thing to say

      - First, Jesus knew the man's name without ever having met him

      - A clear sign of His divinity to know the impossible

      - Can you imagine the expression on Zaccheus' face when he heard Jesus call him out in that way

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- Can you imagine the reaction of the crowd, as they are all stunned to find that Jesus knows this man
- And then on top of it all, Jesus is planning to stay with the man tonight

- Why did Jesus say this to the man?
  - One commentator has said that verse 5 is a perfect representation of God's sovereignty in salvation
  - While verse 6 is a perfect representation of man's responsibility to respond to God
    - I would agree
    - But I would add that Jesus' statement to the man emphasizes that the outcome of this situation was never in doubt
      - Jesus calls the man by name
      - He tells him to hurry
      - He says He must stay at Zaccheus house that night
      - Jesus doesn't request it, but rather He states it as a matter of fact

- The famous 18th century preach George Whitefield said it this way:

With what different emotions of heart may we suppose Zaccheus received this invitation? Think you not that he was surprised to hear Jesus Christ call him by name, and not only so, but invite himself to his house? Surely, thinks Zaccheus, I dream: it cannot be; how should he know me? I never saw him before: besides, I shall undergo much contempt, if I receive him under my rood. Thus, I say, we may suppose Zaccheus thought within himself. But what saith the scripture? "I will make a willing people in the day of my power." With this outward call, there went an efficacious power from God, which sweetly over-ruled his natural will: and therefore, verse 6, "He made haste, and came down, and received him joyfully;" not only into his house, but also into his heart.

Thus it is the great God brings home his children. He calls them by name, by his word or providence; he speaks to them also by his spirit. Hereby they are enabled to open their hearts, and are made willing to receive the King of glory. For Zaccheus's sake, let us not entirely condemn people that come under the word, out of no better principle than

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curiosity. Who knows but God may call them? It is good to be where the Lord is passing by.

- And as Whitefield says, Zaccheus received Jesus gladly
    - And as you might expect, it is Jesus who makes out poorly in the eyes of the crowd
        - They grumble, were told, because Jesus shows favor upon this man who was likely chief among sinners in that community
            - Isn't this such a common reaction among people?
            - When we have someone we despise, someone who is a shameless sinner, someone who does everything and anything to make us angry or to wound us
            - A despicable person, the kind of person who deserves our scorn
        - When that person gets their just desserts, we smile with a sense of satisfaction, don't we – they brought it upon themselves
    - But what happens if that person seems to win out in some way
        - They win the lottery
        - Or they marry the nicest girl in the class
        - They found a hugely successful company
        - Then we feel wronged and cheated – as if life isn't fair
    - What a circumstance when a truly evil person has tried, convicted and received their just sentence
        - The person is sitting in jail for some horrible crime, sentenced to life in prison or perhaps on death row even
        - But then the Governor pardons the person, let's them go free
            - We feel violated, angry
- Now imagine, the crowd faced with Jesus, the rock star, showering kindness on their worst enemy

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- And the man has done nothing to deserve it
- He was simply sitting in the tree waiting for Jesus to pass by
  - And he received grace
  - And it made the crowd angry
- And before we might be tempted to join the crowd in declaring this to be unfair, we need remember we were that condemned criminal set free
  - We were the one who deserved punishment, rightly condemned before God
    - Yet we received mercy
    - Just as Zaccheus did

- Then look at this man's reaction to Jesus' mercy
  - Immediately, he addresses him as Lord
    - While this term can be nothing more than a term of respect, I think the context of all that happens here makes clear that he means it in its deepest sense
    - Zaccheus has come to believe Jesus was the Messiah
  - And it says that Zaccheus stops Jesus
    - I get the impression that Zaccheus took note of the crowd's reaction
    - And he feels the need to respond publicly
      - But while he might have been prone to responding in anger or malice before this encounter with Jesus
      - This time he reacts in a way completely contrary to his old nature
  - He says I give half of what I own to the poor
    - This is a substantial commitment – consider it yourself
  - And if I have defrauded anyone, I will repay back 4 times what I owe

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- Under the law, a man who stole property was required to return it and give back double (Exod 22)
    - But if he was unable to restore the original property (like a goat), then he had to pay back fourfold
    - Zaccheus offer to repay fourfold indicates the degree of his repentance, going beyond what was required here

- Why did he stop Jesus to make these statements in public?
    - I believe Zaccheus desires to make this public confession for at least two reasons
        - First, I believe Zaccheus' heart is heavy with his sin and the wrong he has commitment and he seeks a public confession
            - And a true encounter with the Lord will always prompt genuine, heartfelt repentance of sin
            - This man has been touched by grace and repentance is the natural result
        - Secondly, Zaccheus wants to make his changed heart a matter of public record
            - He desires to show witness to the change that's taken place because of his encounter with Christ
            - Remember the story of the blind begger?
                - A changed heart will bring evidence
                - In this case, the evidence is the man's changed attitude toward his wealth and his treatment of others
    - George Whitefield says it this way:

I do affirm that we are saved by grace, and that we are justified by faith alone: but I do also affirm, that faith must be evidenced by good works, where there is an opportunity of performing them.

- And then Jesus confirms this result

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- As Luke captures his statement, he says that salvation has come to this man's house
- And he is too a child of Abraham
  - This last statement is a bit puzzling when you consider that the man is already a decedent of Abraham
    - As a Jew, he could trace his ancestry all the way back to the patriarch
    - So why does Jesus declare him to only now be a son of Abraham
- The answer is found in Paul's letter to the Romans

Rom. 2:28 For he is not a Jew who is one outwardly, nor is circumcision that which is outward in the flesh.
Rom. 2:29 But he is a Jew who is one inwardly; and circumcision is that which is of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the letter; and his praise is not from men, but from God.

Rom. 9:6 ¶ But *it is* not as though the word of God has failed. For they are not all Israel who are *descended* from Israel;
Rom. 9:7 nor are they all children because they are Abraham's descendants, but: "THROUGH ISAAC YOUR DESCENDANTS WILL BE NAMED."
Rom. 9:8 That is, it is not the children of the flesh who are children of God, but the children of the promise are regarded as descendants.

- Paul's letter reveals the truth that God does not consider those who are physically born of Abraham to be the descendents of Israel and worthy of His promises
  - Rather only those who are spiritually descended from Abraham by faith
  - The promises of Israel were made to a people who would be brought into the family of God by faith
    - First the believing Jew who inherits the promises given to Abraham
    - And secondly the Gentiles who by faith are grafted into this family
  - So when Jesus says Zaccheus is now a son of Abraham, He means it in the spiritual sense, which is the only sense that matters

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- Zaccheus can now expect to share in the promises made to Abraham and Abraham's heirs by faith

- And then Luke ends the story in verse 10 with a statement that many consider to be the key verse in Luke's gospel

  - John's gospel has 3:16

John 3:16 ¶ "For God so loved the world, that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish, but have eternal life.

  - This verse is Luke's touchstone verse

    - Because it concisely sums up point of Luke's account

      - In His first coming to earth, Jesus had but one mission

      - To seek the lost and save them

    - And Zaccheus' reaction expresses that mission perfectly

    - It's almost as if Zaccheus' conversion is such a perfect picture of that mission, that Luke feels that part of Jesus' ministry is best ended with this example

    -

      - And so from this point onward, Luke's Gospel moves away from Jesus ministry to seek and save and moves toward a rapid conclusion of His ministry in Jerusalem

- And so it's especially fitting that Luke introduces this next stage of his narrative with a parable describing what to expect

Luke 19:11 ¶ While they were listening to these things, Jesus went on to tell a parable, because He was near Jerusalem, and they supposed that the kingdom of God was going to appear immediately.
Luke 19:12 So He said, "A nobleman went to a distant country to receive a kingdom for himself, and *then* return.
Luke 19:13 "And he called ten of his slaves, and gave them ten minas and said to them, 'Do business *with this* until I come *back*.'
Luke 19:14 "But his citizens hated him and sent a delegation after him, saying, 'We do not want this man to reign over us.'

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- As we always do with parables, we need to carefully observe the pieces of the puzzle and identify the characters
    - This one is a little easier because Luke himself explains the purpose behind the parable
        - Jesus is telling this parable to set straight is purpose for traveling to Jerusalem
            - The crowd thinks he is traveling to become crowned king
            - But Jesus has other plans of course
            - And this parable explains those plans
    - And the audience is the disciples, both then and today
- First, there is a nobleman
    - He went to a distant kingdom to receive a kingdom and then return
        - Clearly the nobleman is Jesus
            - And His going away is His death and ascension, when Jesus temporarily leaves Earth to receive His kingdom
            - Even before we go farther, it's interesting to note that Jesus says He will receive His kingdom when He goes away
            - This is what the Bible teaches though

1Pet. 3:22 who is at the right hand of God, having gone into heaven, after angels and authorities and powers had been subjected to Him.

    - And while he is away, he expects His subjects to serve His interests
        - And He grants to each some measure of provision for that purpose – about 3 months' wages
        - Just the fact that He is talking about leaving is meant to reinforce that the kingdom will be delayed – not going to come right now
    - But in the meantime, a revolt takes place

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- Interestingly, the revolt is among the citizens of the kingdom, and not the slaves
  - The slaves seems to be obedient and content to do the nobleman's bidding
  - But the citizens are demanding that this nobleman would not rule over them

- Of course, the slaves are the believers in the faith who have received Jesus as the Messiah, both Jew and Gentile
  - While the citizens are the Jews in the nation who should have recognized and received their Messiah
    - For they were the ones who had been promised that a king would come to reign over them
    - But they rebelled at Christ's rule
      - Interestingly, they communicate their rebellion through a delegation
      - They have representatives who speak on their behalf – Pharisees and other leaders

Luke 19:15 "When he returned, after receiving the kingdom, he ordered that these slaves, to whom he had given the money, be called to him so that he might know what business they had done.
Luke 19:16 "The first appeared, saying, 'Master, your mina has made ten minas more.'
Luke 19:17 "And he said to him, 'Well done, good slave, because you have been faithful in a very little thing, you are to be in authority over ten cities.'
Luke 19:18 "The second came, saying, 'Your mina, master, has made five minas.'
Luke 19:19 "And he said to him also, 'And you are to be over five cities.'
Luke 19:20 "Another came, saying, 'Master, here is your mina, which I kept put away in a handkerchief;
Luke 19:21 for I was afraid of you, because you are an exacting man; you take up what you did not lay down and reap what you did not sow.'
Luke 19:22 "He *said to him, 'By your own words I will judge you, you worthless slave. Did you know that I am an exacting man, taking up what I did not lay down and reaping what I did not sow?
Luke 19:23 'Then why did you not put my money in the bank, and having come, I would have collected it with interest?'
Luke 19:24 "Then he said to the bystanders, 'Take the mina away from him and give it to the one who has the ten minas.'

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Luke 19:25 "And they said to him, 'Master, he has ten minas *already*.'
Luke 19:26 "I tell you that to everyone who has, more shall be given, but from the one who does not have, even what he does have shall be taken away.
Luke 19:27 "But these enemies of mine, who did not want me to reign over them, bring them here and slay them in my presence."

- For as long as these verse are, the picture being drawn in this parable is fairly easy to understand
    - As we keep straight our characters, we know it is Jesus returning having received His kingdom
        - This is the moment of Christ's return to earth – His second coming
    - And we have a description of the Judgment Seat of Christ
        - This is the judgment moment for the believers – slaves in the parable
            - What do I mean by judgment?
            - A judgment of the works of believers for the purpose of receiving reward
            - It's a real moment, and one we will each experience
            - Paul describes it in 1 Cor 3 and 2 Cor 5
        - And the parable reflects how judgment will be carried out in that moment
            - Similar to Matt's parable about the talents
            - Each slave (believer) as a life to invest with various talents and gifts and a certain amount of time and opportunity
            - Depending on what we have been given and what we do with it will determine our reward
                - Not all rewards are equal
                - And reward always comes in terms of greater responsibility to serve
                - In a sense we are working now to audition for a bigger part in the next production

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- Most interesting is the one slave at the end who does nothing buy hide his mina
    - The slaves uses as his excuse for inaction his fear of the master
        - He says you are someone who demands much
            - To gather where you do not sow is an expression that means that he had expectations of return even where others might have expected nothing
            - His standards and demands are so high that he looks for grain even in places where he hasn't sown seed
        - But this insight didn't stimulate the slave to greater efforts, but rather to hiding his mina
            - You can see this attitude in so many Christians today
            - They recognize that their Savior has high standards and is demanding, but rather than be stirred to action
            - They seem content to remain invisible in this world and rest on their justification
            - It's as if Christ's high standards give them excuse not to contribute anything meaningful to His kingdom mission
- What Jesus says in response is that He will judge these slaves by the very standard they mentioned
    - And by that high standard, He says they are found unworthy of even what they have
        - Meaning, the little responsibility they were given in this age will be taken away in the next so that they have no opportunity to serve
        - We're not sure what that looks like, of course, but we know we don't want any part of it
        - This is not our salvation, but it's no less important
- Finally, the concluding statement in verse 27
    - To those who reject his rule over them there is no option but eternal death

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        - This is described in Rev 19 when Jesus returns with the saints to set up the kingdom promised in scripture

- As Luke moves into the final part of his Gospel, he has set up the reader for what to expect
    - Jesus is the king and he will rule in his kingdom
    - But it's wont be set up at this point
        - It will be left to others to build by the power of the Holy Spirit
        - And those who are called into this mission are to be held accountable for their work
        - And those who reject the King will suffer his wrath

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Luke 19B

- We come back into Luke today for what will be the beginning of the end of Jesus' earthly ministry
    - Looking back on Luke's Gospel from this point, we can see several periods or stages unfold within Jesus' ministry
        - Early in His ministry, Jesus focused on calling disciples and selecting the apostles
        - Then He used these disciples to declare the arrival of the kingdom and need for the Jewish nation to repent and receive Him
        - Then at a point in chapter 13 we saw the Jesus declare the opportunity for Israel to receive Him in their day to be lost, leaving only judgment
        - This was followed by a period in Jesus ministry where he emphasized training the disciples for their work in His absence
            - Even as Jesus continued to perform signs and present teaching that proved His identity and gave opportunity for men to believe in Him
    - Now we enter the final period of His ministry
        - Christ's entry in Jerusalem, his Passion, resurrection and appearances

Luke 19:28 ¶ After He had said these things, He was going on ahead, going up to Jerusalem.
Luke 19:29 ¶ When He approached Bethphage and Bethany, near the mount that is called Olivet, He sent two of the disciples,
Luke 19:30 saying, "Go into the village ahead of *you*; there, as you enter, you will find a colt tied on which no one yet has ever sat; untie it and bring it *here*.
Luke 19:31 "If anyone asks you, 'Why are you untying it?' you shall say, 'The Lord has need of it.'"
Luke 19:32 So those who were sent went away and found it just as He had told them.
Luke 19:33 As they were untying the colt, its owners said to them, "Why are you untying the colt?"
Luke 19:34 They said, "The Lord has need of it."
Luke 19:35 They brought it to Jesus, and they threw their coats on the colt and put Jesus *on it*.

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Luke 19:36 As He was going, they were spreading their coats on the road. Jesus continues His ascent into Jerusalem

- This is only the second event up to this point in Jesus ministry to be found in all four gospels (feeding of the 5,000)
    - It's interesting to note in passing that from the Jewish perspective, Jerusalem was the high point on the earth
        - To Jerusalem = up
        - Away = down
    - Jesus has left Jericho, passes through the area between Bethphage and Bethany
        - Bethany is about 2 km to the East of Jerusalem – maybe a 40 minute walk
        - And Bethphage lay between Bethany and Jerusalem
            - Today there is only Bethany, possibly because the town grew to encompass both towns
            - In all likelihood, it was in Bethphage that the disciples found the colt mentioned in these verses (Matt 21:1 seems to refer to this town specifically)
                - Bethany means house of affliction
                    - This was the base of operations for Jesus during his time in Jerusalem before His death
                    - He would retreat there in the evenings
                - Bethphage means house of unripe figs
            - And it would be from this town which lay within sight of the Temple walls, that Jesus rode into Jerusalem on the week prior to His crucifixion
- As we look as these verses, we want to examine the events described here both from both an immediate perspective and a prophetic perspective
    - Jesus' last days were filled with one prophetic fulfillment after another

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        - All working together to make clear that Jesus was the Messiah

    - And as Jesus begins His entry into the city, He is care to observe all that was written about this time

        - We're seeing a man utterly obedient to His father, obedient to the point of death, Phil 2:8

- So in the immediate context, we see Jesus instruct His disciples to go into the village opposite them

    - Again, this was most likely Bethphage, a small one-street town

        - Being a small town, it would have been easy to find the colt Jesus had in mind

    - Matt's account tells us that there was actually a colt and her mother

        - The disciples were to take both, so that Jesus rides the colt while the mother walks along side

        - Mark and Luke simplifiy the story to include only the reference to the colt

- Though the disciples might have been a little perplexed by Jesus' instructions, it wasn't altogether unusual

    - Just as we have rent a car services today, it was common to have rent a mule services for travelers

        - Mules and donkeys were the typical transportation in that day

            - Common near a large city like Jerusalem

        - Horses were extremely rare in common day life

            - Almost exclusively used for war

            - In fact, mules and donkeys were associated with peace

        - Kings and princes would commonly ride mules and donkeys in peace time for that reason

            - Solomon rode a mule to his inauguration (1King 1)

            - It was not associated with poverty nor degradation, but rather was the appropriate way for a king to enter Zion

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- Jesus tells the disciples that the colt they find will never have been sat upon
  - This is like getting a rental car with zero miles on it
    - Only in this case, the significance of a an unridden colt was much greater than merely guaranteeing that it had that new-mule smell
  - In Jesus day, when an animal was use by a royal person, it was typically not used again for common purposes
    - So by selecting an animal that had not yet been used for a common purpose, Jesus ensured it was suitable for use by royalty

- On the other hand, it might have surprised the disciples to hear Jesus say just take it and say that the Lord has need of it
  - What if the owner didn't like that reason?
    - But I find it notable that they obeyed perfectly despite the odd direction
      - Luke goes out of his way to describe how closely these men obeyed Jesus' instructions
      - Everything was just as Jesus said it would be
      - And when they took the colt without offering payment, Jesus had prepared them with the right words
        - The Lord had need of the colt
      - And when they spoke as Jesus instructed, the owners gave permission
        - We know this from Mark 11:6 - once the owners heard the disciples' response, the owners agreed to let the colt go
        - And in every detail here Jesus once again demonstrates His omniscience and sovereign control over all events in the world

- There's an easy lesson for us all in these verses

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- First, these verse demonstrate once again that God has perfect knowledge of all that will happen to us
    - In fact, He has perfect knowledge because He has complete control
    - So when he directs us into action, we should never hesitate to obey Him
        - Even when we question the sensibility of His instructions as the disciples might have done here
        - We need to remember that He has already taken into account all that we may encounter,
        - And He's made accommodation for those circumstances
            - As He did here with the disciples
            - He told them what to look for and where to find it
                - He told them what to say
    - His only expectation is that we obey His commands
        - We can trust that His ways are not our ways
        - It shouldn't surprise us when His directions fly in the face of what we would choose to do were it up to us
        - How could it be considered an act of faith if we were to comply with God's instructions only when they agree with our own sensibilities or expectations
            - That isn't faith
            - What if the disciples had decided that Jesus' instructions made no sense and so had not followed orders?
- So since we know it is God's intention to give us opportunities to prove our faith through acts of obedience
    - And faith is shown when we obey in ways that run counter to our own understanding

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- Then God must be necessity direct us in ways that go against our own instincts

- Therefore, we can't simply trust our instincts

- We should expect that there will be times when His instructions to us will not seem sensible in some respect

- But our trust in Him is tested in those circumstances

- You only need to remember examples from the Bible to see this pattern repeated

- Noah and the Ark

- Joshua and the walls of Jericho

- Gideon's 300 men against the Midianites

- Esther and King of Persia

- And on and on

- What is God asking you to do as a test of your faith and trust in Him?

- And perhaps we're using the counterintuitive nature of the request as our excuse for not obeying

- We can't just ask someone for their colt? Who is just going to give us their colt?

- We can't just invite that stranger to church?

- We can't just sign up for that mission trip, we don't have a way to pay for it

- So, the disciples obey and bring the colt

- And then in an act of homage, the disciples take their outer garments and place them on the colt to make a saddle for Jesus

- And the other disciples in the crowd desiring to show respect in a similar way spread their own coats on the ground in front of the approaching colt

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        - Matt and Mark tell us that some people were cutting branches and laying them on the road in front of Jesus – also an honor for an arriving king

    - It's clear enough that the disciples saw Jesus' entry into Jerusalem as the entry of a king into His kingdom, even if the rest of the nation and world were not prepared to accept it in that day

        - And this leads us to the prophetic perspective reflected in these verses

- Based on the day of Jesus' death, we know that this is the 10th day of Abib, the first month of the Jewish religious calendar

    - This was the month that Israel left Egypt and God began the Exodus

        - Corresponds roughly to April

    - And on the 10th day of Abib, God commanded the nation of Israel to take for itself a Lamb

        - And they were to bring this Lamb into their home and make it a part of the family essentially

            - This began a four day period when the family was to inspect the lamb carefully looking for spot or blemish

            - During Jesus' four days in the city and temple, He was inspected by four groups

                - Pharisees, Sadducees, Scribes, and Herodians

                - None found fault with him

        - If the lamb was found without a blemish, it would be sacrificed on the fourteenth day to be eaten on the Passover meal

        - The fourteenth day began on Wednesday evening, at sundown, the family was to share in the Passover meal and remember the death of the first born of Israel and that death passed over Israel that day

            - This is the moment of the Last Supper, as Jesus instructs His disciples to eat of His body

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- We'll study the connections between the Last Supper and the Passover in greater detail in Luke 22

- Then the following morning at 9:00 am, the priesthood would conduct a special sacrifice of a single lamb for the nation

- As we will study later, this is the moment of Christ's death on behalf of the nation

- So as Jesus enters into Jerusalem, He is visibly displays Himself to be the Lamb of God as John the Baptist described Him

- The second way in which His entry fulfills prophecy is in the way he entered

- Riding on the colt was a fulfillment of the OT prophecy of how the Messiah would arrive

Zech. 9:9 Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion!
Shout *in triumph*, O daughter of Jerusalem!
Behold, your king is coming to you;
He is just and endowed with salvation,
Humble, and mounted on a donkey,
Even on a colt, the foal of a donkey.

- In verse 9, Zechariah announces the coming of the king

- He gives the king's attributes

- He is just

- He is endowed with salvation

- Endowed with salvation = yasha = to deliver, to save

- Therefore just and coming to save

- Mounted in a humble way on the colt of a donkey

- Here we see another prophecy fulfilled by Jesus

- Interestingly, if we go on to read the next verse in Zech, it says this

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Zech. 9:10 I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim
And the horse from Jerusalem;
And the bow of war will be cut off.
And He will speak peace to the nations;
And His dominion will be from sea to sea,
And from the River to the ends of the earth.

- This verse is also talking about the Messiah's arrival
    - But notice the detail here
        - War is put to an end
        - Notice the reference to chariots and horses being cut off from Jerusalem
            - Further evidence of how the horse was closely associated with war
        - The bow of war will be cut off
        - The Messiah will speak peace to the nations
        - And He will establish His dominion from sea to sea
    - But these things didn't happen when Christ road into Jerusalem
        - Zech 9:9-10 is a good example of the Law of Double Reference
            - These two verse both refer to the Messiah, but they speak of different points in time
            - Verse 9 is Christ's first coming and verse 10 is His second coming
            - Until we had the full revelation of Christ's ministry, we couldn't have known on the basis of Zech 9 alone that these were two separate times
            - Only in retrospect can we understand them entirely
        - So now we look back on Jesus' fulfillment of verse 9 and we look forward to His fulfillment of verse 10
- Jesus enters into Jerusalem as God promised the Messiah would

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Luke 19:37 As soon as He was approaching, near the descent of the Mount of Olives, the whole crowd of the disciples began to praise God joyfully with a loud voice for all the miracles which they had seen,
Luke 19:38 shouting:
"BLESSED IS THE KING WHO COMES IN THE NAME OF THE LORD;
Peace in heaven and glory in the highest!"
Luke 19:39 Some of the Pharisees in the crowd said to Him, "Teacher, rebuke Your disciples."
Luke 19:40 But Jesus answered, "I tell you, if these become silent, the stones will cry out!"

- Luke describes Jesus' approach to Jerusalem as he arrives from the east coming down the Mt of Olives and into Jerusalem through the Beautiful Gate on the east wall of the city
    - This gate has since been walled up by the Muslims who occupied the city in the fourth century
    - Furthermore, they placed a cemetery immediately outside the wall in front of the gate
        - And the reason they did these things was because of Biblical prophecy
            - Zech 14 describes an eastward approach by the Messiah
            - As does Isaiah in chapter 41:2
        - So they assume they the wall and cemetery will prevent the Messiah's arrival
            - First, the wall blocks His entrance
            - And a Jewish Messiah would never walk through a cemetery and be defiled
    - The whole thing is quite comical
        - First, they missed the first coming, so they're too late to stop that arrival
        - And Christ's second arrival will be on a white horse when he will slay all His enemies by the power of His word

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- So they're efforts are not only pointless, but they completely misunderstand who the Messiah is and how He derives His power
  - Who would have bothered to spend the time and effort to build a wall and establish a cemetery if you knew you were in a fight with God Himself?
  - But here you see a simple example of what drives ungodly men and the devil himself
    - An arrogance and pride that believes they can be equal to God
    - And that they might have the power to overthrow Him
- It's a good example of the self-deception of the evil heart

- Now as Jesus enters, the crowd of disciples begins to declare that the king of Israel, the Messiah, has arrived
  - And they speak from scripture to declare the truth of who Jesus is

Psa. 118:19 ¶ Open to me the gates of righteousness;
I shall enter through them, I shall give thanks to the LORD.
Psa. 118:20 This is the gate of the LORD;
The righteous will enter through it.
Psa. 118:21 I shall give thanks to You, for You have answered me,
And You have become my salvation.
Psa. 118:22 ¶ The stone which the builders rejected
Has become the chief corner *stone*.
Psa. 118:23 This is the LORD'S doing;
It is marvelous in our eyes.
Psa. 118:24 This is the day which the LORD has made;
Let us rejoice and be glad in it.
Psa. 118:25 O LORD, do save, we beseech You;
O LORD, we beseech You, do send prosperity!
Psa. 118:26 Blessed is the one who comes in the name of the LORD;
We have blessed you from the house of the LORD.

- Psalm 118 is a Messianic psalm, and in these verse we have the prophetic picture of how the nation would receive their Messiah in His day
  - Look at how these verse describe that moment

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        - The righteous entering through the gate of the Lord
        - You have become my salvation
        - You are the stone the builders rejected
            - The chief corner stone
        - This is the Lord's doing, marvelous in our eyes
            - This is the day the Lord has made
        - And blessed is the name of the Lord
    - Have we heard that verse before?
        - Chapter 13
            - Turn there now

Luke 13:33 "Nevertheless I must journey on today and tomorrow and the next *day*; for it cannot be that a prophet would perish outside of Jerusalem.
Luke 13:34 "O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, *the city* that kills the prophets and stones those sent to her! How often I wanted to gather your children together, just as a hen *gathers* her brood under her wings, and you would not *have it*!
Luke 13:35 "Behold, your house is left to you *desolate*; and I say to you, you will not see Me until *the time* comes when you say, 'BLESSED IS HE WHO COMES IN THE NAME OF THE LORD!'"

- When Jesus withdrew His offer to the nation for the kingdom He brought, Jesus declared the basis for how He might return to the nation
    - He would not return until the nation received Him with the words from Psalm 118
    - Now when Jesus spoke this requirement in Chapter 13, He was speaking with the leaders of the nation, who represented the nation as a whole
    - And so His requirement was that the nation as a whole would receive Him in this way

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        - As we studied back then, this will not happen until the end of tribulation when the nation is brought to their knees by an outpouring of the Holy Spirit (Zech 14)

    - Consequently, the moment described here in Luke 19 does not fulfill the requirement Jesus gave back in Chapter 13

        - This is merely Jesus disciples giving Him the required praise

- In fact, look at the leaders reaction to hearing the disciples making this statement to Jesus

    - In verse 39, the Pharisees ask Jesus to rebuke His disciples

        - What they want Him to do is stop the crowd from declaring Him to be the Messiah in the way they are doing

            - In that statement alone, you see how the leaders were set against Jesus

            - They gave absolutely no credit to the possibility that Jesus was the Messiah

                - They only saw Him as a fraud

        - So when Jesus' disciples declare Him to be the Messiah and praise Him in words reserved for the Messiah, they object

        - Yet they don't do it for no reason, we're told

            - They do it because of all the miracles they've seen

            - Nevertheless the leaders will not accept it

                - And this is why the nation will be judged over their rejection of the Messiah

                - And it awaits for a future day for the nation to receive their king, when once again these words will be spoken

                - But this time by the entire nation

- Because it can be no other way

    - Look at Jesus' response to the Pharisees

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- If these disciples had somehow remained silent in that moment
  - God's word would have no less power
  - God's word has declared that in His day, the Messiah would be received gladly and that He would receive praise
  - So God's word will not be broken
    - It cannot be opposed, it cannot be voided
- So Jesus tells these leaders that there is no possibility that this praise would not be heard
  - That even when human obedience fails, God will make a way for Himself
    - Remember Jesus' words to the Pharisees who were so proud to be Abraham's children

Matt. 3:9 and do not suppose that you can say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham for our father'; for I say to you that from these stones God is able to **raise** up children to Abraham.

- Jesus reminded them that God was fully capable of raising up new children for Himself from stones
  - Reminding us that the first man came from dust anyway
- Likewise here, God's word is the most powerful force in God's creation, and it will have it's intended effect
  - And even if these people hadn't spoken it, it would be spoken somehow
  - And men are privileged to be God's instrument for declaring His glory
  - But we are not the power, He is

Luke 19:41 ¶ When He approached *Jerusalem*, He saw the city and wept over it,
Luke 19:42 saying, "If you had known in this day, even you, the things which make for peace! But now they have been hidden from your eyes.
Luke 19:43 "For the days will come upon you when your enemies will throw up a barricade against you, and surround you and hem you in on every side,

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Luke 19:44 and they will level you to the ground and your children within you, and they will not leave in you one stone upon another, because you did not recognize the time of your visitation."

- We will come back to these verses next week as we transition into chapter 20, but for today we can see the general meaning and intent of what Jesus is saying here
    - Jesus approaches the city and begins to cry
        - Can you imagine watching this scene if you had been one of the crowd
        - Jesus pronounces here the judgment that the city and the nation would experience in response to their rejection of Him in chapter 13
            - In fact, Jesus mentions that the truth of who He was has been hidden from them now
            - But now they have been hidden, because they weren't received earlier
        - And Jesus even describes the events that will take place some 40 years later
            - Roman soldiers under Titus lay siege to Jerusalem and eventually overrun it, leveling it and murdering most of its inhabitants
            - We will take a closer look at these events when Jesus speaks of them again in chapter 21

- There is and always has been a consequence for rejecting God's offer for rescue

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Luke 20A

- As we ended last week at the end of Chapter 19, we had a few verse in that chapter left to tackle
    - And I left them for today, because as it turns out, they are an appropriate lead in to the early verses of Chapter 20
    - Jesus had just made his triumphant entry into the city on the back of a donkey
        - The crowds declaring Him to be the Messiah
        - And from this entry Jesus would spend most of His last week on earth at the Temple teaching the crowds
        - And in the evenings He would retreat to Bethany to sleep, only to return the next day
    - And had it not been Jesus' purpose to be put to death, it's conceivable this pattern could have repeated itself almost indefinitely
        - Because it was the adoring crowd that formed Jesus' protection from the Pharisees and the scribes who were conspiring to kill Him
            - Historians believe that the population of the city swelled to between 2-3 million people living in and around Jerusalem
            - This would also explain why Rome was especially nervous every year around Passover
    - Remember, these religious leaders had no weapons, no army or police force
        - The only way these leaders could take Jesus captive would be if they could gain the support of either the Roman army or the crowds themselves
            - So far Rome had shown little interest in taking Jesus captive
            - And the crowds weren't going to support any action again Jesus

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- So the leaders were stuck

- In fact, the main reason that Jesus is taken captive at night in Gethsemane is because this was the best time to avoid the crowds

  - They might have rioted had the leaders made a move against Jesus in the Temple

- So now at the end of Chapter 19, we see Jesus entering the Temple for the first time since His triumphant entry

Luke 19:45 ¶ Jesus entered the temple and began to drive out those who were selling,
Luke 19:46 saying to them, "It is written, 'AND MY HOUSE SHALL BE A HOUSE OF PRAYER,' but you have made it a ROBBERS' DEN."

- As short as these verses are in Luke's account, this is one of the best known scenes from Jesus' final week in Jerusalem

  - Jesus walks into the Temple grounds, and here's what he saw

    - The temple structure in Jesus day had actually been expanded well beyond the original design provided in scripture

    - The original design called for three principle areas within the temple

      - An outer court, commonly called the court of women

      - The Holy Place, where the priests sacrificed

      - The Holy of Holies – the mercy seat, the ark and God's very presence

    - By Jesus' day, Herod had enlarged Zurabbable's temple to include a huge, majestic courtyard completely surrounding the Temple proper

      - This outer area was called the court of the Gentiles, because it was not technically part of the Temple

        - Only Jews could enter the Temple proper

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- So the outer courtyard, not being part of the Temple structure, was open to all people, so long as they observed proper decorum

- It was in this outer court that Jesus began to throw out the money changers
    - On the week of Passover, the courtyard would have resembled a giant flea market
        - First you had the merchants selling the animals necessary for sacrifice on the Passover
            - Families might travel a great distance and not bring an animal for the required sacrifice
                - But even if they did bring one, it would almost always be found to be imperfect
                - Some spot or blemish would be found
            - But fortunately, there was a solution
                - The Priests were selling spotless lambs
                - The family would be instructed to take their imperfect animal to the priests who would accept it along with a fee as a trade in on a spotless lamb
            - So you had oxen, sheep and doves being sold literally in the hundreds of thousands to visitors who came to worship at the Temple
        - But the only money the Priests accepted within the Temple was the coin of Judea – Jewish shekel
            - So before a traveler could purchase an animal, they must change their money
                - Jewish priests would not handle Roman coinage with the image of a man on it because they considered it idolatry
                - But the common money of the culture was Roman, so it must be changed

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- Fortunately, the priests had a money changing table nearby, so you could change your money at ridiculous rates

- So the priests made money on the exchange of money, and then they made more money selling spotless certified lambs

- The real joke was that when the next family came into the temple with their imperfect lamb, and were sold the lamb that the previous family had just traded in

- So the priests were making money hand over fist

- It reminds me of another religious holiday that has turned from a celebration of God's mercy and grace into nothing more than a gigantic merchandising effort

- So as Jesus enters the court of Gentiles and witnesses this scene, He is stirred to respond

- He declares that the Temple has become a den of thieves rather than a House of Prayer and God Himself declared it should be

- This reference to thieves is directed against the priests themselves

- It was the priests who have turned the Temple into a bazaar, especially at Passover

- He drives out the money changers, but also all the priests who were engaged in this activity

Matt. 21:12 ¶ And Jesus entered the temple and drove out all those who were buying and selling in the temple, and overturned the tables of the money changers and the seats of those who were selling doves.

- You can better appreciate why Jesus was so incensed

- Here are the men who were to be consecrated, set apart to be the men to intercede on behalf of God's people before the altar

- These were the men assigned the responsibility to care for the needs of Israel, and to serve them in the name of YHWH

- And here they were stealing from these people

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- Taking advantages of people who were especially trusting of them as men of God

- Now if you know your Gospels, you may know this is not the first time Jesus has done this kind of thing

  - In John's Gospel we are told that on an earlier Passover, Jesus entered the Temple and drive

John 2:13 ¶ The Passover of the Jews was near, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.
John 2:14 And He found in the temple those who were selling oxen and sheep and doves, and the money changers seated *at their tables*.
John 2:15 And He made a scourge of cords, and drove *them* all out of the temple, with the sheep and the oxen; and He poured out the coins of the money changers and overturned their tables;
John 2:16 and to those who were selling the doves He said, "Take these things away; stop making My Father's house a place of business."
John 2:17 His disciples remembered that it was written, "ZEAL FOR YOUR HOUSE WILL CONSUME ME."

- Though the circumstances sound very similar to the later example, it's merely because the time of year was the same and the behavior of the priests hadn't changed

- I love John's description because we see how Jesus did it

  - I wonder did he calming begin to make his whip without saying a word

  - Eventually, when it was ready, he attacked the money changers and sellers

  - It must have been quite a scene

- Consider this…if Jesus was willing to drive priests out of the courtyard of the gentiles in His day with a whip for stealing from the people

  - What do you suppose He thinks of men today who use their positions of authority within the church to profit at the expense of the people they serve?

    - I think the answer is obvious enough

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- We need to always be ready to question the motives and intentions of any man of God who makes a point to mix ministry with commerce

- Just like these, priests, anytime a man's role in ministering to God's people becomes his mechanism for enriching himself at the expense of the people's trust, his behavior is to be condemned

Luke 19:47 ¶ And He was teaching daily in the temple; but the chief priests and the scribes and the leading men among the people were trying to destroy Him,
Luke 19:48 and they could not find anything that they might do, for all the people were hanging on to every word He said.
Luke 20:1 ¶ On one of the days while He was teaching the people in the temple and preaching the gospel, the chief priests and the scribes with the elders confronted *Him*,
Luke 20:2 and they spoke, saying to Him, "Tell us by what authority You are doing these things, or who is the one who gave You this authority?"
Luke 20:3 Jesus answered and said to them, "I will also ask you a question, and you tell Me:
Luke 20:4 "Was the baptism of John from heaven or from men?"
Luke 20:5 They reasoned among themselves, saying, "If we say, 'From heaven,' He will say, 'Why did you not believe him?'
Luke 20:6 "But if we say, 'From men,' all the people will stone us to death, for they are convinced that John was a prophet."
Luke 20:7 So they answered that they did not know where *it came* from.
Luke 20:8 And Jesus said to them, "Nor will I tell you by what authority I do these things."

- As I mentioned in my introduction, the leaders of Israel were desperate to kill Jesus
    - Just in that fact alone you can see the evil in these men's hearts
    - They were driven by murder in their hearts against God's anointed one
        - You need not have any clearer proof that these men were of their father, the devil, a murderer from the beginning
    - But it was the crowd that protected Jesus
        - Though I'm not sure they even realized they were his protection
        - They may not have been aware of how much the Pharisees wanted to destroy Jesus

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- But in any case, they were God's means of preserving His Son from harm until the appointed moment

- The scene Luke describes next is especially dramatic
    - This event occurred on the Wednesday before Jesus' death
        - This is the day before his death, the same day on which He will later celebrate the Last Supper
        - Luke says Jesus is teaching in the Temple as usual
            - But more than that, we're told He is preaching the Gospel
            - This phrase can only mean one thing
            - Jesus is proclaiming the meaning of the Messiah, and He would have been declaring Himself to be the one
        - Imagine to be in the audience and to be preached the Gospel from the Author of our Salvation Himself!
            - And to hear this kind of message in the Temple a few days before Passover
            - Could anyone within earshot fail to grasp the significance of this teaching?

- Well, yes, the leaders of Israel still couldn't grasp the truth, as was God's plan
    - And Luke describes this entourage approach Jesus on Wednesday
    - Luke gives us the list of people: chief priests (there was more than one at that time), the scribes, and elders
        - There was only one group within Jewish society that consisted of all three of these groups
            - It was the Sanhedrin – the ruling body of the nation
            - This group ruled the Jewish people under the authority of the Roman authorities
        - The fact that they arrived in this way in the Temple means that they were conducting an official inquiry into what authority Jesus had to be teaching

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- Under Pharasitical rule, no one could teach unless they could substantiate where they obtained their learning
    - Their authority to be a teacher of the scriptures came as a consequence of who taught them
    - Remember how Paul established his authority before the Jewish crowd in Jerusalem

Acts 22:3 ¶ "I am a Jew, born in Tarsus of Cilicia, but brought up in this city, educated under Gamaliel, strictly according to the law of our fathers, being zealous for God just as you all are today.

    - So a man's authority in the eyes of the Jews came as a function of who imparted the man his knowledge

- So the leaders ask Jesus who gave Him his authority
    - Of course the answer is that Jesus' authority came directly from the Father
        - He didn't need the authority granted by men
        - Rather Jesus is Truth
        - All authority to teach in truth comes from Jesus, who is the Word
    - But Jesus won't humor these men and their evil hearts
        - Because their purpose in asking the question is not to discover truth
            - It wasn't as though had Jesus given them the answer that would have said, "Oh, that's fine. Thank you."

- So Jesus answers their question with a question
    - Now this practice isn't as evasive as it may sound
        - It was a common tradition among rabbis to answer a question with a question

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- Dr. Fruchtenbaum tells of a Jewish story when a Gentile asks a Jewish rabbi why do you always answer questions with another question?
- And the rabbi responded, "Why not?"

- Jesus' question in response is was the baptism of John from God or men
  - By baptism, Jesus means his ministry
  - So in other words, Jesus is asking the leaders to answer the same question about John's ministry
    - Basically, Jesus' is daring them to come down firmly on one side or another on who John was
  - Now remember by this time John had been murdered by this time
    - And in the eyes of many Jewish faithful, he had been venerated as a martyr
    - So even among the non-religious or unbelieving Jews, John probably was still seen as a hero for opposing Rome and dying under Roman occupation
  - So Jesus' question was a loaded question
    - Which we can see by looking at the Pharisee's thoughts recorded by Luke
    - They knew that if they attributed John's ministry to heaven, then they would lose all credibility among the crowd
      - Because they had rejected John's ministry
      - And John himself had been a vociferous critic of the Pharisees – calling them vipers
      - So they couldn't say they agreed with John's ministry
    - On the other hand, they couldn't say he was a fraud
      - Because the crowd had decided he was a hero and a true prophet

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- So they risked losing all credibility with the crowd if they went against John

- So they were stuck

- Now Jesus asked this question for a greater reason than simply embarrassing the leaders

  - Had the Pharisees said John was a fraud, they would have discredited themselves in front of the crowd, yes

  - But if they had said that Jon's ministry was from heaven, then Jesus would have simply told the Pharisees that He received His authority from John

    - After all, it was John who had baptized Jesus

    - And it was at that time Jesus had received His anointing by the Holy Spirit

  - But because the Pharisees had refused to answer, Jesus could safely refuse to answer them

    - After all, how could the Pharisees indict Jesus for His silence when they themselves were taking the same tactic

  - The result was that Jesus silenced the Sanhedrin in front of all the people

Luke 20:9 ¶ And He began to tell the people this parable: "A man planted a vineyard and rented it out to vine-growers, and went on a journey for a long time.
Luke 20:10 "At the *harvest* time he sent a slave to the vine-growers, so that they would give him *some* of the produce of the vineyard; but the vine-growers beat him and sent him away empty-handed.
Luke 20:11 "And he proceeded to send another slave; and they beat him also and treated him shamefully and sent him away empty-handed.
Luke 20:12 "And he proceeded to send a third; and this one also they wounded and cast out.
Luke 20:13 "The owner of the vineyard said, 'What shall I do? I will send my beloved son; perhaps they will respect him.'
Luke 20:14 "But when the vine-growers saw him, they reasoned with one another, saying, 'This is the heir; let us kill him so that the inheritance will be ours.'
Luke 20:15 "So they threw him out of the vineyard and killed him. What, then, will the owner of the vineyard do to them?

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Luke 20:16 "He will come and destroy these vine-growers and will give the vineyard to others." When they heard it, they said, "May it never be!"

- Jesus moves directly into telling this parable in response to what had just occurred with the Pharisees
    - When we try to make sense of a parable, we need to begin by looking carefully at how a parable is constructed
        - This means examining the players and the setting – any details that seem important
        - And then we look back into scripture to find parallels to help us understand those details
    - Jesus tells this parable immediately after the inquisition of the Sanhedrin had failed in its attempt to undermine Him in the eyes of the people
        - And as we will learn a few verse later, it's clear that Jesus is teaching this parable as an indictment against the Pharisees themselves
    - In the parable there are 4 main characters
        - First, there is the one who owns the vineyard
        - Second, we have the caretakers of the vineyard – the vine growers as Jesus calls them
        - Third, there are slaves – three slaves to be precise
        - Finally, there is the vineyard owners son
- The basic situation of the parable is fairly simple
    - A vineyard owner wants has gone away from his vineyard for a time
        - While he's gone he wants the vineyard to produce fruit, so he leaves it in the care of vine growers
            - Obviously, the vine growers are to attend to the field and make sure it produces fruit
            - But the ultimate purpose that the owner has in making this arrangement is to bring a return of that harvest to himself

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- It is not merely to give the vine owners something to eat
- The main purpose in making this arrangement is for the benefit of the vineyard owner

- The vine growers merely benefit by association

- The vine growers are an ungrateful and dishonest lot, as it turns out
  - They think of nothing but themselves, and act as if the vineyard was theirs to do with as they please
- Then the owner sends his slaves, one at a time
  - Each of the three slaves brings the same message
    - The owner expects to receive what he is owed from the vine growers
    - But in each case the vine growers don't want to hear it and they beat the slaves and send them away without any of the fruit
- Finally, the owner decides to send his beloved son
  - The hope here is that they would final show the owner respect because he had been gracious enough to send his own son to them
    - To send a son in this way communicated the highest degree of mercy and grace
      - Considering what these ungrateful men had done to the slaves, the owner would have been right to send armed men to arrest the vine growers
      - To send his son instead, was beyond expectations
    - But to add insult to injury, the vine owners murder the son

- As Jesus tells this parable, imagine the scene around him
  - The court of the Gentiles is filled with people, and animals and noise
    - And now the leaders

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- And everyone is likely in rapped attention to Jesus' parable
  - And as Jesus is teaching it, awareness begins to grow among everyone as to who he's talking about
    - The details in the parable are too specific
    - The situation in the moment with the Sanhedrin in attendance and the confrontations with Jesus
    - Tensions running high
  - Then as the parable ends, it becomes clear that Jesus is calling these leaders of Israel murderers
    - Yet he's done so in such a subtle way that He can avoid being accused by them in an unfair way

- Because this is what Jesus had just described
  - The vineyard owner was God the Father
    - And though He owned the vineyard, he had to leave it for a time
      - This is reflected by God separating Himself from Adam and all mankind after sin entered the garden
        - And more specifically, as we know already, the vineyard is a classic picture of the nation of Israel, God's chosen people
      - Now God has left the care of his vineyard to men, and in particular, to the leadership of His people
    - And these leaders have led Israel astray
      - This failure extends all the way back to the time of judges and grows to its height in the years leading up to the exile in Babylon
      - After Israel's return to the land in the centuries that followed, the evils of their leadership returned until the day of Jesus
  - Along the way, God sent men to Israel reminding them of their obligations to Him

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- These slaves were the prophets, who called out for the leadership of Israel to remember they were to serve God and not idols of their own hands

- They were sent to collect on the thing the leaders owed their land owner – the glory that was due God

    - But of course the prophets were rejected

        - The prophets of Israel can be divided into three distinct groups

            - First you have those sent to the Northern kingdom: Elijah, Elisha, Jonah, Amos, Hosea

            - Then you have the prophets sent to the Southern Kingdom: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Joel, Micah, Nahum, Zachariah, Daniel, Ezekiel, Malachi

            - Finally, you have the prophets who spoke in Jesus day before the crucifixion, most notably John the Baptist and the disciples of Christ

        - And of course, you have Jesus Himself as the Father's Son

            - Which means you have yet another incident here of Jesus predicting his own death

            - And once again He says that the direct cause of His death is the Jewish leadership of the nation of Israel (not the Romans)

- And with all that imagery made so clear to the crowd as well as the Sanhedrin, we hear the crowd's response

    - May it never be

    - They are not going to stand for the leadership bringing down the one they have decided must be the Messiah

    - I wonder how close this moment came to a riot in the temple grounds

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- As we'll study next week, the leadership leaves absolutely convinced that the only solution is to murder Jesus
    - And that desire is made even greater, ironically, by the fact that Jesus has called them out to be murderers
    - Next week, we will finish chapter 20 with two more inspections by the religious leaders on that same day
        - As the spotless lamb of God is inspected in the temple to see if it is worthy of the sacrifice that must take place

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Luke 20B

- We're going to jump back into the middle of a scene within the Temple grounds where Jesus was teaching the people
    - A delegation from the Sanhedrin had arrived to challenge Jesus' authority
    - Up to this point we've heard Jesus respond to their challenge by refusing to answer their question
        - Then He proceeded to tell a parable that took aim squarely at the Pharisees
            - They were the bad guys in that they were credited with the fall of Israel
            - And the failure of the nation to accept their Messiah
            - And as Jesus ended the story last week in verse 16, He said that the kingdom would be taken from these leaders and offered to others
        - To which the crowd exclaimed may it never be
- Now we pick up in verse 17 where Jesus continues His commentary against these men by quoting an OT scripture taken from the Psalms

Luke 20:17 But Jesus looked at them and said, "What then is this that is written:
'THE STONE WHICH THE BUILDERS REJECTED,
THIS BECAME THE CHIEF CORNER *stone*'?
Luke 20:18 "Everyone who falls on that stone will be broken to pieces; but on whomever it falls, it will scatter him like dust."

- At the point in the parable where Jesus declares that the treachery of the Israel's leaders would result in the loss of the kingdom, the crowd reacted
    - They had obviously been following the parable closely
    - And they understood its full meaning, especially as it applied to them
    - They saw the connection between the misbehavior of their leadership and the consequences for the nation

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- They obviously understood the meaning of the parable
- And they've seen the hostility of the leadership for Jesus
- And they are putting 2 and 2 together

- And Jesus responds to their exclamation in verse 17
  - Look at how Luke begins the verse: de – But or moreover
  - This simple connecting word in the Greek strongly suggests that Jesus' comments were intended to directly contend with the audience's previous statement
    - He was responding to their exclamation
  - He says What then is this that is written?
    - Another way to say this would be, "Are you surprised to learn this? Well, does your own scripture tell you to expect about the arrival of your Messiah?
  - Then Jesus proceeds to recite a verse to them from a well-known Messianic psalm (118)
    - This is a Psalm filled with Messianic references, and Jesus audience knew it in that way
    - So when He quotes from it, they were already prepared to accept it as a statement about the Messiah's arrival
      - And the verses from Psalms talk about a stone that was rejected as unsuitable for constructing a building
      - But this stone that the builders didn't think was good enough for what <u>they</u> were trying to build ended up being the most important stone in that building
    - Isaiah says it this way:

Is. 28:16 Therefore thus says the Lord GOD,
"Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone, a tested stone,
A costly cornerstone *for* the foundation, firmly placed.
He who believes *in it* will not be disturbed.

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- Interestingly, both Matthew and Mark show that Jesus including one additional verse from that Psalm in His statement
  - Their version reads like this:

Mark 12:10 "Have you not even read this Scripture:
'THE STONE WHICH THE BUILDERS REJECTED,
THIS BECAME THE CHIEF CORNER *stone*;
Mark 12:11 THIS CAME ABOUT FROM THE LORD,
AND IT IS MARVELOUS IN OUR EYES'?"

- Both Matthew and Mark reflect that Psalm 118 attributes this rejection to God Himself
  - The leaders purposed in the their hearts to conspire against Jesus
    - And their conspiracy ultimately resulted in Jesus' murder at the hands of the Romans
  - But the prophecies found in Psalm 118 specifically credits God with this plan
    - That God desired that His Son be rejected, though in the end He was restored and made the chief cornerstone
- And the psalmist's reaction to this plan was sheer amazement
  - He says isn't this marvelous in our eyes?
  - Isn't it amazing that God was willing to see His only Son rejected in this way and put to death so that He could save so many?

- Following the quote from the Psalm, Jesus offers an application for the crowd's benefit
  - Everyone who falls on the stone will be broken and everyone on whom it falls will be scattered like dust
    - There are two possible outcomes for those who encounter this chief cornerstone
      - On the one hand, a person can fall on the stone
        - And they will be broken
        - To fall on the stone is to be broken spiritually

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- As in having a broken and contrite spirit

- Like Psalm 34 when it says:

Psa. 34:17 *The righteous* cry, and the LORD hears
And delivers them out of all their troubles.
Psa. 34:18 The LORD is near to the brokenhearted
And saves those who are crushed in spirit.

Psa. 51:17 The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit;
A broken and a contrite heart, O God, You will not despise.

Is. 66:2 "For My hand made all these things,
Thus all these things came into being," declares the LORD.
"But to this one I will look,
To him who is humble and contrite of spirit, and who trembles at My word.

- The other possible reaction to the stone is to remain resolute and proud and unrepentant

- And that person will be crushed by the stone

- They will not survive their encounter with Christ

Job 40:12 "Look on everyone who is proud, *and* humble him,
And tread down the wicked where they stand.

Is. 2:12 ¶ For the LORD of hosts will have a day *of reckoning*
Against everyone who is proud and lofty
And against everyone who is lifted up,
That he may be abased.

- And Jesus' use of this Psalm only serves to add insult to injury for the Pharisees

Luke 20:19 ¶ The scribes and the chief priests tried to lay hands on Him that very hour, and they feared the people; for they understood that He spoke this parable against them.
Luke 20:20 So they watched Him, and sent spies who pretended to be righteous, in order that they might catch Him in some statement, so that they *could* deliver Him to the rule and the authority of the governor.

- Remember last week I mentioned that the leaders of Israel had a dilemma when it came to dealing with Jesus

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- No doubt they hated Him and viewed Him as a threat to their power and influence in the nation
  - And they wanted nothing more than to kill Him
- But as I said, they had no real power to carry out that sentence
  - The Pharisees could only take action against Jesus through the force of the Roman army or through mob violence by inciting the crowds
  - Since Rome had not yet decided that Jesus was a threat and the crowds largely adored Jesus, the Pharisees could only wait and bide their time
- So their plan was two-fold
  - First they continued to observe Jesus using spies in the hoe they could gather evidence to accuse Him
  - Secondly, with evidence in hand, they would look for an opportunity to get Jesus alone away from the protection of the crowds
    - Then He could be taken prisoner and brought before the Roman authorities
    - And so this became their plan

- Their first attempt to trick Jesus so as to make an accusation is recorded in the next series of verses

Luke 20:21 They questioned Him, saying, "Teacher, we know that You speak and teach correctly, and You are not partial to any, but teach the way of God in truth.
Luke 20:22 "Is it lawful for us to pay taxes to Caesar, or not?"

- Of all the ways the Pharisees had devised to trick Jesus, this may well be the most devious
  - Its simplicity belies its ingenious quality
    - It's almost a perfect trap…almost
    - And to fully appreciate how crafty this question was, we first need to consult the other Gospels to gain a little additional detail

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- In Matt and Mark we learn this:

Mark 12:13 ¶ Then they *sent some of the Pharisees and Herodians to Him in order to trap Him in a statement.

- The key to understanding the deviousness of this scheme is in the fact that it was devised by Pharisees and Herodians
    - These were essentially two political groups within Israel
        - Since Israel a country ruled according to a religious law, the politicians of the days were religious leaders
        - But like any political system, you had factions or parties that each represented different political points of view within the spectrum of religious thought
    - So here we see two of those parties, who happened to be polar opposites in their political points of view
        - The Pharisees represented the conservative wing of Israel
            - They were opposed to any foreign rule in Israel
            - They would never willingly give any credit or honor to Caesar, the Roman emperor
        - The Herodians took their name from the Herod family, the ruling dynasty over Israel that cooperated with Rome
            - They supported Roman rule and did not hold as strictly to the law
            - They promoted acts of honor to Caeser
    - For all their differences, these two groups could agree on one point: they both hated Jesus
        - The Pharisees hated Him because Jesus had rejected their rules and authority within the nation of Israel
        - The Herodians saw Jesus' claims to be King and Messiah as a threat to Herod's rule
    - So they come together and form this near perfect trap

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- The trap worked liked this:
    - First, they pretend to be on His side
        - In verse 21 they say flattering things to put Jesus at ease
            - You know how this works, right?
            - By throwing flattering words at someone, you hope they will lower their guard a little
            - And then you might get a more revealing answer
            - They hoped Jesus would be more willing to speak His mind freely in answering their questions, and thereby fall into their trap
    - Of course, their plan was already doomed to fail because they overlooked two facts about the Messiah
        - First, He could know their thoughts, regardless of their words
        - Secondly, Jesus never spoke anything that wasn't 100% true, so no matter how they prefaced their question, they would get the same answer
            - No amount of buttering up was going to result in any more revealing answer
            - But they weren't going to like the truth
- The next step in the plan was to ask Jesus to rule on a point of contention in that day
    - Should they pay the tribute tax to Caesar
        - Luke's version simply says taxes, but the word in Greek literally means tribute
        - This was the tribute tax, which is kind of offering to Caesar
            - Remember, the emperor of Rome declared Himself to be God
            - And like any God, He expected tributes or offerings
            - So Rome expected people to pay tribute to the Caesar

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- So for anyone to say that Jews should pay this tax was equivalent to recognizing Roman rule over Israel and Caesar's claim to be god
    - So many in Israel, including the Pharisees would never willingly accept such a result
    - And they would have strongly objected to anyone advocating for it
- If Jesus had said pay the tribute tax, it would also mean that Jesus was acknowledging Caesar to be the rightful king and god over Israel
    - This would have resulted in the Jesus losing all credibility with the crowds around him, leaving Him vulnerable to the Pharisees
    - So If Jesus says pay the tax, the Pharisees can make a case against Him and they would gain the support of the crowds to stone Jesus
- On the other hand, if Jesus were to say not to pay the tribute tax, he would be advising insurrection against Roman rule
    - This would have pleased the crowd and the Pharisees, but it would have angered the Herodians
    - They would have had an instant case against Jesus in front of the governor
        - In fact, later in Luke 23 these same men will lie during Jesus' trial claiming that Jesus was forbidding the crowds from paying tax to Caesar
    - So if Jesus says don't pay, then the religious leaders can expect the support of the Roman army to suppress Jesus' ministry

- Remember, there were only two sources of power that the Pharisees could draw upon in the hope of destroying Jesus
    - One was the people and the other was the Roman army
    - So one way or the other, this question seemed destined to get Jesus in trouble with one group or the other

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- So how does He answer

Luke 20:23 But He detected their trickery and said to them,
Luke 20:24 "Show Me a denarius. Whose likeness and inscription does it have?" They said, "Caesar's."
Luke 20:25 And He said to them, "Then render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's."
Luke 20:26 And they were unable to catch Him in a saying in the presence of the people; and being amazed at His answer, they became silent.

- Naturally, Jesus saw through the scheme
    - So he calls for someone to bring a denarius
        - Again, the other Gospel accounts prove helpful here in filling in some details that Luke left out
            - In both Matt and Mark's account we learn that when Jesus called for the denarius, someone had to go get one
            - Meaning, they didn't immediately have one available
            - Remember, they are in the temple so the only currency accepted would have been the coin of the Israel
            - But outside the Temple, the coin of the realm was the denarius
    - So after they bring the coin to Jesus, he asks his famous question
        - Who's picture is on the coin?
        - The obviously answer is Caeser's
            - The denarius was about a day's wage and it had the picture of Caesar on it
            - Since it had the face of a man on it, the Pharisees were not allowed to carry it, since it would be considered idolatry under their law
            - This is why no one had one nearby
        - But this also meant that no Jew living under the Pharisaical rule could use the coin for commerce

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- Now obviously, many Jews did, but the strict Pharisees would never think to use the coin
- To even hold it was idolatry, so if one was to come into their possession, the only thing they were allowed to do according to their law was return it to Caesar

- The irony here is remarkable
  - The Pharisees refused to pay tax to Caesar because it was seen as supporting Roman rule
  - And they refused to take part in Caesar economy, which meant they wouldn't use Caesar's money
  - So by their own rules, the only logical thing to do was return the money to Caesar, since it meant nothing to them
    - It was worthless to a Pharisee – they refused to use it to do business
      - It shouldn't even be inside Israel's borders
    - But they couldn't pay the tribute tax with Jewish coins
    - So if a denarius were to come into a Pharisee's possession, the only thing they could do with it was return it to Caesar
      - He was the rightful owner of it
  - So when Jesus says render to Caesar what is Caeser's
    - Apodidomi - render - literally means give back
    - Give it back to him and you aren't paying Him tribute, because you are giving Caesar something you consider to be worthless
      - It can't be a tribute if you give something you consider to be worthless
      - Travel to a foreign country and return with foreign coins
        - Give to the church?

- Then Jesus says we should give to God what is God's
  - So what is Jesus talking about here?

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- In their midst was a king deserving of tribute as well
  - A king sent from God
  - And like Caesar who received tribute from those who considered him to be God
  - The king in their presence was deserving of tribute appropriate for God
- What kind of tribute is appropriate for this king?
  - Render to God what is God's
  - Give back to Go what we have that is His

- This certainly includes the concept of giving of our money
  - But it has a much wider application

Rom. 12:1 ¶ Therefore I urge you, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, *which is* your spiritual service of worship.

- It's not enough to give God our money and feel as though we've done our part
  - It's like the person who is too self-absorbed to give the kids any time, so they pays someone else to take them to the park
  - It won't suffice
  - Peter says it this way:

1Pet. 2:4 ¶ And coming to Him as to a living stone which has been rejected by men, but is choice and precious in the sight of God,
1Pet. 2:5 you also, as living stones, are being built up as a spiritual house for a holy priesthood, to offer up spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ.

  - Jesus is expecting that of the crowd and of you and I today
    - If we recognize that Jesus is God as He proved Himself to be,
    - And since He saved us from the destruction we were rightly due,

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        - Then He rightly demands our complete obedience dedication to His glory

            - Give back to God was is God's

- With this answer, Luke says in verse 26 that Jesus puts them all to silence

    - I think we may be so familiar with this story and how it ends that overlook how stunned the crowd was by this answer

        - It was like Jesus just solved some unsolvable problem

        - He just proposed a cure for the common cold

        - This had been a question ever since Rome conquered Israel

        - And in one moment, Jesus had pushed the issue aside

    - The Pharisees and the Herodians had proposed an either/or kind of problem

        - And Jesus had responded with an both/and solution

        - And in the process, He had succeeded in making the Pharisees look foolish for having objected to paying the tax

            - When their own rules essentially required it

    - And of course, there was no ground for making an accusation

        - And on top of it all, Jesus had only increased His reputation among the crowd

- The artful way Jesus dismissed these two political groups for the last time, leaves two remaining major political groups to take a stab at bringing down Jesus

    - Next up to bat is the Sadducees to take their best shot at Jesus

        - Remember we are still looking at the way Jesus was inspected before the Passover sacrifice

            - As the Passover lamb for Israel, Jesus was to be inspected just as the Passover lamb to see if there were any imperfection

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- That's the process we're watching here
- And so far, two of the four major groups have fallen

- Today we are going to read the riddle that the Sadducees propose to Jesus and introduce their purpose
  - But we will wait until next week to finish it entirely

Luke 20:27 ¶ Now there came to Him some of the Sadducees (who say that there is no resurrection),
Luke 20:28 and they questioned Him, saying, "Teacher, Moses wrote for us that IF A MAN'S BROTHER DIES, having a wife, AND HE IS CHILDLESS, HIS BROTHER SHOULD MARRY THE WIFE AND RAISE UP CHILDREN TO HIS BROTHER.
Luke 20:29 "Now there were seven brothers; and the first took a wife and died childless;
Luke 20:30 and the second
Luke 20:31 and the third married her; and in the same way all seven died, leaving no children.
Luke 20:32 "Finally the woman died also.
Luke 20:33 "In the resurrection therefore, which one's wife will she be? For all seven had married her."

- As Luke describes the scene, he begins by acknowledging the Sadducees distinguishing characteristic
  - They didn't believe in resurrection
  - They felt that when the body died, all that remained was the spirit
    - They expected that the future state of man in the kingdom was a spirit only experience
  - This was not the only difference between the Sadducees and the Pharisees, but it was probably the most notable
    - Beyond even their theological differences, the Pharisees and the Sadducees were political adversaries much like Democrats and Republicans today
      - In other words, they took great delight in coming up with ways to make the other group look foolish
    - And since the Pharisees were the scrupulous, uptight rule making, rule enforcing right wing extremists of their day

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- And the Sadducees were the more liberal, rule-adverse group,
- You can see who usually got the better of the other

- I tend to think of the Odd Couple
  - Oscar and Felix
- So the Sadducees took great delight in making fun of the Pharisees and their many stupid rules and contradictions within their laws

- One way they did that was to contrive these bizarre questions which the Pharisees could never answer
  - And because they couldn't answer them, it left the Pharisees looking foolish
    - The point of the question was not so much to catch someone in making a mistake or committing a crime
    - Rather it was designed to discredit someone and make them look foolish
  - So the Sadducees come to Jesus with this same goal in mind when the pose the question in the next verses in Luke

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Luke 20C

- Last week we had just begun to look at the third group to inspect Jesus in the Temple during His final week in Jerusalem
    - Inspections were intend to detect imperfections in the Lamb
    - Jesus withstood tests brought by three of the key leadership groups within Israel already (Scribes, Pharisees & Herodians)
    - Now He is going to withstand an attack by the final group

Luke 20:27 ¶ Now there came to Him some of the Sadducees (who say that there is no resurrection),
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Luke 20:31 and the third married her; and in the same way all seven died, leaving no children.
Luke 20:32 "Finally the woman died also.
Luke 20:33 "In the resurrection therefore, which one's wife will she be? For all seven had married her."

- Begin (again) with the Sadducees distinguishing characteristic
    - They didn't believe in resurrection
        - They also didn't believe in angels nor spirits (demons)
    - They felt that when the body died, all that remained was the spirit
        - They expected that the future state of man in the kingdom was a spirit only experience
        - They were a somewhat more liberal group in terms of the political spectrum
        - Though they were still fairly strict in their view of the OT
            - Strict in the sense that they didn't agree with the Pharisee's willingness to add their own rules around the law

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- They felt the OT should adhere strictly to the original OT writing

- Interestingly, the Sadducees were the ones in charge in Jesus day
  - They had the ruling majority on the Sanhedrin council, so they were the majority party in control
  - And they protected that majority by trying to discredit their adversaries
  - They liked to show up their enemies was by devising questions so hard to answer that they could make you look foolish in the attempt
    - A rock too big to pick up

- This is the approach they are taking with Jesus here
  - They ask a question that no one up to this point had ever been able to answer
    - And they choose this particular issue because they knew Jesus had taught on resurrection before
      - Many of His parables and descriptions of the coming kingdom talked about the coming resurrection of the righteous
    - So they want to see Him defend His view of the afterlife
  - Here's how the trap worked essentially
    - The principle is that since this kind of situation is technically possible
    - This is an extreme example of the Levarite marriage responsibility under the Mosaic Law
      - In Deut 25:5 the law required that a widow who had been left childless was to be married to the oldest unmarried brother of the deceased
        - The purpose was to produce a child who would be considered the natural heir of the deceased man

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- But in this extreme example, each new brother keeps dying before the woman gets the benefit of a child
- Each marriage would have been a legitimate marriage, and it was the Levarite rule that resulted in the multiple marriages
- But even though these multiple marriages created no problem on earth be cause they were one at a time, it would create a problem for a resurrected world
- People walking around with multiple binding marriages seemed ridiculous

▪ Therefore the idea of resurrection seemed to be a ridiculous unless you could propose a solution to this problem

- So the Sadducees' point in asking the question wasn't to learn a solution to the problem

▪ They didn't believe in resurrection, so they didn't believe this would ever happen

▪ They just expected Jesus to struggle trying to answer the question and in so doing, he would be made to look foolish

- And like Simon the Pharisee who scoffed at Jesus in Chap 7

- Prostitute washing His feet…a true prophet would know who she was

- Jesus begins by specifically addressing their contrived situation

- In Matt & Mark's accounts, Jesus is recorded as beginning his response with a very critical comment about why they were so confused about resurrection

▪ He says they are mistaken is because they don't know scripture and they don't know the power of God

▪ They didn't understand what scripture taught on the issue of resurrection

▪ And they didn't realized all that God was capable of doing

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- They had limited God's power in their minds so as to produce this problem

- The problem is they had assumed that the nature of a resurrected body would be limited to simply being a carbon copy of the body we have today
    - And that the life and relationships that exist today will be repeated in the next age
    - This perspective was not consistent with what scripture tells us about that next life
    - And it assumes that God's power is unable to go beyond what He created in the first instance

- It occurs to me that Jesus' answer here is probably the correct answer for almost any issue or any person that stands in opposition to the truth
    - People who cling to false doctrine or who refuse to accept sound teaching
    - People who are attracted to unhealthy churches or who are sucked in by false gospels
    - All these people and the issues that draw them
        - All of them are the product of a lack of knowledge of scripture
        - And an ignorance of the power of God
        - Scripture is just a collection of stories, sayings and good advice
        - And God is nothing more than an air traffic controller
        - Passive observer, like a wildlife photographer
    - If these people were to truly study and understand scripture
        - If they devoted as much time and energy to immersing themselves in it, living through it and by it, burying it in their heart, treasuring it
            - Then perhaps they might be able to find the answers they were looking for when their faced with troubling questions or doubts

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- And if they would stop placing the God of the Bible into a box of our own making
    - Our minds and imaginations can't begin to plumb the depths of what God can accomplish
    - We can't do what the Sadducees had done and think that our imaginations can produce limits that God cannot cross

- In His answer Jesus addresses their two mistakes in reverse order
    - First, He deals with their lack of appreciation of the true power of God
    - In verse 34 & 35 Jesus says that while we are married in this age, the resurrected body does not enter into a marriage
        - And the reason for this stems from the nature of marriage and the nature of the resurrected body
    - First, marriage is a reuniting of flesh
        - Remember that the first woman was made from the flesh of the first man
            - So in marriage the two flesh become one again
        - But the resurrected body we will have will be uniquely created
        - All those of this age who are deemed worthy of entering the kingdom will have already been created and present at the beginning
            - No need for procreation
            - No need for a marriage in order to produce new offspring
            - So the point in marriage is something unique to this age
    - Second, marriage was for the relationship itself
        - It was not good that Adam be alone
        - He needed a helper or partner
    - But in the next age the sons of God will no longer need a marriage relationship, since we will have God present in our midst

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- We will serve Him according to Revelation 22:3

- Then in verse 36 Jesus moves to a discussion of the nature of the resurrected body itself
    - Jesus says that the resurrected sons of God will be unable to die, but be like angels
    - This is an especially pointed commented, because Jesus knew the Sadducees also didn't believe in angels
        - He's basically taking a second verbal swing at them even as He teaches them about resurrection
        - But what Jesus says tells us a lot about the nature of next body and the age itself
        - We can get an even better idea of what this will be like from Paul's first letter to Corinthians

- Paul is addressing false teaching in the Corinthian church that had repeated the error of the Sadducess
    - They had begun to believe that resurrection wasn't possible
    - Paul uses the comparison to a seed to teach on the true nature of resurrection

1Cor. 15:35 ¶ But someone will say, "How are the dead raised? And with what kind of body do they come?"
1Cor. 15:36 You fool! That which you sow does not come to life unless it dies;
1Cor. 15:37 and that which you sow, you do not sow the body which is to be, but a bare grain, perhaps of wheat or of something else.
1Cor. 15:38 But God gives it a body just as He wished, and to each of the seeds a body of its own.
1Cor. 15:39 All flesh is not the same flesh, but there is one *flesh* of men, and another flesh of beasts, and another flesh of birds, and another of fish.
1Cor. 15:40 There are also heavenly bodies and earthly bodies, but the glory of the heavenly is one, and the *glory* of the earthly is another.
1Cor. 15:41 There is one glory of the sun, and another glory of the moon, and another glory of the stars; for star differs from star in glory.
1Cor. 15:42 ¶ So also is the resurrection of the dead. It is sown a perishable *body*, it is raised an imperishable *body*;
1Cor. 15:43 it is sown in dishonor, it is raised in glory; it is sown in weakness, it is raised in power;

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1Cor. 15:44 it is sown a natural body, it is raised a spiritual body. If there is a natural body, there is also a spiritual *body*.
1Cor. 15:45 So also it is written, "The first MAN, Adam, BECAME A LIVING SOUL." The last Adam *became* a life-giving spirit.
1Cor. 15:46 However, the spiritual is not first, but the natural; then the spiritual.
1Cor. 15:47 The first man is from the earth, earthy; the second man is from heaven.
1Cor. 15:48 As is the earthy, so also are those who are earthy; and as is the heavenly, so also are those who are heavenly.
1Cor. 15:49 Just as we have borne the image of the earthy, we will also bear the image of the heavenly.

- And Paul says that if God can create a seed, bury it and have it produce a completely different living thing – a tree
  - Then he can do the same for human body
  - Just as the world and the stars are all made out of completely different materials, shapes and natures
  - So God is capable of creating a completely different kind of body for the resurrection
  - This is what Jesus meant when He told the Sadducees that their errors were the product of their lack of understand of God's power
- Then he goes on the describe the nature of that new body
  - The first was buried in its mortality
    - The second will be raised in immortality
    - Unlike the first, it's imperishable – aptharsia - immortal – will not die
    - This means no sin, because the reason death exists at all is because Adam introduced sin
  - The first was buried in dishonor – shame – referring to our sinful flesh
    - God never fixes the sin of our container, our flesh
    - He just replaces it
  - The second body will be raised in glory

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- The first was buried in weakness
    - But our new body will have power

- Finally, Paul makes a fascinating comparison
    - Our first man was Adam, made of the earth, natural, fleshy, earthy
    - The human race started over with Christ
        - He was not born of the same seed but rather of the seed of the Holy Spirit
        - His body was different in the sense that it was without sin in the flesh
    - And just as our original bodies were copies of the first man, Adam
        - Our new heavenly bodies will be copies of Jesus' body at least in the sense that they will be sinless and eligible to enter Heaven
    - But here's the irony
        - Jesus' original body was never corrected by sin
            - He didn't need to have it replaced when He was resurrected
            - When Jesus was resurrected, He had the same body that He had before His death
            - Thomas placed his hands in the wounds remember
        - So while we will have new bodies, perfect in the nature of the body Jesus has
            - Jesus will still bear the marks of his crucifixion in the new kingdom
            - He will be the only resurrected body to bear marks from His time on Earth

- Now Jesus turns to the first reason the Sadducees had been mistaken in their thinking – they didn't understand scripture
    - Jesus bypasses the topic of marriage altogether

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- Jesus moves to a general discussion of the truth of resurrection from scripture

Luke 20:37 "But that the dead are raised, even Moses showed, in the *passage about the burning* bush, where he calls the Lord THE GOD OF ABRAHAM, AND THE GOD OF ISAAC, AND THE GOD OF JACOB.
Luke 20:38 "Now He is not the God of the dead but of the living; for all live to Him."

- Jesus gets to the heart of the issue by attacking the Sadducees lack of understanding of the scriptures and especially the Torah
    - He says that even Moses wrote that resurrection was true
        - Now the Sadducees would have been a little surprised to hear that, because there is no verse written by Moses that directly references resurrection of the physical body
    - But Jesus makes clear that Moses' writings were built on an expectation of resurrection
        - First, Jesus says that when God appeared before Moses, He described Himself as the God of three men
            - Abraham Isaac and Jacob
            - God choose to describe Himself as the God of three men who had died by the time Moses heard those word
                - This tells all we need to know about how God views the issue of resurrection
                - He wouldn't describe Himself as the God of dead people unless those people were to be alive again and He were to continue being their God
                - He was describing Himself as presently the God of those men, indicating they were still before God
                - Just as "all men live before God"
- But Jesus answer here goes another step even deeper
    - Jesus isn't just saying that God is a God who describes Himself in terms of living relationships

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- God is a God who describes Himself in terms of promises fulfilled
    - And that's the deeper meaning implied here
- Anytime the three patriarch names are used in combination in this way, it always one specific thing – the Abrahamic Covenant
    - If Jesus had merely wanted to show the Sadducees that God described Himself as a God of living relationships, Jesus could have stopped at one name, right?
        - He could have said remember God said He was the God of Abraham
        - But Jesus included all three names because it immediately evoked a reference to the Abraham covenant

- The Abrahamic Covenant was the unique promise that God made to Abraham and repeated to Issac and again to Jacob
    - And in that promise, God assured them that their offspring would be a great nation of people
    - And He promised that all three of these men would inherit and inhabit the promised land

Gen. 17:8 "I will give to you and to your descendants after you, the land of your sojournings, all the land of Canaan, for an everlasting possession; and I will be their God."

Gen. 26:3 "Sojourn in this land and I will be with you and bless you, for to you and to your descendants I will give all these lands, and I will establish the oath which I swore to your father Abraham.

Gen. 28:13 And behold, the LORD stood above it and said, "I am the LORD, the God of your father Abraham and the God of Isaac; the land on which you lie, I will give it to you and to your descendants.

- But in their lifetimes, the closest any of these men actually got to owning any of the promised land was a well and a few acres of land for a family burial plot
    - So God has still a promise to keep with these men
    - They are still owed an inheritance in this land

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- God never said they would have it in their first earthly bodies
- And it's evident now that His plan was to give it to them when they could enjoy it in their resurrected bodies in some future day

- God's promises are sure regardless of the calendar
- Unlike men, time has no effect on God nor on the surety of His promises

- So the only way that God could be a covenant keeping God is is resurrection were true
- For without it, God would have to be made to be a liar
- Because these men have never yet received what was promised

- So when Jesus mentions Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, He is using shorthand to remind the Jewish leaders that God has made promises to men of the past
- And keeping those promises required resurrection

Luke 20:39 Some of the scribes answered and said, "Teacher, You have spoken well."
Luke 20:40 For they did not have courage to question Him any longer about anything.

- And so Jesus succeeds in answering the final inspection as the Passover Lamb
- The scribes themselves at this point say Teacher you have spoken well
- This is a important statement, because it means that the leaders can't bring a charge against Him for anything He has said
- This doesn't mean the scribes have become believers
- They only address Him as Teacher, not Lord
- But their statement remains proof that Jesus has not been found guilty of any offense before the people
- He was truly innocent of any possible charge…He was spotless

- Now Jesus takes the offensive

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- He wants to leave the discussion with a pointed attack on the leaders' for their failure to appreciate the true nature of the Messiah's ministry
    - Rather than a man who would be a conquering king
    - Or perhaps a man in the mold of the self-serving rule enforcing Pharisees,
    - Jesus wanted them to know that the true Messiah was someone that scripture described as God Himself

Luke 20:41 ¶ Then He said to them, "How *is it that* they say the Christ is David's son?
Luke 20:42 "For David himself says in the book of Psalms,
'THE LORD SAID TO MY LORD,
"SIT AT MY RIGHT HAND,
Luke 20:43 UNTIL I MAKE YOUR ENEMIES A FOOTSTOOL FOR YOUR FEET."'
Luke 20:44 "Therefore David calls Him 'Lord,' and how is He his son?"

- The question Jesus asks the leaders to answer comes from language found in Psalms 110
    - Now like we said about Psalms 118, Psalms 110 was widely understood then as now to be a Messianic Psalm
        - Full of references to the Messiah and His power and reign
    - And it was also widely known and accepted that this was a Psalm of David, as it is titled
- So Jesus asks, how is it the Messiah would be the son of David, a descendant of David in other words
    - This is a reference to the Messianic descriptions found by Isa 9 and Jer 33 that tell us the Messiah would be a descendant of David.
    - But knowing that the Messiah would be born in David's line, how is it that David Himself speaks of the Messiah and calls Him Lord
        - If the Messiah were merely a man, David could never talk about him in that way
            - In Jewish and eastern culture generally, a father would never dream of calling his own son or descendant by such a title

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- That would be like the President turning to one of his lowest aids and calling him sir
- It would never happen

- The only way it would happen is if this person were someone much greater than merely another rman
  - As Luke has been emphasizing all along in his gospel, Jesus would be the God Man
  - Something and someone completely different than what the leaders expected
    - Which is why they rejected Jesus out of hand despite the mountain of proof He gave them

- And now Jesus makes the application to the crowd and more specifically to the disciples

Luke 20:45 ¶ And while all the people were listening, He said to the disciples,
Luke 20:46 "Beware of the scribes, who like to walk around in long robes, and love respectful greetings in the market places, and chief seats in the synagogues and places of honor at banquets,
Luke 20:47 who devour widows' houses, and for appearance's sake offer long prayers. These will receive greater condemnation."

- These men are the problem, Jesus says
  - Beware these men, be on guard against them
  - And to know why they should beware these men, Jesus lists their chief sins
    - First, Jesus lists four characteristics of the first sin
      - They walk around in long robes
      - They love the respectful greetings
      - They love to sit in the honored places in the synagogues
      - They love the places of honor at banquets
    - All of these are symptoms of pride

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- They are taking pride in their earthly, fleshing, religious accomplishments
- They are not men serving the people nor seeking after God's righteousness
- They are men seeking the praises of the people and a righteousness they earn for themselves
- Avoid them because of their pride

- Secondly, they devour widow's houses
  - While we don't have a lot of background on this, it's not too hard to see what Jesus is talking about
  - In ancient cultures, a widow was a particularly vulnerable member of society
  - There were few social structures to support her, so she was often depended on the generosity of religious leaders to care for her
  - Jesus is indicating here that these men would so greedy they would even take money from vulnerable defenseless widows
  - So avoid these men because of their greed
- Finally, they offer long prayers for appearance sake
  - It had become common among the scribes and religious leaders generally when asked to pray publicly to memorize these long, elaborate prayers
    - They were detailed in their content
    - They included plenty of scripture references and poetic language
    - The list of prayer needs when on and on
  - And the whole event was orchestrated to impress the people, never to reach God
  - It wasn't a prayer so much as a performance

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- SO avoid these men for their hypocrisy

- And the real lesson here is to the disciples
  - Don't become like these men
  - Don't think that your coming role as ministers in Christ's church would mean they take the roll of scribe
  - They weren't to model themselves on these men
    - And in a few short hours, Jesus would teach these men what it really meant to be a leader in the church
    - As He washes their feat at the Passover meal, Jesus teaches the servant roll of a leader

- What kind of leader do we look for in ministry?
  - Do we understand that a man leading in God's church should not carry pride in that accomplishment, but humility?
    - He should not seek the praises of men, but God
  - He should reduce his calling in ministry into a financial pursuit
    - Much less be willing to take advantage of those under his charge for personal financial gain
  - He should not teach and say one thing while doing otherwise
    - Turning his ministry into nothing more than a performance

- Yet how often do we seem to elevate men like that into leadership positions within the church?
  - It seems we might be guilty at times of the same sin as the Sadducees
    - We do not know scripture and we do not understand the power of God
      - We forget the clear expectations found in scripture for who would be qualified to lead in the church
      - And we forget that God is the one doing the work through men in any case

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- Such that any man's individual qualifications for ministry are of minimal importance compared with his wiliness to yield to God's power working through him

- If we remember scripture and if we remember God's power, then we will follow godly men who have a true heart to serve God and God's people

  - While trusting that God can and will work great things through that kind of man

- And that's the kind of men Jesus needed to follow after Him.

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Luke 21A

- As we begin Chapter 21, we are embarking on a series of teaching that will take us through the heart of eschatology, the doctrine of end times
    - Luke's 21st chapter includes one of Jesus' most famous discourses, the Olivet Discourse
        - And the discourse opens up a fascinating discussion on end times events – eschatology
        - In Luke's gospel, this discourse is actually part 2 of Jesus' discourse on the days of the end
            - Part 1 came in chapter 17, which we already studied
            - And in Matthews account of the Olivet discourse in chapter 24, both part 1 and part 2 are placed together
            - Whether Jesus presented the material in one sitting as Matt records or as separate discussions as Luke records (or Jesus simply taught some parts repeatedly) is a matter of debate
    - But the more important issue for our study today is to properly understand what events Jesus is talking about
        - And how they apply to the church today and in the future
- But before we get to that discourse, we need to attend to a few opening verses
    - They transition us from the moment in the temple where Jesus has been teaching in the day before His crucifixion
    - To the private moment on the Mount of Olives when He discusses the end times with the Apostles

Luke 21:1 ¶ And He looked up and saw the rich putting their gifts into the treasury.
Luke 21:2 And He saw a poor widow putting in two small copper coins.
Luke 21:3 And He said, "Truly I say to you, this poor widow put in more than all *of them*;
Luke 21:4 for they all out of their surplus put into the offering; but she out of her poverty put in all that she had to live on."

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- At the end of chapter 20, Jesus had been teaching in the temple grounds, enduring the tests of the Sanhedrin
    - And in the end He posed a question of His own, which they couldn't answer
    - Leaving His questioners to abandon their efforts to discredit Him, and to seek another way to bring Him down
    - Meanwhile, Luke records Jesus' observations of the practice of giving in the Temple
- Within the Temple there was a public collection taken by the priests to be used for charity among the Jewish people
    - These were not sacrifices required under the law
    - Nor where they an offering to the Lord, in the sense of a tithe
    - They were merely gifts for charitable purposes, often called alms
- The rabbis of the day had declared a standard that no less than 2 prutah could be giving to the treasury
    - A prutah was a small brass or copper coin representing the smallest denomination of Jewish currency
    - It was so minimal in value that 2 together roughly equaled about 1/64th of a denarius, which was a laborer's wages for one day
        - Or about 9 minutes of work
        - At minimum wage, we're talking about 75 cents today
    - Some refer to this story as the widow and the mite, from the French word miete, which means crumb or morsel
    - The point being obvious – the woman was giving the minimum she was permitted to give
        - The rabbinical rule required she give no less
        - And presumably she had no more to offer
        - So she gave all she had – voluntarily

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- She gave all the money she had that day, she would have had no expectation of replacement funds, except that she trusted God to provide
- She was the kind of person that fund was intended to help
- She should have been requested a withdrawal instead of making a deposit

- In contrast, the rich were giving large sums
    - It's interesting that we even know what each was giving
    - And this could have been the result of a practice that was supposedly common within the Temple
        - Where priests would stand by the treasury and announce publicly what each person donated as they gave their gifts
            - So as the rich walked by the treasury, they dropped their gifts, and heard the priest call out their donation
            - How often do you think a poor person would think to make a trip to the treasury under these circumstances?
            - Which if this practice was in effect in Jesus day, it would explain to some degree why Jesus would have taken note of this woman's giving
                - It would have likely caught everyone's attention – and perhaps even scorn – to see her donate so little

- Yet Jesus commends her, though He doesn't condemn those who gave a lot
    - The comparison is this:
        - The woman's generosity was to be measured not by the amount of her giving by the degree of her sacrifice
        - And while those who gave much more money are not condemned for their giving
            - Neither should the woman
            - And in fact, her gift should be seen as an even greater gift because of the sacrifice it represented

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- The lesson for each of us here should be obvious enough
    - Our Lord takes note of our giving
        - And He measures our generosity by what we sacrifice in our willingness to serve the needs of others
        - Not by the ultimate impact our giving achieves
            - God doesn't need our money
                - He is fully capable of providing through whatever means He wishes for the needs of anyone and anything He wishes
                - He is never limited by our stinginess
                - Nor is He enabled by our generosity
        - We aren't commanded to give, to be charitable and giving because God needs our money
            - We're commanded to do so for spiritual benefit of developing a growing trust and dependence on God that generosity brings

Matthew Henry

Though we can give but a *little* in charity, yet if it be according to our ability, and be given with an upright heart, it shall be accepted of Christ, who requires *according to what a man has, and not according to what he has not;* two mites shall be put upon the treasury, and credited to our account before God (if given in a right manner) as if they had been a fortune.

It is much to the praise of charity, when we give not only *to our power,* but *beyond our power,* as the Macedonian churches, whose *deep poverty abounded to the riches of their liberality,* 2 Cor. viii. 2, When we can cheerfully provide for others, out of our own necessary provision, as the widow for Elijah, and Christ for his five thousand guests, and trust God to provide for us some other way, *this is thank-worthy.*

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Clarke

He shows that works of charity should be estimated, not by their appearance, but by the spirit which produces them, that all men are properly in a state of equality; for though there is and ought to be a difference in outward things, yet God looks upon the heart, and the poorest person has it in his power to make his mite as acceptable to the Lord, by simplicity of intention, and purity of affection, as the millions given by the affluent. It is just in God to rate the value of an action by the spirit in which it is done.

- Now why does Jesus make this observation at this moment, amidst all that was transpiring around Him and in light of what was coming soon
    - Beyond the simple lesson of charity and giving, the larger connection is probably found in the personal sacrifice that Jesus was about to make
        - For He gave all He had to give for the sake of those who were poor and destitute

Rom. 5:6 ¶ For while we were still helpless, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.
Rom. 5:7 For one will hardly die for a righteous man; though perhaps for the good man someone would dare even to die.
Rom. 5:8 But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

- And then carrying this idea forward, we know Jesus will expect the disciples to make similar sacrifices
- Ands this leads us to the Olivet Discourse, because in this discussion Jesus will talk extensively of the disciples' personal sacrifices

Luke 21:5 ¶ And while some were talking about the temple, that it was adorned with beautiful stones and votive gifts, He said,
Luke 21:6 "*As for* these things which you are looking at, the days will come in which there will not be left one stone upon another which will not be torn down."
Luke 21:7 ¶ They questioned Him, saying, "Teacher, when therefore will these things happen? And what *will be* the sign when these things are about to take place?"

- This discourse has several parts and they need to be separated out if we hope to understand them properly
    - First, let's look at the opening verses in Luke's version

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- The disciples and Jesus are leaving the Temple grounds for the day
  - And the disciples begin some sightseeing conversation
  - The best picture of this is found in Mark's gospel

Mark 13:1 ¶ As He was going out of the temple, one of His disciples *said to Him, "Teacher, behold what wonderful stones and what wonderful buildings!"

- While it's not hard to understand why the disciples were marveling at the Temple, it's also easy to understand why Jesus doesn't seem to have any patience for it
  - He's probably just hours from his passion
  - And He wants to be sure He leaves the disciples with some understanding of God's plan for their future, the future of the church and ultimately the future of the world
  - So in response to their casual observations of the temple's beauty, Jesus gives a provocative response
    - He basically says, you see this temple…well, there will come a day when not one stone will be left unturned
    - This entire structure will be torn down
    - This was an almost unbelievable statement
    - Similar to the world trade center
  - No doubt this comment got the disciples' attention
    - And they obviously appreciated the serious nature of this comment, because they wait to question Jesus privately over what He meant

Matt. 24:1 ¶ Jesus came out from the temple and was going away when His disciples came up to point out the temple buildings to Him.
Matt. 24:2 And He said to them, "Do you not see all these things? Truly I say to you, not one stone here will be left upon another, which will not be torn down."
Matt. 24:3 ¶ As He was sitting on the Mount of Olives, the disciples came to Him privately, saying, "Tell us, when will these things happen, and what *will be* the sign of Your coming, and of the end of the age?"

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- Although Matt's account contains an even longer version of this discourse, we aren't going to spend much time in Matt's version except to take not of these opening verses
    - First, we notice that this conversation took place after they had departed the Temple and arrived on the Mount of Olives opposite the Temple Mount
    - Secondly, we notice that the questions asked by the disciples are recorded a little differently by Matt than by Luke
        - In Luke, the questions are summarized simply as "When will these things take place an what will be the signs of these things?"
        - While in Matt, the questions are broken out in greater detail
            - When will these things happen
            - Signs of coming
            - Signs of end of the age
        - Luke adds that the disciples also want to know the signs before the Temple comes down
- It's relatively easy to explain the different emphasis between the two writers
    - Matt writing to a Jewish audience would have taken a particular interest in any discussion on the ages of time in God's plan
        - The Jews had long been taught about God's plan for them and for the world took the form of a present age and an age to come
        - The age to come was synonymous with the Messianic Kingdom, the time when the Messiah would arrive to save the Jewish people and rule the earth
        - This is the kingdom that we too await, when Christ returns to earth
    - Luke on the other hand wrote to a Gentile audience
        - They had little understanding of an age to come

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        - They would simply have been curious about the circumstances surrounding the destruction of the temple itself

        - Nevertheless, Luke still records Jesus answering all the questions that were asked that day

- If you turn to the handout, which I will also make available for download on the our website, you see the questions broken out by verse reference

    - Jesus actually answers four questions in all during the Olivet Discourse

        - He answers the three questions asked by the disciples

        - As well as a fourth question the disciples did not ask, yet Christ felt it was necessary to include this answer for their benefit

    - So as we study this important chapter of Luke, we are going to focus on Luke's version, but you can see the corresponding cross references in Matt as well

- The first observation is that Jesus is not talking to a crowd

    - Mark tells us that He is talking privately to Peter, James, John and Andrew

    - This is important

- Christ doesn't answer in the same order as the questions are posed

    - Begins with the question that wasn't asked

    - What are not the signs of the end

        - Since the signs themselves are not in and of themselves unique

            - The signs themselves could be confused for the actual signs that are yet to come

            - Although the real signs will be very obvious once they come, there are other more common events that could be mistaken for the signs unless Jesus educates these men on the differences

        - So He wants them to know what are NOT signs of the end so they won't jump to a conclusion about these events

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Luke 21:8 And He said, "See to it that you are not misled; for many will come in My name, saying, 'I am *He*,' and, 'The time is near.' Do not go after them.
Luke 21:9 "When you hear of wars and disturbances, do not be terrified; for these things must take place first, but the end *does* not *follow* immediately."

- False Messiahs will come
    - Don't go after them
    - Don't follow ANYONE who says they are the Messiah (because he real messiah will be obvious)
- Don't let wars or similar disturbances cause you to conclude that the end is near
    - They are not signs in and of themselves
    - Because so many of the true signs are going to bring great disturbances, don't jump to the conclusion that all calamity must mean the end is near
- So then Jesus begins to answer the third question

Luke 21:10 ¶ Then He continued by saying to them, "Nation will rise against nation and kingdom against kingdom,
Luke 21:11 and there will be great earthquakes, and in various places plagues and famines; and there will be terrors and great signs from heaven.

- Need to look at Matt briefly here to help appreciate what Jesus is talking about

Matt. 24:7 "For nation will rise against nation, and kingdom against kingdom, and in various places there will be famines and earthquakes.
Matt. 24:8 "But all these things are *merely* the beginning of birth pangs.

- The question was what are the signs of the end of the age
    - Here Jesus is describing very unique signs
        - Nation upon Nation
        - Famines increase
        - Earthquakes
    - But these are merely the beginnings of birth pangs

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- The end of the age (Jesus' return) will be marked by these events and yet they will come like birth pangs
- Only those looking for these signs and only those near the end will recognize them

Luke 21:12 ¶ "But before all these things, they will lay their hands on you and will persecute you, delivering you to the synagogues and prisons, bringing you before kings and governors for My name's sake.
Luke 21:13 "It will lead to an opportunity for your testimony.
Luke 21:14 "So make up your minds not to prepare beforehand to defend yourselves;
Luke 21:15 for I will give you utterance and wisdom which none of your opponents will be able to resist or refute.
Luke 21:16 "But you will be betrayed even by parents and brothers and relatives and friends, and they will put *some* of you to death,
Luke 21:17 and you will be hated by all because of My name.
Luke 21:18 "Yet not a hair of your head will perish.
Luke 21:19 "By your endurance you will gain your lives.

- But Before all these things
  - Moving back in time
  - To events that precede the signs themselves
  - To a personal moment for the disciples themselves
  - (Different than Matt)
  -

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Luke 21B

- We jump back into Jesus' most revealing description of the end given to the Disciples
    - The Olivet Discourse
    - We introduced this teaching last week by noting the general outline of the teaching and how Jesus approached the various questions He was asked
    - Specifically, we noticed that the Gospels record three questions
        - Luke records one question
            - When will the Temple be destroyed and what will be the signs of the coming destruction
            - Sounds like two questions, but in the way Jesus answers it, He treats it as a single question
            - The answer He gives weaves the two questions together
        - Matt records the other two questions
            - What are the signs of your coming
            - What are the signs of the end of the age
    - Interestingly, Jesus didn't answer the questions in the order they were asked
        - He chose to answer the questions in a different order
        - Jesus began the discourse last week by answering a question that none of the Disciples thought to ask
            - What will not be signs of the end
        - Then He answered Question #3, which we studied last week
- Today we pick back up by re-reading from verse 12
    - This is the answer to #1

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Luke 21:12 ¶ "But before all these things, they will lay their hands on you and will persecute you, delivering you to the synagogues and prisons, bringing you before kings and governors for My name's sake.
Luke 21:13 "It will lead to an opportunity for your testimony.
Luke 21:14 "So make up your minds not to prepare beforehand to defend yourselves;
Luke 21:15 for I will give you utterance and wisdom which none of your opponents will be able to resist or refute.
Luke 21:16 "But you will be betrayed even by parents and brothers and relatives and friends, and they will put *some* of you to death,
Luke 21:17 and you will be hated by all because of My name.
Luke 21:18 "Yet not a hair of your head will perish.
Luke 21:19 "By your endurance you will gain your lives.

- We took note that it begins with But Before all these things
    - Moving back in time
        - To events that precede the signs themselves
        - To a personal moment for the disciples themselves
    - Take note of the events Jesus said would befall the Disciples
        - They will be persecuted
        - Dragged into synagogues and prisons
        - Before kings and governors
    - Have you ever wished that God would reveal your future to you?
        - Don't we all secretly wish God would tell us what He has planned for our entire life?
            - Like Abram
            - He didn't receive a full picture of all that God had planned for his life
            - He was just told to go to a place I will tell you
            - Or Joseph
                - He wasn't given any reason to hope when he was thrown in the well or imprisoned by Potipher

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- Wouldn't it have been nice to know that God planned to make him one of the most powerful men in the world

- I wonder what the disciples would say to us about the benefits of learning your future
  - How do you think they felt to learn that this was their future
  - I guess to some extent it reassured them in the moment when these events happened to remember that it was part of God's plan
  - But how much harder was it for them to know these things would befall them
    - And yet they still went forward
  - Perhaps we can agree that most of the time it's grace to not know what God has in our future
    - Yet we can still rest in the knowledge that He is bringing us to the end He has determined best suits His plan

- Jesus does give these men a glimpse into how these events will ultimately bring Him glory
  - They will be before kings and governors
  - And they will bring the testimony of Christ to these moments
    - This was a tremendous privilege
    - How could these men ever imagine such an opportunity
    - And when these events actually did happen, wouldn't it have been encouragement to them to see events play out just as He predicted?
  - And then God Himself commands them not to try to prepare
    - Rather He instructs them to depend upon God for the words
      - This is a remarkable instruction
      - But it's interesting because it seems to disagree with advice the Disciples themselves gave others

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1Pet. 3:15 but sanctify Christ as Lord in your hearts, always *being* ready to make a defense to everyone who asks you to give an account for the hope that is in you, yet with gentleness and reverence;

- Peter's instruction would suggest that we are generally expected to be ready with a testimony when we have an opportunity to give account
  - But Jesus wanted the Disciples to be yielding in their moment of crisis
- I believe the difference between these two instructions comes down to the circumstances of the moment
  - In the case of the disciples, the situation was one of persecution
  - And their testimony was one of condemnation against these men
    - They witnessed against these men with the truth even as they put the disciples to death
  - In Peter's letter, he talks about giving an account of the hope that lies within
    - That would imply someone asking about the faith, desiring to know more, to understand what makes a Christian different
    - In those moments, we are to be prepared to witness to what we know
- So why does God desire us to yield entirely to Him in one situation but take responsibility for readiness in another
- Because He has commissioned us with one purpose while reserving the other for Himself
  - The GC of Matt 28 directs us to perform the mission of bringing the Good News to men and to be witnesses to what we have received
  - But elsewhere, God reserves judgment for Himself
    - Vengeance is mine, leave room for the wrath of God, and do not judge

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- The purpose of the Apostle's testimony was for the purpose of judging those who would seek to destroy the gospel message
- And against these men, God would speak judgment through the disciples

- The remainder of the these verse reflect further details of the persecutions Jesus knew were coming for these men because of their faith
    - And there is so much we could say tonight abut the persecutions of the early church and over the years that followed
    - But I will leave that discussion to another time
    - For now, it's sufficient to note that the early church was both the most persecuted in history
        - And the fastest growing and most resilient in history
    - By contrast, the modern church is in many ways the least tested and consequently the most fragile and spiritually immature
        - Draw your own conclusions
- Finally, verses 18 & 19 offer a moment of reflection
    - We know that Jesus is preparing the disciples for martyrdom
        - So what can He means that not a hair on their heads would perish
        - Or that they will gain their lives by their endurance
    - Well since we know Jesus was predicting their persecution and death
        - And since we know that in fact the disciples did die, virtually all of them in the midst of this persecution
        - It is self-evident that these statements means something beyond merely physical life
            - Something beyond a promise that they would avoid death
    - Similarly, could Jesus be implying that these men might be earning their salvation by their perseverance?

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- Based on the all the scripture tells us about salvation, we know this too can't be Jesus' meaning

- So where does that leave us?
  - Well, I believe the answer comes in a simple cross reference in Rev

- Rev. 2:10 'Do not fear what you are about to suffer. Behold, the devil is about to cast some of you into prison, so that you will be tested, and you will have tribulation for ten days. Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life.
  - The crown of life is a promise of glory and reward for faithfulness in the face of persecution
    - An eternal reward a believer receives in the kingdom as recognition of their sacrifice in this age
    - And similarly, as we encounter the martyred Apostles in our new life, we will see this crown of glory, and remember their faithfulness in the moment of their testing
    - May we each be found as faithful in our day

- Before we move forward in the chapter, take a moment and look at Matt 24 again
  - Matt's discourse doesn't contain the answer to question 1
  - So after covering question #3, Matt goes immediately into a discussion of question #2

Matt. 24:10 "At that time many will fall away and will betray one another and hate one another.
Matt. 24:11 "Many false prophets will arise and will mislead many.
Matt. 24:12 "Because lawlessness is increased, most people's love will grow cold.
Matt. 24:13 "But the one who endures to the end, he will be saved.
Matt. 24:14 "This gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in the whole world as a testimony to all the nations, and then the end will come.

- Though some of Jesus' statements sound similar, look at the details
  - Many fall away, betray one another, hate one another
  - Many false prophets arise

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- Lawlessness increases and love grows cold
- Gospel is preached to the entire world and then the ends comes
- All these are signs of the end of the age, when Jesus returns
  - This is the beginning of Matthew's answer of what are the signs of Jesus coming
  - So that is why there is so much misunderstanding of this discourse
    - People try to cross compare these two gospels without realizing that Luke includes something that Matt doesn't
    - Yet some of the language is similar
    - Like verse 13 – Jews saved at the end

- Back to Luke…and continuing with question #1

Luke 21:20 ¶ "But when you see Jerusalem surrounded by armies, then recognize that her desolation is near.
Luke 21:21 "Then those who are in Judea must flee to the mountains, and those who are in the midst of the city must leave, and those who are in the country must not enter the city;
Luke 21:22 because these are days of vengeance, so that all things which are written will be fulfilled.
Luke 21:23 "Woe to those who are pregnant and to those who are nursing babies in those days; for there will be great distress upon the land and wrath to this people;
Luke 21:24 and they will fall by the edge of the sword, and will be led captive into all the nations; and Jerusalem will be trampled under foot by the Gentiles until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled.

- Now Jesus explains the events surrounding the fall of the Temple
  - When they see armies surrounding Jerusalem…
    - AD 66 – Jewish revolt
    - Cestius Gallus from Caesarea sent to put it down
    - Encircled Jerusalem in a siege
      - Before he could breach the walls, he leaves to put down attacks to his supply lines in AD68

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- Defeated in a battle along the coast before he could return to Jerusalem

- In AD 68 Vespasian sent in his place

- By AD70 breaches the walls

- Kills 1.1 milllion jews

- The break in the fighting gave the believing the Jews a chance to escape

- These are the days that Jesus described in this part of Luke's Gospel

- Then Jesus adds a fascinating and critically important statement

- The city of Jerusalem will be trampled under foot by the Gentiles until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled

- This is a reference to God's judgment against the nation for the their disobedience to the Covenant of Moses

- And the time Jesus mentions here is a unique period of history when the nation of Israel is placed under God's judgment before the other nations of the earth

- It began with the destruction of Jerusalem by the Babylonians under Nebachanezzer

- And it continues until the Messianic kingdom is established at Jesus' Second Coming

- Revelation study for more detail

- Now Luke moves to the final question #2

Luke 21:25 ¶ "There will be signs in sun and moon and stars, and on the earth dismay among nations, in perplexity at the roaring of the sea and the waves,
Luke 21:26 men fainting from fear and the expectation of the things which are coming upon the world; for the powers of the heavens will be shaken.
Luke 21:27 "Then they will see THE SON OF MAN COMING IN A CLOUD with power and great glory.
Luke 21:28 "But when these things begin to take place, straighten up and lift up your heads, because your redemption is drawing near."

- There will be signs in the heavens

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- Unique signs, unprecedented
- Dismay among the nations (world wide impact)
- Men fainting and fear for come upon the whole world
- Powers of heaven shaken
- Then they will see the Son of Man coming
  - These are the events to cause men to look up for their Lord

- Clearly, these are future events
  - They are the signs for the second coming
  - Different than the signs given for question #3 (end of the age)
    - Proximity
    - The signs for the approaching end are the beginning of birth pangs
    - The signs for the second coming include the tribulation itself and unprecedented events – not confused for other things
    - And they suggest an immediate arrival of Jesus
  - So though we might not know the hour and day of His arrival, neither should a believer living in tribulation be surprised by His return

Luke 21:29 ¶ Then He told them a parable: "Behold the fig tree and all the trees;
Luke 21:30 as soon as they put forth *leaves*, you see it and know for yourselves that summer is now near.
Luke 21:31 "So you also, when you see these things happening, recognize that the kingdom of God is near.
Luke 21:32 "Truly I say to you, this generation will not pass away until all things take place.
Luke 21:33 "Heaven and earth will pass away, but My words will not pass away.

- To reinforce what He's just told them, Jesus uses a parable of a fig tree

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- Now as we've taught at an earlier point in this study, a fig tree is a classic picture of the nation of Israel
- So we can begin in interpreting this parable by noting that, just as has been the case throughout the history of scripture,
  - The key to interpreting prophecy and eschatology properly is to remain focus on God's plan for the nation of Israel
  - Israel is the timepiece God uses to reveal His timing for the world
- So when the fig tree puts forth leaves, summer is near
  - Fig trees lose leaves in winter
    - And they cease to produce fruit
    - Appear as if they are dead
  - But the tree isn't truly dead
    - It's just dormant, waiting for its season to return
    - And when the season for producing fruit is approaching, you can tell
    - Because the tree sprouts leaves
      - It begins to show signs of life again and you know that the fruit is right around the corner
- So, when the nation of Israel come back to life
  - It returns from a dormant period when it appeared as if it was dead and gone
  - And it rejoins the national stage, then you have seen the leaves of the tree
    - And just as assuredly you will see the fruit in the near future
    - And when you see these things, know that the kingdom of God is near
  - Doesn't that just send chills up your spine

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- We are the privileged ones in all of human history to live at the time of the fig tree sprouting leaves
- We are on the threshold of the return of Christ and the setting up of His kingdom

- Jesus then makes one of His most provocative statements
    - He says that this generation will not pass away until all these things take place
        - This had led to endless speculation about which generation Jesus meant
            - If He had meant the generation that heard his words in the moment – the disciples
                - Then these events have already passed
                - Makes no sense in light of all that Jesus would happen
                - Heavens in turmoil
                - The entire earth fainting with fear, etc.
        - The only other possibility would be the generation to see the events He described
            - Not just the events of Israel becoming a nation, but all the events He just associated with His second coming
            - When He says all things in verse 31, He is referring to the same things He's been talking about since he began the discussion of the second coming
            - The same "things" as verse 28
        - In other words, the generation that witnesses the beginning of the tribulation will be the same generation to see it's end
            - This is perfectly in keeping with the 7 year tribulation described by Daniel

Luke 21:34 ¶ "Be on guard, so that your hearts will not be weighted down with dissipation and drunkenness and the worries of life, and that day will not come on you suddenly like a trap;

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Luke 21:35 for it will come upon all those who dwell on the face of all the earth.
Luke 21:36 "But keep on the alert at all times, praying that you may have strength to escape all these things that are about to take place, and to stand before the Son of Man."

- Jesus' final commands regarding this time are potentially seen as a continuation as His comments on the days surrounding His second Coming
    - But as I read them and in light of all that's been said before, I think the interpretation is a little different
        - I believe the best interpretation is to see these statements as a concluding statement to all Christians, including the disciples about how to respond to this information
            - How do you respond to a prophecy like this?
            - Can't change it
            - Can't change the day of your birth
            - Can't change your circumstances in history
            - How should a Christian use this information? What does an obedient Christian do in light of what Jesus just taught?
- I believe verses 34-36 are the answer
    - In light of the seriousness of Jesus purpose and of our roll as disciples and of the coming judgment, we should be all the more serious in our purpose during these days
        - Don't be weighted down with dissipation and drunkenness
        - And the worries of this life
        - Otherwise, the end will come as a surprise
            - Death, rapture, the second coming
            - We will find ourselves expected to call to account for what we've done in this life and we won't be prepared
            - We will wish for more time to set our lives straight and get with the program

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- Serve the interests of the kingdom rather than ourselves
- Condition 3 Christian

- Pray at all times, desire the strength to escape these and to stand before the Son of Man
    - For the apostles and later disciples, it meant to pray for the strength to escape the judgment coming for the city of Jerusalem
    - For you and I today it is a prayer to escape the collateral events that announce the coming judgment
    - For the saints of the tribulation, it would be a prayer to persevere to the end of tribulation
    - Pick up at the last two verses as part of Chapter 22

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Luke 22A

- Our study of Luke is beginning to wind to a close
    - And yet it is reaching its climax in terms of power and significance
    - In the remaining three chapters of Luke's unique gospel,
        - Jesus will celebrate His final meal with the disciples, and in doing so create an indelible symbol for the Church
        - He will be betrayed by one of the twelve
        - He will experience one of the most unjust trials in all of history
        - He will see virtually every friend He ever had abandon Him at His hour of need
        - He will suffer some of the most extreme and inhumane torture imaginable
        - He will endure the most famous and most significant death in all of history
        - Finally, He will reappear in the same body having been resurrected and present Himself to all to see
    - And all of this in exactly 180 verses
- As we dive in, I need to let you know that there are a number of areas of background, context and historical fact that we must understand if we intend to grasp all the details in this account
    - So tonight and at other points along the way, I'm going to take opportunities to provide that background
- Tonight we find Jesus still on the Mount of Olives, probably as evening approaches
    - Wednesday night of the week of His crucifixion
        - At the end of Chapter 21, Luke reminded us that it had been Jesus' pattern to leave the city every night
            - He spend the evening somewhere outside the city

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- Probably in Bethany

- But tonight Jesus didn't walk all the way to Bethany

- He stayed close to the city on the Mount of Olives

- Because He's planning to return to the city tonight

- He had finished His discourse on the end times

- And then as we begin Chapter 21, Luke tells us this:

Luke 22:1 ¶ Now the Feast of Unleavened Bread, which is called the Passover, was approaching.

- As Luke introduces Chapter 21, he begins by drawing our attention to the coming festival of Passover and Unleavened Bread

- Before we go any further into this seminal chapter, we want to be sure we have a complete understanding of the festival events of this week

- Many of us have been taught in the past that Jesus dies on a Friday and was resurrected on Sunday

- There are two fundamental problems with this viewpoint

- First, there isn't enough time between Friday and Sunday to fit the teaching of scripture

- Scripture tells that Jesus was in the ground three days after He died

Mark 9:31 For He was teaching His disciples and telling them, "The Son of Man is to be delivered into the hands of men, and they will kill Him; and when He has been killed, He will rise three days later."

- Matt gives us an even clearer picture in his gospel

Matt. 12:40 for just as JONAH WAS THREE DAYS AND THREE NIGHTS IN THE BELLY OF THE SEA MONSTER, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.

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- So if Jesus must be in the grave three days and three nights, it means that He was in the grave Friday, Friday night, Saturday, Sat night, Sun, Sun night
- Then He would have risen Monday morning
  - But Luke tells us in Chapter 14 that the tomb is found empty on the first day of the week
  - Just like it is today, the first day of the week in Israel in Jesus' day was Sunday
- So if Jesus rises on Sunday morning, we need to count backward three nights and three days
  - Which leaves us with a Thursday death

- The second reason why we know Jesus died on Thursday is because of the Jewish festival calendar for the week Jesus died
  - The week of Passover was actually a combination of two festivals
    - In fact, look at how Luke introduced the chapter
    - He says the Feast of Unleavened Bread which is called the Passover was approaching
      - The word for approaching in Greek is eggizo
      - This word means near, as in drawing near, or about to happen
      - In other words, this was the night for the Passover
    - But in truth, the Jewish calendar for festivals had become slightly askew in Jesus day, as it continues today
  - In the Torah, God established two separate festivals
    - And He placed them back to back
    - First, there was the festival of Passover
      - This is a one day festival God commanded in remembrance of the night that the angel of death passed over Israel

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- It was to be observed on the 14th day of Nisan, the first month of the Jewish religious calendar
- Like all Jewish days, this day ended at sundown and a new day began
    - So the 14th of Nisan turned into the 15th of Nisan at sundown and the Passover began and the Passover meal was held

- Then there was a second festival called the Feast of Unleavened Bread
    - It was established by God as a seven day festival that began the day following the Passover, at the end of the 15th of Nisan

- This is why the two festivals were commonly referred to as a single 8 day festival
    - So even though the Feast of Unleavened Bread technically began on the day after Passover, by Jesus time, the two had become almost synonymous
    - John 19 tells that Jesus body needed to be buried before the Sabbath
        - This has led many to believe mistakenly that they were rushing to avoid the normal weekly Sabbath on Friday evening
        - But in fact they weren't rushing to avoid the weekly Sabbath
        - They were rushing to avoid the Sabbath of Unleavened Bread
    - We know this because Mark 15 tells us that Jesus was buried on the day of preparation
        - The day of preparation was a term for the day before the start of the Feast of Unleavened Bread

- So here's what the puzzle looks like
    - Luke says the Passover and Feast of Unleavened Bread was upon them

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- So as we open Chapter 21, the 14th of Nisan is drawing to a close on a late Wednesday afternoon
  - The Passover is about to begin on sundown Wed
  - Wed night after sundown Jesus celebrates the Passover Meal
  - Passover continues into Thursday
    - On that day, Jesus was killed as the Passover sacrifice
  - But He must be buried before sundown Thursday
    - Because Thursday night began the first day of the feast of unleavened bread, which was a Sabbath Day
  - That means Jesus was in the grave on Thur afternoon
    - So the first day Jesus spent in the grave began the moment He died on Thursday
      - His first day in the grave was followed by His first night
      - He then spent two more days and nights in the grave – both Sabbaths – Jesus truly at rest
    - Then He rose on Sunday morning

- With the scene having been set, we move to verse 2

Luke 22:2 The chief priests and the scribes were seeking how they might put Him to death; for they were afraid of the people.
Luke 22:3 ¶ And Satan entered into Judas who was called Iscariot, belonging to the number of the twelve.
Luke 22:4 And he went away and discussed with the chief priests and officers how he might betray Him to them.
Luke 22:5 They were glad and agreed to give him money.
Luke 22:6 So he consented, and *began* seeking a good opportunity to betray Him to them apart from the crowd.

- Luke announces that there is a conspiracy afoot to murder Jesus
  - This isn't merely a continuation of the hatred and fear that these men have displayed for many months prior

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- This is an entirely new moment
- This is a moment when the leadership of Israel jointly conspired to bring Jesus down
  - And they plotted ways to accomplish it
- Matt gives a more detail about this plotting took place

Matt. 26:3 ¶ Then the chief priests and the elders of the people were gathered together in the court of the high priest, named Caiaphas;
Matt. 26:4 and they plotted together to seize Jesus by stealth and kill Him.
Matt. 26:5 But they were saying, "Not during the festival, otherwise a riot might occur among the people."

- The high priest actually convened a gathering of the leaders of Israel
  - They talked about when and where to seize Jesus
  - They recognized that they couldn't do it while the crowds were with him
  - They probably discussed how to kill him and who would do it
    - This was a well-organized conspiracy
    - If we are to be accurate, both historically and intellectually
      - Then we must acknowledge that a group of Jewish leaders were the principle instigators responsible for the death of Jesus
      - The Romans were the instruments as were the crowds
      - But the leadership of Israel in Jesus' day conspired against Jesus and put Him to death
    - Having said that, should that be excuse for any Christian to harbor hatred or prejudice against Jews today?
      - Of course not
      - First, it was the Father who purposed to use those men to put His son to death
      - But secondly, if we are to hold present day Jews "responsible" for Jesus death

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- Then you had better hold present day Germans responsible for the deaths of Jews
- And you should also hold present day Africans responsible for the death of Christian missionaries
- And present day Caucasians responsible for the deaths of African slaves
- And present day Americans responsible for the death of frontier Indians, and on and on
- Eventually, everyone is responsible for the death of every ancestor

- In verse 3, we see the real power behind the conspiracy, Satan
  - Both John and Luke record that it was Satan behind Judas' act of betrayal
    - But this doesn't lessen Judas' own culpability
    - He was available for Satan's use in this way because Judas was not a true believer in Christ
      - He was a wolf in sheep's clothing
      - And he was there by God's design

John 6:70 Jesus answered them, "Did I Myself not choose you, the twelve, and *yet* one of you is a devil?"
John 6:71 Now He meant Judas *the son* of Simon Iscariot, for he, one of the twelve, was going to betray Him.

  - Jesus identified 12 men early in His ministry
    - But when He did, He consciously chose one who would never believe in Him nor follow after Him
    - Rather, He chose one who God reserved for the betrayal of Jesus
      - For no true follower would have ever considered betraying Jesus
  - And by this plan, God opened the door for Paul to become the 12th disciple of Jesus

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- Judas sought compensation for his willingness to betray Jesus, and the leadership agrees to price
    - This adds insult to injury, in a way, since it tells us that his motivation for the betrayal wasn't a misplaced loyalty to the leadership
    - It was merely a mercenary act
- Matt tells us that Judas was paid 30 pieces of silver
    - This is significant for a couple of reasons
    - The only way the priests could have come by so much money so easily is if they were willing to rob the Temple treasury
    - It was this same treasury that the priests used routinely to purchase the sacrifices used in Temple ceremonies
        - How fitting that Jesus, the Passover sacrifice, would be purchased with Temple funds
    - This price was a fulfillment of scripture, when Zech 11:12 foretold that Israel would reject their shepherd for thirty pieces of silver and be judged for it

- Why was it even necessary for the Jewish leaders to have a man on the inside like Judas?
    - Why not just go arrest Jesus on their own?
        - First the leaders needed to know where Jesus was at night
        - Remember, in the day the crowds were imposing and enthusiastic
            - This is why we hear over and over how the leaders were fearful of the crowds
            - They didn't dare act when Jesus had the crowds around
            - But at night, He was generally surrounded only by His disciples
            - Yet the leadership didn't as yet have anyone close enough to Jesus who was also willing to help them find Jesus

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- The second reason relates to the rules of both Jewish and Roman law
    - The Jewish leaders anticipated that they couldn't kill Jesus on their own without risking their own lives
    - They needed to use the Roman authorities to accomplish the feat for them
        - But Roman society followed a strict rule of law, and the Jews knew they would have to pass a couple of tests
            - First, before a Roman soldiers arrest someone, there must be a formal indictment
            - The Roman governor could issue the indictment, but a witness would be required
            - Finally, Judas would have been needed at the Roman trial to testify against the accused
        - So as I said, this was a very developed and complex conspiracy centered around Judas' wiliness to betray Jesus
- So having agreed to the leadership's plan, Judas now returns to Jesus and looks for an opportunity to betray Jesus

Luke 22:7 ¶ Then came the *first* day of Unleavened Bread on which the Passover *lamb* had to be sacrificed.
Luke 22:8 And Jesus sent Peter and John, saying, "Go and prepare the Passover for us, so that we may eat it."
Luke 22:9 They said to Him, "Where do You want us to prepare it?"
Luke 22:10 And He said to them, "When you have entered the city, a man will meet you carrying a pitcher of water; follow him into the house that he enters.
Luke 22:11 "And you shall say to the owner of the house, 'The Teacher says to you, "Where is the guest room in which I may eat the Passover with My disciples?"'
Luke 22:12 "And he will show you a large, furnished upper room; prepare it there."
Luke 22:13 And they left and found *everything* just as He had told them; and they prepared the Passover.

- Now we move to the first day of Unleavened Bread, which as I mentioned earlier, is actually the start of Passover – Wed night
    - Earlier that day (the day before the Passover begins), the families in Jerusalem were taking their lamb to the Temple courts

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        - This is a different lamb than the Passover Lamb that the priests sacrificed on Passover morning
            - There were two Passover lambs
            - There was the family lambs killed the day before Passover and eaten on the first night of Passover
            - Then there was the sacrificial lamb offered on the day of Passover by the Temple priests
    - The family lambs were brought to the Temple after they had cared for the lamb and inspected it the previous 4 days
        - This families would line up and kill the lamb, the blood was drained into bowls held by priests, who would place the blood on the altar
        - The animals were then skinned, gutted and a portion cut away as a burnt offering
    - The rest of the animal went home with the family to become the Passover meal that night when Passover began
    - Throughout the process, great care was taken to ensure that no one broke any of the lamb's bones
- So this is the meal that Jesus and the disciples are about the celebrate together
    - The Passover meal held on Wed night
    - But they didn't have a lamb to take to the Temple
        - And they certainly didn't have time to prepare an entire meal at this late hour
        - But just as Abraham told Isaac as they walked up the mountain to sacrifice, the Lord will provide for Himself a lamb
    - So Jesus tells two of the Apostles to go prepare the Passover meal
        - And they ask Him where to prepare it
- Jesus gives a very curious answer
    - He tells a couple of the disciples to look for a man carrying a pitcher of water and follow him

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- Talk to the man and he will show you an upper room prepared for the feast

- This was a clever sign because in Jesus day, it would have been very unusual to see a man carry a water pot
  - In that day, men never did domestic chores of this kind
  - Actually I guess things haven't really changed that much
    - But women would always have the job of carrying water
    - So it would have been an effective sign for the disciples to look for a man carrying a water pot
- But its all very cloak and dagger isn't it?
  - Why not just say go to such and such address?
  - Well, the first thing to understand is that that's exactly what this is – cloak and dagger
    - Jesus has a traitor in His midst
    - This man is looking for the first opportunity to betray Jesus
    - So Jesus is making sure that Judas can't learn where the meal will be held and arrange for Pharisees to arrest Jesus in the middle of the meal
      - The instructions give no clue where the final destination will be
      - Judas will be in the dark until Jesus final leads him to the upper room along with the rest of the apostles
- The second thing to consider, though, is how this scene played out from the perspective of the man with the water pot
  - What made him think to prepare a Passover meal for 13 people?
  - And why did he willingly give it up for the use of others under such strange circumstances
- What was going through his mind?

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- Did he have another meal prepared downstairs and this was merely a second preparation he had felt compelled to make without knowing who would sit there?
    - Perhaps, and if so, what a testimony to God's power to drive the behavior of men according to His will
- But more likely the man prepared the meal for himself and his family and then graciously gave it over to the needs of another
    - Isn't that how God works?
        - He grants His children the opportunity to serve the needs of others
        - But so often that opportunity brings with it the necessity of personal sacrifice
        - It's not enough that we are prepare to serve God and others, it's at what cost?
    - I sometimes think that God is inclined to test our limits of obedience so we ourselves can discover where in our life we have reserved something as off limits to God
        - Some possession, some activity, some person, some goal
        - For if anything stands in our way to obedience, then He doesn't have a whole heart

- You know in the feast of unleavened bread there was a requirement that no leaven be eaten during the entire week
    - On Passover, we have an atonement sacrifice
    - And then for seven days, we remember that sacrifice and the flight from Egypt by our own personal sacrifice of abstaining from leaven
    - So in understanding that Jesus was our Passover sacrifice, then we are now called to respond with a time of sacrifice,
        - Of removing the leaven in our lives, of fleeing from the sinful world, represented by Egypt
    - Paul puts it this way

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1Cor. 5:6 ¶ Your boasting is not good. Do you not know that a little leaven leavens the whole lump *of dough*?
1Cor. 5:7 Clean out the old leaven so that you may be a new lump, just as you are *in fact* unleavened. For Christ our Passover also has been sacrificed.
1Cor. 5:8 Therefore let us celebrate the feast, not with old leaven, nor with the leaven of malice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.

- The festival Paul is talking abut here is the festival of unleavened bread
    - He's teaching that spiritually speaking, we now live as if observing this festival
        - Having been saved by Christ's Passover sacrifice, we are to live our new life by purging the leaven from our lives
        - Having been justified by Christ, we now seek to sanctified unto Him
        - And what better example in a way than to think about that man who perhaps sacrificed his own Passover meal for the sake of Christ
    - What are we willing to give up?
    - Or what are we clinging to?
    - Does anything stand in your way to obeying Christ?

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Luke 22B

- Tonight we join Jesus and disciples in an intimate moment
    - The thirteen men join in a small room on the upper floor of a Jewish home in Jerusalem
    - They are preparing to celebrate the most solemn meal on the Jewish calendar
        - It's the night of the fourteenth of Nisan
        - It's Passover
    - And they gather to celebrate the Jewish deliverance from Egypt
    - And as they assemble to celebrate a centuries old tradition, they will unknowingly establish a new tradition
        - One that will be repeated by Jesus' followers for centuries to come
        - The meal we have come to know as the Last Supper
- We join them as the meal begins

Luke 22:14 ¶ When the hour had come, He reclined *at the table,* and the apostles with Him.
Luke 22:15 And He said to them, "I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer;
Luke 22:16 for I say to you, I shall never again eat it until it is fulfilled in the kingdom of God."

- As nightfall comes, it's time for the Passover meal
    - This is a meal intended for a small group, a family or two
    - It involves a very specific, prescribed pattern of activities intended to memorialize the events of the Jewish exodus from Egypt
    - The rules were a combination of instruction from God's Law in the Torah and rules prescribed by the rabbis

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        - The combined effect of both the Law and the rabbis' regulations was the creation of a remarkable picture of the Jesus' work of redemption

            - But Jesus also changed some of the practices in how He conducted the meal

        - So as we examine the events of that night in Jerusalem, we need to also look at how the Passover meal ceremony should be done and try to understand why Jesus changed what He changed

- One other thought as we look at Luke's account

    - Each of the Gospel writers records the Last Support, but the four accounts differ in important ways

        - Matt and Mark largely agree in their account

        - Luke's account is similar to the other synoptic gospels, yet he rearranges some of the events and includes more details

        - John's account, on the other hand, completely ignores the institution of the Lord's Supper

            - And instead John includes a detailed account of Jesus' discussion with the disciples after the meal

            - A description so detailed that it covers four chapters in his gospel and includes details not found in the other gospels

    - Given the significant differences, we won't spend much time tonight trying to harmonize the gospels

        - First, time wouldn't allow for it

        - Secondly, this is a study of Luke so I want to focus on that writer's viewpoint

- As Luke's account begins tonight, the apostles and Jesus recline at the table

    - Here's an opportunity to bring together several things we've already learned in our study of Luke

        - First, we learned in Luke 7 how men in that day reclined at tables to eat a meal

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- Tables were low to the ground
- Men reclined with their feet stretched out behind, resting on the left elbow

▪ The second thing we learned about a table came in Luke 14, where we last saw the disciples competing for the best places at the table

- We learned there are prescribed places at the table
- In this scene, the same was true
  - Jesus would have sat at the place of the host
  - The disciples would have been seated according to honor
  - But as we will see later in Luke's account, they are still burdened with illusions of grandeur

o By looking at the various Gospel accounts, we can place the exact position of three of the disciples as well as Jesus position

▪ First, the table was probably a long rectangle made up of two table placed end to end

- The main table, the dining table was the larger table
- A second smaller table stuck to one end of the larger table
  - The smaller table was the Paschal table, which held the Passover meal elements

▪ The rules for seating prescribed that the host take the first position at the main table

- On the end with the smaller paschal table immediately to his right

▪ We know that the guests reclined with their feet behind them

- So if they lean on the left elbow, they are perched and an angle leaning to the left
- John tells us in chapter 13 that he was leaning against Jesus' breast

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- This means that John was seated immediately to the right of Jesus in front of the paschal table
- This was the position reserved for the youngest member at the table
- This would tell us that John was the youngest disciple

- We'll wait for later in this study to identify the other two disciples

- As the meal is set to begin, Jesus says something intriguing
  - He says that He has been eagerly awaiting the opportunity to eat this Passover, because He won't eat it again until it is fulfilled in the kingdom
    - When the disciples first heard this, they must have expected that the kingdom was right around the corner
      - After all, Jesus would expect to eat this meal at least once per year
      - So at the very least, the kingdom must arrive in less than a year
    - If they did think this, we know it was misguided
      - Jesus wasn't promising a quick arrival of the kingdom
      - He was promising that the ultimate purpose of the Passover itself was about to be fulfilled in His body
        - And the next time they would feast together, would a memorial to His death and return for the kingdom
        - Rather than a memorial of the first Passover, the meal will be a celebration of what that first Passover itself anticipated, which was Christ's sacrifice
    - Just as we honor that memory now by our own celebration of the Last Supper
  - But we need to be clear

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- What we do know in the form of our Communion or Last Supper is not the same thing as the Passover meal
    - And Jesus indicates here that we will once again celebrate the Passover itself when He returns
    - Which implies we will enjoy a roasted lamb
    - And we will remember the Passover sacrifice on the cross
- But the Last Supper was a new institution build upon the Passover, but yet different
    - We'll see that more clearly in a while

Luke 22:17 And when He had taken a cup *and* given thanks, He said, "Take this and share it among yourselves;
Luke 22:18 for I say to you, I will not drink of the fruit of the vine from now on until the kingdom of God comes."

- Luke's narrative drops the reader into the middle of the Passover meal
    - And we know this based on some clues in the narrative itself
    - To understand this completely, let's familiarize ourselves on the basic format of the Passover meal
        - I won't try to teach an exhaustive overview on the traditions of the seder meal, but some of the details are important to this scene
    - The meal consisted of three courses interspersed by four cups of wine mixed with water
        - The courses were bitter herbs, unleavened bread and the Passover lamb
- Gamaliel said:

Whoever does not explain three things in the Passover has not fulfilled the duty incumbent on him. These things are: the Passover Lamb, the unleavened bread, and the bitter herbs
The Passover Lamb means that God passed over the blood-sprinkled place on the house of our fathers in Egypt. The unleavened bread means that our fathers were delivered

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out of Egypt in haste. The bitter herbs means that the Egyptians made bitter the lives of our fathers in Egypt.

- Furthermore, every Jew was look upon the experience as if it applied to him personally

From generation to generation every man is bound to look upon himself not otherwise than if he had himself come forth out of Egypt. For so it is, and you shall show your son in that day, saying, this is done because of that which the Lord did unto me when I came forth out of Egypt.

- So the meal proceeded through these steps
    - The first step was to recite a specific prayer of blessing
    - This was followed by the drinking of the first cup of wine, mixed 50/50 with water
        - The drinking of wine was not prescribed by God's law but had long since become a standard feature of the meal
        - It's important to note that not only did Jesus keep God's law, but He also observed prescribed tradition and rules, so long as they didn't contradict God's law
        - The drinking of the wine therefore was an added tradition, yet it was one Jesus observed and eventually incorporated into the church's communion celebration
        - The very fact that the wine has become a picture of Jesus' blood tells me that God intended that man would add wine to the Passover celebration
    - After the first cup of wine, bitter herbs were dipped in salt water and small pieces of bread were dipped in a relish mixture
    - Both were were passed around the table
        - In Mark and Matt's gospel, we hear of a moment in the meal when the disciples are dipping herbs into the bowl
        - John mentions the dipping of the bread in the sop
        - In Luke's gospel, none of this is mentioned

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- And these were just preludes to the Passover meal itself

- After the herbs, there is a second cup of wine and water
  - Before the cup the group sang from Psalms 113 and 114
  - Followed by a prayer and the second cup of wine

- Following the second cup, the meal proper begins
  - The herbs are eaten, which could include lettuce, beets, or similar bitter vegetables
  - Then the unleavened bread broken into pieces and passed around the table
    - Once everyone has the bread in their hands, then the host gave a prayer of thanksgiving
    - The rabbinical rules were very specific here
    - The prayer was to following the breaking of the bread and not to proceed it
      - Because it was the bread of poverty while in captivity
      - And the poor have not whole cakes of bread only broken pieces
      - This distinction becomes more important in a moment
    - Following the bread, the lamb would be eaten
    - Nothing else could be eaten after the Lamb, since taste of the Lamb was to be the thing that lingered in the mouth
  - Following the meal there was a third cup of wine called the cup of thanksgiving

- This is the moment when Luke's account joins the meal
  - In verse 17, Jesus is giving thanks and sharing the cup of wine with the table
    - There are a number of clues to tell us this
      - First, Jesus says a prayer of thanks associated with this cup

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- Only one of the four cups was consumed with a prayer of thanksgiving, the third cup
- Second, Jesus says he will not drink wine again until the kingdom
- If this had been one of the earlier cups in the seder meal, then Jesus' announcement that He won't drink wine again would have meant He wasn't going to participate in the remainder of that meal
- But as the third cup, it made sense

- The first cup was a cup of blessing, the second the cup of plagues, the third was the cup of thanksgiving and the fourth was the cup of redemption
  - Jesus would have naturally participated in the first three cups
  - But He pauses after the third, and He states He will not drink any more wine until the Kingdom celebration feast
  - And this makes sense, in that Jesus would not have observed the drinking of the cup of redemption until the redemption itself is fulfilled in his blood
    - Jesus is not just observing the early Passover
    - He was instituting the true Passover in His body
    - Therefore, there could be no observance of God's redemption until the day when the redemption is complete
    - That day awaits until the kingdom arrives

- So Jesus has paused at this point in the meal
  - The herbs and bread have been eaten and the Lamb has been consumed
    - Now last week I mentioned that I didn't see the lamb present in this meal except in the form of Jesus himself
    - But in looking at the text this week, I feel I need to back away from that viewpoint
    - In light of Jesus' statement that He came to fulfill the Law

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- And based on some things I saw this week in the events of the meal, I believe its more likely that Jesus and the apostles did eat the Lamb as required in the Law
    - Therefore, I believe it's the case that the meal has proceeded as expected up to this point including the Lamb with one exception

Luke 22:19 And when He had taken *some* bread *and* given thanks, He broke it and gave it to them, saying, "This is My body which is given for you; do this in remembrance of Me."
Luke 22:20 And in the same way *He took* the cup after they had eaten, saying, "This cup which is poured out for you is the new covenant in My blood.
Luke 22:21 "But behold, the hand of the one betraying Me is with Mine on the table.
Luke 22:22 "For indeed, the Son of Man is going as it has been determined; but woe to that man by whom He is betrayed!"

- In verse 19, Luke says that Jesus toke bread, gave thanks, and then broke it and distributed it
    - He tens said eat it in remembrance of me
    - This was not a seder meal tradition
        - First it came after the Third cup, which means it came after the lamb had been eaten and the meal finished
        - There was not supposed to be anything else eaten after the lamb
        - We know this bread is different than the bread eaten as part of the seder meal because Jesus gives thanks before breaking it
            - First, it occurs after the third cup, which ends the meal
            - Secondly, In the tradition of Passover, the bread of the passover meal is supposed to be broken and distributed and then thanks is spoken
            - Since Jesus reversed that order, it tells us that this is a new institution created apart from the Passover meal itself
    - Next, Jesus picks up the cup again, and distributes it saying this is the cup of my blood for the new covenant

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- Jesus himself doesn't drink from this cup in keeping with His earlier vow
- Secondly, he doesn't call this the cup of redemption
    - He says it's the cup of a new covenant
    - He specifically calls it out as different than then the fourth cup of the Passover meal
- This suggests that the Passover meal that Jesus enjoyed with His disciples is in a sense suspended
    - There is no evidence that Jesus included the fourth cup in that meal
    - Which means the meal ended without the fourth cup being shared
    - At the very least we know Jesus Himself didn't partake of that final cup of wine
- And meanwhile, he gave a new ceremony that Christians are to observe in the interim while we all await for Jesus to return and complete the seder meal He began with His disciples that day
    - We will all be there for that final cup, the cup of redemption
    - At which point we will al celebrate in a new feast that began on that night

- And when we observe the Last Supper, we remember how Jesus lived out the meaning of the Passover meal
    - How he endured the bitterness of His own rejection
    - Of how he carried our sin and shame so that we could be seen as sinless, without leaven
    - Of how He became our sacrificial lamb
    - And of how his blood was poured out for us
        - Blood mixed with water just as it will be in the cup of redemption which we all await to drink in His presence

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- How exciting…we have a ticket to that dinner

Luke 22:21 "But behold, the hand of the one betraying Me is with Mine on the table.
Luke 22:22 "For indeed, the Son of Man is going as it has been determined; but woe to that man by whom He is betrayed!"

- Luke doesn't mention the moment of the betrayal itself, but in the other gospels we learn that after the second cup but before the meal began, Judas leaves the room
    - Specifically, he leaves at the point where the bitter herbs and pieces of bread are dipped into the salt water and relish, Jesus identifies His traitor

John 13:21 ¶ When Jesus had said this, He became troubled in spirit, and testified and said, "Truly, truly, I say to you, that one of you will betray Me."
John 13:22 The disciples *began* looking at one another, at a loss *to know* of which one He was speaking.
John 13:23 There was reclining on Jesus' bosom one of His disciples, whom Jesus loved.
John 13:24 So Simon Peter *gestured to him, and *said to him, "Tell *us* who it is of whom He is speaking."
John 13:25 He, leaning back thus on Jesus' bosom, *said to Him, "Lord, who is it?"
John 13:26 Jesus then *answered, "That is the one for whom I shall dip the morsel and give it to him." So when He had dipped the morsel, He *took and *gave it to Judas, *the son* of Simon Iscariot.

- Remember the seating arrangement we mentioned earlier?
    - Here we see its significance
    - When Jesus announced that a traitor was among the group, everyone wondered who it would be
        - Doesn't that amaze you?
        - We know that Judas was an unbeliever
        - He was a wolf in sheep's clothing
        - Satan indwelled him
            - And yet when Jesus tells of a betrayer among the group, no one suspects Judas

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- This man was able to play the part of a believer, a follower of Jesus,
- And he did so convincingly, even to men who lived together with Jesus for three years

- Should we therefore be surprised to hear that there are potentially unbelievers among us
- Men and women who act the part of a Christian but are not
- The solution for this problem is to remain true in our words and witness
  - Let the word of God take a prominent place in the activities and priorities of the fellowship
  - Teach the congregation to obey all that Jesus commanded
  - And trust that if we honor and obey God's word, than it will do its perfect work in the hearts of those who hear it
  - And when we discover those who won't obey the word, we call them out, we preach the gospel, we disciple them,

Eph. 4:13 until we all attain to the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a mature man, to the measure of the stature which belongs to the fullness of Christ.

- But back to the scene in John
  - After Jesus' statement, Peter gestures to the one reclining on Jesus, the one He loved
    - We know that the one He loved refers to John himself
    - And it's likely that if Peter gestured to John, he would have been directly opposite John
    - This meant that Peter had chosen the lowest place at the table, which is somewhat in keeping with Peter's style
      - Peter was prideful at times, but in an ironic way, Peter would often take pride in his humility

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- You only have to look a little farther in John's gospel when Peter protests at having Jesus wash His feet

- So Peter sat opposite John and asked John to find out what Jesus meant

- Luke says the one who will betray him has his hand with Jesus on the table

- In John's gospel Jesus responds by saying whoever receives this dipped bread

- In Matt and Mark it was the one who dipped his hand into the bowl with Jesus

- In all three cases, it means that the person sitting immediately to Jesus left was the betrayer

- This was the position of honor at the table

- Which means that Judas had chosen for himself the position of honor at the table

- This also means that Judas left the room without participating in either the Passover meal itself nor the Lord's Supper that Jesus inaugurated at the same time.

- For he could not share in the promises Jesus made

- This suggests a couple of principles about the way we observe the Last Supper

- As Paul teaches in 1 Cor 11, it should be a solemn occasion, reflecting on Jesus words and on our worthiness to participate

- Ultimately, this reflection means are we partaking because we are believers in Jesus' work on the cross

- Believers in His sacrifice as the Lamb of God

- If not, we should not partake

- Unbelievers should not be a part of this meal, as Judas was not

- Jesus identification of Judas lead to one of the most bizarre scenes imaginable

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Luke 22:23 And they began to discuss among themselves which one of them it might be who was going to do this thing.
Luke 22:24 ¶ And there arose also a dispute among them *as to* which one of them was regarded to be greatest.
Luke 22:25 And He said to them, "The kings of the Gentiles lord it over them; and those who have authority over them are called 'Benefactors.'
Luke 22:26 "But *it is* not this way with you, but the one who is the greatest among you must become like the youngest, and the leader like the servant.
Luke 22:27 "For who is greater, the one who reclines *at the table* or the one who serves? Is it not the one who reclines *at the table*? But I am among you as the one who serves.

- The disciples are first taking about who will betray Jesus
    - Which means the conversation must have been about who was capable of being so low, so despicable
    - And then somehow, incomprehensibly, the conversation swings to the other extreme and the disciples begin to talk about who is the greatest
        - How do you even make that transition?
            - Who among us could be so low, so dirty to betray Jesus
            - Simon → Bartholemew doesn't clean his beard
            - Bart → Peter he's always bragging about his name, Peter's rocks
            - Peter → I can't help it if Jesus gave me a better name,
                - Besides I can't be the traitor, since I'm going to be the greatest one in the kingdom
                - Jesus just sighs and shakes His head
- This argument wasn't over who would be the most effective minister
    - Or who would have the greatest success in ministry
    - Or who would leave the greatest legacy
    - Or who would do the most to help God's people

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        - The word for greatest here in the Greek is megas – as in biggest, most important, who will have the distinction of being the #1 apostle - the leader, in other words, of the group

- In response, He turns to them and says:
    - You know, the Gentiles have kings too – leaders who lord it over them
        - We know Jesus is upset at these men because He rebukes them with a particularly strong comparison
            - He compares them to Gentiles
    - The Gentile was the lowest of low to a Jew – the dogs of society – completely without worth
        - So Jesus says that the Gentiles have leaders too
        - There's noting noteworthy in being a leader
        - There are plenty of ways you can be a leader if that's your goal
        - There is nothing godly about desiring leadership for the sake of ruling over people, and as proof Jesus reminds them that the ungodly gentiles want that very same thing
            - So if you mimic that desire, you are imitating godless behavior
- When Gentiles rule, they lord over their people – act like a master, as if the people exist to serve them
    - These leaders use their position of leadership to gain something for themselves at the expense of those they rule over
    - And everyone of those disciples knew exactly what Jesus was talking about, because they had all grown up in a Jewish culture that was under the constant oppression of the Gentile Roman empire
- Then Jesus adds in verse 25 that a Gentile rules adds insult to injury by portraying himself as the people's benefactor, their provider, the one who supports the people
    - The word benefactor is e-uru-getes – it means simply doer of good
    - The ruler sees himself as the doer of good for having given back some small piece of what he took in the first place

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- How hypocritical, to assume the image of a benefactor by returning something you took in an unjust manner to begin with

- Then in verse 26, Jesus says that leadership in His church must look different than it does in the world

  - The one who is greatest is the one who serves to rest – Matthew uses the world slave (doulos) to describe a leader

- The world's model of leadership – where those in charge aim to benefit in some way from their leadership position – is the wrong model for leaders in the church

  - The one who wishes to be greatest – to lead the church - must be the one who aspires to the lowest stature

    - To give himself up, to deny himself – and serve others with no expectation of reward or even thanks – like a slave

    - A man ready to assume roles that result in others in the fellowship being lifted up – rather than himself

      - Personally, I have always thought that if we give a pastor a reserved parking spot, it ought to be the spot farthest from the church entrance

      - Or the smallest office

    - A leader should be someone willing to make personal sacrifices of his time and wealth to ensure that the church's resources are used first and always to further the work of God in the body of Christ

- The trend today, however, seems to be for churches to model themselves after businesses

  - We have marketing plans,

  - We develop corporate branding

  - We hire fundraising consultants to ensure high giving

  - We pay for demographic studies to determine where to plant our next church to ensure the fastest growth

  - We teach our pastor to adopt Harvard business school leadership principles – to become experts in business trends and business thinking

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- Now, none of these things are wrong in and of themselves, as long as we are confident that God has directed us to do these things
    - But when they become the church's principle tools for moving the kingdom forward, rather than relying on God's word and His will,
    - Then we've stopped being the church and we're just another business – we're no longer salt and light
- And when we run our churches like businesses, is it any surprise that so often the men we have leading them turn out to act more like CEOs than pastors
    - Seeking after personal reward, prestige and honor for themselves rather than for God
    - Remember, Christ is the CEO of His church and He's not looking for help – He doesn't need a CEO
        - He doesn't need slick marketing, He doesn't need fancy new business leadership principles, He doesn't need seeker-friendly programs
        - He personally appeared to the most vehement Christian hater of His day and called that man to a life of extraordinary faith and service without the help of a single person –
        - Christ turning Saul into the Apostle Paul
            - If he can do that without a church or a program or even an evangelist, then He doesn't need our help to build his church
            - But He desires to work through us for our own benefit

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Luke 22C

- We're still in the midst of the Passover evening
    - But the focus of Luke's narrative has moved beyond the meal itself
    - Luke now captures some of the conversation that ended the meal between Jesus and the disciples that night
        - Luke mentions essentially three topics in his narrative
        - Although we know from John's Gospel that there was much more spoken on that night
        - His three topics are:
            - The roles these disciples will play in coming kingdom
            - The coming betrayal that night
            - The responsibility to be prepared for the scattering that must take place as they become ambassadors for Christ

Luke 22:28 ¶ "You are those who have stood by Me in My trials;
Luke 22:29 and just as My Father has granted Me a kingdom, I grant you
Luke 22:30 that you may eat and drink at My table in My kingdom, and you will sit on thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

- These 11 men (Judas had left by now) were the ones above all others who stood by Jesus in His trials, Jesus says
    - This is a somewhat ironic statement, especially in light of what Jesus is about to say to Peter
    - Nevertheless, Jesus statement stands here unqualified
        - But I believe it not only looks backward, but forward as well
            - It not only recognizes the disciples' sacrifice and commitment to follow Jesus up to this point

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- It also acknowledges what they will do in their work to spread the Gospel
- God knew what He would call them to do and how they would respond
- So it's only natural that these promises were built on all that these men would do

- I especially like the placement of this comment in Luke's discourse
  - Last week we looked at the verse that came right before this promise
  - It had been a bad moment for the disciples
    - They had been absorbed in their own pride and desires for recognition
    - They argued over who would be the greatest, and then Jesus had to step in to teach the servant nature of leadership in the church
  - It had been a rebuke, and I wonder if the disciples weren't hanging their heads a little by now
    - Feeling as though they had let Jesus down
    - And Jesus in a compassionate move, reminds them of an earlier promise He had given them
    - In Matt's gospel, at an earlier point in His ministry, Jesus had promised the disciples this:

Matt. 19:27 ¶ Then Peter said to Him, "Behold, we have left everything and followed You; what then will there be for us?"
Matt. 19:28 And Jesus said to them, "Truly I say to you, that you who have followed Me, in the regeneration when the Son of Man will sit on His glorious throne, you also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.
Matt. 19:29 "And everyone who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or children or farms for My name's sake, will receive many times as much, and will inherit eternal life.

- This exchange is somewhat similar to what we studied in Luke 18

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- And it makes sense to conclude the Jesus made promises like this to the disciples at multiple occasions during His ministry
- Jesus seems to be taking the moment to encourage these men having just called them on the carpet for their petty self-centered argument a moment earlier concerning their place in the kingdom
- And what He promises is an amazing right and privilege
    - Jesus says these men (and the Apostle Paul with them) will reign over Israel during the coming kingdom
        - While Jesus uses the word judge, He's using it in the same sense as the judges who ruled Israel in the times of the Judges
            - To make determinations over the affairs of the tribe
    - The nation was a Theocracy with God as the leader but with men (and sometimes women) appointed to lead as God's representative
    - And they will share in the Messianic banquet that ushers in the new age of the kingdom
- Each of these men will have role of leadership for an entire tribe of Israel
    - Like a CEO or Prime Minister in Jesus' government ruling earth upon His return
    - Consider what that will be like
        - Judgments and various decisions
        - Organizing economy and societal rules
- But I believe the expectations for those leadership positions will be the same as those Jesus expressed to these men a few verses earlier
    - They will be servant Leaders
    - They will have real authority and power under the authority of Jesus, but authority nonetheless
    - And they will retain this authority for the entire 1,000 year kingdom

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- But do you want to know something equally amazing?

Rev. 2:26 'He who overcomes, and he who keeps My deeds until the end, TO HIM I WILL GIVE AUTHORITY OVER THE NATIONS;
Rev. 2:27 AND HE SHALL RULE THEM WITH A ROD OF IRON, AS THE VESSELS OF THE POTTER ARE BROKEN TO PIECES, as I also have received *authority* from My Father;

Rev. 20:4 ¶ Then I saw thrones, and they sat on them, and judgment was given to them. And I *saw* the souls of those who had been beheaded because of their testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God, and those who had not worshiped the beast or his image, and had not received the mark on their forehead and on their hand; and they came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.

1Cor. 6:1 ¶ Does any one of you, when he has a case against his neighbor, dare to go to law before the unrighteous and not before the saints?
1Cor. 6:2 Or do you not know that the saints will judge the world? If the world is judged by you, are you not competent *to constitute* the smallest law courts?
1Cor. 6:3 Do you not know that we will judge angels? How much more matters of this life?

- Did you realize that we will have a similar role in that 1,000 year reign?
    - While each of the Apostles will have their hands full judging the 12 tribes, we will be busy too judging the world
    - As Jesus put it in His letter to the church at Thyatira, we will judge the nations, quoting Psalms 2
        - Nations here means Gentiles
        - We will be in positions of authority over the gentile nations
    - With so many saints to assume positions of authority, it seems clear enough that our rolls will extend deeper into a structure of some sort
        - In fact, the same assumption could be made for the tribes of Israel
            - Just as Moses was advised to appoint lieutenants under himself to help rule
            - We should expect that the Apostles will have other OT saints ruling with them over the tribes
            - In fact, their former king David will return to rule over all the tribes as a prince

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Ezek. 34:21 "Because you push with side and with shoulder, and thrust at all the weak with your horns until you have scattered them abroad,
Ezek. 34:22 therefore, I will deliver My flock, and they will no longer be a prey; and I will judge between one sheep and another.
Ezek. 34:23 ¶ "Then I will set over them one shepherd, My servant David, and he will feed them; he will feed them himself and be their shepherd.
Ezek. 34:24 "And I, the LORD, will be their God, and My servant David will be prince among them; I the LORD have spoken.

- Now remember this is being written 40+ years after David has died
    - So we're not talking about a promise that looked forward to David's reign as recorded in 2 Sam
    - This is clearing looking forward to a future day
        - And you only need to read a little further to see that

Ezek. 34:25 ¶ "I will make a covenant of peace with them and eliminate harmful beasts from the land so that they may live securely in the wilderness and sleep in the woods.
Ezek. 34:26 "I will make them and the places around My hill a blessing. And I will cause showers to come down in their season; they will be showers of blessing.
Ezek. 34:27 "Also the tree of the field will yield its fruit and the earth will yield its increase, and they will be secure on their land. Then they will know that I am the LORD, when I have broken the bars of their yoke and have delivered them from the hand of those who enslaved them.
Ezek. 34:28 "They will no longer be a prey to the nations, and the beasts of the earth will not devour them; but they will live securely, and no one will make *them* afraid.
Ezek. 34:29 "I will establish for them a renowned planting place, and they will not again be victims of famine in the land, and they will not endure the insults of the nations anymore.
Ezek. 34:30 "Then they will know that I, the LORD their God, am with them, and that they, the house of Israel, are My people," declares the Lord GOD.

- So Jesus will rule the World in peace
    - The nation of Israel will return as the chief nation over the earth in that day
        - Prince David will rule under the authority of Christ the King
        - The 12 Apostles will rule over the 12 tribes, under David's command

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- The Gentiles will be ruled by the Church saints and those saved during the Tribulation
  - I wonder who will be at the top of that ladder among the Gentiles?
    - The early church martyrs like Stephen?
    - The faithful who endured Roman persecution in the coliseum?
    - Luther? Calvin? And the other reformists?
    - The pilgrims and early missionaries to foreign lands?
    - The great evangelists of the 18th and 19th centuries?
    - Billy Graham?
  - Maybe, but remember Jesus' words:

Matt. 19:30 "But many *who are* first will be last; and *the* last, first.

- And perhaps the better question is where will you and I be? And what are we prepared to do now to ensure our place in that next age?

Luke 22:31 ¶ "Simon, Simon, behold, Satan has demanded *permission* to sift you like wheat;
Luke 22:32 but I have prayed for you, that your faith may not fail; and you, when once you have turned again, strengthen your brothers."
Luke 22:33 But he said to Him, "Lord, with You I am ready to go both to prison and to death!"
Luke 22:34 And He said, "I say to you, Peter, the rooster will not crow today until you have denied three times that you know Me."

- Here's the second piece to Jesus' conversation that night
  - He turns to Peter and presents a challenge
  - Actually, I think the rendering here isn't quite right
    - The pronoun at the end of verse 31 is actually plural
    - In Texas, we know exactly what the plural of you is – you all
    - That's what Jesus said here

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- Peter, behold – which could easily be translated look or pay attention
- Then Jesus says Satan has demanded to permission to sift you all
- Sifting here is similar to pick you apart, to see what you're made of

- Consider the setting for a moment
  - Jesus said they will have opportunity to rule the nations
  - And then I wonder if Peter got too excited for a moment
    - Perhaps Jesus efforts to encourage the disciples with His reminder of their future leadership rolls worked too well for Peter
    - Perhaps he started to shows signs of that pride again
- Seeing that Peter is thinking himself worthy of that place of honor, Jesus stops him and says, Simon listen to me
  - He uses Peter's natural name
    - The name he had before Jesus awarded him the title rock
    - It's almost as though Jesus wants to emphasize that Peter isn't as invulnerable as he assumes he is
  - Jesus says things are about to get rough
    - Satan has his eye on you all
    - He has asked permission to come after you to see if you are truly mine

- There are several important lessons we learn in these verses about God, and Satan and our relationship to them
  - It's clear that Satan has approached the throne, which we know from Rev and Job Satan can do for now
    - And he asks God to give him freedom to test the saints

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- Now would Satan seek God's permission if he didn't have to?
    - Consider how God dealt with Satan in the book of Job
    - Satan could only go as far as God allowed
- And would Jesus have even mention this to the disciples if God weren't planning to grant Satan his request?

- Well we know from Jesus says immediately after in verse 32 that the test is coming
    - And of course we know what happened to these men as they were persecuted for their faith

- So clearly he must have the father's permission to bring an attack against the saints

- Consider what that means for you and me

- When we suffer at the hands if the enemy or his demons, God has first allowed it

- Now knowing that our God is God who loves us and who turns all things for good for those who love Him

- And remembering what Hebrews says:

Heb. 12:5 and you have forgotten the exhortation which is addressed to you as sons,
"MY SON, DO NOT REGARD LIGHTLY THE DISCIPLINE OF THE LORD,
NOR FAINT WHEN YOU ARE REPROVED BY HIM;
Heb. 12:6 FOR THOSE WHOM THE LORD LOVES HE DISCIPLINES,
AND HE SCOURGES EVERY SON WHOM HE RECEIVES."
Heb. 12:7 It is for discipline that you endure; God deals with you as with sons; for what son is there whom *his* father does not discipline?
Heb. 12:8 But if you are without discipline, of which all have become partakers, then you are illegitimate children and not sons.

- So knowing that God is at work to produce good

- And knowing that He is inclined to discipline us for our own good

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- Now we can understand what Paul meant when he says in Phillipians 4 rejoice in everything and be anxious for nothing

James 1:2 ¶ Consider it all joy, my brethren, when you encounter various trials,
James 1:3 knowing that the testing of your faith produces endurance.

- Not every bad consequence in our lives is directly attributable to Satan's activity
  - When we caught speeding and we're pulled over by a policeman
    - We can't go home that night and tell our spouse that we had an encounter with Satan and he was wearing a badge and packing heat
    - That was merely a consequence of your own sin
    - Satan never had to be involved for you to feel the pain of your own mistakes

- But here Jesus is warning the disciples and Peter especially to be ready for the coming test
  - Because it will be by these tests that they will earn the right to rule
  - And then we learn another interesting nugget from Jesus' words to Peter
    - He says but I have prayed for you Peter
      - While the pronoun you used in verse 31 was plural
      - This use of the pronoun is singular
      - Here we've learned Jesus' reason for calling Peter out
    - Jesus prayed specifically for Peter

- What does it mean that Jesus prayed?
  - It means He made an appeal to the Father on the basis of Jesus role as our intercessor
  - What an encouragement to see Jesus demonstrating His roll as our advocate before the Throne

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Rom. 8:27 and He who searches the hearts knows what the mind of the Spirit is, because He intercedes for the saints according to *the will of* God.

Heb. 7:25 Therefore He is able also to save forever those who draw near to God through Him, since He always lives to make intercession for them.

- And what does Jesus intercede for on behalf of Peter?
  - Not that Peter won't suffer trials
    - For we know that the trials are God's will, otherwise Satan wouldn't be granted permission
  - Not that Peter would be forgiven his denials
    - For Peter will have already been forgiven his sin by Christ's blood
  - Not even that Peter won't succumb to the devil and deny Christ
    - For we know that Peter does in fact deny Christ

- So what does Jesus pray for?
  - That Peter's faith would not fail
    - What does that mean?
      - Is Jesus suggesting that Peter could end up in a place where he would revert to a state of unbelief?
    - Heb 7:25 we just read would tell us that this isn't possible
      - Jesus has the power to save forever those are brought near God by faith
      - The moment you belief you have drawn near to God through Jesus
        - And in that moment, Jesus has power to save you forever because He lives to make intercession for you
        - Forever means the saving that He accomplished is never to be undone for any reason

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- So again, what does it mean that Jesus prayed for Peter's faith not to fail?
    - Well, look at the end of the verse…

Luke 22:32 but I have prayed for you, that your faith may not fail; and you, when once you have turned again, strengthen your brothers."

    - Jesus says once you have turned back, you shall be the one to help your brothers return as well
        - Here we see clearly that Jesus expected all the disciples to fail in their moment of testing – not just Peter
            - We too often run to judgment over Peter's failure forgetting that all the disciples were equally guilty
    - But Jesus intercedes for Peter in a unique and specific way
        - Jesus prays that after the trials of the crucifixion, Peter would be restored
        - Restored back to a close fellowship and trust in Jesus
            - And by that restoration, Peter would become the one through whom the rest of the Apostles would be restored as well
    - The point of the prayer was to grant to Peter a unique privilege
        - The one restored first and the one who would restore the others
        - This is a privilege consistent with his position as an early leader in the church

- What Peter heard was Jesus' subtle remark about turning back
    - Which means he turned away
    - And of course Peter would have nothing of it

Luke 22:33 But he said to Him, "Lord, with You I am ready to go both to prison and to death!"
Luke 22:34 And He said, "I say to you, Peter, the rooster will not crow today until you have denied three times that you know Me."

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- Peter makes his famous statement of bravado
    - To which Jesus has no choice but to give Peter a specific prediction of how he will respond to Satan's attack
    - He will deny Jesus three times
        - Now we also know that Peter is the first Apostle to react to Jesus' appearance after the resurrection
        - So we know that Jesus' prayer is ultimately answered
            - But His promise here is equally sure
            - Peter, despite his self-confidence and sincerity, was still unable to stand in the face of his fear
        - But later he would stand mightily, most likely because of what he had experienced here

Luke 22:35 ¶ And He said to them, "When I sent you out without money belt and bag and sandals, you did not lack anything, did you?" They said, "*No*, nothing."
Luke 22:36 And He said to them, "But now, whoever has a money belt is to take it along, likewise also a bag, and whoever has no sword is to sell his coat and buy one.
Luke 22:37 "For I tell you that this which is written must be fulfilled in Me, 'AND HE WAS NUMBERED WITH TRANSGRESSORS'; for that which refers to Me has *its* fulfillment."

- Finally, the third issue Luke records,
    - Jesus makes a reference back to an experience that the disciples had in Luke 9
    - At that earlier point in His ministry, Jesus directed the disciples to go out to proclaim the gospel and to perform miracles
        - And when He sent them out, the purpose was to invite the Jewish nation to respond to the invitation to accept their Messiah
        - And as they went, He told them to take no money belt, no shoes, no walking stick

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- When we taught Chapter 9, we learned that those instructions had the purpose of impressing upon the disciples two things
    - First, they were to be dependent on the Lord, for it was His message and His power in their midst that they needed to depend upon
        - And they found success, at least in that they realized that even the demon world was subject to them
    - Now Jesus reminds them of that time but changes the instructions
        - Now they are to make those very same preparations that he stopped them from making earlier
        - Now they were to have money bags, coats, and even swords
- Why do the instructions change here?
    - Well He tells them, quoting from a prophesy of the Messiah taken from Isaiah 53:12 that Jesus would be seen as a criminal
        - And therefore so would they
        - The world would be after them
    - Secondly, the circumstances will be different
        - When Jesus was on the earth, the disciples were in a situation where the Kingdom was available to the earth should the Nation of Israel receive it
        - Satan's power to interfere and create harm was completely in subjection to Jesus' ministry
            - This is why the crowds and leaders couldn't harm or thwart Jesus until the appointed time
            - The disciples didn't need to be on guard or ready for trouble during those days
            - Like when Jesus answered the critics for why His disciples didn't fast

Matt. 9:15 And Jesus said to them, "The attendants of the bridegroom cannot mourn as long as the bridegroom is with them, can they? But the days will come when the bridegroom is taken away from them, and then they will fast.

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- And now those days are upon them
  - They will still be dependent on God just as much as before
    - But now the change in circumstances means that God is expecting these men to be prepared for the battle they face
    - And to take a seriousness of purpose into the battle
    - It's time for these men to grow up, to understand what's about to happen to them all
  - And it's important to understand that these references are symbolic, not literal
    - Jesus says have a money bag, meaning be ready to put your personal resources to work for the kingdom
      - Hold nothing back from God financially
      - You're working for Him now
    - And buy a sword because you about to enter a battle, a spiritual battle
      - Jesus is not expecting these men to literally engage in armed violence
  - You only have to look a little farther into this chapter to know that
    - When Peter tries to defend Jesus with the sword they have, Jesus stops them
    - They were so ready to do anything for their master, that had Jesus commanded armed insurrection, they would do it
    - And that's what they think He's saying here

- In other words, the disciples still don't get it
  - Jesus is talking about preparedness for a spiritual battle
  - And they are thinking about armed conflict

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Eph. 6:12 For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the powers, against the world forces of this darkness, against the spiritual *forces* of wickedness in the heavenly *places*.

- We only have to look at the next verse to see that Jesus decides it's not worth clearing up the confusion now

Luke 22:38 They said, "Lord, look, here are two swords." And He said to them, "It is enough."

- Can you see Jesus shaking His head a little here?
  - Some enterprising apostle says Hey check this out Jesus, we have two swords
    - Jesus says, it is enough
    - This is a common phrase in the Bible and it means there is no point in talking further
    - The conversation is over
    - He's shutting them up before they go any further off track
      - He knows they'll understand what he means soon enough
- How prepare are we to face the battles God has in store for us?
  - Are we picking up our sword, the sword of the spirit?

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Luke 22D

- We return to Luke tonight standing at the doorstep of the crucifixtion
    - Within the hour, Jesus will be alone, all his friends including the disciples having run away and abandoned him… and then the slander will begin
    - In less than three hours, the Jewish authorities will have tried him on trumped up charges in a kangaroo court…and then the beatings with fists and clubs will begin
    - In less than 6 hours, Jesus will be standing before the most powerful men in all Judea remaining silent in the face of accusations…and then the mocking will being
    - In less than 9 hours Jesus will be brought before hostile crowds who call repeatedly for his death, the same crowds that loved his teaching and were awed by His miracles…and then the scourging will begin
    - In less than 12 hours, Roman soldiers will drive the first nails through Jesus' body as he lies naked on the cross…and His agonizingly slow death will begin
    - And in less than 18 hours, Jesus will be dead, and the mourning will begin
- An abrupt end to a brief earthly ministry for the man who's life and death had eternal significance for every other human being
    - And as we begin to study these 18 hours, let's do what we can to put aside all the images that may have formed in our mind concerning the events of this moment
    - Whether those images may have come to us from books we've read or movies we've watched or even other studies, let's free ourselves of those constraints
        - For the true power of what happened during those 18 hours isn't found in imagery of Hollywood or even in the words of Christian authors
        - It's found in our own hearts as we come to understand the love of a God who would take His own Son's life before He would take yours and mine

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- And so with that, we return to Chapter 22 of Luke

Luke 22:39 ¶ And He came out and proceeded as was His custom to the Mount of Olives; and the disciples also followed Him.
Luke 22:40 When He arrived at the place, He said to them, "Pray that you may not enter into temptation."
Luke 22:41 And He withdrew from them about a stone's throw, and He knelt down and *began* to pray,
Luke 22:42 saying, "Father, if You are willing, remove this cup from Me; yet not My will, but Yours be done."
Luke 22:43 Now an angel from heaven appeared to Him, strengthening Him.
Luke 22:44 And being in agony He was praying very fervently; and His sweat became like drops of blood, falling down upon the ground.
Luke 22:45 When He rose from prayer, He came to the disciples and found them sleeping from sorrow,
Luke 22:46 and said to them, "Why are you sleeping? Get up and pray that you may not enter into temptation."

- Tonight's teaching opens with Jesus having left the upper room where He celebrated Passover
    - And we're told He is heading back to the Mount of Olives
    - This is the place He's been staying at night during His week in Jerusalem
        - This is an important detail for us to note
        - Jesus knows that His betrayer is busy arranging for His capture
            - Jesus knows that Judas can only lead the authorities to places that he believes he can find Jesus
            - Judas may have tried the upper room, we don't know
            - But regardless, the only other place he could assume to find Jesus was on the Mount of Olives
            - And this is exactly the place Jesus goes, to the garden of Gesthemane, which means oil press
        - Jesus isn't trying to evade Judas
        - Jesus is cooperating with the Father's plan

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- As they arrive at the Mount, Jesus tells His disciples to pray to avoid falling into temptation
    - It seems a little odd to me that in the midst of all that was going on, and all that Jesus knew was coming
        - That He then tells the 11 to appeal to God in prayer to avoid falling into temptation
        - What kind of temptation would the disciples experience in this time?
            - In a sense, it was the same kind of temptation that Jesus Himself was praying to avoid in His own prayer time
- Because at the same time, at a distance, Jesus prays to the Father if the Father might be willing to remove the cup of suffering that Jesus knew He was preparing to experience
    - The image of a cup of judgment, by the way, is a consistent picture in scripture
        - Judgment is commonly described as something that is poured out
        - Bowl judgments of Revelation
            - And the Great Babylon receives the cup of wine of God's wrath
        - Jeremiah talk about the cup of wine of God's wrath being poured out against all nations that come against Israel
    - So Jesus understands that He is to drink of a cup of God's wrath
        - The judgment that is due you and I will be placed on Jesus through the experiences of the crucifixion and Jesus time in the grave
        - And this is an unbearable expectation
        - And yet Jesus knew this was the Father's plan for salvation
            - This is why Jesus adds the phrase ei boulamai
            - If you are willing, but God' will above His
    - Isn't that always to be our prayer?

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- Not our will, but God's will
- And Jesus expresses that same thought
    - Can there be any doubt that Jesus was truly a man
        - He felt the anxiety of His coming suffering
        - He felt an instinctive desire to run away, to stop the process, to say no to God's will
        - He probably had that sinking feeling in the pit of His stomach as He contemplated what was about to happen to Him
    - Luke, the doctor, even observes that Jesus' nervousness and fear drove Him to sweat so profusely that the sweat was like drops of blood
        - Medically, it is possible that a person could have blood leave the body through a condition called hemohidrosis
            - Under extreme stress, tiny capillaries in the sweat glands can rupture missing small amounts of blood with the sweat
            - This leads to sweat that becomes like drops of blood as Dr. Luke puts it
        - The point is the extreme degree of suffering Jesus is experiencing
- Remember, this is early spring in Judea
    - It's still cold at night
    - We'll see in verse 55 that someone kindles a fire in the courtyard of the high priest because it's a cold night
    - Jesus is in a cold sweat, so intense that it ruptures blood vessels in the skin

From these factors, it is evident that even before Jesus endured the torture of the cross, He suffered far beyond what most of us will ever suffer. His penetrating awareness of the heinous nature of sin, its destructive and deadly effects, the sorrow and heartache

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that it inflicts, and the extreme measure necessary to deal with it, make the passion of Christ beyond all comprehension. – Dr. Dave Miller

- And it was under these circumstances that Jesus would experience temptation
    - What kind of temptation does someone face in these circumstances?
        - A temptation to avoid the persecution
        - To stand in the face of coming persecution and run
        - To flee and in so doing to lose an opportunity to testify to the Gospel
        - Most importantly, temptation to go against God's will
            - For if persecutions come, they only come because God permits it
    - Jesus obviously desired to avoid the cross…who wouldn't?
        - But He wouldn't avoid it if doing so required going against God's will for His life
        - He humbled Himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross (Phil 2:8)
    - And even in that Jesus wants to teach a lessons to these 11 men who themselves will experience persecution and martyrdom
        - Even now they will be tempted to retreat
            - To deny Christ and avoid sharing in His persecution
            - And Jesus demands they pray and yet they are neglectful
- God has a plan for each of us, to His own glory
    - That plan may include a long peaceful life lived as a testimony of the peace we have in the Lord
    - But instead God's plan for our life might involve hardship, disappointments, suffering, persecution, and even a violent end

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- So that through our forgiveness of those who persecute us and through our hopeful praise of God even in the midst of trials God may receive glory in the eyes of men

- God can direct our lives any way He chooses to His own glory and one way is as good as another

Phil. 2:17 But even if I am being poured out as a drink offering upon the sacrifice and service of your faith, I rejoice and share my joy with you all.

- Paul declared that even as God was pouring him out as an offering for the sake of the Philippian church, Paul rejoiced

- Paul was only too glad for God to use him in that way

- As we look through the rest of this chapter, consider the example Jesus is setting here of how to face persecution when you know that it is God's will that we endure such trials

    - Pray for the test to be removed, but only if it be God's will

    - And if it be His will that the trial come nonetheless, pray not to be tempted to avoid it

        - Pray to endure it as your Lord endured His trial

        - Pray knowing that His will is being met in your suffering and that His glory and your reward will be great

            - Remember His words of encouragement to the church at Smyrna

Rev. 2:10 'Do not fear what you are about to suffer. Behold, the devil is about to cast some of you into prison, so that you will be tested, and you will have tribulation for ten days. Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life.

Luke 22:47 ¶ While He was still speaking, behold, a crowd *came,* and the one called Judas, one of the twelve, was preceding them; and he approached Jesus to kiss Him.
Luke 22:48 But Jesus said to him, "Judas, are you betraying the Son of Man with a kiss?"
Luke 22:49 When those who were around Him saw what was going to happen, they said, "Lord, shall we strike with the sword?"
Luke 22:50 And one of them struck the slave of the high priest and cut off his right ear.
Luke 22:51 But Jesus answered and said, "Stop! No more of this." And He touched his ear and healed him.

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Luke 22:52 Then Jesus said to the chief priests and officers of the temple and elders who had come against Him, "Have you come out with swords and clubs as you would against a robber?
Luke 22:53 "While I was with you daily in the temple, you did not lay hands on Me; but this hour and the power of darkness are yours."

- The moment of the betrayal
    - Judas enters the garden leading a crowd Luke says
        - In studying Luke, we miss a few of the important details of this event found in the other gospels
            - For example, we learn in Matt gospel that the crowd is armed with clubs and swords
            - In John's gospel we learn that the group also had torches and that it included officers from the chief priest and a Roman cohort assigned to follow Judas and provide backup
                - A cohort was about 600 soldiers
                - It seems unlikely that an entire cohort would be assigned to this responsibility
            - But then again, if the leaders were worried about a large crowd trying to protect Jesus, Pilate might not have wanted to take any chances

- As they approach, John tells us that Jesus asked them who they were looking for
    - When they ask for Jesus of Nazareth, Jesus says I am he
        - At that moment, the entire group drew back and fell to the ground
        - Why they reacted that way we don't know except to acknowledge that the power of God compelled them to respond
            - Though God wasn't content to stop them, nevertheless He made it be known that nothing that was about to happen was happening outside His will and purpose

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- In Luke's account, we're told that Judas confirms Jesus identity with a kiss
    - Jesus responds to Judas' gall with the famous line, do you betray me with a kiss
        - Judas had obviously arranged that sign ahead of time
            - Did you ever stop to ask why?
            - Why a sign at all
        - This was at least in part a result of the Roman legal proceedings of the day
    - Before an arrest could happen under Roman law, there would have needed to be an indictment
        - We can only assume that when Judas left the Passover dinner, he had approached the Jewish leaders and told them where they could find Jesus
            - This would have prompted the Jewish leader to take Judas to the Roman governor to obtain an indictment against Jesus
            - Without an indictment, the Romans wouldn't have agreed to Jesus' arrest
            - And without a witness like Judas, the Jewish leaders couldn't have secured an indictment
    - So as this group approached Jesus, it falls on Judas to identify the accused
        - Much like the witness points to the accused at trial and says He's the man
            - Only in this case Judas uses a common greeting to identify Jesus
            - A rabbi's disciples would often greet their rabbi by kissing their hand
        - How ironic that Judas would use a gesture intended to show love and honor in order to accomplish an act of hatred and betrayal
            - Remember that as this moment occurs, Satan is still direct Judas

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- So it's true to say that the Devil himself is betraying Jesus with a kiss
- How the spiritual realm must have shuddered at that moment

- Now the scene gets even more bizarre, if that were possible
    - The disciples are still trying to figure out what Jesus meant by His earlier comment about needing swords
        - So they ask Jesus here if this would be a good time to use the sword
    - Then one of the disciples takes one of those swords that Jesus told them to carry and swings it at the men arresting Jesus
        - John tells us that this man was Peter
        - Which shouldn't surprise us very much
    - This is actually a pretty pathetic display if you think about it
        - Do you think Peter was aiming for the ear of a slave?
            - Should we assume that Peter carefully calculated in this moment that the best way to defend Jesus was to surgically remove the ear of the lowest ranking member of the entourage?
        - Have you ever lifted an ancient machete?
            - They're a bit heavy
            - They're bulky
        - Peter is a fisherman, not a soldier
            - What Peter did was the equivalent to a person who has never fired a gun drawing a pistol and shooting his own foot
            - Jesus probably asked Peter to put it away because He was afraid Peter might cut himself
        - Peter was probably trying to take off someone's head, and the best he could manage was taking off an ear

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"Peter had been sleeping when he should have been praying, talking when he should have been listening, and boasting when he should have been fearing. Now he was fighting when he should have been surrendering."
Wiersbe

- And as we read, Jesus then heals the man's ear
  - Showing amazing compassion even in this moment against his accusers
    - Though I'm sure that slave had arrived that night with no particular interest in dispute surrounding Jesus
    - He certainly left with a different impression of that man

- Finally, Jesus asks an obvious if rhetorical question
  - Why bring such a mob
  - We have this remarkable scene playing out here
    - Dozens if not hundreds of Roman soldiers
    - Angry villagers with torches, clubs and swords
    - Officers of the chief priest
    - All marching into an otherwise peaceful night in the Garden to arrest a simple teacher from Nazareth
      - The whole thing would be comical if it weren't so tragic
  - What propelled these people?
    - That's Jesus' basic question
    - Where did their anger come from?
    - What motivated them to come with such overwhelming force against a man who never did anything more than preach forgiveness and love for God
    - A man without sin
  - Jesus provides the answer in verse 53
    - This was a battle being waged in the spiritual realm

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- And the people in this moment were merely chess pieces moving on the board of human history
    - But unlike a true chess game where each side start with the same pieces and has equal opportunity to win
    - In this battle, the enemy has only pawns and the Lord has a unlimited number of Queens, Bishops, Knights, and a King who can never fall
- So under those circumstances, the only way the enemy takes any piece off the board is when God permits it
    - Jesus says this time is yours
    - This is the time God has appointed for the enemy to achieve a limited kind of victory
- And this time was appointed from the earliest days of man's existence

Gen. 3:14 The LORD God said to the serpent,
"Because you have done this,
Cursed are you more than all cattle,
And more than every beast of the field;
On your belly you will go,
And dust you will eat
All the days of your life;
Gen. 3:15 And I will put enmity
Between you and the woman,
And between your seed and her seed;
He shall bruise you on the head,
And you shall bruise him on the heel."

- The promise to mankind made in that moment was that the seed of woman and the seed of the serpent would contend with one another
    - First thing to note is that woman don't have seed, strictly speaking
        - The male as the seed
        - Yet God says it will be by the woman's seed that God will deal with the serpent's treachery
    - The only person ever born of a woman's seed was Jesus, born of a virgin

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        - And then the serpent will have the power to bruise the seed of the woman on the heel
        - But the seed of woman will be able to strike the head of the serpent
    - The imagery here especially in the Hebrew is very clear
        - The seed of woman, Christ, must be bruised by the serpent, who was Satan according to Rev 20:2,
        - But Christ will ultimately have the power to destroy this same serpent in the appointed time
    - And now the hour and the power of darkness is theirs, Jesus says
- Weirsbe also said that all men face a similar decision like the moment here in the garden
    - In the face of God's plan for the salvation of mankind, all men must choose to either:
        - Go through life pretending like Judas
        - Fighting like Peter
        - Or Submitting to God's will like Jesus

Luke 22:54 ¶ Having arrested Him, they led Him *away* and brought Him to the house of the high priest; but Peter was following at a distance.
Luke 22:55 After they had kindled a fire in the middle of the courtyard and had sat down together, Peter was sitting among them.
Luke 22:56 And a servant-girl, seeing him as he sat in the firelight and looking intently at him, said, "This man was with Him too."
Luke 22:57 But he denied *it*, saying, "Woman, I do not know Him."
Luke 22:58 A little later, another saw him and said, "You are *one* of them too!" But Peter said, "Man, I am not!"
Luke 22:59 After about an hour had passed, another man *began* to insist, saying, "Certainly this man also was with Him, for he is a Galilean too."
Luke 22:60 But Peter said, "Man, I do not know what you are talking about." Immediately, while he was still speaking, a rooster crowed.
Luke 22:61 The Lord turned and looked at Peter. And Peter remembered the word of the Lord, how He had told him, "Before a rooster crows today, you will deny Me three times."

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Luke 22:62 And he went out and wept bitterly.

- As they are leading Jesus away, Mark's gospel tells us that all the disciples fled at this moment
    - Luke tells us that Peter at least had the decency to follow at a distance, hoping not to be spotted and identified
        - These men had real reason to fear
        - When the teacher is accused of treason and blasphemy
            - Then his students could easily be charged with a similar offense unless they repudiate their teacher
            - They were under similar suspicion
    - While Jesus is at the house of the chief priest, Peter is recognized in the courtyard as they all wait outside
        - And as we read, he fulfills Jesus' prediction by denying Him three times in quick succession
        - All this time, the crowd and Jesus with them is waiting outside the High priest's house
            - All that is happening is within ear shot of Jesus
            - Peter's final denial prompt's Jesus to catch Peter's eye, almost as if to say I told you so
    - What a difficult moment for Peter
        - Not that he didn't deserve the conviction he felt, but still how hard must it have been for Peter to disappoint His master in this way
- The trial of Jesus at the hands of the religious leaders finishes the chapter, followed by the civil trial at the hands of the Romans.
    - We will look at the trials as a single series
    - Examine all the mistakes and violations of Jewish Law to understand the travesty of this event

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Luke 22E

- Tonight we begin our study of the trial of Jesus of Nazareth
    - As I mentioned last week, there are actually three distinct trials
        - Two separate religious trials conducted by the Jewish leadership
        - One civil trial conducted by the Romans
            - Though even the civil trial was really three separate scenes split between two different Roman rulers
    - Even more striking than the complexity of the events of that night was the short period of time in which it occurred
        - The entire trial process probably began in the last hours of Wednesday night and were finished by early morning on Thursday
    - So it should be obvious that if we aren't careful in our observations of the text, we could easily miss important details and perhaps confuse the events
- In fact, though we left off in verse 63 of chapter 22, I want to remind you of an earlier verse in order to set the scene properly for you tonight
    - In verse 54 we learned an important detail

Luke 22:54 ¶ Having arrested Him, they led Him *away* and brought Him to the house of the high priest; but Peter was following at a distance.

- The first place they led Jesus after the arrest in the garden was to the house of high priest, we're told
    - This is the place Luke places the scene of Peter's denial
    - If Luke's gospel was the only gospel we had, then we would never have known which high priest Jesus met
    - Because in His day, there were actually two high priests in Israel

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- When the Roman's entered Judea and took control of Jerusalem a few decades prior to Christ's birth, they permitted the Jews to maintain their religious leadership
- But the leadership was expected to support Roman rule
- The senior most religious leader within Israel was the high priest, and in Jesus day, the High Priest held his position for life
    - A man named Annas was high priest in Israel from AD 7-14
    - In AD 14 Annas did something to upset the Roman governor of the day, and Annas was deposed
        - The Roman governor removed Annas from his position as High Priest
        - This act upset the Jews of course, so the governor tried to lessen the sting of Annas' removal by appointing one of Annas' sons in his place
        - That son was quickly succeeded by another of Annas' sons, and then by Annas' son-in-law
        - In the day that Jesus was crucified, that son in law was the man serving as high priest, a man named Caiaphas
    - But at this point, Old Man Annas is still alive and living in Israel
        - So he stills carries considerable sway in the affairs of Israel
        - Because as long as he was alive, the Jews still saw Annas as their high priest
        - So they would give deference to him, even as they simultaneously gave homage to the Roman-installed high priest, Caiaphas

- So this is why on the night of Jesus' trial, he is actually tried by both high priests, though Luke only records the stop at Annas' house

- We know that Jesus went first to Anna's house because of John's gospel

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John 18:12 ¶ So the *Roman* cohort and the commander and the officers of the Jews, arrested Jesus and bound Him,
John 18:13 and led Him to Annas first; for he was father-in-law of Caiaphas, who was high priest that year.

- So as we look at the scene in Luke's gospel we begin at Annas' house
    - In this house the first trial takes place
    - Though Luke doesn't offer a description of the trial itself, John again provides those details

John 18:19 ¶ The high priest then questioned Jesus about His disciples, and about His teaching.
John 18:20 Jesus answered him, "I have spoken openly to the world; I always taught in synagogues and in the temple, where all the Jews come together; and I spoke nothing in secret.
John 18:21 "Why do you question Me? Question those who have heard what I spoke to them; they know what I said."
John 18:22 When He had said this, one of the officers standing nearby struck Jesus, saying, "Is that the way You answer the high priest?"
John 18:23 Jesus answered him, "If I have spoken wrongly, testify of the wrong; but if rightly, why do you strike Me?"
John 18:24 So Annas sent Him bound to Caiaphas the high priest.

- At this point, we begin to witness the hypocrisy of these religious leaders
    - Jewish law had a long list of strict rules for how a Jewish arrest and trial was to be conducted
    - And like our law today, these rules existed largely to protect the accused and ensure a fair trial
        - Some of these rules include:
            - No arrest should be a by product of a bribe
                - Judas
            - No steps of the criminal justice system should take place after night

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- The entire proceeding takes place at night

- Judges and members of the Sanhedrin could participate in the arrest
  - Members of the Sanhedrin were present at the arrest
- All trials must be public and Sanhedrin trials could only be conducted in the Temple Compound
  - Private homes
- There had to be two or three witnesses and their testimony had to be in perfect agreement
  - We'll see that the witnesses were terribly inconsistent
- The accused was not allowed to testify against himself and he couldn't be condemned on the basis of his own words alone
  - Jesus was compelled to testify against Himself
- The high priest was forbidden to tear his garments
  - The high priest will do that in the end
- The charge of blasphemy could only be committed if a man pronounced the very name of God
  - Jesus is charged with blasphemy but He never meets the requirements of the crime
- Trials could not be conducted on the eve of a Sabbath or a feast day

- And there were many others
  - We can already in the text we've already studied how many of these requirements were set aside for Jesus' trial
    - The trial
    - But that's nothing new for these men

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- They routinely set aside rules when it suits them

- We'll point out their violations as we go along

- The purpose of the trial was to establish whether Jesus had violated any of the Jewish religious laws or rules

  - As John describes it, the High Priest Annas questions Jesus about His disciples and His teaching

    - The goal is simple

    - They are looking for anything in Jesus' teaching or in His instructions to His disciples that could serve as a basis for a charge

      - This is a fishing expedition

      - They don't have a specific charge in mind, though they hope to pin something like blasphemy on Him

      - Something that has the death penalty associated with it

    - Of course, the other purpose in asking about the disciples was to determine if charges could be brought against any of them as well

  - Jesus' answers to Annas to show their failure to follow their own rules of order and procedure

    - They were the ones who were supposed to do an investigation and produce a credible charge against Jesus

    - Instead, they simply arrested Him and then began to pick at him until He gave them something they could bring Him down by

  - In retaliation for speaking the truth, the officers of the High Priest strike Jesus

    - And other mistreatment follows, which was just the beginning

  - Annas quickly grows frustrated and sends Jesus to Caiaphas

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- This ended the first trial, but essentially nothing was gained
    - No charge was confirmed so no verdict could be rendered
        - The way they are going about this process almost makes you wonder why they bothered to go through the process
            - This was typical for these men
            - They longed for the approval of men
        - Appearances were important to them
            - But appearances were all that mattered, but not the truth

- At this point in Luke's gospel, (v. 63) the account of jumps to the very end of the second trial, officiated by Caiaphas
    - We'll return to Luke's account in a minute
    - But before we get there, I want to fill in the gaps in the events of the trial as provided in the other gospels
        - As I've said before, since we're studying Luke, I prefer to stay as close to the text of Luke as possible without straying too far into the other gospels
        - But this is one case where I believe it's necessary to see all the detail
        - So we will take a few moments to see what transpired in this second trial before Caiaphas
- From John's gospel, we have already learned that Jesus was ushered into Caiaphas home for the second phase of the trial
    - Not only Caiaphas, but he has assembled the entire Sanhedrin

Mark 14:53 ¶ They led Jesus away to the high priest; and all the chief priests and the elders and the scribes *gathered together.

        - The 71 rulers of the nation of Israel, chief priests, elders, scribes, and the high priest himself

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- At least a couple of men were absent from this council that night, including Joseph of Arimathea who John says was a believer and was not in agreement with the death sentence

- So Annas' home had merely been a courtesy stop out of respect for Old Man Annas and his position within Israel

- But this is going to be the place where the real verdict would be rendered

- The success of this trial, as with any trial, depended on having good evidence of a crime

- And the best evidence, and the only kind of evidence that could work in these circumstances were credible witnesses

- Mark goes on to record how the Sanhedrin sought earnestly for witnesses against Jesus

- Yet they couldn't secure reliable witnesses

Mark 14:55 Now the chief priests and the whole Council kept trying to obtain testimony against Jesus to put Him to death, and they were not finding any.
Mark 14:56 For many were giving false testimony against Him, but their testimony was not consistent.
Mark 14:57 Some stood up and *began* to give false testimony against Him, saying,
Mark 14:58 "We heard Him say, 'I will destroy this temple made with hands, and in three days I will build another made without hands.'"
Mark 14:59 Not even in this respect was their testimony consistent.

- As Mark describes the scene, the entire council was looking for witnesses against Jesus, yet witnesses consistently disagreed with one another in the various details of their testimony

- These facts bring out a few more examples of violations of Jewish law committed by these religious leaders

- First, the trial is bring conducted in a home, and not the compound

- Secondly, Jewish law required that though all members of the council may argue for acquittal, not all members of the Sanhedrin are permitted to argue for guilt

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- But here we see the entire council seeking witnesses against Jesus, so as to put Him to death

- Third, the accused couldn't be condemned on the basis of witnesses' testimony unless their testimony agreed perfectly

  - You can see what these men are doing

  - They have canvassed the crowds that followed Jesus in the past week

  - And they are looking for anything to seize upon

    - Someone heard Jesus says He could destroy the temple and rebuild it

    - Remember that statement was made on the way out of the temple in full hearing of others

    - The full explanation didn't come until Jesus was on the Mount of Olives in private

  - But this example shows you how the conspiracy against Jesus worked

    - If anyone had anything negative to say against Jesus, they were invited to be witnesses at the trial

    - And who knows why people choose to come forward, but come forward they did

- I find it ironic that in the midst of these proceedings, the ones working so hard to find an accusation to make against this sinless man were the same ones violating their own law over and over again

- From here we go to Matt's gospel to follow the details of the trial before Caiaphas

Matt. 26:62 The high priest stood up and said to Him, "Do You not answer? What is it that these men are testifying against You?"
Matt. 26:63 But Jesus kept silent. And the high priest said to Him, "I adjure You by the living God, that You tell us whether You are the Christ, the Son of God."
Matt. 26:64 Jesus *said to him, "You have said it *yourself*; nevertheless I tell you, hereafter you will see THE SON OF MAN SITTING AT THE RIGHT HAND OF POWER, and COMING ON THE CLOUDS OF HEAVEN."
Matt. 26:65 ¶ Then the high priest tore his robes and said, "He has blasphemed! What further need do we have of witnesses? Behold, you have now heard the blasphemy;

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Matt. 26:66 what do you think?" They answered, "He deserves death!"

- After the testimony of the witnesses citing Jesus' comment about destroying, the high priest turns to Jesus and demands that he respond to the charges
    - In this demand, the high priest broke another rule of Jewish trials
        - A defendant couldn't testify against himself – no option
        - And here we see Jesus exercise His right to remain silent
    - This leads the High Priest to place Jesus under an oath
        - He says I adjure you (exorkizo) – to administer an oath
        - And then the High Priest says something fascinating
            - The high priest says tells us if you are the Christ, the Son of God – the Messiah
        - What caused him to ask that question?
            - One moment he was asking about charges related to showing disrespect for the Temple
            - The next he's asking Jesus if He's the Messiah
    - Simply by asking this question the high priest is condemning himself
        - For by the question he is admitting his knowledge of Jesus' claim to be the Messiah
            - Now we know that he didn't accept it
            - But the only explanation for him asking the question the way he did was that he had knowledge of Jesus' claim to messiahship
                - This man knew the Jesus has a credible claim to be the Messiah but refused to accept it
                - He knew enough to know that if he placed Jesus under oath and asked the question, he would get an affirmative answer

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- In response, Jesus points out that the High Priest himself had brought up the issue of Messiah and had stated the claim
  - Jesus then said that there would be a day in the future when they would be required to acknowledge the truth themselves when they see Christ's return to earth in power
  - That's an important thing for all of us to remember
    - There is a day appointed by God when the entire world will know that Jesus is His Son
    - And God is content to wait until that day to bring that knowledge to the entire world
      - In the meantime, we all wait together

- The high priest then responds by tearing his clothes, and asking the council if they need witnesses, in light of Jesus' statement
  - This statement violated numerous Jewish laws
    - For example, the HP couldn't tear his clothes to incite the council
    - They couldn't condemn without witnesses
    - They couldn't condemn on the testimony of the accused
    - They couldn't pronounce judgment on the same day as the trial
    - The charge of blasphemy was only appropriate if the accused spoke the name of God
- At this point, we can rejoin Luke's account

Luke 22:63 ¶ Now the men who were holding Jesus in custody were mocking Him and beating Him,
Luke 22:64 and they blindfolded Him and were asking Him, saying, "Prophesy, who is the one who hit You?"
Luke 22:65 And they were saying many other things against Him, blaspheming.

- The injustice continues, after the verdict has been rendered by the council, the guards take advantage of the opportunity to mistreat the prisoner in their custody

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- They mock him and beat him
  - It's so easy to read past those words and fail to appreciate the degree of mistreatment taking place
    - A beating by a group of men is a severely painful experience
    - And in the blindfolding, they could take a punch when Jesus wasn't' expecting it and the body couldn't be prepared to take the punch
  - The urge to run, to save himself must have been increasing with the sting of each punch
- But consider who it is
  - He is God
    - He spoke the creation into existence
    - With one word, He could bring everyone who hit him or insulted him to the pit of hell
    - He could call a legion of angels to his side
    - With one word from His mouth he stilled storms on the Sea of Galilee
    - He cast out demons
    - He is the deity who created everyone of these men who now assault Him
  - No matter how long I ponder this, I can't get my mind around it
    - This is the Biblical definition of love
    - To lay one's life down for friends
    - That while were still enemies of God, Christ died for us
    - All the while that Jesus is being beaten, He is fulfilling His purpose of dying so that perhaps someone in that very room would one day be saved from their sin

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- Then the final moment of the second religious trial

Luke 22:66 ¶ When it was day, the Council of elders of the people assembled, both chief priests and scribes, and they led Him away to their council *chamber*, saying,
Luke 22:67 "If You are the Christ, tell us." But He said to them, "If I tell you, you will not believe;
Luke 22:68 and if I ask a question, you will not answer.
Luke 22:69 "But from now on THE SON OF MAN WILL BE SEATED AT THE RIGHT HAND of the power OF GOD."
Luke 22:70 And they all said, "Are You the Son of God, then?" And He said to them, "Yes, I am."
Luke 22:71 Then they said, "What further need do we have of testimony? For we have heard it ourselves from His own mouth."

- The council tries to maintain at least the appearance of respectability,
    - Though they had already arrived at the verdict, they waited until daybreak to conclude the trial so that they could appear to abide by the rules against conducting trials at night
    - Not only that, but they move the trial to the council chamber, which was in the Temple compound
    - They essentially re-enact the core element of the trial for the sake of the crowd
        - Now of course, the crowd isn't necessarily aware that this trial started earlier
        - The whole point of this trial was to give it a sense of legitimacy in the eye of the people
    - They again ask Jesus to say whether He was the Christ
        - Jesus says why bother?
        - If I were to tell you, you wouldn't believe me
            - In other words, the only point in me testifying of myself is for the purpose of bringing faith
            - But if faith isn't going to the result of my testimony, then there is no point in the confession
        - Secondly, Jesus says if I ask, you wouldn't answer

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- This is another damning statement
- Jesus is basically saying that if I were to ask you what you thought about me, you would stay silent
- He's referring to the way they refused to answer anytime He asked them who they thought he was

- They wouldn't answer because they were always faced with the dilemma of how to deny who He was in light of all that Jesus had done to prove Himself
  - They couldn't agree with Jesus, of course,
  - But they couldn't refute the claim either because they couldn't otherwise explain away Jesus' power and words
- Likewise here, Jesus says if I asked you to address these same claims, you wouldn't answer me
  - Which is an acknowledgement in itself that you know the proof and you nevertheless refuse to accept it
  - Therefore, Jesus' witnessing would be pointless

- But then He says that He will be gone and seated in His proper place at the right hand of God

- Finally, I think Jesus senses it's time to put an end to the charade
  - They ask Him the question yet again
  - Are you the Son of God?
    - And Jesus answers plainly I am.
    - For those who try to tell you that Jesus never claimed to be God, you can bring them here
  - And as expected, his statement brought the council what they were looking for
    - It was a true statement, but because they refused to believe it, they considered it blasphemy

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- So the charge going forward into Chapter 23 and the trial before Pilate will be blasphemy

- A charge that Pilate couldn't care less about – not a charge that the Romans would even think to act upon

Luke 23:1 ¶ Then the whole body of them got up and brought Him before Pilate.
Luke 23:2 And they began to accuse Him, saying, "We found this man misleading our nation and forbidding to pay taxes to Caesar, and saying that He Himself is Christ, a King."
Luke 23:3 So Pilate asked Him, saying, "Are You the King of the Jews?" And He answered him and said, "*It is as* you say."
Luke 23:4 Then Pilate said to the chief priests and the crowds, "I find no guilt in this man."
Luke 23:5 But they kept on insisting, saying, "He stirs up the people, teaching all over Judea, starting from Galilee even as far as this place."

- By this point, we are at the early morning hours of Thursday
    - Jesus hasn't slept in nearly 36 hours
    - He's been beaten, probably to the point where his face has been bloodied
    - His sides ache
    - He's been spat upon
- And as He stands before Pilate, the group of religious leaders who brought him to Pilate are worked up into a tizzy
    - Pontus Pilate was the governor of Judea, and he normally resided in Caesarea
        - He would have been in Jerusalem because of the need to provide extra security during the Passover
        - We know that Judas would have been required to testify before Pilate Wednesday night to obtain an indictment against Jesus
            - This could explain why Pilate was up and dressed early to receive this group on Thursday
            - He was expecting the prisoner who was indicted to be presented before him for trial

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- In Luke's gospel, we see the Jews jumping to new accusations before Pilate
    - Accusations that would have gained the support of the Roman governor
    - But these were not the charges made during the religious trial
- And in fact, the religious leaders didn't start with these accusations
    - In John's gospel we see how the encounter started

John 18:28 ¶ Then they *led Jesus from Caiaphas into the Praetorium, and it was early; and they themselves did not enter into the Praetorium so that they would not be defiled, but might eat the Passover.
John 18:29 Therefore Pilate went out to them and *said, "What accusation do you bring against this Man?"
John 18:30 They answered and said to him, "If this Man were not an evildoer, we would not have delivered Him to you."
John 18:31 So Pilate said to them, "Take Him yourselves, and judge Him according to your law." The Jews said to him, "We are not permitted to put anyone to death,"
John 18:32 to fulfill the word of Jesus which He spoke, signifying by what kind of death He was about to die.

- As they first bring Jesus to Pilate, they have no charge to bring
    - They merely expect Pilate to accept their own pronouncement of guilt
    - Why don't they have a charge and a case to make against Jesus?
        - Because the charge of blasphemy is not a crime to the Romans
    - And Pilate appreciates this fact as he makes his response
        - He says if He violated your law, judge him yourself according to your law
    - But then they say, we can't because we can't put him to death
        - This is Pilate's first clue that they are requesting the death penalty
    - John's comment that this was to fulfill scripture is a reference to the manner of Jesus' death

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- Because only the Romans could carry out the death penalty, Jesus' manner of death would be different than if the Jews could carry out the penalty
    - Jews would stone
    - Romans would crucify
    - And scripture called for Jesus to be lifted up, to hung on a tree between criminals
    - So this was a fulfillment of scripture

- Pick up here next week…

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Luke 23A

- Jesus' long night (or nightmare) continues, as we return to Luke's account of the midnight trial of Jesus
    - Last week we examined the religious trial
        - A two-part affair, some might say a three part affair,
        - With Jesus tried once at the home of the first high priest, Annas
        - The a second time at the home of the other high priest, Caiaphas, and members of the Sanhedrin
        - Finally, Caiaphas moves the Sanhedren trial into the Temple at dawn to make the verdict official give some credibility to an otherwise joke of a trial
    - In the end, the religious leaders reach the pre-determined verdict of guilt and pronounce the death sentence upon Jesus
        - But as we discussed last week, the Jews were powerless in their own land to actually carry out this verdict
        - They must appeal to the Romans to gain their agreement with the verdict and to carry out the sentence of death
        - Thus the stage has been set for the trial before Pilate
- We studied the first five verses of Chapter 23 last week, and I will re-read them now simply to give us context and we move forward in the text

Luke 23:1 ¶ Then the whole body of them got up and brought Him before Pilate.
Luke 23:2 And they began to accuse Him, saying, "We found this man misleading our nation and forbidding to pay taxes to Caesar, and saying that He Himself is Christ, a King."
Luke 23:3 So Pilate asked Him, saying, "Are You the King of the Jews?" And He answered him and said, "*It is as* you say."
Luke 23:4 Then Pilate said to the chief priests and the crowds, "I find no guilt in this man."
Luke 23:5 But they kept on insisting, saying, "He stirs up the people, teaching all over Judea, starting from Galilee even as far as this place."

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- By way of review, we need to cover two things from last week
    - First, we noted that the Jews did not bring to Pilate the same charge they used against Jesus in their religious trial
        - At the religious trial, they convicted Jesus of blasphemy, and wrongly so of course
        - But here, they do not mention the charge of blasphemy
            - Instead, they toss out an assortment of civil charges hoping something will stick and prompt Pilate to act against Jesus
            - In fact, John in his gospel tells us that their first tactic with Pilate was to not even name a charge against Jesus in the expectation that Pilate would just go along with whatever they wanted
        - But Pilate isn't playing their game
            - He sees the pathetic person of Jesus before him, bloodied, beaten, obviously not a warrior or revolutionary
            - And he quickly determines that whatever Jesus did to upset the Jewish leaders, he certainly isn't a threat to Rome
            - He says I find no guilt in this man
    - The second thing to remember from last week is the important detail in verse 5.
        - In the tirade of charges against Jesus, the Jewish leaders blurt out that the man has been teaching all the way from Galilee to Judea
            - This comment got Pilate's attention

Luke 23:6 ¶ When Pilate heard it, he asked whether the man was a Galilean.
Luke 23:7 And when he learned that He belonged to Herod's jurisdiction, he sent Him to Herod, who himself also was in Jerusalem at that time.

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- The Jews' reference to the Galilee gave Pilate a convenient opportunity to pass the buck
    - And it introduces a new character into the drama - Herod
    - At the time of Jesus' death, Rome ruled most of Judea through governors or procurators who held the power of life and death over the province
        - These leaders were agents appointed by Rome to police the people and collect taxes
            - They usually had a small contingent of Roman soldiers at their disposal (about 3000)
            - And these men often took a variety of titles
                - Usually governor or prefect
                - Occasionally tetrarch or ethnarch
                - And in a couple of occasions, these men might gain the title of King of the Jews, either by self-decree or as a result of a decree of the Roman senate
        - One of these men, Herod the Great, was appointed to rule Judea from 37 - 4BC
            - He began as governor of Galilee in 43 BC and eventually rose to power through artful politics with Mark Antony and Octavian
            - And the Roman senate elected him King of the Jews in 37 BC
            - Though he claimed to be a Jew, he was actually descended from the Edomites, Esau
            - So he was never accepted by Jews as a true king, but his power and legacy are still well known today
        - When Herod the great died in 4BC, the kingdom of Judea was divided into fourths
            - Three of Herod's sons were appointed as tetrarchs by Rome to rule over these fourths,

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- Archelaus gained two fourths of the kingdom including Judea and Samaria
- Herod Antipas became ruler of the northern part of Judea, known as Galilee
- Herod Philip received modern day Syria & Lebanon
    - Herod Philip was the one accused of immorality by John the Baptist

- By the time of the events of Luke 23, Herod Archelaus had been diposed by Rome for excessive cruelty to the Jews and for offenses against the Mosaic Law
    - In Archlaus' place, the Romans continued to rule Judea directly through Roman governors like Pilate
- Leaving only Herod Antipas remaining to share power in Judea
    - So the Herod mentioned here in Luke 23 is Herod Antipas, ruler of the Galilee

- Like Pilate, Herod didn't live in Jerusalem but had traveled down to be in town for the Passover
    - Pilate was there to keep the peace and Herod was there presumably to honor the Passover since his family claimed to be Jewish royalty
        - So the mention of the Galilee gives Pilate an easy way to offload this problem
        - He sends Jesus to Herod, since technically Jesus is subject to Herod's authority
            - Now remember, the right to imposed capital punishment on Jesus inside Judea still belonged to Pilate
            - So even were Herod to declare that Jesus should be put to death, it would require Pilate to issue the order
            - Nevertheless, Pilate is giving Herod the chance to make the first decision about Jesus' disposition

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Luke 23:8 ¶ Now Herod was very glad when he saw Jesus; for he had wanted to see Him for a long time, because he had been hearing about Him and was hoping to see some sign performed by Him.
Luke 23:9 And he questioned Him at some length; but He answered him nothing.
Luke 23:10 And the chief priests and the scribes were standing there, accusing Him vehemently.
Luke 23:11 And Herod with his soldiers, after treating Him with contempt and mocking Him, dressed Him in a gorgeous robe and sent Him back to Pilate.
Luke 23:12 Now Herod and Pilate became friends with one another that very day; for before they had been enemies with each other.

- We saw mentioned way back in Chapter 9 of Herod's interest in meeting Jesus
    - Ever since the storied of Jesus' miracles had reached Herod after the execution of John the Baptist, Herod has wanted to meet Jesus
        - And it was in Chapter 13 that the Pharisees had tried to keep Jesus from traveling to Jerusalem by claiming that Herod was seeking to kill Jesus
        - And now Jesus stands before Herod
    - Obviously, Herod's only interest in Jesus was as a magician or miracle worker
        - Herod certainly had no spiritual interest in Jesus
        - So when he received Jesus, he took some time to question Jesus , about what we can't be sure
    - Interestingly, the chief priests and scribes were there as well continually to accuse Jesus
        - These guys are following Jesus everywhere He is sent and continue to do their best to obtain some kind of conviction or charge against Him
        - Do you see the work of the enemy at work here?
            - These men were being used by the enemy to accomplish Satan's purpose in his battle against God
            - They are puppets, and Jesus refuses to participate in this scheme of the Devil

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- He merely submits patiently to the abuse

- Can you imagine how spiritually dark that room must have been?

- Inevitably, the interrogation turns into sport, as Herod encourages his soldiers to mock and abuse Jesus

    - Then as an inside joke to Pilate, Herod returns Jesus dressed in an elegant robe

        - As Luke mentions, Herod had long been enemies with Pilate

            - The reason probably stemmed from Herod's connection to his father Herod the Great

            - As a descendent of the great king Herod, Antipas desired to be elevated to the position his father held – King of the Jews, ruler of Judea

            - But if he were to ever obtain that title from the Roman Senate, it would be displacing the Roman governor Pilate

        - So naturally, each man was suspicious of the other

    - But by sending Jesus to Herod, Pilate had sent the equivalent of an olive branch to Herod

        - It was a tacit recognition of Herod's authority over the Galilee that Pilate would send Jesus to him for judgment

            - And Pilate probably also knew that Herod had a personal interest in Jesus

        - Herod had absolutely no appreciation of the importance of who Jesus was

            - Jesus was just an insignificant figure of passing interest to Herod

            - But the fact that Pilate had been willing to submit to Herod's authority was a hugely significant event to Herod

        - So after entertaining himself at Jesus' expense for a short time, Herod sends Jesus back to Pilate dressed as if Jesus were King of the Jews

            - The message here was unmistakable for Pilate

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- Just as Pilate had shown Herod respect by recognizing Herod's authority
- Now Herod returned the favor in a playful way by sending the "King of the Jews" back to Pilate to submit to his authority
- It was a way suggesting that Herod's desire for kingship was not to be a threat to Pilate's rule

- And so they became friends

- The end of Herod's life offers an interesting contrast to the events of Luke 23
  - Herod never gave up hope to become king of the Jews
  - You may remember Herod's wife, Herodius
    - She was the one who had used seduction to get her husband to put John the Baptist to death
  - And likewise, she eventually convinced her husband to travel to Rome to appeal to Caesar to be made king of the Jews
    - When Herod appears before Caligula, instead of receiving the title king, Herod and Herodius are disposed from power and banished to Gaul (western Europe)
    - They both die there living in poverty
  - So though Herod stands over Jesus in power and wealth as Jesus stands pitifully weak and humble
    - At the end of his life, Herod lived as a pauper, destitute
    - And upon his judgment day, Herod will stand before the very same Jesus who once stood before him
    - And Jesus will pronounce Herod's sentence to his shame
  - Ultimate justice isn't found in this life, but it is found

Luke 23:13 ¶ Pilate summoned the chief priests and the rulers and the people,
Luke 23:14 and said to them, "You brought this man to me as one who incites the people to rebellion, and behold, having examined Him before you, I have found no guilt in this man regarding the charges which you make against Him.

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Luke 23:15 "No, nor has Herod, for he sent Him back to us; and behold, nothing deserving death has been done by Him.
Luke 23:16 "Therefore I will punish Him and release Him."
Luke 23:17 [Now he was obliged to release to them at the feast one prisoner.]
Luke 23:18 ¶ But they cried out all together, saying, "Away with this man, and release for us Barabbas!"
Luke 23:19 (He was one who had been thrown into prison for an insurrection made in the city, and for murder.)
Luke 23:20 Pilate, wanting to release Jesus, addressed them again,
Luke 23:21 but they kept on calling out, saying, "Crucify, crucify Him!"
Luke 23:22 And he said to them the third time, "Why, what evil has this man done? I have found in Him no guilt *demanding* death; therefore I will punish Him and release Him."
Luke 23:23 But they were insistent, with loud voices asking that He be crucified. And their voices *began* to prevail.
Luke 23:24 And Pilate pronounced sentence that their demand be granted.
Luke 23:25 And he released the man they were asking for who had been thrown into prison for insurrection and murder, but he delivered Jesus to their will.

- After receiving Jesus back from Herod, the civil trial concludes where it started – with Pilate
    - Pilate brings the religious leaders together and the people, we're told
        - And Pilate works incredibly hard to avoid crucifying Jesus
        - As with the earlier religious trial, we need to look at the other Gospels to understand all that happens at this point, because Luke records only an abbreviated portion of it
    - Pilate's first attempt to release Jesus is recorded in verse 13 through 16
        - The reason is simple: Pilate sees no basis to condemn this man – he's been found innocent of sedition or treason
    - The Luke make s a passing reference to Pilate's second attempt to release Jesus
        - In Mark we see a more complete picture of this second attempt, which involved a murderer name Barrabas

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Mark 15:7 The man named Barabbas had been imprisoned with the insurrectionists who had committed murder in the insurrection.
Mark 15:8 The crowd went up and began asking him *to do* as he had been accustomed to do for them.
Mark 15:9 Pilate answered them, saying, "Do you want me to release for you the King of the Jews?"
Mark 15:10 For he was aware that the chief priests had handed Him over because of envy.
Mark 15:11 But the chief priests stirred up the crowd *to ask* him to release Barabbas for them instead.

- Pilate attempts to force the crowd into selecting Jesus by offering as their only alternative a man named Barabbas
    - Barabbas was a murderer and insurrectionist
    - Not a man loved by anyone, and certainly not someone who the crowd would have naturally preferred to see released
    - Pilate is banking on the crowd choosing Jesus over Barrabas for release
        - The name Barabbas means son of the father
        - Interestingly, some sources claim that Barabbas's full name was Jesus Barabbas
    - So Jesus Son of the Father stands next to Jesus son of the father
        - Both accused of sedition or rebellion against Rome
        - The crowd chose life for the imposter and death for the truth Son
    - We're also told that Pilate had become aware that the real motive of the religious leaders was envy against Jesus
        - Pilate had come to understand that Jesus wasn't a true threat to anyone except to the power of the religious leaders
        - And so Pilate had no interest in allowing these leaders to manipulate him
        - But Mark records their manipulation in verse 11
            - These leaders were the ones working the crowd to persuade them to ask for Barabbas over Jesus

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- And when the crowd again called out for Barabbas to be released, Pilate's second attempt to release Jesus was foiled

- But Pilate isn't done yet…he still sees no reason to give in to the demands of the leaders nor of the crowd they have incited

    - Luke's narrative simply notes that Pilate addressed them a third time asking what had Jesus done?

        - Pilate still doesn't understand the origin of the crowd's hatred of Jesus?

    - We have to go to John's gospel to see the details surrounding Pilate's third attempt to release Jesus

John 19:1 ¶ Pilate then took Jesus and scourged Him.
John 19:2 And the soldiers twisted together a crown of thorns and put it on His head, and put a purple robe on Him;
John 19:3 and they *began* to come up to Him and say, "Hail, King of the Jews!" and to give Him slaps *in the face*.
John 19:4 Pilate came out again and *said to them, "Behold, I am bringing Him out to you so that you may know that I find no guilt in Him."
John 19:5 Jesus then came out, wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe. *Pilate* *said to them, "Behold, the Man!"
John 19:6 So when the chief priests and the officers saw Him, they cried out saying, "Crucify, crucify!" Pilate *said to them, "Take Him yourselves and crucify Him, for I find no guilt in Him."

- We can see Pilate's frustration growing here

    - After his second attempt to release Jesus, he takes Jesus out and has him scourged

        - This is a devastating form of punishment

            - A man is whipped forty times all over his body, not just his back

            - The whip has pieces of glass and metal tied to the end of the leather so that they cut deeply into the flesh ripping out pieces

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- Creating deep lacerations
- It would cut away so much flesh that it often exposed bones or internal organs

- Scourging often result in death all by itself
  - And in fact in Isaiah tells us that Jesus was so disfigured, that he no longer had human likeness

Is. 52:13 See, my servant will act wisely; he will be raised and lifted up and highly exalted.
Is. 52:14 Just as there were many who were appalled at him — his appearance was so disfigured beyond that of any man and his form marred beyond human likeness —
Is. 52:15 so will he sprinkle many nations, and kings will shut their mouths because of him. For what they were not told, they will see, and what they have not heard, they will understand.

- Then some inventive soldier thought it would be funny to give Jesus a crown
  - Only they made one of thorns
  - So that when they placed it on his head, the thorns stuck into his head, covering his face with blood
  - And then they struck him more and placed that same robe back on him
- With this having been done, Pilate now brings Jesus before the crowd again
  - We can now see Pilate's purpose in this plan
    - It's one of sympathy
    - How could a crowd not look upon this man in such a hideous state and not take pity on him
    - Pilate expects the crowd to see Jesus and be moved to compassion
  - And perhaps the tactic might have worked

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- Because we're told it was the leaders who began the chanting again to have Jesus crucified
- Don't you get the impression that the crowd itself may have actually been silenced at first by the brutality evident in Jesus' wounds

- And sensing that the tide might be turning, the leaders step up their cries
- To this Pilate, says crucify him yourself
  - You can almost hear the disgust in Pilate's voice
  - He's disgusted at the relentless envy and conspiracy of these leaders
    - Despite all that Pilate has done to avoid an injustice, these men are determined to have Jesus' blood
- And so Pilate's attempt to free Jesus a third time is thwarted

- Then John tells us of a fourth attempt by Pilate to free Jesus

John 19:7 The Jews answered him, "We have a law, and by that law He ought to die because He made Himself out *to be* the Son of God."
John 19:8 ¶ Therefore when Pilate heard this statement, he was *even* more afraid;
John 19:9 and he entered into the Praetorium again and *said to Jesus, "Where are You from?" But Jesus gave him no answer.
John 19:10 So Pilate *said to Him, "You do not speak to me? Do You not know that I have authority to release You, and I have authority to crucify You?"
John 19:11 Jesus answered, "You would have no authority over Me, unless it had been given you from above; for this reason he who delivered Me to you has *the* greater sin."
John 19:12 As a result of this Pilate made efforts to release Him, but the Jews cried out saying, "If you release this Man, you are no friend of Caesar; everyone who makes himself out *to be* a king opposes Caesar."

- Pilate had just told the Jews to crucify Jesus themselves
  - Which was really a flippant comment, because Pilate and everyone else knew they couldn't crucify Jesus – only Pilate could make that happen
  - And now the Jewish leadership drops all pretense and give Pilate the true reason they hate Jesus

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- They refer to their own law, and say that Jesus has claimed to be the Son of God
- Having heard the true reason for their hatred of Jesus, Pilate grows afraid
    - He brings Jesus back into the Praetorium to question Him
    - Jesus refuses to answer his questions, and in his exasperation, Pilate says don't you know I can decide your fate
    - Jesus says you have no authority except as the Father has granted it
    - Therefore, the one who delivered me to you has the greater sin

- What a clear and compelling statement of God' sovereignty over the affairs of men
    - Pilate was doing only what God permitted
    - Was Pilate sinning? Yes, despite his awareness that Jesus was innocent, nevertheless he goes along with the Jews
        - Pilate shares in the guilt of the Messiah's death
    - But like all men, Pilate is an instrument of God
        - As creator, God has unrival authority over that creation, to include using the sin of men to accomplish His purpose
        - No good God vs bad God
        - All these events were foretold by God, directed by God and according to God's will
            - And even though Pilate didn't know that he was operating according to God's plan, he was
            - God doesn't require that we know what He's doing through us in order to be able to use us
            - It His grace that He allows us to be aware of His work through us

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Gen. 18:17 The LORD said, "Shall I hide from Abraham what I am about to do,

- Then Jesus says that the sin of he who delivered Him was greater
  - Jesus could be speaking of Judas, but He could also be speaking of Caiaphas, since it was the High Priest's verdict that directly led to Jesus coming before Pilate
  - His sin was greater on the basis that it was the High Priest and the other leaders who had determined to seek Jesus death
    - Pilate was simply to become the instrument of that death
    - God would use Pilate's sin to bring Jesus to death
  - But God will ultimately hold the Jewish leader and the leadership overall responsible for the death of His Son
    - And the city of Jerusalem will be judged in AD 70 as a result of that sin

- Finally, in verse 12 the leaders pull out the last card they hold
  - They basically threaten Pilate
  - If he doesn't side with them against Jesus, they will claim that he is not a friend of Caesar
    - Since anyone he doesn't oppose a person claiming to be a king can't be a friend of Caesar
      - Pilate came to power as a result of an influential Roman senator, Sejanus
      - Sejanus had been executed for treason, so now Rome was investigating any of Sejanus' friends
      - Pilate would have been especially nervous about any accusation that he wasn't Caesar's friend
  - At this point, Pilate relents and sits in the judgment seat and declares that Jesus would be crucified
    - Matt and Mark include the detail that Pilate washed his hands before the crowd

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- Could Pilate truly divorce himself from the sin of crucifying Jesus?
    - Jesus himself said Pilate's sin was less but not zero
- Just because a person can find others who prompt their behavior, it doesn't change the fact that they agreed to participate

- Pilate was guilty of putting Jesus to death
    - As was the Jewish crowd who took the advice of the leaders egging them on
    - And of course, the leaders themselves were the chief sinners
    - And so were you and I
        - For Jesus death was conceived and carried out by the Father as a response to your sin and mine
        - In a very real sense, it was you and I who called for His death from within that crowd
- Now consider that it was the Father who stood by all the time this took place and orchestrated the events to ensure the desired outcome of Jesus' death at the hands of these evil men
- What kind of God does this for His creation?
    - A God that demonstrates His love for us by this: that while we were still sinners Christ died for us.

- It's probably a little after 8:00 am on Thursday morning
    - Jesus is on his way to the cross…
    -

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Luke 23B

- When we left Chapter 23 last week, the trial of the Jesus had concluded, and the necessary though unjust verdict had been reached
    - Even though Pilate knew Jesus to be innocent, nevertheless he pronounced a verdict of death against him
    - And as Luke records it in verse 25, Pilate handed Jesus over to their will
        - "Their will" of course meant the will of the people, of the crowd
        - But even more specifically, it meant the will of the religious leaders who had instigated the whole affair, leading the people to cry out for Jesus' crucifixion
- And in those days, they wasted no time in carrying out the punishment
    - There were no appeals…who would you appeal to?
    - There was no reason to delay
        - You would just end up feeding and housing a condemned man
    - And today was the day of preparation before the Sabbath on the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread
        - The Jews didn't want the execution to take place on a Sabbath
        - And in fact, as we'll see in a short while, the Jews were even anxious to get Jesus' body down from the cross so that it might be buried prior to the Sabbath
        - But before we get ahead of ourselves, we join Jesus now as He is taken from Pilate and led to somewhere in the street to take Pick up His cross

Luke 23:26 ¶ When they led Him away, they seized a man, Simon of Cyrene, coming in from the country, and placed on him the cross to carry behind Jesus.
Luke 23:27 ¶ And following Him was a large crowd of the people, and of women who were mourning and lamenting Him.
Luke 23:28 But Jesus turning to them said, "Daughters of Jerusalem, stop weeping for Me, but weep for yourselves and for your children.
Luke 23:29 "For behold, the days are coming when they will say, 'Blessed are the barren, and the wombs that never bore, and the breasts that never nursed.'

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Luke 23:30 "Then they will begin TO SAY TO THE MOUNTAINS, 'FALL ON US,' AND TO THE HILLS, 'COVER US.'
Luke 23:31 "For if they do these things when the tree is green, what will happen when it is dry?"

- Jesus, we're told, is taken away after the verdict
    - Matt and Mark tells us that before Jesus begins His walk to Golgotha, the Romans removed his purple gown given to Him by Herod
    - And placed his own clothes back on his bleeding body
        - Matt and Mark also mention that the soldiers whip Jesus more for good measure
    - And this background helps explain why we hear about Simon the Cyrene
        - Normally, a criminal condemned to execution is forced to carry his own cross beam to the place of his execution
            - He didn't carry the entire cross
            - He usually carried only the cross beam
            - It was heavy but generally it could be carried by an adult male
        - Here we see Jesus unable to carry the beam himself
            - This is clearly the result of the extreme trauma He experienced as the hands of the Romans
            - His body is so weakened that if the Romans want to complete this execution, they will have to make a concession to allow someone else to carry the beam on Jesus' behalf
- So at this moment, a man named Simon of Cyrene has come in from the country
    - Cyrene was a land in North Africa, so he's a gentile
        - Which makes sense, because no Jew would have allowed himself to involved in an execution on the Passover
    - And he suddenly finds himself caught up in procession to Golgotha

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- So he's pressed into service
- I wonder did Simon know who Jesus was?
- Had he even heard of Him? I suspect so

- The imagery here is quite remarkable
  - With Jesus leading the way, Simon picks up His cross and follows Jesus
    - Does that ring any bell with you?

Mark 8:34 ¶ And He summoned the crowd with His disciples, and said to them, "If anyone wishes to come after Me, he must deny himself, and take up his cross and follow Me.

- If the disciples wanted to be like their teacher, they only needed to learn from the example set by the unsuspecting Simon of Cyrene
  - In fact, I wonder where are the disciples at this point
    - Do you notice that they are noticeably absent from Luke's description of the crowd
    - They aren't anywhere to be found
      - Within this large crowd of followers, Luke only makes special mention of the women who follow along mourning and wailing loudly.
      - The disciples seem to have vanished – not a one there to offer even tears
    - I wonder if the significance of this man's name hit home for the disciples later
      - Simon the Cyrene walks behind Jesus to His crucifixion obediently carrying His cross
      - Simon the Rock, who vowed to never leave Christ's side even to the death, is missing in action
    - While it's east to sit in judgment of Peter here today, 6 thousand miles and 2000 years away from the event

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- So instead of picking on Peter, perhaps we should ask ourselves which Simon we would have been has we been there

- And I especially wonder which Simon we are today?

    - Are we prone to walk away from following Jesus when times get tough?

- Even the laziest preacher could preach a month of Sundays on the topic of staying close to Jesus in desperate times

    - And so I don't intend to cover that well worn ground tonight, except to remind us of one thing

    - Even when we are faithless, He is faithful, because He cannot deny Himself

        - And since the Holy Spirit resides in each of us, never to depart, the Lord can never forsake us

    - Therefore, even if we run from the trials brought upon us for our faith, can we ever fully escape them?

        - Since we never cease to be a child of God, can we ever gain anything by hiding our faith from others?

        - In the end, did the disciples escape persecution simply because they ran away during Jesus' trial or crucifixion?

    - So isn't better to stand firm in our days now, and let what come may,

        - so that at least when we one day stand before our Lord we might be received as one who was faithful?

- Luke then goes on to record Jesus' comments to the crowd that followed

    - And more specifically, Jesus addresses the women in the crowd

        - By the way, it was customary in that day for professional mourners to follow a condemned man

            - It was a curious tradition, but woman would often take up the duty of wailing and mourning for the condemned regardless of whether they even knew Him

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- In Jesus case, I have no doubt the mourning is largely authentic, even if there were a few professional mourners mixed in

- And then Jesus turns to them and says don't mourn for me, mourn for yourselves
  - And then Jesus quotes from Hosea 10:8
- The verse Jesus quotes includes the phrase, "They will say to the mountains, 'Cover us!" And to the hills, fall on us
  - But to fully appreciate why those words appear there and what they mean, we need to look at the context of that chapter of Hosea

Hos. 10:1 ¶ Israel is a luxuriant vine;
He produces fruit for himself.
The more his fruit,
The more altars he made;
The richer his land,
The better he made the *sacred* pillars.
Hos. 10:2 Their heart is faithless;
Now they must bear their guilt.
The LORD will break down their altars
And destroy their *sacred* pillars.
Hos. 10:3 ¶ Surely now they will say, "We have no king,
For we do not revere the LORD.
As for the king, what can he do for us?"
Hos. 10:4 They speak *mere* words,
With worthless oaths they make covenants;
And judgment sprouts like poisonous weeds in the furrows of the field.
Hos. 10:8 Also the high places of Aven, the sin of Israel, will be destroyed;
Thorn and thistle will grow on their altars;
Then they will say to the mountains,
"Cover us!" And to the hills, "Fall on us!"
Hos. 10:10 When it is My desire, I will chastise them;
And the peoples will be gathered against them
When they are bound for their double guilt.
Hos. 10:12 Sow with a view to righteousness,
Reap in accordance with kindness;
Break up your fallow ground,
For it is time to seek the LORD
Until He comes to rain righteousness on you.
Hos. 10:13 You have plowed wickedness, you have reaped injustice,

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You have eaten the fruit of lies.
Because you have trusted in your way, in your numerous warriors,
Hos. 10:14 Therefore a tumult will arise among your people,
And all your fortresses will be destroyed,
As Shalman destroyed Beth-arbel on the day of battle,
When mothers were dashed in pieces with *their* children.
Hos. 10:15 Thus it will be done to you at Bethel because of your great wickedness.
At dawn the king of Israel will be completely cut off.

- Even from just the parts of the chapter that I read, it's easy to see that the theme is judgment for Israel's unfaithfulness and sin
    - And in a day the Lord appoints, they will be chastened
        - They will suffer His wrath for their national sins
        - They will wish that mountains would fall on them to put an end to the misery
    - Now, Hosea's prophecy is referring to the coming judgment of the nation of Israel which takes place during the time of Tribulation
        - You can even see Jesus speaking similar words spoken by the men of the Tribulation at the end of Chapter 6 of Revelation after the sixth seal is opened
    - So when Jesus turns to the women on the way to His death and quotes these words from Hosea
        - We know these words are associated with God's judgment poured out on Israel for unfaithfulness
        - So we can understand them here to be a prediction of coming judgment for a similar offense
            - On the one hand, they can simply refer to the same event as Hosea
            - The judgment that will come upon the nation of Israel in the days of Tribulation
                - Days God has specifically set aside as payment for their violation of His covenant and for their rejection of the Messiah

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        - So, clearly included in the meaning of this statement is a reference to the coming tribulation upon Israel in the last days

    - But it's also fair to say that a more timely event is also on Jesus mind

        - The same one that was on His mind as He enter Jerusalem a week earlier

        - The coming destruction of the city at the hands of the Romans

    - And in that day of judgment, it will be a horrible day

        - Somewhere between 1-2 million Jews lost their lives in that siege

            - But the destruction of the city was preceded by a nearly 2 year long siege that almost starved the entire city

                - The situation in the city became so desperate that at the end, women were willing to eat their own afterbirth as they miscarried their children

            - And obviously, the children alive at that time suffered greatly as the entire city lived under a fear of impending doom

            - Severe judgment indeed

        - And it will be circumstances like those that lead mothers to actually be jealous of women who have no children

- And then Jesus adds a proverbial saying of that day

    - A proverbial saying is a colorful turn of a phrase that succinctly communicates an accepted truth or wisdom

        - Like you can lead a horse to water, but you can't make him drink

        - Or a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush

        - Give Steve 30 minutes to talk, he'll take 60

    - So Jesus uses a proverbial saying – a saying that would have been well known and understood in that day – to emphasize the point

        - He says for if they do these things when the tree is green, what will happen when it is dry?

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- There is no literal tree here
    - Just like there is no horse or bird in the earlier proverbs I used
    - They merely stand for something else
- The picture here is of how hot a fire burns
    - If fire burns hot on green wood, how hot will it burn on dry wood?
    - And the fire is a picture of wrath and anger

- By using this proverb, Jesus is reinforcing His warning about their future
    - The "they" here are the Romans and probably God as well
        - If the Roman's viciousness is this bad for someone like Jesus, when things are relatively good for the Jews
            - when the Romans are sympathetic to the Jews
        - How bad do you think things will get when they are mad at the entire nation?
        - And if the Father in Heaven is willing to pour out this kind of treatment against His son as a measure of God's wrath,
        - Then how terrible with the day of judgment be for the entire nation when God judges them for refusing to accept His Son's sacrifice?
            - Terrible indeed
    - The Romans were mighty upset when they finally took siege of Jerusalem for the final time in AD 68
        - They had been forced to march down with a he contingent of their army a few years earlier to put down the rebellion
            - Only to have to leave Jerusalem when their supply lines were attacked
            - And in the process, their commanding general dies
        - Then they return even more angry and take hold of the city again

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- They then have to wait nearly 2 years before they breach the city walls
- So how angry do you think they were once they broke through?
- No one survived, families brutally murdered
- The gorgeous temple systematically dismantled and destroyed

- Dry wood indeed

Luke 23:32 ¶ Two others also, who were criminals, were being led away to be put to death with Him.
Luke 23:33 ¶ When they came to the place called The Skull, there they crucified Him and the criminals, one on the right and the other on the left.
Luke 23:34 But Jesus was saying, "Father, forgive them; for they do not know what they are doing." And they cast lots, dividing up His garments among themselves.
Luke 23:35 And the people stood by, looking on. And even the rulers were sneering at Him, saying, "He saved others; let Him save Himself if this is the Christ of God, His Chosen One."
Luke 23:36 The soldiers also mocked Him, coming up to Him, offering Him sour wine,
Luke 23:37 and saying, "If You are the King of the Jews, save Yourself!"
Luke 23:38 Now there was also an inscription above Him, "THIS IS THE KING OF THE JEWS."

- The scene at the cross was a strange mixture of humanity
    - Jesus reaches the place called the Skull
        - The word in Aramaic is Golgotha
        - In Greek it's kranion
        - The Latin word is calvaria, from where we get Calvary
    - He name is often reported to have come from the shape of the hill and its appearance like that of a skull
        - While that might be true, it's just as likely that it came simply by association with it's use as place of execution
    - This hill was outside the city walls, north of the Jerusalem
        - This fact is significant in its connection to Leviticus 16

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- That chapter of the Law provides for the rituals surrounding the Day of Atonement

- A day marking when the national sins of Israel are covered by two goats specially prepared by the High priest on that day

▪ The priest chooses lots to determine which of the two goats lives and which one dies

- The goat that must die is sacrificed in the temple as a sin-offering the Lord

  - Then the blood of that goat is brought behind the veil and sprinkled on the mercy seat

  - This was only day of the year when a man may walk behind the veil and live

  - And then the body of that goat is taken outside the city and burned

- After the first goat has been sacrificed, the second goat is taken to the outside of the city

  - Leviticus calls this goat the scapegoat

  - And the priest presents the second goat to the people and then lays hands on the goat and confess the iniquities of the nation and all their transgressions

- And the priest symbolically places those sins upon the head of the goat and releases the goat outside the city to carry the nations sins away

  - By Jesus day, the religious leaders had added a tradition of pushing the goat off a cliff so that it would die, to ensure the sins never returned to the city

o Jesus' death outside the city is significant in how it carries with it the fulfillment of the scapegoat

▪ Ultimately, for those in the nation who place their sins upon Jesus will see them carried away never to return

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- And even in the unbiblical tradition of the religious leaders ensuring the death of the goat by killing it violently, there was a parallel

- There was another interesting tradition that grew up around this day, based on Isaiah 1:18

Is. 1:18 ¶ "Come now, and let us reason together,"
Says the LORD,
"Though your sins are as scarlet,
They will be as white as snow;
Though they are red like crimson,
They will be like wool.

- The rabbis would tie a scarlet ribbon around the horn of the scapegoat before it was sent out into the wilderness

  - Every year, the priests would report a miracle had taken place as the goat left the city

  - The red ribbon had turned white, which became a symbol for the nation's sins having been forgiven

    - The legend goes on to say that 40 years before the Temple was destroyed in AD 70, the ribbon stopped turning white

    - 40 year before AD 70 was AD 30, the approximate year the Messiah died

      - If the legend is true, or even if not, the fact that it is repeated even to this day reinforces the imagery of what Christ's death means

      - The scapegoat no longer removed Israel's sin since Jesus did it once for all when He died

- Then Jesus is placed on the cross

  - Before He was actually nailed to the cross, He would have been removed His outer garments

    - Meaning that He was crucified in virtually nothing

    - Probably loose hanging undergarments that left little or no modesty

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        - Further humiliation

    - Remembering Jesus carried only the cross beam, there was a couple of ways the cross could be constructed

        - One way was to nail the cross beam to the vertical post while on the ground, and nail the condemned to the cross

        - Then the whole cross was lifted into place

    - The second way was to nail Jesus to the cross beam, and then hoist the beam up with ropes until it rested atop the vertical beam already placed in the ground

        - Finally, the condemn man's feet were nailed to the post

        - We can't be sure how it was done here

    - At the top of the cross, the Romans would usually place a plaque announcing the crime for which the person was condemned

        - The point was to discourage similar behavior in the future

        - Pilate wrote Jesus of Nazareth, King of the Jews

            - The religious leaders protest that it should read He said He was King of the Jews

            - But Pilate says I have written what I have written

        - In John's gospel, we hear the religious leaders protesting that Pilate

    - As they placed Jesus on the cross, they placed him between two criminals who happened to be condemned on the same day

        - We'll hear more about them later

    - And we're told that the Roman soldiers are so callous over the death of the prisoners, that they take a moment of pleasure casting lots to gain Jesus' discarded clothing

- Luke gives a few other brief details

    - First, Jesus was compassionate to the end, remaining sinless even under circumstances when no other man could remain so composed

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- Luke records the statement Father forgive them
    - Only Luke captures this famous line
- Who is this prayer for?
    - It seems that if Jesus asks for the Father's forgiveness on behalf of someone, then it would happen
    - Perhaps it was for the Roman soldiers at the cross
        - We know that the centurian comes to know who Jesus was in that moment, perhaps others as well
        - The crowd at the cross seem to have a change of heart at the end

- But in the midst of this compassion, the sneering and hatred continue
    - The crowd demands that if he was the messiah, he should be able to save himself
        - That is true, but it's a ridiculous statement
    - If the test of messiahship is whether he can save himself by leaving the cross, then he's a pretty pathetic messiah to even allow himself up on the cross in the first place
        - If the true measure of his claim to be the messiah is to be found in his ability to overcome the will of men, then wouldn't it stand to reason that he should have shown that power long before he reached this point?
        - If that were the test, then wouldn't he have stopped the false trial?
        - Wouldn't he have stopped the beatings and scouraging?
        - Wouldn't he have stopped them nails before they entered his hands?
        - Wouldn't he have avoided this whole scene by now?
    - It's not a true or even logical test of whether Jesus was truly the Messiah
        - It completely misses the point

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- The real test of Messiahship is to either avoid the entire debacle and rule in power from the start
    - And this is something we know Jesus was indeed capable and prepared to do, but for the sin of Israel and all men prevent Him from doing so
- In which case the only other test of Messiahship was to remain on the cross until death, and then do something that no mere man could ever do
    - Return from the dead
    - To leave that cross, though it might have impressed someone, was not a true test of power
    - The real test was to let death take its course and then conquer it for all time
- And in winning that victory, He proves something much more important to you and me
    - For a man who can save himself from the cross can impress me
    - But a man who can raise himself from the dead can save me
    - For if he can save himself from death, then I can certainly trust him to do the same for me

- Which is the promise to anyone who would place his sins upon the head of our scapegoat
    - And allow him to carry our sins away forever
    - And upon our bodily death, we can be sure that as He raised Himself from dead, He will likewise do the same for all those who believe in His name

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Luke 23C

- Tonight, we study the death of our Lord Jesus
    - So much of the gospel account we've studied over the past weeks has been leading to this point
        - Jesus Himself has predicted His own death no less than three times, and alluded to it more times than that
        - What's more, the entire Old Testament record exists ultimately to point to three moments in human history
            - First, it records the moment of man's fall, resulting in his spiritual debt to God
            - Second, it points over and over again to our God appointed need for a savior to rescue us from that debt
            - Finally, it describes the glory and joy awaiting those who place their trust in the Lord for that rescue one day to come
        - So here we see that entire plan consummated in the death of a perfect God-Man, a death undeserved
            - And a death which satisfied the wrath of a holy and just God who's anger burns against sin
            - But Who was satisfied to set that anger against His own Son rather than against you and I
- But we are still about three hours away from that death, at noon on a Thursday in April, the day of Passover
    - Given the terrible suffering that accompanied crucifixion, they must have been the three longest hours of Jesus' life

Luke 23:39 ¶ One of the criminals who were hanged *there* was hurling abuse at Him, saying, "Are You not the Christ? Save Yourself and us!"
Luke 23:40 But the other answered, and rebuking him said, "Do you not even fear God, since you are under the same sentence of condemnation?
Luke 23:41 "And we indeed *are suffering* justly, for we are receiving what we deserve for our deeds; but this man has done nothing wrong."

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Luke 23:42 And he was saying, "Jesus, remember me when You come in Your kingdom!"
Luke 23:43 And He said to him, "Truly I say to you, today you shall be with Me in Paradise."

- Here again Luke presents us with a unique perspective, one that has become an iconic image for the church over the ages
    - Matt and Mark mention the thieves in passing, but only Luke gives us the story of their conversation
        - And yet I believe it's fair to say that this conversation is as important to establishing sound Christian doctrine as perhaps any other single conversation recording in all the Gospels
        - We should all be thankful to Luke and to God Himself that this story was recorded – even more so that it even took place
- We have Jesus and these men hanging next to one another suffering together
    - Jesus was crucified because He was King of the Jews, which was no crime at all, as even Pilate himself admitted
    - But the thieves were crucified for a legitimate offense – stealing
        - Stealing was a capital offense in Rome
        - So these men are not victims – they are justly condemned
    - And since they now hang on a cross, their death is only a matter of time
        - It's a disturbing thought to consider that these men knew they would not be rescued
            - Their lives were essentially over
            - It was only a matter of time before they died
        - This is different perhaps than someone who sits on death row and awaits their day of reckoning
            - They hold out some hope of a rescue
        - Not these men
            - They are experiencing a slow death, but it will be a death nonetheless

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- So what thoughts would enter your mind in those last excruciating hours?

- I can't pretend to know what we would be thinking, but I find it interesting that for at least one of these men, his thoughts turn to taunting Jesus
    - And what's even more interesting is that his taunting takes the form of requesting a rescue
        - The irony here is piled high upon itself
            - First, consider that the thief that mocked Jesus is asking Jesus to do the very thing that Jesus is capable of doing
            - More than capable, Jesus is willing to do it
            - At least in the sense that Jesus is willing to rescue the man spiritually
        - But of course, the man doesn't really believe that he can be rescued
            - His comments are clearly spoken in a mocking tone
            - And in case we had any question about the man's intent, Luke removes any doubt when he causes these comments abuse (blasphemeo)
    - So here is a man who is in the process of dying
        - So he knows that he is essentially a walking dead man
            - Yet he has no idea just how dead he truly is, spiritually dead in other words
            - Nor do all men, of course
                - All men are equally dead in their trespasses, Paul says
                - All men are simply waiting for a day to come when they breathe their last
                - This thief just happens to know that his last breathe is a little closer than for those standing by watching him

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- He calls out to Jesus the Christ and says save us
  - But he doesn't really believe Jesus is the Christ nor that He can save them
- He says the words, but the meaning escapes him

- Before we look at the second thief, we should ask what can we learn about our own relationship with Christ from the experience of this man?
  - First, we learn that words alone don't save us
    - We can't say the right words and be saved
      - If you stand back for just a moment and look simply at what the man said, here's what you find:
        - You're the Christ
        - Save yourself and save us
    - Looking just at the words, we might be tempted to see a confession of faith
      - He called Jesus the Christ, which is a specific term meaning Messiah
        - He addressed Jesus as the Messiah, the one sent to save the Jews
        - Secondly, he specifically asked the Messiah to save Him
      - Isn't this the formula for salvation?
    - How many times have you seen or heard people coaching others that they need only repeat after me
      - Say this prayer with me and you will be saved
      - Can the words alone save someone?

John 6:37 "All that the Father gives Me will come to Me, and the one who comes to Me I will certainly not cast out.
John 6:38 "For I have come down from heaven, not to do My own will, but the will of Him who sent Me.

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John 6:39 "This is the will of Him who sent Me, that of all that He has given Me I lose nothing, but raise it up on the last day.
John 6:40 "For this is the will of My Father, that everyone who beholds the Son and believes in Him will have eternal life, and I Myself will raise him up on the last day."

- The experience of this man proves that the answer is no
  - The words alone are meaningless unless that are accompanied in the heart by faith

Rom. 10:9 that if you confess with your mouth Jesus *as* Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved;
Rom. 10:10 for with the heart a person believes, resulting in righteousness, and with the mouth he confesses, resulting in salvation.

- Belief is a state of being that differs from the physical act of speaking or confessing
  - One act cannot take the place of another
  - My words are not equal to belief
    - They stand apart from belief yet both are expected from a believer
    - To those who, like this first thief, say the right words when prompted
      - When desperate and near death or in some other crisis
    - But yet do not carry a belief in their heart are not saved
    - Likewise, the scripture says that the confession of the mouth results in salvation
      - There is an expectation that the one who believes will demonstrate that belief in a confession

- So our first lesson is that we need to beware the first thief
  - Have we spoken meaningless words yet expected somehow that it will save us in the end?

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- Or perhaps we have never spoken any words, never a public confession of our faith and trust in Jesus
    - We assume that our kind and generous thoughts toward Jesus will carry the day?
    - Perhaps we've thought that association with Christians and our attendance at church should be enough to prove our intentions
    - Then again, maybe the requirement to confess with our mouth was intended to expose exactly that kind of ambivalence
        - To shine light on a true heart
        - So if a confession of Christ is a expected part of a changed life

- Finally, this first thief reminds us never to be so determined to see someone come to faith in Christ that we inadvertently try to lower the bar for admission into the family of God
    - If we lead someone to think that they are saved because they repeat a prayer without also taking time to gain their agreement with the belief behind those words
        - Or if we allow someone to assume that salvation can come because they merely think and act like a Christian without ever asking them to declare their faith in Christ,
        - Then we are giving them false comfort
    - A person who speaks a confession without holding to the faith is merely fooling others
    - And a person who assumes they have the faith but never speaks the confession is merely fooling themselves

- But God in His infinite wisdom places a second thief on another cross on the other side of Jesus
    - And when this other thief hears the words of the first thief, he quickly joins the conversation
    - The man rebukes the first thief

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- He says that this man should fear God, since he is under the same sentence of condemnation
    - Here's this man joining in the crowd's mocking of Jesus
    - But unlike the crowd, this man is hanging on a cross just like Jesus
        - He's not dead yet but he's as good as dead
        - So you would think he would fear God, because he's under the same sentence of condemnation
        - Meaning, he's about to see God, he should be thinking about that right about now
- This statement suggests that the second thief sees this man's comments as being offensive to God
    - You should fear God rather than invite His anger against you
        - What does it suggest to us to learn that this second thief feels mocking Jesus will anger God?

- The answer comes in the rest of the second thief's statements
    - He says we are guilty and suffering rightly
    - But Jesus is innocent
        - So therefore, while we are suffering for our mistakes
        - Jesus is suffering for other's mistakes
    - In this one statement, the second thief acknowledges his own sin and Christ's sinlessness
    - Finally, the man makes a request of Jesus
        - Remember me when you enter your kingdom
            - Now he isn't asking Jesus to simply make note of him so that one day in the future when Jesus is walking through the kingdom He might say, "Gee, I wonder what happened to that thief?"

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- By remember me, he means specifically please include me among those you invite into your kingdom

- It's a specific request to be with Jesus in the future kingdom of those saved

- By contrast to what the first thief said, the second thief gives a Biblically correct confession of faith sufficient to be saved

  - He recognizes that how one respond to Jesus is of utmost importance to God

    - And fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom

  - Secondly, he acknowledges his own sin and recognizes the punishment that is justly awaiting him for that sin

  - Third, he recognizes Jesus' sinlessness and therefore Jesus death on the cross was a penalty paid for sins of others

  - Finally, he makes a specific appeal to Jesus to be rescued on the basis of mercy, not on the basis of merit

- To which Jesus responds, surely you will be with Me in Paradise

  - The term paradise occurs here and in Paul's description of heaven in 2Cor 12

  - And Jesus uses it again as a description of Heaven in his letter to Ephesus in the Revelation He gave John

    - But in simple terms, Paradise simply means be exist in a glorified state in Jesus' presence

- God gives us a perfect picture of salvation in a remarkably concise picture

- It's no wonder that the story of this second thief has a unique place in the Biblical record as a testimony against countless number of false doctrines and wrong teaching

  - Would you teach me that I must keep the Law to be saved?

    - To you, I will point to the salvation of this law breaker

  - Would you teach me that I must be baptized to be saved?

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- To you, I will point to the thief on the cross who never went down into the water

- Would you teach me that I must perform a certain work to be saved?
  - To you, I will point to the thief, who's only work was the labored breathing on the cross.
- Would you teach me that I must speak in tongues to be saved?
  - To you, I will point to the thief who never spoke beyond his confession.
- Would you teach me that I must belong to a certain denomination, participate in a special ritual, attend a certain class, acquire a secret knowledge, meet a certain test, or strive in any way…
  - To you I say, witness the thief on the cross
  - A sinner who did nothing more than believe in his heart and confess with his mouth that Jesus was Lord.

Luke 23:44 ¶ It was now about the sixth hour, and darkness came over the whole land until the ninth hour,
Luke 23:45 for the sun stopped shining. And the curtain of the temple was torn in two.
Luke 23:46 Jesus called out with a loud voice, "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit." When he had said this, he breathed his last.

- Luke records that the day reaches the sixth hour
  - Luke is using the Jewish manner of recording the hours with a day
    - Meaning that the it was noon
    - At noon, the world went dark
      - The word for dark in Matt is a word that means a heavy darkness, spiritual darkness
      - Without additional explanation, we can immediately draw the appropriate conclusion regarding the meaning of this event

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- The world grows dark as God's judgment and displeasure is made manifest to the creation

- There are many examples in scripture where God's judgment is displayed through a darkening of the Sun
  - But the significance here is even more significant
    - In Genesis 1, we learn that light and darkness was created even before the sun and moon
    - And in Revelation 21 we learn that the new heaven and earth will not have need of a sun or moon either because all light comes from the Lord
    - Leaving us to conclude that the existence of light is independent of the objects God has created to produce light
    - God has given us the physical light produced by the sun to as a representation of His light when we are in His presence
  - All of this suggests to me that when the light leaves the earth at this moment, it is a physical representation of the Father separating Himself from His Son
    - Forsaking His Son
- For three hours, hours that must have felt like an eternity to Jesus, He was separated from the Father
  - From the Father's love, fellowship
  - For three hours, Jesus experienced a kind of separation that every one born into sin experiences
    - A spiritual separation that begins at birth and lasts for an eternity for those who fail to believe in Jesus
  - But Jesus, sinless and having been with the Father since the beginning, is now experiencing that separation for the first time
    - And how dreadful it must have been

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- In Matt gospel we get a sense of Jesus' dread, when Jesus exclaims :

Matt. 27:46 About the ninth hour Jesus cried out with a loud voice, saying, "ELI, ELI, LAMA SABACHTHANI?" that is, "MY GOD, MY GOD, WHY HAVE YOU FORSAKEN ME?"

- Near the end of that darkness, that time when the Father had forsaken His own Son
  - Jesus cried out in desperation over the separation
  - It even makes me wonder if this part of the ordeal was something that Jesus didn't – or couldn't – anticipate
    - That somehow it even took Him by surprise
    - How could Jesus anticipate separation from the Father when He had never yet experienced it?

- Crucifixion was such a painful death because of the way it left the condemned struggling to combat the physical effects of the punishment
  - As the body is raised up, the weight of the body pulls on the arms, and almost immediately the shoulders are out of socket
    - Not only is the pain unbearable, but the person can't breath in that position
      - So as the person suffers is tremendous pain in the hands feet and shoulders, then the person feels like he's being held under water
      - So eventually, he will push himself up by pushing against the nails in his feet just enough to relieve the pressure on his diaphragm long enough to take in a breath
    - Of course, at that point, the pain in his feet causes him to relax the legs, only to bring back more pain in the shoulders and begin the cycle all over again

- Writings of the day say that the sour vinegar wine was often given to these men because it also acted as an astringent, which shrinks and dries membranes
  - The point was to constrict the throat to make it harder to cry out in pain
  - Because the cries of pain from the men were so persistent and disturbing

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- And this process went on for hours and even days
    - Some men took several days to die
        - Usually from dehydration, which brought it's own kind of torture
    - But if people wanted to hasten death, they might break the legs of the prisoner, which quickly resulted in asphyxiation, since the prisoner could not longer lift himself to breathe
- When Jesus cried out, He gave us a clear reference to an OT prophecy concerning the Messiah
    - Many centuries before this event, God gave us a description of how He would accomplish redemption by His Anointed One
    - And God gave us this picture hundreds of years before crucifixion had even been invented…

Psa. 22:1 ¶ My God, my God, why have You forsaken me?
Far from my deliverance are the words of my groaning.
Psa. 22:2 O my God, I cry by day, but You do not answer;
And by night, but I have no rest.
Psa. 22:3 Yet You are holy,
O You who are enthroned upon the praises of Israel.
Psa. 22:4 In You our fathers trusted;
They trusted and You delivered them.
Psa. 22:5 To You they cried out and were delivered;
In You they trusted and were not disappointed.
Psa. 22:6 ¶ But I am a worm and not a man,
A reproach of men and despised by the people.
Psa. 22:7 All who see me sneer at me;
They separate with the lip, they wag the head, *saying*,
Psa. 22:8 "Commit *yourself* to the LORD; let Him deliver him;
Let Him rescue him, because He delights in him."
Psa. 22:9 ¶ Yet You are He who brought me forth from the womb;
You made me trust *when* upon my mother's breasts.
Psa. 22:10 Upon You I was cast from birth;
You have been my God from my mother's womb.
Psa. 22:11 ¶ Be not far from me, for trouble is near;
For there is none to help.
Psa. 22:12 Many bulls have surrounded me;
Strong *bulls* of Bashan have encircled me.
Psa. 22:13 They open wide their mouth at me,
As a ravening and a roaring lion.

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Psa. 22:14 I am poured out like water,
And all my bones are out of joint;
My heart is like wax;
It is melted within me.
Psa. 22:15 My strength is dried up like a potsherd,
And my tongue cleaves to my jaws;
And You lay me in the dust of death.
Psa. 22:16 For dogs have surrounded me;
A band of evildoers has encompassed me;
They pierced my hands and my feet.
Psa. 22:17 I can count all my bones.
They look, they stare at me;
Psa. 22:18 They divide my garments among them,
And for my clothing they cast lots.

- Luke also mentions that at this moment of Jesus' death, the veil was torn in two
    - Matt adds that the tear began at the top and proceeded to the ground
        - Josephus described the veil as 82.5 feet in height, 24 feet in width, and three inches thick
        - It hung from a 30 ton beam above huge wooden doors to the temple
    - When it was ripped, it sent an unmistakable message of what Jesus' death meant
        - Where once before men depended on priests to intercede on our behalf before God,
        - Now all men have the opportunity for direct access to the throne room if they accept the Messiah's sacrifice on their behalf
        - God removed the veil through the death of His Son
- Then Jesus dies at the ninth hour
    - Jesus cries out in loud voice commending his Spirit to the Father
        - Again, Jesus fulfills a prophecy from the OT

Psa. 31:1 ¶ In You, O LORD, I have taken refuge;
Let me never be ashamed;

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In Your righteousness deliver me.
Psa. 31:2 Incline Your ear to me, rescue me quickly;
Be to me a rock of strength,
A stronghold to save me.
Psa. 31:3 For You are my rock and my fortress;
For Your name's sake You will lead me and guide me.
Psa. 31:4 You will pull me out of the net which they have secretly laid for me,
For You are my strength.
Psa. 31:5 Into Your hand I commit my spirit;
You have ransomed me, O LORD, God of truth.

- The Greek word here is megas, great
  - His throat is already going to be incredibly dry, and he was given some of the vinegar, making it harder to speak
  - Now we hear he cries out, entrusting his soul to the Father
- On Yom Kippor, the high priest of Israel was required to call out the holy name of God (YHWH) when he performed the sacrifice for the nations sins
  - Jewish writing records that when the high priest spoke this name, his voice was supernaturally empowered to be so loud that all the multitude of Israel could hear it.
  - So it was here again, our high priest's voice echoed supernaturally through the valley and in the city, heard by the entire city
  - Which leads to the natural reaction…

Luke 23:47 ¶ The centurion, seeing what had happened, praised God and said, "Surely this was a righteous man."
Luke 23:48 When all the people who had gathered to witness this sight saw what took place, they beat their breasts and went away.
Luke 23:49 But all those who knew him, including the women who had followed him from Galilee, stood at a distance, watching these things.

- A Roman centurian and the crowd see the events at Jesus' death
  - The darkened sky
  - The supernaturally loud cry to the Father

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- The earthquakes, mentioned by Matt and Mark

- And they praise God and declare Jesus to be righteous
    - It seems that Jesus' prayer that God forgive them, for they know not what they do has been answered

- But those closest to Jesus watch from a distance
    - This fleeting reference to the women is important because it will be the women who remain the most diligent to attend to Jesus after death
        - They are intent on remaining nearby to see this through
        - As Luke describes the scene, he retreats from the centurion, to the crowd to the women at a distance
            - Like a camera lens pulling back from the cross

- And that's where we leave Jesus tonight, hanging lifeless on the cross, having declared it is finished, our debt paid in full.

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Luke 24A

- As our lesson came to a conclusion last week, Jesus' lifeless body still hung on the cross
    - The crowds have left
    - The religious leaders have returned to the city, no doubt congratulating one another on the success of their plan to kill Jesus
    - The women who know Jesus have stayed behind, perhaps watching Jesus hanging in a hope that something miraculous will happen
- Before we return to Luke, I want to take just a brief moment as we begin tonight to look at how John describes the scene at the cross following Jesus' death

John 19:31 ¶ Then the Jews, because it was the day of preparation, so that the bodies would not remain on the cross on the Sabbath (for that Sabbath was a high day), asked Pilate that their legs might be broken, and *that* they might be taken away.
John 19:32 So the soldiers came, and broke the legs of the first man and of the other who was crucified with Him;
John 19:33 but coming to Jesus, when they saw that He was already dead, they did not break His legs.
John 19:34 But one of the soldiers pierced His side with a spear, and immediately blood and water came out.

- If you were present for my description of the crucifixion last week, you'll immediately understand the reason for the Jewish leaders' request
    - The ability of these men to push themselves up by their legs was critical to their ability to breathe
        - As long as they could use their legs to push up, they could remain alive on the cross for several days
    - Normally, Romans left their victims to die slowly on the cross
        - Which could be several days
        - After which they let the body on the cross for birds to pick at the corpse until it rotted away
    - But the Jews are concerned about the approaching Sabbath

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        - It would have been a great concern to see a body hanging in this way over a Sabbath day
        - The Law of Moses required in Deut 21:22-23 that no one be permitted to hang on a tree overnight
        - So to permit Jesus to hang there into a Sabbath would have been especially offensive
    - Therefore, the Jewish leaders say lets get on with it
        - Break their legs,
            - The Romans used an iron mallet to smash the legs
            - The inability to push up promptly lead to asphyxiation
- But when they go to Jesus, He is dead already
    - But a soldier decides to test whether Jesus is truly dead
    - The soldier pierces Jesus' side
        - Of course, if Jesus wasn't dead, He would be now
    - Out flowed blood and water
        - This is actually normal physiology
        - The Roman probably aimed upward into the body cavity reaching the heart
            - And if he hit the heart, it would have resulted in blood and a watery fluid of the pericardial sac surrounding the heart pouring out the wound
    - There have been so many attempts to attach symbolism to the fact that both blood and water are observed
        - If there is symbolism intended, I lean toward a connection with the Last Supper
            - Jesus declared that the wine of that meal was His blood
            - But we know that those cups of wine were mixed with water

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- Therefore, in the mixing of blood and water now, though it is a natural event
  - Perhaps it was intended to reinforce the image of Jesus as the blood of the new covenant, shed for the remission of sin and the Passover celebration

- With that background, let's go back into Luke, beginning at verse 50…

Luke 23:50 ¶ And a man named Joseph, who was a member of the Council, a good and righteous man
Luke 23:51 (he had not consented to their plan and action), *a man* from Arimathea, a city of the Jews, who was waiting for the kingdom of God;
Luke 23:52 this man went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus.
Luke 23:53 And he took it down and wrapped it in a linen cloth, and laid Him in a tomb cut into the rock, where no one had ever lain.
Luke 23:54 It was the preparation day, and the Sabbath was about to begin.
Luke 23:55 Now the women who had come with Him out of Galilee followed, and saw the tomb and how His body was laid.
Luke 23:56 Then they returned and prepared spices and perfumes.
¶ And on the Sabbath they rested according to the commandment.

- Luke's description of the burial process paints a nicely detailed picture
  - As these verse begin, Jesus is still on a cross
    - But this being a preparation day before a High Sabbath, Jesus friends wouldn't want Him to stay there past sundown
  - So this man Joseph of Arimathea claims Jesus' body
    - We don't know too much about Joseph, but from the four Gospels, here's what we know
    - He comes from Arimethea, a town about 21 miles northwest from Jerusalem
      - This is the same city where Samuel the prophet lived and was buried
      - A legend grew up in the church that Joseph later became an evangelist traveling to England, founding the first Christian church outside Judea in Glastenbury and is buried there

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- He was a member of the powerful ruling council of Jews – the Sanhedrin
- He was a believer in Jesus, but John tells us he was secretive in his belief
    - And Luke says Joseph hadn't agreed with the council's ruling against Jesus
- And Mark tells us that Joseph had to gather up the courage to approach Pilate to request the body
    - Joseph had good reason to fear here
        - He was a member of the counsil that had convicted Jesus
        - And Jesus had just been executed as a insurrectionist by the Romans
    - Up to this point, Joseph had been a secret admirer of Jesus
        - Now he was preparing to associated himself with Jesus publicly
        - And in doing so, he would be suspected by both the council and the Romans
    - When he asks Pilate for the body, Pilate asked if it were possible that Jesus was already dead
        - A six hour crucifixion was relatively quick
- We also know that Joseph was a man of wealth, according to Matthew
    - Which makes sense, since you wouldn't expect him to have bee on the council without some source of influence
- Joseph had recently prepared a burial place for himself
    - It was hewn out of rock
        - This was an expensive kind of burial
        - Only the wealthy could afford the labor and the land to have such a burial

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- Consider what Joseph did here

    - First, he was used by God to fulfill scripture

Is. 53:9 His grave was assigned with wicked men,
Yet He was with a rich man in His death,
Because He had done no violence,
Nor was there any deceit in His mouth.

    - Secondly, Joseph was obeying Jesus' own words to his disciples a few months earlier

Matt. 10:25 "It is enough for the disciple that he become like his teacher, and the slave like his master. If they have called the head of the house Beelzebul, how much more *will they malign* the members of his household!
Matt. 10:26 ¶ "Therefore do not fear them, for there is nothing concealed that will not be revealed, or hidden that will not be known.
Matt. 10:27 "What I tell you in the darkness, speak in the light; and what you hear *whispered* in *your* ear, proclaim upon the housetops.
Matt. 10:28 "Do not fear those who kill the body but are unable to kill the soul; but rather fear Him who is able to destroy both soul and body in hell.

    - Joseph realized that serving Jesus in this dark hour required the courage to trust in the Lord rather than fear men

        - He showed more courage in that moment than all the disciples combined

        - God so often finds the least among His people to perform the greatest deeds in His name

    - I also admire the generosity of this man

        - The donation of this grave would have been equivalent to donating a mausoleum

            - The price of a small home

        - You could have argued that now that Jesus was dead, there was little reason to go to so much effort to bury Him in such an elaborate way

        - Joseph didn't let reason get in his way of serving His Lord

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- Like the woman with the alabaster vial of perfume
- She gave it all to Jesus for His feet without regard for its worth
- Because our service to Christ is priceless

- And what did Joseph receive for his sacrifice?
  - Only to have his story included in all four gospel records and his faithfulness immortalized forever
    - Seems like a fair deal, so long as your priority isn't personal wealth

- We also know from the other Gospels that when Joseph came to claim the body, the women were still there guarding over Jesus,
  - And they followed Jesus' body to the tomb,
    - And they observed Joseph and Nicodemus prepare the body for burial and place it in the tomb and roll the stone over the entrance
  - The presence of the women here is important because they provide a chain of custody of sorts
    - If you've read ahead, then you know it is the women who first discover Jesus' body missing on Sunday
      - Many commentators offer ideas for why the women were granted the privilege of learning of the resurrection first
      - At least one reason is because they provide the eye witness proof that Jesus was buried in the grave
        - And then when they return, there is no body to be found
      - Add to that the fact that Matt tells us how the Jewish leaders feared the body would be stolen, so they appeal to Pilate for a guard to watch the tomb and seal it shut
  - There move, by the way, only served to add evidence to Jesus claims to resurrection
    - It was harder to claim that Jesus resurrection was a fraud

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- Together with the women's testimony

Luke 24:1 ¶ But on the first day of the week, at early dawn, they came to the tomb bringing the spices which they had prepared.
Luke 24:2 And they found the stone rolled away from the tomb,
Luke 24:3 but when they entered, they did not find the body of the Lord Jesus.
Luke 24:4 While they were perplexed about this, behold, two men suddenly stood near them in dazzling clothing;
Luke 24:5 and as *the women* were terrified and bowed their faces to the ground, *the men* said to them, "Why do you seek the living One among the dead?
Luke 24:6 "He is not here, but He has risen. Remember how He spoke to you while He was still in Galilee,
Luke 24:7 saying that the Son of Man must be delivered into the hands of sinful men, and be crucified, and the third day rise again."
Luke 24:8 And they remembered His words,
Luke 24:9 and returned from the tomb and reported all these things to the eleven and to all the rest.

- The first day of the week, as Luke describes it, was Sunday
    - This was the first day after the crucifixion that the women could travel to visit the tomb
        - The day of the crucifixion was Thursday
        - The next day was Friday, which was a Sabbath because it was the first day of the Festival of Unleavened Bread
        - The next day was Saturday, which was a normal Sabbath
        - So Sunday was the first day these women could return to pray and mourn at the grave and preserve the body
- They arrive at dawn, and actually a little before dawn according to John
    - The first thing they noticed was that the stone was rolled away
        - The stone is very large
        - In fact, in Mark's gospel they are quoted as wondering who will help them roll the stone away

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- I get the sense that these women were so steadfast in their faith and devotion that they didn't let the fact that there was this huge stone covering the grave discourage them from going to Jesus

- But when they arrive, they find the stone has already been moved
  - It's shaped like a disc, so that it can roll from one side to another inside a groove cut in the ground
  - It would take several strong men to move it
    - But there were guards at this stone up till the moment that an angel, we're told in Matt's gospel, moves it
    - And scares the guards away in the process
  - So the chain of custody is complete

- They enter the tomb, we're told, but of course the body of Jesus isn't there
  - And they are perplexed or at a loss
    - Here for the first time, Luke uses the term Lord Jesus, which was the popular term in the early church
  - The resurrection of Jesus was a specific event
    - We'll study it in stages a little here and there as we go through the chapter, but let's begin with the most important piece
  - Jesus was resurrected in body and spirit
    - Jesus was all man and all God
      - He had a sinless body and He was one in His spirit with the Father
      - When His Body died, it died no less than when you and I suffer death
        - But that's where the similarities end
        - His body didn't decay, even in the slightest

Psa. 16:10 For You will not abandon my soul to Sheol;
Nor will You allow Your Holy One to undergo decay.

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- From this passage, we see confirmation that Jesus body never suffered any decay
  - It was dead but never deteriorated
  - This is confirmed by the fact that the soldiers' sword drew blood and water as if the body were still alive
  - Because the deterioration process itself was something God instituted as a result of sin
  - Part of the curse on creation brought about because of the sin of Adam declares:

Gen. 3:19 By the sweat of your face
You will eat bread,
Till you return to the ground,
Because from it you were taken;
For you are dust,
And to dust you shall return."

- Since Jesus didn't share in the sin, He didn't share in the curse
  - So though He was dead, the body was not decaying
  - What made Jesus dead then? It was that the spirit had left the body
- Remember in Luke 23:46 when Jesus said that into the Father's hand He committed His Spirit
  - To fully understand the significance of that statement, we need to consider one other statement Jesus spoke before His death

John 10:17 "For this reason the Father loves Me, because I lay down My life so that I may take it again.
John 10:18 "No one has taken it away from Me, but I lay it down on My own initiative. I have authority to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again. This commandment I received from My Father."

- When Jesus spoke His dying words, He was in a sense dictating the timing and manner of His own death

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- He was laying down His life by commanding His spirit to be separated from His body, which is the cause of His body's death
- At that point, His spirit went to the place that all departing spirits went
    - Abraham's Bosom, Sheol
    - This was the waiting place for the departed souls
- The spirits of the saints who died prior to the resurrection, couldn't leave the earth and enter heaven
    - Because until Jesus had died and His blood had covered the mercy seat in the heavenly tabernacle, there hadn't yet been atonement for sin
    - Without atonement for sin, those souls couldn't enter God's presence without judgment for sin
- So God graciously prepared a suitable waiting place for the day when Jesus would sacrifice Himself, and after His death, His soul joined those who waited for Him in Sheol

- How can we be sure of this?
    - Scripture teaches us the details

Eph. 4:8 Therefore it says,
"WHEN HE ASCENDED ON HIGH,
HE LED CAPTIVE A HOST OF CAPTIVES,
AND HE GAVE GIFTS TO MEN."
Eph. 4:9 (Now this *expression*, "He ascended," what does it mean except that He also had descended into the lower parts of the earth?
Eph. 4:10 He who descended is Himself also He who ascended far above all the heavens, so that He might fill all things.)

Is. 44:23 Shout for joy, O heavens, for the LORD has done *it*!
Shout joyfully, you lower parts of the earth;
Break forth into a shout of joy, you mountains,
O forest, and every tree in it;
For the LORD has redeemed Jacob
And in Israel He shows forth His glory.

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1Pet. 3:18 For Christ also died for sins once for all, *the* just for *the* unjust, so that He might bring us to God, having been put to death in the flesh, but made alive in the spirit;
1Pet. 3:19 in which also He went and made proclamation to the spirits *now* in prison,
1Pet. 3:20 who once were disobedient, when the patience of God kept waiting in the days of Noah,

- So Jesus' body is sitting in the tomb without decay
    - His Spirit is in the depths comforting the OT saints while witnessing to the coming judgment for the disobedient
    - And Jesus spends three days away from His body
        - At which point He is resurrected
        - The resurrection of the body is the moment when our Spirit is resident again in a physical container
            - Jesus' physical container was not corrupted by sin
            - So as we mentioned at an earlier point in this study, His spirit can re-enter His original body and return to life in the same form He had upon His death
        - It must be different for you and I
            - First we were born with a corrupted spirit, inherited from Adam's nature
                - That spirit could never enter God's presence
                - So to those who are to be saved, God must put the old nature to death and give the body a new spirit, one that isn't corrupt any longer
                - Ultimately, when the day of our resurrection comes at the Rapture of the church, the second part of our renewal will be complete
                - But unlike Jesus, we will require a new body, since our original body will have returned to dust

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Rom. 8:10 If Christ is in you, though the body is dead because of sin, yet the spirit is alive because of righteousness.
Rom. 8:11 But if the Spirit of Him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through His Spirit who dwells in you.

Rom. 8:20 For the creation was subjected to futility, not willingly, but because of Him who subjected it, in hope
Rom. 8:21 that the creation itself also will be set free from its slavery to corruption into the freedom of the glory of the children of God.
Rom. 8:22 For we know that the whole creation groans and suffers the pains of childbirth together until now.
Rom. 8:23 And not only this, but also we ourselves, having the first fruits of the Spirit, even we ourselves groan within ourselves, waiting eagerly for *our* adoption as sons, the redemption of our body.

- So back to the scene, Luke reports that the women see two men sitting in the tomb in place of Jesus
    - We know these men to be angels, but there is no indication that these women did
        - Remember, the word angel means messenger, and just as angels heralded Jesus' birth, here again God uses angels to announce Jesus resurrection
            - They open the conversation by asking why they are looking for the living among the dead?
                - This is a polite rebuke, in that it suggests these women should have know to expect the resurrection
            - And then the angel reminds them of all of Jesus' predictions and they are then given the insight to see the big picture
    - Remember we said earlier in studying Luke that the reason that the meaning of Jesus' earlier predictions of His coming death were hidden at the time was so that the meaning revealed now would have more impact
        - There would be a clearer understanding that this was all a part of God's plan

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- Now that encouragement and explanation is put to use with these women and later with the disciples

- And in Matt's Gospel, they tell the women that Jesus has gone ahead to Galilee and would meet them there

  - These are great details

    - Jesus has just been resurrected, but He doesn't just float around the tomb

      - He's truly alive, truly a man in a body again never to suffer death again

      - So He plans to meet the disciples in Galilee, His home

    - He literally, stood up in the tomb, waited for the angels to push the stone back, and walked out probably moments before the women arrive

    - And now He begins His 80 mile walk back to the Galilee

      - We'll come back to a discussion of how Jesus actually travels in the days after His resurrection next week

  - And with this great news the women return to tell the eleven still hiding somewhere in Jerusalem

Luke 24:10 Now they were Mary Magdalene and Joanna and Mary the *mother* of James; also the other women with them were telling these things to the apostles.
Luke 24:11 But these words appeared to them as nonsense, and they would not believe them.
Luke 24:12 But Peter got up and ran to the tomb; stooping and looking in, he *saw the linen wrappings only; and he went away to his home, marveling at what had happened.

- Naturally, the women run back to tell the eleven apostles

  - And naturally their reports are met with skepticism

    - Can you blame the disciples?

    - Well, in a way yes, since they had been warned

    - But forgetting that for a moment, the culture would have been a great barrier to belief

      - Women were not seen as credible witnesses

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- They couldn't testify at trial, they had no leagal standing
- They were viewed to be too emotionally frail to be trustworthy in serious matters
    - Just the fact that Jesus first appeared to women is the best proof I can offer that the Gospel account of Jesus' resurrection is not a contrived story written by some Jewish disciple
    - No Jewish writer wished his story was seen as credible would have made the first witnesses to the resurrection to be women
    - He would have selected men to encourage trust in his readers

- When they hear the report, it sounds like nonsense to the disciples
    - In fact, to show you how little trust these men had in the women's testimony, only Peter and John decide it's worth the risk to be seen in public to run to the tomb
    - But the only thing they saw in the tomb were the left over wrappings
    - Jesus had come back to life

- Why is the resurrection so important to our faith?
    - First and foremost, it establishes the truth of everything else that came before it
        - Jesus made many astounding claims about the nature of the Creater God and His character and His plan for mankind
            - And these claims were mutually exclusive to any other claim
            - Jesus said that the God is Israel is the only true God, and that He was the only Son or deliverer offered by the Father to mankind
            - Jesus declared that belief in Jesus was the one and only opportunity for men to reconciled to their Father

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- And He promised that just as He would be resurrected, those who trust in His atonement will likewise be resurrected

- Now talk is cheap
  - It's easy to make claims
  - Countless other faiths have come along and will come along making any number of claims about these same issues
  - And in every case, those claims come to us in much the same way as Jesus' claims first came
    - A man makes statement and demonstrates certain principles
    - He obtains a devoted following
      - The win over a few or many
  - So in the end, how do we know who to believe?

- Well consider what are offering you?
  - In these messengers are claiming to have an answer to the question of death and eternity, then you should ask what happened to their spokesman?
    - Many have come to make claims, but only one backed it up with proof
      - The resurrection was the proof that we can believe Jesus' claims
      - The fact that He rose from the dead and was seen by witnesses proved His divinity
      - And it gave us the hope that He can do as He promised for those who believe in Him

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Rom. 6:3 Or do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus have been baptized into His death?
Rom. 6:4 Therefore we have been buried with Him through baptism into death, so that as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, so we too might walk in newness of life.
Rom. 6:5 For if we have become united with *Him* in the likeness of His death, certainly we shall also be *in the likeness* of His resurrection,
Rom. 6:6 knowing this, that our old self was crucified with *Him*, in order that our body of sin might be done away with, so that we would no longer be slaves to sin;
Rom. 6:7 for he who has died is freed from sin.
Rom. 6:8 ¶ Now if we have died with Christ, we believe that we shall also live with Him,
Rom. 6:9 knowing that Christ, having been raised from the dead, is never to die again; death no longer is master over Him.

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Luke 24B

- Tonight we reach the culmination of Luke's Gospel and of course, Jesus' ministry during His first coming to earth
    - Jesus' teaching would have no meaning for us today, had it not be mirrored by His sinless life
    - Jesus' sinless life would have held no significance for us had it not be met by an unjustified death
    - Jesus' death would have held no power had it not be followed by his glorious resurrection and ascension
    - And so tonight, as we end the book of Luke, we study His departure from the earth
        - A departure that lasts only for a time as we await His return
- Last week we witnessed the empty tomb
    - And like the apostles, we wonder where is the body? Where is the Lord?
    - Meanwhile, we know he has set out for the Galilee

Luke 24:13 ¶ And behold, two of them were going that very day to a village named Emmaus, which was about seven miles from Jerusalem.
Luke 24:14 And they were talking with each other about all these things which had taken place.
Luke 24:15 While they were talking and discussing, Jesus Himself approached and *began* traveling with them.
Luke 24:16 But their eyes were prevented from recognizing Him.

- Among the Synoptic gospels, this is by far the most detailed account of Jesus' appearance outside Jerusalem
    - John's gospel gives more detail of His appearance in Jerusalem
    - And John tells of a third appearance in the Galilee
- The story begins with two men walking a road as they leave Jerusalem headed toward Emmaus

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- We can only assume they had journeyed to Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover and now were headed home
    - And we're told they are talking about the things that had taken place in Jerusalem that week
    - Obviously, Jesus' ministry had made a big impact on the city
    - He had become the talk of the town
        - And not just His death, of course,
        - The real news were the wild rumors of His missing body and of Jesus being alive again
        - Impossible things, really
        - National Enquirer kinds of things
- And as they walk, Jesus approaches
    - And He joins them in their walk
        - This wasn't the least bit unusual
        - Traveling in Judea was done largely on foot and along well kept Roman roads
        - But thieves were common, and the only safe way to travel was in groups
            - So it would have been natural for a solitary figure like Jesus to come along side another traveling party and join them
    - Since Jesus walk the same direction, they can only assume that Jesus has been in Jerusalem as well and is now returning home

- And the scriptures tell us that these men were prevented from knowing and recognizing who Jesus was
    - Isn't that fascinating
    - The phrase in Greek literally means something took away their eye's ability to be aware of what they saw

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- I think this is similar to the invisible force that prevents husbands from recognizing their wife's new hairstyle
- We know they weren't blind, but the point is they could know who Jesus really was
  - They saw the man Jesus, they spoke with Him
  - Yet they couldn't recognize Him for Who He truly was

- What caused this strange kind blindness?
  - Or perhaps we should ask who caused this blindness?
  - We know the answer…it was God Himself, through the Holy Spirit
  - God would not allow these men to know who Jesus was in that moment, for He had better things planned

Luke 24:17 And He said to them, "What are these words that you are exchanging with one another as you are walking?" And they stood still, looking sad.

- Before we continue in the dialog, I want to pause here just for the comic effect I see in the text
  - Imagine these men walking down the road, perhaps three abreast
    - Personally, I imagine Jesus in the middle by this point with each man on either side
  - And at first, Jesus doesn't say much
    - He just listens
  - And these men are talking excitedly back and forth about all that they saw in Jerusalem
  - And finally, Jesus speaks up and His first comments are to ask what they were talking about
    - Jesus basically acted as though He had not heard about the Prophet who taught in the Temple, and who was tried and who was crucified
  - And when Jesus speaks these words, the men literally stopped in place

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- And I imagine Jesus continued walking forward a few more steps until He too stopped and looked back
- And when He did he saw these two men with frozen expressions, looking at Him with a gloomy face
  - They were stunned to find someone leaving Jerusalem who didn't know about the extraordinary events of the past week
  - And they were sad to think that any Jew could have missed the significance of a prophet having visited God's people

- Look at what they said in response

Luke 24:18 One *of them*, named Cleopas, answered and said to Him, "Are You the only one visiting Jerusalem and unaware of the things which have happened here in these days?"
Luke 24:19 And He said to them, "What things?" And they said to Him, "The things about Jesus the Nazarene, who was a prophet mighty in deed and word in the sight of God and all the people,
Luke 24:20 and how the chief priests and our rulers delivered Him to the sentence of death, and crucified Him.
Luke 24:21 "But we were hoping that it was He who was going to redeem Israel. Indeed, besides all this, it is the third day since these things happened.
Luke 24:22 "But also some women among us amazed us. When they were at the tomb early in the morning,
Luke 24:23 and did not find His body, they came, saying that they had also seen a vision of angels who said that He was alive.
Luke 24:24 "Some of those who were with us went to the tomb and found it just exactly as the women also had said; but Him they did not see."

- Cleopas begins by asking a mocking question of Jesus
  - Are you the only one who doesn't know these things?
    - It's a lot like saying what rock did you crawl out from under?
  - How could it be possible that someone be in Jerusalem and not know the story
    - The dialog here makes absolutely clear how all encompassing Jesus' death had been

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- In response to the question, Jesus continues to bait them into telling Him what they believe happened
    - What Jesus is doing here is very specific
        - He's not just having fun at these guys' expense
        - He's working toward a point, a point which Luke is intent to capture
    - So Jesus asks them to give the details
        - They begin by saying these were the events of Jesus of Nazareth, the mighty prophet who impressed the peoples
            - Their description is true, at least in the sense that Jesus was a prophet during His time on earth
            - And He did perform mighty deeds, and He did teach with mighty words
    - The problem with their response, of course, is that it didn't go far enough
        - Jesus was not merely a prophet, but He was also the Messiah
            - God in the flesh
        - And these men's statements make clear that though they gave Jesus respect and admiration
        - And they even were willing to acknowledge that Jesus came with God's power
        - But they still fell short in their understanding of who Jesus truly was
            - And it's particularly interesting that they are currently being prevented from recognizing Jesus even in their midst
        - They haven't connected the dots yet
- Then they go on to tell how the chief priests were responsible for Jesus' death
    - We're only a few days following Jesus death, and already the common man's understanding of what happened in Jerusalem includes an awareness that the Jewish leaders were responsible for Jesus' death

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- The early Church carries this same understanding
  - Stephen, the first martyr, specifically blames the religious leaders for killing the Messiah

- But the men say why they were so sad
  - They say that they had hoped Jesus would redeem Israel
    - That's an interesting word for them to use, redeem
    - They didn't say rescue or free Israel
    - They expected redemption

Psa. 130:6 My soul *waits* for the Lord
More than the watchmen for the morning;
Indeed, more than the watchmen for the morning.
Psa. 130:7 O Israel, hope in the LORD;
For with the LORD there is lovingkindness,
And with Him is abundant redemption.
Psa. 130:8 And He will redeem Israel
From all his iniquities.

- They were saying that they hoped that Jesus might be the Messiah
  - So they were looking for a Messiah as the scriptures promised
  - They saw Jesus and hoped He was the Messiah
  - And now they are sad because He died
    - In a silly comparison, you might say they were sad in the same way that Chicago Cubs fan often are
    - Every year they get their hopes up that this might be there year
    - And yet in the end, things fall apart, leaving them saddened and disappointed
  - But what's interesting is that they probably still had hope for a Messiah
    - Like the Cubs fans, they probably said there's always next year

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- The Messiah will come one day, but it's such a shame that Jesus wasn't that one

- These men are so close to knowing the truth but yet still so far
  - They are on the verge of missing their Messiah
  - And here He stands in their midst
  - And yet they are being prevented from seeing Him for who He is
- Then say besides all this, it's been three days since He died
  - Even more telling, they seem to know that three days was significance and they suggest that there was some reason to look forward to the third day
    - And yet nothing seems to have happened
  - Except that when the women found the tomb open, they claim to have heard from angels who said He was alive
  - And went to check on what the women reported, they found the empty tomb,
    - They found the stone rolled away
    - They found the body wrappings
    - Everything just as they reported
  - But since they hadn't seen a body, they weren't willing to trust the testimony of a woman
- First, it's obvious from their testimony that they were disciples of Jesus and had been spending time among the apostles
  - They keep using references like some of us or some of those who were with us
- Secondly, these men are obviously not prone to thinking logically about what they've heard
  - If they had been, then they wouldn't have been so reluctant to accept the women's testimony

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- After all, they had remembered something from Jesus' teaching that led them to believe that the third day might be important
- And then they find that everything the women said was been found to be true
    - Stone, tomb, missing body
- The only part of their story that required faith was that a body had been resurrected and brought back to life
    - If these women were trustworthy with respect to the rest of their story, then why not believe the all of it?
    - If they were liars, then why give them any credit at all?
- And if they were willing to accept Jesus when He raised others like Lazarus from the dead, then why be doubtful of His own raising

- And to this, Jesus finally responds:

Luke 24:25 And He said to them, "O foolish men and slow of heart to believe in all that the prophets have spoken!
Luke 24:26 "Was it not necessary for the Christ to suffer these things and to enter into His glory?"
Luke 24:27 Then beginning with Moses and with all the prophets, He explained to them the things concerning Himself in all the Scriptures.

- How foolish indeed
    - But not just because they failed to accept the testimony of the women
    - Jesus focuses on an even more important failing for these men
    - Jesus says these men were slow of heart to believe in all that the prophets have spoken
        - Look at what Jesus charges them with

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- Failure to believe their scriptures – the prophets
- And in verse 27, we see that the term prophets includes Moses, so essentially Jesus means the entire OT

- Jesus says they are foolish men because they have been slow to believe in all that the OT has spoken concerning the coming Messiah
  - In particular, they have decided that Jesus couldn't be the Messiah after all because Jesus had been put to death
    - And obviously the real Messiah couldn't end that way
    - This means they were ready to reject Him and move on
  - To which Jesus responds they are fools

- Do you remember a few chapters back in Luke 16 we saw Jesus teach the story of Lazarus and the rich man
  - In that story we leaned how God's one chosen tool to bring men to understand the truth of His Son is the Word of God
    - And in Jesus day, the Word of God was the Jewish Bible, the OT
    - When the rich man asks for a miracle, a raising of the dead to convince his brothers to avoid hell
      - Abraham answers that even a raising of the dead will not accomplish the purpose the man intended
      - It will not succeed in convincing the hearts of men to repent and believe
      - That power is uniquely reserved for the Word of God, because when God saves by the power of His Word, then He will rightly receive all the glory for that work
        - If it is seen to be by another means, then the sinful pride of men will quickly seek a way to claim credit for that work
        - But God will not share His glory with men, and by vesting the power to know the Lord in His holy word, God has ensured that He will rightly receive all the glory

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- And in earlier chapters when we saw Jesus blast the Jewish leaders,
  - He accused them of blinding Israel to the truth of who Jesus was
  - And He said the way that they blinded the people was by twisting the meaning of the law and the OT scriptures so that when the Messiah arrived, the people couldn't recognize Him
    - The OT had been given to the Jews so that they might know who the Messiah was,
    - But they missed Him in part because they hadn't been prepared properly by their leaders to understand what scripture taught about his arrival

- So likewise again, Jesus says to these men by saying that they were fools because they relying on what they saw rather than on what they should have known from God's word
  - And until they saw His body, they wouldn't believe that Jesus could be the Messiah
  - But Jesus says they were slow to believe God's Word

- Now what does Jesus do in response to their foolishness?
  - What would you do?
    - We know that God is the one holding back their vision from recognizing Him in their midst
    - If you were Jesus wouldn't you seek to remove that impediment in this moment and reveal Himself?
      - Isn't this the perfect moment, after all?
    - Why not just drop the scales from their eyes and announce Himself and then they might see the truth?
  - Isn't that what we might do here?
    - And if that is how we are thinking, then we would be wrong
    - Because if Jesus were to do that here, then He would be repeating the error of the rich man when he asked Abraham to allow Lazarus to make an appearance to His brothers

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- We would be looking for a physical manifestation to take the place of the Word of God

- Remember, they have already seen the death of Jesus
  - And there is now a missing body with the report that He has been raised
  - And if Jesus appeared now, it would certainly be an impressive moment
    - And it might have caused them to wonder in amazement
    - And perhaps God would have been gracious even to work in that moment to ensure it resulted in their faith
    - But it would be wrong, because it would have been placing emphasis on what they saw rather than what they might believe in faith

Heb. 11:1 ¶ Now faith is the assurance of *things* hoped for, the conviction of things not seen.

Rom. 8:24 For in hope we have been saved, but hope that is seen is not hope; for who hopes for what he *already* sees?

- Our faith in Jesus is rooted in our trust and faith in God's Word
  - And any basis for faith apart from a trust in God's word is no faith at all

- Just look at Jesus deals with these men
  - Beginning with Moses, and all the prophets, Jesus explained the things concerning Himself in the scriptures
    - Jesus gave an exposition of the Word of God that only God could give
    - What could that conversation have been like?
      - What would it have been like to listen as God explains His word and reveals how the text speaks about Jesus on every page

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- Well, let me tell you, you can have that experience
  - Jesus promised that to those who become His disciples, God will give the Holy Spirit to each
    - And God will come to reside inside each believer
    - And the Holy Spirit will teach us all things, Jesus said
  - So when we open the very same scriptures that these men had heard
    - We have God available and ready to speak to our hearts about all that He would desire us to know about His Son and His commands for our life
  - But like these men, we must walk with Him and spend time with Him and listen to Him
    - And since we don't have a physical manifestation of Jesus before us today, we are required to carry out this same devotion through the written Word
    - Devoting ourselves daily to searching the scriptures to know how the Lord would speak to us

- One of the reasons this ministry has made a point to teach God's word verse by verse, and to do so consistently is our conviction that nothing else can take the place of scripture in persuading an unbeliever of the truth of the Gospel or for preparing the Saints for the work of ministry

Luke 24:28 ¶ And they approached the village where they were going, and He acted as
though He were going farther.
Luke 24:29 But they urged Him, saying, "Stay with us, for it is *getting* toward evening,
and the day is now nearly over." So He went in to stay with them.
Luke 24:30 When He had reclined *at the table* with them, He took the bread and blessed
it, and breaking *it*, He *began* giving *it* to them.
Luke 24:31 Then their eyes were opened and they recognized Him; and He vanished
from their sight.
Luke 24:32 They said to one another, "Were not our hearts burning within us while He
was speaking to us on the road, while He was explaining the Scriptures to us?"
Luke 24:33 And they got up that very hour and returned to Jerusalem, and found
gathered together the eleven and those who were with them,
Luke 24:34 saying, "The Lord has really risen and has appeared to Simon."

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Luke 24:35 They *began* to relate their experiences on the road and how He was recognized by them in the breaking of the bread.

- So they continue until they reach a stopping point for the day
    - And Jesus leaves the impression He would continue on
        - How odd
        - Where's He going?
        - Why keep walking?
    - Once again He's baiting the men, it seems
        - It's almost as though He's waiting for an invitation to stop
        - And when they urge Him to stay, He agrees
    - And at the table He reclines and begins to take bread, bless it and break it, and hand it out
        - And at this moment they recognize Jesus
        - Now what caused the recognition?
            - Some might think that it was merely the breaking of the bread in a way that reminded them of the Last Supper
            - Except that these men weren't at the Last Supper
        - Besides, the text says how they came to recognize Jesus
            - Their eyes were opened because God choose this moment to reveal Himself to them
- What has happened here?
    - Well, two men who had seen and known Jesus were prevented from knowing who He was until they had heard the truth of Jesus according to the Scriptures
        - And once they had heard these things, it had an immediate effect on their heart
        - They came to a new understanding, but not only that

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        - They came to a new spiritual place

    - Look at verse 32

        - When were their hearts burning?

        - After they saw Jesus and recognized him at the table?

            - No on the road when they were taught the word of God

        - So when did the belief enter their hearts?

            - Surely on the road?

        - So what brought about their faith?

            - The Word of God

            - Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the word of God

            - The seed is the word of God, and where it lands it will bring new life

1Th. 2:13 ¶ For this reason we also constantly thank God that when you received the word of God which you heard from us, you accepted *it* not *as* the word of men, but *for* what it really is, the word of God, which also performs its work in you who believe.

- And then Jesus vanishes

    - Which tells us that Jesus in his resurrected will do supernatural things

- And then these men run back to confirm that Jesus has risen

    - And they are so excited they run back that very hour, which means at night when it would have been dangerous to travel

    - And they testify to the 11 of all that happened

        - I wonder if the 11 are believing yet?

        - Well, read on

Luke 24:36 ¶ While they were telling these things, He Himself stood in their midst and *said to them, “Peace be to you.”
Luke 24:37 But they were startled and frightened and thought that they were seeing a spirit.

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Luke 24:38 And He said to them, "Why are you troubled, and why do doubts arise in your hearts?
Luke 24:39 "See My hands and My feet, that it is I Myself; touch Me and see, for a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have."
Luke 24:40 And when He had said this, He showed them His hands and His feet.
Luke 24:41 While they still could not believe *it* because of their joy and amazement, He said to them, "Have you anything here to eat?"
Luke 24:42 They gave Him a piece of a broiled fish;
Luke 24:43 and He took it and ate *it* before them.

- Jesus appears to the 11 even as they are hearing the story from Cleopas
    - Now observe their reaction
        - Did they run to embrace Jesus based on the testimony of the two men?
        - No
    - So Jesus says why are you so troubled?
        - And look, Jesus cites that they have doubts in their hearts
    - Now He shows them His feet and hands and the holes from the crucifixion
        - And He emphasizes that He is a flesh and bone man – not a spirit
            - This testimony in Luke's gospel is a direct contradiction to the gnostics in the early church who claimed that Jesus was never a true fleshly man
        - But back to the disciples, look at verse 41
            - They still aren't believing in Him
    - Finally, in a scene that's downright comical if you imagine it in all its details
        - Jesus says someone give me some food
            - At which promptly takes a bites and begins to eat the broiled fish
            - And do you seen Jesus with a big grin on his face as he crews? I do.

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- Do we need any more proof of the story of Lazarus and the rich man than this scene?
    - Here are the 11 disciples inspecting Jesus' own resurrected body
        - And yet they can't bring themselves to believe that He was truly who He said He was
        - Can I say it again…nothing can bring about faith in the heart of a man except the word of God preached
        - And in one final confirmation of that truth, look at how Luke's gospel ends

Luke 24:44 ¶ Now He said to them, "These are My words which I spoke to you while I was still with you, that all things which are written about Me in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms must be fulfilled."
Luke 24:45 Then He opened their minds to understand the Scriptures,
Luke 24:46 and He said to them, "Thus it is written, that the Christ would suffer and rise again from the dead the third day,
Luke 24:47 and that repentance for forgiveness of sins would be proclaimed in His name to all the nations, beginning from Jerusalem.
Luke 24:48 "You are witnesses of these things.
Luke 24:49 "And behold, I am sending forth the promise of My Father upon you; but you are to stay in the city until you are clothed with power from on high."
Luke 24:50 ¶ And He led them out as far as Bethany, and He lifted up His hands and blessed them.
Luke 24:51 While He was blessing them, He parted from them and was carried up into heaven.
Luke 24:52 And they, after worshiping Him, returned to Jerusalem with great joy,
Luke 24:53 and were continually in the temple praising God.

- Once again, Jesus begins with His words and the words of the OT scriptures
    - And He explains how all was fulfilled in His life and death
    - And with that explanation from the word of God, in verse 45 we're told Jesus opened their minds
    - And they believed in the risen Lord
        - Whatever belief they shared in Jesus prior to the resurrection, only now did they finally understand it all

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        - I believe the scripture suggests that perhaps only Peter really understood who Jesus was from before His death

            - First we have Peter acknowledging Jesus in that famous confession from Matt 16:18

            - Add to that the fact that Jesus appeared to Peter alone before he appeared the other disciples (verse 34) which is also mentioned in the other gospels

    - In any case, we now see their understanding made complete on the basis of an understanding of God's word

- Finally, Jesus gives His final instructions to the disciples

    - Jesus commands them to remain in the city until they receive power from on high

        - The time when the Holy Spirit arrived to open the Church age and empower these men for their ministry – a promise we share

        - He then led them outside the city to the place where Jesus returned to the Father

        - Leaving the disciples to return to a joyful worship of God in the temple

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